



1. [IMPORTANT](#)
2. [Part Two: AMNSE - The Dark Side](#)
3. [Chapter 126: Back to school](#)
4. [Chapter 127: Mine](#)
5. [Chapter 128: Roommate](#)
6. [Chapter 129: Ash](#)
7. [Chapter 130: Accident](#)
8. [Chapter 131: Blood](#)
9. [Chapter 132: Karate](#)
10. [Chapter 133: Kiss](#)
11. [Chapter 134: Anger](#)
12. [Chapter 135: Unexpected Visitor](#)
13. [Chapter 136: Falling In Love](#)
14. [Chapter 137: Punch](#)
15. [Chapter 138: Love Hurt](#)
16. [Chapter 139: Trident](#)
17. [Chapter 140: Why and When](#)
18. [Chapter 141: New York](#)
19. [Chapter 142: Message](#)
20. [Chapter 143: Sunday Morning](#)
21. [Chapter 144: Sundate](#)
22. [Chapter 145: Mentally Ill](#)
23. [Chapter 146: Frustration](#)
24. [Chapter 147: I love... Me?](#)
25. [Chapter 148: How](#)
26. [Chapter 149: Father](#)
27. [Chapter 150: Escape plan](#)
28. [Chapter 151: Near Death](#)
29. [Chapter 152: Gun](#)
30. [Chapter 153: Argue](#)
31. [Chapter 154: Watson Family](#)
32. [Chapter 155: Friendship](#)
33. [Chapter 156: Strong](#)
34. [Chapter 157: Keiren](#)
35. [Chapter 158: Boss](#)
36. [Chapter 159: Death wish](#)

37. [Chapter 160: Know](#)
38. [Chapter 161: Words](#)
39. [Chapter 162: Inner Pain](#)
40. [Chapter 163: Past](#)
41. [Chapter 164: Galawang Ulupong](#)
42. [Chapter 165: Dinner](#)
43. [Chapter 166: Bread Knife](#)
44. [Chapter 167: Papers](#)
45. [Chapter 168: Exam](#)
46. [Chapter 169: Holy Shit](#)
47. [Chapter 170: Cyrus Velasco](#)
48. [Chapter 171: Nice meeting you](#)
49. [Chapter 172: Admit](#)
50. [Chapter 173: Operation: Bawiin](#)
51. [Chapter 174: Operation: Bawiin 2.0](#)
52. [Chapter 175: Tray](#)
53. [Chapter 176: Freya Hidalgo](#)
54. [Chapter 177: Keifer's side](#)
55. [Chapter 178: Barakuda](#)
56. [Chapter 179: Truth or Dare](#)
57. [Chapter 180: No more secrets](#)
58. [Chapter 181: Midnight Convo](#)
59. [Chapter 182: Bridge](#)
60. [Chapter 183: A.M.](#)
61. [Chapter 184: Wedding Gown](#)
62. [Chapter 185: Complicated](#)
63. [Chapter 186: Fiancé vs. boyfriend?](#)
64. [Chapter 187: Started with a kiss](#)
65. [Chapter 188: Boiling point](#)
66. [Chapter 189: The Prince](#)
67. [Chapter 190: Open ears](#)
68. [Chapter 191: Brother](#)
69. [Chapter 192: Stepbrother](#)
70. [Chapter 193: I shall return](#)
71. [Chapter 194: Last cry](#)
72. [Chapter 195: Old Jay-jay](#)
73. [Chapter 196: Keifer's plan](#)

74. [Chapter 197: Back Attack](#)
75. [Chapter 198: No care](#)
76. [Chapter 199: Game of Pain](#)
77. [Chapter 200: Drunk Percy](#)
78. [Chapter 201: Angelo's rule](#)
79. [Chapter 202: Monday Madness](#)
80. [Chapter 203: Evil Phone](#)
81. [Chapter 204: Eruption](#)
82. [Chapter 205: Visit Kiko](#)
83. [Chapter 206: Switch](#)
84. [Chapter 207: Cold](#)
85. [Chapter 208: Master](#)
86. [Chapter 209: Section E](#)
87. [Chapter 210: Gang War](#)
88. [Chapter 211: Birthday gift](#)
89. [Chapter 212: Motorbike](#)
90. [Chapter 213: King](#)
91. [Chapter 214: Heypi Birthday](#)
92. [Trivia \(This is originally from the book\)](#)
93. [Chapter 215: Saving you](#)
94. [Chapter 216: Broken](#)
95. [Chapter 217: Engage no more](#)
96. [Chapter 218: Textmate](#)
97. [Chapter 219: Begin Again](#)
98. [Chapter 220: No longer the King](#)
99. [Chapter 221: The real King](#)
100. [Chapter 222: Island](#)

111. [Chapter 233: Tren](#)
112. [Chapter 234: Penmanship](#)
113. [Chapter 235: Forgiveness](#)
114. [Chapter 236: Forgiveness](#)
115. [Chapter 237: Siblings](#)
116. [Chapter 238: Birthday Wish](#)
117. [Chapter 239: Happy Birthday](#)
118. [Chapter 240: Kuya's Pain](#)
119. [Chapter 241](#)
120. [Chapter 242: Happy Family](#)
121. [Chapter 243: Basement](#)
122. [Chapter 244: Cousins for reason](#)
123. [Chapter 245: Say goodbye](#)
124. [Chapter 246: New room, new enemy](#)
125. [Chapter 247: Fly](#)
126. [Chapter 248: Dora vs Diego](#)
127. [Chapter 249: What now](#)
128. [Chapter 250: Saving friendship](#)
129. [Chapter 251: Human](#)
130. [Chapter 252: Hide and seek](#)
131. [Chapter 253: King](#)
132. [Chapter 254: Who knows](#)
133. [Chapter 255: Forgive & Forget](#)
134. [Chapter 256: R.Sato](#)
135. [Chapter 257: Enemy who?](#)
136. [Chapter 258: Black and white](#)
137. [Chapter 259: White & Red](#)

IMPORTANT

I TRIED MY BEST TO TRANSLATE IT AS BEST AS I CAN. I HAVEN'T EDITED ANYTHING, NO PUNCTUATION, NO SPELL CORRECTOR, NOTHING AT ALL, IT IS AS SAME AS THE ORIGINALLY WRITTEN.

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Part Two: AMNSE - The L

Jay-jay.

She's the only girl.

They adore her so much.

Protect her no matter what.

But what if the girl they thought they knew is not what tl

Section E

They are more than friends and classmates to her.

She always helps them.

She will fight with or for them.

But what if, everything she thought about them is just a l

Part Two of 'Ang Mutya ng Section E'.

The Dark Side.

Chapter 126: Back to scho

Jay-jay's POV

Very Wrong! I feel like I'm going crazy, or maybe I'm al

This is so annoying!

I can't understand what's happening to me. I already acce
proposal, so I shouldn't have done *that* with Keifer.

You know, *that* thing—during New Year's.

That jerk is so infuriating. UGH! It makes me feel like I'
Damn it!

What's worse is that it almost happened. It almost really
so close. Damn it!

I don't know how to face Yuri anymore. This is so frustra
remember what happened, my heart races. My face feels

I looked at the ring on my finger. Kuya told me to wear i
off.

But every time I see it. I feel like I'm betraying someone

outside my room.

I knew it was Tita Gema and Kuya Angelo. I just didn't u
they had to talk right outside my door.

After getting ready, I went out, which made Kuya and Ti

"Good morning," I greeted them.

"Good morning. Go eat breakfast," Tita said, smiling at i

I didn't even look at or greet Kuya Angelo. I'm still mad

I went straight to the dining area. I found Aries eating th
was dead serious. When will he ever smile?

Only when he's with Ella.

While eating, I noticed Aries kept looking at me, like he
something.

"Do you have something to say?" I asked him.

"You're the one who should be saying something to me,'
me look at him in confusion.

"Huh?"

"What's your decision? Are you staying in that stupid se

I paused. If I had followed him, would this really have h
still be tied to this arranged marriage?

Honestly, I'm so tired of thinking about this damn engag
my food and got ready. I walked outside and noticed Ari
garage.

I thought he had already left!

I looked at the gate. Aries was there, talking to someone.
and was surprised to see who he was talking to.

"Yuri..." I called out to him. "...W-why are you here?"

He was leaning against his car with his arms crossed. He
smiled at me and stood up straight.

"I'm here to pick you up," he said.

He was about to approach me, but Aries suddenly steppe
blocking me.

"She's not going with you... Leave," Aries said sternly.

"You're not the one who gets to decide here," Yuri replied

"A-Aries... It's okay. I-I want to talk to Yuri too," I said, I

He stepped aside and let me walk over to Yuri. Yuri open

"Sorry about that. I should've told you about it from the s
force you, so I tried to make an effort," he explained.

So that's why he went down on one knee. That's what it v

I touched the ring on my finger.

"H-how are we going to tell our classmates?"

"I..." He took a deep breath. "...I've already thought about
don't tell them yet."

I looked at him, confused. "Why?"

"It's for the sake of our Section. Things will get messy if
Especially now, since they all think Keifer has feelings f

Shoot!

Why did he have to bring up that King of the Snakes? U
again! I remembered what happened on New Year's.

I'm such a cheater!

I looked out the window. I was too ashamed to face Yuri
did.

"What do you think?" he asked.

I took off the necklace I was wearing—the one Poseidon gave me for the Christmas party. I still don't know who it's really from, but I wore it.

I also took off the ring. I threaded the necklace through the ring and made it into a pendant. Then I put the necklace back on.

"Great idea..." Yuri commented, smiling at me.

I just smiled back. We fell silent during the ride. Thanks to the necklace, which, damn it, is still terrible even on the first day of school, became even more awkward.

There were moments when I'd look at him, and he'd look at me, and that was it. We kept doing it, even though we probably looked ridiculous.

"This is awkward," he said, chuckling a little. "...You know, we don't have to take this engagement too seriously. We can still talk about it the same way we did before."

"Huh?"

"No pressure. Let's not think about the engagement when we're not together. Just act like the Jay-jay I know," he said, smiling at me.

I smiled back. He's right. Why should we overthink this? Kuya was just pressuring me.

I lowered my fist. I saw him rubbing his arm. For some reason I started laughing.

"You punch hard... You're stronger than me," he said.

"That's your fault."

The awkwardness started to fade. Even the pressure from the engagement seemed to disappear. I like this better.

Back to how we were before.

The car stopped in the school parking lot. After taking one last thought we were going to get out, but Yuri grabbed my hand.

"I forgot something," he said.

I was surprised when he suddenly leaned in and kissed me.

When he pulled away, he smiled at me.

"No pressure about the engagement, but that doesn't mean I have feelings for you," he said before getting out of the car.

Jay-jay, you cheater! Jay-jay, CHEATER!

It took a while for my brain to function again. I just scratched my head when I realized Yuri was waiting for me to get out of the car.

I'm so confused. When Yuri kissed me, all I could think of was deceiving him.

This is so wrong. We're engaged, right? Even if it's arranged to it. I still accepted it. I have an obligation to this engagement.

I need to fix this mistake. If I need to stay away from Kenji, he knows I'm engaged to Yuri, so he'll understand.

I need to talk to him properly so we can stop this.

Yes! That's what I'll do! I fixed myself up and opened the door.

Not even a second after I opened it, I wanted to close it and run. Luck! The person I'm trying to avoid is right in front of me.

I was a little shocked, but I immediately glared at him.

He had one hand on the stall wall.

"W-what are you doing here? This is the girls' CR!" I screamed.

He suddenly smiled mischievously. "I don't care... No one's here," he said, pushing me back into the stall.

Oh my God...

I just said I'd stop this!

Chapter 127: Mine

Jay-jay's POV

"What happened to you?" Edrix asked Keifer as soon as

"...Did you get into a fight?"

Keifer looked at me, so I quickly looked away. Guilty! It was my fault. He had to push me into the stall and then—ugh!!! He even had to do New Year's *thing* part two!

So annoying!

I had no choice. I bit his lip and punched him. I even kicked him. That's why he looks like he just got into a fight.

"No... I just ran into a jerk," Keifer replied, walking to his stall.

A jerk, huh?

I avoided his gaze. I pretended I didn't know what happened. This guy is probably doing it on purpose.

"You'll pay for this..." he whispered as he passed by me.

What happened to him? I really want to go to his house and see what his Kuya did to him?

I remembered how he yelled at me over the phone. It was a jump through the line just to yell at me in person.

Sigh...

Next, I looked for Kit. He had his headphones on and seemed to be unaware of what was happening around him.

Mayo, on the other hand, looked like he wanted to approach but was hesitating.

Love life, huh?

Sir Alvin arrived. He greeted us and asked how we celebrated New Year's.

He didn't teach and just chatted with us instead. I missed his lessons with us and these snakes, and how he joined in on our shenanigans.

"...We've already started planning your retreat," Sir Alvin said.

Retreat?!

"Are we even part of that?" Calix asked.

"Yes. You're fourth years now. All students have to join a retreat."

Post-final exam?

I turned to Yuri and tapped him.

"What's the post-final exam?" I asked.

"There's a fifth exam. That's where they determine if a student passes or not,"

Yuri explained.

Oh no!

Why is there something like that? What if I don't pass? I won't graduate?

I suddenly felt nervous. We haven't even reached the third exam yet, and now I find out there's something like this.

I need to prepare for this. I might have to burn the midnight oil, not being able to leave this place, Kuya will skin me alive.

Our morning class was mostly spent chatting. Even the teachers weren't teaching. Maybe they're not in the mood or just don't want to teach.

Lunchtime!

"Is this all?" Drew asked Eman.

Keifer suddenly sat down on the bench in front of me. W
he kept staring at me.

"Get out of here!" I snapped at him.

"What if I don't want to?" he challenged.

I grabbed my food and stood up. I was about to leave wh
spoke.

"Boooooxxeeerrr..." he whispered, almost singing.

Okay... I sat back down.

I glared at him. So annoying! I don't want them to find o
who gave him that.

This jerk thinks he has leverage now.

"What do you want?!" I asked irritably.

"Nothing... Is it wrong to watch you while you eat?"

"Yes! Go away!"

Instead of listening, he just laughed at me.

Look at this guy!

I nodded. He glanced at Keifer before walking away.

I kept my eyes on Yuri until he was out of sight. Once I heard us, I turned to Keifer.

I glared at him like I wanted to kill him.

"Stop this..." I whispered firmly.

He leaned closer to me. "Why?" he whispered back.

"What do you mean why? Keifer, come on!" I looked around. No one could hear us. "...I'm engaged to Yuri."

He chuckled. "You're asking me to stop?" I immediately asked.

"This! What you're doing! Stop it... Stay away... Stop flirting."

He glanced at Yuri before turning back to me and speaking.

"What's wrong with flirting with you? With flirting with Yuri... Love..."

Why do I feel shaky when I hear that word from him?

"Keifer," I called him. "...This is wrong."

Okay...

That feeling in my chest. He's right, we're not in a relationship even demanding this from him?

"...There's nothing wrong with what we're doing..." he said.

Damn it!

"...You have nothing to worry about..."

Please stop!

"...You're not cheating on Yuri because we're not in a relationship."

His words felt like a slap to my face. We're not even in a relationship, why is he doing this? So annoying! I felt like crying, but I didn't.

I just bowed my head, and for some reason, I couldn't move. I wanted to leave and walk away from this jerk. But how can I when they've locked up?

I felt so heavy, like I was about to cry right there, but the door opened.

"...." His words didn't register in my mind, but they made sense. They hit me hard and shook me to my core.

"Did you hear what I said?" he asked.

I had so much I wanted to say, but my mouth wouldn't open. I must've retreated. Should I be happy about what he said?

"Y-you're crazy," was all I managed to say.

I stood up abruptly and quickly walked out. My cheeks were even hit my chest because my heart was racing so fast.

This is wrong!

I stopped at the stairs leading to the second floor. I ran my hand through my hair.

Damn it!

I must've paced around a few times. I kept sighing too.

Keifer is so infuriating. I don't even understand myself anymore. I'm so confused!

"Aaaaggggghhhhh!!" someone screamed, making me jump.

W-who was that?

I immediately looked around. No one was there, and it didn't seem like a ghost room. Is there a ghost here?

I looked at the stairs leading to the second floor of our building.

He stopped and turned to me when he heard me.

"What?" he asked.

I could hear his voice cracking. It sounded like he was crying.

"Is something wrong?"

He didn't speak. It seemed like he didn't want to talk about it. He just walked away when he suddenly sobbed.

I didn't leave. I waited to see if he would say something.

"S-sorry... I just can't help it," he said before leaning against the wall.

I walked over to him and leaned against the wall too.

"What happened?" He took a deep breath and wiped his eyes. He looked hard for me to see them like this.

"I'm just so frustrated with myself. I'm such a coward," he said with a sad smile.

I feel the same way. I'm also frustrated with myself. It's a struggle.

"Why? Can you tell me about it?" I asked.

At times like this, I want to focus my mind on something else. I get annoyed when I think about my situation.

I looked at Edrix. "W-who's the girl?"

He looked at me too. He took out his phone and started t

He seemed to be looking for something, and when he fou
me his phone.

It was a picture of a beautiful girl. She looked simple, wi
too.

"She's beautiful, right?" he asked me.

I quickly nodded. "Yes... She's beautiful."

"Freya is really beautiful."

"Yeah... She's really—HUH?! THIS IS FREYA?!" I aske

I looked at the picture again. Impossible! I zoomed in an
It's really Freya!

She looks so beautiful without makeup. When she's simp
an angel.

Is this photoshopped?!

"S-so Freya is the girl—"

"Yes. It's been a long time." he cut me off

Chapter 128: Roommate

Jay-jay's POV

Whose is this?

This suitcase is huge. I could probably fit inside it. This is the biggest one I've ever seen, but whose is it?

As soon as I opened my eyes, this was the first thing I saw. I was hallucinating at first.

I got up from bed. I inspected the suitcase and looked for marks. I tried to open it, but the zipper was locked with a combination.

I tried to push it and move it to another spot. It's blocking the door.

It's so heavy!

It feels like there's a person inside! It's ridiculously heavy. The house is packed inside.

"Whose is this?" I said irritably.

I scratched my head. This thing just appeared here without me. I checked the time on the wall clock. It's still early.

Ci-N?!

"...you're such a funny kid. Hahahaha..." Tita said.

"But I'm handsome, right?" Ci-N replied, making Tita la

Even Tito, who was drinking coffee, was laughing along smiling while shaking his head.

"Hahahahaha... Go eat already," Tita told him.

"Later. I'll eat with—Jay!" he called out when he saw me

"Good morning, Jay... Go eat. Join your friend," Tito Jul

Kuya Angelo just looked at me. I still don't want to talk t

"O-okay."

"We'll head to the dining room," Ci-N said.

I walked out of the kitchen. The idiot followed me. Before enter the dining room, I grabbed Ci by the collar.

"Ow... Jay!" he yelled.

"You idiot! What happened to you?!" I asked irritably bu

Who wouldn't be concerned about this kid? Seriously! I

"...he said he's sending me to London. I refused, so he locked me in my room," he explained. Tsk!

I felt anger toward his annoying brother. That guy must be a straight. Locking up Ci-N?!

"Lola and I were worried about you," I said.

"S-sorry... He also took all my gadgets."

"Is that all he did to you? He didn't hurt you, did he?" I asked.

I don't trust his Kuya anymore. Who knows what else he did to you?

Ci-N didn't answer. He looked away and rubbed the back of his head.

"Ci. Speak up! What else did your Kuya do to you?!"

He shook his head. "Nothing else... But he threatened me after you if I didn't behave."

Me?! Ha!

"Then let him come after me! As if I'm scared of him!" I continued walking to the dining room.

Ci followed me. His Kuya thinks I'm scared of him. That's why he wants to face him. We'll settle things between us.

Huh??

I didn't understand him. His mouth was too full, and he kept eating.
Aries turned his gaze to me.

"I-I don't know yet. I was about to ask him," I quickly replied.

Aries didn't say anything. He just sat down and ate. Occasionally he gave sharp glances at me and Ci-N.

Even though I wanted to keep eating, I had to stand up quickly.

"Let's go, Ci... We might be late," I told him.

"Huh?! It's still early," he replied, taking another bite of food.

"Can't you read the room?! he didn't get what I was trying to say."

I glared at him. "Let's go," I said firmly.

Even though he was confused, he stood up and walked with me. While walking, he kept poking me. "What?"

"I wasn't done eating. Why did you make me leave?" he asked.

"This idiot! he really didn't get that a storm was brewing and we had to leave!"

"Nothing! We might really be late." I lied.

"I ran away," he replied quickly.

I looked at him in confusion. Ran away?!

"Seriously. What's going on?" I asked again.

he opened the suitcase first before looking at me and ans

"I ran away. My Kuya said if I didn't listen to him, I shou
So I did," he explained.

Oh my God...

Very nice. Her brother's influence is strong. he actually t
seriously.

"Where are you going to stay if you ran away?!"

he took out some clothes and placed them on the bed.

"Here, with you," he replied while picking out socks.

My eyes widened at what I heard. he's crazy! he's really
here. He must've forgotten that Aries is also in the house

Who knows what he'll do to him—or worse, he'll take it
He doesn't like seeing anyone from Section E.

"No way! Are you out of your mind?!" I shouted at him

"Why? Of course, so they know where I'm going." He ha

"Did Kuya really agree?" I asked, confused.

He walked toward the bathroom door. He had a towel dr
shoulder and was holding a bottle of shampoo.

"Yes... He said I could stay in your room," he replied. "..
he said and went into the bathroom.

Wow!

I'm so embarrassed. This idiot is making himself at home
before me. But honestly, this is better. At least I can mak
isn't bullying him.

I'm just not sure what kind of trouble this kid will cause

"Bubble butt... Bubble bubble bubble butt.." Ci-N sang v

I just laughed because I could hear him moving around i
It sounded like he was dancing while singing.

I grabbed the clothes I was going to wear and waited for
the bathroom.

I heard my phone ring. I immediately grabbed it from un
had two text messages.

Message: Get up! Your pillow's soaked with drool. 😴😞

Jerk! This guy probably texted just to annoy me. I didn't phone back on the bed.

Ci-N suddenly came out of the bathroom. he was just wr

That was fast!

I checked the time on the wall clock. He only spent less 1 the bathroom.

"Your turn," he said.

I grabbed my towel and clothes. I went into the bathroom shower routine.

While showering, I could hear Ci-N outside. It sounded l to someone. I turned off the shower for a moment to liste quiet.

I hurried up with my shower and got dressed. Since there room, I got dressed in the bathroom.

When I came out, I was right. The kid was talking to son Aries.

"W what are you doing here?" I asked irritably.

he shook her head and quickly grabbed his shoes. he put walked out of my room.

Why do I feel like Aries said or did something bad to him
Tsk!

I finished getting ready and grabbed my bag. I quickly ran to the room where Ci-N was waiting for me.

"Let's go?" he asked.

I just nodded, and we walked out. I was waiting for him to tell me what happened earlier, but Ci-N chose to stay quiet.

Why? What happened?!

So annoying! I'm not used to Ci-N being like this. I tried to tease him, but he just forced a smile.

When we got to school, we were near the room when he was walking, making me stop too.

"What's wrong, Ci?"

"Is it true?" he asked sadly. "...Are you leaving Section

Who told him—damn it! It was Aries!

"Who said Jay-jay is leaving Section E?!"

Chapter 129: Ash

Jay-jay's POV

"Are you leaving Section E?!" they asked me in shock.

Suddenly, all the troublemakers in the room came out with Keifer's shout. This is really scandalous!

I immediately shook my head. "N-no..."

"But that's what he told me," Ci insisted. "...Because you be with your dad than with us."

Oh my...

That Aries really hit hard. He even told Ci-N about it. No suddenly became so down. Oh my! This horoscope is real death of me.

"What?! Why would you do that, Jay?!"

"Don't you want to be with us anymore?!"

"I thought you were solid with Section E?!"

I didn't answer, but he looked me in the eyes. I couldn't look away, so I avoided his gaze.

Suddenly, he walked away. Even without him saying anything, I was going to confront Aries. I wanted to follow him, but he hugged my leg and started crying.

Oh no!

"Ci! What's wrong?!" I shouted.

"Don't leave! Stay here in Section E!" he cried while sobbing.

I tried to remove his arms from my leg, but he only tightened his grip.

"Jay-jay! Please!" he pleaded.

"N-no! I'm not leaving! Let go!"

"Jay-jay!"

I looked at the troublemakers for help, but they just stared at me.

How am I supposed to stop Keifer if I can't even leave him alone?

"Can you guys get Ci-N off me?!" I ordered them.

"Promise us first that you won't leave Section E," Eren said.

"Ci-N, come on!"

"Jay-jay!" someone called me.

I tried to see who it was. It was Yuri, running towards us

"...What's... Why is Ci-N like this with you?" he asked.

"Because----"

"JAY-JAY IS LEAVING SECTION E!" Ci-N cut me off.

Yuri immediately looked at me. "Is it true?"

"No! I'll explain later! Go after Keifer, he might fight Ar

It was clear I wouldn't be able to leave anytime soon. I w
catch up to Keifer, so I asked Yuri to go instead.

he immediately obeyed. Very good! Very good!

I turned back to the kid clinging to my leg. he was still c
troublemakers were just watching.

I held his face and made him look at me.

"Ci-N! I'm not leaving! No one's leaving!" I said serious

he stopped for a moment and looked at me. I didn't break

"Let's go! We need to stop Keifer!" I said and immediately ran to the main building.

They quickly followed me.

I wasn't wrong. Keifer had gone to confront Aries, and they were starting to fight.

"Stop it, Keifer!" Yuri shouted, trying to separate Keifer and Aries.

But Keifer wouldn't let go of Aries' collar. Even Section 8 was trying to intervene. The other students were starting to get involved.

"Let's go! We'll finish this elsewhere!" Aries challenged.

"I will really END this now!" Keifer angrily replied.

I looked at my friends. I thought they followed me to stop the Troublemakers, but they were just watching again.

You guys are so helpful!

"Maybe you want to help?!" I sarcastically asked them.

"No... Let your cousin get beaten up," Drew replied.

I glared at him. Maybe I should beat him up for the debt he seems to have forgotten.

"Stop it, Keifer!" Yuri shouted.

I bit my lower lip. He really didn't want to be stopped. He was fighting. What's wrong with him?!

"Keifer really won't stop!" Eman said.

I couldn't just stand and watch. I ran towards them and tried to help them. I almost got crushed in the scuffle, but I didn't back down.

I pushed Keifer with all my strength, giving Felix and the others a chance to pull him away and stop him from charging.

"Stop! Stop! Please!" I shouted while standing between them.

"Can you?! Get out of here with your trash!" Mykel shouted at me.

I glared at him. He talks like he's so clean, but his breath smells like garbage.

"Shut up! Don't ever talk to Jay-jay like that!" Yuri shouted at him.

"Get out of here, Jay-jay! You're causing a scene!" Ella cried.

As if she's so important....

I ignored her and went to Keifer.

"Stop it! Let's go!" I said and started to walk away, but he

standing properly.

I've thought about this for a long time. Once I say this, there's no turning back.

I know I need to make sacrifices. This is the only way, and it's a lot.

"I'm sorry..." I said. Aries immediately smiled, and Yuri looked on. "...Aries..." I continued. "...But I'm not leaving Section E."

Aries' smile disappeared, and the troublemakers were visibly upset by what I said.

"That's your decision. I can't do anything about it," Aries said, pulling something out of his pocket.

Damn it!

It was the information about my dad! He borrowed it from the library and was shocked to see Mykel hand him a lighter.

"I hope you don't regret this," Aries said and lit the paper. "...You lose your chance to be with your father."

I couldn't help but feel weak at what I saw. That was the information my dad left with my brother. My brother said he decided to leave when he found out Aries had a copy.

Aries frowned at him. The paper had already burned, but still on Keifer.

"I think you're forgetting something," Keifer added. "...I want."

"What do you mean by that?" Aries asked.

"Anything... Including information about Jay-jay's father with a smirk.

Holy cow!

Now I remember. He has a motto like a bank. I'm so stupid night thinking about how to get the info about my dad.

I should have told Keifer earlier; he might have helped n

Annoying!

"Ha! So you're saying you can find him?" Aries asked ar

"In one week, I will find his information. In another wee him," Keifer said.

Aries clearly wasn't happy. He didn't want me to meet m was bad news for him.

"Can you really do that?" I asked Keifer

"Let's go! We're wasting our time here!" Calix shouted at
Keifer and Aries exchanged one last glare before we finally
I felt excited. This is what I've been waiting for.

Chapter 130: Accident

Jay-jay's POV

Late! Late! Late! Late!

Ugh! Ci-N didn't wake me up. He let me sleep and left w
to wake me.

I'm so embarrassed! After I let him stay in my room, he c
effort to wake me up. He even turned off my alarm. So h

I checked the time on my phone. It's too late! I'm definite
make it.

What's worse? There's no ride available—everything's fi
stopping for me. So annoying!

It's still morning, but I already feel like it's afternoon. I'm
crazy!

I've been running and walking. I didn't even have a propo
up late, so I just grabbed some bread and left.

I stopped for a moment at a corner. I was already out of l
going to make it anyway so why bother running?

"I woke up late too," he replied.

We walked together, not rushing anymore since we were point in hurrying now.

"Do you live around here? Aren't you and Edrix neighbors?"

He came from the subdivision across the street, but Edrix and I know they live farther apart.

"No... I stayed over at my girlfriend's place last night," he suddenly smiling.

Oh, I see where this is going.

"Typical you..." I muttered.

He just scratched the back of his neck and grinned at me, looking proud of what he'd done.

"Is that how you guys are? Is it, like, a requirement for guys to do *that*?" I asked, feeling awkward but unable to stop.

"Not really... It just happens sometimes. Especially when temptation," he replied.

Really? Just like that?

Temptation. Good thing I didn't give in during New Year's.

"W-what? Don't ask me that!" I stammered.

"Why are you blushing?"

I immediately covered my cheeks to hide my embarrassment. How did the conversation have to go this way?

"...whatever. When you and Keifer finally get together, you teach me," he said, then burst out laughing.

Ugh, this guy! What a jerk!

I glared at him and punched his arm hard to make him stop.

"Ow! That hurt," he complained, rubbing his arm.

As if I need Keifer to teach me anything like that! And why would I want to be with Keifer, of all people?

Ugh, don't even think about it!

But why does it hurt a little to think that Keifer might've feelings for me? I shouldn't care about what he does with his life. He's just messing with me anyway.

What if Yuri's done it too?

I don't know why, but it feels weird to think about them having feelings for me and living their life, but deep down, part of me still feels

I felt a chill. I wanted to look back to see who it was, but to.

We walked faster and turned into an alley.

"Call Keifer," Rory ordered me.

I immediately grabbed my phone. I was about to call Kei when he suddenly pushed me, making me lean against the wall.

I was shocked when I saw the guys who were following

"Rory!" I shouted.

One of them tried to come after me, but Rory stopped him. I couldn't do anything to help him.

"That's the girl!" one of the guys shouted.

"Jay-jay! Get out of here!" Rory yelled.

But I couldn't move. I couldn't leave him.

"Jay-jay!"

I didn't think anymore. I ran to Rory and helped him. I started punching blindly.

"I told you to leave! Why are you still here?!"

What?!

Keifer's girlfriend?! What the—where did that rumor come from?

"No! I'm not that jerk's girlfriend!" I denied.

"You think we'd believe that?!" Of course not!

I know you guys are too dumb to believe me. Where did that come from?

"We need to get out of here," Rory whispered.

"How?"

"Like this..." he said, looking around as if searching for someone. He then looked at me and said, "RUN!"

He suddenly took off running. I was confused but followed him.

"Hey! Come back here!"

No way!

Why do they always shout that when someone runs away? They say we'll actually come back just because they said so?

"Jay-jay! Go back!" Rory shouted.

Crap!

Four of them suddenly pulled out knives. Rory tried to slip away, but it was pointless—they surrounded us.

"Just hand over Keifer's girlfriend, and we won't cause trouble," they said.

I'M NOT KEIFER'S GIRLFRIEND! Ugh, this is so frustrating. It's all that jerk's fault.

"There'll be even more trouble if I do that," Rory replied.

The guys with knives glanced at each other, then suddenly

I turned to the other side and saw one of them coming at me. I tried to move—it was too late to dodge. I closed my eyes and waited for the blow to hit me.

"JAY-JAY!"

****Keifer's POV****

Why isn't she here yet? Even if she woke up late, she should be at least halfway through Sir Alvin's lecture.

But two subjects have already passed, and she's still not here.

If she's absent, she'll call or text one of us. This is really

"Why isn't Jay-jay here yet?" Ci-N asked, looking at her

That's the same question I've been asking myself for the
glanced at Yuri. He was looking at his notes, but I knew
mind.

"Did she text or call you?" I asked him.

He shook his head without looking at me.

Damn it!

Why are you making me worry like this? I have no choice
took out my phone and used it to track her.

For about a minute, I stared at it, waiting for the result. I
to find her.

Suddenly, the result appeared. I stood up immediately with
current location.

Hospital?

"Ci-N!" I shouted. He looked at me, confused. "Call you
if they have a patient wearing an HVIS uniform!"

Even the others looked confused. Ci-N took out his phone

I couldn't wait anymore. What if something happened to know what I'd do if something bad happened to her. Not

"There is one... A guy, last name Abejar," Ci-N suddenly
So it's not her!

I should feel relieved, but I don't. I need to see her and confirm with my own eyes.

"Abejar? Isn't that Rory?" Edrix asked, and everyone looked at the empty seat.

What the... I just noticed. Rory isn't here either. Wait, where is she?
together?

I didn't hesitate anymore. I immediately ran out of the room, not caring who was calling me, but I didn't stop.

What if something happened to her?!

I got into my car, started the engine, and drove like a maniac. No one could stop me at this point.

When I got to the hospital, I went straight to the emergency room. There were so many patients. I was about to go to the information desk, but there were too many people blocking the way.

... ..

But I couldn't answer him. Rory wasn't the reason I came

Where the hell are you, Jay-jay?

Chapter 131: Blood

Keifer's POV

Jay-jay!

Please answer your damn phone!

It just keeps ringing, but no one's answering. If I check h
she's still here.

"Keifer! I found Rory!" Drew shouted.

We immediately followed him. He opened one of the cu
was Rory. He wasn't wearing a shirt, and a nurse was sti
wound on his back.

"Good thing the wound isn't deep. But we still stitched it
bleeding," the nurse said as she bandaged his wound.

"Thank you," Rory said.

We waited until the nurse walked away.

"Where's Jay-jay?!" I asked immediately.

"Huh? What did you say?" Ci-N asked.

"She suddenly started shaking in fear when my blood started talking and just cried," he explained. No!

Did it happen again? It can't be. What if it happened again out of her mind right now?

I was about to walk away to look for her again when Roi's name that made me stop.

"Good thing David showed up to help us," he said with a

David helped them. F*ck! No! They can't be together. Did you notice? He's up to something.

I ran as fast as I could, calling her phone at the same time. Nowhere, I heard a very familiar ringtone.

Secret by OneRepublic.

I followed the sound. The closer I got, the louder it became. I was in the emergency room now. The hallway was dimly lit, and people passing through.

I stopped when the sound stopped, and my phone stopped. In the corner, she was sitting on the floor, hugging her knees down.

I hugged her back. Oh crap! I thought something had happened. I thought it happened again.

"You made me worry sick!" I said and kissed her head.

"Keifer... There was so much blood," she said, still crying.

I rubbed her back and hair. "Shhh... It's okay, I'm here. Don't worry."

"I-I was scared... I thought it would happen again."

"Stop crying... Everything is okay now," I said.

But she wouldn't stop. It's hard to calm her down when she's scared. So, I just let her cry like a child.

But I felt relief when she said she thought it would happen again. It means it didn't happen for some reason, but why?

As much as I wanted to ask Jay-jay about it, I knew I couldn't. I couldn't even explain why it happens, so how could she explain why it happened this time?

Her phone rang. She was still crying, so I took her phone.

Her bag and belongings were also stained with blood. It wasn't this time!

I put her phone on silent without declining the call. I was

"He's okay..." I said, forcing a smile.

I wiped her tears and the blood on her cheeks.

"I-I don't understand," she said.

"Hm?"

"I saw blood... So much blood, but I didn't pass out or hu

"We'll figure that out. But right now, you need to rest and said and stood up.

I offered her my hand. She grabbed it and stood up, but l and she almost fell. Thankfully, my reflexes were fast, a before she hit the floor.

"Are you okay?" I asked worriedly.

"M-my knees are still shaking."

Without a second thought, I picked her up in a bridal car up.

"K-Keifer..."

"Shut up and let me be a gentleman," I said with a smirk

Sometimes this girl doesn't realize when I'm trying to be

"Nothing. She just needs to clean up and rest."

I laid her down on the bed next to Rory's. Now that I could see, she had scratches and bruises on her elbows and knees.

"Ci-N! Get some towels and water!" I ordered.

He immediately called a nurse and asked for the things I needed.

Yuri approached us and looked at Jay-jay.

"Jay! What happened? Are you hurt?!" Yuri asked worriedly.

I almost laughed at his expression. He's being too obvious to his classmates. He said he didn't plan to reveal what's going on with Jay-jay, but here he is, practically shouting it.

That f*cking engagement!

"I-I'm okay... How's Rory?" Jay-jay asked.

Rory, who was just across from her, immediately waved. When they looked now, Jay-jay seemed more battered than Rory.

A nurse approached us with the things I asked for. I grabbed a towel, soaked it in water. I held Jay-jay's face and wiped off the blood.

I couldn't help but look into her eyes, but she avoided my gaze. I understood, especially since Yuri was right in front of me.

They look so weird. If it weren't for what happened, I'd p
these two. I can't tell if they're really helping me or just s

I'm so confused! Why didn't what happened before happ

While these two continued what they were doing, the oth
about the guys from another school who attacked us.

"There were so many of them... They wanted Jay-jay, jus
Rory explained.

"I'm sure they'll come back," Edrix said.

"What's weird is why they're showing up now? We've be
before without any trouble," Eren said.

Yeah, why not before? And why am I their target again?
I'm almost at my limit.

"It's very simple," Keifer interjected. "...Ram has weaker
one controlling the gangs in this area anymore."

Ram? The guy I hurt before.

"What do you mean controlling?" Ci-N asked.

When it comes to fights, this guy suddenly becomes inte

"Tale the one who controlled them. Now that he's weak

Oh... right!

That's what the guys who attacked me during the Christmas earlier said. Where did that rumor even come from?

"What are we going to do now?" Yuri asked, pausing when

"We can take turns watching Jay-jay to make sure no one suggested.

"That could work... But we all have our own things to do Felix said.

"Whoever's available," Drew said.

"I can do it, 24/7!" Ci-N said, raising his hand.

"24/7?" Josh asked.

"I live with them, so it's no problem."

My eyes widened at what he said. Crap! They didn't know Everyone froze and looked at Ci-N.

"You live with Jay-jay?" Kit asked.

Ci-N proudly nodded and looked at us. Suddenly, he hid some reason I couldn't understand.

Why am I suddenly nervous? I looked at Ci-N for help, t
hiding behind Felix.

What is this?!

Chapter 132: Karate

David's POV

"How is she?" Percy asked over the phone.

"She looked terrified when I found them. I thought she was stabbed because of all the blood, but it turns out she was Rory," I explained.

At first, I thought it was just a simple fight between rival gangs. I heard one of them mention Keifer's name and call her his

It's a good thing I followed my instincts. Jay-jay was frozen, staring at her blood-covered hands, surrounded by men who were shouting. Rory, on the other hand, was pale and struggling to fight. She looked weak.

If I hadn't arrived, who knows what would've happened to her.

"Why did this happen?! What kind of stupidity did Keifer and Jay-jay get involved?!" Percy asked angrily.

I'm not entirely sure, but I have a strong feeling that his plan was coming back for him. Especially now that Ram no longer

This guy's something else! His anger toward Yuri seems don't know the full story between their group of friends, meddle in things that aren't my business.

But I know somehow that Yuri owes him something. Me keeps making him mad because of Jay-jay. I haven't heard about Aries, though. Maybe in the future, I'll find out exactly what happened between them.

I was about to go back inside the hospital when I saw my coming out. Rory was in a wheelchair, and Ci-N was pushing. Meanwhile, Keifer and Yuri were helping Jay-jay walk.

While looking at them, I couldn't help but think of Ella. ' repeating itself in the same section and with the same people. Jay-jay can handle the true nature of those two and the way when things get messy.

****Jay-jay's POV****

"Karatey! Karatey!" Ci-N kept shouting while kicking the

I swear, I'm going to slap him!

He's like a broken record. My ears are about to fall off. I brain cells are gone. This guy's so annoying!

"Ci-N!" I called him. "...I'll karate-chop your neck if you
The idiot finally stopped and scratched his head as he wa
"Keifer's taking too long," he said.

"Ugh! Don't expect that jerk to be early. He's even worse
when it comes to being on time."

Ci-N just shrugged. I glanced at the time on my phone. I
and we didn't have classes today because the teachers we

I accidentally looked up at the rooftop of the main buildi
you can see it clearly from here, even though it's a bit far

And there's someone there...

Who is that? It looks like they're watching me and Ci-N.
because she's wearing a girl's uniform.

"Do you see that?" I asked, pointing to the rooftop.

"Hm?" He looked where I was pointing. "...Yeah, why?"

"Nothing... Just wondering."

"That's Ella," he said boredly while fiddling with someth

"Ella? How do you know?"

"She did something wrong to me," he said, looking at the
Ella was still there, watching us. Now she had someone to
think it's Aries.

"What did she do?"

"She let her classmates hurt me and didn't do anything. I
help, but she just looked away," he explained.

I could hear the sadness in his voice. It must've been hea
asked a friend for help, but she just ignored him.

"And that's not all," he added. "...She accused me of stea

Oh, right! I remember that. Imelda Maldita. She thought
with it. Good thing I arrived then, or else Ci-N would've
Well, he already was...

"Yeah... I remember that."

"She was behind it," Ci-N said, looking down.

WTF?!!!

"H-how did you know?"

"From Keifer," he almost whispered.

I was right.

Ugh! There's this heavy feeling in my chest, and it's hard though Keifer said he wants me now, I can't help but feel

I stayed quiet and looked away. I didn't want to look at them anymore.

"Jay-jay!" someone called me.

I looked over. "What?" I asked Kit.

"What do you mean 'what'? Let's go! Keifer's here," he said.

Ci-N and I stood up and walked over to him. When we got there the tables were arranged and pushed to the sides.

I saw some of them wearing just t-shirts, like Yuri and Keifer.

"Karatey 101 begins!" Ci-N shouted while clapping.

"We'll teach you the basics," Yuri said.

I scratched my head. Basics, basics... Pfffttt...

Keifer pointed to the spot between him and Yuri. He was standing there. I wasn't really paying attention, so I just followed.

"We'll show you what we've learned first," Felix said.

That's when I realized what they were going to do. Ci-N the notebook out of Felix's hand. No way! It's too high, and short.

Suddenly, Ci-N jumped and spun in the air.

He won't reach it! He won't reach it!—HE REACHED IT!

Wow! Damn! Ci-N actually did it. He kicked the notebook out of Felix's hand. I couldn't help but clap in amazement.

"That was amazing! I want to do that too!" I said.

"It'll take a while before you can learn that. Let's focus on basics first," Yuri told me.

"No! That's what I want!"

"Next time! Basics first!" Keifer insisted.

"That's what I want!"

"You're so stubborn! It's not that easy!" Keifer said angrily.

"Then teach me!"

"Are you stupid?! I said next time!"

"You're the stupid one! You don't get what I want!"

"One more word, and I'll scold both of you!" he threaten away.

I looked at Mayo, who was still clearly annoyed with me

"It's Kapour..." I muttered, which he probably heard.

"You're so dumb! I said Parkour!" he shouted at me.

This jerk! He called me dumb.

"You're dumber! Idiot!" I shouted back angrily.

Everyone suddenly froze, clearly shocked by what I said just say?!

"Uh... Jay-jay just cursed," Ci-N said, looking at Keifer.

Even I looked at him. I think I know what's coming. Oh : smirked.

"Profanity."

Chapter 133: Kiss

Jay-jay's POV

I swear, this King of the Idiots!

He stole another kiss from me. And the worst part? He did it in front of Yuri.

Those useless idiots just stood there, staring at us like fools.

So annoying!

"Yuri..." I called him.

He hasn't been paying attention to me since earlier. He's ignoring me because of what Keifer did. I'm in trouble!

"Hm?" He glanced at me briefly before going back to his work.

"Hey..." I called him again. "...Why are you ignoring me?"

"Because we're supposed to be studying."

"Really? But before—"

I wanted to ask him again, but I might get scolded by the teacher. I looked at my notes, which were just full of doodles. I did that because I wasn't paying attention.

I tore off a piece of paper and wrote on it:

'Yuri, why?!'

I folded it and quickly handed it to him.

He hesitated at first, unsure whether to take it or not. He raised his eyebrow before looking at me and writing a reply.

He quickly threw the paper back at me.

'Please! Pay attention to our lesson and not on me.'

Ouch!

That hurt! Straight to the core. Okay, since I got embarrassed, I crumpled the paper and threw it in my bag.

I slumped in my seat, facing the board. So annoying! I noticed that he just humiliated me.

Suddenly, another piece of paper landed on my desk. I knew it was from Yuri, so I ignored it. He said to pay attention to the lesson, not the lesson!

"Ms. Mariano! If you don't plan to listen, you can leave!" the teacher said angrily.

Oh, great...

"B-but Ma'am—"

"OUT!" she cut me off.

I had no choice but to stand up. I glared at Yuri. This is a

I walked out with my head down, but I couldn't avoid seeing at me.

This little brat!

I'm going to get back at Ci-N when we get home!

Once outside, I went to the side of the room. I headed to the trees. I didn't have anywhere else to go.

Thanks to Yuri!

I sat on the bench where we used to hang out. I suddenly realized this was where Yuri first kissed me.

Ugh!

I get so annoyed whenever I think about him. It's his fault!

I got startled because I thought I was alone outside. I imagined whoever scared me.

"Hahahahaha..."

He just laughed! Yuri, you just keep laughing!

"Are you happy now?!" I asked angrily.

He walked over and sat beside me. I kept glaring at him. Annoying!

"Sorry you got kicked out because of me," he said.

"Will your sorry change anything? I'm already outside!"

He looked down and scratched the back of his neck. Maybe I sounded so mean.

"Why are you here anyway?" I changed the subject.

"I want to apologize and join you as well."

I raised an eyebrow. Join me? Is Yuri crazy? So, he wants humiliation I just experienced.

"You're really something, huh? 'Join you as well,' my focus."

"I know it's my fault you got kicked out. It wouldn't be for

I froze. I was right about what I thought earlier.

"...I know you've never admitted that you love me, but I love with you, and I can't control my jealousy," he added.

I bit my lower lip. This is exactly what I was afraid of. And this would happen eventually.

"...I'm your fiancé, but I feel like I'm sharing your attention," he said. I was shocked to see a tear fall from his eye.

I panicked. I wanted to wipe his tears or stop him from talking, but I couldn't move. It was so awkward, especially since he was my fiancé. Ugh!

"...I shouldn't be demanding anything from you because,

I didn't let him finish. I knew the day would come when I would have to choose between what Keifer was doing. I just didn't think about how much I loved him.

I already said before that I agreed to this marriage, and I was including giving him a chance to prove his feelings for me.

And I'm ready to prove that.

I stopped him from talking in a way I knew wouldn't offend him.

... ..

"J-Jay..." he called me.

I waited for him to say something, but I couldn't keep looking at him.

"Jay... You pervert! You stole a kiss from me!" he said, n

This guy's so shameless!

I slapped his arm hard. He just burst out laughing, which was only a little more annoyed.

"You're so shameless!" I shouted at him.

"Just kidding..." he said, so I stopped.

I bit my lower lip. The embarrassment I was feeling—ug

I glanced at Yuri briefly. I could see him biting his lip w

"Jay-jay..." he called me. "...Can we do it again?"

I glared at him. This guy's crazy!

"You're pushing it! I'll punch you!" I threatened, but he j

"Because... Shit! I'm so giddy."

I couldn't help but laugh at that. It was the first time I heard him say something like that. His expression was so funny.

I nodded, and we stood up. I was about to walk when he my arm and pulled me close to him. He hugged me tight

"Y-Yuri..."

"Shhh... Please give me this moment," he said, so I stopp

"...You don't know how happy I am right now. It's just a means so much to me," he kissed my forehead.

"...Thank you, Jay!"

D-did I do the right thing?!

Something feels off. I don't understand what it is, but I f wrong with what I did.

He let me go and held my hand. "Let's go..."

I pulled my hand back, making him stop.

"I-I'll stay here for now... C-check if Ma'am is still there.

He smiled at me and nodded. He walked away, so I took think.

I don't know why I feel like this. What should I do? Did wrong?

He pinned me against the wall, and that's when I saw what he also saw. I also see the anger in his eyes. I felt fear for some reason I didn't understand.

"What do you think you're doing?!" Keifer asked angrily.

"W-what now—"

"ANSWER ME! DAMN IT!" he shouted, making my chest hurt.

I couldn't hide or deny the fear I was feeling. My knees were almost giving out.

"W-why are you like this?!" I asked, almost crying.

He grabbed my chin with one hand.

"Y-you're hurting me!" I complained.

He brought his face closer to mine. "I told you... You're not safe. What you did with Yuri again, you'll pay for it."

He let me go, and I couldn't stop my tears. This was the first time he treated me like this.

"I'll let what you did today slide," he said before walking away.

I just sat on the floor. The fear I felt was overwhelming. I couldn't handle it. I saw Keifer's Angel!

Chapter 134: Anger

Jay-jay's POV

"You do it!" I shouted at Ci-N.

"Come on... What if your cousin sees me? He'll pick a fight," he pleaded while kicking his legs in frustration.

I scratched my head in annoyance. We've been like this for weeks. He's been ordering me to get ice cream from the kitchen. I have to leave the room because Aries keeps picking fights with him and I see each other.

It feels like I'm the owner of the room, and he's the one who is the one being ordered around.

Nice!

"This is so annoying!" I said to him and stood up from my study table.

"Yay! Thanks, Jay!" he said, clapping his hands.

Ugh, whatever!

I continued walking back to my room. When I entered, I happily.

"Where's the spoon?" he asked as I handed him the ice c

Oh, great!

"I forgot," I said and immediately left the room again.

I almost slipped while running. So annoying! I quickly g
needed and ran back to the room.

I even passed by Aries, but he didn't pay attention to me.

Of course! What else is new?

When I got back to the room, I was out of breath from ru
Ci-N and the ice cream. I was so embarrassed!

The ice cream I brought was almost gone. How could he

"Hey! You're so unfair!" I shouted at him.

"Hehehe... You took too long!"

In my frustration, I threw the spoon at him, but the little
a ninja. So annoying!

"I hope you get tonsillitis " I muttered

It reminded me of Kuya Angelo.

"Ci..." I called the Little Brat.

"Hm?" he replied, still devouring the ice cream.

"Have you ever seen Keifer really angry? Like, really, re asked him.

He's been with Keifer longer, so I couldn't help but ask h

"Yeah, of course... Many times," he answered.

"Really?"

"Yeah... But the one I can't forget is when he got really n said, pausing his eating.

I adjusted my seat to face him properly.

"W-what happened?"

"We didn't know the reason. He was just so angry and ke Ella was crying and kept trying to stop them," he explain

I got another piece of gossip from this kid!

That happened during Ella's time. I wonder what caused

"No... Yuri's a coward," he quickly replied, making me r

"You're the coward!"

He adjusted his seat and faced me properly. He looked so
for him.

"Yuri's a coward. That's why he always sticks close to K
to fight him," he said, making me freeze.

"...He doesn't fight fair either. He acts behind our backs
knowing."

As Ci-N spoke, I felt something inside me that didn't wa
This is the first time I've heard him talk like this about hi

Sure, he's told stories before, but never in this way.

"...That's why I don't like him for you. Don't say yes if he
added before going back to eating.

Too late! We're already engaged...

I turned back to my study table. It felt weird. It's hard to
from Ci-N. He's been with Yuri and Keifer longer than I

I'm just not sure if this little brat is a reliable source.

"Let's watch a movie!" he shouted, pulling something ou

"Ci! That's so gross!" I shouted, covering my nose.

The shameless brat farted!

"Jay-jay! You're so mean! It's just the two of us here, and me?!"

I was about to scold him, but his stomach growled, and he

"My stomach hurts..." he muttered, rubbing his belly.

I took his laptop. "Go to the bathroom! Hurry up!"

He immediately stood up and ran to the bathroom. As soon as he opened his laptop.

I know how to use this, at least. I thought I'd fiddle with it until I knew his password.

This guy's so dumb with passwords!

12345! Hahaha... Welcome Ci-N_Pogi. Pffftt!! Shameless!

I checked the movies first to pick one. There were so many I didn't know which one to start with.

I also checked the pictures. I saw three folders: 'Random', 'Secret', and 'Secret'. Being the nosy person I am, I opened 'Secret'.

She almost ripped my scalp off from pulling my hair so I

Something pushed me to open that folder. There were a bunch of pictures inside.

I clicked on one to enlarge it and see it clearly. But I froze. I was in front of me.

I-it's Kiko!

He was lying on the floor, covered in blood and unconscious. What happened?!

I clicked next, hoping to find an answer to my question. I found another angle of Kiko's position.

I clicked next again. There was a picture of Kiko sitting on the floor. Others were in the frame, making peace signs as if nothing happened. The other guy.

W-what?! W-what happened here?!

I kept clicking until I came across a video. I played it and

The camera was focused on Kiko, struggling against Kit. Kit was hitting him down.

"Beat him up!" Ci-N's voice shouted.

Suddenly, Yuri and Keifer appeared from the other side, and smoking.

"You probably know why you're here, right?" Keifer ask

"Obviously! So you can gang up on me!" Kiko replied a

"You're something else! You really targeted Jay-jay," Yu
another cigarette.

"She was supposed to be mine! You guys interfered!" Ki
Yuri punched him hard in the stomach.

He almost fell to the floor from the pain, but Kit and Ere
stand.

I couldn't understand why they were doing this. I though
confronted Kiko that night he tried to attack me. But why
this?

"I'm getting impatient! Let's start this!" Keifer shouted, t
cigarette butt somewhere.

The camera suddenly moved, and I think Ci-N was holdi
on the other side of Kiko, next to Keifer.

When the angle adjusted, I noticed the others lined up in
David was first.

"You messed with the wrong person!" someone shouted.

"Jay-jay is ours!"

"Learn your lesson!"

"Finish him! Finish him! Finish him!" they chanted in unison.

I felt pain for Kiko. I know he did something wrong and have to go this far?

Someone else took the camera. Ci-N stood in front of Kiko.

"My turn!" he shouted.

He suddenly kicked Kiko in the face. They let him fall to the ground laughing loudly.

He was covered in blood and wasn't moving. His eyes were clear he was struggling to breathe.

Oh my God!

"I'm not done with you yet!" I heard Keifer say before he knelt.

Kiko was so weak that all he could do was cry. I could hear him scream from the pain Keifer caused, but he couldn't.

"Why did you do that to Kiko?!" I shouted at him.

He looked confused at first, but when he saw his laptop c
froze.

"Ci-N! Why?!"

Chapter 135: Unexpected

Jay-jay's POV

Should I go?

Maybe not! Maybe I'll just go straight to school. But I ne
Ugh, so annoying!

"Jay-jay..." Ci-N called me. "...Keifer's going to scold me

"I don't care!" I snapped at him.

He's the one who's going to get scolded, not me. These j
even feel sorry for Kiko and just did that to him.

I already talked to Ci-N, and he clarified what I saw in th
their way of getting back at Kiko for what he did to me.

But I couldn't hide my anger at him. Yes, Kiko did some
but what they did was way too much.

Wasn't it enough that they hurt Kiko that night they save

"Don't go... Keifer might look for you through me. I don
sav." he nleaded.

"Then do better..."

"It's not that simple!" he said irritably.

"Tsk! Just go away!" I ordered him, trying to do a high k

I've been practicing that move for a while now. I almost trying to do it, but I still can't pull it off!

"Jay-jay, come on!"

I quickly flagged down a taxi that was approaching. I go stopped. I glared at the little brat, who looked like he wa where he stood.

"Sir, to Benedict Hospital, please," I told the driver, and

The taxi started moving, leaving the little brat behind for figure out how to explain things to Keifer.

Benedict Hospital was quite far. Good thing Ci-N finally hospital Kiko was taken to. I thought I'd have to force it

I stared out the window. The traffic was light today, and nice. It's a good day for——why do I sound like a report

The trip took about 20 minutes. My wallet was drained f I should've asked Ci-N for money since this is their fault

I went straight to the main entrance. A security guard greeted me and checked my bag before letting me in.

I approached the information counter—or "Information," as the sign on it said.

"Good morning... Do you have a patient named Kiko Evans?" she asked.

She looked at me for a moment and then smiled. "Yes, we have him, your classmate?"

She must've noticed my uniform. I just smiled and nodded.

"Can I borrow your ID?" she asked.

I handed her my ID. While she typed on the keyboard, I noticed the hospital looked fancy, and there really weren't many people around.

"One of your classmates just left earlier. You didn't cross the street yet, still typing."

"Ahh... They didn't tell me," I lied.

She handed my ID back. "I see... He's in Room C9," she said.

"Thank you," I said and was about to walk away when I realized I didn't know where C9 was. "Where's C9?"

When the elevator doors opened, I felt like I wasn't in a hotel. The hallway was beautiful, with white walls and wooden floors.

I looked for Kiko's room.

C5... C6... C7... C8... C9!

I stopped in front of it and took a deep breath. I was nervous. It was a crazy thing to do.

I knocked lightly first. No one answered, so I knocked again. No response, so I gathered the courage to open the door.

I moved slowly. The loud volume of the TV greeted me. It had heard me.

The room was big, with a sofa set near the bed. There was a small fridge, a small dining table, and another door that led to the bathroom. The bed was in the corner, facing a large window with a screen TV.

"I'll eat later... I'm not hungry yet," Kiko said, facing the door.

I didn't know how long he'd been here. But his appearance was... well, not great.

His left leg was in a cast, from his foot to his thigh. This was the part Keifer kicked in the video.

He looked at me, and when he recognized me, he just stared at the TV with the remote in his hand.

He didn't say anything. He didn't even react. It was hard to be mad at me.

"How are you?" I asked as I walked closer to him.

The question felt awkward.

"I-I just found out... that this happened to you," I started, out of breath. "...I-I want to apologize—"

"Don't," he cut me off.

"Huh?"

"Don't apologize. I deserve this," he said, surprising me.

"But..."

"What I did is unacceptable. I deserve this," he forced a smile, the one who should apologize to you."

I couldn't speak. I just looked at him. It felt like I was seeing someone I used to have a crush on again.

"Please... accept my apology. I wasn't in my right mind to do that to you because you rejected me, so I lost control. I

I nodded. I walked around to the other side of the bed and sat down and opened my bag.

I took out the food I brought and placed it on the bedside

"What's that?" he asked.

"Sopas... I didn't know what else to bring you. Manang h this because Kuya Angelo was sick," I explained.

"Thank you... I'll eat it later."

I let him be since he really didn't seem to have an appetit

I observed his face and body. He'd lost weight, and his h longer.

We both fell silent. It was awkward because I didn't know him.

This is so awkward!

Suddenly, my phone rang, so I quickly grabbed it from n

King Idiot Calling...

I silenced my phone without answering. I don't want to t deal with it.

That confused me. They weren't like this with Ella? Why with Ella, who's so beautiful?—harsh!

"Maybe..." I muttered. I coughed lightly. "...H-how are y When can you leave?" I changed the subject.

"It'll take a while. Approximately 6 to 8 months for my f I'll need therapy," he said.

I swallowed hard. Damn! He's been through so much.

"...I've been here for over a month. So, I still have 5 to 7 here," he added with a slight laugh.

I looked down. I felt bad for him. The time he should've wasted lying in this hospital bed.

"H-how about your studies?" I asked, feeling like it was Expelled, man!

"Home schooling... My teacher comes here before 10 a.r long we'll spend studying," he explained.

Wow, he's living the life! Home schooling? I kind of wa

"What did Freya say?"

I might as well ask. Let's begin a bit

"That girl is something else."

"That's just how she is... When someone's no longer useful discards them."

"Tss... I can tell," I commented, and he laughed lightly.

"But she wasn't always like that. She just got hurt, and th

I looked at him. Freya got hurt? Impossible! She doesn't who'd get hurt.

"It doesn't seem like she's been hurt, though."

He suddenly laughed. "You're really harsh on Freya... Se always like this. She was our fantasy back in grade school class with Mykel. But when we got to high school, she c

I suddenly remembered the picture Edrix showed me. Sh fantasy back then. She was so beautiful and simple.

"What do you think happened to her?" I asked.

Kiko didn't answer right away. He stayed quiet and thou

"Ask Keifer and Yuri," he almost whispered.

I looked at him, confused. It took me a moment to remer
Keifer's first girlfriend

I couldn't believe it! I felt like my brain was doing some
stunned by what I was hearing.

F-Freya... Argh!

Chapter 136: Falling In Love

Jay-jay's POV

"WHERE HAVE YOU BEEN?!" Keifer greeted me angrily.

I scratched the back of my head and looked away. "...I-I

"Ci-N said you went somewhere," Yuri added.

I immediately looked for the little brat. That idiot! He was overslept.

"Y-yeah... T-that's why it took me so long, right?" I made

But Keifer was still glaring at me. I kept my head down and

"Why weren't you answering your phone?" he asked sternly.

"B-because... I knew it was you calling," I replied and quickly

Hehehe... I'm so bad!

"Next time, tell us right away. We were worried about you."

Oh, come on!

Are they ganging up on me now? These jerks!

"But where did you really go, Jay?" Kit asked.

"*Cough*... U-uhm... Just around..." I muttered softly.

I couldn't say it properly. I didn't know what place to me

"What?" they asked.

"Uhhh... Around... There..." I dragged out my answer, waiting for them to react.

"If you don't want to say it, then don't!" Keifer said angrily and walked straight to his seat.

The others let me be and sat down too. Just in time, our teacher arrived.

While class was going on, I couldn't help but glance at Emily and what Kiko told me. It seems like he fell in love with the girl.

But what happened to her that led her to those three?!

I also remembered something Rakki told me before. That was about something between Aries and Freya back then. Could that be what he was talking about?

"Jay-jay..." Eren called me.

I looked at him, and he signaled for me to go outside. I followed him. When we got outside, I thought he needed something, but he pointed to the stairs.

"W-what's up?" I asked him.

"It's about Mayo..." he said, glancing at the classroom door. He was bugging me. He's asking me to help him with Kit."

"Then help him..." I said boredly.

That's all it is, and now he's bothering me.

"I can't... Kit threatened me. If I interfere with him and his GIRLFRIENDS. So, I was hoping..." He paused, waiting for a response. "...You could talk to them instead."

Me?

"I don't think so," I quickly replied. "...I don't even know them."

"Just say anything... Get them to talk properly. Like, make them men."

I frowned. This idiot isn't making sense.

"Fine... I'll talk to them."

He clapped his hands in joy. Afraid of being exposed to I dragged me into this. Tsk!

He should be thankful I'm also worried about those two.
really complicated. Neither of them can act properly.

We went back to the room just as our next teacher arrive noticed Mayo glancing at Kit, but the latter was acting o

Sigh...

Class ended. Lunchtime! But we're still eating canned food because the family hasn't settled their debts, so Eman can't buy anything yet.

"I want something with soup..." I heard Ci-N mutter as h
food. "...Sinigang or maybe nilaga."

"Next time, maybe this weekend, Eman and I will go grc
said.

I usually go with him when he shops. It's a promise I made. I could cook for these guys.

"Jay-jay..." Ci-N called me. "...What happened with you?" Ci-N whispered.

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He scratched the back of his head, pouting. "I'm just aski

"He doesn't look good. He's crippled and can't move pro]

"Ahh... What a waste..." I heard him mutter.

What waste?! This idiot!

I immediately pulled his ear. "What do you mean, waste'

"Oww... J-Jay! It hurts! Ow!"

"You were muttering nonsense!"

"T-that's not what I meant!"

I let him go. He was on the verge of tears, rubbing his ea

"Stop muttering nonsense," I said irritably.

"I'll tell Keifer about this," he threatened, mimicking my

I glared at him. As if I'd be scared of his threat. He's tryin
me?

"KeiferJay-jaySwears!" he said quickly, almost unintelli
immediately covered his mouth.

"What did he sav?" Felix asked.

"Ci-N," Yuri called Ci-N, but he couldn't answer because covering his mouth.

"Hmm... hmm... hmm..." he mumbled.

"Huh? What? You want to go out?" I said, pretending to mouth.

"Hmm... hmmmmm..."

"Let's go! You want to go out? Let's go! Let's go!" I said dragged Ci outside, still covering his mouth.

Once outside, I let him go.

"I didn't say I wanted to go out," Ci said, scratching the b

"You're such a jerk! You almost got me in trouble," I said

I walked a few steps away from him. He followed me. I lost my food because of him.

Speaking of food, I saw Josh feeding a black cat. I walked and tapped his shoulder.

"Is that your food? Why are you feeding it to the cat?" I asked beside him.

Ci-N approached the cat and watched it eat.

He just smiled at me in response. Josh is really weird. So him staring at me, and then he'll just smile.

He rarely talks. He teases like the others, but he's usually

"You're so greedy, Edy," Ci-N said to the cat.

Josh and I looked at him, confused.

"Who are you calling Edy?" Josh asked.

"This cat."

"It doesn't have a name. Don't call it Edy."

I looked at the cat, which was still eating. Even though it still see the dirt on its body.

It's a stray!

"Where did you get the name Edy?" I asked Ci-N.

"From its color... It's like the cat in the Eveready battery Edy," he explained with a smile.

Oh, right! That black cat in the commercial. This kid's sr

"No! You can't call it Edy!" Josh said irritably.

"Huh?"

"The ones you saw during the festival night."

Mayo and Kit.

"Hmm... Yeah," I muttered, playing with Edy.

"Now that you know, what's your plan?"

I avoided his gaze. I didn't know how to answer. I don't want to help them.

"Just leave them be. Keifer might get mad if he finds out I'm involved," he said, looking at me. "...You haven't seen him yet."

What the... Why does it feel like he's contradicting me? I want him to tell me something I don't understand.

"What are you trying to say?" I asked him.

"Mayo and Kit are my friends... It's better if they stop this now than only end up hurting themselves," he said.

I could feel his concern for his friends, but why does he want me to stop from fixing things?

I suddenly remembered Ella in him. He talked to me like he was trying to stop Mayo and Kit.

"Aaaggghhhh!!! It bit me!" he shouted, pulling his hand teeth.

But the cat seemed really mad at him. It bit down harder

"I told you not to do that!" Josh said irritably.

"Argh! Get Edy off me!" I shouted at Josh, pushing him.

"His name isn't Edy!"

He really had to argue about the name.

"GET IT OFF!" I shouted.

"Jay! It hurts!" Ci-N cried, tears streaming down his face

Josh grabbed the cat. He petted it, making it let go of Ci-

"There's blood!" I shouted, pointing at his finger.

"I'm going to die! Rabies!"

"Stop overreacting!" Josh shouted at him.

"What the hell?! What is going on here?!" someone shout

I looked up and realized the idiots had already come out

Chapter 137: Punch

Jay-jay's POV

"I'm going to kill Edy!" Ci-N shouted.

"His name isn't Edy!" Josh said irritably, trying to keep t
Ci-N.

They've been like this since yesterday. After getting the a
N has been acting like he's traumatized and has been loo

Josh, being clever, held onto the cat and didn't let it go.

"Leave the cat alone!" I scolded Ci-N.

"But it bit me, Jay..." he replied, almost crying.

I scratched the back of my head. It's his fault for getting
poking it while it was eating.

"It's your fault," Mayo said, petting Edy's head.

"I even fed it, and it bit me!" Ci-N complained.

"It's a cat, not a dog. What's wrong with you?" Josh lectu

"You're getting too attached to Jay-jay. Maybe you should said.

Ci-N didn't respond but looked at me as if saying, *"What problem?"* Yuri walked away, but we were all still staring.

He's probably jealous again.

Speaking of jealousy, I found myself glancing at Keifer straight at me. I couldn't tell if he was angry or not.

I looked away, but my gaze naturally returned to him for he suddenly rolled his eyes.

Oh, please!

His eye rolls are sharper than mine! Ugh, this jerk!

"Are you and Yuri together?" Mayo asked me.

I shook my head. "N-no."

"Why does he act like that? Like he owns you?" Ci-N asked.

"J-just... B-because..."

Tsk! So annoying!

It's Yuri's fault! I don't even know how to respond. Ugh!

I stood up and walked away. I heard Ci-N call me, but I didn't go outside and headed to the second floor of our building.

The wind was strong there, and it felt refreshing. When I

"Why are you here?" I asked him.

He looked at me and forced a smile. "Nothing... I just want

"Same here..." I said and walked closer to him. "...How about you? Hmmm... Mayo?"

"I don't know. He keeps bugging me, but I really don't know what's wrong with me."

"There's nothing wrong with you. There's nothing wrong with your gender," I said, making him look at me.

"It's easy for you to say that. You're not in my position,"

I froze. He's right. I'm not in his position, so I shouldn't say

"Maybe... But you didn't choose this. You became this way

He chuckled lightly. "That's the thing. I wish I was given a choice to become like this."

"Who knows... Everything happens for a reason."

"Let's go..." he said.

I nodded. We walked together toward the stairs but stopped when we saw someone. He was staring at us, and I could see a mix of confusion and anger in his eyes.

"D-did you kiss Jay-jay?" Mayo asked.

Kit didn't answer but kept walking downstairs. He just passed us and quickly followed him.

"Wait! I'm still talking to you!" Mayo shouted.

Kit still didn't listen and kept walking. We were almost at the stairs when Mayo suddenly grabbed Kit's arm.

The two exchanged angry looks.

"Let me go," Kit said firmly.

"I'm still talking to you!" Mayo replied.

Honestly, I didn't know what to do. I'm not part of their lives.

I kept walking toward the room, but as I passed them, a hand grabbed my arm.

"Stay here," Kit said.

Mayo immediately glared at me.

I frowned. What is he trying to say?

Kit immediately grabbed Mayo by the collar. "Don't talk that!"

"Why? It's true! She's no different from Ell-----"

A strong punch from Kit silenced him. He fell to the floor in shock, which caused the idiots to come out of the room.

"What happened?!" Edrix asked, immediately helping Mayo.

"Nothing... He was being rude, so I punched him," Kit said and went into the room.

The others stayed behind, and I was left staring at Mayo. Up, he pushed Edrix away and glared at me.

"Let's talk, just the two of us," he said firmly and pulled me away from the others.

"W-wait! You're hurting me, Mayo!" I shouted, trying to get away.

We stopped near a tree on the side of the building. I yanked Mayo by the collar.

"What's your problem?!" I said angrily.

"Do you like Kit?!" Mayo asked angrily.

"Who tried to kiss you?" someone asked.

Mayo and I both looked to see who it was. I breathed a sigh and thought it was Keifer who asked and heard us.

"...Who?" Edrix repeated his question.

"N-nothing... Y-you misheard," I replied.

"But you were shouting----"

"Edrix! Please!" I pleaded.

I didn't want to tell him who it was. It might reach Keifer and what he'll do to Kit.

"Does Keifer know?" Edrix asked.

I quickly shook my head and walked closer to him. "P-please! Please!"

"But Jay----"

"Can you stop meddling?!" Mayo shouted at Edrix.

Edrix frowned, clearly not happy with how Mayo was acting.

"What's your problem?!" Edrix asked irritably.

"What?! Did you fall for this girl too?!" Mayo said arrogantly. "...Nice! Go ahead and seduce the whole Section E. from Ella!"

"What did you say?! Don't----"

I didn't let Edrix finish. There was no point in wasting his time. I took matters into my own hands.

I was so annoyed! Out of all people, he had to compare me to her. I could've chosen someone else.

"J-Jay... He's bleeding," Edrix said, looking at Mayo on the ground.

Oh no!

I couldn't hold back. So I punched him. But I think I messed up. He was bleeding now.

Ugh! I messed up! I punched him too hard. I hope I didn't hurt him too much.

Chapter 138: Love Hurt

Jay-jay's POV

"How's Mayo?" Edrix asked me as I came out of the clinic.

"He's... being taken care of by the nurse."

"Tsk! That punch of yours was strong. It even surpassed him," he said, shaking his head. Seriously?!

"He made me mad," I reasoned, but he just laughed at me.

I sat down in the waiting area outside the clinic. Edrix forgot to want to go back to the room yet. I'm sure the idiots would have asked questions.

"What were you and Mayo fighting about?" he asked.

"N-nothing... It's just... complicated," I replied, avoiding his gaze.

Edrix seemed to get the hint. He didn't ask further and just went back to his phone.

I heard his phone ring. He took it out, and I immediately saw his wallpaper.

"This is my dream..." Edrix almost whispered. "...For her and shout to the world that I'm the one she loves the most."

I could feel the pain and struggle in his words. How long has he had his feelings for Freya?

"D-did you ever try to approach her?" I asked.

He immediately shook his head while looking at his phone.

"I can't... She's mad at Section E, right?"

Oh, right. And it seems like her anger only grew when I bumped into her.

"If only I could help you with her. But we're not on good terms, so I'm just forcing a smile."

He did the same to me. I wouldn't help him either if we were on bad terms. I still don't know the full story about Freya, Yuri, and Edrix.

"Being in love is hard, huh?" someone asked.

We immediately looked toward the clinic door. Mayo was sitting there, holding a tissue and an ice pack.

He sat down beside me. Now I was sandwiched between Edrix and Mayo.

"Ugh... Your punch hurts, Jay." Mayo said to me.

"...I just got carried away by my anger," he added.

"I-I'm sorry for punching you too," I said, smiling back at

"It's fine! You two are good now," Edrix said, standing up

"...Let's go back to class."

Mayo checked the time on his phone. I looked too. We've
for quite a while.

"We're already late. Let's just go to the next subject," Ma

It was already too late to go back to class now. I'm also f

Edrix sat back down. "Alright, let's go later."

"Who were you and Edrix talking about?" Mayo asked.

"Chicks!" I replied, and Edrix immediately glared at me.

"Girlfriend?" -Mayo

"No." -Edrix

"The one he's dreaming about." -Me

Edrix glared at me again, but I just laughed at him.

"At least you're like that. She knows I love her, but she a said, pressing the ice pack to his face.

"That's even more painful."

I kept glancing between them. It was nice listening to the simple, no drama.

I leaned back and sighed. "Being in love is hard," I comr Mayo and Edrix looked at me.

"You're having a hard time, and you already have two g you," Edrix said, making me frown at him.

"You have Yuri, and then there's Keifer," Mayo added.

W-what? Wait!

"Maybe she likes someone else. Not one of them." -Edrix

"Maybe... Who is it? Tell us." -Mayo

Oh no!

"Keifer will get mad at you." -Edrix

"Poor Yuri. He'll be heartbroken again." -Mayo

"Stop it!" I shouted at them " I just joined your drama!

The two of them were clearly waiting for my answer. But

"If I were you, I'd choose Yuri," Mayo suddenly said, meeting his gaze at him.

"Why Yuri?" Edrix asked.

"Keifer doesn't stand a chance. The problem with him is when it comes to girls. Even if Yuri is the only one left among his friends, he took Ella from him," Mayo explained.

It felt strange. The way Mayo talked about Keifer now was so different from the way Ci-N talked about Yuri before.

Yuri once mentioned that Keifer is selfish when it comes to girls, though two people have said it and I've experienced it myself. It was hard to believe.

"Took her? Who did Keifer take from Yuri?" Edrix asked.

"Ella! Yuri was the one she should've chosen. But Keifer was so stubborn she ended up with him."

Yuri was supposed to be the one?

But Yuri said Ella never loved him. So how did it happen if she was supposed to be the one?

"Yuri said she never loved him. So how did it happen if she was supposed to be the one?"

"H-hi... Why are you here? Don't you have class?" she asked.

"This one's at fault," they both said, pointing at me.

"Huh?!"

"Hahahaha... You guys skipped class and dragged Jay-jay along. He teased.

"No! Jay-jay's really the one at fault," Mayo said, pointing at me.

"That's karma..." Rakki said, turning to me. "...How's Ciara? I heard he's staying with you now."

Aww... Someone misses him.

"He's fine... Especially if he learns how to do his laundry himself," I replied.

I'm the one who does his laundry. It's so embarrassing for him.

The feeling of not doing my own laundry but doing his is terrible.

Lazy!

"Don't expect that from him. Even getting water, he'll just ask me to do it," Rakki said.

Even with us, he's like that. It's so tempting to punch him.

"Probably stressed... Her problems are piling up," Mayo

I looked at him, confused. "Problems?"

Mayo glanced at the clinic door before looking back at n

"Ever since Rakki sided with us, Section A blocked their
she's scrambling to get back the benefits meant for them,

Poor Rakki. She's the president of her section, so the respo
falls on her.

"Don't tell Ci-N about this," Edrix suddenly said.

"Why?"

"Do you want more chaos?" he replied sarcastically.

True, who knows what that kid would do. Aside from pick
Section A, he might even confront the guidance counselor

We talked about a lot of things. Mostly about our classmate
strong connections.

From them, I also found out that Josh lost his girlfriend.
when, but since then, Josh has been acting weird.

Drew, on the other hand, has been sneaking into a nearby
That isn't! He still hasn't paid his debt, and now he's back

We slowly turned around. The King of the Idiots was standing crossed and glaring at us.

I forced a smile, but it didn't seem to work.

"Get back to class... NOW!" he shouted, and we quickly ran back to the room.

"This is your fault, Jay-jay!" Mayo said as we ran.

I glared at him. "You're the one who started it!"

"Enough! Keifer's coming! We're in trouble!"

Chapter 139: Trident

Jay-jay's POV

"Jay... Ice cream..." Ci-N whined, but I ignored him.

"Ice cream... Ice cream..."

He's been bugging me for a while now. I'm annoyed because he's asking me to get him food. He doesn't even clean up after himself. He's so lazy!

"Jay... Jay... Jay... Jay... JAY!" he shouted.

I slammed my hand on the study table. He's so annoying.

"Enough! It's late! Go to sleep!" I shouted at him.

Suddenly, he started sniffing and rolled on the floor.

"Jay-jay's being mean to me!" he said and started crying.

Oh, crap!

Why does this Little Brat seem to have more influence than I do by a cat, and now he's acting like this.

I went straight to the kitchen. But when I got there, there was no ice cream. Aries had taken the last one. I even caught him going to the kitchen while holding the ice cream I was supposed to get.

"Can I have that instead?" I pleaded.

He just looked at me and rolled his eyes as he walked past. "You're so stingy!"

No more ice cream. I'm in trouble with the Little Brat. I went to his room and slowly opened the door, hoping he was already asleep.

But no luck, he was awake. Wide awake. Alive and kicking.

"My ice cream!" he said.

"It's gone."

He started sniffing and rolling on the floor again.

I just scratched the back of my head.

"I'll just buy you some," I said and quickly grabbed my wallet from the table.

Suddenly, he stopped crying and stood up.

Huh?

I was left speechless, amazed by this brat. He's something nothing to say.

I walked out without saying goodbye. They might already grabbed my bike from the garage.

The road was dark, but thanks to the streetlights, I could go. Next time, I'll buy a flasher for my bike so I can ride confidently at night.

This Little Brat is such a hassle!

I headed to the Mini Mart near our house. It's open 24/7, anytime.

I parked my bike and went inside. There weren't many people already late.

I had the Mini Mart to myself!

While I was looking at the ice cream, I felt someone's presence. I didn't move immediately, trying to sense what they would do.

I also looked at the reflection on the glass door of the fridge. I saw the person's face, but it was hard to make out.

"You're taking too long to choose," the person behind me said.

~~~~~

He suddenly laughed. "Because you looked so serious. You want ice cream, but you're staring like it's a life-or-death decision."

"I'm choosing!" I said irritably and turned back to the friend.

Annoying!

"Do you have something to do?" he asked.

I shook my head without looking at him. I was still trying to decide my favorite flavor.

Rakki—I mean! Rocky Road!

Rocky Road! Where's the Rocky Road?! I'll just slap it in my face.

"Do you want to eat first? My treat," David said.

I immediately turned to him and smiled. "Let's go... The car's here. Wait."

He smiled back and shook his head. It's rude to refuse freebies for free. You don't get freebies like this often.

I just got juice and a pre-heated sandwich. I'm still full, so I don't waste too much.

"Did you come out just for ice cream?" he asked.

"What about you? Why are you out?" I asked him.

"I can't sleep. Overthinking, I guess," he replied, looking

"Why?"

"I don't know."

"About what?"

"Lots of things."

"Just tell me!" I insisted.

"You won't understand. It's just some random stuff."

I pouted. He really doesn't want to talk, so there's nothing

I just focused on eating the sandwich in front of me. When I checked my phone. I took it out of my pocket and saw the name of the Idiots.

**\*\*From: King Ulupong\*\***

**\*\*Message: Where are you?\*\***

I frowned. I had no intention of replying to that jerk. What the hell was I doing? Acting like he's my boyfriend, even more than my fiancé.

Oh, come on! There he goes again with his "instinct." It's

How do I get an instinct like that?

I drank some juice, hoping it would stop me from choking

"Are you and Keifer together?"

I almost spat out the juice and nearly threw up right there

Damn it!

My throat hurts! Ugh! It burns!

"S-sorry..." David said, helping me and handing me a tissue

"Damn \*cough\* it!"

He suddenly laughed. If I weren't tearing up from choking  
him with my glare.

This guy's questions are so sudden!

Once I felt better, I drank again. I did it quickly in case I  
question.

It really hurts!

"Your clothes got wet." he said, handing me another tissue

"Huh?"

"Your eyes! Stop staring!"

"S-sorry... It's just your necklace. Why is there a ring with it?"

I touched the necklace. The engagement ring. They don't match.

"I-it was given to me, but I can't wear it, so I just put it here." I nodded, accepting my answer.

"...W-who gave you this necklace, by the way?" I changed the subject. I didn't want him asking who gave it to me; I wouldn't know.

"You're so slow..." he said, making me frown. "...Even now I have no clue."

Damn it!

"Just tell me!"

He took a deep breath and leaned closer to me.

"What's written on the box?" he asked.

"Nothing... Except for the symbol of Poseidon's Trident, which is on the box."

"Exactly! That's your clue."

I shook my head. "Poseidon has so many children in Gre

"You don't know anyone?"

"The only one I know is the fictional character Percy Jac

You're so slow, Jay-jay!

I looked at David, who was smiling at me as if saying, \*'

Google is a thing, but it's like I don't know how to use it.  
right away. Ugh!

But wait! If Percy sent this...

"Do you see Percy?" I asked him.

"No... He just sent it to me."

"B-but you talk to him?" I pressed.

David stared into my eyes. Damn it! My head hurts from  
And here's the answer right in front of me.

Oh, this is intense!

"He calls whenever he wants. We don't have complete co  
replied, and I almost melted.

"I can send him a message, but I can't guarantee he'll reply if I took out his phone.

He typed a message and pointed the camera at me.

"Smile," he said.

But before I could even smile, I heard the camera click. I

"Don't ruin it!" I said irritably.

"Sent," he said and put the phone down in front of him.

We just stared at it for a few minutes. I really wanted to go and bombard Percy with messages.

Damn it! He's such a tease!

I finished my sandwich and juice. I even ate David's food but still no reply. Until suddenly, the phone lit up, and a message came. "Message."\*

David took his phone and read the message. He hesitated for a moment before speaking out loud.

I stared at him intently, so he had no choice. But I froze when I saw the content of the message he was reading.

"Remove that ring from the necklace. Or I will kill you."

# Chapter 140: Why and Wh

## Jay-jay's POV

"Ahhh!" Ci-N exclaimed. "...Why do your eyes look like

I touched the area under my eyes. My eye bags had eye l  
Ugh, so annoying!

Percy hadn't replied after his last message. I almost snate  
begging him to help me.

But David refused to help anymore. He insisted on drivin  
no choice but to cry. He even bought food for Ci-N, but I  
because he was already asleep when I got home.

"I didn't sleep well," I replied and headed straight to the  
couldn't sleep.

I tried closing my eyes and counting sheep, goats, horses  
and dogs in my head, but nothing worked. My head was  
body felt so heavy.

What I still couldn't understand was why he sent that me  
wrong send? But that's impossible.



find what he was looking for.

"What are you looking for?" I asked.

"The thing that's ringing."

As soon as he said that, my eyes automatically searched  
That's mine! That's my ringtone!

I flipped over my bed, but it wasn't there. Then I glanced  
Crap!

I threw my phone in frustration last night. I was so upset  
phone was useless, so I tossed it in the trash.

I quickly grabbed it and checked who was calling.

**\*\*King Ulupong Calling...\*\***

I glanced at Ci-N before answering.

"Hello," I said as soon as I picked up.

["Kindly explain why you're not answering any of my pl  
messages."] His authoritative voice demanded.

"Huh? W-what... I mean... Uh." That was all I could say  
back of my neck

Oh, right! I checked the wall clock. Good thing it was sti

"Y-yes... I'm going. Why?"

["Meet me after."] He said, and then the call ended abrupt

Rude?!

This jerk! He's bothering me this early in the morning. I remind him about our grocery trip. He said he'd come wi

But he looked serious, staring at his phone.

"Hey... What's wrong?" I asked.

"I can't go with you guys."

I gave him a puzzled look. "Huh?"

"I'm meeting with Rakki and... my sister."

I just nodded. I wanted to ask what it was about, but I ch had a strong feeling it was something serious.

He went to the bathroom to wash his face. I changed my came out, I invited him to have breakfast.

On our way, we ran into Aries, who—as usual—gave us

Wait, what?!

When I returned to the room, he was already getting dressed. He looked so put together! When he dresses like this, he doesn't look like a loser at all.

I took a quick shower too. I moved fast, even while getting ready. We left the house together, but Ci-N was the one who left first. I stayed at the corner, waiting for my ride.

While waiting, I noticed a group of men smoking at the corner.

Here we go again!

They were staring at me and whispering among themselves. Just as I could make a move, a loud car horn shattered my eardrums.

Crap! It's Eman!

"Get in!" Eman shouted.

I scowled as I got into the passenger seat. I already knew I wasn't in the shotgun seat. Who else but the guy who deserved to be in the shotgun.

Blaster?!

"What are you doing here?!" I asked, surprised.

I shook my head. "No... They didn't do anything to me."

So early in the morning, and they're already looking for :  
are something else.

Eman just shrugged and started the car. We headed to the

After parking, we went straight to the supermarket. Ther  
of us, so there wasn't much chaos.

Eman held the list, while Blaster and I pushed the cart. V  
noticed the phone Blaster was holding.

The wallpaper was a picture of a beautiful girl.

I elbowed him. "Who's that?"

"Huh? Uh... My best friend," he replied.

His best friend?

"The one who's... Kei's girlfriend—"

"Yeah," he cut me off and walked away.

No wonder Keigan was so protective. She's really pretty.  
Yeah, right!

We continued shopping, and it went quickly since Eman

Then I remembered we were supposed to meet later. An my head. I grabbed the jar of lollipops.

"You're paying for that," Eman said.

"Yeah, yeah... It's for me anyway."

We continued shopping. Once Eman confirmed we had € headed to the cashier.

The line was long.

"This is going to take a while..." Blaster said, turning to me first. I need to buy something from a stall over there.

I looked at the line. It was long, and the person in front of items.

I nodded. "Sure... This will take a while."

"You're leaving me?!" Eman said irritably.

"Then come with us... Let's go!" Blaster urged him.

Eman just gave him a dirty look. We said goodbye and h

Eman didn't seem like the type to pick fights like the oth mature. But when he felt like messing with someone, he had as the rest

But it seemed true because across from them sat Rakki and he resembled Ci-N and his brother.

She was stunning and looked sophisticated.

I wasn't sure how long they had been talking or how long I was staring, but their expressions were very serious.

Suddenly, Ci-N stood up and approached Rakki. I thought I should say something, but he leaned in and kissed him.

"Ooohhh... Ooohhh.." I called out to Blaster.

I suddenly forgot his name. The salesperson he was talking to was me.

"What's wrong, Jay?" Blaster asked.

I couldn't speak. I just pointed to where Ci-N and Rakki were.

"Nice! Looks like the youngest in Section E is all grown up!" Blaster quickly taking out his phone to take a picture.

That little brat!

"...Let's go. They might see us," Blaster said, grabbing the salesperson.

But I couldn't move. I wanted to see what would happen

"You look ridiculous, Jay..." Blaster commented, making  
"...Smiling to yourself. People will think you're crazy."

I just glared at him. Who cares if I'm smiling because of

When we got back to the supermarket, Eman was next in line. I joined him.

"Emaaaaannn..." I called out to him, still giddy.

"What's wrong?" he asked.

"Because we saw Rakki and Ci-N—"

"They kissed," Blaster cut me off.

Show-off!

I glared at him. I was supposed to be the one to say that. Blaster was annoying.

"Nice!" Eman commented.

"At least Ci-N scored. Unlike someone here who's still single with his girlfriend," Blaster teased.

There were only three of us here. Obviously, it wasn't me. I didn't have a girlfriend. It wasn't the cashier either since we don't know her.

# Chapter 141: New York

## Jay-jay's POV

"...Admit it, man! You're really weak!" Blaster teased.

"Leave me alone!" Eman snapped back.

They've been like this since we were at the cashier, all the way to the parking lot.

I was the one apologizing to the people who were staring at these two.

"Woohh! Virgin!" Blaster shouted, and I couldn't help but laugh.

"Hahahahahaha..." There was nothing wrong with what I laughed because Eman looked so annoyed.

"You jerk! I told you to stop!" Eman yelled, his face turning red.

Why is it so funny when guys tease each other like this? It's just a joke, it feels so serious and annoying.

"Why? Are you embarrassed? Because you're still a virgin?"



I should've checked the caller ID first. Pffttt...

"Y-yes..."

["Don't go anywhere. I'll pick you up."] He said and hung

So rude!

\*I'll pick you up?\* Does he even know where I am? May I call him.

Speaking of the two, they were still arguing. I walked over and looked like they were about to throw punches.

"I'll go ahead. I have somewhere else to be," I told them.

"Where? I'll drive you," Eman offered.

"It's nearby."

They both nodded. I took the jar of lollipops from them. since Blaster had something else to do.

I watched their car drive away. Just as they disappeared, the GTR appeared.

Rich people, huh?

"Get in " he said as soon as he arrived

The ride was short because of how fast he drives. He par alongside his other cars. I looked at the other vehicles ne I'm so jealous.

"Keifer... You're rich. Can I have one of these?" I asked,

He looked at me seriously. "Which one?"

Wait, what? He said \*which one\*?!

"Are you serious?!"

"Yeah... Just make sure you don't marry Yuri. I'll give yo he said, crossing his arms.

I looked at his cars and his mansion. Maybe I don't want all. The payoff is huge.

Hehehehe, just kidding!

"Bleeehhh..." I replied.

"Tss." He smirked. "...Even without all these, you'd still

So arrogant!

"In your dreams!" I shot back.

He just laughed and shook his head. So full of himself X

We went to their basement, the mysterious hangout of the  
This was where Keigan brought me before when I was lo  
"What's that you're carrying?" Keifer asked.

He was talking about the jar of lollipops. I handed it to h  
He took it, looking puzzled.

"I remembered you had a lollipop in your mouth the first  
said, smiling.

He was silent for a moment, as if thinking.

"I remember. Those were the times I tried to stop smokin  
raised the jar slightly. "...as a substitute, but it didn't worl  
I nodded. Right! That was when I hadn't seen him or Yui  
"...but thanks anyway. It's a shame, though."

I looked at him, confused. "A shame?"

"It's not the kind of sweet I want to substitute for cigaret

The first thing that came to mind was Lips candy. But th  
different about the way Keifer was looking at me.

We kept walking. When we opened the door to their myse  
Edrix, Rory, and Felix were there.

"Hi Jay!" They greeted me.

"Hello, what's up? Why are you guys here?" I asked, sitt  
them.

"Why? Is it bad? Do you want Keifer all to yourself?" Ec

I smacked the back of his head. This guy's so annoying!

I was asking a simple question.

"That hurt..." He complained, rubbing his neck.

"Serves you right... I asked you a simple question."

Rory and Felix chuckled a little. Keifer sat across from u  
of alcohol.

Alcohol again!

Does this guy have a drinking problem? Every time I see  
a bottle or a glass of alcohol.

But honestly, it takes a lot for him to get drunk. His liver  
steel.

"Are you kidding me?" I asked irritably.

"Huh?"

"How can I tell it's my dad? He's facing away!"

Edrix scratched his head and started clicking something

In the next picture, everything changed. My annoyance disappeared. All my attention was on the laptop screen.

It was Dad!

He was wearing golf attire, looking into the distance. I was sure the picture was taken, but it was clearly him.

Edrix clicked next, and the picture changed. Dad was in a different setting, facing someone dressed similarly.

The picture changed again, and this time he was at a long table with other men in business suits.

Edrix kept showing me pictures, and I'll admit, I didn't want to stop. But he had to because some of the pictures started repeating. Edrix only had a few.

"W-where did you get these pictures?" I asked.

"Some from a business magazine, others from a news outlet."

I was stunned. A businessman? Dad's rich? But if he's wealthy, why hasn't he done anything to see me?

I couldn't understand. My head was hurting again. It felt like a wedge between me and Dad was growing wider.

"...He's currently in New York right now," Rory added.

It felt heavy. I had no idea what his life was really like.

"Aside from that... We have something else we want to show you," Edrix chimed in.

Edrix clicked something on the laptop. A folder opened, and a gallery of Dad appeared, but this time he was with someone.

P-Percy?

I looked at Felix. He didn't react, but I knew he had questions.

"H-he's with Percy?"

Edrix showed a few more pictures, and they looked like a family. They were golfing, laughing, eating at a restaurant, and I was part of the family.

Aside from feeling confused, I also felt jealous. I wanted to be like that too.

I ran my fingers through my hair. Tears started falling on so heavy. I really wanted to get to know Dad, and then I with Percy.

Percy, who I've faced and talked to several times.

"Jay..." They called me.

"I'm okay... It's just unfair," I said.

Felix handed me a tissue. I looked at Keifer, who was also seriously.

"Thank you... At least I have a clue about him now," I said.

"But you don't look happy about it," he said.

"I am happy... I'm just annoyed. It only adds to my quest

"I know... It makes you frustrated."

I nodded. It's true. The questions keep piling up, but there

"...But no matter what happens, we'll help you find answers to your questions."

# Chapter 142: Message

## Jay-jay's POV

If my eyes had a mouth, they would've been cursing me from the layers of eye bags, I've added even more.

Thankfully, I haven't seen Tita or Kuya yet. Otherwise, I'd be with questions again.

"Did something happen?" Ci-N asked me.

I just shook my head. "N-nothing..."

He put down what he was carrying and sat beside me. Even when there were no more tears, I kept wiping my eyes.

"Jay... What happened?" he asked.

"I found out something about Dad."

"Shouldn't you be happy?"

I forced a smile. "I am happy. It's just that the situation is... Tears were threatening to fall again."



I grabbed a pillow and smacked his face with it. he didn't keep hitting him with the pillow.

"Hahahahaha... Ouch! Hahahahaha... W-wait! Hahaha St

How am I supposed to stop if he won't stop laughing?

We both got tired eventually, so I stopped. This little break moment.

"You're so annoying," I said irritably.

"S-sorry... I'm just not used to seeing you sad," he said, s

Well, I'm not used to being sad either. The Ulupongs are and it's contagious.

Even though what Ci-N said had no connection to what I it still managed to lighten my mood.

"What happened with your errand earlier?" I changed the

"U-uh... It's fine," he replied, avoiding eye contact.

I suddenly remembered what happened earlier. I couldn't wasn't sure if I should tease him about it or keep it to my

"Ahhh..." I said, nodding.

Condo units? Penthouses? Apartments?

What's this? It looked like a brochure of places to live. The estimated prices at the bottom of each page.

"Why do you have this?" I asked Ci, who was changing

"My sister gave it to me... She told me to pick one. She'll

"Huh? Get it for you? Why?" I asked, confused.

he looked serious as he stared at what I was holding.

"I can't go back home anymore. Mom wants me to mature, they think is the solution," he explained.

WTF?!

Did they forget Ci-N is only 14 years old? And what's this? Are they serious?

I felt sad. I thought we'd be laughing and teasing each other. It happened earlier. But it seems like he came back with a

"What's your plan?"

"I don't know, but it might be better this way. Nothing's changed since I was practically alone at home anyway. Except for... could have argued and mess with," he said, forcing a smile.

"Can you apply to be my maid?" he said, grinning misch

Oh, come on!

This brat really knows how to ruin the moment. I grabbe immediately smacked him with it. I thought he was goin serious.

"Just kidding!" he said.

"You're so annoying... You ruined the moment." I put the sat beside him. "...When are you moving? Will someone

"Impatient much?! I still have to pick a place to live!" he eyes at me.

I couldn't help but laugh at his expression. Sometimes, C questionable. If it weren't for what I saw earlier, I might' like Mayo and Kit.

Someone knocked on the door. It opened, and Tita Gem

"Jay... Let's go. It's dinner time," she called us, smiling.

Ci suddenly stood up and ran out. Tita just laughed at him

"What about you, Jay?"

"I'll follow," I said, smiling.

["About what? Can we talk about it in person?"]

"There's no time... Can you just tell-----"

["I'll come to you. Where are you?"] he insisted.

"No! Please, David... Just tell him for me."

I heard him sigh.

["What do you want me to tell him?"]

I held onto my necklace. "Tell him this... 'If you have no me who you really are, then don't show up or make your again.'"

["I'll pass it on."] he replied and hung up.

This is for the best. I'm only getting more confused by w obvious he doesn't want to admit his intentions or who h

It's just frustrating.

+++++

**\*\*David's POV\*\***

["...I can't blame her."] Percy said.

"Just get back here as soon as you can." I said and ended

I don't know exactly what happened to Jay-jay or why she  
know Keifer did something to make her say it.

Last night, she was practically begging me to call Percy,  
doesn't want to talk to him anymore.

Percy...

I want to end my contract with him. I just hope he comes

+++++

**\*\*Percy's POV\*\***

I really want to go back. I want to see Jay-jay and explain

"Sir." Someone called me.

I just looked at him boredly.

"...Your Mom is waiting for you."

When will this end?

I stood up and walked to their office. It's not far, but it feels  
to reach their door.

I just nodded shortly. I waited for them to finish their con

I stood near the glass window. I could see the cars and p  
looked like toys and ants from where I was standing.

"Percy... What did your doctor tell you?" Mom suddenly

"Same old, same old." I answered boredly.

"Did he give you new medication?" Tito Jasfher asked.

"Nope... He said my body is responding well to the first  
me."

"Tell us immediately if you feel pain in your spine again

I forced a smile and nodded. Stupid spine! Why can't you  
when I thought I was okay and could get closer to her, th

We had to come here for therapy and surgery.

That accident.

It changed my life. Literally. It killed Percy Rey Collins  
Percy Rey Mariano. Which is stupid!

It took me away from my friends, my family, my girlfrie  
used to have. In exchange for all that, I have this now.

I knew what it was for. My hands itched to grab the envelope, but I couldn't wait.

We reached the basement parking. As soon as we got in, I had been waiting for.

Tito handed me the envelope.

"Finally..." I said.

I opened it and looked at the contents. It was a picture, a

"What's the update on Jay-jay?" Tito Jasher asked.

Nothing new, she's going to school. Walking with that kid home with food.

I suddenly stopped when I saw something new.

"This one..." I started and handed the picture. "...She visited Benedict Hospital."

"Does it indicate who it is?" he asked while staring at the

"No."

Mom started to laugh at us. "Both of you look like stalkers."

"Can you blame me? I'm her Dad." He answered, sounding

# Chapter 143: Sunday Morning

## Jay-jay's POV

"...So you go to church?" I greeted Ci-N as he came out of the room.

"Only sometimes. Someone just invited me today," he replied.

Ayyyiieehhhh...

I already knew. No need to ask further. It's none other than Diego.

I glanced at my phone when I heard it ring.

Yuri Calling...

I stepped out of the room. I didn't want Ci-N to know Yuri knows what he might think.

"Hello?" I answered almost in a whisper.

["Are you busy?"] he started.

"N-not really... Why?"



ready.

I went back into the room and immediately sat on the bed. Nothing happened.

"Do I look okay?" Ci-N asked.

"You look fine."

"Do I look like 'That's my Bae' material?" he said while looking at me.

"Are you going to church or a fashion show?"

He scratched his head and pouted. "I'm going to church."

"Then get out already! You look fine!" I said irritably.

Just leave already!

A few minutes were wasted just talking to him.

"Okay, okay... I'm leaving now," he said, checking his watch.

He walked toward the door. I thought he was finally leaving me alone.

"Are you sure I look okay?" he asked.

"YES! YOU LOOK HANDSOME!" I shouted, and he stopped.

I immediately ran to the bathroom and took a quick shower in a hurry too.

I just put on pants and a t-shirt. I was in a rush and didn't have time to wear anything else.

I ran out of my room and headed to the living room. Tita

"Jay... Where are you off to?"

"To... To... To... Church-----"

"Ma'am, there's someone outside waiting for Miss Jay-jay. I interrupted before I could finish.

It's Yuri!

"Who's-----"

"I'm leaving, Tita!" I shouted and quickly ran outside.

I didn't wait for Tita's response. When I got outside the gate I was underdressed compared to Yuri.

He was wearing something semi-formal, while I was just in my pajamas. I went back and changed.

"Jay!" he called out when he saw me. "...Shall we go?"

Oh my! Such a gentleman!

Not like that other guy. So---Haaaaiiiizt! Don't think abo

Yuri started the car as soon as he got in. I thought he was somewhere far, but we just went to the nearest church.

I hope Ci-N didn't go to church here.

"Are we going to church here?" I asked as I looked at the

"Of course... Don't you want to?" he asked while parking

"Not really... I expected you to take me to a Buddha tem

He raised an eyebrow.

"...Because you're Japanese, right? Japan is Buddhist, is

He suddenly burst out laughing, even hitting the steering

"What year were you born? It's the 21st century, Grandn  
everywhere now," he said, talking to me like I was some  
couldn't understand.

I pouted. "How was I supposed to know?"

He just shook his head. He opened the car door and got c

"Okay?" he asked, confusing me. "...Okay, right? Can you hold my hand now?"

This guy!

We were already sitting, and he was still holding my hand, enjoying it.

He looked at our hands. I thought he'd let go, but he just tightened his grip.

"Hey. Are you going to let go or not?"

"Just let me hold it," he pleaded, pouting.

I shook my head. "Stop that. It doesn't suit you."

He leaned closer to me. I thought he was going to do something, but he just made puppy eyes and pouted again.

"Doesn't it suit me?" he said.

I was about to laugh at his expression, but someone else looked over and saw a group of girls staring at us and giggling.

Oh... Are we that close, ladies?

Yuri suddenly straightened up and looked forward, becoming serious. He let go of my hand.

While listening to the priest, I couldn't help but glance at who had laughed at Yuri earlier.

They kept looking at us—or more accurately, at Yuri. The giggle.

Seriously? Did you come here for mass or what?

I slightly elbowed Yuri to get his attention.

"What?" he whispered.

"You have a fan club," I replied, subtly pointing at the girls.

He seemed to understand immediately and looked at them.

"Just ignore them," he said.

I followed his advice. But there are times when you just let others act.

Now they were targeting me. How did I know? They'd look down and then laugh.

Hey!

This is so annoying! We're in church, for crying out loud! For I am a sinner... A sinful creature...

"Look at your fan club and laugh," I instructed.

"Why?"

"Just do it," I insisted.

The idiot forced a laugh and looked at them. But this Yuri charm, suddenly giggled, causing the people around us to

"Behave," I whispered again.

"Sorry... I couldn't help it."

Ugh! I shouldn't have paid attention to them in the first place, just embarrassing ourselves. So annoying!

I forced myself to ignore the other group. Until it was time.

We lined up, and as luck would have it, the group of girls lined up across from us.

Seriously?!

They were all trying to act cute for Yuri. And this guy, since I couldn't see if he was playing along.

I suddenly lost my appetite. So annoying! I left the line and went alone. The nerve of him, he didn't follow me.

Hm?

"Come on... Open your mouth," he insisted.

Even though I was confused, I did as he said. I was surprised when he suddenly placed the host in my mouth.

"That was supposed to be for me, but I decided to give it to you," he said with a smile.

I was speechless.

I was stunned for a moment. But you're not supposed to be surprised. Yuri's in trouble if anyone finds out.

I forgot about the group of girls earlier. Until the mass finished.

He held my hand, and we walked out of the church together.

"Where do you want to go?" he asked me.

"A-anywhere."

"Are you sure?"

I just nodded. I had no idea where to go on a day like this.

"How about a motel?"

He was quiet for a moment, thinking. He also checked the watch.

"Let's just cook something."



# Chapter 144: Sundate

## Jay-jay's POV

"...Fried chicken?" I asked.

"Legs!" Yuri replied.

"Same here... Do we need seasoning mix?"

"Probably... Let's grab some," he said, picking up a pack

We were currently at the supermarket. We decided to just stay here, it was too tiring to go somewhere else, and I might just run into those girls earlier. Ugh!

We were looking for other things to buy aside from what we needed to cook.

"Snacks? Should we grab some?" he asked, pointing at the snack aisle.

"Sure... Sure..."

We went to the junk food aisle and started grabbing stuff. It's actually a couple doing this. It's actually kind of fun.

I nudged Yuri, who was waiting for the cashier to finish.

"Where are we going to cook?" I asked him.

"At my place... We can't do it at yours. Aries and I might fighting."

He had a point there. They might clash. Better not risk it we're having fun with what we bought.

The cashier finished, and Yuri paid. I didn't contribute at pointing out what to buy.

We headed straight to the parking lot where his car was. groceries into the passenger seat.

"Let's go... Let's cook our lunch," he said, starting the car.

We were quiet during the drive, but I noticed him smiling.

He's gone crazy!

"Hey! What's wrong with you?" I called out to him.

"Huh?"

"You're smiling to yourself."

"Oh hahaha Sorry I'm just excited "

STOP! Don't think about him, Jay! Yuri's with you now. wrong!

I quickly got out of the car and grabbed our groceries, but from me.

"I'll handle it..."

"Let's split it," I said, trying to take one of the bigger bag

"I've got it. I can manage," he insisted.

I let him be. No point arguing with him. He's stubborn like

We walked to the elevator. As the doors closed, I suddenly something.

My hand automatically rose, and I slapped Yuri hard on the neck.

"Ouch! Why?!" he asked, startled.

"You jerk! I finally figured out what 'baka' means! It too!" I said angrily.

I heard Calix say it to Felix once, and I suddenly remembered to me when I accidentally hit his... you know... that thing brought me to his place.

He was quiet for a moment, thinking. He seemed to remember and rubbed the back of his neck and looked down.

"W-well... I was just mad back then. Sorry," he said, forcing a smile.  
This guy!

At least now I know. If he ever says that to me again, he's not coming from me.

"Baka! Baka! Baka!" I shouted at him.

Suddenly, his face turned serious. He seemed annoyed by my outburst.

"Jay-jay..." he started. "...Aishiteru."

Huh? What did he say?!

I immediately raised my fist to punch him. "Are you insulting me?"

He suddenly burst out laughing. Oh no! He's completely ignoring me. He's treating me seriously, and he just laughs at me. There must be something wrong with his brain.

"I'll teach you a few Japanese words," he said.

"Why?"

"Because if I take you to Japan, you might just start picking fights with me."

Ahhh... Konnichiwa.

"Konnichiwa..." I said.

"Konbanwa means Good Evening."

This is actually easy. I thought it would be harder. Yuri u on the phone, and it sounded like alien language to me.

"How do you say 'Thank you'?" I asked.

"Arigatou Gozaimasu..."

(N/A: Gozaimasu is pronounced as gozaimas)

Suddenly, the elevator doors opened. I didn't even notice trying to repeat what he said, but I didn't get it right.

"What? Aribato nilamas?!"

He suddenly stopped and looked at me. Just as I looked at maids standing there.

Oh no!

I said it so loudly too. They were all looking at me, probably what I just said.

I bit my lower lip and quickly walked closer to Yuri, hiding

I didn't even notice where we were going until we reached. It had a modern vibe, except the floor was still wooden, and still Japanese-style.

"You handle the chicken, I'll take care of the pasta," he said, handing over our groceries.

He said he was going to cook spaghetti. No one's birthday cooking.

He grabbed something from a small drawer near him. He then turned and surprised me by putting an apron on me.

"So you don't get dirty," he said.

I just nodded. They even have this? At home, I just wear a kitchen apron to cook. Sometimes I even look like a rag.

While preparing, I kept repeating the Japanese word for 'mess up' and want to mess up again and have someone hear me.

"Ariga-to... Go-go-go..." I whispered.

"Arigatou Gozaimasu..." Yuri corrected.

"Arigato Golaymas," I said, and he burst out laughing.

Pffttt... So annoying!

"A-ri-ga-tou," he said, and I followed.

"A-ri-ga-tou."

"Go-zai-masu."

"Go-zai----" I didn't get to finish.

Oh my!

His lips were already on mine. He took advantage of the

And me, like an idiot, didn't even stop him. I was frozen  
Nice!

This guy's something else. He just steals a kiss out of nowhere. He really timed it while we were doing something.

He pulled away slightly and looked at me. He even smiled. He touched my lip with his thumb.

"I'll teach you again next time. But now, let's continue cooking. Let's go back to what he was cooking.

I, like a fool, went back to what I was doing, even though I was a bit blank. I think I was shocked by what Yuri did.

My heartbeat wasn't normal either. Ugh! What's wrong with me? I've been feeling like this? I don't know how long I've been like this.

I felt bad, so I helped too. I started cleaning up as well. I  
of the trash.

While cleaning, I didn't notice some of the utensils. Sudd  
of my palm.

"Ahhh..." I screamed, immediately holding my hand.

I looked at what I had touched. Crap! There was a knife

Yuri immediately came over to help me.

"Blood... Tsk!" Yuri said.

My whole body automatically started shaking. It felt like  
with cold water. I could feel the blood flowing from the  
hand.

Damn it! Why now?

"Hold still... I'll just get----"

"NO!" I shouted, stopping him. "...No! D-don't leave!"

I pressed hard on the wound. I couldn't look. I was scared  
happens again? I closed my eyes.

"I-I'll just get the first aid..."



True, it's small. Far from my gut. But I couldn't help but happens again? What if I lose control and hurt someone?

He's the only one here with me now. I don't want to hurt

Please, no...

"I-I'm scared... I-I don't want to hurt you," I whispered.

I knew Yuri was confused because he went silent.

"I-it's okay... Why would I get hurt? You're the one who

"Please... Y-Yuri. Call Keifer," I begged.

I knew it was wrong. Very wrong because Yuri's the one Keifer knows about my situation.

I knew he wasn't moving.

"I'm here, Jay... W-why do I need to call Keifer?"

# Chapter 145: Mentally Ill

## Jay-Jay's POV

"...The wound is shallow. It doesn't need stitches, but I need to clean it so it won't bleed anymore," the maid explained to me. So

He didn't call Keifer, but he did call the maids to help me. Damn it!

"Th-thank you," I said and forced a smile at them.

They smiled back. "Please wait here for Young Master," leaving.

I was left alone in what looked like a mini-clinic, staring weak. I looked at my apron, which had blood on it.

It's gone...

I can't understand why this only happens with fresh blood wrong with me?

A light knock on the door made me look up. It was Yuri, sadness.

"It's okay... But I wish you'd explain to me what happened. I don't know anything about you."

I bit my lower lip. This is my fault. I should have told him we get married and he still doesn't know the truth?

"You do know things about me... just not everything. I want you—tell all of you. Because even I don't understand what's happened to me," I explained.

"It's not wrong to open up. Who knows? Maybe I can help you out."

He was right...

I've been trying to understand it on my own for so long, I don't know where to go anywhere. Maybe he really can help me.

"Yuri, the thing is..." I took a deep breath. "...s-something happened to me."

He looked me in the eye, waiting for me to continue.

"W-when I see blood, something strange happens to me. It was just a phobia, but as time passed... it became something more."

"...I black out as far as I can remember. But people say I start hurting others," I continued.

I shook my head. "That's the story we agreed to tell you. Angelo and Aries know what really happened. They told me they knew something... but they didn't."

"Keifer knows? Is that why you wanted me to call him?"

I nodded in response.

Yuri looked at my wounded hand, then fell silent, as if doing so hurt.

"I-if you don't want to be with me anymore because of this,"

"No. No. Don't say that," he cut me off. "...I love you, Ja. No matter what happens or what you do, I will always love you."

"But what if—"

"Don't think about anything. Don't ever think that... Please."

I forced myself to nod. But the truth is, my mind was filled with thoughts.

What if it happens again and I hurt him? What will I do?

He stood up and stepped closer to me, gently lifting my chin to look at him.

"We will figure this out. You trust me, don't you?" he asked.

I had no reason to refuse, so I just closed my eyes, waiting for his touch to reach mine.

Neither of us moved, and I almost stopped breathing.

I won't lie, I didn't want time to move forward. I don't know how I knew that I felt comfortable being with Yuri.

Our lips stayed together for a few seconds until he slowly pulled away from his.

Oh, crap! Wait a second...

I tried to pull away, but he immediately held the back of my hands on his chest, but even that didn't stop him.

Damn it...

I had no choice but to respond to his kiss. For some reason, his kiss wasn't rough, a part of me was telling me to stop.

He wasn't like Keifer—of course, they were different people. Compared to Keifer, Yuri's kiss was light. Sweet, gentle, and something I never felt with Keifer.

But why am I still thinking about Keifer's kiss?

I forced myself to pull away from him. I gasped for air and

"N-nothing... I just remembered something," I replied.

He immediately hugged me. "I probably had bad timing.

Before I could even answer, I froze and looked toward the girl who stood there, with full bangs and unbelievably pale skin.

A ghost?!

"Why are you eating Yuri-san's face?" she asked me.

Yuri quickly pulled away and looked at the girl in shock.

"Yoichi!" Yuri shouted.

The little girl, Yoichi, immediately ran out of the mini-classroom.  
Yoichi? Yuri's sister?!

"She's so stubborn..." Yuri muttered, then turned back to me.

"...I'll go check on Yoichi. You can get to my room on your own.

"Y-yeah..." I think.

He smiled at me before leaving to find Yoichi. I was left alone.

This is the right thing. It should be Yuri because I agreed to do this. A part of me is telling me this is wrong.

As long as there's a staircase!

Since that was all I could recall, I climbed every staircase flights of stairs, I finally found the right way to Yuri's room.

Success!

His room hadn't changed. Except for the curtains that used to be closed. Now they were open, showing his big balcony.

I finally had the chance to look around his room. I didn't go in before because he was always grumpy.

I walked toward his study table and noticed the picture of him and his family. There was also a class picture of his classmates.

This must be from last year!

As I kept looking, his books caught my attention.

Such a hardworking student! There's the internet, but he doesn't use it.

Suddenly, the door opened. I thought it was Yuri, but it was his mother. They brought the food Yuri and I had cooked, along with plates and utensils.

Will I even be able to eat this?

"Yeah... She's in her room now," he answered.

We both nodded and fell silent. Avoiding each other's gaze awkward.

Pfft...

"W-want to eat?" he asked, pointing at the food.

"Sure..."

As he prepared the meal, I walked to his bookshelf.

One book stood out. A photo album disguised as an old book.

"Can I look at this?" I asked.

"Go ahead..."

I picked up the book. The cover was just a design—inside were pictures.

Fancy photo album!

I sat beside Yuri and opened it in front of him. The first picture was a crying young Yuri.

"Hahaha... Is this you?" I pointed at the kid.



I flipped another page and saw a picture of Yuri, Keifer,

They looked happy in the picture—except Keifer, who was smiling while Percy had his arm around him.

I kept looking. There was one where Yuri and Aries were Keifer and Percy rode behind them.

There was even one where they wore church acolyte robes.

"You guys served at church?" I asked.

"Yeah, Angelo made us do it. He thought it might straighten us out."

"What happened?"

"They kicked us out. Keifer punched the head acolyte."

Pffftt! Hahaha...

"What an idiot."

I flipped more pages. There was a picture of Aries in a baseball uniform. I knew he used to play, but I didn't know why he quit.

Percy and Keifer were in baseball uniforms in another picture.

Wait...

This picture felt heavy.

"That was the last photo of us together."

# Chapter 146: Frustration

## Jay-jay's POV

I don't want to ask. I don't want to, even though I do. It's really don't want to.

I don't want to open the topic of the accident. Even though I know the truth.

I already know some parts, but not the whole story. The I'm already intimidated!

"We're here..." he said, stopping the car in front of our house.

"...should I pick you up tomorrow?"

"Maybe not... I'll go with Ci-N. he still doesn't know," I said.

"Ahh... Okay. Maybe next time."

I just smiled at him. I was about to open the car door when he grabbed my arm.

"Wait..." he said.

"I'm just making up for lost time."

Making up for lost time?!

"What are you making up for?" I asked, confused.

"B-because... Keifer, you've been kissed so many times, few times," he explained.

I immediately felt annoyed by what he said. It felt like he

"What do you mean by that?" I asked seriously.

"N-nothing... I'm just jealous," he answered like a child.

"You're acting like a kid... And this isn't a competition!"

"Sorry..."

"Oh! Now you're quiet!" I offered, ready to hug him.

He immediately smiled and hugged me. He made the mc for a while before letting go.

I opened the car door and got out. I waited for him to leave approaching our gate.

I was just one step away from entering when another car  
our house

I just stood in front of the car. I looked at our open gate and

If I ran inside, he probably wouldn't catch me. He couldn't because Aries and Kuya Angelo were there.

"Don't even think about it..." I heard Keifer say.

Was I that obvious? Even he realized it.

Fine!

I angrily got into his car—a different one again! He got in before the car even moved, I grabbed onto something to

This guy drives like a maniac. He really thinks he's a car supposed to survive as his passenger?

As he continued driving, I watched him. His eyebrows w again, and he looked like he was mad at the world.

"W-where are we going?" I asked.

He didn't answer. We turned right, left, and went straight sky. The sun was setting, and Kuya was probably worrie

I took my phone out of my pocket. I was about to text Ci Keifer suddenly grabbed my phone and threw it toward t

"I need to let Kuya know!" I said inevitably.

Was he planning something?!

We were on the side of the road. There were no houses on either side of the road. It felt like we were in a newly built subdivision because we had just passed earlier.

"Where are we?" I asked.

"What did you and Yuri do?" he asked calmly, but his voice was filled with anger.

I'm in trouble!

"W-we went to church," I answered hesitantly.

"What else?"

"We went grocery shopping and cooked."

"What else?"

I was starting to feel scared because of what he was doing. I decided to tell him everything. He might get angry again like before.

"N-nothing else!"

"What. Else." He emphasized.

I just swallowed. What's his problem now?

"D-don't lie to me," he said.

I just looked in another direction and breathed deeply.

Damn it!

"W-we kissed----"

I didn't get to finish what I was saying. He suddenly got slammed the door shut. I felt the car shake from what he

He just stood there, looking somewhere. His back was to me. I could see him running his hands through his hair several

I bit my lower lip. It was so dark outside, and the only light came from the car.

I had no choice but to get out of the car. I slowly walked out and stopped when he slightly turned to look at me.

"Keifer..."

"Why are you doing this to me?" he asked.

It felt like something punched my heart when I saw his eyes. They were soft, and he seemed like a different person.

"...You're mine. Only mine. Everything about you is mine."

"Yes. That's why I accepted his marriage proposal," I said.  
He slightly moved closer to me. He looked straight into my eyes.  
"Liar."

I furrowed my brows at what he said.

"...You can't lie----"

"I'm not," I interjected.

"-----to me."

"I'm telling the truth," I emphasized.

"And yet you responded to my kiss that night," he said but I didn't respond.  
Don't open that topic! I don't want to remember that.

"...You responded to my touch, and you moaned my name. You said you like Yuri? What about me? What am I to you?"

No! I don't want to talk about that! It was just a mistake.

"...You almost gave yourself to me! Come on! HOW COULD YOU LIKE YURI?!" he added angrily.

I couldn't stop myself from crying. Tears fell one after another.



I wiped my tears and took several deep breaths.

My chest felt so heavy. I didn't know we'd end up like th

"Because it's the right thing... I can't bear to think or see again for the same reason," I said, leaning back against th weakened. "...That's why, even though I'm not sure, I acc him to experience happiness."

"So you chose to sacrifice your feelings?" he asked calm

I didn't answer. I just sat on the ground, continuing to wi

"Ha! Yuri again!" he said, making me look at him.

"...The 'oh so genius kid.' The good boy, the heir of Han is loved and cared for by so many people."

He walked away slightly and looked up at the sky. I coul in every move he made.

"...Why is it always about him?! Always! When we thou dead, he was the first thing they thought of! But me?! W No one even asked if I was okay. Everything is always a even the woman I love?!" he shouted angrily.

I didn't understand what he was saying. Did he have a gr I tried to stand up while looking at him.

Enough... It's hurting me!

"...But him, with just a scratch, they almost rushed him to  
They might as well worship him," he added.

I didn't wait for him to say more. I immediately went to hug  
him tightly. Tears fell again.

"Enough! Please..." I pleaded.

"Don't you too! Jay-jay!" he said, hugging me tightly. "F

This is wrong! So wrong! But I can't seem to fix it. I always  
stop, but how can I do that?

How....

How? Especially when it hurts both of us.

I don't want to make promises. I don't want to commit. But  
what Ci-N said is true, promises are meant to be broken.

But in our situation right now....

"No... I'm not," I said, and I felt him take a deep breath.

"I can't lose you..." he said.

I just closed my eyes. I didn't care if this was still wrong.

# Chapter 147: I love... Me?

## Jay-jay's POV

I have so many fears. Too many to count. But I manage to

It feels like I'm facing one of my fears right now.

Kuya Angelo...

"Yuri said he dropped you off here at 5:38 pm," he said,

"Was it 5:38 pm? I think it was past 6," I replied, pretending to understand what he was implying.

He raised an eyebrow while looking at me. I avoided his gaze, possibly to match his intense stare.

I got home at 12 am. We had a long drama session earlier and... you know—we talked again.

I thought everyone would be asleep when I got home, but I was waiting for me.

I couldn't make excuses because he had already called Y

Where exactly is 'just around'? I don't know any place or except the mini mart I usually go to.

"At the Mini Mart."

Kuya took a deep breath and held his forehead.

"Aries went there... Why didn't you see each other?!"

Signal #3!

Oh no! Does he really go to the Mini Mart? And of all time tonight. Wow!

"I avoided him," I quickly replied.

Wow! Great excuse, Jay.

Kuya immediately gave me a sharp look. He knew I was knows, maybe I could get away with it.

"Is it so hard to tell me where you were?!" he asked angrily.

Signal #4!

Here comes the storm! I'm in trouble now.

"...Look at the time! Is this the time a decent girl comes home?"

"...It's late. Scold her tomorrow. She still has school," she

"Just a minute, Mom. We need to clear things up," Kuya

"Tomorrow..." Tita insisted. She looked at me and signaled her. "...Come on. Leave your Kuya for now."

I immediately went to Tita. I didn't look at Kuya because he would melt me.

Tita walked me to my room.

"Go to sleep... We'll talk tomorrow," she said and walked

I slowly opened my bedroom door, knowing Ci-N was a bit wasn't wrong because his snoring was loud.

As soon as I entered, my phone rang.

**\*\*King of Snakes Calling...\*\*b>**

I answered it after closing the door.

"Hello..."

["Did he scold you?"]

"Hmmm... Yes, but he said we'll talk tomorrow."

"Cut it out!" I shouted.

I immediately covered my mouth. I forgot Ci-N was already

"...you're crazy. Just go to sleep."

["I can't sleep yet. I have many things to do."]

"Like what?"

["Secret... I have to go. Don't have wet dreams about me

Damn it! This shameless jerk is really something!

"You're so thick-skinned!" I shouted again.

I didn't care if Ci-N woke up. He was really annoying me

He just laughed loudly in response. It felt wrong to admit  
him.

["Alright... Good night, my life. I love you to infinity and

I froze at what he said. I bit my lower lip.

Am I really feeling giddy?! Damn it!

"Good night too, and I love...." I stopped when I saw Ci-N  
staring at me. "...Me."

I just gave him a sharp look. This crazy boy! he even has me.

"Who was that?" he asked.

I immediately looked around the room and pretended to

"Who? Where? Do you see something?" I said, continuing

I knew who he was referring to. Maybe I could get away

I didn't want to tell him, and I knew that if this night was town would know what he found out.

"Keep it up... I'll spread the news that you have a boyfriend

He's not my boyfriend!

"Go ahead..." I said arrogantly.

"Who was it?" he pressed.

"Nothing... It's nothing."

he suddenly stood up and tried to grab my phone from the

I immediately ran and almost tripped just to beat him to the

"Why don't you want to show me?!" he said irritably.

Ci-N and I had no choice but to stop. We glared at each other.  
Good luck figuring out when we'll finish this.

+++++

### **\*\*Keifer's POV\*\***

"I love me?"

Was it hard for her to say "I love you," and that's what she said.

Anyway, it doesn't matter. I heard her say it once, and then she said it back. She's officially mine.

But that's not what's bothering me. Other important things.

"Where's Keiren?!" I asked everyone.

All the lights in the house were on. The maids and butler were all there. I knew something bad had happened.

"Kuya..." Keigan called me.

Keiren was hiding behind him. He suddenly ran toward me and hugged me tightly. He was crying.

"It's okay... Kuya is here," I said, hugging him back.



"We've also added more security for your brother," he said.

I smiled and nodded at him. I let them all leave. Only the  
remained. Keigan looked furious at me.

"What happened?" I asked calmly.

"Dad came here! He tried to take Keiren! Good thing we  
said.

I looked at Keiren, who was still crying.

"I don't want to go with him."

I shook my head. "No... He won't take you. Not as long as  
I are here."

I carried him and walked upstairs. Keigan followed us.

Damn it!

I didn't know they'd come back so soon. I would have said  
if I had known.

We're all minors here in the house. The law still states that  
under the care of a parent or relative.

Dad went after Keiren first because he's the youngest and  
But I won't allow it.

"I'm turning 18 soon... I almost have your and Keiren's lo and walked away.

Keigan immediately followed me.

"So, we're just waiting for your birthday? Is that it? Kuy: Keiren before that day comes?!" he said angrily.

I stopped walking and looked him straight in the eye.

"No... That will never happen," I answered seriously.

"I hope you can fulfill what you're saying."

I understand Keigan. What older brother would allow his the wrong hands?

I quickly walked to the office next to my room. I gather needed, including a copy of my mom's last will and testa

I need to study everything written here and the laws that fight back legally.

Keiren can't fall into his hands. Then what? Will they do did to Keigan? And until now, I still don't know what the

I also grabbed my phone and called my lawyer.

"Good evening Mr. Duder. Sorry for disturbing you. I'm

"I love me..."

# Chapter 148: How

## Jay-jay's POV

\*Yaaawwwwnnnnn....\* Ci-N yawned while walking. "

"Me too... This is your fault! You were so noisy last night

"If you had just told me who you were saying 'I love you' we both slept by now."

I glared at him immediately. His mouth was so loud. We've been together since last night, and I don't even know what time we finished

"Stop being so loud! You're so annoying! This is why I don't love you!"

He rolled his eyes at me. "I'll tell Keifer about this."

Hahahaha... Go ahead and tell him!

We continued walking. When we got to school, a big tarp covering the main building greeted us.

It was the schedule of school events. Valentine's Day was next. But before that, our retreat would happen first. Why is it

"What? Me? You're the one who's embarrassing with all

"You're the one!"

"You!"

"Hey! Are you really going to fight here?" Calix scolded  
"...you're both being ridiculous."

Ci and I looked at each other and exchanged glances again several times.

We were repeating what we did last night. We arrived at the door before I could step inside, I stopped walking.

"What?" they asked me.

I just shook my head. "Go ahead... I just need to check something."

They both nodded and went in. The truth was, I wasn't really that shy, I just felt so shy around him.

So shy...

I didn't know if I should tell him the truth or not. I didn't want to lead him on, but I also didn't want to lead him on.

But it would hurt him more if I didn't tell him and kept going. Maybe it's better to just tell him the truth. But I didn't

Yuri was already sitting in his seat. He smiled at me as so  
smiled back at him.

"Why did Angelo call me last night?" he asked me.

"H-ha? W-what... I-it's because..." I stammered awkward  
waiting for my answer. "...h-he didn't see me right away.  
were still together."

He just nodded, accepting my answer. Phew!

How am I going to tell him?

I glanced at the King's seat. As usual, he wasn't there yet  
come later. He's even worse than the school staff when it  
punctuality. The staff and teachers arrive earlier than him  
him; maybe he's still taking care of Keigan and Keiren b  
school.

What I don't understand is how he managed to kick his d  
house. It's so weird—I've never seen or heard of a child l  
out.

How did that happen?

I also remembered what he said about Yuri. I glanced at  
reading his notes and marking down important details fr

Even the King of Snakes has a soft spot.

Sir Alvin arrived. Class was about to start. I looked at the door and knew the annoying one would arrive soon.

I don't know how long I've been staring at the door, but I can't see the shadow of him.

Where is he?

"He's not coming," Yuri suddenly said.

I looked at him, confused. "Huh?"

"Keifer's not coming if that's who you're waiting for. His brother is and he's dealing with a big problem again," he explained.

He's back? Since when? He didn't tell me anything last night.

"W-what do I care about that... And I'm not waiting for Keifer."

I didn't want him to notice. I wasn't ready to tell him yet. I didn't even have the thought of the right words to say.

But why isn't the annoying one coming? I couldn't help but wonder. He was so annoying!

Our class with Sir Alvin ended, and it seemed like he really was. He wasn't texting me either. Even in our next subjects, he

"Maybe she's just missing Keifer," Drew teased, and they laughing.

I glanced at Yuri, who was just looking at his notes. I know listening.

"Maybe it's not Keifer she's missing," Ci-N chimed in. "one----"

"HEY! SHUT YOUR MOUTH!" I cut him off.

Everyone looked at me because of my outburst. Ci-N such me like I was crazy.

"Why are you so defensive?" he teased.

"I don't know!"

"Oh! She doesn't want to say----"

"Ci!" I scolded him.

I was starting to get annoyed with what he was doing. He in front of the whole class. Worse, Yuri was here too. If he would be the end.

Suddenly, there was a meow near the door. Ci-N automatic look.



Oh no! Go ahead, chase each other because of a cat. It re  
Cecilio Susuman. I have a cat!

"What was Ci-N talking about?" Felix asked.

"Nothing... We were just joking around at home."

"How's Ci-N at your place?" Eren asked.

"He's fine... Just messy."

"Do you sleep together?" Drew asked.

For some reason, I suddenly felt heavy, and there was th  
couldn't explain.

Even though he wasn't talking and was pretending to be  
I knew it was Yuri. He's just like Keifer.

"N-no... He has his own bed on the floor," I quickly ansv  
strange feeling disappeared.

"But does he see you naked?" Drew asked again.

Felix gave him a hard smack on the head. "You're such a

"That hurt!" Drew complained.

If I were next to him, I wouldn't just smack him. I might

was too busy thinking about him.

I didn't even eat dinner properly. I just played with my f

"What's wrong, Jay?" Ci-N asked me when we got back

I shook my head. "It's nothing."

"Are you sure? You're acting weird," he said.

"Just don't mind me," I replied.

I grabbed my phone and walked out of the room. I tried c  
one answered.

What's happening to you?

I cried for no reason. My annoyance and worry for him v  
together.

What if his dad did something to him that I don't know a  
they're already in chaos at home.

Ugh! My imagination is making it worse.

"Are you okay, Jay?" Kuya asked.

Aries happened to come out of his room, so he looked at  
wiped my tears

Probably because of exhaustion, I fell asleep quickly. In rest and my wonderful dream about an ice cream island, King of Snakes Calling...

I DIDN'T WANT TO ANSWER! But I accidentally pressed button. Annoying!

"Wha----"

["I miss you..."] he said immediately.

Oh my!

I looked at Ci-N, who was currently snoring. He might have

"What happened to you? Why are you only calling now?

Why beat around the bush? I wanted to know if he was coming

["Long story... How about you? How are you? Is Yuri missing? I'm gone?"]

"You're so annoying... I was worried about you, and that's what I was worried about?"

He chuckled a little. ["I didn't mean that. I just had a lot to say. I don't know when I'll be able to come back."]

["You're cute when you're like this."]

What?

"Huh?"

["When you're sulking. How I wish I could see your face

"Should I send you a picture?" I offered, laughing.

My annoyance with him disappeared. Ugh, this guy! I co

["Sure... Nude photo, please."]

You wish!

"What if I just end this call and never talk to you again?"

If I didn't have a roommate, I would've screamed at him.

["Hahahaha... I'm just kidding. But seriously, what are yo  
now?"]

I glanced at what I was wearing. Thankfully, there was a  
room from the lamp next to Ci.

"Superman t-shirt, why?"

["Aahh... I'm only wearing boxers. I'm wearing my favori

"Good night and sweet dreams too. I love..." I glanced at and staring at me again. "...me."

# Chapter 149: Father

## Jay-jay's POV

I woke up in a good mood for some reason I couldn't understand. I found myself singing...

"Good morning to you..." I sang while taking a shower.

Ugh, what's this? Yuck! It doesn't suit me. Why am I suddenly singing \*pabebe\*? Ugh, this is so annoying!

When I stepped out of the bathroom, I was greeted by Ciara. He stared at his phone.

He had showered before me, so he was already dressed and ready. Meanwhile, I was rushing to get ready.

"We're going to be late," he said, which confused me.

"Huh? W-why?"

"It's dangerous," was all he said before going back to tap dancing. Weird.

"What time are we leaving?" I asked Ci.

He didn't answer, so I was about to walk over to him when there was a knock on the door, and one of Tita's maids came in.

"Miss Jay... They're asking you to come downstairs. Sorry to you."

Ci-N and I exchanged looks. He was still holding his phone.

"Who is it?" I asked.

"They didn't say. But Sir Angelo told me to call you down."

I just nodded at the maid. Even though I was confused, Ci-N grabbed his bags and headed out. We went to the living room, expecting everyone there, but no one was around.

Where are they?

Just then, Aries showed up. He looked at us like he was surprised by something.

"Where's Mom?" he asked me.

I shook my head. "I'm looking for them too."

Aries quickly walked to the kitchen but came back just a moment later.

"Tita..." I called out to Tita Gema.

She looked at me and quickly hid me behind her. What's Aries looked confused.

"Are you Ms. Jasper Jean Mariano, Ci-N Peralta, and Mi Fernandez?" one of the men in black asked, holding a pic

Ci-N and I exchanged looks. He subtly signaled for me to understand because we didn't know them—

"Yes! That's us! Why?!" Aries answered.

Oh my God!

Aries really has no filter sometimes. Love must have me

"The Watson Family has summoned you," the man said.

Suddenly, one of the men opened the door of the black car widened when he saw Ella inside.

"Aries!" Ella called out, clearly scared.

She tried to get out of the car, but one of the men stopped the other cars and saw the windows rolling down. Inside Denzel, and Felix.

The other cars had passengers too, and I had a strong feeling



"How can we be sure you won't harm them?" Tita asked

"The Watsons are well-known people. Any negative news about their name is unacceptable."

Why do I feel like Keifer's family is way above our league?

Tita looked at me. Before Kuya could say anything to us, we walked toward the car and stood next to Ella.

"We'll be fine, Tita," I said, smiling at her.

Kuya let us walk toward the car. Ci-N and I got in. Aries got in the car. The other cars followed. We were quiet, and Ci-N and Aries were exchanging looks.

What's going on?

I looked out the window. The places we passed were familiar. As time went on, it felt like we were heading somewhere familiar.

It felt like we were leaving the city.

"W-where are we going?" Ella asked.

That's what I wanted to know. For the first time, Ella and I were in something.

"To Keifer's real home," Aries said seriously.

I didn't know how long we'd been driving. I kept texting right—they were in the cars behind us.

"It's been two hours," Ci-N said, checking his watch.

Are we leaving the Earth? I really need to pee, to be honest.

Thankfully, my prayers were answered. The cars started turned onto a road lined with trees. It was so shady, with everywhere.

"This is it..." Aries whispered.

What's "it"?

Suddenly, Ci-N pressed his face against the window. He of me.

"It's even bigger in person!" he said in awe.

Bigger in person?

I looked at what he was staring at. There was a huge house far, but you could already see how massive it was.

It was hidden behind a hill, which is why I didn't see it earlier. When we turned the corner, part of the house came into view.

"Have you seen this in pictures before? Kiefer's mansion is real."

from sight.

The car stopped in front of a HUGE GATE!

OH MY GOD! This gate is so tall. It's like it's not meant

A giant!—No! A ghost!

When the gate opened, the car started moving again. Tall lined the road. It felt like this place was hiding something greenery.

But slowly, the greenery faded, revealing what was hidden

A palace!

The house was enormous. It looked like it was only three had so many sections.

All it needed was a dragon and a tower, and it could be called

When the car stopped, no one wanted to get out. We all just other.

"We're here..." the driver said.

Still, no one moved, until I saw Calix and the others walking standing near where the cars were parked.

So rich!

We stood there for a few more moments when suddenly it opened! It's official—this place isn't meant for humans. It's huge. Ugh!

Slowly, a...handsome man stepped out! Is he an actor? He was in his 40s or younger. And he looked so much like—

"Keifer's dad," Ci-N said.

I kept looking back and forth between him and the man that was Keifer's dad.

Really?!

Not that I'm saying Keifer's ugly, but you know... There's something about him... Ugh! Fine! He's so handsome and looks too young to be his dad.

I think I have a crush on him!

Keifer's dad—I mean, Mr. Watson—walked toward us. I have to admit, he had a strong presence.

"Good morning..." he greeted us. "...are we all complete?"

I looked at my friends. Speaking of complete, Yuri and Kaito were

One of the men in black suits approached him and whisper

We all looked at him. Are they close?

"...can you tell us what you need from us?"

Finally! Someone asked. This horoscope might actually

Mr. Watson chuckled. "You haven't changed, still so imp at all of us. "...I just want to have a lunch date with my son

I suddenly felt butterflies. I mean, his gaze lingered on me "lunch date."

Is he asking me out?

Before anyone could say anything, we heard the loud roar sounded like it was racing.

"He's here," Mr. Watson said, positioning himself right in

RIGHT IN THE MIDDLE! Where the car could potentially was getting closer—no, two cars. And they looked familiar

One was Yuri's car, but the other...was Keifer's. They looked racing, driving so fast.

Yuri's car turned to find a parking spot, but Keifer's car kept my God!

Is he going to run over his own dad?

# Chapter 150: Escape plan

## Jay-jay's POV

Shallow!

The distance between Keifer's car and his dad's was so close that his dad's car was really going to hit him, but he suddenly hit the brakes.

My heart stopped beating for a moment there. My soul ached.  
Damn that!

Keifer got out of his car and immediately glared at his dad.

"You're blocking my driveway!" Keifer said.

His dad didn't respond. He just smiled and walked back to the car. It was weird, but I didn't see any fear in him.

I saw Yuri walking towards us. He looked really serious, but I didn't see Aries and Ella.

"Why did your dad pick us up?" Felix asked Keifer.

But he didn't answer. He immediately walked towards the house and entered through the fancy door.

We probably stood there for a few minutes before Aries entered into the house, followed by Ella.

Wow! Feeling at home?

"What was that?!" Eren asked.

"Nothing's going to happen to us here! Let's go!" Rory said and immediately walked into the house.

Since we didn't know what to do, we followed. When we entered, we felt ashamed of the shine of their floor.

What did Sia say about their chandelier? It's bigger than the hotel. Damn! I won't just swing here, I'll even sleep here.

Keifer's place is nothing compared to this mansion. It feels like the president of the Philippines lives here.

"Good morning," greeted a woman dressed as a maid.

I felt small; I looked more like a helper compared to her. Her skin was so smooth, and her clothes were so clean. My uniform, which was neglected by the iron, felt ashamed.

"Please follow me," she said and started walking.

Eren was the first to follow. Chicks, you know! As we walked, we

Someone tapped me. I looked and it was just Ci-N. he br close to my ear and whispered.

"Come with me... I need to go to the CR (comfort room/I said.

Good thing he mentioned it! I've been needing to pee for noded at him, and we went out.

"Where's the CR?" I asked.

Ci-N didn't answer. he just suddenly walked away. Even confused, I just followed him.

We went through so many places. We probably passed b didn't ask or talk to any of them. I felt like we were getti

Suddenly, Ci went up the stairs to the second floor. Dam are fancy. What's next, a stairway to heaven?

"Hey, Ci!" I called him. "...Where are we going? I thoug the CR?"

he didn't answer and kept walking. I felt like the CR was anymore.

We entered another hallway. I was starting to get annoye Until he suddenly stopped in front of a door.



So Keigan's here too?

"What's going on?" I whispered.

Yuri was the first to see me. "Jay..." he called me.

I slowly walked closer to them.

"W-what's happening?" I asked them.

"We need your cooperation here," Keifer said.

I pointed at myself and looked at them, confused.

"Dad is up to something. He wouldn't have brought me here for no reason," Keigan said.

I didn't speak. I waited for them to explain further.

"We don't know what it is, but one thing is for sure," Yuri said. "Keiren is his target, and he might use all of us to get to him."

I looked at Keiren. He looked pale and sick.

"I'm asking you, Jay... In case everything goes wrong, please stay here," Keifer pleaded. "Keigan will help you escape here," Keifer pleaded.

"I-I'm going to leave you?"

I didn't want to, I didn't want to do that. It's not like me. ]  
He looked pitiful.

"O-okay... I'll do it."

"Great! You know what to do, Keigan!" Keifer said, looking at them.  
They just nodded and started walking towards the door. 'over.

Keifer passed in front of me, so I grabbed the hem of his pants.  
me, confused.

"W-where's your CR?" I asked him.

He looked at Keigan and Yuri. He signaled for them to go.  
pointed to the door behind me.

I immediately ran inside. I couldn't hold it anymore. My  
much pain.

When I entered, my butt felt ashamed touching their toilet.  
But I couldn't hold it anymore, let the cleaner disinfect it.

But honestly, I enjoyed peeing here. The bathroom was so clean.  
was even alcohol!

When I got out, no one was in the room anymore. Keifer

W-what is this? W-wait a minute!

"...please say something."

How can I speak? I froze in my spot. He was still hugging me.

"K-Keifer..." I called him.

He suddenly buried his head in my shoulder. He didn't speak for several moments when his hug tightened.

I understood.

He didn't just hug me because he missed me. He needed me right now. Even if he didn't speak, I could feel his pain.

I held his arm.

"Ssshhh..." I started. "...I missed you too."

I felt his head slightly lift.

"...don't think about that. There's still time to make it up. I need to focus on first," I said and tapped his head.

He rested his chin on my shoulder.

"Thank you..." he whispered. "...Thank you for being here."

"Before we go..." he said and suddenly kissed me on the

It was brief, but it was enough to stop my heart.

Ahihi...

He opened the door and immediately went out. I saw Ci-wall, playing with his phone.

"Hey!" I called him. "...Let's go!"

"What were you talking about?" he asked me.

"Nothing..." I answered and started walking.

He immediately followed me.

"Really... What was it about?" he pressed.

"Just..."

"Are you going to tell me, or should I tell Keifer you have now?" he threatened.

I suddenly laughed. If only you knew...

But my laughter disappeared when I saw Yuri. Shit! Did said?

I signaled to him, 'It's nothing!' Who knows what else Ci  
"Yeah! So----hmmmm! hmmmm!" I immediately  
"Ahahahaha... Ci's just really out of it!" I said awkwardly.  
Yuri just smiled at me and nodded before walking away.  
I let go of Ci and immediately glared at him.

"Your hand smells!" he complained.

You jerk!

I smelled my hand. I didn't smell anything other than the  
earlier.

"Let's go! They said it's time to eat!" he said and quickly

Nice! Time to eat!

# Chapter 151: Near Death

## Jay-jay's POV

Is this for real?! A lunch date or a feast? A simple lunch or

There's so much food. Super extravagant! It feels like attending a christening. The food is set on the side.

Of course, since we're naturally gluttonous, here we are, one of them—I'm a glutton too. Who wouldn't get hungry?

Lechon, my friends!

Among all the greasy foods, this one is the most tempting.

These damn people are taking so long to get their food. They have everything already.

"There's ice cream!" Ci exclaimed, clapping excitedly.

"Eat rice first... You might get a stomachache if you eat ice cream away."

"But I want ice cream." he pouted stubbornly.

While we were happily enjoying our food, they, on the other hand, were having such a serious discussion. Just Keifer's aura alone, mixed with Yuri and their dad to the mix, and it became even more intense.

What I don't understand is why Aries was also sitting at the table with Ella.

Edi wow! (Well, isn't that something?)

"...How's school? Are you studying well?" Keifer's dad asked.

"My studies are none of your business." Keifer replied back.

"Come on, Keifer. I'm still your dad. I still have a responsibility towards your brother."

"Bullshit!" Keifer spat angrily.

"Language, my son. You're still in my house." His father said.

Damn! Intense!

It felt like I was watching a dramatic showdown. All that tension, like in the movies.

Keifer's dad turned to Aries and Yuri.

"Look at you. You used to come here just to pick up Keifer. Now you're missing someone." He said with a smile.

Then, Keifer's dad suddenly looked at me. I almost choked  
surprising!

"The only rose among the thorns?" He asked.

What the hell?!

"...What is your name? You're new to me."

I glanced at Keifer, who was also looking at me. It was like he was  
telling me to be careful with my answer.

"J-Jasper Jean Mariano, sir... Just call me Jay-jay."

He was silent for a moment, as if thinking, but his attention was on  
me.

"I know a few Marianos in the business industry. What are their  
names?" He asked again.

"Those are none of your business." Keifer interrupted quickly.

Thank God he spoke up. I didn't want to say their names  
especially my dad's.

"It's just a name. There's nothing wrong with asking someone  
said, then looked at me again. "...Mind telling me their names?"

CHAPTER 1



"...It just so happens that I know your father. He's a stock telecommunications company. On the other hand, I also She's the sister of Gema Fernandez, who happens to be r then turned to Aries. "...So, you two are cousins?"

Aries averted his gaze. It was obvious he wasn't proud o heard. He wasn't proud that we were related.

"...Never in my life did I imagine your parents together. offense, but your mom seems a bit... 'tactless.'" He said, choosing the right word to describe my mom.

I just bowed my head. He wasn't wrong—my mom is bl mind with no filter, which often gets her into fights.

We'd just hear that she was at the police station because and my grandma would have to bail her out. Meanwhile, at home.

"...I never even saw them together before. It amazes me 1 mid-sentence.

Keifer had suddenly shattered his glass. He didn't throw broke in his palm.

Slowly, he clenched his fist, and blood started dripping c

"Did you bring them here just to insult them?" Keifer asl

A man in a black suit handed him a document. He took it from Keifer.

"...Sign it." He ordered.

Keifer read the paper, and whatever was written on it inspired him to be angry. He stood up and glared at his father.

"If you don't want to give me custody of Keiren, then return it to me."

"That was my mom's money! She worked hard for it and

"Your mom had no money... She stole it from the company. From me, to be exact."

Keifer threw the paper away. "I'm not signing anything!"

His father looked at him seriously. "You leave me no choice."

Suddenly, the men in black suits approached. We all stood back away.

My food!

They tried to grab Keiren, but before they could, Keifer jumped. The others got alarmed, and more black suits came in.

Even more of them arrived! Just how many are there?!

The guy I pushed earlier was now pointing a gun at my t

Shit! No jokes now. This is it.

Keifer's dad scanned the room. "Where is Keiren?"

No one answered. No one else knew except me.

One of the men pointed at me. "Sir! This girl was with K

His father walked toward me.

"Where is my son?" He asked seriously.

I shook my head. "I-I don't know... W-we got separated.'

He clearly didn't believe me.

"Keifer, why are you so stubborn?" His father asked, ste]

Keifer didn't answer.

"...Tsk! Plan A isn't working. I'll go with Plan B."

More guns were drawn.

Shit. This just got real.

"JUST PULL THE TRIGGER!"

# Chapter 152: Gun

## Jay-jay's POV

Everything stopped. Literally stopped.

The man in the black suit standing in front of me was glared at me. He was also the one holding the gun, aimed straight at me.

"Pull the trigger!" I repeated.

The man looked at Keifer's dad and then back at me.

"Jay! Shut up!" Aries shouted at me.

I ignored him. I kept my eyes locked on this bastard in front of me.

If he even tried, I'd flick his eyelid.

"Pull it!" I yelled. "...You can't do it, can you?"

I smirked when he didn't answer.

"What will people say when they find out a student was in the Watsons? That would be a disgrace for you."

Dead air.

Some exchanged glances, while others looked at Keifer's

But the man in front of me, he held his ground. Our staring continued.

Then, suddenly, Keifer's dad started a slow clap as he wa

"Put the gun down," he ordered, then turned to face me.

"You're a brave woman, you know that?"

If only he knew. The courage I had saved up for facing n  
think I just used it all up.

I didn't respond.

He walked toward Keifer and took the document.

"I thought I had outplayed you this time... But it seems I  
looked at me.

"You and your friends can leave now. I'll talk to you aga

He walked away, followed by the men in black suits.

But the one facing me glared one last time before finally

My heart was beating so fast, it felt like it was about to jump out of my chest.

"Are you okay, Jay?" David asked.

I grabbed his arm.

"Jesus! I thought I was going to die!"

I looked over at Yuri, who was struggling to help the Kirilovs. That proud bastard kept refusing help.

"You were really brave back there... I'm proud of you," Cade said. Wow!

I just smiled.

While the others were checking on me, I didn't realize Kade's brothers had approached us.

"Are you out of your mind?!" Keifer asked angrily.

Everyone turned to look at us.

"...Do you even know who you just challenged?!"

I shook my head.

"JAY!" They rushed to help me, but this time, I had no s

I just came face-to-face with Death!

And I had the nerve to act tough and cocky. Damn it!

If he hadn't spared me, shit! I would've gone home as a c

"I-I-I barely made it," I stuttered, still shaking.

"It's okay... You're still alive, aren't you?" Ci said.

I wanted to smack the kid, but I couldn't.

I couldn't get over what I had done.

"Where's Keiren?" Keigan suddenly asked.

With my trembling hand, I pointed to the table where I h

Keigan immediately went over and peeked underneath.

Keiren came out and hugged him.

Keifer also approached them and wrapped his siblings in

It might look cheesy to others, but to me, it was insanely

"We should get out of here," Drew suggested.

Then he turned to us and glared at me.

"Don't ever do that again!" he snapped at me.

"Keifer! She only did that to help you!" Felix defended r

"What if Dylan actually did what she said?!" Keifer shot

We all fell silent.

He was right.

What if Dylan had pulled the trigger?

But if I hadn't done that, the document would've been sig  
mother's hard work would've been wasted.

"...You just gave them a new idea of what they should do

I don't know why, but my chest suddenly felt heavy whil

It felt like I had become a burden to him.

"...Next time, think before making reckless decisions!" h  
getting into his car.

"Don't mind him... He's just worried about you," David s

I nodded, but that wasn't the point.



At least someone appreciates what I did.

Even if it wasn't the person I had hoped for.

+++++

### **Third Person's POV**

1... 2... 3...

Dylan counted in his mind.

He was counting the bullets in the gun he had used to air

His palms were itching.

He wasn't going to get paid, just like the rumors said.

His palms were itching to pull the trigger.

Killing was his livelihood.

But even without pay, he could kill.

It wasn't money he was after.

It was the feeling he got when he killed—that's what he l

"How many times do you need to count those bullets?" h

His boss chuckled slightly.

Kaizer Watson.

Keifer's ruthless father.

For reasons Dylan didn't understand, he had refused to let his classmates—even though they easily could have.

"Because of that girl... She has a point," he said.

"...She amazes me."

Dylan thought about it.

That girl was truly brave, but even so, he saw the fear in her eyes.

And he loved seeing fear in the people he killed.

"You know Jeana, right?" Keifer's father asked.

"...Somehow, I see that woman in her. They really are mother and daughter."

Dylan had only met Jeana once, a very long time ago.

So he didn't quite understand what his boss meant.

"What are you planning to do with Keifer?" Dylan asked.

If there was any goodness left in him, it was his concern once cared for.

"I have no use for that kid. I already took his money. What about Keifer and Keiren's wealth."

Dylan lowered his head.

This was a huge amount of money at stake.

Keigan had already been discarded like trash after they took what he needed from him.

His boss had no love for his own children—or even his last.

"Call my lawyer. I need to speak with them," Kaizer ordered.

Dylan bowed and left the room.

He followed the order, picked up his phone, and dialed a number.

But he called someone else.

"Hello...?"

["Next time, tell us about his plans in advance."] The person on the other end immediately said.

"Sorry. I didn't have time to send a message."

This was the right thing to do...

Dylan wanted to atone for his sins, and helping those kids he knew how.

# Chapter 153: Argue

## Jay-jay's POV

"Aren't you going to answer that??" Ci-N asked me while

I continued flipping through the pages of the catalog I was ignoring the cellphone and this kid who had already finished his cream.

Ci-N glanced at my phone for a moment and then went back to doing.

"Are you two having a lovers' quarrel?" he asked.

I didn't answer again.

"What's this? No 'L' yet but there's already a 'Q'," he said

I couldn't help but think. No 'L' yet? What 'L'? It seems I'm winning. I was forced to face him and talk.

"What 'L'?" I asked.

"Love," he quickly replied. Pffttt...

He asked me to choose his place to stay. He said he does about that. Me neither! But I still helped him so I could k

"Quarrel," he said after he finished laughing.

"Hm?"

"Lover's Quarrel. You and Keifer."

I avoided his gaze. "We're not lovers."

"That's why... No 'L' yet but you're already at 'Q'," he rep

Ugh!

I don't want to talk about him right now. I also know that keeps calling me. Whatever!

Ci-N's cellphone rang. he fiddled with it for a moment at me.

"Keifer has a message for you," he said. "...in 5 minutes, up, he said he'll talk to Angelo today."

What? Show up? Talk?

I was puzzled and looked at Ci-N. I waited to see if he h he just shrugged.

No people or cars. That jerk! He must be messing with n  
go back inside when I noticed a nice car not far away.

The window was rolled down, and... there he was, the an  
I walked towards him. I faced the King of Snakes.

"Hey! I'm here! What do you want?!" I asked angrily.

"Get in," he calmly ordered.

"No! Just tell me what you want."

"Get in."

"I said no! If you have nothing to say, leave."

"Tss."

That's it?! That's all he's going to say? How annoying! I'

"You're such a pest! I'm leaving!"

"Get in or get in!" he said angrily.

Fine! I'll get in!

I was shocked by what he did. I felt like I lost control and  
really can't resist his anger.

"W-what should I say?"

"Anything. You're mad at me? Shout! Curse me! Say any

What's his problem?

His mood must be acting up again. Yes, I'm mad at him.  
be the one to speak?

"W-where are we going?" I changed the subject.

He didn't answer. Until I noticed the gate we were entering  
familiar.

Where have I—woot! He brought me here before. That  
him those words I struggled to say.

I was right, it's the subdivision. But there were no houses  
building some.

We stopped under a big tree. I stayed quiet, looking out in  
directions except at him.

We were silent for a few minutes. From the corner of my  
looking at me.

I glanced at his side. Pretending to look at something else  
was looking at me. Staring intensely!



You're the one who's mad!

"Just because I'm mad, I should be the first to speak?! He who caused my anger!" I said angrily.

"Look, if this is about what I said earlier—"

"At least you know!" I cut him off. "...and I should be the

"What do you want me to say?!" he asked irritably.

He matched my tone. It seems like he's planning to match

"Why don't you figure it out?!"

Let's see how good you are!

"I'm not a fortune teller! How am I supposed to know what you hear?!"

Damn it!

I just slapped my own forehead. Can't he understand that a little appreciation would be enough?!

"A-PO-LO-GIZE!" I emphasized, which made him raise

"Why should I?!"

"Then it's wrong if it's wrong! But at least appreciate wh

He just ran his fingers through his hair. It's obvious he's 1  
anger.

"I do appreciate it! I appreciate you risking your life! Es  
you worried me!"

When you're so angry, you just feel like punching your e  
argument.

Aaarrrrggghhhh....

"Damn it! That's it, I already risked my life! Not even a l  
Damn it! I should've just let you sign that damn paper—'  
saw him smiling at me.

This jerk!

I almost lost my voice from all the shouting, and he just  
must be completely crazy. Insane!

"What?!" I asked irritably.

"Three," he answered, holding up three fingers.

Three?!

" Three are forty words "

What's this?! I'm suddenly singing. This King is so anno

"...What do you mean?! You might have forgotten, but w reminded me.

"I didn't forget! But because I'm angry, no KISS!"

"HEY! That is not counted!" he complained.

"Counted your face! And, no! I don't want to! You smell

After I said that, he immediately smelled himself. He pro wouldn't notice. He really smells like cigarettes.

"And so what, if I smell like cigarette?" he asked arrogan

"I don't like the smell!"

"Tss... As if you didn't smoke before?"

I glared at him. "Excuse me! That was just a try! I won't smoke! That's for the whole day!"

"What?! You can't be serious about that?!" he asked, not

As if!

"I'm dead serious," I teased him.

Earlier, I was so angry at this devil. Now, I'm laughing at a kiss addict!

"I'm serious about that," I said.

"Jay... If this is still about our argument. Fine! You win!. Thank you... For risking your life to help me and my bro

Ahahahaha...

"Nice... Suddenly changed your mind when it comes to a

He looked at me pleadingly. As if his handsome face wo

"...but my answer is still no. I'm mad at you! For many th

The crazy guy just let out a heavy sigh. He almost screar

"What's the reason now?!"

I glared at him. "I don't know. Figure it out."

He suddenly slapped his own forehead. I really wanted to because of his expression, but I needed to keep up this 'a

Also, there's something I want to know.

"I feel like..." I started, making him quiet and look at me know you that well yet "

I just avoided his gaze too. I feel like a stranger to him. I  
me his parents' names. I feel like—

"My Dad killed my Mom."

# Chapter 154: Watson Fam

## Keifer's POV

"...Annoying! You'll pay for this," I whisper while walking.

"Keifer... What did I tell you?" Mom said with her signature what-I-said' tone.

"Don't curse back," I answered innocently.

"What else?"

"Revenge is not the answer."

Mom smiled at me, but I couldn't smile back. I lost to Yut Hanamitchi! He already beat me in the exam, and now he fistfought too.

I hate him.

"Why aren't you smiling yet?" she asked.

"Mom... He beat me again. Dad will get mad at me," I said disappointed.

I had no choice but to force a smile. I didn't want to, but wouldn't stop bugging me until I did.

We stopped at the gate where Dad's car would pick us up. On the other side of the street, I saw him. The one who beat me, toget-eyed friend.

His eyes met mine briefly, but they quickly returned to h

Dad's car arrived, but it looked like he wasn't in it again. because I knew he would only scold me once he found o

As soon as we got in, the car started moving. From the v He was with his scary older brother.

But I didn't care about them. My mind was still on Yuri.

Thinking about how I would get back at him.

"You lost to that Hanamitchi again?" Dad asked.

I couldn't answer. I just bowed my head.

I was waiting for Mom to say something, but Dad gave h

"I'm asking you a question, Keifer," he said with authorit

"Y-yes."

"That's the problem!" Dad interrupted Mom. "Because he's a kid! He needs to learn while he's still young! He won't listen to me until he grows up!"

I wanted to cry, but I couldn't. Dad would surely get mad at me crying.

I could do nothing but look down.

I was scared of him when he was like that. I glanced at Keigan looking at me, and I could see the tears welling up in his eyes.

Even Keigan couldn't cry out loud. I stared at the food in front of me, lost my appetite, but Mom's gaze seemed to say, 'Please, eat.'

Even though I didn't want to, I forced myself to pick up the fork and start eating.

"Next time, make sure you win against that Hanamitchi," Mom said.

I nodded in response. But I immediately regretted it, especially when I saw how Mom looked at me.

Sorry.

"Keigan sleep here," Keigan said, pointing to my bed.

He had gotten used to sleeping in my room. He always did.



"Keigan sleep," he said and made snoring sounds.

So stubborn!

I just let him be.

Someone knocked on my bedroom door. I didn't say anything.  
Mom.

The door opened, and I was right.

"How are my boys?" she asked while smiling at me.

"Keigan will sleep here," Keigan said, grinning.

Mom kissed his forehead. She was about to kiss me too when I  
heard a loud banging sound outside.

"SERINA!" It was Dad.

Shouting like a madman.

"WHERE THE HELL ARE YOU?!"

I knew Mom was scared, but she managed to hide it. She spoke  
reassuringly.

"Stay here," she told us.

"N-no... T-that's my money. I have the right—"

Dad suddenly grabbed Mom by the neck.

Keigan and I both trembled in fear.

"You have no right! This is my money! You have no money!" Mom shouted angrily.

I wanted to help Mom, but I didn't know what to do! My sister and I was just a kid.

"K-Kaizer... Y-you're hurting me..." Mom said, struggling.

"You should be hurt!" Dad yelled and suddenly slapped Mom.

She collapsed to the floor.

All we could do was cry and call out to her.

"Stop it, Kaizer! Not in front of the kids!" Mom pleaded.

"I don't care!"

He slapped her again.

"Dad! Stop, please!" I begged.

"Kaizer! Please, stop!"

I hugged her tightly. "Mom!"

"Shhhh... Don't cry. Mom is okay," she said while hugging me.

I felt useless.

I didn't do anything to help her.

We just watched as Dad hurt Mom.

It's haunting me. It's a nightmare for Keigan and me.

Seeing our Mom hurt by our own Dad.

And we couldn't do anything about it.

"Keifer!" One of my classmates called.

"Come on! Let's play!" I shook my head and looked down.

I wasn't in the mood to play. I needed to think about what happened  
that again.

Suddenly, a ball rolled to my foot.

"Keifer! Pass it!" someone shouted. I looked up to see who it was.

Yuri.

For what? To prove that you're great at everything?

"Sure," I answered quickly.

He glanced at his teammates. I grabbed the moment.

With all the force I could muster, I threw the ball straight

Bullseye!

"Yuri!" they shouted.

He collapsed to the ground as his friends rushed to him.

"What's your problem?!" the blue-eyed kid asked angrily

"None of your business," I replied indifferently.

Yuri stood up, blood dripping from his nose.

"There's blood! Call the teacher!"

He wiped his nose and looked at me with confusion and

"What's wrong with you?" he asked calmly.

"Nothing. I just hate your face," I answered.

"You're mean! We'll report you to the teacher!" the blue-

How can he stay so calm in this situation? Something inside me was angrier.

Without thinking, I ran toward him and punched him in the

"MARK KEIFER WATSON! GUIDANCE OFFICE! NO MORE

I'm dead!

# Chapter 155: Friendship

## Keifer's POV

I'm dead. I'm so dead. Mom will get mad at me. Dad will hit me. And here I am facing my penalty. What have I done?

"Damn! This is all because of someone here! So brave to tell me. Percy was complaining to me.

He could just say it to my face, we're almost standing next to each other.

"Shut up! It's your fault too!" Aries shot back at him.

I don't understand. Out of all the people who got into a fight, only the four of us were called to the guidance office.

"Why me?!" Percy asked angrily.

"Stupid! If you hadn't punched me and pushed me towards Aries, you wouldn't have been dragged into this!" Now I understand.

So that's why he suddenly flew towards me. It was Percy.

"Sorry... I thought you were the thin classmate of ours." Aries was scratching the back of his head.

"Y-yes, of course!" He thought for a moment and tried to  
Is he having amnesia? Our last fight wasn't even that lon

"I don't remember," he replied. "...But if that's true, I apc

He apologized even though he didn't remember what hap

"Stop apologizing!" Percy shouted at him.

"But it's really my fault. If we hadn't fought before, we w  
mess right now." He looked at me again.

"...Again, I'm sorry, Keifer, for what I've done."

I felt more embarrassed. I shouldn't have fought with him

"S-sorry too. I shouldn't have made a scene and started tl

Yuri smiled at me, so I did the same.

"Say sorry to me too!" Percy demanded.

My eyebrows furrowed. "Why would I?"

"You dragged me into this mess!"

"You only dragged yourself into it! Keifer and Yuri are tl  
fought!" Aries said.

"What happened?" Angelo asked.

The counselor looked at me. "Mind explaining?"

I avoided looking at them. I have nothing to explain to them. I just got so annoyed that I started a fight?

If this gets to Mom, I'm sure she'll be so disappointed. So he raised his hand. "I! I'll explain!"

Yuri and I exchanged glances. What is he going to explain?

"Keifer suddenly started a fight, then he fought with Yuri to help, and I punched Aries, then—"

"Mr. Collins! That's enough." They stopped him.

The counselor and Angelo talked for a while. I wanted to know what they were talking about, but there were times when he gave me a cold stare, so I just looked down.

Then the counselor walked out, leaving the five of us inside the door behind him.

We all gulped in fear.

"K-K-Kuya A-A-Angelo." Aries called out, trembling.

Angelo slowly turned to face us, and just as he started to



He just apologized to me, and now this is how he's pushi

"It's scary when Kuya gets mad!" Aries screamed.

Is that why they're pushing me?

"You can handle it! You're brave, right?" Percy said.

I'm alone, and since the three of them were pushing me,

I almost stumbled into Angelo.

From where I stood, I could clearly see the cold stare he  
why am I so scared of this?

"You... Keifer..." he asked slowly.

"Y-yes." I only nodded in response. I thought he would s  
he stayed quiet.

I looked at Yuri for a moment, wishing I hadn't done this  
lifted me and flipped me upside down. He shook me like  
drink.

"Aaaahhhh... Waaaagggg!" I screamed.

"You're so brave to start a fight, huh?! What?! Answer m

"T-TaaaaAaaamMaa naaa nOoo!" I screamed

"I don't want to die yet!"

"Open the door!"

"I won't do it again!"

They screamed. Is this it?! Is this our punishment for causing rather have told Mom about what happened than go through this?

I hate this!

That's weird. Only Dad's driver picked me up, not Mom.

I entered the house, and Keigan greeted me. "Where is Mom?"

"Mom sick, in bed." I grabbed his hand and led him to their room.

"Dad mad again. Keigan heard shout," he said.

Dad got mad again? Could he have hurt Mom again? I questioned and Keigan followed.

When we got to their room, I knocked first, but no one answered.

I couldn't wait any longer, so I opened the door.

Keigan was right; Mom was in bed, asleep. I walked toward her and touched her forehead to check if she had a fever. But I thought she was fine.

Mom slowly opened her eyes and looked at me. "What h

"It's my fault. I just wanted to get back at him, but it's ok  
apologized to each other.

"We're friends again," I explained.

"Please don't do that again," Mom said, sounding disapp

"I'm sorry. I promise I won't do it again."

She held my hands and smiled. Something felt off with M  
didn't look the same as before.

I noticed a red mark and a wound on her neck. She quick  
her hair when she saw me looking.

"Go change... Ask maids to prepare you a snack," she or

I nodded. "Okay."

She kissed my forehead before I left the room. I took Ke  
told him to leave with me. I wanted Mom to rest.

I changed as she instructed. Keigan was still following n

"New guy!" Keigan shouted by the window. I looked at  
pointing. There was a new guy? I had never seen him be

"Keigan saw it!"

A gun? Why does he have that?

"Please... Don't talk to that Dylan again."

"But why?! Keigan likes him."

"But I don't. I'm still your older brother, so follow what I

"Okay..." I don't trust that Dylan guy, and I heard him talk. He mentioned something about killing someone.

Mom said killing is bad. So Dylan must be bad because I

I just hope he doesn't do anything bad to us, especially to Keigan.

# Chapter 156: Strong

## Keifer's POV

Nightmare! That's what I'm experiencing right now.

Dad's abuse toward Mom has become more frequent. It's where he's quickly getting sick. And it's so frustrating that we can do about it. I just don't understand why Mom is still in the house if that's how he's treating her. It's infuriating!

"Kuya... Your friends are here," Keigan called out to me.

Him too! Something's off with him. He's been quieter lately, seeming distracted. I told him to stay away from Dylan, to keep them together.

"You don't want to join us?" I asked him while getting down.

"No. I want to stay here with Mom," he answered and walked away.

I want to stay with Mom too, but I can't. Every time I see her, she sinks. Why does she put up with this? With Dad?

I've asked her many times, but she always gives the same answer: "It's okay with your Dad." Which obviously is not happening.

"Out with my friends," I quickly answered.

"Seems like you're going out a lot."

"Why? Are you going to lock me up here too?" I asked, l

He looked me straight in the eye. I know I was being dis  
just couldn't take it anymore.

"I don't like the way you talk to me."

"And I don't like talking to you," I said and walked out o

The three of them immediately followed me.

"Aren't you scared of your Dad?" Aries asked.

"No. Why?"

"We are," Percy said and laughed.

I wish everything could be so easily laughed off. We got  
usually the one who drives during our outings. We just g  
as it's far from this damn house!

"So where are we going now?" Yuri asked.

"Let's go to a fun place. We need to celebrate," Percy sai

He immediately shook his head. "It's our anniversary! We've been together for two years!"

"Ahhh..." we all said in unison, nodding.

"What's with that? Isn't our friendship important to you guys?"

"Is this a relationship? Are you counting the days?" Aries asked.

"Yeah! So you should kiss me!" Percy yelled and tried to shove his face against Aries.

Aries quickly pushed his face away. "Yuck! Stop it!"

"Okay, okay, let's just go back home. Hahaoya will cook for us, signaling the driver to start the car."

It's been two years since that day we fought and Angelo was gone.

"Keifer," Dad called me. I wasn't planning on showing up, but he seemed like he was really waiting for me.

"Do you need something?" I asked him.

"What time is it?"

"I don't know. You're wearing a Rolex, why don't you look at your watch?"

"DON'T YOU DARE TALK TO ME LIKE THAT!" He yelled.

"Is your Mom not teaching you properly? Or is she teaching you wrong instead?!"

"No! Don't drag Mom into this!" He looked at me angrily, then he walked toward me, and what he did next was something I never wanted him to do to me.

He slapped me hard. I fell to the floor. I could feel the sharp pain on the side of my lip. My cheek went numb. I couldn't hold back my tears. I was right!

He could hurt me, just like he hurts Mom, and probably Dad.

"YOU'RE STARTING TO DISRESPECT ME! YOU'RE DISRESPECTING WHO I AM!" He shouted at me.

He grabbed me by the collar and slapped me again. It hurt, but what hurt even more was that I couldn't fight back.

"KAIZER!" Mom's voice. Dad stopped and glared at Mom, but she stood behind her, showing no reaction.

"M-mom!" She rushed toward me and hugged me. "Kaizer is just a kid."

"That's why he's acting up! You're tolerating him!" He pointed at Mom.

"But you don't need to hurt him!"

"A kid who doesn't respect his parents is a bad kid!"



"What do you want? A picture for proof?" Aries said sarcastically.

He received a death glare from Percy.

"He hurt you too. Aren't you guys going to file a complaint to have your Dad arrested," Yuri said.

I shook my head. I wish we could, but Mom doesn't want to see what Dad did to me, she still doesn't want to leave.

"Why is Mom still enduring this from that man?!"

"You won't understand because you're still a kid," Angel said in conversation.

"...Just pray that nothing bad happens to you, Mom, and realize he was listening to our conversation. I thought he was outside the house. We were outside Aries' house.

He wasn't allowed to go out, so here we are, just outside.

"But what if prayer isn't enough?" Percy asked.

What then? What will happen to us?

"Then we'll just have to force it," Aries added, but he got the back of his head from Angelo.

Tell I don't need a joke. I need a way out of Dad's grip.

"I want to be strong! If Mom doesn't want to leave Dad, to protect her! So please! Help me!" I begged.

He crossed his arms and faced me. It was obvious he was what I said.

I've seen him fight many people on his own and take the joke! And that's what I want to learn.

"It's not like that. I can't teach you," he said seriously.

"Teach me how to fight!" I insisted. "...Please, Angelo!"

"Keifer—"

"We'll help too!" Percy interjected.

"We should help too!" Aries added.

"SHUT UP!" He yelled at us angrily. "...I'm not teaching already!"

He suddenly walked inside and slammed the gate shut. We standing outside, dumbfounded.

"If he won't teach us, we'll just teach ourselves. There's a my place," Percy said.

That karate class takes too long. They only teach basic

"Mom?"

"Get up please... Take your stuff." She ordered and kept  
in my walk-in closet.

I got up and rubbed my eyes. I saw Keigan and Mom, bc  
things.

"W-what are you doing?"

"We're leaving..." Keigan quickly answered.

Leaving? Was I dreaming? Is this real? Are we leaving?

"Please Keifer... Get up and help us," Mom said.

I immediately stood up and helped them. I didn't plan on  
I just grabbed the important things and left the unnecessa

I wanted to get out of here as quickly as possible. This w  
happen. It's happening!

We quickly went outside with our things. The maids and  
get everything into the car.

"Mom... What's going on? Why are we leaving?" I asked

Mom didn't answer, so I stayed quiet. Maybe she didn't v  
truth not

# Chapter 157: Keiren

## Keifer's POV

New house. It's similar to our old house, but it's bigger. A one was indeed larger.

"Mom... Who lives here?" Keigan asked.

"No one. It used to be my parents' house, but they're dead."

Mom stopped at the garage. The front yard was huge. Two men greeted us.

"Good morning, Ma'am Serina!" they greeted Mom as we got out of the car.

"Good morning. Are the rooms ready?" Mom asked.

The woman and Mom talked for a bit, while the two men waited from the car.

"Kuya..." Keigan called me. "...Do you think there's a ghost in my head. "Ghosts are not real."

After Mom and the woman finished their conversation, she told us to enter. We followed her. Honestly, I just realized how big the house was.

One question kept running in my mind. What now?

"The house is awesome!" Percy said joyfully.

"Psh! Kid..." Yuri commented on him.

I looked at their backs. Something was missing. Aries was

"He's not here," Yuri said when he noticed I was looking

"Why? Where did he go?"

"He went back to the province with his family. Somethir cousin—what's the name again?—Jay-R? Jayson? Ugh! Percy explained.

So he had a cousin? He never mentioned it before. Anyw I invited them to come inside.

There were a lot of maids and butlers cleaning. Mom bro helpers so we wouldn't be alone in the house.

"Where are we going?" Percy asked.

"I want to show you something," I answered and continu

We went straight to the basement and stopped in front of revealing my discovery.

"You're ruining the moment! You should've just gone alone as he walked in.

Yuri and I just let him be. We stayed by the door, watching.

"How's your mom?" Yuri asked me.

"She's fine. A bit busy because of this house."

"And how about Keigan?"

I paused. How is Keigan? He's not alright. Something is

"I'm not sure."

"What's your plan for your dad?" Percy added to the conversation.

"We haven't talked about it yet."

I knocked on Mom's room door. No one answered, so I checked if she wasn't on her bed, so I walked toward her walk-in closet to see if she'd be there. But just before I took a step, I heard someone voice from the bathroom.

"Mom!" I shouted, running toward the restroom. "...Mom, is there a problem?"

I kept knocking on the door, but she didn't answer. I started

"You did? What did they say?" I asked, even more concerned.

Even though we were no longer under the control of that man, I was worried about her. Sometimes, she preferred to stay quiet about what she's feeling.

"They said it's normal, especially when you're two weeks pregnant?"

I was speechless. I didn't know what to say. Not that I wasn't just a bit shocked.

Mom suddenly laughed. "Your face, son. Don't you want to know?"

I shook my head. "Not that I don't want to. But... I... I... don't know what to say." I forced a smile.

She hugged me tight. "Please... Help me take care of you, son." I hugged her back. "I will."

Mom's belly was already large. So that's how pregnancy works. In a few months, the baby will be born.

"When are you giving birth?" Keigan asked Mom.

"In two months," she answered, smiling. "...Are you excited, Keiren?"

One of the maids walked up to Mom and whispered in her ear. Mom nodded and forced a smile.

"Is there a problem?" I asked her.

She stood up and motioned for us to follow. I felt something seemed like I wouldn't like what was coming next.

We went to the living room, and when the door opened, I saw the one person I hated most walk in.

"What is he doing here?!" I shouted angrily.

"Keifer... That's still your dad," Mom said.

I glared at him. What is he doing here?! He shouldn't be here.

"What do you want from us?!"

"I just want to fix our family, we're going to have a new start."

"No!" I screamed. "...You're not welcome here! Leave!"

"Keifer!" Mom scolded me. "...Don't talk to your dad like that."

"Mom! Please... Don't let this guy hurt us again."

"I won't, Keifer." he interjected. "...I apologize for what I did."



I looked at her hand. It was tightening on her belly. I did get angry. It wouldn't be good for her or Keiren. Someth them.

"S-sorry, Mom."

"Apologize to your dad," she ordered.

NO!

I looked at Mom pleadingly. No, I wouldn't do it! Please

"Keifer... Apologize to your dad," she repeated.

My fists clenched. It was so frustrating!

"I-I'm sorry... Dad."

He won this battle. He smiled at me and opened his arms

When he noticed I wasn't moving, he came closer and hu

But I didn't hug him back. NEVER!

This would be the last time I'd apologize to him. I will N myself like that again. Mark my words!

I chose to lock myself in my room. I couldn't stand seein

He didn't answer. He just walked away. There was something about Keigan. I didn't know what it was, but I thought he would move here. But now, things were different.

Still, I thought about what he said. It was true. I didn't want to leave the house. I grabbed my phone and texted Aries.

The good thing about this house is that it's close to theirs. They can pick me up.

I got dressed and left my room. I passed by Keigan but ignored him. Even if I invited him, he wouldn't come with me.

"Where do you think you're going?"

As soon as I heard his voice, I hurried my steps, but then I stopped.

"Out with my friends," I answered, bored.

"Only that far?"

I didn't answer. I just stared at him. If you weren't here, I would be leaving.

"...If I can't stop you, then fine. Go!"

I didn't answer and quickly left the house. In my frustration,

# Chapter 158: Boss

## Keifer's POV

"There's Boss!" Percy shouted while pointing at a group

He was referring to Angelo as Boss. I don't know where it all started when he saved us from a gang fight... again.

But honestly, I only call him Boss when I need something

"Are we going to help him?" Yuri asked.

"No need. Kuya can handle it," Aries said.

I looked back at Angelo. Is that 'handling it'? He's almost in the fight.

"Let's go... My hands are itching to fight," I said to them joining the fight. They followed me. We already knew he but that wasn't enough.

"What are you doing here?!" He angrily asked us.

"We're joining your fight!" Percy answered.

"You're so hard-headed!" Angelo shouted at them.

He looked at me and Yuri, so we immediately turned away. I was scared, but maybe—shit.

"Why do you have to hit me?!"

I looked at Yuri, who was rubbing his head. He was so far from me. Just a few days ago, he was holding the two of them, and now he was being held.

"I told you! You won't get anything from fighting! Focus on your studies!" Focus scolded us. Tss...

I don't want to study. I'd rather be outside of school, where I can learn how to fight.

"We can fight and study at the same time!" Percy shouted at him with a nasty glare.

Angelo was about to speak when suddenly someone's phone rang.

We all reached for our phones, but only one person said,

"...How are you, babe?" Percy asked on the phone. Babe

"...Did you eat well? Stay away from those guy classmates. They'll crush them, you'll see!"

While he was talking, we couldn't help but raise our eyes and

Percy looked at him seriously. "Sorry bro..." He even put his hand on his shoulder. "...We have no chance. I really like women."

Aries gave him a hard slap on the head. "You idiot! I don't like you! I'm not GAY!"

We just shook our heads at his behavior. It feels like Percy is just getting worse.

For the second time, someone's phone rang, but this time it was mine.

"Hello?"

["You need to go home... Now!"] It was Keigan.

He didn't wait for my response. He ended the call without saying anything. For some reason, I knew this was about Mom and that made me nervous.

I rushed home as quickly as I could. I went straight to Mom's room. I was still far, but I could already hear that man shouting and talking.

My heart started beating so fast. I feel nervous and scared and immediately opened the door.

"...I TOLD YOU! THAT'S MY MONEY!" He shouted with a loud voice. Mom's hair.

~~~~~

"STAY OUT OF THIS! GIVE ME MY MONEY BACK

"That is not yours. It's for the children! You know that," Money again! Is that all that matters to him? Is that why because of that? Why is he like this?

"You look like money!" I shouted as I stood up.

"What did you say?!" He glared at me. "...WHAT DID Y

"You look like—" I couldn't finish what I was going to s

He hit me with a strong punch in the face. I was thrown l same time, I felt dizzy. My jaw was almost numb from tl

"KEIFER!" Mom shouted. "...Kaizer! Have mercy on yo

"Stay out of this! I'm already full of this kid!" I tried to s body was shaking. Suddenly, he kicked me in the stomach up everything because of what he did.

"Argh!"

"Kaizer! Enough!"

Another kick hit me, followed by two or more. Even tho his kicks, I couldn't do it because of my weakness.

"You're just my son! Who do you think you are? What e

She approached me and tried to help me stand. "Leave! I dad!"

"I-I won't! I'm not leaving you here!"

"Leave!"

"No-----MOM!!" I almost lost my voice shouting.

Suddenly, that monster pulled her by the hair. He looked stand, but my body was still shaking from all the kicks.

"I'm so tired of you, woman!" He said and suddenly slung against the wall.

"NO!" He did that several more times. Until Mom's body collapsed. Her eyes were open, and she was looking at me.

"M-Mom..." I called her.

I got no response. Since I couldn't stand, I tried crawling

With every second, my heart beat faster. Please don't let me
got closer to her, I could see the tears falling from her eyes.

I held her cheek. "Mom... Please... Answer me."

Blood started flowing from her nose. I was terrified to see
hering she was just sleeping or unconscious. "Mom! Ple

Internal Hemorrhage. That's what caused Mom's death. I fault. I couldn't even protect her from that man.

"Kuya... Where is Mom?" Keiren asked me. That was the question I've heard from Keiren. He had asked me that so I couldn't answer him properly.

"She is in a better place now," Keigan answered and forced a smile. It was so hard for me. So difficult!

"Keifer..." Someone called me. It was Aries with Angelo.

"I'm sorry about what happened to your Mom. If you need anything, I'm always here for you," said their mom.

I forced a smile and nodded. "Thank you."

Behind them were Percy's family. Their mom was holding their sister, and beside her was their stepbrother, Felix.

"Bro..." He said, tapping my arm. "...You're the only funny one here." Facepalm!

Felix gave him a hard slap on the head. "Your joke is out of context."

If I weren't friends with these siblings, I would have kicked them myself.

"Bro..."

"Thank you."

I looked at a man who had just arrived. He wasn't familiar here, but there was something different about him.

He was holding a briefcase and seemed to be looking for

I excused myself from Yuri's family and approached the reached him, that monster walked up to him.

"Mr. Brian Ryder..." He called to him. "...You arrived early to see you next week."

The man, Brian Ryder, looked at him. "Because I need to see my son. Urgently." Son? Is he talking about me?!

"I understand... Let's go here," he motioned, but the man

He looked at me. "I need to speak to your son... Only."

W-why me?!

Chapter 159: Death wish

Keifer's POV

I don't understand

"H-how is this happening?" I ask Mr. Ryder.

I have millions—no! Billions of money I never knew about.

What I don't understand is, even my grandparents, who have been dead for so long, left me an inheritance. I wasn't even alive in this world when there was money already allocated for me.

"Let's say your grandparents didn't trust your dad. So they left it to their grandchild." He explained it to me.

"But... I... I..." I stutter.

"Speechless? Let me explain everything to you."

I looked at him as he took all the papers I was holding.

He sat in front of me.

"100% of your grandparents' assets and liabilities are now yours."

My head was hurting. This money is huge. What am I supposed to do with all this? I don't even know if I can handle such a large amount of money.

"Keifer?" he called me.

"S-sorry... I just... I can't believe this." I said, brushing my hands. "...I don't know if I can manage this."

I looked at the other papers on the table. I froze when I saw what was written on them.

"W-what is this?! A company? What company?! Why is it so much money?!" I asked in shock.

What is this?! I can't take it anymore... I feel like my brain is exploding from all of this.

"It looks like you're not ready for this." Mr. Ryder said as he handed me the papers. "...I knew you were too young, but your mother wanted you to have this."

"My mom?"

He looked at me seriously. "Your mom is a friend of mine. She died on the exact day of your brother's birth—Keiren—she came to me about her last will and testament."

She did that, but why?

He handed me a small piece of paper. "Call me when you

"Where is your father?" I asked Keigan angrily.

"H-he's in his room. He has someone with him."

I held my temple. I knew what he meant. I quickly walked to the room where he often brought his guests.

I didn't knock and just opened the door. As expected, I found an unpleasant scene.

"Keifer! Don't you know how to knock?!" He said to me

The woman with him quickly covered herself with the blanket.

I raised an eyebrow. The woman looked so young. She looked only 18 or even younger.

"You! Don't you know how to respect? Mom has only been dead for less than a month!" I yelled at her angrily.

"So? She's dead. She won't be coming back no matter what," she replied coldly.

Yeah! She's dead because of you! I slammed the door and

I punched the wall in frustration. Why did mom have to die? I didn't like it. It's so infuriating! I can't stand being with him

It wasn't hard to find, since it was on my study table. I qu
number.

["Hello?"] he answered from the other line.

"Mr. Ryder... It's me, Keifer."

["I guess you're ready."]

I'm not freaking ready!

This is more complicated than I thought. I feel like I'm g

"...Do you understand?" Mr. Ryder asked.

"Hmmm... Yes?"

Mr. Ryder sighed. "Let's start all over again."

He took all the papers off the table. Even the ones I was
one paper in front of me. "This is your total assets and li
placed another paper down. "...This is the monthly incon
Enterprise. Even if you don't work, the profits of the con
to you."

I understood this part. Even if I don't do anything, the co
will still come to me.

He placed another paper down. "This is the only amount

I looked at Keigan and Keiren's papers. Their amounts were probably because they're younger. But why does the money

"Why does their money still go to me?"

"Because they are in your care. Unless you want to send them somewhere else, we will send their money to them."

I understand. He explained more, and I also found out that everything is under my name, there's still a chance that I can get access to their money, especially Keigan and Keiren's.

But that's not the only thing I'm worried about and want to

"Do I have the right to kick him out of this house?"

He looked at me confused. "Yes... This house is in your name."

"Even him?"

He knew who I was referring to. I can't stand having him in the house. He disrespected my mom. It's not even 40 days since he moved in and he's already brought another woman here.

"You know that you're still a minor, right? Under the law, I'm your guardian." He explained.

I knew he was going to say that. Ever since I called him,

"Nowadays, everything can be fake." I said, running my papers. "...They could have named one of mom's trusted

"Keifer... You know—"

"I know. I also know that we could get sued." I smirked. "use of the law when you have money?"

No one dares question my mom's death because that mom has money. He played dirty, so will I.

"...I need to fight back. If I can't fight him physically, I'll

The last will and testament is more powerful. It can break

Mr. Ryder took a deep breath. I know he understands my situation. He's my only hope. He's the only one who can help me v

"As you wish, Mr. Watson." He replied.

This isn't the way I want to do it, but I have to. For mom

"Kuya!" Keiren shouted.

I just came home from school. I was confused when he started crying.

"What happened?"

["Keifer?"]

"He took Keigan! He kidnapped my brother!" I shouted.

["Calm down... Maybe they just went on a trip or a business trip."

"No! You don't understand. He knows he won't get anything inheritance! He kidnapped my brother!"

I almost cried while saying this. I knew he had a plan. It was a coincidence. What if he does something to Keigan?

["Take a deep breath, Keifer. I'm on my way."] He said and went away.

I looked at the maids and butlers with anger. "YOU'RE ALL GET OUT OF MY SIGHT!"

I looked at Keiren, who was still crying. I went to him and hugged him.

When will he ever stop hurting us?

Chapter 160: Know

Keifer's POV

Present....

She's crying. I want to hug her and comfort her, but my c

Seriously?

What the hell is wrong with this girl? I told the story of r
trusted her, but I never expected that she would cry.

"S-sorry... I just can't help it," Jay-jay said.

I look away and scratch the back of my head. "Please... S

But her crying just got louder. I slapped my forehead in :

"Jay..."

"You're so brave," she said, making me stop and look at
my life story was the worst, but yours is even worse."

Pity...

She looked away. She cleared her throat. "H-how did you back?"

"I didn't get him back... They came back a few years later with his new wife." I let out a heavy sigh. "...That's when to kick him out of the house."

"I see... So, you're the only child who kicked your father

I barely laughed at what she said. "Strange, right?"

She nodded. I glanced at my wristwatch. It's already 10 p notice she's been gone for a while.

"I need to take you back. It's already late."

I started the engine. She remained silent the entire drive. the same spot where I picked her up. I couldn't stop in front someone might see us and Jay-jay wouldn't want that.

"Here's fine. Goodnight." She said and was about to open stopped her. "...W-why?"

"Are you no longer mad at me?"

She shook her head. "Not anymore. Your story was so long being mad."

~~~~~

She's really serious about that. I couldn't do anything but frustration while she was just smiling at me.

"...If you want a kiss, stop smoking. That's the deal!"

She opened the door and got out of the car, without even walking straight into the gate.

I started the engine and drove home. A few minutes into my phone.

A text message.

I didn't check it right away and decided to do so when I got front of my gate, waiting for it to open. My phone rang a message.

Out of curiosity, I picked up my phone and opened the n from Jay-jay. Maybe she missed me already.

But I was wrong...

I looked at it twice, making sure I was reading it correctl

From: Sexy Jay-jay

Message: 'he knows...'

'...Alicia knows about us!'

I feel like attending mass tomorrow. He's letting me stay first time. We couldn't be in my room, Ci-N's there. We are outside, someone might hear us.

He has so many books in his room. So this horoscope about I thought he was only obsessed with Ella.

"Aren't you gonna speak?" His calm question.

I closed my mouth and looked down. I didn't know he saw Keifer's car. I was about to make an excuse, but he suddenly was the second time. He had also seen the first. So now it's an interrogation session.

"Jay..." He called me.

I looked at the ceiling again. No dust, nice!

"Jay-jay..."

I looked at the floor. It's so shiny, nice!

"Jay-jay!"

I looked at the corner of the room. A ghost, not nice!

Suddenly, he hit the table, and I got startled. I was about to say something but luckily I covered my mouth.

I nodded. "Yes! You said the electricity bill is going down."

In his anger, he raised his hand to smack me, but I quickly pulled my arm and moved slightly away from him.

He glared at me. He dropped his hand and touched his temple.

"What's going on with you and Keifer?" He calmly asked.

"He's acting like Kuya Angelo. They really are siblings."

"Be specific." I answered, which made him even angrier.

He suddenly walked up to me and grabbed me by the collar, pushing me to my limit?!"

"N-no."

"Answer my question if you don't want me to tell Kuya!"

I felt scared. He really would do that. My tears started to fall from my eyes.

"I-I can't say it... There's no clear conversation. We just have a conversation."

He let go of me and stared at me seriously. "Did you believe me?"

I looked at him in confusion. "What...?"

Oh right, they're fighting. But I never thought Aries would

"He wouldn't do that." I firmly said.

"Think about it!"

"He wouldn't do that! How could he use me? Tell me!" I said, which made his eyebrows furrow even more.

"I know Keifer. He'll do anything to get back at whoever

I bitterly laughed. "Is that your reasoning? How can he use me if we don't even get along? You don't care about me, right?!"

He stopped. His furrowed brows disappeared, but he was looking at me. I met his gaze, but I couldn't hold it, and tears started to fall.

I was hurt by what I said. It hurts because Aries, the one who used to love me, always played with me, brought me presents, and told me how to introduce me to his friends, is no longer the same. He's become Aries who doesn't care about me.

"I just know." He said weakly.

He's right!

He's just trying to ruin Keifer for me.

"I don't believe you." I said and quickly walked toward the door.

"...Because that's the exact words he said to Ella."

It felt like a knife stabbed my heart. My tears fell again, I speak again, I quickly left his room.

I could hardly breathe. My chest felt tight. What's happen

So what if he said the same thing to Ella? That doesn't m me. This horoscope is just jealous!

He wouldn't do that. He trusts me. He shared his life with happened with his dad. So how could what he's saying h

I can't believe Aries would do that. In his anger at Keifer to ruin him for me.

But what if it's true?

No! Keifer wouldn't do that. I walked back to my room. asleep, probably didn't wait for me. I grabbed my phone

Just a few minutes and he called me. I took a deep breath wouldn't notice I was crying.

"Hello..."

"[Are you crying?]" He asked right away.

"It's not?" I answered in a voice

"Stop it." I almost raised my voice.

I was trying to keep it down so the little brat wouldn't wa

"[I'm dead serious, Jay. If I need to face everyone in you prove I love you... I will.]"

"Keifer..."

"[Even if I have to fight Angelo and Aries. I'll fight.]"

I smiled at what he said. That's why I don't believe Aries wouldn't do that.

"Thank you."

"[Wrong!]" He said, which raised my eyebrows. "[...] Yc love you."

I chuckled a bit. This guy is something else!

"You're such a weirdo."

I heard him chuckle. "[...I love you Jay. To infi-----]"

"Keifer." I cut him off.

I suddenly felt a bit awkward. It wasn't because I believe but because there was something about how I felt



Instead of getting mad at his "Tss," I laughed out loud. It was so funny.

"[Keep laughing... You're so happy.]" He irritably said, and I laughed even more.

"You're such a flirt."

"[I love you.]"

I froze for a moment. Gotcha!

"[This is better, no complaints. I love you Jay, until science discovers the universe.]"

Long! This guy knows too much! Where did he even get that?

"Isn't the universe infinite?"

"[Exactly!]"

I bit my bottom lip. This guy's a trip. And I'm here looking at him, feeling all giddy!

He suddenly became serious, and I could feel it. "[...Don't worry. When Angelo finds out about our relationship, I'll talk to them. I'll be some fighting.]" I laughed at the last part, and so did Jasper Jean Mariano, until scientists find the end of the universe.

# Chapter 161: Words

## Jay-jay's POV

I feel like crying.

If it weren't for... Haizt!

"Pain..." Ci-N whispered as he gently touched his ear. It's like he's listening to me and the person I was talking to on the phone. In my frustration, I pulled his ear. And even though we had already agreed, he's still feeling the pain. What a jerk!

"Do the other one... so it's even." I said, and he quickly covered his ear.

"I don't want to." He said. I just glared at him and walked away. We were going to have breakfast, and we still had school. I wasn't in the mood because of what happened yesterday. I can't remember Dylan's face when he pointed a gun at me, my hands shaking again.

I lost my courage. What a pain in the ass!

Suddenly, Ci-N rushed ahead of me while still holding his hand. He's stopping. I stopped walking when I saw Aries. He was

"You're really beautiful..." Yeah, what? Are you jealous? insulting. My brows immediately furrowed.

"You're getting married to Yuri, and yet you still have Ke..." He shook his head and walked away from me.

Aside from being annoyed with this horoscope, there's one thing on my mind right now. I'm going to tell Yuri the truth. I don't love him anymore. That wasn't my intention, and I don't want to commit sins against him.

I had breakfast in a daze. Even while showering and getting dressed, I was still out of it. I didn't know how, but I knew today was the day to tell him.

"Jay-Jay." Ci-N called me while we were walking.

"...You're not listening."

"S-sorry. Did you say something?"

"Oh, nothing..." he sarcastically replied, making me a little annoyed.

"I've said a lot. My good looks are gone now." I scratched my head.

"Am I handsome?" He suddenly squinted his eyes.

"Don't yell too loud. That's a secret of mine." His audacity was

usually beats me to it. I sat down and grabbed my phone, have checked earlier. I saw that Yuri had texted me.

From: Yuri

Message: "Can't go to school. I have fever. Please take care.  
Shit! Why now?! This is crazy!

I should have told him today. I shouldn't wait any longer to go see him.

I was in a daze... Is it a sin to ask the heavens for one—he suddenly felt like singing. Sir Alvin and Keifer came in, realizing. I was far gone—probably on Pluto by now.

Then suddenly, someone pinched my ear. It hurt so much.

"Damn! That hurts!" Everyone stared at me.

Sir Alvin was also looking at me angrily. I looked at Keifer to hide his smile. Bastard! What's his deal? Pinching my ear nowhere. I just lowered my head.

I wanted to get back at him, but that's not what I was thinking about what I had to say to Yuri. How I would start.

The rest of the subjects went by, and I was still out of it.

Keifer answered for me. "You go ahead. We need to talk confused, he followed instructions. There was no one left looked at the jerk and waited for him to speak.

"Why? What do we need to talk about?" I asked. "What's have noticed you're not yourself." Tsk!

I didn't want to say it, but maybe he needed to know.

"Well... I've been thinking about how to tell Yuri the truth

"What do you mean?"

"I feel guilty. I don't want to deceive Yuri anymore." He

"I understand. Even I feel ashamed in front of him." He s  
"...Why is it that we both like the same girl?" I bit my bo

The image of Yuri's face when he was hurt by Ella kept p  
It's going to happen again.

"I was planning to go see him now." I said, looking at Ke  
"...I'm going to tell him." Suddenly, he stood up and walk  
I immediately followed him.

"I'll drive you." He said as he continued walking. We got  
and I saw Aries, who was with Ella. It looked like they p  
themselves by Keifer's car.

I can already see Yuri's building ahead. The closer we go, the faster my heart beat. When we arrived at the parking lot, I didn't get a chance to had to gather my strength.

"I'll stay here. We might end up fighting." Keifer said. I didn't respond.

"Thanks." I got out of the car and went to the elevator. I waited for Keifer as I waited for the doors to open. He forced a smile at me.

I got in as soon as the door opened. I pressed the button for the top floor.

My hands were sweating. I didn't know if it was the heat or my nervousness. When the doors opened, four women in traditional Filipino attire greeted me. They were fewer than before, and they bowed and greeted me in Tagalog. I bowed and greeted them back—in Tagalog. I went to his room.

Fortunately, I was somewhat familiar with the layout by the time I had trouble finding his room. I knocked, but no one answered. I waited a minute and then I left. He was sick, and maybe this wasn't the right time to visit.

Now or never! Damn! No choice.

I opened the door. I expected him to be lying in bed, sleeping. But he wasn't there. I looked toward the balcony. The door was open, and the curtains were fluttering in the wind.

*Everybody loves the things that you do From the way you*

Just like before, his voice sounded beautiful. If you think Keifer are quite similar. They're friends, after all.

*"You look like a movie You sound like a song My God, th when we were young..."*

They're both talented, smart, a bit bossy, quiet, and have They're both good-looking, a bit rebellious, but never tak anyone, and most of all, they're not hard to love.

*"Let me photograph you in this light In case it is the last be exactly like we were Before we realized..."*

Suddenly, tears started falling. If I could just teach my h to hurt him. I don't want him to go through the same pain

*"We were sad of getting old*

*It made us restless It was just like a music It was just like*

I was crying so hard because this was unfair. I want him I'm doing is hurting him. I thought I could do it.

Suddenly, he stopped playing and turned to face me.

"Jay? You're here." He said, setting down his guitar. He s at me, but my heart shattered when I saw the smile fade, crying.

"I'm sorry... I'm really sorry." I couldn't stop crying. It felt like I hardly breathe. "I really tried."

"Jay..."

"But... It's Keifer."

My crying worsened. I waited for him to say something, but he was silent. I couldn't look at him out of shame.

I waited for what felt like several minutes. Finally, he spoke.

"I know." Those were the first words he said, and it made me feel like I had been punched in the gut.

"...I've known from the very start. It's always been Keifer. I felt it in my chest as I processed his words. Questions flooded my mind, but my mouth wouldn't move to speak.

"Hahaoya wasn't lying when she said she saw you with him. I was there from embarrassment." Damn... that's all I could think.

"And I also know you made out with him in the restroom. I saw it. Bitterly. "...I was there when you confessed to him."

Shit! I didn't even have enough curse words to describe what I was feeling. How did he know all of that?

"If you're wondering how I knew..." He walked closer to me, his eyes fixed on mine.



He turned his back on me. "I'll let you continue with Kei wedding day comes, you'll say 'I do' no matter what, or i Fer Corp." His tone was authoritative.

He's still going through with it?!

"Y-Yuri... Y-you'll just get hurt."

"What's the point? You're already hurting me." I heard hi

Even though he wasn't facing me, I knew he was crying. his pain.

"...Trust me, at the end of the day, you'll still be mine." E

I tried to step closer to him, but my knees wouldn't move

"Y-yuri... Please."

"Jay... Leave now." He commanded, his voice heavier.

"...Leave. Now!"

I had no choice but to slowly walk toward the door. He r me, even as I left.

But just before I could leave completely, he said one last me.

# Chapter 162: Inner Pain

## Jay-jay's POV

You are exactly like Ella. His words keep repeating in my broken record. It hurts so much! He led me on.

Keifer hugged me tightly. He didn't say anything and just like a child crying uncontrollably. His arms and shoulders held my tears and snot.

"You can't blame Yuri..." he said while still holding me. "I'm sorry again."

"I know... But it hurts so much."

That wasn't my intention. I didn't mean to lead him on. I had a purpose. I understand why he's so angry at me. But I just can't help it. It feels like a million needles are piercing my heart.

"Keifer... He doesn't want to cancel the wedding."

He let go of me and held my face. Even though my face was covered in snot and tears... he kissed me. For a moment, I forgot what I was feeling. I also forgot that I looked like a mess. Oh, damn! His mouth tasted like cigarettes and Mentos. He pulled away from me and immediately

"Don't worry about the wedding. We still have time to think about how to stop it."

I sniffled and nodded at him. He kissed me on the forehead and I felt a little better.

He took something from his pocket and handed me a white handkerchief.

"Blow your nose. You're disgusting," he said, laughing.

I grabbed the handkerchief and blew my nose loudly. I threw out everything that was hiding in my nose, and I almost felt like I blew my brain out too. After clearing out, I gave the handkerchief back to him.

"Thanks."

"It's yours... You might need it. I think you didn't finish your nose clear out."

I just held onto the handkerchief. Keifer started the car. He told me to go home.

"I want to go home," I almost whispered.

He just nodded at me. I remained quiet during the ride. Even if I wanted to talk, what would I say? There were moments when Keifer looked at me, but I couldn't return the gaze.

"Hm?"

"I talked to Percy."

My heart stopped. I slowly looked at Keifer, who was staring ahead. Here's another thing confusing me.

"H-how?"

"Remember my promise to you? About your father's info?"  
I nodded in response.

"...I did get his contact number and tried to call it. His secretary  
Keifer stopped the car. That's when I noticed we were already at the house. He didn't stop at the same spot as yesterday. He took out a card and started pressing something. He held it out to me, and I was playing.

"Good morning... You're reaching Mr. Mariano's number, who's on the line?" A man's voice. From the way he spoke, I knew he was a foreigner, with a very thick accent in his English.

But why is Keifer showing this to me?

"This is Keifer Watson. Can I speak to Mr. Mariano? This is urgent."

Keifer's voice sounded authoritative. There was no room for argument.

I couldn't detect any joy in Percy's voice. It was serious and annoyance. The way he said "Bro" had emphasis.

"Who's this?" Keifer replied quickly.

"Oh crap! You're making me cry... Have you already forgotten years been so long for you to forget your dead friend? Oh pain!"

I wanted to be annoyed by what he said, but I didn't know or just messing with us.

"Percy?"

"Finally! I thought you'd never remember my very hands!

"What the hell?! I have no time for your crap! I need to see Mariano. Now!" Keifer's irritation was obvious.

Suddenly, Percy laughed. I could feel my irritation too. I was playing with Keifer... or maybe with both of us.

"Mark Keifer Watson... You haven't changed. You're still thinking you're still the King?"

"Percy..."

"Keifer..." Percy mimicked Keifer's tone. "...You are already dead."

"Shit! Percy! What the hell is your problem?! I need to take care of my daughter! She needs her father!" Keifer said angrily. Even I would be pissed off if I was Percy was saying.

"Don't shout, Bro! You can't talk to him. No matter how much you want to. I heard something clink, and then someone spoke in a language I don't understand.

"...I have to go. Don't worry, we'll be back soon, and we'll take Jay-jay from you. From you and from Angelo."

The recording ended, and all I could think about was: I don't know any of that.

What is this?! I'm so confused!

"W-what do they mean by 'take her back'?! I don't understand! I said angrily.

Keifer set his phone aside. "I'm confused too. I'm starting to lose track of time with him."

I just held my head. What the hell is going on?! Who are they? What do you need from me?! Percy Mariano?!

"It looks like we have no choice but to wait."

"I don't know what to do."

David had told him that.

Keifer kissed me on the forehead. I looked up and suddenly was drawn to the gate of the house. It opened, and... shit!

"It's Kuya Angelo..." I said, quickly looking down. I almost closed the window.

I glanced up at Keifer, who was panicking as he went up the stairs.

"Is he still there?!" I asked.

"Y-yeah... Shit! I got startled by you. I pressed something, but he didn't answer, laughing.

I also laughed. His timing is crazy! He just suddenly appeared in the house.

I glanced at him, and he wasn't doing anything. He was just looking around.

What is this?!

Here's the problem: if he doesn't leave or go inside the house, he'll be in the back of Keifer's car. He'll see me from where the car is parked.

"I can't get out... He'll see me," I said, almost pleading.

I looked at him, and I noticed him staring ahead of the car almost had a heart attack when I saw Aries.

Shit! He was staring at us. I could see his fist clenched.

"It's Aries... I'm getting out now."

I thought he'd let go of me, but his grip on me tightened.

He turned me to face him and smiled.

"Bak—" I didn't finish saying it as he suddenly kissed me.

Oh... just the cheek?

"Take care. I love you, Jay, until scientists find the end of

I? Speechless! I was so out of it that I just nodded. Because the hell!

"...What's your answer?" he asked.

"W-what... I love----Ah, frog!"

Suddenly, Aries banged on the car window. His look was do anything but pull away from Keifer and rush to get out.

"Are you really doing this here?" He said, burning me with



I thought he had forgotten about it. Or maybe he's been there earlier, but I was zoned out? He really emphasized the word.

"It's fine," I said while grabbing some clothes.

"Jay... I know I'm handsome and girls quickly fall for me. I raised an eyebrow at me. "...but you don't need to tell Keifer that I like you like."

What did he just say?!

If my eyebrow could separate to raise higher, it would've done so now.

"I love Ci-N... Ahihihi..." I just grimaced. He really hits home that the 'I love you' last night wasn't meant for him.

I grabbed the pillow and threw it at him with all my strength. He just caught it and laughed at me.

"You're annoying!" I yelled and jumped at him.

I started hitting him with the pillow. He just laughed and the pillow was gone, I grabbed his hair and started pulling it.

"Ouch! Ouch!" He yelled.

Impact!

I instantly got a little brother in Ci-N. Even though he of annoys me, he's actually fun to be with.

I let go of him and watched as he squirmed in pain. He looked seriously, and I thought he'd get angry, but he suddenly smiled mischievously.

"Are you jealous of my side?"

"Shameless! I have one too."

"Why are you pinching the side of someone who has one?"

"Idiot!"

"Jay-jay's jealous!"

I hit him again hard, and he blocked it with his arms.

"If I lose my side, I'll never hear the end of it," He threatened.

"Oh yeah? You won't lose your side, and you eat too much!"

"Go ahead... pinch my side too, let's see if it disappears—"

"OW!"

I punched him hard on the arm. He'll mess with my side

My nervousness disappeared, but it was replaced with co

He looked at me with sad eyes before finally standing up

He went out of the room, and I followed. He was holding  
like he wanted to pull it out. He ended the call after a few  
talking.

"W-what?" I asked.

He looked down. "They said my condo unit is okay now

# Chapter 163: Past

## Jay-jay's POV

There was a time when I was annoyed with Ci-N because of his attitude and how he left a mess in my room. All I could think of was how to kick him out.

I was quiet in my room when he wasn't around. I didn't really talk to him every day or night. But my world shook when he came back.

Every now and then, he would eat chips, ice cream, juice, and cake. I was always hanging out at the Mini Mart to buy snacks for him. I did his laundry because he didn't know how to do it. He didn't want to ask their maid Tita Gema to do it for him—she said her hands had germs.

I was also always sleep-deprived from watching movies. He would often get scolded because of his nonsense, and I'd have to explain to him why he was always taken care of by Tita Gema and Kuya Ang. It was my job to take care of me.

And most of all, Aries and I would often fight because of our different opinions. But it was also so much fun...

~~~~~

"Hey! Are we going to finish this or what? Keep doing it grabbing the clothes I was holding.

"Leave tomorrow instead," I begged him.

"Mom doesn't want to. She said it's too embarrassing," he

"...If you don't want to be separated from me, apply to be

I looked at him with a sharp glare. he was crazy! Why would I be a maid?!

"...This is also good so Keifer and Aries won't get jealous

What?!

"Keifer and Aries?" I asked in confusion.

I understand Keifer. He's really possessive, even candy gets jealous about. But Aries? That's impossible.

"How do you know Aries is jealous?"

"From his eyes. He gets really jealous when we're having sex," I answered quickly.

That's unclear!

That's more unclear than floodwater. He might be jealous

I frowned but still gave it to him. We finished organizing and he was amazed. We managed to squeeze everything into his suitcase.

Because of the sheer amount of clothes, toys, and other things I brought, it looked impossible to fit it all in his suitcase. I was sure it wouldn't.

There was a knock on the door, and it opened. Kuya Ang immediately looking at Ci's suitcase.

"Are you ready?" he asked us.

Ci-N smiled and nodded. I stood up and we tried to push the suitcase, which was so big that it seemed like I could fit in it.

But we were unsuccessful. We'd just barely gotten out of the room and already felt like all the blood had drained from my body.

"Ci-N! What are these, gold?" I asked.

he just shook his head. We were close to the stairs, so I pushed.

I pushed too hard, and the suitcase accidentally rolled down the stairs.

Shit! Shit!

"Argh!" someone screamed.

We ran downstairs. My eyes widened when I saw the suitcase. It was so big that it was better to say it crushed him than to say it killed him.

"What the hell?! Where did this come from?!" he yelled

"S-sorry. It's my suitcase," Ci-N said.

Aries slowly stood up and immediately yelled at Ci. "Yo
You're causing trouble!"

I hid Ci-N behind me. "I'm the one who's at fault! You do
Ci-N!" I said angrily, locking eyes with him.

You could clearly see the pain on his face, and beads of s
forming. He walked away, but not before shooting Ci a c
behind me.

We tried again to push the suitcase after Aries left. We fi
door and were met by Kuya Angelo.

He took the suitcase, almost stumbling as he realized how

"How much do you want to bet? Kuya can't lift this," I w
little brat.

"He can lift it. Kuya's strong," he answered.

Kuya tried lifting the suitcase, counting "One, two, three
push.

Ci and I couldn't help but laugh at how he looked, like he

We were silent for the rest of the ride. I stared at the light buildings we passed.

His condo wasn't that far away. But it felt like we were in a new world now.

A world of extreme wealth!

We arrived at the condo and, just as we pulled in, I saw Ci waiting at the entrance.

Rakki was also there next to her older sister.

I heard Ci sigh next to me. he lowered his head and started fidgeting with his fingers.

"This is it... I'll be living on my own now," he said.

I felt a wave of sadness. I knew he couldn't handle this by himself and he was like a 4-year-old in his thinking. How was he supposed to be alone?

he looked at me. "Are you sure you really don't want to be his maid?"

I immediately pinched his cheek. he was so persistent! Why was he insisting I be his maid?

~~~~~



I punched him in the stomach to stop him. I was already hearted because he was leaving, and all he could think all he winced. "Joke! Why'd you punch me?"

"You're so annoying!"

We got out of the car, and he followed me. Kuya Angelo suitcase. Even though he didn't show it, I could tell he was

"Sorry for the trouble, Mr. Fernandez," Ci's mom greeted

"...I know Ci-N has caused a lot of trouble for you," she

Ci-N bowed his head, clearly embarrassed by what his n

"It's okay. Ci-N wasn't any trouble," Kuya Angelo said, s

"Let us thank you for letting Ci-N stay with you. How about dad asked.

"Thanks, Mr. Peralta. That would be great," Kuya answered

"Saturday night?"

"Sure."

I kept glancing between Kuya and Ci's dad. Their conversation fancy. They both sounded so rich.

"Ci-N! Let's go! Say thank you and goodbye to your friend  
ordered.

he turned to me and smiled. "You really don't want to appear

he's so persistent!

I just shook my head, laughing.

"Too bad... The salary is 50,000," he teased.

My eyes widened at his words, but he quickly laughed, s  
joking. he's such a brat!

I messed with his hair. Honestly, I wanted to push him to

"Goodbye, Jay... I'll see you at school tomorrow," he said  
his family.

Kuya came up to me and put his arm around my shoulder

I nodded, and we walked back to the car. Once we were  
sat in silence, or rather, the silence of the surroundings.

Nobody was making any noise.

Sigh...

Kuya stopped in front of the Mini Mart

I smiled and grabbed my own basket. Since he said I could take everything. Just kidding—but I really wanted every

As I was picking out things, I glanced over to the other side and saw someone with yellowish hair. They were tall, and I could see above the shelves.

Yellowish hair!

Suddenly, I remembered. Who had yellowish hair? That cheesy name, and they looked like someone who sang "I

"Jay-jay?" someone called.

I turned around, and there was the guy with yellowish hair. He looked like the "PPAP" singer.

"T-Tiger?"

"I knew it was you!" he said and quickly walked toward me.

I stepped back, as he looked like he was going in for a hug. I realized I didn't want one.

He looked like a mess!

He was wearing a long-sleeve shirt with holes, faded shorts, and socks. Fashion on point!

"Jay!" Kuya Angelo called from a distance. "...Is everything stopped in his tracks when he saw who I was talking to."

Leo?

Who's Leo? I kept glancing between Kuya Angelo and Tiger like lion.

I looked at Tiger. "You're Leo?"

He suddenly smiled widely and put his arm around my shoulder, pulling me closer.

"Long time no see, Angelo," he said teasingly.

Kuya's grip on me tightened, and I glanced at him.

He was glaring at Leo—Tiger.

"Everything's fine. Nice to see you here," Kuya said, forcing a smile.

They stared at each other for a long time. There was something in the air. Then Tiger looked at me and winked.

My eyebrows furrowed. "I'll poke your eye out," I threatened.

He chuckled a little. "You're cute. I'm not buying you pizza."

Final

Leo and Kuya knew each other?

# Chapter 164: Galawang U

## Jay-jay's POV

Sick in the Lungs! But why? How?

I didn't understand anything from what Aunt Gema and t talking about. The only thing I heard was "damaged tissu like that. When did that even happen?!

"Jay..." Keifer called me. "...A penny for your thoughts." what you've been thinking about again?" I shook my head referring to Yuri. His absence made me even more worri I tried texting and calling him, but his phone was off.

But what was really bothering me was Aries. I thought h because the suitcase fell on him, but when the doctor sai problem, I started to think.

I don't remember Aries smoking. He's always jogging in why would he have lung problems?

"Aries... He's in the hospital." I almost whispered. "Why lung problem." Keifer went quiet. I don't know why, but clicked in my mind. I looked at him, and suddenly, "secc

like he was choking on his cough. Along with his cough, "How sweet."

That brat!

Everyone started staring at him like a bunch of snakes. I grabbed Keifer's hand. I knew he knew that Ci knew what was going on.

Our next teacher arrived after Sir Alvin. During the class, I moved to Yuri's seat. What if he went back to his old ways? What about Leo, aka Tiger? I hope not!

Suddenly, someone kicked my chair. I almost screamed.

I glared at Keifer because he was the only one next to me who had done that.

He pretended not to notice and just stared at the board.

What now?

I straightened up, and suddenly, my chair shook. One of the legs was uneven. Ugh, so annoying! I tried to fix it, but everyone was watching.

"Ms. Mariano? Is there a problem?" Our teacher asked.

"Sorry, sir. I'm just fixing my chair." I said and stood up. I let me continue what I was doing.

"Mr. Watson and Ms. Mariano," our teacher called.

Ci-N raised his hand. "Correction, sir, it should be Mrs. "

The whole class erupted in laughter. They're all animals!

"Keifer... What are you doing? I'm going back to my sea pleading.

"Stay here." He ordered and looked at our classmates. ".. chair."

What?!

Eren walked over and started trying to fix my chair. I did I'd have to sit here, but I didn't like it.

Seriously?!

Everyone in class was watching us. Some were giggling others gave serious looks, like Josh and David, who didn

Once Eren finished, I quickly returned to my seat. I bowed both embarrassed and irritated. Who likes that kind of at

The class ended without me acknowledging the annoying I felt like he did that on purpose.

Our next teacher arrived, and we had a long discussion



Keifer stood up and began speaking. Honestly, I didn't understand what he was saying. I didn't understand the lesson at all because he wasn't paying attention.

He suddenly stopped and looked at me. "What's the Tagalog word for Profit... earnings?"

"Kita or kinita, I think," I answered uncertainly.

He went back to explaining. I noticed that his explanation was confusing. What was the connection with what he asked me?

He stopped again and looked at me. "What about 'Expensive love'?" Does that even exist?

I shook my head because I had no idea, but he kept waiting for an answer. So without thinking, I blurted out:

"Expensive love?"

He smiled at me. "I love you too."

Oh crap!

The class erupted in laughter again. That idiot!

I just lowered my head. I didn't want them to see my face.

just to stay away from him.

Maybe he noticed me avoiding him. In the next subject, tapping me, but I ignored him.

"Jay..."

Don't pay attention! He's just trying to get attention.

"Jay-jay..."

Keifer is just being a brat!

"Jasper..."

Forget it!

"Jean..."

You jerk!

"Mariano..."

I'm done with you!

"Watson."

That's you, not me!

"My life..."

Hmm?!

"My everything..."

What is he even saying?!

"Just pay attention, Jay... I think Keifer wants to serenade

Calix said, and I glared at him.

He just laughed at me. Apparently, everyone else was waiting for our teacher taking so long?

"Hey..." Keifer called again.

This time, I faced him. "What is it?"

"Do you want lips?" He asked, smiling.

I raised an eyebrow. Is this guy for real?

"...here!" He pulled out four pieces of Lips Candy from his pocket and handed them to me.

I thought he meant something else. I was about to take the sweet stuff, but suddenly, he pulled his hand away with a

I felt dizzy, not because of the loud cheering and the ban but because of how fast my heart was beating.

"Delicious, right?" He said, still smiling.

Asshole!

I stood up so quickly in shock. I was about to say something but just froze. Nothing came out.

I could only stomp my feet and walk out of the room. I went to the second floor of the building. Damn it!

Yes... we kissed, but not in front of everyone. I didn't like what he was doing either. Even if Yuri wasn't here, I was hurting him.

I just lost the desire to be in class. I sat on the floor and leaned against the wall.

"Jay..." someone called me.

When I looked, it was Drew and Denzel. I got a little scared. They might be a ghost.

"What?"

They sat down beside me.

That kid!

He can't keep anything to himself. He tells everyone. He later.

"Keifer is the one you picked? What about Yuri?" Denze

"You should've chosen Yuri." Mayo added.

"I can't control what my heart feels." I said quietly.

"Even so... you don't understand," Drew added.

I looked at them confused. "What do you mean?"

Denzel stood up from beside me. "Keifer will just make

Then Drew followed him. "I hope you don't regret not ch

What the...

"The class is divided again. I just hope you don't get cau  
Mayo said and walked away.

Denzel and Drew followed him. I was left feeling confused  
they said.

Whatever happens, think carefully. This love triangle is c  
trouble in Section F. I don't want you to go through what

# Chapter 165: Dinner

## Jay-jay's POV

I'm all over the place again! Not because of drama, but because of overthinking. The thing I've been afraid of is starting to lose the friends who were supporting Keifer and Yuri are no longer talking to me. I'm indifferent, but they are forced to get involved in the conflict.

What's worse is that it's escalating. Like with Kit Mayo. He's not talking because of their issue, and now it's affecting us too. It's getting crazy!

Then, I heard a knock on my door. It opened, and Kuya came in.

"Jay... Get dressed. We're going somewhere." He ordered.

"Ha?"

"Get dressed, just wear a dress or something."

He walked out of my room. I didn't get the chance to ask where we were going.

I stood up and grabbed some clothes. Even though I was not dressed anyway, I also fixed my hair. But I wasn't feeling

"You told me to..." I began, but he interrupted me.

"Never mind! We're going to be late. Let's go!"

I scratched my head and followed him to the car.

"Where are we going?"

He didn't answer and just silently stared out the window. even doing? Tito Julz and Tita Gema weren't with us either watching over Aries in the hospital.

The car slowed down and parked in front of a fancy restaurant like only wealthy people ate there.

And I was right. Just stepping inside, I already wanted to though I was wearing a dress, I didn't feel like I belonged even though he was in semi-formal wear, still looked the was wearing a messy, everyday outfit, he still fit in.

"Kuya, what's going—" I didn't need to finish the sentence stood, I could see Yuri and his parents.

Great!

"We're having a dinner date with Yuri and his parents," he towards their table.

... ..

He smiled again and pulled me to sit down. He helped me sit on the seat. I looked at him with confusion because, well, it felt like something had happened between us.

"...How's Aries? I hope it's not too serious what happened. Mom said to Kuya.

"He's okay now. He's been sick for a while. His body just wasn't doing well and he had difficulty breathing again," Kuya explained.

Sick for a while? I had no clue Aries had been sick for that long. Nothing in his appearance to indicate it.

"That's good to hear. Anyway, let's talk about the wedding.

Ugh, seriously...

Here we go. I'm about to be dragged into this mess again.

"We were hoping to have the wedding next year, but Otc that. So, we'll just wait for Jay-jay's birthday."

My head started to hurt. My birthday? Is this a joke? My birthday is in a few months! A FEW MONTHS!

"Jay-jay?" Kuya called my attention.

He probably noticed I was staring at the table. I couldn't



"That's great! I'll go with you to choose," Yuri's mom said with a smile.

I smiled back, but I noticed Kuya's meaningful look. He looked at me intently.

I turned away quickly but ended up meeting Yuri's gaze. I saw a sign of anger or frustration from him.

Why is he like this? He should be mad at me. He should be angry. He shouldn't be talking to me. Why?

Suddenly, Yuri looked at me again and smiled. The conversation continued.

"We also need to teach Jay-jay Japanese so she won't have to go to Japan."

I almost lost my balance from hearing that. Japan? Why Japan? What's my role there?

"Are you okay?" Yuri asked.

I just nodded, but he didn't seem to believe me.

"I'll take Jay-jay outside to get some fresh air," he said, and he stood up.

He guided me to the side of the restaurant, where there were some

He sighed deeply. "I can't. I can't be mad at you or hate y

I looked at him in confusion. What do you mean you "ca  
You should be angry at me.

He sat down in front of me, his knee serving as a suppor  
at the same height now.

"...That's how much I love you. Even with all the betraya  
hurt you've caused me. I can't hate you. Yeah, I yelled at  
realized that was wrong, and I apologize for that."

Apologize?! Is he serious?

Tears fell from my eyes without me realizing it. It felt lik  
choking me.

"Don't make this harder for me," I begged. "...I don't des

He held my face, wiping away my tears with his thumb.

"Maybe you don't deserve it. But I still love you. I still w  
you."

Stop it...

"Yuri... Please... Stop."

He smiled at me. "I won't stop. Not now." He pulled his

I sat back down on the bench, my knees giving out under tears over and over again. But every time I tried to get up the tears kept racing down.

How frustrating...

A few minutes later, I heard my phone vibrating in my pocket. It was calling.

"Jay?"

I looked at the one who called my name. I was surprised calling me. It wasn't Keifer. He was wearing glasses.

Keigan!

He was with a woman I recognized.

"What are you doing here?" I asked, adjusting myself.

"We're here to celebrate my girlfriend's birthday," Keigan said, his companion and pulling her closer. "...This is Elixera, my girlfriend."

She smiled at me and extended her hand. I took it and she remembered her now! She was Blaster's best friend, the one on his phone.

She was Blaster's best friend, the one on his phone.

"I... well, I..." Suddenly, her phone rang.

She signaled for me to be quiet and took a step away from

While I waited for Keigan to finish his call, I couldn't talk to my girlfriend. There were times she'd glance at me and smile at me, but I was self-conscious.

I couldn't stop staring at her!

Suddenly, her phone rang again. She took it out of her bag and saw a picture of Blaster on the screen with the word "Calling..."

She panicked and quickly turned off her phone, putting it away. She looked at Keigan, but he didn't seem to notice. She then turned back to me, as if she wanted to say something.

"Are you Jay-jay?" she asked.

I nodded.

"U-uh, I was wondering... maybe you could..."

I knew what she was about to say. She didn't want Keigan to know Blaster called her. I smiled and made a zipping motion as if to say

I'd stay quiet. It might cause a scene if I said anything.

"Happy birthday," I said.

Keifer! Suddenly, I felt a rush of excitement for reasons  
After everything that happened, I also wanted to talk to h

I walked ahead of Keigan, and when I entered the restau  
with another woman.

# Chapter 166: Bread Knife

## Jay-jay's POV

When I first met Freya, I hated her so much. Why? It's so matched my level of pettiness. If we had talked properly we would have been friends. I would have accepted her even if she had a coloring book and had a record of being a Total Bitch. But if we both wanted to back down, we could never get along.

I thought Freya was the worst, but I was wrong. So wrong when I met this woman!

I feel like Yuri's parents—no, scratch that. Let's remove that because they definitely did this on purpose. Sharing our hell! They had their own celebration, yet they decided to joke?! This whole situation feels more like a joke than the companion. She's clinging to his arm like crazy.

They're dressed so formally too. She must be Freya's friend like a coloring book. What's weird is that she seems familiar, I remember which hell she crawled out of. Demon!

I glanced at Yuri's mom. She was staring at me, but she seemed to have noticed I saw her. She's seen me with Keifer before, so not a big deal.

The King of Snakes cleared his throat. "I met her at a Halloween year..."

Halloween? Holy cow! The flirty Bunny Girl who dance remember! That's why I felt so angry around her. He confessed saying he only recently found out she's Mr. Ryder's niece so annoying... Honey Bee Ryder.

Nice! But why is she here?!

There's so much food in front of us, but I've lost my appetite woman's face. What's even more annoying is that Keifer is at me. On top of that, Yuri and her mom are clearly trying to get a reaction.

What do they want?

"Maki... Open your mouth." The woman said, trying to force me to eat.

What? Maki?! Maki! MAKI!!! Where the hell did that "Maki" come from?

"Maki?!" I asked loudly, causing everyone to look at me.

Honey—no, Bee—raised an eyebrow at me. "It's Keifer! He's the one who said it to him! Got a problem with that?" she asked in a sassy tone.

I looked at Keifer, but he had no reaction as he stared at me. "Aren't you doing anything? Don't you have anything to say?"

"It's your favorite, right?" he cut me off.

he still remembers that. When we had dinner at her house, grandma, I asked him for the potatoes.

"Thank you..." I said, forcing a smile.

The heaviness of our earlier conversation hasn't gone away. Irritation with these two is stronger.

he smiled back at me.

"Are you two together?" Honey suddenly asked us.

I was caught off guard by her question. I didn't know how to make things worse, Yuri's sister and parents also looked at me, all waiting for my answer.

Wait! Why me?!

Even Keigan and his girlfriend looked at us.

"W-we... We're—" Yuri suddenly held my hand.

I looked at her, and she gave me a meaningful smile.

"We're more than friends but less than lovers," Yuri answered Keifer and the woman.



shoulder of this SNAKE King.

My ears burned at what she said. He doesn't want an official relationship with her? Seriously?! You don't even look serious, and you're not an official?

The fabric of your dress is barely holding on! And you expect a relationship? Oh, please! Should I shave your head?

A male waiter approached us with a cake. Keigan stood up and placed it in front of Elixera. We started singing "Happy Birthday" and clapping.

While everyone was busy singing, I took the chance to look at Elixera. Thankfully, he was also looking at me.

I glared at him. I wanted to scream at him and curse him. I wasn't thankful there are so many people around. He seemed to be trying to say something because he forced a smile that looked more like a grimace.

"...Happy Birthday to you!" We finished the song and we all started to blow out the candle.

We gave her a loud round of applause. They went back to their seats and went back to staring at the two of us.

I'm so annoyed by their appearance. I couldn't take it any longer. I pulled out my phone. I almost crushed the screen typing a message.

To: King of Snakes

Message: 'You're crazy!'

I saw him frown when he saw my reply. It didn't even take long to get his response.

From: King of Snakes

Message: 'Profanity!'

I raised an eyebrow. He really had the nerve to demand that I be profane.

To: King of Snakes

Message: 'You're the profanity!'

He kept looking back and forth between me and his phone while typing a reply, Honey suddenly took his phone and turned it off.

She placed it on the table, and this idiot didn't even come back to me.

Honey turned to him and held his chin with one finger.

"I want your full attention on me. Only me," she said, bringing her face closer to Keifer.

Damn it! The bread knife is ready!

he leaned closer to me and whispered, "Jealous?"

I immediately shook my head. "I'm just annoyed by their

"That's part of jealousy," he said, looking at Keifer. "...D  
back at them?"

I don't know, but what he said was tempting. It's true... It  
good to get back at them, and they'd both be crawling in

I slowly nodded. he leaned even closer to me and whisper

"Giggle," he said.

Huh?!

"What? Goggle?" I asked, and he suddenly laughed.

That got the attention of Keifer and Keigan, who were no

"Is that Mr. Billiones?" Yuri's dad suddenly said, looking  
who looked like businessmen because of their attire. "...C  
We'll introduce you."

Yuri's sister and parents stood up. They approached the g  
businessmen. The six of us were left at the table, and I w  
by the way Keifer looked at me.

Yuri and I almost melted

She might remember that I was with Keifer at the Halloween party. I can't remember! I know she saw... There's no answer to that question. It's important...

"Impossible! My beauty is unique. It's hard to find someone like me," she said, laughing a little.

She raised an eyebrow. "Really? Where can you find someone like you in the market?"

I narrowed my eyes at her. The market?! And what does that mean?

"Excuse me?!"

"You're excused," she replied with a sassy smile.

She's challenging me. Wait! I'll just sharpen the bread knife.

Bitch Mode: ON!

"You? Where can someone like you be found?" I asked.

From my peripheral view, I saw Yuri drinking water. Keifer and Elixera and Keigan exchanged looks.

The girl flipped her hair before answering. "It's hard to find someone like me. I'm one of a kind."

I slowly nodded. "Ahh... Not at a party, huh?"

I mimicked her tone. "Ha.Ha.Ha. You're so Fanget."

Her eyebrows furrowed completely. She's about to explc  
She might even pull my hair. The bread knife should be 1

"...I mean, Funny," I corrected.

"You know what?" She crossed her arms, making her ch  
don't like your tone. In fact, I don't like you at all."

I also crossed my arms, though my cleavage was hidden

"It's okay... I don't like you either, and the feeling is mutu  
an annoying smile.

She just shook her head. "This makes no sense."

"You make no sense."

She was starting to turn red with anger. She couldn't stop  
looks.

"Relax... Please... Don't make a scene here," Keigan said

Honey seemed to snap out of it. She took a deep breath a

"I'm going to the restroom," she said, looking at Keifer. '

Join?! Join huh!

I stood up and excused myself to go to the restroom. No even though Yuri really wanted to. he seemed scared with a mean look.

I walked straight to the restroom. As expected, she was finishing retouching her makeup, and seemed to be waiting for me.

I looked at her reflection in the mirror. She did the same.

She stopped and seemed to sense the other women in the left, and some didn't even enter the stalls.

We waited for everyone to leave before she spoke. "I remember," she said, turning to face me. "...You're the girl who was at the Halloween party. You're also the one he kissed that night."

I crossed my arms. "So what?"

She smirked. "You have something going on with the guy earlier, right? And then there's Keifer. You're such a flirt."

"Yes! Just like you."

She looked me up and down. She raised an eyebrow when she saw my shoes. I know, wearing a dress with sneakers is tacky.

"You're not that pretty, but if you flirt... You might run out of guys," she said, making my eyebrows furrow completely.

I didn't want to hurt anyone or get into a physical fight. I pushed me too far. For the first time... I lost a battle of pe

All because of the words I once heard people throw at m

Running out of men.

Honey's hand was shaking as she tried to wash the blood sink.

I left the restroom feeling so upset. I was in the hallway

He looked at me and immediately walked over. He held me against the wall. He was smiling as he slowly leaned with his hands.

"How's your conversation with Honey?" he asked, annoy

It's like the name "Honey" sounds wrong coming from h

"None of your business!" I snapped.

He laughed a little. "Are you jealous?"

ME?! JEALOUS?! WHY?!

"No," I answered calmly.

"You're jealous "

I'm really not!

He raised two fingers. I thought he was making a peace sign, but he had his annoying smile.

"Two profanity words—actually, it's three from yesterday."

I slapped his hand. "You're the profanity! You kissed me and I thought you smoked, I could taste it." I leaned in to smell his hair. "You smell like cigarettes now!"

He smelled himself. "I didn't smoke! It's Honey, the smell of my hair."

I narrowed my eyes at him. "Don't lie! Go kiss your Holy Bible and walked away from him.

"And you say you're not jealous," I heard him say.

I'm really not!

Like an idiot! I have no reason to be jealous. Why would I? Because I love him and he loves me too? Pffft... Not really.

When I got back to our table, Yuri's sister and parents were there. They glanced at me briefly and went back to their conversation. They had agreed on something with the person they introduced as Sister, Angelo.

"Don't worry, I'll take care of you."



Honey couldn't answer properly because she was having  
It seems I hit her pretty hard.

"Sorry, Auntie and Uncle, but we have to go now. I need  
the hospital," Keifer said, kissing their cheeks.

"It's good that you're taking care of her," they replied.

He asked Keigan, and it seemed they were leaving too. I  
to me and walked out of the restaurant.

Before they completely disappeared from my sight, I sav  
cling to Keifer's arm again.

Keifer, you better watch out!

# Chapter 167: Papers

## Jay-jay's POV

"Hey! Pay up! You're trying to run away!" Rory shouted payments.

It was time to settle the fees for the retreat on Monday. To cover our expenses, so we had to pay ourselves.

Only for Section E!

I fumbled for my wallet in my bag. I needed to pay too. It was embarrassing if I was the last one to pay, and it's hard to

"I've paid!" Felix shouted and looked at me. "...Have you

"Not yet—"

"Consider it paid!" Rory cut me off before I could finish.

I stopped searching for my wallet in my bag and gave him

"Hey, I haven't paid yet!"

"Keifer already paid for you earlier." That jerk?

He was clearly annoyed by what I did. Maybe I shouldn't have tried to wake him up, but I was irritated.

He suddenly stood up and grabbed my hand, dragging me to the side of the building.

We stopped at a distance, and he looked at me angrily. "What's the problem? I've treated you before, haven't I?"

"It's different now... It's not the same as before."

He crossed his arms and stared at me for a long time. "Tell me the truth... Because... Ugh! Ever since he told me about how rich he was and how poor I am.

And last night, after they left the restaurant, Yuri's parents talked about Watson Enterprise. On Keifer's birthday, the company would be replaced, and he would be given full access.

At 18, he already owns his own company. How about that?

He's one of the youngest bachelors and millionaires—not even in the Philippines.

Compared to me, I'm about to turn 18, and all I can think of is ice cream.

~~~~~

thinking.

"Why didn't you answer my calls last night?"

I swallowed hard. He had called and texted me several times but I didn't answer because I was so annoyed with him and that Hon

I don't want any drama!

"I-I was... busy."

"Doing what?" he said, stepping closer.

I stepped back because of his proximity.

"Hmmm... Cleaning my room."

It was true! I was cleaning, especially after I saw under r
of junk food wrappers.

"Ms. Mariano... Are you lying to me?" He took another s

"No! It's true..."

"Is that really the reason? Because it seems like there's so
stepped closer again.

I stepped back again. I almost tripped over a stone but m
myself

"As if! Who would I be jealous of? Honey? No way!" I s

He suddenly laughed while stepping closer to me. I tried
was already against the wall.

Oh no!

Can't I just phase through this wall? Like in Harry Potter

Keifer grabbed my chin and forced me to look at him. M
on their own.

"You're too obvious. You know that?" he said slowly, alr

His voice was so enticing. It was almost seductive.

You're being seduced?!

Yes—crap! No, I'm not!

"...you almost got sued by Honey for what you did to her

My eyes widened, and my knees almost gave out. A law
jail!

"A lawsuit?"

"Yes... But we already talked about it. So, no need to wo
smiled

Did I admit it? Not really! This guy is making things up.

"I'm not—" He stopped me from speaking by pressing his lips against my lips.

"Stop explaining," he said and slowly leaned in closer.

I subtly sniffed him without him noticing. No trace of cigarettes. That is good.

I closed my eyes, waiting for the—ahihihhi! Oh my!

Why am I so flirty? Ugh!

And then it happened. What I was waiting for. It started with a playful nibble. Kidding! Our lips met. Honestly, I missed this.

The kiss deepened gradually. My hands were on his chest and shoulders, while one of his hands was on the back of my head, pushing me against the wall.

With every move he made, I responded, until suddenly...

"That's so sweet."

We immediately pulled apart. I faced the wall, pretending to be busy, while Keifer turned to face the person who spoke.

"I thought this was the way to platform 9 3/4!" I looked at

I looked to see who it was, and of course, it was bad luck classmates were watching us.

Led by Ci-N, followed by Kit, Edrix, Rory, and Felix. On at me. Some of Yuri's supporters weren't there, and other indifferent.

"Tss..." I heard Keifer say. He seemed annoyed by what I did. "...Do you need something?"

"Nothing... They just called Jay-jay to the Guidance Office Guidance Office?!"

Did I do something wrong recently? Did I fight with Fre kids? Section D? Did I argue with any of them?

Why was I being called to the Guidance Office? I looked

"Do you want me to take you there?"

"Ayyiiieehhhh...." Ci-N and the others teased, causing I off.

"N-no... I can go on my own."

I walked slowly. No matter how many times I tried to thi get called, I couldn't remember anything.

"S-sorry..." I said to the person I grabbed.

They just nodded and walked away. I looked at who but of course, it was bad luck.

"ARE YOU BLIND?!" Freya shouted angrily at me.

I wasn't in the mood to argue. So annoying!

"If I'm blind, what does that make you? Stupid?" I replied.

She crossed her arms and glared at me. I noticed other students watching us.

Tsk! I don't want to fight.

"If I'm stupid, you're useless!"

I chuckled lightly. "So you admit you're stupid?"

She suddenly paused, thinking about what I said. I could see disappointment on her face. She was speechless.

I didn't wait for her response. I continued walking to the

I stopped right in front of the Guidance Office door.

I hesitated to knock. What if I was called because I did something

"Weirdo," he commented and walked away.

Weirdo? Be thankful you just got out of the hospital. Oh to send you back there.

His classmates were laughing at me. Just you wait, your

I entered the office, and the guidance counselor greeted me by name again?

"Ms. Mariano?" she asked.

"Y-yes... You called for me?"

"Yes... Come here," she said, walking to her office.

When I entered, she pointed to the chair in front of her desk and waited for her. She rummaged through her drawer.

Mrs. Reyaldad.

Okay... Thanks to the nameplate. I remembered her name.

After rummaging through her drawer, she walked back to her desk and sat down.

She handed me a few pieces of paper. "Sign these for the Counselor of Holy Saints High School."

She nodded. "We want to make sure your records from y
in order."

What's wrong with my records? Holy Shit—Saints, I me
grudge against me. They're making my records a proble

"What if I can't get them signed?" I asked.

"You won't graduate," she replied quickly.

Shooooooooooooooooooooottt!!

I won't graduate? Just because of some records. How abo
goodness... I don't want to go back to Holy Saints. This i

I looked at Ma'am. I wanted to plead with her. Ask her to
handle it. I can't go back there.

"It shouldn't be a problem, right? Especially since your r
and it's happening near that school," she said, confusing

Happening? Next week? Oh my gosh! Next week ahead

And it's happening in our province.

Nice...

"...I hope you can get it signed quickly," she smiled at m
your adviser about this so they can let you leave "

I walked back to the room absentmindedly. Can't Sir Alv is so annoying!

Because I was lost in thought, I accidentally bumped into with me. When I looked up to see who it was, I froze.

"Sorry... Are you okay?" Yuri asked me.

"Y-yes... I'm fine. Sorry too."

I continued walking, and he walked with me. He's back i should be good news, but I was more worried about the 1 holding.

When I got back to the room, they suddenly went silent. passed by.

When I looked up, Keifer's eyes met mine. I guess I didn't do anything—his angry gaze was enough to melt me.

Yuri held my shoulder and walked to his seat. I followed put the papers in my bag.

When I sat down, the atmosphere in the room was heavy everyone was doing their own thing, it felt like they were something to happen.

What's going on?

Oh no!

Josh followed and immediately punched him. I panicked them.

I was about to stop them, but I froze at the scene inside t

They were all fighting. Like, everyone!

"What the..." I muttered.

"F*** you!"

"You're an idiot!"

"This is for you!"

"F*** you too!"

"Your breath stinks!"

"Pay your debts!"

"There's no such thing as forever!"

I pulled my hair in frustration. They were so chaotic, and even doing?

Don't go to the restroom again!

"What's this? What's going on?!" I asked anxiously.

The others gradually stopped fighting. He avoided my gaze with no intention of explaining. I let go of him and faced Yuri getting up.

"What's going on? Why are you all fighting?"

I thought he would answer, but like Keifer, he avoided me.

They really had no intention of explaining, so I looked at the floor. They all avoided eye contact. Ci-N, who had just entered the room, didn't speak, but David covered his mouth and held him tightly.

These jerks!

I felt annoyed by their behavior. It was obvious no one was going to talk.

"No one's going to talk?" I asked irritably.

Even with that question, no one answered. Out of frustration, I took my bag and quickly left the room. Let them be! I lost the desire to stay.

So annoying!

Chapter 168: Exam

Jay-jay's POV

WHY?!

Why didn't anyone tell me that the exam was this Saturday? I decided to decide not to talk to me? They didn't even tell me the exam was on Saturday, crying!

Aside from not telling me, I also didn't get to review. Is that fair to me?!

"Kuuyyyaaaa... I haven't reviewed at all. Come on!" I pleaded with my older brother, Angelo, as I followed him.

Since I had no review at all, I planned to fake being sick, but it didn't work!

I kept begging him to call the school and tell them I was sick.

We were in the middle of our argument when—

"...Kuuuuyyyyaaaa..."

He stopped walking and gave me a sharp look. "Cut it out."

"That's why you have to take the exam today," Kuya said walking away.

T_T... I'm really about to cry.

"That's what you get for being lazy," Aries said as he wa

Is it my fault? Those jerks pissed me off. I got lazy and s few days. This is all their fault.

R.I.P. to my grades. I walked to school with a frown. I w bike, but I was too out of it—I might get into an acciden

When I got to school, the first person I saw was Calix. It just dropped Mica off. He smiled at me, but that didn't hi his lips.

He immediately noticed where I was looking and quickly walking straight to the classroom. My feet felt heavy, bu move.

From the corner of my eye, I saw Felix and Rory. They t but Felix winced, probably because of the cut on his lip. cheek, which had a scratch.

I couldn't bring myself to return their smiles. Worry took seeing them come to school with bruises and wounds, bu did that to each other... It made me sad.

I wanted to review, but I knew nothing would stick in my deep sigh. I still had to try.

As I sat down and opened my bag, I was about to grab my chocolate when I froze.

Why are there so many chocolates?

I quickly glanced around. I had to make sure no one saw me grab my chocolate for it.

Did my bag suddenly start producing chocolates? Because I didn't buy or take any—oh! Right...

Aunt Gema must have put them in. I saw her earlier with a bag full of chocolates. She even mentioned that eating them while riding the train was a tradition.

That's why my bag felt so heavy earlier.

I glanced at Ci-N. He was folding paper into an airplane.

Light bulb moment...

I grinned widely as I took a chocolate from my bag.

"Ci-N!" I called out.

He turned to me, still holding his paper airplane.

"No! I already know what you're going to ask! I'm not asking you to shout without looking at me.

Pfft... Annoying!

But I won't give up. I know your weaknesses, guys!

I looked at the others. They quickly averted their gazes, but I told them they wanted some.

Tsk... You think I'll give up? No way!

I unwrapped a chocolate. Slowly, I took a bite, even closing my eyes dramatically, like in a TV commercial.

"Shit... So good," I said just loud enough for them to hear. "Your mouth instantly."

I glanced at them. They pretended not to care, but some of them bit their lips.

"...The sweetness isn't overwhelming," I added. "...It's so good, I'm reviewing."

I looked at Yuri, who was staring at me.

I saw his Adam's apple move up and down. He forced himself to look at his notes.

Still avoiding me...

I glanced at the troublemakers. One of them even wiped was drooling.

Then my phone buzzed. A text message.

From: King of Trouble

Message:

"Stop it! It's not funny!"

Looks like he's getting pissed. I looked up, and our eyes glaring at me like he was about to attack.

Okay... Sorry.

I was about to reply when Ci-N suddenly lunged in front desperate.

"I'll talk! Just give me some!" he begged.

I gave him a wide grin. I finished the chocolate in my hand and showed him its contents—making sure the others saw

"See this?" I asked.

He nodded, practically drooling

"It's just chocolate! We can buy some!"

But Ci-N seemed deaf to their protests. His eyes were locked on the chocolates. I almost clapped in excitement.

"Tell me, Ci... Why were you all fighting last time?" I asked.

He glanced at Keifer and Yuri before motioning for me to follow. When I did, he whispered.

"Keifer and Yuri fought. Of course, we all took sides, so it was a brawl."

IT'S HAPPENING!

This is it. Section E is splitting apart. This shouldn't be happening. It filled me as I looked around. The others quickly avoided my gaze.

"W-what were they fighting about?"

Ci-N bit his lip and looked at Keifer before shaking his head.

I opened my bag wider and leaned it toward him. His eyes widened, longing.

"B-because... It's—"

"Shut your mouth, Ci-N!" Keifer suddenly cut him off.

"You're just making things harder for Ci-N!" Denzel add

"Mind your own business!" Kit shouted.

I just watched them. I didn't understand. Was it that hard fought?

This is a disaster.

I signaled Ci-N to go ahead and take the chocolates from hesitated at first, but when I smiled at him, he finally too

After grabbing the chocolates, he went back to his seat. I who was glaring at Mayo. Why doesn't he want the other

Sir Alvin arrived, carrying our test questionnaires. He did first—he must have sensed the tension in the room.

"Go back to your seats! Sir is here."

David said, causing everyone to sit properly.

During the exam, my focus wasn't on answering the test on their fight. Why wouldn't they tell me anything? What from me?

One by one, the Ulupong members submitted their papers. Staying, they grabbed their bags and started leaving the room.

"Don't forget the documents you need to get signed on Monday."

I just nodded and forced a smile. Ugh! I almost forgot about my headache to deal with.

When I stepped out of the room, they were gone. Looks like they were home to avoid my questions. I had no choice but to go home.

I tried texting Yuri and Keifer about it, but they didn't reply. I also messaged the others, but I got nothing from them either.

When I got home, Aries and Ella were the first people I saw. I was in a bad mood to talk to them, so I went straight to my room.

I changed into comfortable clothes and lay down on my bed. I started checking my inbox, hoping someone would reply.

This is so annoying!

I heard a knock on my door, and it slowly opened.

I was facing away, so I didn't see who it was. I immediately turned around, either Kuya Angelo or Tita Gema.

"My exam went fine. I just want to rest for now."

I said without looking back.

"Your room is very simple."

She looked around my room first. Good thing I cleaned it so my gaze finally landed on me.

"I wanted to talk to you."

She said directly.

"...Can I look around?"

I just nodded, allowing her to do so. There wasn't anything in my room. No decorations or anything visually appealing to look at.

"So, you and Keifer are together now."

She said while looking at my study table.

I didn't answer, but I didn't take my eyes off her either.

What do you want?

"...What about Yuri?"

I let out a small laugh. I knew it. This was about Yuri and the guys who were part of her past in Section E.

"What about Yuri?"

I asked in a bored tone.

"...He's still hoping."

She put it down and continued walking around in front of

"...And he wouldn't be hoping if he wasn't being given hope."

Nice...

This girl is pissing me off! What is she trying to say?

"Oh?"

"Stop leading Yuri on. You're just hurting him."

She ordered.

I stood up from my bed and glared at her.

"Look who's talking. Have you forgotten that you hurt him?"

Ella met my glare. Just by her expression, I knew she was

"You don't know what really happened. So you have no right to talk like that!"

"You're doing the same to me. So don't talk down to me either."

I walked to the door and opened it—not for myself, but for

"Ella!"

Aries called out.

Ella walked away, and I shut my door before sitting down on my bed.

What did she mean by that? And why is she even interfering? She should be focusing on Aries—he's the one who needs her now.

Because of what she said, my thoughts became even more chaotic. I realized how much time had passed until it was already late and getting dark outside.

I stepped out of my room to get some water. On my way down the hallway, I ran into Kuya, who was dressed up nicely.

"Why aren't you dressed yet?"

He asked me.

I looked at him in confusion.

"F-for what?"

"We have a dinner date with the Peraltas."

Wait... That's today?

We were dining at a Chinese restaurant.

Wow, fancy—Ci-N and his family really know how to p

"How was your exam, Jay?"

Kuya asked me while driving.

I looked out the window. How do I even tell him I barely anything?

"I-it was okay..."

I replied.

Neither Kuya nor Tita asked anything further. It seemed my answer without question.

When we arrived, Kuya parked the car. The first person at the entrance was Ci-N, smiling widely at me.

"Good evening, Mr. Fernandez."

Ci-N's older brother greeted Kuya Angelo.

They shook hands briefly. He did the same with Tita. When he turned to me, he just gave me a sharp look.

~~I swear. I'll poke your eyes out!~~

"Hey... You owe me answers." I whispered to him.

His face suddenly turned serious. He stopped walking ar

"Jay... I don't want to talk about it. It's not my place to sa
hand. "...But please, forgive me."

Forgive him?

"What are you talking about?"

"We did something terrible to you. Something really bad

He didn't say anything more.

Even though I wanted to ask, I couldn't bring myself to c

Another thing to stress over...

Chapter 169: Holy Shit

Jay-jay's POV

Our province is simple. Some parts have houses, while others are just open fields. Unlike in the city, where vehicles are packed closely together, biking is more common here.

When I was old enough to remember, there were only a few houses. The house with Mama wasn't fully built. It had one room for sleeping and one for cooking.

There was a big tree nearby, and I often climbed it with my friends.

Then came the incident I couldn't remember. After being sent to the hospital, I moved in with Grandma. It was a bigger house, but Spanish-style, but sturdy.

I was enrolled in a public school, but my student life was not good. I got into fights, so they transferred me to a private school. I thought things would get better at Holy Spirit.

I became famous, but not because of my looks. It was because I got into fights. I had no friends. My classmates were either afraid of me or pretended to be nice because they could benefit from me.

I was in the Guidance office almost every day. They call me a troublemaker.

He was insane!

He replaced me as the school's top troublemaker, acting best. Then something I never expected happened. I unintentionally hurt him. Grandma had a heart attack and almost died.

That became the reason my aunt took me in. I left all the friends I had in this province.

I never thought I'd return so soon. So soon? I was hoping years before coming back.

"We're almost at the camping site..." Sir Alvin announced over the microphone.

Some students who were sleeping woke up and stretched and tried to go back to sleep.

Thankfully, we had our own bus this time. We thought we'd have to sit in with other sections again.

I hate that!

I glanced at the seat across from me. Keifer was staring at me and away. I was still mad at them.

But that wasn't the real reason I avoided eye contact. Since then, I had felt uneasy all the way to the province. I didn't want

The bus stopped, and we all got off with our things. This trip, according to the organizers.

I had been to this place before when it wasn't developed. out and drink here, but the landowner kicked us out, saying many snakes.

Could there still be snakes here?

As expected, my batchmates started acting fussy.

Who in their right mind goes on a retreat wearing heels?

Freya!

That girl is so clueless. Her heels were so high—did she go to the mall? So dramatic!

"This way, everyone!" the organizer called out using a megaphone.

We lined up by section, and from where I stood, I saw A. I knew he understood that I wasn't happy to be back in the city.

The organizer gave a speech, but I wasn't paying attention elsewhere.

"...You'll see your section's flag, and that's where your cabin is," he continued before signaling us to move.

Our disappointment was immeasurable when we arrived
Trash everywhere! It looked like aliens had camped here

Not far away, I spotted tall grass. Damn it... What if there
there?

"Is this really our spot?" Felix asked while kicking a bur
ground. "...Does the organizer have a grudge against us?

I wanted to ask the same thing. It felt like we weren't eve
retreat.

That's why Rory complained, saying we weren't include

"The place seems too small for us," Eman pointed out as

I scanned the area. He was right! It was too cramped for
up individual tents.

The organizer really had it out for us!

"We're already here... There's nothing we can do," Denze
to clean a spot. "...Let's just set up our things."

The others followed his lead, putting down their bags an
tents. I was about to set mine up beside Ci-N's tent when
grabbed my bag.

"..."

Once we finished setting up the tents, I realized mine was
So that's why he put me here!

I went inside my tent and arranged my things—pillow, blanket, and of course... Snorlax.

I couldn't leave him behind, even though squeezing him was a struggle. While organizing, I noticed the envelope

Tsk! The documents I needed to get signed!

I made sure my things were in order before stepping out the envelope, I faced Keifer.

"I—I need to go," I told him.

"Where are you going?" Yuri asked.

"T—to my old school... I need to get this signed," I answered.

"I'll go with you," Ci offered, but I shook my head.

"It's fine... I'll go alone. I won't take long."

I didn't wait for their responses and walked away.

I saw Sir Alvin talking to the organizer, so I approached for permission. Since he already knew about it, he let me go.

It felt like I was heading toward my death.

Sounds dramatic, but that's exactly how I felt.

When the tricycle stopped in front of the school gate—I had been in this exact situation before.

I approached the guardhouse and stated my purpose. The new and didn't recognize me. I wasn't sure if that was a g

He signaled me to enter. Since it was class time, the hall but I couldn't avoid the janitor.

"Jay-jay?" he asked, squinting at me with his weak eyesi really you?"

Nope! Just a hologram!

I walked closer and forced a smile. I felt guilty—let's jus the people who used to disrespect him. But he never got

"How have you been, Manong?"

"It is you!" he said, surprised, placing the rag on his shou around. "...Why are you here? Are you enrolling again?"

"N-no... I just need to get something signed at the Guida

He smiled at me—the same smile he always gave me, an

I scratched my head. Damn it! I expected the school to be left, but it got worse.

"...Alright, I should get back to work. Take care! It's good to see you."

Before he could grab his broom, I held his arm. He looked at me in confusion, but I was serious.

"Manong... I—I just wanted to say... I'm sorry for everything."

I felt a heavy weight as I said those words—not because of the words themselves but because "sorry" wasn't enough.

He smiled again. "It's all good, dear."

That was all he said, yet the weight in my chest disappeared.

I smiled, not out of force, but from the heart.

My confrontation with Manong was one of the reasons I had the courage to walk straight to the Guidance Office.

But if bad luck really exists... The school bell rang, and all the students who used to be my classmates and schoolmates came out.

Shutanginames!

Shock. Confusion. Anger. These were some of the reactions I saw.

"Why is she here?"

They started murmuring among themselves. I quickened the Guidance Office. It was located in the second largest school.

But before I could get there, I had to pass in front of the half of the school's population usually gathered.

Kingina naman!

I should have put on my headset. Annoying! Now I'm gc comments again.

As I walked, I saw many familiar faces—people I either bullied by, or were classmates with Cyrus and me.

Speaking of Cyrus, I heard he was back at school. I was Kuya Angelo was the one who told me. That made me e

"Look who's here!"

a familiar voice shouted.

I stopped walking and slightly turned to face them. It was many people I had a fight with here.

"You have some nerve coming back here! After what you
~ ~ ~

Father

, not the flirtatious kind of

Papa

.

To be honest, I had already forgotten their name.

"...Your face is still so annoying! Do you know that?!"

I looked at them with irritation but tried not to show it. Just as they blocked my way, I answered the same thing:

"And what does that have to do with me?!"

Loud laughter erupted from the other students. It wasn't that I felt like they laughed because, after all this time, I still argued my way, and this person still couldn't get back at me.

I continued walking. Finally, I reached the Guidance Office on the second floor, so I hurried up the stairs. I just wanted to get here as soon as possible.

When I reached the office door, I hesitated before knocking. The brown envelope I was holding tightly.

You can do this, I said.

she asked.

"Y-yes."

My heart skipped a beat. She remembered me! Well, I was in the Office every day, so it was impossible for her to forget me.

"Do you need something?"

"Hmmm... I just need this signed."

I said as I handed her the brown envelope.

She chuckled, which confused me. Was there something I had said?

She took the envelope and checked it.

"You're so polite now... Back then, you used to yell at me when I was the same age."

she said with an annoyingly amused smile.

Oh, crap!

She remembered that too. How embarrassing! I scratched my head and forced a smile, but it probably looked more like a grimace.

After reading the paper, she handed it back to me.

That made me smile. I knew every corner of the Guidance entered Ma'am's office, but my smile quickly disappeared person inside.

"What the..."

I whispered.

He was looking at me.

"Nice to see you here."

He slowly smiled.

"...Jay-jay."

"C-Cyrus."

Chapter 170: Cyrus Velasc

Jay-jay's POV

*

Flashback...

*

"You have a new classmate!" announced Ma'am.

Go find my care!

She signaled towards the door, and a guy walked in.

He was tall with slanted eyes. Because he was good-looking—who seemed thirsty for the sight of a handsome guy—excitement.

"Hello... I'm Cyrus Velasco. 16 years old. Nice to meet y new classmate," he said and smiled.

Tss. Of course!

Our eyes suddenly met. I quickly looked away, uninteres

Suddenly, my classmates at the front started screaming. I was looking for a seat. I rested my chin on my hand and window.

The dust stuck to the glass window was much more interesting. From the corner of my eye, I noticed my classmates staring.

What's their problem?

Annoyed, I looked at the idiots. That's when I realized they were all looking directly at me. My gaze landed on the guy standing in front of me.

"Can I?" he asked casually, pointing at the seat beside me.

"It's taken," I replied, bored.

"But no one's sitting there," a classmate chimed in, so I sat down.

"Shut up!" I snapped, earning a sharp glare in return.

"By who?" he asked casually.

"By my bag," I said quickly, placing my bag on the seat.

He laughed loudly, and irritation instantly flared up inside me. There were so many empty seats, yet he chose this one. He was teasing me.

"Don't laugh! I'm serious... It's studying, see?" I pointed to my bag, which was slightly open, revealing some trash inside.

"Son of a b*tch!" I spat angrily.

"Ms. Mariano!" Ma'am shouted at me.

Oh, she's here?!

"Yes?"

"To the Guidance Office, now!"

My classmates laughed.

You're all dead later!

So annoying!

End of Flashback...

It has been nearly two years since he walked into our class and introduced himself.

He looked kind, and because he was handsome, many admired him. But it was all just a facade.

Because Cyrus is insane—full of arrogance and hungry for power.

"I knew you'd come back," he said, stepping closer to me.

I stepped back. I never expected we would face each other again.

"Argh!" I cried out as he shoved me against the wall.

"Good thing you came back... Because I really missed you
emphasizing the word

missed.

I knew what he meant, but I couldn't focus on it due to n

"L-let... me... ugh! Go..."

He tightened his grip even more. My vision started to bli

"It hurts, doesn't it?" he mocked. "...That's exactly how I
piece of sh*t!"

"C-Cy..." I gasped, barely able to produce any sound.

Damn it!

Even my hands had no strength left to fight back.

Am I really going to die here?

Somebody, help me!

Suddenly, Cyrus laughed and slowly let go of me. I colla
coughing violently as I struggled to catch my breath.

My body trembled as I crawled toward a chair. I reached my phone.

My hands were shaking. I wanted to call Keifer or Yuri.

But... for what?

I'm not a child who needs to tattle. They were already worried, there was no need to add to their stress.

I forced myself to sit down on one of the chairs. I wiped myself.

I had forgotten about the envelope! I quickly searched for it on the floor. I picked it up and placed it on Ma'am's desk.

I fixed my hair and covered my neck. Even though I could see there would be a mark. Good thing the Guidance Counselor would not return.

"Sorry I took so long," she said as she sat in her chair. "...waiting?"

I shook my head, but she suddenly stared at me.

"Are you okay?" she asked.

"Y-yes..."

"That boy has been nothing but trouble since he got out of the hospital. He's practically replaced you here at school," she joked.

But I wasn't laughing.

"...If you don't mind me asking, what exactly happened to him? We've heard so many different stories—it's confusing."

I avoided her gaze. It happened so long ago—why did she even ask?

"W-well... It's just that..."

Flashback...

"This one's stubborn! Should I just beat him up, Boss?" one of my friends shouted.

I looked at what they were doing. They were bullying a freshman. The kid was small and dark-skinned.

I felt anger bubbling inside me. How many times had they felt any shame bullying freshmen?

I walked up to them. "Cy!" I called out.

Cyrus looked at me and smiled. But I was no longer amused. I was no longer amused by anything they did.

"HE'S BACK!"

"M-me?" he asked, trembling and pointing at himself.

I nodded. "Go back to your classroom."

"Wait! We're not done with him yet!" one of Cyrus's friends

"Jay, come on!"

The freshman managed to escape, and they could do nothing but give him a sharp glare. Cyrus's friends no longer respected him.

"Your girlfriend is such a killjoy, Cy!" one of them complained.

Cyrus walked toward me, grabbed my arm, and whispered.

I followed him. I already knew what he was going to say. He wanted to be embarrassed in front of his friends.

"I hate what you did," he said, facing me.

"And what about what you did? Do you think I liked it?" he asked, flexing his arms.

"We weren't doing anything wrong. We were just messing around."

I raised an eyebrow. How many times had they

messed around

He ran a hand through his hair. "...You're the one ruining
ours!

"

Me?! Wow!

"...You know what? So you don't get dragged into anything,
just break up."

His eyebrows furrowed.

"You can't break up with me!" he snapped.

He spoke loudly, which immediately caught the attention of
friends. A few students were also watching us.

"I can break up with you."

I turned to walk away, but he suddenly grabbed my arm.
glared at him, and he returned the look.

"We're not done talking."

"Cyrus! I don't want this anymore!" I shouted at him.

Suddenly, he grabbed my jaw, squeezing it tightly, making
from the pain

I pushed his hand away with all my strength. Before he could react, I threw a punch at him. He fell to the ground, and his friend rushed to him.

They tried to help him up, but he shoved them away. I saw blood from his lips.

Tsk! I guess I hit too hard.

He wiped the blood with his hand and stared at it. Then, I could tell he was angry.

I took a step back, but it was too late. His palm met my face, and I fell to the ground. His slap was much heavier than my punch.

"Bro!" one of his friends yelled. "...What the hell?! She's bleeding!"

My face went numb from the impact. I glared at him as I got up.

I tasted something different in my mouth. I knew it wasn't just blood. I felt a stinging pain on my lips. I touched them, and—just as I

B-blood!

Shit! He split my lip with that slap! Bastard!

I was about to glare at him again, but something was off. I couldn't leave my blood-covered hand. My body started to tremble.

WHERE IS THAT VOICE COMING FROM?! WHO IS

"What's wrong? Scared of blood?" Cyrus mocked, but I

Why does it look so... beautiful? Why does the color of blood
captivating?

Before I even realized it, my hand was moving closer to

T-the taste of blood...

End of Flashback...

"We had a fight... M-my vision went dark," I answered M

It literally went dark.

"Tsk! Tsk! You young people are all the same. Whether you're a
girl, you fight like there's no tomorrow," she said while s

She put the papers down and was about to sign them when she
stopped and looked at me.

"By the way, where is Mr. Fernandez?"

Kuya?

"H-he's at work. Why?"

"Y-you want me to ask Kuya to donate money?" I asked

"Something like that."

Son of a fishball!

I knew it! I never should've come back here!

I once overheard Ma'am talking to Kuya, but since I didn't hear their conversation.

But now it's clear to me—Kuya was bribing this school!

"Why would I do that?" I asked, now irritated.

"Because, Ms. Mariano... It wouldn't look good if I put in a request if you've had multiple suspensions and were expelled." She

Huh?! But I've never—

"...Mr. Fernandez is the reason you've never been suspended for your troublemaking," she continued, leaning in slightly. "The reason why we wrote 'transfer for personal reasons' in your file instead of 'expulsion.'"

I looked down at the papers in front of me. They were lying flat.
Damn it!

No wonder my records are such a mess. They kept changing them.

"We'll be waiting," she said, still smiling.

"Alright. Thank you," I replied, then hurriedly left her of
Damn it!

I was already on the stairs when I stopped. I took a deep
myself down. My frustration was overwhelming.

Wasn't this embarrassing for them? If I got called to the
hundred times, that means Kuya bribed them a hundred t

Very nice!

This school is seriously infuriating. If it weren't for—shi
I stopped in my tracks.

Cyrus was waiting for me at the bottom of the stairs, smi
the look on his face, he was about to do something bad.

I tried to turn back and go upstairs again, but his group w
blocking my way.

"Can we have a little chat?"

Chapter 171: Nice meeting

Jay-jay's POV

"Shit!" one of them shouted after I punched him.

I forced myself to fight—wrong! I

was trying

to fight even though, in truth, my body wasn't in the con

There were only five of them, but I had been struggling t
a while now. I didn't know why, but it felt like I wasn't th
who could fight anytime, anywhere.

It was weakening to face Cyrus now. He was just looking
like every gaze of his was sucking the strength out of me

What do they want?

"You haven't changed... Still punch hard," one of them s
the blood from his lip.

Students were already watching us. Worse, even the teac
standing there. watching.

He crossed his arms and chuckled slightly. "It's simple, J experience the suffering that I went through."

I was about to open my mouth to speak when something the back of my thigh.

"Ugh!" I screamed and collapsed to the ground.

I clutched my thigh in pain, tears welling up in my eyes. friends holding a wide wooden plank.

Shit! This is worse than hazing!

"Does it hurt?" Cy asked, smiling. "...That's not enough."

Another blow landed on my arm. I gasped at the pain. I c tears from falling anymore.

"Jay is so pitiful!"

"She deserves it!"

"Cyrus is such an asshole!"

"Someone help Jay!"

There were all sorts of reactions. But no one would help

Who would dare help someone like me?

"Hey, she can still stand!" one of them laughed.

"Stop this, Jay-jay," an older man called out from a distance.

Shit! Manong, don't interfere!

"You want us to hit you too?!" one of them threatened.

The old man didn't flinch. He looked at me with pity. I saw him, silently telling him to stay out of it.

I turned back to Cyrus, and he was smiling at me.

Another strike landed on my other thigh. I fell to my knees.

The students were now screaming.

Damn it!

Why can't I fight back? Why does it feel like I'm cowering?

Why now?!

I tried to get up when I saw someone approach me. He stood in front of me while I was still crouched down. Suddenly, his hand, which was pressed against the grass.

I bit my lip to stop myself from screaming in pain.

"C-Cy..." I muttered, looking up at him and his laughing
Was what I did to him really so horrible that he had to h
He was hospitalized, sure!

Wrong question! The real question was—was there really
what I did?

But then again, Cyrus didn't know how to forgive.

So, no matter how many times I apologized, it would be

"Argh!" I screamed as I received two more kicks to the s
I couldn't take it anymore. My body trembled with pain.

Please... Someone help me.

"Cry as long as you want. No one will help you," he said
grin.

Please...

"Should we finish her off?" one of them asked.

"Not yet... I'm still having fun," Cy replied, then suddenl

It wasn't that strong, but I still gasped in pain.

A strong slap landed on my face.

My body was already so numb from the beating that I ba

"She's really tough!" one of them holding me said.

What was their definition of "tough"?

I was practically a lifeless rag doll. Was that what they n

I saw Cyrus clenching his fist, preparing to punch me.

I shut my eyes, bracing for impact.

But seconds passed, and nothing hit me.

Had my body gone completely numb?

I opened my eyes and saw the real reason why I didn't fe
because it never landed.

Someone had stopped him!

I squinted to see if I was hallucinating.

How...

Someone was gripping Cyrus' fist—Keifer.

gang surrounding us.

The ones holding me suddenly let go.

Since my knees were weak and I couldn't stand properly when David caught me.

"Are you okay?" he asked.

I simply nodded at him. Then, I looked back at Cyrus.

"Let me go!" Cyrus shouted, but Yuri and Keifer didn't b

"Cyrus Velasco?" Yuri asked.

"What do you want?!" he snapped.

Yuri smiled.

He smiled?

But why?

There was nothing unusual about his smile.

It was the same natural smile he always gave to others...

"We've finally met," Yuri said.

He only acted like this when he was excited about somet

"Ci... H-how did you—how did you guys get here?"

"We asked Sir. Then we asked the

Camp is Rock

staff for directions."

I nodded to show that I understood.

"Let me go! What the f*** do you want from me?! And you?!" Cyrus yelled angrily, still struggling.

"I'm Yuri Hanamitchi," Yuri said with a smile.

"Mark Keifer Watson," Keifer said seriously.

"...And we're here to make you pay for what you did to J

Then, Keifer suddenly punched Cyrus in the stomach.

The impact was so strong that Cyrus' eyes nearly popped

Before he could even collapse, Yuri grabbed him and for

"Nice to f***ing meet you," Yuri said and punched him :
well.

"That guy with red hair is really good-looking!"

"The small one is so cute!"

"Who's the one holding Jay?"

"Aaaayyy... I wish I were Jay!"

"You want to get beaten up by Cyrus too?"

"Idiot! I just want to be surrounded by handsome guys!"

That's when I remembered that we actually had an audience around for the four who were with Cyrus earlier. Felix, F Denzel were now holding them down. They were all here

Wait a minute!

If they're all here, then who's watching over our campsite the organizer looks for us? This is bad!

"W-we need to go b-back." I told David. I looked at the g gone. It looked like I had left it somewhere.

"...M-my stuff!" Ci-N and David looked around. But they because I remembered that when I arrived at the field, I anything anymore.

"We'll have someone look for it." David said

Nice... Passing the blame.

"What was that for?!" Eren asked, annoyed.

No time to explain. They can get mad at me if they want wasn't actually the one who asked Ci-N to do that.

"M-my stuff... P-please f-find it," I ordered.

"That's all?" Calix said.

"...Let's go!" The two of them immediately left. How wo when they didn't even ask me where I last had it? Oh we

"F*CKING ASSHOLE!" Keifer suddenly yelled.

We all turned to look at him. He was holding Cyrus by tl

Yuri was sitting on the grass, wiping his lip."W-what hap

I asked worriedly. "The bastard fought back! Yuri was th he ended up taking the hit!" Drew explained.

"Beat him up!" Ci-N shouted excitedly.

"Ci-N!" I scolded him.

"Who the hell is Jay-Jay to you?! What business do you with what I do to her?!" Cyrus asked angrily as he strugg

"She belongs to Section E," Yuri said as he stood up.

"And she is mine," Keifer added.

I smacked my forehead. Why did he have to say that?! H

"Jay's boyfriend!"

Someone from the crowd suddenly exclaimed.

He's not my boyfriend! What the hell?!

"You're the one Jay-Jay replaced me with?!" Cyrus asked

It was clear that the 'King' was insulted by that. I wanted stop talking. If Keifer gets even more pissed, this won't e

"...You let yourself be fooled by that girl too?!" Cyrus ad Keifer's brows furrow even more.

Before I could react, Keifer punched Cyrus so hard that l short distance away. Blood immediately started dripping and lips.

I thought that was it, but Keifer quickly approached him him.

Shit! He just got out of the hospital!

It really looked like no one was planning to stop him. They were getting scared and starting to back away.

"Keifer!" I called him. "...Keifer! Please! Stop!"

Even though it was clear that he didn't want to, Keifer stopped to face me. He was breathing heavily as he slowly walked toward me.

"Why?"

"He just got out of the hospital. Something bad might have happened," he answered.

"Then let's send him back to the hospital he came from. The doctors did a poor job treating him," Ci-N said, making some of the others laugh.

But I wasn't amused. I was grateful that they came to help him, but Cyrus like that... I wasn't sure if I should be thankful or not.

"What should we do with these guys?" Felix asked, still holding his friends tightly.

"Do whatever you want," Keifer replied indifferently.

Ci-N suddenly clapped his hands excitedly. "I get to punish them!" he said happily.

Now I get it. That's why he seemed so hyper—because he was excited to punish them.

"Jay..." Keifer called my name. "...I forgot something," he suddenly kissing me on the lips.

I could hear people squealing in excitement.

I stared at him in shock.

"W-what was that for?"

"You owe me a kiss. You cursed last time while eating cl with a smile.

He still remembers that?! Wow. There's no escaping this

I saw Calix and Eren walking towards us, carrying my st

"Keifer... Let's get out of here," I whispered to him.

He nodded. "Let's go!"

Ci-N looked disappointed as he walked with us, clearly t was over.

We were leaving this school.

If possible, I never wanted to come back here. I didn't wa everything that had happened.

I glanced at Cyrus, who was now being surrounded by h

Chapter 172: Admit

Jay-jay's POV

I remained silent. Keifer and the others could sense that I was still there, yet. They tried to take me to the hospital, but I refused. I went to the organizer, and I didn't want to cause any trouble. I was afraid of what the school would do about what happened. I was afraid that Cyrus's family might suddenly come after me. I hope not.

When we arrived at Camp Keneme—annoying name, by the way—we went straight to the hall. It was already past lunch, and none of the others were there. We were the only ones left there since the others had already left their camping sites.

"No more viand?" Felix asked, peeking into each pot. The food to be prepared for everyone, lined up on a long table, was supposed to line up and eat, but it looked like most of it was gone.

"There's only soup left. But there's still some of this," a student pointed to a few other pots.

I just sat there, watching them scramble. David was sitting there eating.

"No more viand?" Felix asked, peeking into each pot. The food to be prepared for everyone, lined up on a long table, was supposed to line up and eat, but it looked like most of it was gone.

I looked at what he brought—soup, a little rice, some pie
banana. I looked like a hospital patient with this meal.

"I-I'm not hungry."

"If you don't eat, I'll take you to the hospital."

But I really didn't have an appetite. On top of that, I felt
beating I took.

I sighed and pulled the tray closer. I forced myself to eat
swallow felt like a stab to my stomach.

Ouch!

As I ate, I couldn't help but feel uncomfortable. The King
stop staring at me.

What's his problem?!

Yuri arrived and sat across from me. He also had a tray,
down on the table.

I glanced at David. He was also looking at the two of the
looked at me for a moment, forced a smile, and then sud
taking his tray with him.

Wait! Don't leave me here!

"Why? What for?" I asked, irritation creeping into my voice.

I couldn't help it. This idiot was really getting on my nerves. Yuri's stare, which seemed to agree with everything the I

"Look what happened to you! What if we hadn't come?! I would have been in the hospital by now," he said angrily.

"I didn't know that would happen. No one at Holy Shi—no one hurt me," I explained, though it didn't seem to convince him.

"No one?! And what do you call what that Cyrus guy did to you? BEAT you up?! HURT you?!"

"I didn't know he would do that to me!"

Damn it!

I didn't understand why I felt like crying just trying to explain to them. They were just like Kuya Angelo—so hard to reason with.

"I thought Cyrus was in the hospital?" Yuri asked, shifting his weight.

"He was released a few weeks ago and is back in school,"

"So you knew?!" Keifer asked angrily, his brows furrowed over me.

"Maybe you two planned to meet up?" Yuri interjected.

Keifer clenched his fists, his eyes closed. I could tell he couldn't control his anger.

"W-what? How would that happen? We don't even get along. We haven't been in contact!" I snapped at Yuri.

"Then why did you still go? Maybe you really wanted to see the Cyrus guy?!" Keifer said angrily.

What the heck?!

My head was starting to hurt because of these two. I couldn't think anymore!

"Why would I want to see—Wait a minute!" I narrowed my eyes back and forth between them. "...Are you two jealous?"

Yuri looked away. The King glared at me.

"Yes!"

"No!"

They answered at the same time. I was a bit confused about who said "Yes."

"You two are so confusing! What are you really mad about?"

"Tss," he said.

Thanks for the clear answer.

I narrowed my eyes even more. I looked like a Chinese p
I was glaring at him. Daomingzu! Sanchai!—oh wait, th

We had a long staring match. The worst part was that he
stubborn. I was going to be Chinese for a while.

Nihaoma!

"Fine!" he said angrily. "...I'm f***ing mad because of j
would be happy to find out that the girl he likes is meetin
ex?!"

I heard some laughter. I looked over at the table nearby.
there, and it seemed like they were watching us.

You're so good at this!

Keifer glared at the idiots. "Tell me! You'd feel the same

Some of them scratched their heads, avoiding his gaze.

"I would feel the same. I agree with Keifer," David said.

"I'd probably kill Grace's ex," Denzel said.

I winced at his words. He was really getting into my head, so misplaced.

"You're crazy! Why would you be jealous of Cyrus?!" I said.

"Tss."

"You're both insane!" I shouted at him and Yuri.

"Why me?" Yuri asked.

"Stop acting like you're not jealous!" Keifer shouted at him, "pretending! You're the one who told me we should cripple you to get close to Jay-jay!"

Yuri scratched his head and smiled awkwardly at me, but with a grimace. I knew it! These two.

Oh no! Oh no! Oh no!

"There's nothing to be jealous about. Both of you, stop it!"

"Tss... I should've just finished off that Cyrus guy," the K said, "which was loud enough for everyone to hear."

"Tsk! Stop it already!"

"If I find out you meet up with that guy again, I'll lock you up and burn Cyrus alive!" he threatened me, and the idiot said

"Keifer! Keifer!" someone shouted.

We all froze and looked at who was shouting. It was Edr

"What?!" the King snapped.

"O-our stuff..." He took a deep breath. "...it's missing!"

"What?!" we all shouted almost in unison.

"The cooler, the box of canned goods, and the rice are al
explained.

What? Were we robbed? Damn it! What are we going to
school only provides breakfast and lunch. But for us in S
provide lunch—and it's leftovers at that.

That's why we pooled our money earlier to buy food, and
Great!

Some of them immediately ran off, heading back to our c
stand up, but luckily, Ci-N quickly came over to help me

The others reached our campsite quickly. We were the la
of how slow I was.

Our stuff was a mess. Some of the tents were torn, and o
Some of our things were missing—the cooler with our fo

"My Snorlax!" I shouted.

"F***ing hell! We were robbed! Worst of all, they destroyed the tents!" Keifer said angrily.

"But who would do this?!" Kit asked, worried.

"We should tell the organizer!" David suggested.

"That's a good idea," Yuri agreed.

The others were about to go find the organizer when Josh appeared, holding a flowery handkerchief.

"Is this yours?" he asked.

They all looked at me. I was the only girl here who might have a flowery handkerchief.

But I'm not into flowery things.

"No..." I answered.

Josh examined the handkerchief more closely, unfolding it.

"John... Rose," he read out loud, reading what was written on the handkerchief. "...Who's this?"

"Is that a guy?" Felix asked.

"Where's Section B's campsite?" Mayo asked.

"It's on the other side. We're the only ones separated from the other sections," Drew answered.

Damn it!

"What's this?! Did Section B rob us?!" I asked angrily.

"Looks like it," Eren said.

This is so annoying! Why did they have to do this?! To rob us of our stuff they took my Snorlax. That was a gift to me!

A gift from Percy.

"We need to get our stuff back!" Felix shouted.

I agreed with him. I needed to get Snorlax back... and our stuff.

Chapter 173: Operation: E

Jay-jay's POV

The fire from our bonfire was strong. Thankfully, I wasn't else I might have started shouting random things again. I shook my head, trying to erase that memory from my mind. I looked so stupid back then, and there's even a video of it that I can watch again. So embarrassing!

"Still nothing?" David asked.

We looked at the lookouts, but they just shook their heads. There was still no sign of them.

We strongly suspected that we had been robbed. We needed a plan, and the plan we came up with was to send spies to the other sections. We were focusing on Section B first since one of them owned the warehouse we found. But Keifer suggested sending spies to the other sections too.

Fancy spies!

"They're here! They're here!" Mayo shouted.

We immediately waited. Rory and Edrix arrived first from Section A, followed by Kit and Evan from Section B. Lastly, E

"Is everyone here?" David asked.

"We're here!"

"All present! No one's missing!"

"We're good!"

Everyone gathered around the bonfire. It felt like we were at a meeting. Well, it *was* important because it was about c

"Rory and Edrix! Did you see anything?" Keifer asked.

"Yes!" Rory answered. "...they have our cooler!"

"Shit!"

"Why do they have it?!"

"What are we going to do now?!"

Yuri silenced everyone by raising his hand. They obeyed and continued speaking.

"...The worst part is, they filled the cooler with alcohol. 'I'm the organizer now.'" He took a deep breath. "...They might

Most of us agreed. We couldn't just say it belonged to Seamus. We definitely turn it around on us

Or were we?

"Our canned goods and noodles are with Section D. All brought," Blaster added.

"Section C is clean!" Ci-N said, raising his hand. "...Rakki wouldn't do that to us."

Sigh... thank goodness.

That's what I thought too. Rakki would never do something like that. It seemed like our food was only in three sections.

But what about my Snorlax?

"It's confirmed, they have it," Yuri said, pacing around as if he was thinking. "...But how do we get it back from them?"

Great question! But no answer!

"We can't report it to the organizer," Rory reminded us.

"What if we confront them?" I suggested.

"They might report us to the organizer instead and turn it in," Edrix said.

He had a point!

Ci-N scratched his head and nodded, looking at us confused.

"Are you on meds?" Eren asked.

"Meds for what?" Ci-N asked innocently.

"For your brain! You're acting crazy!" I snapped.

he just laughed at us. This kid must be sleep-deprived. It was kicking in!

"We have no time for jokes! We need to figure out how to get back," Keifer said seriously.

He was right. It was still early for dinner, but I was already hungry. If our stomachs started growling, it would be a big problem.

Did anyone see my Snorlax?

Everyone started suggesting ideas and possible plans. We started brainstorming and Ci-N kept insisting we follow his plan behind him.

he looked at it, and before we could even ask what it was, it started screaming like a girl.

"Snake! Snake! Snake!" he shouted.

The Ultroness immediately panicked and started running.

I tried to stand up, but of all the bad luck, Ci-N suddenly back, screaming.

"Jay-jay's best friend! It's going to bite us!"

Best friend?!

Since when did I have a snake for a best friend? This is i

Because my body was in pain and he was heavy, I couldn't where I was standing.

"Ci-N! Get off me!" I shouted.

"Get your best friend away from me!"

Damn it!

My body couldn't take it anymore. We both fell to the ground.

"Ouch!" I shouted as I hit the ground.

Damn it! My body was already in pain from the beating this kid climbed on me, and we fell to the ground.

"Nobody move!" someone shouted.

I opened my eyes. Holy crap! Face to face with my besti

I saw Yuri picking up a tree branch, but before he could his head rose higher. A sign that it was ready to strike.

Literally, no one moved. If I could stop breathing, I would even blink or look away.

Suddenly, we heard the sound of a stick breaking. That cobra opened its mouth and lunge at me.

But its mouth didn't reach me. Someone grabbed its tail and pulled it from me.

Keifer!

He threw the snake away, and it hit a tree. But that didn't stop it, huh?!

The snake quickly slithered back toward Keifer to bite him and ran away.

Jay-jay's really unlucky!

"Jay! Get out of there!"

"Jay-jay!"

I was really its target! Before I could even stand up to run close to me. I thought it was the end. I thought my life was over.

I glanced at Yuri for a moment. I could see the pain in his eyes as he walked away from us.

"Jay-jay's best friend is dead," Ci-N announced, as if he were reporting news on the radio.

Insane!

"There are snakes here! Why did the organizer put us here?" I asked angrily.

He was right! Why did they put us here? My suspicions were confirmed when I saw the tall grass not far from us.

I saw David pull the Swiss knife out of the snake's head. He cut it out, and put it back in his pocket.

"David!" I called out to him, and he turned to me. "...Thank you."

"Anytime," he said with a smile.

Ci-N and the others approached the snake. They poked it with a branch to check if it was still alive. It was still moving a little, like a worm doused in salt.

Suddenly, Ci-N grinned widely and faced all of us. "I know where our food back."

"What? Where?" I asked, looking at him with a questioning expression.

After he finished, everyone agreed. We divided the group would go to Sections A, B, and D. The others would stay our campsite.

Drew left to get what we needed. David made sure the snake wouldn't interfere with our plan.

"Did anyone see my Snorlax?" I asked everyone.

They all looked at each other to see if anyone had an answer like no one did.

"I'm not sure..." Edrix said, making us all look at him. "...stuffed toy, but I didn't get a good look at it."

Oh no!

No one else would bring a stuffed toy here—except me. My Snorlax!

"It's here! It's here!" Drew shouted, running over with a flashlight.

David quickly prepared the snake, tying it to the fishing line to ensure it was secure and well-attached.

Once they were done, they got ready. They were heading to retrieve our canned goods and noodles.

THE END

We stood there for a few minutes, just staring. I looked at Yuri. They were quiet, occasionally talking but only briefly.

Why does it have to be me?

If I weren't the only girl in Section E, would they still like at least one of them would like someone else.

Sigh... I'm feeling sad. I'm struggling with their situation fault.

"Jay..." Mayo called me and sat down beside me. "...how

"Still sore when I move."

"Josh has some pain relievers. Do you want some?" he offered.

I immediately shook my head. "No... It'll go away eventually."

"You're tough... You're really going to endure the pain?"

"Of course... It's not like I've never been in a fight before."

He just nodded, accepting my answer. We both fell silent. I felt like he wanted to say something, which was why he

"Is there a problem?" I asked.

He forced a smile. "It's about Kit..."

He took another deep breath. I could feel his sadness. It meant to sit together in a corner.

Why do they both have to be guys? Why did my best friend like me?

"Maybe..." he started. "...I'll just stop pursuing him..." He walked into the distance. "...I think it's time."

I don't know why, but it seemed like those words hurt him almost on the verge of crying in front of me, confirming my feeling.

We heard some noise. Mayo and I immediately stood up carrying our boxes full of canned goods and noodles.

They were laughing and teasing each other. They placed them in front of Keifer, who opened them to check if anything was missing.

"Some are missing... It looks like they took some," Yuri said.

"It's okay. At least we got most of it back," David said.

"Let's head to Section B now," Ci-N said excitedly.

David must be really happy because his plan worked.

The idiots left again, carrying the fishing rod with the snail.

"I-I'll go with them," he said to me and immediately followed the others.

I turned my attention back to Kit and saw him watching me. I tapped his arm, so he quickly went back to what he was doing.

Did he see Mayo crying?

I felt bad for both of them. I hope they can talk things out. As much as I want to interfere, I can't. I have my own problems.

And right now, they're both looking at me.

Chapter 174: Operation: E

2.0

Jay-jay's POV

"Start cooking the rice!" Felix shouted as he walked toward them, carrying the big bucket of rice. They got it back.

Nice! Rice!

Now, we only had one problem left—Section A. They had to make sure they filled with alcohol. I hope Ci-N's plan works on them.

David took a short rest. He looked tired from going back and forth.

"Let's head to Section A now," Ci-N said, looking hyper.

"Wait a minute!" Calix complained.

"Take a break, Ci-N! You're too excited about your plan! I need to help him.

Ci-N pouted and sat down beside me. I couldn't help but laugh. He was way too excited about his plan.

"I'm coming," I said, and they all looked at me.

"No. Stay here and rest," Keifer ordered.

"I've been resting for a while now."

"Even so, Jay... what happened to you wasn't easy. You n insisted.

"But—"

"Jay," Keifer called my name authoritatively. "...stop arg

"It's about my Snorlax. I need to get it back," I pleaded. '

He sighed and ran his fingers through his hair. "Fine."

YES!

"...but I'm coming with you," he added, looking at the U
of you stay here. We'll go."

They nodded in agreement. Me, Ci-N, David, Felix, Yuri
walked toward Section A's campsite.

We passed through a wooded area. Even though my bod
endured it just to find my Snorlax.

We hid in the bushes. Ci-N climbed a tree and positione

He walked to the spot David pointed to. He was close to was.

"You stay here," Felix said to Yuri. "...keep an eye on Jay
Yuri nodded and looked at me, then smiled.

"Let's go here," David said to Felix.

They walked closer to the cooler, but Felix grabbed some cover.

I scanned the area for my Snorlax. My eyes widened when hugging it.

Hey! That's my Snorlax!

"That's my Snorlax," I said, pointing at Ella.

"I'll get it," Yuri said and walked toward Ella's spot.

I watched David and the others, who seemed to be waiting exchanged signals and then executed the plan.

Ci-N cast the fishing rod like he was fishing. The snake and the girls were chatting.

"Aaaahhhhhhhhhh!!!" they screamed, led by—who else?

I looked for Yuri and saw him slowly picking up Snorlax looked like Ella had thrown it in her panic.

Once he got it, Yuri was about to run back to us, but Ella seemed to talk for a moment, and Yuri nodded before ru

What did they talk about?

"I got it," he said, handing me Snorlax.

"My Snorlax!" I hugged it tightly.

Ci-N suddenly approached us. he was sweating and look

"Let's go!" he said.

We looked at the fishing rod. The snake was gone. Only "bestie" remained.

My best friend!

"We'll talk later! Let's go!" David urged.

We quickly left, passing through the wooded area again. to be honest. Thankfully, the moonlight helped us see a l

We couldn't use a flashlight, or we might get caught.

"What happened? Why is only the head left of my best fi

"Of course!" he answered proudly.

"Then throw that thing away!" Keifer ordered angrily, pointing at the snake's head.

"Are you sure? Jay-jay will lose her memento of her best friend if you try to guilt-trip us.

Yuri and the others laughed, looking at me. I glared at Ci-N, but he just made them laugh harder.

We returned to our campsite. Ci-N didn't throw away the snake's head, he hung it near the bonfire.

"Nice! I've been thirsty for a while!"

"Let's drink!"

"Why is there San Mig here?"

They were all making a fuss, gathered around the cooler, hugging Snorlax tightly.

"Let's eat first!" Eman said.

I saw that they had already cooked rice. Our dinner was :

HAM with eggplant and shrimp paste!

I couldn't even talk to him. I didn't want a repeat of our last

Someone suddenly handed me a plate of food. I looked up and it was.

Keifer, the idiot.

"Eat," he ordered.

Even though I didn't feel like eating, I took the plate. I kept eating with me until I did what he wanted.

He sat down beside me, holding his own plate.

"What are you doing here?" I asked, confused.

He looked annoyed at my question and glared at me.

"You're seriously asking me 'what I'm doing here'?"

I slowly nodded. I felt like I said something wrong.

"Am I not allowed to eat beside you?" he asked sarcastic

Ohhh... that's what he meant!

"N-no, it's not like that..." I answered and automatically

He was lying on the hammock he brought, looking at us.

"N-no... W-what's wrong with you?" I forced a smile. ".. being so dramatic!"

He didn't react but started eating. I followed suit, even though it felt awkward. I noticed the others looking at us.

It felt like a huge crime to eat with the King of the Ulupe and swallow felt like punishment. The corner of my lip hurt and was sore.

At least I could eat. When Section D ganged up on me but I couldn't even swallow my own saliva.

"Hey! Ugly people!" Felix shouted, but no one looked at him. "Am I ugly?!"

"Ugly people!" he shouted again.

"You're the only ugly one here!" Ci-N shot back.

"Handsome people!" he shouted again, and this time, me and Ci-N responded.

"WHAT?!" they all shouted in unison.

So annoying!

"You're all shameful!" Felix said irritably. "Some of the

"Ew! Gay!"

I heard loud laughter from them. I wanted to laugh too, but I automatically looked at Kit. He looked sad as he continued.

The thing he was crying about was just a joke to the others. It weighed heavily on my heart.

"Jay!" Ci-N called me. "...I'll share with you."

"Sure..." I said boredly.

"No," Keifer said authoritatively.

We all froze. Even the others who were laughing fell silent. His eyes closed earlier, opened them and looked at us.

"I-it's okay with me. Ci-N and I have shared a room before."

"Jay... Your room is wide, and your tent is not," Keifer said.
"...you're a girl, and Ci-N is still a guy."

His mind is so dirty. Please clean it!

"So what? Ci-N isn't a stranger to me," I said, annoyed.

The truth was, I missed bonding with Ci at night. I wanted stories about where he lived.

He stood up and walked closer to us. "...No one is allowed with her. It's inappropriate for a girl and a guy to share a tent."
What?!

Keifer stood up, looking like he was challenging Yuri. Obviously, they were getting along. Why does it feel like there's tension?

"Fine. Jay-jay will sleep alone in her tent," Keifer said seriously.

"Why don't you just let Jay-jay decide?" David suggested. I looked at me.

Why me?!

If I say the wrong thing, they might start fighting again. I looked at Yuri. The others were watching too.

"Maybe just Ci-N," I said softly. "...if that's okay."

Keifer took a deep breath. "Fine. That's what you want."

"Okay," Yuri said.

I didn't want to, but... Ci-N was giving me a pleading look. No one to share a tent with. His tent was also torn.

After eating, they cleaned up. Calix and Eren washed their faces. Some just brushed their teeth and went to bed.

he ignored me and kept walking. We passed by some people in sections. They were chatting.

"Wow! There are snakes here."

"Yeah! One even came to our site."

"Us too!"

"We didn't have any."

Ci-N and I exchanged looks and had to hold back our laughter.

If only they knew!

"Rakki!" Ci-N shouted, waving. "...mi'loves!"

Rakki frowned as she approached us, about to hit Ci-N on the head. We were staring at us because of what he did.

"You're so loud!" she said irritably, but Ci just laughed.

She looked at me, so I smiled. "Hi."

She looked at me, scrutinizing my face. "Is that a bruise?"

I turned slightly so she couldn't see it clearly. The lighting was bad where we were, so I knew she couldn't see it well.

The sound of water from the showers echoed in the bath, were the laughter and chatter of the other sections.

My best friend was their topic!

"Did you have snakes at your site too? We didn't," Rakki in front of the sink.

"Y-yes," I almost whispered.

Our best friend showed up at our site first. Then we just

I faced the mirror, and from where I was standing, I could see the bruise on the corner of my lip. I also saw the marks on my neck. Cyrus choked me.

"I was right. It is a bruise," Rakki said, examining my face. "Did it hurt you?"

I shook my head. "N-no... It's nothing... I got hit when we were out of the snake."

She clearly didn't believe my explanation, but there was nothing I could do, so she just nodded. She put toothpaste on her toothbrush and started brushing.

I glanced at the girls showering. They were so loud, chatting and laughing, though I wanted to shout at them, I didn't. I just brushed

"Your towel, Mica! It fell."

Ella's voice!

Why is it like that? I recognized Ella's voice, but not Mica's. I knew how it is when you dislike someone.

They kept talking for a while. I continued showering. I was still there when I heard them again, and for some reason, I suddenly felt nervous.

"...Are you sure about that? Won't Aries get mad?" Mica asked.

"I don't know. But I'm sure he'll understand."

"But... it's over. You shouldn't bring it up again."

I heard Ella sigh. "Yuri deserves to know the truth."

Yuri? The truth?

"When are you meeting?" Mica asked again.

"I'm not sure yet, but I told him to wait."

They're meeting? What truth? Why do they need to meet?

I didn't hear them talking anymore. I peeked out of the shower stall. They were no longer in front of the mirror.

Rakki followed me, and when we were far enough, she g
turned me to face him.

She looked angry. "Did Keifer do that?!"

"No," I answered quickly.

"Jay... You don't have to hide it from me. I know you're i
with Keifer." she looked around to see if anyone was nea
you, tell me."

"Keifer didn't do this. Yes, someone hurt me, but it wasn
my head. "...Why would you think Keifer did this?"

She took a deep breath. "Because he's done it before. He
psycho!"

My heart suddenly raced. I wasn't sure if I was nervous.

"H-he did? To who?"

She avoided my gaze. I knew she didn't want to say. But
she couldn't keep it to herself.

"T-to... Freya."

To Freya?

Shit! They were together, after all. But it's hard to believe

But even so, that's not a good enough reason. Even if Fre coloring book, she's still a girl—even if she looks like a

"Hey! You're here already!" Ci-N shouted, running toward

I snapped out of my thoughts.

"I've been waiting for you," he said, catching his breath.

"You weren't even there," Rakki said irritably.

"You're just blinded by your love for me, so you didn't see

"You're just too short to be seen."

Ci-N glared at Rakki. "I'll grow taller! And when I do, w

My thoughts were momentarily distracted by their bicker and I could hear the organizers calling everyone.

"Let's go, Ci. You can continue your wedding plans tomorrow him.

"Good idea, but before that... I'll kiss the bride," he said and Rakki on the lips.

Smack!

If it were brighter, I might have seen Rakki blushing. She

"Crazy."

Chapter 175: Tray

Jay-jay's POV

I woke up early. Not because I slept well, but because so
Ouch!

Ci-N moves around so much in his sleep that he accident
As much as I wanted to retaliate, I didn't. he might end u
from how hard I'd hit him back!

I just got up and peeked outside the tent.

It was so quiet, and I didn't hear anyone moving yet. All
the chirping of birds and the rustling of leaves.

I stepped out of the tent and stretched—which I immedia
body ached, especially the parts that got bruised. I took a
before grabbing my toothbrush and some water to wash

I didn't go to the bathroom because it was too far. It was
just to wash my face. I'd take a shower later anyway.

While brushing my teeth, I noticed Yuri's hammock mov
lying there, completely wrapped in a blanket. Wait!

at me again.

"Oh, it's you," he said, smiling. "...Good morning."

I wanted to smile back, but my lips refused. I felt so embarrassed, so much so! I tried to fix what was left between us, but I couldn't do it anymore.

He got off the hammock and grabbed his toothbrush from the table. He walked over to me and got some water from the jug beside me.

"Sorry... I didn't recognize you," he said as he started brushing his teeth.

"It's okay... Why did you put your glasses back on?" I asked.

I didn't want to completely distance myself from him. I could feel his eyes on me. It would be so wrong to disregard that just because of our past.

"I take off my contacts before sleeping. I couldn't see without them. I wear these," he said, pointing to his glasses.

I nodded. Is it hard to wear glasses? But it's probably hard for him. Everything blurry. The world is just a blur.

"My parents are asking about us," he suddenly said, making me look up.

I glanced around. Someone might hear us, and it would cause more gossip or fights.

I wasn't looking at him. Was I that obvious? I just didn't still had to go through with it.

I finished brushing my teeth and went back to my tent. C awake, looking disheveled and smiling at me.

he still had bedhead.

"You woke up early," he said.

"Wouldn't you wake up if someone slapped you while yo Let's see if you wouldn't," I muttered while grabbing clo

"Huh?"

"Nothing."

I set my clothes aside. I was planning to shower right aft that would have to wait since Eman was still asleep.

I stepped out of the tent and saw that the others were alre walked past me, and for some reason, his gaze felt differ

I followed him with my eyes.

What's his problem?

I saw Felix gathering small branches, probably for firew walked over to help him

I tried learning from Eman before, but I stopped. He hit me when I held the knife wrong once.

And that was just holding the knife!

"Felix! Jay-jay!" someone called us.

We both turned and saw Rory waving at us. We walked over. Everyone was awake, and it looked like we were about to have a discussion.

"Is everyone here?" Edrix asked.

We all looked around. Once we confirmed everyone was here, we answered "yes" almost in unison.

"Okay... We need to get ready early. The retreat program starts at 10 AM. Lunch is at 12 PM, and the recreational activity is at 1:30 PM," Edrix explained. "...but we're not included in that."

We all had the same reaction to what he said. How are we not included? Why are we even here if we're not part of it? Just to cause trouble?

"What? Why?" I asked.

"How did that happen?" Denzel asked.

Rory chuckled. "You guys act like this is new."

"Boring," Calix said boredly.

"Then go join your girlfriend," Ci-N suggested to Calix.

"If I could, I would."

It really was boring. Rest? We already sleep so much at night we have to rest during the day too.

"There's nothing else we can do," Eman said as he opened hotdogs. "...we can't go out anymore. We'll get scolded."

"Do you guys want to go swimming?" I asked out of nowhere. They all look at me.

The truth was, I still knew a lot about this place even though I've been here since I last hung out here.

"Is there a pool here?" Ci asked.

I shook my head. "There's a small waterfall and a river."

The idiots seemed to perk up and gathered around me. I had their interest in what I was saying.

"There is? Let's go there."

"Wait! The organizers might not allow it."

"Okay! Let's just go there!" Ci-N said excitedly.

"Let's talk about it later!" Eman said, looking at me. "...h

I immediately walked over to help him cook breakfast. I had five packs of hotdogs, five packs of bacon, and a dozen eggs. I also had leftover rice from last night.

The others were busy drinking coffee while waiting. I had to leave because the food we brought wouldn't last long with how much we ate.

We really ate a lot!

After cooking, we fed the idiots. The crazy kid was clearly swimming. he was even pretending to swim with his hands.

Go ahead. Swim all you want!

I wasn't sure if the path we used to take was still there. The forest had developed, so it might be gone.

After eating, they all rushed to the bathroom. There were a lot of people, and they'd have to fight for a spot. As I was chilling. A little wait, and I could shower.

I wasn't disappointed because when I got there, there were a lot of people in the bathroom. While arranging my clothes and suddenly crossed my mind.

When Yuri took Snorlax. Ella said something, and Yuri n
be it? A segue!

What the hell! I couldn't relax because of that damn "tru
to be nothing, I'll pull Ella's hair. Even if it means fightin

I continued showering. More people were coming into th
finished quickly and left.

When I got back to the site, only a few of them were thei
still gone and would probably take a while.

"Get ready, Jay! Let's go ahead!" Eman said.

I nodded at him and went straight to my tent. I put down
ready. After that, I joined Eman and Edrix, who were wa

"What about the others?" I asked as we walked.

"They'll follow. Our seats are at the back, so they'll see u
Eman said.

We continued walking and arrived at the hall. Eman was
were at the very back.

There was a huge sign that said "SECTION E!" right acr
of benches, so we wouldn't get lost. As soon as we sat dc
Mayo arrived, followed by Ci-N, who immediately sat b

We all stood up. One of our batchmates started praying in Hindi. After that, we sat back down and listened to what the org

"Thank you so much for... Blah blah blah...."

For some reason, I started feeling sleepy while listening. I kept yawning and wiping my teary eyes.

I rested my head on Ci-N's shoulder. he didn't resist and my eyelids started to droop. It was so boring.

Before I knew it, I had fallen asleep. Even in my dreams I heard something. It sounded like bees in a bottle.

"Jay..." someone called me.

I didn't respond. I wasn't sure if I was still dreaming. Then I woke up and then I suddenly heard clapping.

Oh no! It's over!

People were clapping, which meant it was over. I quickly stood up and joined in the clapping. But when I looked around, no one was clapping.

I stopped clapping and looked around. Our batchmates were all standing up. I looked at Ci-N beside me, and he was giggling.

"What's so funny?" I asked him.

You jerks! Animals!

"I did get tired," Ci-N said innocently, and they all fell si

They looked at me and then at Keifer. Even without them
knew what they were thinking. Their minds are so dirty!
King, who was frowning and clearly ready to punch some

"...we talked for a long time. And we talked about a lot of
added, and the Ulupongs seemed to relax.

They're so green-minded!

"We thought you did something else," Blaster said, laugh

"Enough. Let's eat," Keifer said and stood up.

The others followed him. There was a long line in front of
was.

"Is it lunch already?" I asked Ci-N.

he nodded. "You were sleeping so soundly. We didn't wa

Wow.

We lined up for lunch. Thankfully, there was plenty of fo

Unlike yesterday, when we only got leftovers, Ci handed

"Freya... Don't start a scene," Mica, who was behind Freya's classmates, warned.

"Shut it, Mica!" Freya shouted at her and turned to face me. "Is this what I heard? You and..." She looked at Keifer, who was sitting next to me. "...what a great choice!"

Another scene! So annoying!

"I don't want trouble, Freya," I said calmly but firmly.

"Oh, really?!" she asked sarcastically. "...what if I want to?"

"Freya! Please..." Mica pleaded.

Freya ignored her. I saw Ella, who was also beside Mica, looking back at Freya and suddenly had a bad feeling.

Are they doing this on purpose?

"Freya."

"You think you're so pretty," she said snobbily, looking at me.

"Stop it, Freya!" Yuri scolded, making her sharp gaze turn to me.

"Shut up! Don't you dare interrupt me when I'm talking!" she said angrily.

I was scared she might shout it out. There were so many
us.

I tried to walk away, but Freya was really in a mood. She
causing me to drop the tray I was holding.

My food!

I pushed her hand away and glared at her. "What's your p

"You! Because you're such a flirt!"

"You're so embarrassing!"

"Hah!" She matched my glare.

"Can you just stop, Freya!" Felix said irritably.

Freya looked at him. "Why are you talking to me like that?
won't like it."

Brother?! Is she talking about P-Percy?

Why is Percy involved here? What's going on? Does she
alive?

"Percy's been gone for a long time! You've been gone for
Felix replied.

"So you know him too?" she asked irritably. "...Let me guess, you told you?" She emphasized the word "friends."

It was Percy. But what happened? Why did she end up with Yuri? Did they know about it too? Did they do it on purpose?

I was so confused.

I looked at Yuri and Keifer, and they both avoided my gaze, not wanting to be questioned about it.

"Did your friends also tell you what they did to me?" Freya glared at the two.

What they did?

"Enough, Freya," I said, but she clearly didn't want to stop.

"Why? Don't you want others to hear?!"

"What do you want?!"

I was starting to clench my fists. If she didn't stop, I might hit her.

She crossed her arms and stared straight at me. "I want to know when you find out what those two did to me."

Even though I wanted to know, I didn't think I could hear

Freya smiled and walked away. Her classmates followed at me apologetically.

"Section E, go back to your campsite," Sir ordered us.

We had no choice but to obey. The worst part was that we had no choice. When we got back, I immediately confronted Yuri and told him to care if the Ulupongs were watching.

"What was Freya talking about?" I asked, clearly annoyed.

I was trying to stay calm, but my emotions were all over the place. I was the only one who wanted answers. Even Edrix was listening.

"We're all tired and hungry. Can we talk about it later?" I asked.

I got even more annoyed. I knew he was just avoiding it. I would talk about it later.

"Why not now?!" I couldn't hold back my irritation.

"Jay... Please," Yuri pleaded.

"What's the problem?!"

"Because that was a mistake!" Keifer shouted, making me freeze. "...It was just a mistake back then! Why do you not care now? It can't be undone!"

"Jay..." Ci called me. "...I thought we were going swimn

I knew Ci was just trying to change the subject. Things r
tense between us.

"I'll check if the path we used before is still there," I said

They let me go. The path led back to the hall, but that wa
going. Behind the hall was a fishpond. It was just a short

I wasn't disappointed because I immediately saw the wat
even that had been developed. There was a big gazebo in
looked like an island. To reach it, there was a long bridge

I just glanced at it and continued walking along the edge
found what I was looking for. I went to the wooded area,
immediately met with barbed wire and a big "Keep Out"

Pffttt...

But that wouldn't stop me. I peeked through to the other
pathway we used to take.

I smiled because the path was still there. We could go to
I started walking back to invite them, but I froze when I
the bridge.

She was crying, but I could see the anger on her face. I n

Chapter 176: Freya Hidalgo

Jay-jay's POV

I wanted to ask her. I wanted her to clarify what she said I wanted to do that.

But I knew this wasn't the right time for it. I watched her because I enjoyed seeing her cry, but because I was seeing of Freya.

The real her.

I was about to walk away because I knew what I was doing. Freya noticed me before I could leave.

Damn!

She glared at me, as if waiting for my excuse. I couldn't speak, my tongue had tied itself in knots.

"What do you want?" she asked seriously.

It was clear she didn't want to argue anymore, and neither could I. I couldn't speak.

Tsk! So annoying! As embarrassing as it was, I wanted to already here, I might as well clarify things.

"W-what you said earlier. I... I don't understand," I said,

She chuckled slightly. "I thought your friends already told

I shook my head slightly. Freya looked me up and down.

"Then again, I'd be more surprised if they actually told you," I smirked annoyingly.

She was back to being B*tch Freya!

"What's—"

"Yuri and Keifer are my exes," she cut me off, emphasizing

Kiko had already told me that. I didn't say anything, waiting for her to continue.

"After Percy died, Yuri was the first one to approach me, showing that he was there for me anytime..." she said, tearing her eyes again. "...but what that asshole did is unforgivable."

Tears streamed down her face, but she didn't care. She was seeing the pain she was going through.

"He made me fall for him and took what he wanted, like

I wanted to go to Freya and hug her. I wanted to let her know I was listening. But who was I? I'd be such a hypocrite if I did that. Freya Hidalgo—she's stronger than me.

She wiped her tears and took a deep breath. "And then K... Taking the spotlight." She shook her head slightly. "...at... I should be grateful to him, but I was wrong."

She looked back at me. I almost stepped back because of her intense gaze.

"It was too good to be true. He's the ideal boyfriend that I've ever had. Treating me like queen, even though only a few knew we were together. Tears were forming in her eyes again. "...but it all changed. It was still Yuri. That bastard let jealousy consume him! I never saw the point where he laid his hands on me!"

Damn it!

Is this what Rakki was talking about? Keifer can hurt a very sensitive person. I'm so confused!

"What's worse? He became controlling! I felt like a prisoner. I took a deep breath to hold back her tears. "...Don't talk to this girl like that. Don't go here! Don't leave your house without my permission. Don't try to disobey me!" She mimicked Keifer's voice.

She ran her fingers through her hair and looked into the crowd.

"W-what did you do?"

She smirked at me, as if bragging. "I went out with other guys, got tired of me and left."

She slept with other guys? Not just one? Multiple?! What?

"...Then people started calling me a slut, bitch, and whore —if you knew!" she said, pointing at me. "...would you say the same?"

I looked down. If only I had known. Maybe I could've been a better person. Maybe I would've tried to talk to her back then. Maybe I would've understood her bitterness.

"I'm pathetic, right?" Tears fell from her eyes again.

I was about to walk closer to her, but she raised her hand to stop me.

"Don't! I don't need your fake sympathy," she said and walked away.

She bumped into me but didn't even look back. I didn't know what to say. I wanted to blame Yuri and Keifer, but what for? Yuri. She loved him. She just took what he wanted and left her. Keifer. He was the one you'd want to marry, but he could also hurt you.

Impossible!

"Jay-jay!!" someone called me.

I looked at him, confused. "Huh?"

"The small waterfall and river. We thought you were che

Tsk! Deaf!

"Ahh... Y-yes. I-I saw it. Are we going now?"

I looked at David. His gaze was different, as if saying, "wrong with you."

"Sure. We don't have anything else to do," Ci-N said exc

"I'll go get the others," Felix said and walked away.

The three of us were left. Ci-N saw the gazebo and immed it. David and I just watched him as he inspected every co

"We ran into Freya. Did you two talk about something?"

I deliberately avoided his gaze because I had a strong fee

"Just our argument earlier."

He didn't ask further. That's how he is—he doesn't pry o still wondering how he and Percy met.

Ci-N ran back to us, still smiling and clearly excited.

I looked at the idiots. They were clearly excited too. The of me when I noticed something.

The King and Yuri weren't there. I looked back to where thinking they might've been left behind.

"Josh, Keifer, and Yuri stayed behind," Felix said. "...the needs to watch our spot."

I just nodded. Watch the spot? More like they didn't want. Those guys are good at making excuses. I don't know what.

"Let's go! Let's go!" Ci-N, the most excited of all, urged.

I walked ahead of them since I knew the way. We passed an overgrown area beside the fishpond. Like I saw earlier, the "Keep Out" sign.

"We'll cross here," I said, squeezing through the wires.

"Be careful," David said, helping me.

Once on the other side, I waited for them to cross. I made sure I was here before we continued walking. We just followed the path without plants because it was frequently used.

When I said it was overgrown, I expected tall grass, but it was more than that. The path was slippery, and there were

We kept walking. I was getting nervous because I felt like I was on the wrong path.

You're in trouble, Jay!

What scared me more was the possibility of running into my best friend for me!

My worries disappeared when I heard the sound of rushing water louder with every step we took.

And they were amazed when they saw the small waterfall. It was clear, shimmering with every drop and flow.

"Let's swim!" Ci-N shouted and immediately ran toward the water.

The other Ulupongs followed. The guys immediately took off their shirts except for Ci-N, who was only wearing boxers. I facepalmed at his appearance.

"Damn! It's not just your height that's small, huh?" Eren teased.

We all laughed, and it got even louder when Ci grabbed my arm.

"It'll grow! Don't provoke it!" Felix shouted, laughing.

"Hey!" I scolded him.

He seemed to have forgotten there was a girl with them.

"Don't you want to join them?"

I turned to the person who spoke. David was standing with his hands in his pockets. He was also smiling as he watched

"Maybe later," I replied.

"Up to you," he said and took off his shirt.

Why did it suddenly feel hot?

He immediately joined the others and started swimming. He turned his back, and they almost slipped.

As long as we don't get caught by the organizers, we'll be fine. We can handle it. Superman could too, but he's busy swimming with the Ulupongs.

I noticed them running toward me. Before I could get up and sit down, they surrounded me.

"W-what?" I asked nervously.

Wait a minute!

I think I know what they're planning. Felix and Rory immediately grabbed my wrists. They pulled me until we reached the waist-deep water.

They stopped and surrounded me. They let me go.

One by one, they stopped when they got tired. I took the breath. I felt like I was drowning in what they did.

"Wow! Were you trying to kill me?" I asked them.

They just laughed. Animals!

"Don't be shy! Take off your clothes!" Ci teased, but he i
hard slap on the back of his head from David.

"You're really something!"

"Why? It's fine with me. I've already seen her naked," he
the back of his head.

My eyes widened at what he said. Even the others were s
he's seen me naked?

"We're telling Keifer," Edrix threatened.

"Are you serious?" I asked Ci.

he nodded innocently. "I saw your back when you were 1

"Oh my!"

"he's really something!"

"This is bad!"

"You do," he insisted.

I looked at Felix, who was the closest to me.

"Can you check?" I asked, and he came closer.

I slightly lifted the back of my shirt, enough for him to see what I was talking about. The others also peeked and looked.

"There is," Felix said.

"Is that a scar? Why does it have a shape?" Edrix asked.

"Idiot! It's probably a scar," Eren countered.

"A scar? It's blurry! And if it's a scar, it should be smooth!" Eren interjected.

"Why does it have a shape?" Eren asked.

A shape?

"It's shaped like the bottom of an iron," David said.

I felt like I'd been doused with cold water. Colder than that. I pulled my shirt down and gripped the hem tightly.

They seemed surprised by what I did. They immediately looked at me curiously.

Even I didn't know where I got it.

It was one of the things Lola had treated when I woke up. Whenever I asked them, they wouldn't answer. I thought it completely disappeared. We kept going to the doctor to see if it seemed like it didn't want to go away.

"O-oh... Y-your scar is so fancy. It even has a shape," he

I forced a laugh, even though it was really awkward. I knew what he meant to say.

"...You're probably too lazy to scrub it, so it didn't go away, making the idiots laugh.

You crazy kid!

Do scars even disappear by scrubbing? he's really something. I was just saying that to ease the awkwardness.

"That's why Jay-jay needs another bath!" Felix shouted at me.

The shameless ones joined in. I almost drowned in what I tried to fight back, but it was useless because of how hard they were splashing.

We stayed in the water for a long time. If we hadn't gotten

"You're the only one who's unsatisfied!" Felix teased him

They continued messing around as if they had endless energy almost at the hall when I stopped.

I was confused when I saw who Sir Alvin was talking to. When Ulupongs noticed me, they also looked at what I was looking at.

"Why is your cousin here?"

Chapter 177: Keifer's side

Jay-jay's POV

"Where have you been?" Kuya Angelo asked while looking head to toe.

My clothes were soaking wet, so it was obvious that we were swimming or gotten wet. He also looked at my companion.

"W-we went swimming----"

"Where?" He cut me off.

He already knew there was a small waterfall nearby. That's why he picked me up when he wanted me to go home.

"At the fishpond," Ci answered, causing all of us to look at him.

"Excuse me? At the fishpond?" Sir Alvin clarified.

We all nodded nervously. It was better than admitting we were at the waterfall and river. We might get into trouble.

"Do you know how dirty the water in that fishpond is?!" Sir Alvin said, tinged with irritation.

"Jay-jay's grumpy Kuya is here!" Ci-N said.

Yuri and Keifer exchanged glances before looking at me anything. I just grabbed what I needed and ran to the rest

Since there weren't many of us, I didn't wait or line up for quickly washed up and changed. I didn't want Kuya to go

I ran back to the campsite to drop off my things.

"Why are you so panicked?" Felix asked me.

I stopped. "I feel like something happened. Kuya wouldn't reason."

A big part of me was telling me that. He could've just called signal here was terrible.

"Think positive, Jay. Maybe your Kuya just wants to check said.

But that didn't help ease my feelings. Something felt off.

"Go ahead... Go see your Kuya," Yuri said, smiling at me

I returned the smile and walked back to the hall where I was talking to Sir Alvin.

They were still there, and now Arica had joined them. He

Kuya crossed his arms and looked at me intently.

"Cyrus's parents called me," he said.

Oh no!

"...He was brought to the hospital along with his friends.

I avoided his gaze. I knew it! Kuya wouldn't come here if I wasn't
how annoying!

"Did you have something to do with that?" Kuya asked calmly.

His voice was starting to rise, and my heart was pounding.

"B-because..."

"Damn it!" Kuya shouted, making me tremble in fear. "What
happened?!"

My tongue and mouth refused to cooperate. It was as if I was
scared of Kuya. I wanted to explain everything, but I couldn't.

"Did your craziness act up again?" Aries asked sarcastically.

Crazy?

Was he calling me crazy? For some reason, I felt insulted.
It wasn't true.

I looked down. I didn't know the answer. No matter how couldn't find one. Maybe... Maybe I really was crazy.

"I-I don't... know."

Aries chuckled lightly. "Then you're crazy."

"Enough!" Kuya shouted at the top of his lungs.

His voice was as loud as thunder. It felt like the sky might split from the intensity. Maybe Kuya would make a good referee for as loud he could yell.

Kuya looked at me. "Did you do it?!"

I slowly shook my head. "N-no-----"

"I did," someone cut me off.

Who else would it be but the King of Snakes who loved to watch things turn out. He turned to look at him. He had his hands in his pockets and looked bored.

"Excuse me?" Kuya asked irritably.

"That thing that happened to-----what's his name again?" he asked innocently.

Seriously? After all the jealousy, he couldn't even remember

"I don't know," the pest replied quickly.

What a jerk!

"What do you mean 'you don't know'?" Kuya asked irrita

This idiot was probably trying to piss Kuya off before gi
answer.

"Tss."

Damn it!

Kuya was holding onto his patience, but he was clearly g
probably knew how this guy operated.

"If you don't have anything sensible to say, you can leav
angrily to Keifer.

The two of them stared each other down. It felt like they
shoot lasers from their eyes.

Just let one of them melt already.

"Keifer... I don't have time for your jokes," Kuya said ca
authority.

I looked at the pest, pleading with my eyes. If he wasn't ;
he shouldn't stir up trouble. I was the one getting blamed

"...so I did what I could. I took down that Cyrus."

"And what are you doing in Holy Saints? I know Jay-jay do there. What about you?" Kuya asked.

"Sightseeing," he answered quickly.

Nice!

What a great answer! I was amazed. This guy really love I really wanted to punch him.

I glanced at Aries. His fists were clenched tightly. Between he was quicker to lose his temper.

"Seriously?" Kuya asked sarcastically. "...Keifer----"

"You're so stupid," Keifer said bluntly, causing Aries to g

"What did you say?!" Aries shouted angrily. "...what did brother?!"

"Stupid," Keifer repeated.

Oh no!!!

"Aries," Kuya called. "...Let him go," he ordered, but Ar willing to comply. "...Now!"

Because he's gay and jealous of my beauty!

Maybe the King was right. Kuya really was stupid. Did I
past with Cyrus? Sometimes Kuya was so dense.

Like Aries, Keifer, Yuri, and even Percy. They were all tl

"Because... of what I did to him before," I sighed. "...He

I heard Kuya take a deep breath. I didn't know if he was
didn't react, but his fists were still clenched.

"Did you do that to Cyrus's friends too?" Kuya asked Ke

"No. It was our classmates," he answered while looking

"Thanks for clarifying that. You can go now," Kuya disn

I nodded and started walking away. My steps were slow
heavy. I could feel the King behind me.

We were near our site when I stopped. He stopped too, a
him saying anything, I knew he had something to say.

"Jay," he called.

I turned to him. I didn't know if he was just bored of this
dealing with me.

He looked down. "I can't promise."

I felt weak at his words. What if he didn't answer any of my worry disappeared when he held my hand.

"...but I will try my best," he added, smiling.

I couldn't return the smile, but I held his hand tightly.

"D-did you really hurt Freya?" I asked, looking into his e

He didn't look away. "I did."

My chest tightened, and I didn't understand why. He real
Why? Hadn't he learned from what happened to his mon

"W-why? Why did you do that?"

I couldn't help raising my voice. I felt angry at what he d
understand what he did to me, let alone what he did to F

We weren't friends, but we were both girls. That was enc
to feel angry about what happened to her.

"Freya is my first in everything," he let go of my hand, a
my heart. "...but I'm not hers."

Freya had told me that.

"...I'm sure you won't understand how much it hurt me and especially when I realized Yuri was on her mind while we he took a deep breath. "...jealousy and fear consumed me until I couldn't control myself anymore... I-----"

"You hurt her," I continued for him. "...but that's not a girl. Freya is a girl."

He looked away. Maybe I didn't understand the pain he felt was trampled. How much it hurt that Freya was thinking while they were together.

"I don't know... Maybe I'm like Dad," he said, looking down.

I felt his sadness when he said that. I suddenly felt ashamed on him without considering his feelings.

I stepped closer and hugged him.

"No. You're not like him," I said.

I felt his arms wrap around me too. "Believe me. I was scared. I did. I made sure I wouldn't do it again."

But you almost did it to me.

His grip tightened around me, as if he had read my mind.

"Dad, I'm not like him. I'm not like him. I'm not like him."

"Sorry. I understand you. I just couldn't believe you coul

He forced a smile. "Do you have more questions?"

I did.

"I-I do... Maybe next time----"

"It's okay. You can still ask me," he cut me off.

But I didn't know if I should ask more. I felt like I had al
much.

He looked at me, waiting for my next question. So, even
want to...

"Freya told me something else," I took a deep breath. "...
restrained her like a prisoner."

He suddenly laughed. I was annoyed by his reaction, but
lightened the mood.

"That thing is actually normal."

Normal for him?!

"Normal?"

He nodded. "She was acting out back then. I kept seeing

"A-Aries? H-how...?"

"Remember Mykel Mitchell?" he asked, and I nodded. "Aries and Freya were in a relationship. He even showed of them making out."

"W-what did you do?"

Why did that story sound familiar?

"Nothing. She was breaking up with me at that time, and didn't want to let go. Then when Mykel told me about the maybe she really didn't want me anymore," he forced a smile and went back to his seat.

MIRACLE?!

He didn't even confront or punch Aries. This was a miracle. An angel passed by at that time. Or maybe Mykel talked some sense into him.

"Really?"

He looked at me curiously. "What?"

"You didn't confront Aries?" I asked, and he nodded. "...I can't believe."

"Yeah... I didn't confront him. I went after Mykel instead."

"I do. Freya said Yuri only took what he wanted and then he left. Is that true?" I asked with concern in my voice.

"That one... I don't know," he said, and I looked at him curiously. I didn't bother finding out what happened between them----all I knew was that he did things, which I accepted."

Pffttt...

Why didn't he know? He should've known. How lame! My next questions were about that.

"It's hard to believe Yuri would do something like that," he said, and I whispered.

"I doubt Yuri did that kind of thing," he said, thinking. "If he and I were together, he still asked me about Freya."

That meant he still cared about Freya.

"...there were times when he showed he still had feelings for her, which is why I got really jealous too."

I felt relieved. Yuri wouldn't do that. If he only wanted her, he wouldn't care about her anymore. But the look on Freya's face told me about it... I could see how much she was hurt. It was her fault, her to be lying.

"Okay. Let's go back," I said to him.

Before I could take a step, he grabbed my arm. I looked at him, then at his face. He was smiling and raising his eyebrows.

I think I know what that means.

He pouted, confirming my suspicion. The idiot was asking me a question.

"No," I replied quickly. "...it's already dark."

He immediately frowned and looked at me annoyed. He changed his expression so quickly.

"Kuya's there, right? What if he suddenly comes here..." I reasoned.

"Fine," he said irritably and walked ahead of me.

I just laughed. He needed to be controlled. If it went too far on New Year's might happen again.

At least some of my questions about him and Freya were answered. Yuri's part was left.

I knew he had an explanation too.

I was ready to listen to it.

Even though I was confused, I took it and looked at all o
know they brought alcohol----wait!

This isn't ours! This is from Section A. Tsk! These guys :

"Eat first, Jay! You might get sick from that," David said
plate full of----pulutan (snacks)!

"Hey! Don't get her drunk!" Edrix shouted worriedly. "..
demons in the fire again!"

Everyone laughed loudly while looking at me. These idi
making fun of me? I just rolled my eyes and looked for a

I just hope I don't get drunk.

You're all in trouble if I do.

Chapter 178: Barakuda

Jay-jay's POV

"I don't like tight spaces. I don't like it hot. I don't like m

That's a line from a movie, right?

Ugh, this is annoying! I woke up feeling so cramped. I w
sweat. Even though I didn't want to, I opened my eyes, a
head hurt even more.

Curse this hangover!

I never learn. I keep drinking even though I know I'll wa
terrible headache.

Damn it! It feels like my head is splitting in half. I trie
head with my hands, but for some reason, I couldn't mov

I forced myself to look at my hands. My senses fully wo
the reason.

I WAS TIED UP!

Son of a—! My hands were tied to both sides. On ton

So, even though I didn't want to, I slowly turned to the left. He was so close, it felt like he was about to kiss me.

"K-Keifer," I called out to him.

The idiot didn't budge and seemed to be in a deep sleep. My right, and the situation and position were almost the same.

"Yuri," I also called out to him.

He didn't move either. I was so sticky from sweat. I tried to lean into them. I heard a loud groan from them, and they slightly moved away from me.

"Wake up. Please! My tent is small, and you both squeeze me here," I said irritably.

Yuri was the first to open his eyes and sit up. He yawned.

"Good morning," he greeted me with a smile.

"Good morning to you too. Maybe you can untie me now," I said sarcastically.

He looked at my hands. I thought he was going to reach out, but he just poked Keifer to wake him up. He did it several times, but Keifer didn't wake up. Finally, Yuri woke up.

"Yuri, Keifer is still asleep. I need help."

"Are we doing it now?" Yuri asked.

Doing what?!

"We could."

Doing what?!

"Won't we be heard outside?"

Heard doing what?!

"Cover her mouth so we won't be heard."

I was so confused, my neck almost snapped from looking at them. I couldn't understand what they were talking about.

Yuri smiled and leaned his face closer to me. I was getting nervous.

"Jay... Don't get mad, okay?" he asked, which made me even more confused. "...we're going to—."

Holy crap!

"What?! You're crazy!" I shouted, struggling against the restraints.

They both burst out laughing. That's when I realized they were laughing at me. My eyebrows were almost touching from how close they were to my face.

I was about to walk toward the jug to get some water, but saw their reactions.

These weirdos!

They all moved away but kept looking at me. Some hid behind their tents. Ci-N hid behind David.

"What's wrong with you all?" I asked.

No one answered. Suddenly, someone tapped my shoulder, smiling.

"That's the last time for you. No more drinking," he said and handed me some water.

Holy cow!

What happened last night?! I got drunk! I know that! But what after? Here we go again.

Another hand tapped my shoulder. Keifer also walked past.

"Nice..." he said and also got some water. "...Barracuda."

Damn it!

Flashback...

I heard Keifer and Yuri laughing. I glared at them. Even saying it, I knew they were laughing at me.

I looked at Ci, who was still hiding behind David. he kept

"Ci-N..." I called him and tried to approach him, but he immediately stepped back while still holding onto David.

"D-don't come near me."

I looked at him irritably. "What's wrong with you?!"

"Hide me, David!" he shouted.

David just let him hide behind him. I was so confused by

I looked at Eman, but before I could say anything, he ran the same, even though he was glaring at me.

"Hey! What's going on with you all?" I asked, but no one

"You were so wild last night," Yuri said, handing me some

I immediately felt nervous. I think I know what I did. Oh

"Who's Barracuda, by the way?" Keifer asked.

"Huh?"

"Congratulations! You portrayed your character very well with an annoying smile."

Argh! What the—?!

"What did I really do?!"

I noticed Felix slowly approaching me. He was clearly holding his phone and started pressing some buttons. When he walked it to me.

A video... Again?!

I played the video. The footage was shaky. It hurt my eyes to endure it to remember what I did.

They were shouting loudly. The person recording kept asking why the footage was so shaky.

"I need a virgin!" a loud shout... Was that me?

I couldn't see myself in the video, so I couldn't be sure if I was shouting. But my gut told me it was definitely me.

"I am Barracuda!" I shouted again.

This time, I was sure it was me.

"Shit! Looks like you're going crazy!" Calix's voice said

"Ci-N! Hide!"

"Hurry, Ci!"

"Ci-N! Play dead!"

Suddenly, Ci-N and I disappeared from the frame. The camera came back again.

"Where are they?!" Felix asked worriedly.

The camera focused on the bonfire. A moment later, I appeared around as if searching for something.

"I need a virgin! I need a virgin! In exchange for eternal shouting.

I cringed at how I looked in the video. The things I was saying were the same lines from our school play back then.

I looked so stupid!

"Eman! He's still a virgin!" Blaster suddenly shouted in the background by loud laughter.

"Idiot, Blaster!"

"Eman! Run!"

I thought they were going to chase each other again, but and Yuri appeared with ropes. They immediately approached wrapping the ropes around my entire body.

The crazy bunch clapped loudly and started gathering around

"Burn the witch!" Ci-N shouted, but David gave him a hard back of his head.

That's where the video ended. I was so embarrassed to find out wonder they were so scared of me.

"We couldn't sleep. We were scared of you," Felix said at the phone.

"Sorry," I said.

I also faced Ci-N, who was still hiding behind David.

"Ci... Sorry."

"Please, Jay... Don't get drunk like that again," David said.

"I won't... I'm really sorry."

Ci slowly came out from behind David. he was still looking at me.

"Can you..." he started, and we waited for him to continue.

"Where are you going?" David asked.

"I'm going to take a shower!" I shouted back as I continu

I almost ran to the bathroom to get there quickly. I didn't
breakfast. You know how it is!

These snakes are ruthless!

Since it was still early, I was the only one in the bathroom
myself! Nice! I had the right to sing whatever song came

Oh yeah!

I started showering, and while I was busy, I kept singing

" ...Baby you don't have to rush

you can leave your toothbrush

at my place... At my place.

We don't need to keep rush

you can leave your toothbrush

at my place... At my place.

Stuck in the limbo----Aaaaooohhhh!!!"

"H-how was I supposed to know someone else was here. screamed again when I saw her fully.

The girl was completely naked! Her hair was soaking wet still some shampoo in it.

I just looked at the ceiling. I'm a girl too, but... *Damn it

"What?! Can't look at my gorgeous body?" she teased.

I didn't answer. I tried to close the curtain with my foot, but it was blocking it.

"...Or maybe you're hiding something?" she added and she took a towel.

I held onto it tightly. I almost slipped while struggling with it. She was about to see something she shouldn't.

"FREYA!" I shouted, still struggling. "...You're such a jerk."

This girl was so annoying. I thought she wouldn't stop, so I held on tighter when she finally let go.

"You're no fun," she said irritably.

I glared at her. But it slowly faded when I saw that her eyes were closed. She also looked like she was hungover or, more accurately, like she had been drinking too much.

"W-what?! Just go away!" I felt my face burning.

Damn this girl! Doesn't she have anything better to do flaunt her body like that? She has no shame.

But in fairness, she has a nice body!

She just smirked and walked away. I didn't take my eyes noticed something shiny on her ear.

I wasn't sure, but it looked like an earring. It sparkled for then disappeared.

It looked familiar!

But before I could think about where I'd seen it before, I again and quickly finished my shower. I didn't want her mess with me again.

After showering and brushing my teeth, I went back to o fresh. I was so embarrassed earlier. I didn't want him to s scary.

When I got back, they were already eating breakfast. *Pl even wait for me.

"Eat, Jay!" Calix called out to me.

"E

"Tsk! That's the last time for you. No more drinking," he

"O-okay. We're good, right?" I said, making a peace sign

He smiled while shaking his head. "Yeah, we're good."

I got some food and sat next to Ci, who was being his usual
telling stories.

"Barracuda! Barracuda!" they called me while laughing.

Damn it!

I glared at them. "I'll throw this plate at you!"

"Alululululululu!" Drew shouted, and they laughed even

"You're all demons!"

"That's enough!" Edrix scolded them. "...She might cook

"Hahahahahaha... Witch!"

Damn it! I thought he was going to stop them, but he j
in. These snakes are always like this.

They kept teasing me while we ate. Afterward, they start
one to go to the bathroom. They were going to shower be
attend the program again. Lunch would follow, and then

"Barracuda! Barracuda!" someone shouted while running.

Who else could it be?!

Just one time. Just one slap for this kid. That's all I ask!]
I'll be happy.

"Move over! I'm sitting there," he said, pushing me.

Look at this guy. Pushing me like that. I almost fell face-him, but he just smiled at me.

Little brat!

The others started arriving. The organizer spoke into the
quieted down. We started with a prayer again.

"Keep an eye on that one. She might fall asleep again," I
they laughed.

"Tsk! I'm not going to fall asleep," I snapped at them.

We looked to the front as the organizer cleared his throat
attention.

"Let's talk about something that everyone can relate to,"
the mic said. "...very common and known to this world."

I know this! I know this! MONEY!

Everyone immediately looked at him. There was loud laughter and applause.

Holy crap!

"Woohoo!"

"Hahaha..."

Even the organizer just laughed at him. I glared at him, but proud of what he did.

"...BUT RAKKI AND I HAVE FOREVER! I LOVE YOU DIEGO!"

I just facepalmed. he's really something else. I'm sure this is another long day.

It's always like this!

Chapter 179: Truth or Dare

Jay-jay's POV

This little brat is so annoying. He's always stealing the spotlight and hitting me fast.

"Rakki! I love you!" Ci shouted while chasing Rakki.

"Stay away from me! You're so annoying! You're embarrassing!" Ci shouted back as she ran away.

We just watched them. Even the other people around were laughing and shaking their heads. They really know how to steal the spotlight.

We were currently in line. It was lunchtime, and after the event, the organizer—I didn't understand anything. It was all about the event. There were even some confessions of feelings, but of course, not from Ci-N.

"Jay..." David called me while handing me a tray.

I took it and immediately picked out some food. I couldn't resist the lechon from afar. *Oh my gosh! Lechon!*

It was so shiny and delicious!

"Why do you care?" I asked him irritably.

He glared at me and handed me a bottled water. "You're

I just ignored him and continued eating. Before going to waited for the others.

Since Ci-N took so long—he was the last one we were w food was almost gone. I couldn't help it. The organizer's hungry.

"Finally, it's over," Calix said irritably.

"Let's go! Let's go!" Edrix urged.

We started walking back to our spot. I had only taken a f tray suddenly flew into the air and landed on the ground.

My food!

"Oops! Sorry," Freya said with a laugh.

I wanted to get mad at her and confront her, but sadness Sadness because the floor got to enjoy my food instead c

"Here we go again," I heard David whisper.

I was still staring at the overturned tray. Even though I h more than ten bites of rice and viande, it wasn't enough!

"Excuse me?!" she snapped back.

"Do you know how hard it is for a pig to get fat just to be said, pointing at the pieces of lechon on the ground.

"What?!"

"The lechon."

"Jay-jay has a deep connection with lechon."

"...it almost didn't get chosen because there was a bigger
drowned in deep

sadness!" I added.

Almost everyone was staring at me and what I was pointing
control my irritation.

The lechon!

"What the hell are you talking about?!" Freya asked irritably.

"Obviously, this!" I answered, pointing at the pieces of lechon.
just how you are! Did you even think about the pig's feelings
chosen to become lechon? Of course, it was so happy."

"HUH?!" Everyone around me responded in unison.

"What...the...fvck?!" She raised an eyebrow. "What's the between what you're saying and what I did?"

My eyebrows furrowed in irritation. "Connection? There There's no internet, and it's not paid for!"

I felt a hand on my shoulder. I looked and saw Ci-N. he his head, as if sympathizing with me.

"Jay..." he started. "...whatever you're going through with took a deep breath. "...just eat it, because we don't under

I was about to speak again, but Yuri suddenly put his arm like he was about to strangle me. I glared at him.

"Let's go! Stop being dramatic," he said, pulling me awa

I tried to resist, but his grip was too tight.

"Crazy," I heard Freya say.

I had no choice but to walk with these annoying snakes. wasn't done making Freya realize what the lechon went t

When we got back to our spot, I sat down with my arms back. My eyebrows were still furrowed as I stared at Sec

You think... Piggy's going to haunt you.

I didn't want to take it. It was his food, and I would be the one who was still hungry because Freya ruined my meal earlier.

"Let's just share," I suggested.

He sighed and sat beside me. I smiled as I took the tray from him and started eating. I gave it back to him after taking a bite or two.

It was like the first time we shared food. We took turns eating and both hungry then and had no choice but to share.

But why did I share with him back then?

He suddenly flicked my forehead. I held it and immediately felt pain.
That hurt, you jerk!

"Ow! What did I do to you?!" I asked irritably.

"You were smiling to yourself," he answered, which confused me.

Smiling? Seriously! I just remembered the time we shared food and smiled without realizing it. *What the—?!* So embarrassed.

I just took the tray from him and continued eating. I didn't even think anything of my smile.

After eating—I mean, after smiling—we went back to our original activities. We weren't part of their activities anyway.

Little brat!

This kid is so annoying. he had to remind everyone about even get to lie down on the hammock because Yuri came and they had to leave so he could lie down instead.

Serves you right!

We all found our spots. Some of them slept because they were up late because of what I did last night. Others played cards or betted. Some were just chatting, and of course, that was

"What did you tell them?" he asked about the school play.

"I said no. I didn't know anything about that," I answered.

"How did they convince you?"

"They threatened to tell our adviser. They said they'd tell him if I didn't agree."

"Why were you chosen?"

"Of course... To get back at me. Those classmates of mine."

"What was the story about?"

"They made it up. It was about a beautiful maiden who was kidnapped by a witch. And the prettiest girl in our class played the role of the witch."

"I am Barracuda, and I need a virgin in exchange for eternal life," he mimicked what I said, which I also heard in the video.

I cringed. he was so amused by what he said. he even raised his hand and opened his mouth wide.

"It was longer than that! I just forgot the other lines."

"What did they say when you went on stage drunk?" he asked.

"Nothing."

"Nothing? Why nothing?"

"They found out too late. After the program ended, I suddenly felt sick."

"Where did you go?"

"To the bathroom. I kept throwing up. There were even rumors that I was pregnant."

"What did you say?"

"I told them the truth, that I was drunk. But no one believed me. The rumor that I was pregnant was stronger."

he suddenly burst out laughing, even slapping his thigh. I was shocked. I never saw him like that; my classmates back then were so clueless. Even now, I can't believe it.

"Why are you even telling me about her?" I cut him off.

The conversation had shifted to Veronica, whom I hadn't
kid has a weird way of telling stories. The topic just char
noticing.

"Just because," he answered quickly.

"Maybe you have a crush on Veronica?" I teased him.

he glared at me. I just laughed when he suddenly blushed
Rakki about this?*

"NO!" he shouted loudly, as if he was mad. "...don't ever
What if Rakki finds out..." His voice got softer as he pou

I just laughed at him. *Guilty!* I only asked once, and th
It's just a simple crush, so it's not a big deal. Besides, he'

he kept pushing me like a kid trying to get rid of a playm
getting annoyed, I just laughed even more. he was bowin
to hide his face.

"What about Rakki? There's Veronica now," I teased him

"It's just a crush... I still like Rakki," he answered, poutin

So you admit it.

he told me to forgive them because they had sinned great. I didn't clarify what he meant. That's why I'm still confused.

he suddenly stood up and stared in one direction. I thought I was wrong, so I stood up too. I even brushed off my clothes.

"What?"

"J-just going to the restroom," he said and quickly ran away.

It was so obvious he was avoiding my questions again. I was so annoying!*

I just took my phone and checked the time. We had been there for four hours.

I saw Felix starting to light the pile of branches in the middle of the camp. It was starting to get dark. Eman was also starting to prepare wood for the fire to cook. I immediately went to him to help.

"You and Ci had a long chat," Eman commented while handing out paper plates—so we wouldn't have to wash dishes, we'd just throw them away.

"he's so talkative!"

He just nodded and continued. The other snakes were likely to have had just woken up from their nap and were still stretching.

With a few more minutes, the camp was finally set up.

"Just eat that."

Ci was stomping his feet like a child. I raised an eyebrow

"Come on! I saw them over at the hall! They're playing t
insisted.

"Who's them?" Calix asked.

"The other sections."

Oh right, we were the only ones not participating.

"Come on! Please..." Ci pleaded, looking at me as if beg

"O-okay with me. We're not doing much anyway," I said
others.

The others reluctantly agreed. I looked at the King, who
smiled and nodded. The others just scratched their heads

We ate first before starting the game Ci-N wanted to play
the area. We sat in a circle around the bonfire.

They took some alcohol from the cooler. They all looked
suddenly burst out laughing.

Fine! Gang up on me.

"That's gross!"

"Sala-Ola!"

"Gross? This is just the drink for those who don't want to face the truth," he said, showing us the bottle of Pepsi mixed

"You're disgusting. Let's just start so we can finish," Josh

"Explain the mechanics," Felix said.

"Like this..." Ci handed the bottle to Drew, who was beginning to sing while passing the bottle around. When the song stopped, the bottle points to who will be asked truth or dare."

"Totally original, huh?" Denzel commented sarcastically

"Let's start!" Ci said cheerfully and sat beside me.

he took out her phone and played some music. We sang along, even clapping.

We passed the bottle around. Some passed it quickly, while others slowed it down on purpose before handing it to the next person.

Suddenly, the music stopped, and we all stopped singing at...

Josh

"Are you gay?" Blaster asked directly.

We all burst out laughing. *What an idiot!* I glanced at them and they were just laughing along.

I wasn't sure if they were just pretending not to be affected or if they really didn't care.

"No," Josh answered casually.

"Why don't you have a girlfriend yet?" Drew asked.

"Because of her..." Josh answered seriously, staring at them. "You probably already know."

Not me!

Suddenly, everyone became serious. I didn't know what was going on. I've only heard a little about Josh.

I know he has a sixth sense or a third eye. He had a girlfriend who died in an accident.

Was that what he was referring to?

"But... Bro. She's been dead for a long time, right? Maybe not," Felix said.

That's definitely what he meant. Josh smiled bitterly.

The order of who would ask was no longer followed. It seemed others didn't want to ask anymore. They just let whoever

"Yeah..." Josh answered boredly. "...it's probably in our grandparents' cousins, and uncle have it. Only my parents don't."

Ci-N raised his hand. "What's the most unforgettable thing?"

Josh suddenly became serious and stared at Ci. It was like a wrong question or shouldn't have asked that.

"Someone's death," he answered directly, sending shivers down my spine. "...And I don't like it."

Holy crap! That was so creepy.

"Damn! That was creepy," Eren commented.

"I have a question," I said, grabbing their attention.

Josh stared at me. I could also see a hint of anger in his eyes. He wanted to ask this in front of everyone, but I didn't have a chance to ask privately.

"Why are you mad at me?"

They all looked at him. They were waiting for his answer. I noticed his sudden mood swings toward me.

We all looked at him. *Wow!* Only Kuya Angelo has done that. He was glaring at Josh, and Josh was glaring back at him. The first time I've seen Josh look at him like that.

So cool!

"If no one has any more questions for Josh, let's get back to the game," Kuya Angelo said, and we all sat back down.

I don't know where this game will take us. But I have a feeling it won't end without some drama.

Chapter 180: No more secret

Jay-jay's POV

"...Do the Miley twerk!" Ci-N shouted at Blaster.

We were still playing Truth or Dare. Fortunately, the bottle hadn't landed on me yet. Blaster was the seventh one to get the bottle this time.

It seemed like the sleepy ones had woken up and were now fully participating. The teasing was loud, especially when David did the Buckle Up.

"Dance now!" Felix shouted, already holding his phone to film.

Blaster had no choice but to twerk. We all laughed loudly, and he looked like he was having a seizure with his stiff movements.

"Enough! Your dancing is so annoying!" Calix shouted and waved his hand.

Blaster scratched his head and stopped. He went back to his seat and started passing the bottle and singing again.

And wouldn't you know it, the idiots deliberately sped up their game and suddenly stopped when the bottle landed on me.

Damn it!

"I said... I'll choose Truth!"

These jerks didn't even give me a choice. But Truth was knows what they'd make me do if I chose Dare.

We waited for Rory's question. But the shameless guy la all looked like idiots staring at him.

"Jay..." he started while still laughing. "...how many time Keifer?"

Oh crap!

Sometimes, I really want to punch a friend. Those friend that they drag you into their craziness. The other snakes loudly.

"You're such an animal!" I answered him.

"That's not the answer," Ci-N said, laughing at me.

I look so stupid!

Why would I answer that? Are they crazy? If these were probably get offended. Thank goodness I know how they

"She doesn't want to answer. Jay-jay has to drink the Per

"No way!" I quickly refused. "Your question is so stupid

His bored expression slowly turned into a smile. He look
as if showing off.

*If you dare mention that New Year thing, this Pepsi bot
to your face!*

"That smile... Looks like there's something there," Calix

"Nothing!" I shouted.

Keifer's smile was so annoying. *Ugh!* Add to that his s
like he was giving them a clue.

"Just answer the question," Rory said.

"We've only kissed! I don't even have any experience!" I all laughed.

I probably shouldn't have added that last part. Their laugh and I knew they'd tease me even more. I could feel my cheeks looked down.

So annoying!

Now I feel the struggle of being the only girl in our Sect
Ugh!*

"You were looking for a virgin last night. You should've

nervous about his question.

The others were also waiting for an answer.

Honestly, I couldn't even answer that to myself. David had been with me and Ci-N in our shenanigans. He treated there's no special occasion. Even though he looks so serious, he enjoys being with us.

But no matter how I look at it, it doesn't seem like there's anything special about it. We're just friends, and that's how he sees me too.

If I say no, he might get upset with me. If I say yes, I'm not sure he might get his hopes up.

He suddenly laughed, so I looked at him. "W-what?"

"You don't have to take it seriously," he said, which made me feel better.

I just laughed, even though it was forced. "W-well... You know what?"

The annoying snakes laughed, even though some of them were faking it. David just shook his head at their antics. They were just snakes.

"What's an Ulupong?" Ci-N, who was beside me, asked.

Oh no!

The others looked at him curiously. I hadn't even told him I thought he'd forgotten that I called him that. I forced a smile and charm my way out of it.

If I'm even charming!

"...So you mean I'm the King of the Crazy People?!" he asked.

I smiled even wider, showing my teeth if I had to. But it was because he was glaring at me.

"N-not exactly----"

"Wait!" Felix cut me off. "...If Keifer is the King, are we?"

Oh no!

I stared at them. I couldn't even blink. I was hesitant to speak because they'd definitely get mad at me and get back at me.

Why did I even call them that?

"That's us, right? I'm right!" Felix shouted.

I just bowed my head in embarrassment.

"You're the crazy one, Jay!"

"Nice nickname for us "

Don't do that! Don't scare me. That's bad, especially for already scared.

"Because of that... You have to answer all our questions,"

"Didn't you already ask one?" Drew asked him.

"That doesn't count."

"Don't cheat!" Denzel scolded him.

"That doesn't count!" he insisted, facing me. "...tell me! 'The most handsome among us?'"

"Oh, Ci! You already know the answer to that. Of course answered.

"Huh?! Where?!" Rory asked, squinting at his face. "...do The most handsome is right in front of you," he said, ref

And so the bragging began. I didn't even get to answer th they were all insisting that they were the most handsome

Oh well! They're all handsome. So embarrassing!

"Enough of that!" Yuri said irritably. "...you're just causi

"Fine, let's ask something else," Ci said. "...who's the ugl

With all the pointing, the majority of the fingers were pointing at me. I was so annoyed at everyone.

Nice! Poor Ci.

"Pointing at the ugly one..." he said, clinging to my arm. "You're bullying me."

he looked like a child tattling to a parent. I cringed at his look like his parent?*

"I'll ask next," Kit said, and the attention shifted to him. "How did you get that?"

"What scar?"

"What?"

Yuri and Keifer asked almost simultaneously. They didn't join our little swimming session earlier.

No one spoke. Everyone was looking at me, waiting for all my friends. Honestly, they should know something about me. No matter what I do, the fear is still there. The fear of what they think of me.

"Jay-jay..." Keifer called me.

I just bowed my head and looked at my hands. I was fidgeting.

a bit of my past.

"...I don't know what really happened to me. They asked and mentioned some names----but I didn't know any of them."
"...I had a lot of wounds on my body----including the one on my leg. It took a while before I was discharged, but instead of taking Mom, they took me to Grandma..."

I sighed. It felt so heavy whenever I remembered the time at the hospital. There wasn't a day I didn't wait for Mom to visit. But nothing hurt more than when they told me she didn't want me all.

"...when I got home, that's when I found out what happened. I overheard my uncles and aunts talking. They said I was Mom's last husband. And apparently, her previous husband was me..." Tears fell from my eyes. I couldn't hold them back. "What's strange is that I don't remember any of what they told me... I tried to remember the names they mentioned..." I and sighed. "...but nothing."

"Episodic Amnesia..." Josh suddenly said, and we all looked at him.
"...That's the loss of specific parts of your memory. It can happen. It might not."

"I-I don't know."

"Have you seen a doctor again?" Yuri asked.

"Your stepdad is crazy!" Ci said angrily. "...Don't let him me!"

"Oh, what are you going to do?" David challenged him.

"Hi, Stepdad!" he said, waving and smiling.

We all laughed at what he did. I thought he was going to serious. he's so good at breaking the tension.

"You're crazy, Ci-N!"

"All bark, no bite!"

"Ci-N, as always!"

"How would I know? I don't even know him. Of course, first," he said, pouting.

"Enough of that!" Blaster shouted. "Let's continue the ga gotten my revenge yet!"

We laughed a little. The others adjusted their positions. \ and passing the bottle again.

While singing, I watched them. It might sound dramatic, happy I ended up in this Section. I've probably said it a f always be grateful for it.

he smiled back and went back to his spot. The singing stopped. I looked for the bottle. I was so shocked when it landed on the ground.

"Truth or Dare?!" we all asked in unison.

"Truth," he answered quickly.

Damn it!

Why did you choose that? I have a strong feeling that he knows about us. I also know that he knows about it!

"I'll go first!" Rory said. "...When did you start liking Jay?"

I knew it!

"I don't know... Maybe a few weeks after she joined us," he said casually.

"Did you know Keifer likes her too?" Mayo asked.

"Yes... It's obvious," he answered and smiled.

Why do you look so calm? I suddenly felt a heavy presence. When I looked, Keifer was staring at me intently.

I immediately stood up and went to him. He held my hand. I felt something strange. It was like he was angry even though he was smiling.

I was about to speak up to stop them, but someone beat r
caused a sudden shock.

No!

Chapter 181: Midnight Co

Jay-jay's POV

The whole Section E was kind to me—even though they mischief. Of course, I also had some conflicts with other and Yuri.

There was Eman, because I messed with his stuff. But w okay after I helped out at their family's restaurant.

Then there was Felix, because of what happened with A also became cool after I helped him get back into the bas

Blaster and I had a little disagreement during a group act quickly patched things up.

Mayo and I had issues because of that stupid parkour inc because Kit tried to kiss me. He's so jealous! But we bec punched him.

And now, it seems like I have a new enemy. Someone's a seems to hold a grudge. But I didn't expect things to esca

"When are you planning to tell us about you two?" Josh

"I heard you..." He stood up and looked at me before turning to Yuri. "...when are you going to tell everyone that you're

"What?!"

"Is that true?"

"Since when?!"

"Are you messing with Keifer?"

One by one, they stood up, their eyes darting between me and Keifer for one of us to answer.

Damn it!

I looked at Josh, pleading with my eyes, but he just glared at me. What did I do to him? Why is he so mad at me? Did I cause too much of a section for him to hate me this much?

"What?! No one's going to answer?!" Felix asked angrily.

I couldn't answer. I couldn't think of anything to say. Because our engagement is real, but we chose to keep it a secret from everyone.

"Keifer! Don't you have anything to say?!" Rory asked him.

"That engagement is a deal between their families. Jay-jay has nothing to do with it. End of discussion." he replied calmly.

working for Percy!"

"What?!" Felix shouted angrily and immediately approached
"...you're in contact with Percy?! Is that true?!"

"Damn it! What else don't we know?!" Drew said angrily

"Why don't you answer that?!" Denzel yelled at him. "...
know you've been gambling again?!"

"You have no right to talk about that! Take care of your
since you can't even stand up for them!"

Denzel's fist immediately flew toward Drew's face. May
break them up.

Everything was chaos again. Everyone was trying to stop
just holding onto Keifer, who was angrily arguing with I
Felix.

"Don't act all high and mighty! You might've forgotten a
done!" David shouted at Keifer.

The King didn't hold back and went straight for David to
was caught in the middle. I didn't know what to do. Ever
again. Everyone was in chaos, trying to stop each other.

I felt so heavy. This is all my fault. There's no one else to

"Don't you dare talk to Jay-jay like that!" Ci-N shouted at Josh.

They started throwing punches at each other. I tried to stop but they pushed me away. I just knelt down, feeling weak.

"Stop..." My voice was barely audible, but I needed them to stop. Please!"

No one was listening. I took a deep breath to hold back my tears and to face all of them. They needed to stop.

Enough! Stop it!

"Stop it!" I shouted, but no one paid attention.

"PLEASE! STOP IT!" I screamed at the top of my lungs.

One by one, they started to stop and turned to face me. I had red streaked cheeks.

"Look at yourselves!" I said, looking at them. "...You're doing petty things!"

"You just don't understand," Felix said calmly, but the rest of them were there.

"Then explain it to me! Make me understand!"

We looked toward the flashlight approaching us. The person turned it off when they saw it was already bright enough. That's how we saw who it was.

It was Sir Alvin, along with two organizers and two guys. I quickly composed myself, afraid they'd notice we were f

"Section E... What's going on here?" Sir Alvin asked calmly.

No one dared to answer. Everyone avoided his gaze. Only the courage to approach them. He forced a smile and scratched his head.

"J-just a little commotion. You know... just some teasing hands," he said, making excuses.

"We were told you were fighting," Sir Alvin said, looking at Yuri.

Yuri looked at us, clearly asking for help. We didn't know what to say to them.

Sir Alvin seemed to notice the problem. He turned to the guys and the two organizers.

"It seems like there's nothing to worry about. It's just a little misunderstanding," Sir explained.

"But Sir... They were really fighting earlier. They were talking about it."

"Explain what happened," Sir ordered Yuri.

"It was just a little misunderstanding. We were playing a game," I explained, scratching the back of his head.

Sir looked at all of us, and his gaze stopped at me. I just looked down. I knew I looked like a mess since I had been drinking.

"You better clean up and go to sleep. Throw away those bottles," Sir ordered, pointing at the empty bottles they had been drinking from.

Thankfully, only Sir saw that. If it had been one of the other guards, I would've been in big trouble.

I helped clean up. Some of them avoided me, while others stared at me. Even though we weren't done cleaning, I decided to go to my tent and get my things.

I wanted to clean myself up. Maybe it would make me feel better. I went to the restroom, but the line was long.

Great!

I had no choice but to wait in line. But with every person passing, the line even heavier. After what they found out, I knew they'd all probably felt like I was playing with the two of them.

I'm engaged, but I still flirted with others. I'm so stupid. I

I suddenly had a bad feeling about what I was hearing. V like they're talking about us? I subtly hid behind the girl continued listening.

"What else do you expect from their section?" her friend

"They're so handsome... but they're just troublemakers."

"Tell me about it!"

"It's such a waste for Grace... She ended up with her boy useless."

I knew they were talking about Denzel. I'm used to gossip about your friends, it really pisses you off.

"What's the only girl in their section doing?"

"Nothing... She was just crying in the middle. She couldn't classmates from fighting."

"She probably thought it would be fun to be in that section know, it's hell."

They laughed a little. Even though I wanted to confront them the energy. I felt too heavy to even argue.

I endured their gossip while waiting in line. It took a few

Now you're playing dumb?!

I walked outside. Every step felt heavy. It was like my body was being pulled back to our site. I hadn't even gone far from the restroom when I stopped.

There was someone sitting on the rocks near where I was standing. When they felt my presence, they looked at me and stood up.

I already had an idea of who it was, even though it was dark. They were standing. They walked toward me, into the light. I saw their sad face.

"Jay... I'm sorry about what happened earlier," Yuri said.

I shook my head. "You don't have to apologize. It's my fault."

He held my hand. "Jay—"

"Let go of her hand."

I immediately pulled my hand away. I felt scared of the person. Yuri and I both looked at him. It was Keifer, angry but trying to control himself.

He walked up to me and held my hand. He subtly pulled me toward him.

"Yes, they already know you're engaged, but that doesn't mean it's right to hold her hand in front of me," he said authoritatively.

"L-let's go back," I whispered.

They exchanged sharp glances. It was like they were having a contest.

Don't get in the middle! You'll get stabbed!

"K-Keifer," I called.

I thought they'd keep at it for a while. Thankfully, he finally followed him, still holding his hand.

I tried to look back at Yuri, but Keifer seemed to have a subtle pull. He subtly pulled my hand before I could even get a good look.

Wow! I had nothing to say.

Once we were far enough, I pulled my hand away from him. He glared at me.

"Why did you have to do that to Yuri?" I asked, trying to sound calm.

"Now you're concerned about him?" he asked sarcastically.

"I've always been concerned about him. It's just that we're not talking about the same Yuri."

"Then he shouldn't interfere!" he shouted, cutting me off.

Some were already preparing to sleep when I got back. Some were cleaning up, while others were talking. It was like I suddenly. No one paid attention to me.

I went straight to my tent and decided to just sleep. I was sure Snorlax would still sleep next to me. I just hugged Snorlax tightly.

I felt like crying because of how heavy everything felt. It was my fault they're like this. If only I had thought things through before making decisions.

You're so stupid, Jay-jay!

Out of sheer exhaustion and crying, I eventually fell asleep. I felt slightly better when I felt someone hugging me.

Ci-N was the first one I thought of, so I just let it be. I was sure only I could just not wake up so all the problems would go away.

I hadn't been asleep for long. I think it was only two or three minutes. I woke up again. I felt warm breath on the back of my neck. Snorlax was hugging me tightly. Snorlax, who I had been hugging earlier.

I tried to turn around to check on Ci, thinking he might've moved. I hugged Snorlax as a leg pillow again. My eyes widened when I saw Snorlax hugging me and sleeping next to me.

You're not Ci-N!

I lightly poked his sharp nose. His body didn't react, so I spent a long time examining every corner of his face.

His skin is so smooth—my pores are jealous. Do you even get pimples? They come one by one, but they're so big. Thankfully, I have deep marks on my face.

I've only seen him sweat heavily once. But instead of smelling bad, he smelled good. Is his sweat naturally fragrant?

I looked at his eyebrows. I remembered the time I drew on his forehead with a marker. I thickened his eyebrows. My hand instinctively touched his face. I used my finger to trace the shape of his eyebrows.

My finger moved down to his nose and then to his lips. His lips are redder and thinner than mine. How many people has he kissed? I removed my finger from his lips. They were so soft, like butter. Like balm.

I suddenly felt a pang of sadness and pain in my heart. When I think about what he's been through, I feel so sad. I wish I could've been there during those times. I would've been there for him.

I used my hands to prop up my cheeks so I could look at him more closely. My gaze stopped at his eyelids.

I remembered his gaze—the one that could kill you, the one that made you feel like you'd have a heart attack if he stared at you for too long.

And I didn't know that when I finally felt this, I'd end up else.

"...I don't think I can handle it if you leave me," I added.

I looked at his lips, and it was like I was magnetically drawn. I slowly leaned closer to him. You're asleep, so you won't

Just a little closer, and there would be no space between suddenly stopped.

I noticed his lips were moving slightly. I stared at them as he pouting.

Are you awake?

"Keifer," I called him.

I waited to see if he'd move, but he didn't. I looked at his lips, but they weren't moving anymore. I stared at him for a long time, growing my suspicion.

"If you will kiss me... Do it now," he said, his voice hoarse.

I smiled and immediately slapped his arm hard. He opened his eyes and glared at me.

"You jerk! What are you doing here?" I whispered angrily.

"I just... miss you," he said, almost in a whisper.

I couldn't help but smile at what he said. If only he knew
Even though we see each other every day, it still feels like

"I miss you too," I said.

He smiled at me and hugged me. "Please... just for tonight
passionately."

I let out a small laugh. He sounded like he was begging.
something when we suddenly heard rustling outside.

It was as if someone was walking around. Keifer immediately
from me and gestured for silence with his finger. I nodded.

He slightly unzipped the tent and peeked outside. He stayed
while, making me uneasy—was there really someone at our
campsite?

But who?

Suddenly, Keifer unzipped the tent completely and stepped
on his slippers and walked towards Yuri's hammock.

It was like he was looking for something, but when he finally
quickly came back.

"What is it?" I asked, my heart racing.

"I'm coming with you," I said, but he quickly shook his h

"...I'm coming with you," I insisted.

"Jay-jay..."

"Come on," I pushed.

Even though he was reluctant, he had no choice but to ag
deep sigh.

I put my phone back in my bag and grabbed a hooded ja

Where were we going to follow Yuri? We had no idea.

Chapter 182: Bridge

Jay-jay's POV

Each step was light, like a ninja, making sure no one would hear. I moved through the dark and among the plants, ensuring no one would notice.

"What are you doing?" the King asked me.

I looked at him beside me. He was standing where anyone could see him, while I remained hidden like a ninja.

"Don't stand there. Someone might see you." Camouflage

"Jay... it's midnight. Everyone's asleep."

He had a point. Who would be awake at this hour—except Yuri? On earth was that Yuri going?

We looked down the hall and saw a small light. It seemed like a small flashlight, reflecting off something glass-like.

The light moved, and that's when we realized what it was. It came from Yuri's phone, which he was using to illuminate his path. His reflection had come from his glasses.

Yuri headed toward the back of the hall, so we followed. The only place he could be going—the fishpond, where a bridge and gazebo in the middle.

I wasn't wrong. Before we could get any closer, we saw

I glanced at Keifer, but he showed no reaction. He quickly found a place where we could hide nearby.

He forced me to crouch in the thick bushes while he stood. I looked at Yuri, but he and Ella weren't saying anything.

"What do you want?" Yuri finally broke the silence.

"...Does Aries know about this?"

Ella shook her head. "I-I just really wanted to talk to you

For what?!

"Yuri deserves to know the truth."

—Ella (Chapter 174)

Is this what she and Mica were talking about in the bathhouse when they'd meet. So this was it. But what truth? What was it about

A mix of worry and fear filled me. My mind was torn—should I listen to their conversation? A large part of me said to leave and not

You should be asleep!

"Yuri!" Ella suddenly yelled. "...Listen to me. You need t

Yuri didn't speak and simply waited for her to continue. I
head several times, fidgeting with her fingers, clearly res

"Do you really love Jay-Jay now?" she asked.

W-wait!

Yuri sighed and visibly held back his frustration. He let c
laugh.

"You asked me to meet you for that?"

"Please answer me," Ella pleaded.

"Yes, I do!" Yuri replied proudly.

I looked at Keifer, but he was focused on them. Even thc
was on them, he couldn't hide the way he clenched his fi

"...If that's all you had to say, I'm leaving," Yuri added, t
away.

"Yuri!" Ella called out again, tears now streaming down
sorry."

"Your mom talked to me. She told me to stay away from you. She wouldn't allow us to have a relationship," she explained.

"I-I don't understand," Yuri said, confused.

"She said I wasn't good enough for you. She told me that if I was with you alone, my family would never be able to set foot in Italy. I was scared... I was really scared, Yuri."

"I don't get it! Cut to the chase, Ella!" Yuri yelled angrily.

"You were the one I really loved, not Keifer!"

Sh*t!

It felt like someone had punched me in the chest. My head spun. Slowly, I looked at Keifer. He had turned his back on me and was leaning against the tree with his head lowered.

I couldn't see his expression clearly, but I could feel his anger. His hands were still tightly clenched. I wanted to approach him, to tell him everything, but what could I say?

Now I understood the depth of his hatred for Yuri.

I looked back at them. No one spoke. Ella continued crying. I was visibly shocked.

~~~~~

*"Usotsuki!"*

Yuri suddenly yelled. "Liar!"

(A/N: Usotsuki = Liar)

I didn't understand what he said. Even Ella seemed confused. Yuri ran his fingers through his hair repeatedly, pacing in a completely lost.

He took off his glasses and held his forehead.

"I-I don't understand... Yuri."

Yuri stepped closer and pointed at her. "

*Urusai!*

"

(A/N: Urusai = Shut up)

"I don't understand!" Ella shouted back.

You're not the only one! I think he's cursing at you!

Yuri took a deep breath, trying to calm himself. He covered his face multiple times.

"So you chose to hurt me?" Yuri exhaled deeply. "...Do you?"

"It's the truth... Keifer knows it too. Your mom talked to him on the same day he beat you up."

I automatically looked at Keifer. This time, he was staring in that direction, hands in his pockets, deep in thought.

"You knew?" I whispered.

"I don't want to talk about it," he quickly replied, sighing.

Then, I suddenly remembered my conversation with Ci-] I had never ever seen Keifer truly angry.

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*Flashback*

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"Ci..." I called the little brat.

"Hm?" he answered while eating his ice cream.

"Have you ever seen Keifer angry? Like, really, really angry?"

Since he had been with Keifer longer, I couldn't help but

"We didn't know why. He was just furious, punching Yuri crying, trying to stop them."

(See Chapter 134: Anger)

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*End of Flashback*

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That was the real reason. Keifer was furious because Ella hit him. Because she always chose Yuri.

I don't think I can listen anymore. I want to leave, but my... I looked at them again when Ella suddenly screamed Yuri.

"Enough!" Yuri shouted.

I didn't understand myself. It felt like my heart was aching for them. Seeing how much the past still affected them.

Because it shouldn't matter anymore.

"Answer my question! Why are you only telling me this angrily.

"Because... Because I can't hide it from you anymore. I've been waiting for you to talk to me again. I waited for that "sh

"...It hurts so much." He pointed at his heart. "...I change a different person, hoping that you would choose me too didn't. Because then, you wanted Aries!"

"I'm sorry, Yuri."

"Sorry?" He let out a bitter laugh. "...Did your sorry char

Ella tried to step closer to him, but he quickly moved aw

"Yuri... Please."

"Why? Ella, WHY?!" Yuri shouted again, his tears fallin  
"...Why didn't you fight for me?"

My tears fell on their own. I couldn't stop myself from fe  
words. I also couldn't understand why he even had to ask

Do you still love him?

"Jay..." Keifer called my name.

I quickly wiped my tears away. I took a deep breath to ea  
my chest. Then, I looked at him and forced a smile.

Keifer took a deep breath and turned back to face Ella. I  
and his posture straighten. My heartbeat sped up, and I a  
look at them. I hoped I was wrong about what I was thin

Yuri and Ella immediately pulled away from each other. turned to Aries. His face was filled with rage as he slowl them.

I quickly stepped out from where I had been hiding. I ha forgotten that they didn't know I was here.

Yuri looked at me in confusion. "Jay?"

"What is this?!" Aries asked angrily, making all of us tur him. "...What is this, Ella?!"

Fear was evident on Ella's face. "A-Aries... B-because..."

"Explain yourself, NOW!"

Even I felt scared. I had never seen him this angry before terrifying.

They really are all the same!

"Aries... I-I was just telling him the truth." Ella explained again.

"What for?" Aries briefly glanced at Yuri before looking you still have feelings for him?"

Ella didn't say a word. Even I was waiting for her answer

through his hair.

"You told me before. You explained to me—made it clear you would forget your feelings for him," Aries said calmly, pausing. "...Then what the fvck is this?"

"Aries..." Ella continued sobbing.

"You begged me. You asked me to save you from Keifer so you wouldn't want to end up like Freya... I gave you what you wanted. I made you happy." Aries suddenly started crying.

It hurt me even more to see him like this. It hurt more than the Keifer cry. He was still my blood relative, and we were close. I couldn't help but be affected.

"...In exchange for our deal that you would stay away from those guys! That you would forget about Keifer, and most of all, Yuri!" He took a deep breath. "...But what is this?!"

Ella collapsed to the ground, sobbing uncontrollably. She was barely able to breathe. Aries turned his gaze to her. In a moment of hesitation, punched her.

I was shocked by what he did and immediately rushed to her.

Yuri fell to the ground, and Aries was about to punch him. I stepped in between them.

Damn it! Keifer! I quickly looked at the tree where he was still there, just watching as if it was an intense scene in a

"Keifer! Stop them!" I ordered.

He didn't react or move closer. I thought he was going to but instead, he suddenly punched Aries. Aries fell hard and lost consciousness.

What the hell?! I said to stop them, not join in!

"Aries!" Ella screamed and ran toward him.

I was about to yell at her, but I stopped. Keifer and Yuri looked at each other, exchanging sharp glares, as if they were about to fight too.

"You knew... But you didn't tell me." Yuri spoke calmly.

"For what? Why would I tell you?"

Keifer's tone was almost taunting. I wanted to step between them but I was afraid I'd get caught in the middle too. I might end up fighting even more.

"What did Hahaoya say to you?"

Keifer took a deep breath. I knew he didn't want to answer but he had to.



I immediately ran over to them. "Aries."

"Jay... H-he's not waking up." Ella sobbed.

I looked at Keifer. Was his punch really that strong to kn

"...He said he couldn't breathe, then he lost consciousness

I felt a wave of panic. I didn't know what Aries' condition he had lung problems.

"Keifer... Help us," I pleaded.

Keifer didn't say a word. He simply lifted Aries onto his strength. We assisted him, and we quickly headed to the

Unlike us, who were sleeping in tents, they had actual room walls, doors, windows, and air conditioning.

This is totally unfair!

Before I could complain about their accommodations, Ella was banging on the door loudly. She banged so hard it was as if there was someone inside.

I bet they could hear her from the next room too.

"Help us!" she yelled.

I stopped at the door. Aries was going to be okay. They v  
help. I wasn't needed here anymore.

I turned and ran back to the fishpond. I tried to think abc  
gone. He didn't head toward our site—he turned somewh

Shit! HE WENT INTO THE FOREST!

I sprinted in the direction he had taken. It was dark, and  
anything, but I had to find him. He was alone, with no or

But where was he?!

"YURI!" I shouted, but only my echo answered back.

"YURI! ANSWER ME!"

I still didn't hear any response from him. I kept walking.  
path clearly, so I almost tripped.

Then, I saw something glowing. I quickly ran toward it,  
Yuri, but it was just a cellphone. I picked it up and check

It was Yuri's phone!

I was on the right path! He had passed through here. He

"YURI!" I yelled again.

# Chapter 183: A.M.

## Jay-jay's POV

"YU----Aray!" I suddenly tripped.

So unlucky!

I stood up, dusted off my clothes, and did the same with around again. Am I lost?!

I took Yuri's phone from my pocket and checked the time. It was drawn to his wallpaper. It was a picture of the two of us looking at the camera, while he was smiling brightly.

It looks like this was taken in the classroom. He was sitting from the angle and how I looked, it seemed like we were taking it.

I smiled, but at the same time, tears started falling. I suddenly felt like a child, sitting down and hugging my knees.

I'm scared! I'm scared I might never see Yuri's smile again.

"Where are you?!" I cried, continuing to sob.

"Damn it!" I muttered angrily.

I was about to resume searching when, just my luck, I stepped on the edge of a cliff and fell straight down.

I immediately grabbed onto whatever I could.

Thankfully, a large tree root saved me. My heart was pounding and I felt like my soul had left my body.

Shit! A near-death experience?!

This is all Yuri's fault! Damn it! So much drama in life. Why did I wander into the forest?! He could've just stayed in the ha campsite.

Unbelievable! Annoying!

I struggled to pull myself up. Once I was in a safe position, I realized my frustration grew when I realized the cliff wasn't even that high. It was a small river below.

I reached into my pocket to get Yuri's phone, but it was gone.

I frantically patted down my entire body, but I couldn't find anything anywhere.

Damn it!

I carefully climbed down, gripping tightly onto roots and dark, so I had to move slowly.

When I reached the bottom, I almost slipped because of

I immediately searched for Yuri's phone. This is an iPhone

I finally found it in a pile of thick leaves. I picked it up and also checked the time—something I should have done earlier.

2:46 AM.

It's almost morning, yet I'm still here in the forest, searching.

Damn it!

Once I find you, you're really in trouble—

I stopped, stunned. There was a body lying on the other side.

I knew it was a person, even if I couldn't see clearly.

Could it be Yuri?

I ran toward it. I waded through the river, letting half my body get wet just to reach the figure.

But when I got there, my hope shattered. It wasn't a person.

My heart pounded faster. No matter how much I tried to  
kept falling.

Standing in front of me now was the very person I had been moments ago.

"Yuri..." I whispered and crossed the river again to where I was standing before.

I hugged him tightly but pulled away when he let out a s

"S-sorry..." I said, scanning his whole body.

His clothes were torn, and there was a piece of cloth wrapped around his right arm. His face had scratches, and his glasses seemed to have been broken.

"What happened to you?" I asked, filled with concern.

"I-I fell... I heard your voice. I tried to find you, but this is all I could do," he explained.

I started crying again. "Why do you keep wandering off? to be dramatic, why do it in the forest?! Do you know how lost someone here?!" I scolded.

He scratched his head and gave me a sheepish smile. "So you'd follow me."

1100 1110 1120 1130 1140 1150

I scanned our surroundings. I wasn't familiar with this place. Maybe if I followed the river, I'd find the falls where we were swimming.

"Let's go this way," I said, pointing behind him.

I walked ahead, assuming he would follow, but I stopped struggling to walk properly.

He was limping. I quickly went back to support him.

"I-I'm fine," he said.

Yeah, right.

"Who are you fooling?" I asked sarcastically.

He chuckled slightly.

I helped him walk, feeling his pain with each step.

Then, I noticed a fallen tree. One of its branches, full of leaves, was an umbrella.

"Stay here," I told Yuri before approaching the tree.

I checked if it could be used for shelter. Since one branch was an umbrella, it seemed good enough.

No stars. It was possible. I hoped not! If we got sick, we harder time getting back.

"Let's hope it doesn't," he said, leaning against the fallen

It was still dark.

I suddenly remembered Yuri's phone. I took it from my j thing it didn't get wet earlier.

"Here's your phone," I said, handing it to him.

"Thanks."

He pressed the button to light up the screen, and the glove revealing his injuries more clearly.

Scratches and bruises, and a forming black eye.

I cupped his face, making him look at me. I couldn't help

"Where did you fall? Why do you look like this?" I asked to shine light on the rest of his body.

"...You have so many wounds!"

Aside from his arm, there were small cuts all over his arm

"I-I'm okay " he insisted forcing a smile



"No. The rain might catch up with us. Besides, I want to sunrise."

He nodded in acceptance of my response. I wondered what Aries. I was worried about him. I didn't know if it was because of Yuri that he lost consciousness or if it was Keif's punishment.

I DIDN'T EVEN SAY GOODBYE TO HIM!

"Jay... are you okay?" Yuri asked when he noticed the suppressed expression.

Fear and panic were evident in me. He was probably looking for me now. He was probably going crazy searching for me. What if he found me?

I wanted to call him, but I didn't have my phone. I had left it at home earlier, thinking we wouldn't need it. Besides, there was no way I wouldn't be able to use Yuri's phone either.

Damn it! So frustrating!

Out of frustration, I leaned my head back against the log for a moment, but before I knew it, I had fallen asleep.

I woke up to the feeling of something dripping on my face. My eyes, I panicked upon seeing that it was raining. I turned and was hugging myself from the cold.

I tried my best to keep him warm, but he was still shivering. My only choice but to hug him to share body heat.

I gently rested his head against my neck. The rain kept pouring. I was grateful for the small shelter we found—otherwise, we would have been soaked by now.

"Just hold on a little longer. We'll be back at the site soon."

He didn't respond, so I had a strong feeling he had fallen asleep. I wanted to close my eyes. But I couldn't. I stayed awake this.

I fought off my drowsiness. Suddenly, Yuri's phone, which was in his pocket, lit up. The battery sign appeared, indicating that it was low on time. 4:36 AM.

The sun would rise soon!

"Jay..." Yuri whispered. "...Jay."

"What?" I responded, thinking he was awake.

I glanced at him slightly, but his eyes were still shut. It seemed like he was either talking in his sleep or delirious from the fever.

"I'll fight for you..." he whispered again, and I froze. "...I don't want to lose again..." He buried his head into my neck.

But it doesn't work that way.

The heart is foolish—just as foolish as the human brain. problems.

You're almost perfect in every angle. Handsome, rich, sn even be considered a good boy. Yes, you have flaws, but can be adjusted. But despite your perfection, I realized o

I don't deserve you. Someone else better does.

I looked up at the sky, noticing that it was gradually gett reached for Yuri's phone, but it had already shut down. I him up, but we had to go.

"Yuri..." I called, gently tapping him. "...Wake up."

His body was still warm, meaning his fever hadn't gone o softly before slowly sitting up and opening his eyes.

"Let's go... The rain has stopped," I told him.

I stood up first to help him. I don't know why, but he felt before. Maybe earlier, he was trying not to be a burden to he had a fever, he could no longer hold back.

We continued walking, but at a much slower pace than b completely brightened. I could clearly see the dirt on bot

He smiled weakly at me. "I'll be fine... Just need some re

I sat beside him, letting him rest his head on my shoulder. His breathing was something I could not only hear but also f

I hope his condition doesn't get worse.

Suddenly, I heard a stomach growl. He raised an eyebrow

"I haven't eaten since last night," I said with a grin.

He chuckled softly. "We'll eat when we get back."

I nodded. Now my stomach was really making its hunger felt. I stayed here much longer, I might be the next one to get s

Yuri leaned back against my shoulder again. Silence filled the room. I didn't want to bother him since he was resting.

"Did you know..." he suddenly broke the silence. "...Hah, I almost got me to get sick," he said with a smile.

"Every mother is like that," I replied.

"But do all mothers do what she did?"

I fell silent. I didn't know how to answer that since I had experienced it with my own mom—except for when she interfered with my plans.

"...Because of their reputation, they never accepted my n being half-Filipino, her family wasn't well-known. It pai move she made was an embarrassment to the clan. And i more when she found out that she had a slim chance of c

I continued listening to him. Even though he hadn't expe happened to his mother firsthand, I could tell that it still ]

"...So when I was conceived, she took extra care of me. S house to make sure I was safe. They said luck came to th was born," he sighed deeply. "...So they became even mo me. I'm a prince but was never put on the throne. I am th Hanamitchi Clan."

"Only? But you have a sister."

"...Yoichi is adopted," he said, making me freeze.

"H-ha?"

"She was chosen to fill the gap in the family. They need into a pure bloodline of a well-known Yakuza clan. She's she comes from far away."

Damn!

My situation was already depressing, but it turns out it co She's still so young, but there's already an arranged marr

he didn't speak. he suddenly stood up and began walking

I followed him immediately to assist him.

We kept walking, and I still hadn't heard a response from him. He was hiding something from me.

I could already hear the loud rush of water. That meant we were close to where we were going to swim. I looked at Yuri and could see a smile on his face.

I immediately stopped. "Let's rest for a while. You might get a fever."

He didn't respond. he leaned against a tree with his eyes closed, wiping away sweat.

"We're almost there----"

"Jay," he cut me off. "I have something to confess to you."

I stared at him, waiting for what he was about to say. Something that was making my heart race. I started to tremble, but it wasn't because of the heat.

"I-it wasn't Tanda who arranged our marriage," he said, his words making my thoughts even more confused. "Angelo refused when Tanda made the arrangement. That old man doesn't believe in second chances. The chance was gone quickly..." he looked away and took a deep breath.

didn't like you, she forced it."

Tears started falling on their own. "B-but you said before stop the wedding. Y-you said they wanted it."

"I-i lied to you. I'm sorry."

"I don't understand... Why did you do that?"

"Because I love you and I can't lose to Keifer again."

he answered quickly. "...I also want to save you from him

I wiped my tears. A mix of emotions filled me, but mostly myself. I couldn't understand why he had to be so selfish

I shook my head and looked directly into his eyes. "No."

"No. Please don't say that."

"You're just afraid of having your ego crushed!" I tried to

"...You're just afraid of being humiliated again for the sake

"No. It's not like that."

"Okay! If you truly love me, why are you still affected by him? He challenged him.

he looked away and didn't answer. I was right! he still he

Damn! I'm so stupid, Jay!

I could only shake my head at what I learned. About their damned marriage. It's driving me crazy!

I heard voices talking nearby. I went silent and almost at Yuri and I looked up, realizing they were close.

"People!" I almost shouted.

I quickly ran, but stopped when I heard Yuri cry out in pain, mind that he couldn't walk properly.

I assisted him and we slowly walked.

"HELP! THERE'S PEOPLE HERE!" I yelled so they could hear whoever they were. "PLEASE HELP US!"

The voices of the people grew louder, meaning they were closer. I breathed a sigh of relief at our situation.

We were almost back. I wanted to eat and sleep.

"Here!" I heard someone shout.

I was about to shout back when Yuri suddenly grabbed my arm.

Everything happened so fast.



My heart stopped, and I felt like I had died without realizing I would've been the end now.

K-keifer.

He was staring at us with a furious and angry gaze. His face was so tightly, it seemed like he was ready to charge at us.

"K-keifer..." I said, about to approach him, but suddenly, he turned and ran off quickly.

Shit!

I immediately chased after him and only then did I realize I was in Ulupongs. I stopped when they blocked my way.

"Jay! Finally... We found you," Felix said.

I was still staring at Keifer. I had to chase him.

I had to explain things to him.

"Go to Yuri! he's back there!" I said, pointing to where we were.

I didn't wait to hear what they would say. I ran off to catch up. I didn't care about being tired or hungry anymore.

I wasn't disappointed because I caught up with him standing in front of him. I slowly approached him.

I wasn't sure if what he said was a good thing, but my fear dominated me.

# Chapter 184: Wedding Go

## Jay-jay's POV

After the retreat ended unexpectedly. Due to what happened and the other students who were caught with alcohol and organizers decided to end the retreat early.

Aries and Yuri were rushed to the hospital. We left Camp in complete silence with the whole Section E. Even if some of us didn't discuss the chaos that happened. No one wanted to.

The retreat was supposed to last a week, but it was cut short in a few days, so the remaining days felt like a vacation.

It's Saturday now, two days since Aries was hospitalized. I've been ignoring Yuri's texts and calls. For two days, Keifer has been ignoring me.

"Is that so?" I asked Keigan.

"Yeah... Sorry about that," he replied, forcing a smile. ".. I'll call you immediately."

"Okay. Thanks."

Keigan's response to me yesterday was the same as today home yet, after leaving.' It's disheartening. I want to blar what's the point?

I heard my cellphone ring. I pulled over to check it. A text from Kuya Angelo.

From: Kuya Angelo.

Message: 'Where are you? Come home.'

I sighed. Kuya didn't know I left the house. He wasn't around and didn't ask for permission. I quickly pedaled back home. I was quite far from ours. I'm just a reckless bike rider. If it's just a bike more if it's a car?

When I got home, a fancy car greeted me. Rich people! I stood for a moment before pushing my bike into Tita's garage.

I went inside and only then did I realize who owned the house, mom, and she was with who I assumed was their driver.

"Konnichiwa..." she greeted me with a smile and a bow.

I bowed back because I remembered that's how they show respect.

"Konnichiwa."

"Konnichiwa..." she greeted me with a smile and a bow.

"No. It's okay," Yuri's mom interjected. "...No need."

"But—"

But Jay-jay looks like a rag.

"We'll only be out for a short while, so it's fine," she cut about to say.

Kuya had no choice but to agree. Yuri's mom smiled and approached me and linked her arm with mine as if we were

Are we close now, girl?

"Shall we go?" she asked.

"S-sure," I replied hesitantly.

She looked at Kuya Angelo and smiled. "We'll go ahead.

We walked out, straight to their fancy car. I felt so out of quiet the whole ride. I wanted to ask where we were going but I brought myself to do it.

What's really going on?

"Is something wrong, Jay?" she broke the silence.

"N-nothing "

Seriously? Are you mad?

We reached the elevator. Luckily, it was already open, so we didn't have to wait.

"Sorry for rushing. We're already late," she said.

Late for what?

She pressed the button for the 20th floor. There were only a few people with us, and they looked like foreigners. I didn't want to stand out aside from feeling out of place—I REALLY FELT OUT OF PLACE. I didn't want to be rude either.

"H-how's Yuri?" I asked.

Shit, Jay!

Maybe I shouldn't have asked that. Stupid! Now she'll think I was being rude. I had been talking.

"He's okay... Fully recovered already," she replied.

The elevator bell rang, and the door opened. Yuri's mom followed. A strange floor greeted me.

There was a receptionist, and it looked like an office. We were greeted by two women at the reception. They talked for a bit, and then we

"You still look pretty," Gertrude said.

Yuri's mom replied, "Thank you."

Suddenly, Gertrude looked at me, so I forced a smile. He as he scrutinized me from head to toe.

"Shinken ni? Kono shōjo?" (Seriously? This girl?) he said just smiled.

What the—?

I felt like he insulted me. I didn't know how to react. If I look rude.

Should I punch him and say it was an accident?

"Yeah... She's pretty. Right?" Yuri's mom said and gestured closer.

I did and forced a smile at Gertrude. He just smirked and

What's your problem?

I don't have a problem with gay people, but now I might. anything to you, so why are you messing with me? I might I can't handle this.

"Whatever," he said sarcastically. "Let's go."

I felt a chill when I realized why we were here. I looked Yuri's mom, who were in front of me.

They were happily chatting and laughing. They stopped opened a glass door labeled VIP. Yuri's mom entered first Gertrude.

Did they leave me?!

I pushed the door open and entered alone. The first thing circular sofa set. It could probably fit 15 people. There was a curtain in front.

"Beautiful!" Gertrude called me sarcastically.

As I approached him, he walked towards the curtain.

Are we being rude now?!

"Madam Yakito! She's here! Take a look!" he said excitedly and opened the curtain.

In front of five rows of large mirrors, a dazzling white wall caught my eye. I was almost blinded.

"Oh my..." Yuri's mom said happily and immediately approached me.  
"...Look at this! You did a great job."



I can't.

I can't be as happy as she is. After everything Yuri told me that happened. I can't...

A woman arrived and immediately approached the gown mannequin and gestured for me to come closer. Yuri's mother pulled the curtain.

"Please remove your clothes," the woman said.

I hesitated, looking at her. "A-all of it?"

"Just the top... including your undergarments."

Son of a... I'm going topless?

Reluctantly and slowly, I took off my T-shirt. I was about to but... damn!

I stopped and looked at the woman pleadingly. "C-can I stop before I take that off?"

She smiled and nodded. The wedding gown, which looked like it was competing with Marian Rivera's gown, was so hard to put on up to my chest, I finally removed my bra.

She adjusted the back and other parts. She also fixed my hair.

But slowly, my smile faded. Slowly, it dawned on me that I was going to marry someone I don't love. I'm going to marry someone I trusted. Someone I thought was just a victim of the business.

"Don't you like it?"

I was slightly startled. I quickly looked up and saw Yuri's mom. The curtain was already open.

"I-I like it," I forced myself to say.

"That's great to hear," she said and turned to the woman in the dress. "...Leave us for a moment."

The woman nodded and walked away. She left my clothes on the floor before leaving.

Yuri's mom stood in front of me and took out her phone. She pressed a few buttons before pointing the camera at me.

"Smile," she said, and I smiled. "...I'll send this to Yuri."

She pressed a few more buttons before her phone chimed. She looked slightly before facing me.

"He asked if you can go straight to the altar now," she said.

~~~~~

"...but I love my son so much, and I'm willing to sacrifice," said sadly. "...The whole Hanamitchi clan doesn't like me. From the moment I married Yumori, I've been trying to prove that I'm a part of their family, but... they never accepted me."

Y-Yuri mentioned that to me.

She forced a smile and tucked my hair behind my ear.

"I thought it would be like that forever. But when Yuri came, the clan thanked me. To them, he was lucky. He was born at a time when the family business was declining."

Honestly, I don't understand why she's telling me this. But I just listened.

"Smart, cheerful, and obedient. That's my Yuri... I gave him a lot of freedom, though he wasn't asking for it. From the start, he didn't give up. He was my grandfather, but he never backed down to prove himself."

I wanted to ask why she interfered with Yuri's wishes. With Ella. But I held my tongue, as if it didn't want to cooperate.

"I also treated his friends like my own children, especially the closest to him, even though I was against their friendship. I took a deep breath, and that's when I saw her tears forming. "...I introduced me to Ella, everything changed."

Even though I wasn't sure, I hugged her and let her cry o
could feel her pain over what happened to Yuri.

"Please..." she said while still crying. "...love my son."

Damn!

Ask for something else. Not that, not to love him.

"...I can't bear to see him miserable again. I beg you... Lc

I started crying too. I hugged her tightly. I wanted to do
asking. I want to, I really want to!

But I can't!

I love someone else, and no matter what I do, it's him I v
Keifer.

+++++

David's POV

["She's okay... In a few weeks, she can go home."] Percy
line.

"Are you going with her?"

I bowed my head. "Y-yeah."

He ended the call. I looked at the gate of their house. Jay didn't ask me to come here, but I really wanted to.

And see her.

The gate opened, so I quickly got in the car. I didn't want to. I wasn't disappointed in my wait. Jay-jay came out of the garbage bag.

She placed it in front of their gate, next to some sacks of about to go back inside when Angelo suddenly came out scolding her. She just bowed her head, but after her cousin's face and mimicked what her Kuya was saying.

She's really mischievous.

I just laughed. That was enough, so I started the car and

I don't exactly know what I'm doing. I'm head over heels but when I got close to Jay-jay, I suddenly got confused. worse because of my agreement with Percy.

If I hadn't agreed, maybe this wouldn't have happened.

Flashback...

"Eat something, son. I'll buy you something. What do you want?" Cheon's dad, offered.

I immediately stood up. "No, it's fine. I'll buy it myself."

He smiled at me and let me go. I know they're worried about Cheon, but since Cheon was brought back to the hospital, I haven't gone home. I'm not eating well either.

I walked away. I wasn't myself and was just staring blankly. I can't leave. I'm afraid of what might happen while I'm gone. I know I'm okay when she was taken to Hong Kong, but it didn't help.

I kept walking when I bumped into someone. I immediately stopped and apologized.

"S-sorry," I said. "...I didn't mean to."

He was staring at me as if he recognized me. He had blue eyes and he looked Filipino.

"It's okay," he replied.

I went back to walking and headed straight to the hospital. Even though I had no appetite, I forced myself to eat. I didn't want to get sick.

After eating, Tita texted me. The operation was over, and

Tita sat down, but I remained standing. The doctor took a few seconds, pressed a few buttons before showing it to us. It was a vi
ultrasound.

"The operation wasn't successful. We don't want to take a
hole in her heart is too big, along with the swelling of so

I didn't let him finish. I immediately left his office. I pun
of frustration.

"Tsk! Don't take it out on the wall."

I froze at the voice. I immediately looked at him angrily.
eyed guy I bumped into earlier.

"What do you care?!" I asked irritably.

Why is he meddling? I don't know him, and he doesn't k

"David Brewer," he said, stopping me. "...Former presiden

H-how did...?

"D-do I know you?"

He smiled at me, and honestly, I was so confused. I don't
not a student of HVIS—I know. Somehow, he looks arou

"Maybe you've heard the name... David Brew Collins?" he

I didn't shake his hand. My mind became even more tangled. I couldn't understand why he approached me. He retracted his hand and smiled.

"Well... I won't beat around the bush. I would like to offer you a job."

"E-excuse me? A job?"

"Yes... A job." He repeated. "...We can talk about this now or later, if you have time?"

I shook my head at what he was saying. "Look... Mr. Wang. I don't know you. The Percy I knew is dead, and I'm not interested in your offer. Now, if you'll excuse me----."

"I can help Ms. Cheon Sa Kim." He interrupted what I was saying.

I was even more confused about what was going on. How did he know my girlfriend's full name? And what kind of help was he talking about?

"...Her operation wasn't successful. Other hospitals won't operate on her anymore because it's too risky and they don't want to ruin her. He continued. "...The only thing you can do is take her to the hospital where her family can't afford it."

Crap!

How did he know all that? The doctors had been insisting that she

"How can I be sure that you're telling the truth?" I asked, whispering.

He smiled widely. "Let me explain it to you."

He walked to a room. I just followed until we stopped in. He sat on the bed and started explaining. He even showed proof of what he was saying.

He also explained why he was doing this. I was starting to even though I didn't really trust him.

"...I have only one rule," he said after explaining my job. her."

I tried to hide my reaction. How? How can I do that? Well, start, I already feel something else?

But Cheon needs me now. So, despite having many questions

"I accept your offer."

End of Flashback...

Now here I am. So freaking confused about my feelings. feeling this way. I love Cheon, that's why I'm making sacrifices

But when I'm with Jay-jay, my heart beats differently.

Chapter 185: Complicated

Jay-jay's POV

"Love my son."

Damn it! It feels like a broken record in my head, what Y Seriously?! She's the one asking me to love her child. It's more confused. The worst part is, Keifer still isn't answer come home yet. I'm starting to get worried. My mind is a

It's like a mess, a mix of everything.

I heard a knock on the door. I was about to open it, but it and Tita Gema walked in.

She looked anxious and confused. She broke the door an

"Tita?"

"Jay... uhmm... W-what... I... Uh..." she stammered.

I didn't know what the problem was. It was obvious she was something. She looked like she was holding something in trying to hold in a fart.

No matter the reason she was here, I was so happy to see her smile faded slowly when I saw how anxious Tita Gema was.

"T-Tita Gema."

"She's with your Mom... and... her fiancé."

It felt like the sky fell on me. Really now? Now? Why not? Nice!

"Tita... I don't feel well. I-I'm not coming out of my room," I quickly lying down on my bed and covering myself with a blanket.

Tita Gema sat next to me and gently shook me. "No, you have to face your Mom."

I angrily threw the blanket off and gave her a pleading look.

I didn't want to see her, especially now with everything I was going through.

"I don't want to."

"Jay-jay... They're staying here too, so you'll see them."

What kind of day is it today? Is it a day for bad luck? If only it was! So annoying!

"I miss you too, Apo," she replied and hugged me tighter.

"How sweet... I wish you would hug your Mom like that."

The happiness in my heart died instantly when I heard that she wanted to break my hug with Lola, but to be honest, I wasn't sure.

Slowly, I turned to her. She was smiling at me. A smile I had never seen before. A smile that I wanted to wipe off her face.

"Jay-jay, dear..." she called me while waiting for a hug.

"...Mom's waiting."

Well, let her wait.

I looked at Lola and Tita Gema. My brother was signaling for me to hug Mom. I had no choice but to hug her.

The first thing I noticed was the perfume she was wearing. It was the same as the one I remembered from what I remembered. Maybe it had been so long since I last smelled it that I couldn't recall it.

If you look at her, it seemed like she didn't change. She looked even younger and more beautiful. Now I could see how Lola and Tita were so alike.

I tried to pull away from her. I didn't know why, but I couldn't.

"It's fine too."

I knew she was waiting for me to share, but I didn't want say anything to her. Silence filled the room.

Suddenly, a man walked in through the door. All our attention was on him. He was holding a paper bag.

"Hon!" Mom called out and led him toward us. "...This is our new son."

What?! Why like this?!

My heart was pounding. I felt scared even though there was no one else in the room. I grabbed onto Tita. I knew she could feel my shivering.

The man smiled and handed me the paper bag. "For you."

No!

I looked at Tita, as if asking, 'Should I accept it?'

She held my hand and nodded.

Slowly, I reached out and took the bag from him.

Mom smiled broadly when she saw me accept it. I didn't want to go inside; I just returned to Tita's side.

"Jay-jay... This is going to be your Dad. We're getting married."

"Jay-jay." My brother called. "...He's trying to get to know

There was authority in my brother's voice. I didn't realize she had already come close to me. She grabbed both of my arms and pulled me toward Andy.

"Mom..." I called to stop her, but she wouldn't listen.

She stopped me right in front of Andy. He looked at me and I couldn't help it. This was me now. I had no choice.

"Say hello to your Uncle Andy properly," Mom ordered.

Why me?! You could've done it yourself. Like—here's Jay. You can both get along now.

I looked at Mom, and I could see her annoyance. I guess I was irritating her, but what could I do? I was terrified.

I couldn't stay here stubbornly. No choice.

"I'm Jay-jay... Thank you for this," I said, almost in a whisper.

"You're welcome... Just let me know if you need anything."

"S-sure."

He smiled at me and reached his hand out to pat my arm.

Tita rushed to my side and helped me. "Are you okay?"

I couldn't answer. I dropped the paper bag I was holding myself. My gaze was all over the place.

I didn't understand why, but the fear I was feeling was di

"I... What's happening to you?" Lola asked me.

"Mom! Please take Jay-jay to her room!" My brother ord

Tita Gema helped me to my room. Even though we were feeling didn't change. When we got inside, Tita immedia sat on the bed, staring into space.

"Are you okay? What happened? Is there something hurt remember anything?" She asked one after the other.

I just shook my head, still staring into space. Even though by her questions, fear was the dominant feeling in me.

I knew I had felt this before, but I didn't know where.

It's strange! So strange. It felt like a scared child, afraid of a parent.

"...Jay-jay. Please talk to me," Tita pleaded. "...Tell me w

The scared

him!"

"Jeana... Please understand Jay-jay," Tita Gema replied.

Mom turned her angry gaze at Tita. "Understand?! She h
front of us! You want me to understand that?!"

"The girl is going through something!" Tita insisted. "...
like that!"

"Don't lecture me about my daughter !"

"I'm not lecturing you!"

Tita and Mom kept arguing. I couldn't stop myself from
was seeing. Why was it that the one who wasn't my mon
understood me? Why?

"Can you step out for a moment? I just need to talk to my
Mom said.

"I'm sorry, but I'm not leaving Jay-jay," Tita said firmly.

Mom sighed, and I could see her sharp glare. Instead of
lightly pushed Tita aside to get closer to me. She sat in fi

"Jay... my child." She said calmly. "...You need to accept
We're married now, and you'll live with us, even if it's in

As my tears fell, my anger toward her flared up.

"Can you leave my room?" I softly pleaded.

"Jay-jay," Tita Gema called me.

I looked at Mom and saw her shock at my words.

I didn't want to be rude, especially to her, but I was truly everything.

"Leave. I'm talking to you."

"W-Why are you talking to me like that?!" she angrily asked as they're teaching you here?!"

"Don't ask anymore! Just leave!" I shouted.

"Jay-jay!" Tita Gema scolded me, but I didn't back down.

"Don't shout at me! Maybe you've forgotten who I am!"

I stared right back at her. "I know! But if you don't leave who you really are!"

Though it pained her, she left my room. When the door closed freely. Tita quickly sat next to me and embraced me.

"Scchhh Jay-jay" Tita said, stroking my back and hair.

It was late afternoon when I woke up. I didn't want to get started to hurt. I listened to the voices downstairs.

They were still there!

My shoulders slumped as I headed for the bathroom. I don't shower longer than usual. It felt heavy being with her in

I didn't know why I felt this way. I used to be so excited especially when I was in the hospital. That was when I realized it is to hope for something that never comes. The longer the less I hoped for anything from her.

It hurt when people came by and said that Mom was in trouble because her enemies had her arrested. I stopped going back to see her in that state. When people asked about her, I couldn't because I hadn't seen her. Slowly, it crept into my mind that I didn't know her anymore.

I didn't know my own mother. I only knew her name, and "Mom" felt forced.

As the water from the shower fell, so did my tears.

It was frustrating! I didn't want to cry. It was exhausting, me feel weak.

I bowed my head, trying to stop myself from crying loudly.

with me.

And the most painful part for me was when she visited told myself not to hope anymore, but when Lola texted me, I didn't even go to my last class just to see her. Then when she was already gone.

It felt like she was avoiding me. Like she didn't want to see me every day, I stopped believing she would ever show up for me. I realized that my own mother was pulling away from me and avoiding me.

I sat down on the floor, feeling weak in the knees. I didn't cry out loud because they would hear me and worry. Each breath I took was being suffocated.

Why is this happening to me? What did I do wrong?

I don't have a father anymore, so why do I also have to look for a father?

Why do I have to feel love from other people, people I never knew as part of my life? Stupid snakes!

I tried to calm myself down. I had been in the water for ten minutes. I knew Tita would be knocking soon to wake me up.

I quickly dried myself off and got ready. When I opened the door, irritation grew when I saw Mom. She was rummaging through my things.

"Does it look good?" she asked.

I couldn't say "no" because, in truth, it looked better on her and she had a beautiful figure. No wonder so many men still

"Is that the only reason you're here?" I asked, halting her

She smiled tightly, though it looked fake. "I'm choosing our family dinner."

Family dinner?

"We're a family now?" I asked sarcastically.

Her look at me became sharp. Maybe it was because of her. I must have inherited her attitude too. She wasn't fake; when she was angry. When she didn't like something, she didn't back down. If she wanted to fight, she was ready.

She lowered the dress on the bed and slowly approached right in front of me, not taking her eyes off me.

"Jay-jay... I'm trying to make up for my mistakes with you. I love you too far, even though you're 17, I'll still discipline you how I see fit. Do you understand?" she said softly.

I didn't respond. I stared back at her. I didn't want to argue. I didn't want to lose the little respect I had left for her.

She didn't wait for my response. As I turned around, she and left my room.

Nice! She was really going to force things.

I tossed the t-shirt I was holding onto the bed in frustration. I wouldn't stay here. I collapsed onto the bed, staring at the

I wanted to look at Mom's face, but a huge part of me felt I saw her. She still looked so young. After all, she was only pregnant with Kuya, and 17 when she had me.

She was only 34!

That's why she still looked so good. I let out a deep sigh. It wasn't the reunion I had expected.

Someone knocked on my door, so I quickly stood up. The door opened, and Andy—Mom's new husband—walked in.

My brows immediately furrowed. Just his presence was enough to make me want him in the house.

"H-hi..." he greeted awkwardly. "...Can I come in?"

"If I say 'no,' are you still coming in?" I asked sarcastically.

He chuckled awkwardly. "I just wanted to ask... what we

He looked confused. Maybe he didn't understand the word. I learned it from Ci-N. It was derived from "eat," meaning I can eat.

"Alright... I'll just tell your mom," he said.

I thought he was leaving, but he stood there by the door, trying to signal that he should leave. But he didn't move, say something else.

"Do you need anything?" I asked.

He sighed and looked down. "Look... I know you're uncomfortable."

"At least you know," I interrupted, pretending to be pleased.

He seemed to lose his shyness, and I could tell he was getting comfortable.

He stared at me. This was the moment I was waiting for. He was about to say something.

Let's see... Andy!

"I'm trying to understand your situation here. I don't want you to be like me as your father, but please learn the word 'respect'."

I grimaced. Was that it? Was he really angry? I knew the

"We'll call you when dinner is ready," he said, and then I

I knew I would be scolded for what I just did. I guess I'll myself, especially for what Kuya Angelo will say. They me, but that's okay.

I'll get my ears ready!

Chapter 186: Fiancé vs. bo

Jay-jay's POV

I waited. I waited for someone to scold me for what I did, but no one did. Not a single one of them did that as I watched them while setting the dining table. Lola was chatting with Andy, the annoying one. I'm recording this

"Jay-jay!" Tita Gema called me. "...help your Mom in the

I reluctantly nodded. "O-okay."

Almost at the same time, Andy and I headed to the kitchen ahead, and Mama immediately greeted him with a kiss.

Suddenly, I felt disgusted by the word "kiss." Yuck!!!

"Jay... my child. Please take this," Mama instructed.

She was smiling at me while pointing to a large bowl filled with food. I glared at her before taking it and heading straight to the table.

When I looked up, I almost dropped the bowl in shock. I

"Hi..." Yuri greeted me awkwardly.

Truthfully, I'm still upset with him . After he revealed the man who set up the wedding—I mean, the marriage. I don't know what he's ganged up on me. I was already worried about Mama, and now this. Great job! Let's give him a round of applause!

"And who is this handsome young man?" Mama asked for the first time.

Yuri smiled from ear to ear. Wow! Handsome—like the first time I saw him. I'm mad at him, so I shouldn't compliment him.

"Good evening. I'm Yuri Hanamitchi," he introduced himself. He handed the bouquet to Mama. "...this is for you."

Mama quickly accepted it. She was even giggling while holding the flowers.

Wow!

"So you're the one marrying my child," Mama said to Yuri. "...you can call me Mama too."

It felt strange when she said that. A different kind of "Mama." Someone clear their throat and turned to see Andy standing there.

"Oh! This is my fiancé, Andy Estrada," Mama introduced him.

Yuri extended his hand, and Andy hesitated before shaking it.

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Damn it!

I was starting to regret it. Why did I let Yuri kiss me that make sure we were okay before going our separate ways

I felt someone's presence behind me. I slightly turned an up at the sky too. I took a deep breath.

"What are you doing here?" I asked Yuri.

"I'm keeping you company—"

"Not here!" I snapped, pointing to the road. "...here, in on home!"

He slightly bowed his head. "Angelo texted me. He said to your Mom."

I didn't say anything. I looked up again, feeling the wind quiet surroundings somewhat cleared my mind.

he was holding a broom.

"Your Mom..." Yuri broke the silence. "...she looks like y

I looked at him, pretending to be amazed. "Really? I did

Instead of getting annoyed, he just laughed at me. I said
not to make him happy. Obviously, I'm her child, and me

"Yeah... Like us now, if you go through with the wedding," he said sarcastically.

he chuckled slightly. "I'm not going to get you pregnant."

Damn it!

I suddenly felt chills after he said the word "pregnant." I should've used a different word. This person is something.

I glared at him. "Tsk! Just go inside!"

"Why?"

"I don't want you around... Go inside."

His face turned serious, with a hint of sadness. "Jay-jay.. mad at me. I can't change that. But I will still apologize."

I covered my face with my hand before moving it to my forehead. I took a deep breath to ease the heaviness in my chest, even just a little. I wanted to get completely angry at him.

"If you don't realize it, I'll explain it to you... If you hadn't had a wedding, we wouldn't be like this. I wouldn't be confused. Importantly, I wouldn't have hurt you," I explained calmly.

I should've been inside eating by now.

happiness too..."

I looked down. "...but I guess I'm not the one who can gi

If only you knew how much I want to love you the way y

But I can't force myself. I can't command my heart. Ever
it into my mind, Keifer is the first one who pops up. Wa
"tss" in my brain.

Overflowing with lust, flirtation, and handsomeness, hol
hand and a cigarette in the other. Wearing red boxers wit
—Wait!

Why am I even thinking about that?!

"I understand... But there's no turning back. I won't take
up, and I won't let you end up with Keifer," he said serio

My mouth hung open. My tongue retreated again, unable
never cooperate when I have so much to say. Enough, Yi

"Jay-jay? Yuri?" Mama called from the gate.

Yuri looked at her while I remained still, not moving an

"Come inside... Let's eat," Mama invited us.

"Okay. You go ahead, we'll follow." Yuri replied

I just shook my head. Things were already confusing, and worse. I stomped inside, leaving him outside. I knew he'd

Or maybe not!

I went straight to Tita Gema's dining area where I could have conversation. There were many empty seats, but there was a prepared plate.

I didn't want to sit beside her, so I sat next to Lola. There were utensils prepared there. Lola looked at me curiously, but

"Jay-jay... Sit here beside me," Mama instructed.

"I'll stay here... I prefer sitting next to Lola," I answered.

She just smiled. I knew their eyes were on me, but I chose to ignore them. Especially Kuya Angelo's gaze.

I might die!

Yuri also sat beside Lola, where I was supposed to sit on. I didn't look at him and focused on the table. A maid gave me utensils.

"Let's pray first..." Lola said, leading the prayer.

We followed and started praying. After that, they began to

They all looked at me. I had no idea who that person was or what their deal was for coming to see me at this hour.

"Were you expecting a visitor?" Tita Gema asked me.

I wasn't. I shook my head.

"Who is it?" Kuya asked the maid.

"he... he doesn't want to say," the maid replied.

"Go ahead, Jay. It might be important," Lola instructed.

Yuri stood up with me. I looked at him in confusion. I didn't know the Jay-jay of the moment.

"I'll come with you," he said.

"No... I'll go alone," I replied without enthusiasm.

I didn't wait for his response. I left and headed straight out. My thoughts were running through my mind as I walked.

It felt weird.

When I stepped outside the gate, I froze. It felt like everything had stopped. Even time seemed to stand still—in my mind, a

Almost four days. Almost four days of him not answerin

I wanted to scream at him and curse him. I wanted to put
I wanted to be angry at him for making me worry. So me
through my mind. I thought his Dad had hurt him.

But my tongue tied under his gaze. Almost four days felt
passed. I had so many questions for him. Why did he dis
he show up? Why didn't he even call me? But out of all
was the only one that came out of my mouth.

"H-have you e-eaten yet?"

He chuckled slightly and walked closer to me.

"W-why—?"

Oh no!

I didn't get to finish my question. He grabbed my hand a
to him. I stumbled into his chest in surprise. He hugged me

"I miss you..." he whispered.

I closed my eyes, savoring every word he said. His voice
my ears. My hands and arms instinctively wrapped around
the tightness of his embrace as if making up for the days

"I miss you more," I whispered.

~~~~~

"London. England. United Kingdom," he clarified.

"W-what were you doing there?"

"I met up with my cousin," he answered seriously.

"Can you explain it properly?" I pleaded.

It was like one question, one answer. We wouldn't get an  
We might finish this conversation by tomorrow.

"It's about Kaizer, my Dad. I visited my cousin and other  
that one of them could help me..." He took a deep breath  
want to help. They don't care about us anymore."

So that's why he wasn't responding. He must've been stru  
mess between him and his Dad. Even I would have a har  
situation.

"W-why wouldn't they help?" I asked with concern.

They're family; they should help each other. Now that K  
guardian by his side, they should support him.

"That's the problem with the Watsons. If there's nothing  
have no reason to care..." He smiled, but it was bitter. "...  
anything from me, so they don't want to help."

~~~~~


"W-why didn't you at least text me?" I changed the subject, "I was worried about you."

He held my hand. "I had to do that to stay longer in London. If I didn't text or heard your voice, I would've come back immediately."

I didn't know if I should be happy about what he said. I thought he was mad at me, which was why he avoided me, but it turned out to be a family matter.

You're overthinking, Jay!

"Did you just get back?" I asked while observing him.

He looked tired. Like he had done so much. He also looked sad because of his eyes.

"Yeah... I came straight here because I wanted to see you and you smiled."

Wow...

"You're crazy... You should've rested first. We have school tomorrow."

"Let's not go to school yet."

I frowned at what he said. It seemed like he was losing his mind. He was saying all sorts of things. It was like he wasn't in his right mind.

"No. Tomorrow. Please..." he pleaded. "...I'll take you to
I'd love that!

It's so hard to refuse him. He brought my hand, which he
his lips. He kissed the back of my palm and my fingers.

"But Keifer... Kuya might find out," I reasoned, and he l

"Please, Jay... I really miss you so much."

I bit my lower lip. I glanced at the house for a moment. I
go with him, but I was also scared of Kuya. The day he w
a date was a school day. I didn't want to disappoint him e

Keifer kept kissing my hand, and I felt like that was his v
me. A mischievous smile spread across his face. I wanted
so...

"Okay. Let's go on a date tomorrow," I whispered to him

He smiled and was about to touch my cheek, but he sudd
the gate and stopped. I immediately looked there too, afr
Angelo might have seen us, but it wasn't him.

"So you're back," Yuri said in a bored tone.

Did he know?

I didn't know if he was doing this on purpose. What if th fighting right here in front of the house? If that happenec would find out everything. I'd be in big trouble!

"Yuri! Have you seen Jay-jay?" Mama's voice called out

The idiot still wouldn't let go of my hand. I felt like a chi a toy from him. My hand was almost slipping from how but he just wouldn't let go.

"Yuri... Where's—?" Mama stopped mid-question.

She looked shocked when she saw our hands. Even I was us. Yuri had no reaction and stayed silent.

Let go, dude!

"Jay-jay," Mama called my name, as if ordering me to ex

"Keifer..." I whispered. "...let go. That's my Mom in fron

He looked at me before finally releasing my hand. I walk who was giving me a strange look.

"Good evening," Keifer greeted Mama and walked close jay's...?"

"Mother," Mama answered curtly.

Mama took his hand, and the TRAITOROUS KING imr back of her hand. He didn't take his eyes off Mama, as if with compliments.

Her cheeks turned red instantly—ugh! Damn this flirt! E didn't want to smile, I could tell from her expression that

So this is where I got my flirtatiousness from?!

"*Ahem* H-have you eaten yet?" Mama asked.

"Not yet. I just came home from a trip."

"Join us for dinner," Mama offered, making my eyes wic Yuri. "...That's okay, right?"

"Yes, of course. Besides, Keifer is also a friend of mine,' smile.

I felt like screaming at the top of my lungs to stop them. HAPPEN! Kuya Angelo might find out the truth. They n start a fight.

Mama went inside with Keifer. Yuri followed them, and there, utterly confused by what was happening.

Damn this flirtatiousness!

F I N I S H E D T H E M A N U S C R I P T

Wait a minute?! Where am I supposed to sit?!

I looked at the bench between Keifer and Yuri. Lola was I looked for her, she was already sitting in the seat next to

"Thank you," Keifer said, winking at Mama.

Mama turned to me, and I could clearly see her flushed cheeks and grimaced at her expression. She looked like she was about to Mamon and act all cutesy.

Seriously?! A teenager?

"Sit here, my child," Mama told me, pointing to the bench between Keifer and Yuri.

I sat there, and Mama returned to her seat. I glanced at Aunt Lola and seem to like Mama's behavior.

You're not alone.

They started eating. Even though I had no appetite, I forced myself to eat in. With every bite, I kept looking around, sensing the tension in the air for a disaster to happen.

"So, what are you doing here?" Kuya asked bluntly.

All of us turned to him. His question was so rude. Tita G

They stared at each other. I admit, tension was starting to build between them. Add to that the fact that this annoying King of Snakes was provoking him again. I could tell everyone was noticing the looks.

"Hmm... If you don't mind, I just want to know your name," the King interjected.

This guy is really meddlesome!

"Keifer... Mark Keifer Watson," the King answered.

Mama's expression suddenly changed. She was smiling at me.

"So you're a Watson. No wonder you have such a unique name," the King said, glancing at Tita Gema.

Tita shot her a sharp look, as if saying, "Don't start." Keifer knew Mama and Tita Gema, so maybe that's why Mama was smiling but I didn't understand Tita's reaction.

"So, what's your relationship with Jay-jay?" Andy asked.

I almost choked on my food because of his question. Seriously! Damn it! This guy really had to ask that. Can't he just eat?

I felt like banging my head on the table!

~~~~~

"Of course. Make sure Jay-jay gets there," Keifer smirked bad if my bride doesn't show up."

Yuri's eyebrows furrowed even more. It was clear Keifer teasing him. I couldn't help but lower my head. I was embarrassed of their argument.

"Excuse me... What the hell is going on?" Kuya asked at

He was irritated and clearly not happy with how the two of us were acting. I knew, I felt it, and he definitely wouldn't let something like this happen again.

"...Jay-jay!" he called my name, which made my body shake. "What's your relationship with Keifer?"

Shut the hell up!

I looked at Keifer and Yuri, both waiting for my answer. I couldn't answer. I didn't know what to say. I looked at Lito, who was worried about me, and then at Tita Gema, who seemed to be. Andy and I were also waiting for my response.

"A-what---"

"Were more than friends, but NOT less than lovers," Keifer said.

There was a loud shaking of the table. I accidentally bumped my head.

"Angelo... Calm down first," Tita Gema intervened.

"Calm down?! How am I supposed to do that?!"

While Kuya kept yelling, I felt a hand on my back. When the damn King. I slapped his hand off to get rid of it.

Damn you, you jerk!

"S-sir Angelo?" the maid suddenly spoke up.

"What?!" Kuya snapped back.

"T-the phone... The hospital is calling," the maid answered.

I immediately looked up and stared at her. Was it about Aries? I couldn't help but feel anxious. What if something happened to him?

You no longer have a grumpy cousin.

Tita Gema and Mom stood up at the same time. They were worried. Naturally, Tita was concerned since Aries was her child. I couldn't help but feel suspicious.

Kuya Angelo went out to answer the call. Tita, Mom, and I followed him.

There was no video there.



# Chapter 187: Started with

## David's POV

Smoke, sweat, perfume, and alcohol—that's what I still s  
though I'm no longer in the bar.

I'm so confused.

I shouldn't be doing this. I shouldn't have stopped my car  
shouldn't have waited for her to come out. I shouldn't be  
affairs.

What the hell is wrong with you, David?!

I'm just drunk. It's just the alcohol talking. I'll stop once  
the last time. When Cheon comes back, I won't wait for her  
won't steal glances anymore.

"Please, Jay, just come out. Even for a moment. I want to  
whispered, not taking my eyes off their gate.

My grip on the steering wheel tightened. There were two  
outside their house. I knew one belonged to Yuri, but I w  
owned the other one.

I cleared my throat. "I'm driving. Can you call me later?"

["I will. But since you're driving... Do me a favor. Head house. Text me when you get there. Thanks."]

He didn't wait for my response. I didn't tell him the truth already near Jay-jay's house. It's not my intention to lie. I can't tell him the truth.

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### **\*\*Jay-jay's POV\*\***

"What's the truth, Jay?" Lola asked me calmly.

I trust Lola. I could tell her the truth, but a big part of me to speak.

"L-Lola, it's just..." I whispered.

I'm on a diet right now!

"They're in a relationship, Keifer and her," Yuri said emotionless.

"...even though we're engaged."

Even though there was no emotion in his voice, even though much, I knew it hurt. He was hurting because of our situation.

Oh my!

"You're all still so young! You don't understand what you said, shifting her gaze to me. "...Jay! You're playing both

"I-it's not like that."

"Please... Don't blame Jay-jay for this," Keifer said. "...If she's the one who'll look bad, but..." He glanced at Yuri. about it, their relationship is forced. So I'm the only offic

"Official? You don't even have a label. How can your rel official?" Yuri asked, his voice tinged with annoyance.

"We have a label," Keifer quickly replied. "...husband an

\*Facepalm!\*

Once again, I banged my head on the table. My head was know if Keifer was just messing around or if he was seri was saying.

"You kids are raising my blood pressure," Lola said, shal

Suddenly, Tita Gema came in, and everyone's attention s We're heading to the hospital. We're going to see Aries."

"Oh, okay... We'll stay here. Take care," Lola replied, sta

We all stood up and followed her to the living room. As I found myself sandwiched between the two again. Lola sat across from us.

"Keifer," Lola called out to the fool. "...I want you to be a grandchild."

W-what... Why?

"Lola..." My voice was almost pleading.

\*\*Lola looked at me.\*\*

"It's not that I don't like him for you. It's just that you're already married... I didn't want you to get married either because you hadn't had your fill of single life yet. But that's what's needed now."

"But... Jay-jay and I can't break up," Keifer replied. "...what about a baby?"

Oh my God... Here we go again.

My eyes widened as I slowly turned to look at Keifer. Holy mind! What baby? Where did that even come from?

"B-baby?" Lola asked, shocked.

"Jay-jay is pregnant," Keifer added. "...she's a few months

That's why I knew she was just acting. She's done this before. I could tell the difference between her real thing.

"The poor baby will grow up without a father," Keifer called.

This idiot just won't stop.

I gave him a hard smack on the back of his head. He almost didn't feel how hard I hit him. He glared at me, and I glared back.

"You're out of your mind! Nothing has happened between us. What you're saying is impossible!" I said angrily.

He suddenly smiled mischievously. "Nothing yet... So don't worry. It will be?"

Damn it!

I slapped myself multiple times. I couldn't believe it. He was hitting me with my head. Why did I even fall for someone like this?

I looked at Lola, who was leaning on Yuri's chest. She had her eyes closed, pretending to take deep breaths.

"Lola, please... What this idiot is saying isn't true."

Lola opened her eyes, stood up, and looked at me seriously.

Keifer just smiled at her. If it weren't for the shock of his might've banged his head against the wall or the table.

Lola became serious again, and so did we. I knew she was anymore.

"I want the three of you to fix this mess. I'm not against relationships. She's old enough to know right from wrong," she looked at Yuri. "...I know you don't want to force Jay-jay either, but if there's something you can do—do it! It's not to force each other into this." She turned to Keifer. "...And together! We're having a serious conversation, and you people

Keifer just scratched the back of his head. Yuri had no reason to look down at his hands.

Lola then looked at me. "Jay... I know you don't want to do it, but don't do something you'll regret later."

If this had happened before, I might've talked back to Lola and tried to understand. I know this is for my own good.

Silence enveloped all of us. No one spoke. Even Lola stood there and continued to look at us. I was also trying to gauge the reactions.

"\*Ahem\*..." Lola broke the silence. "...it looks like Gemma will be late. Let's clean up."

Lola went straight to her room, while I went to the living room where the other two were. Keifer was sitting, and Yuri was standing near the door.

"Sorry... About what happened," Yuri started.

"I'm sorry too. You got scolded by Lola because of me."

"It's okay..." he replied, smiling. "...by the way, you look like you're wearing a wedding gown."

Oh no! Did he really have to bring that up?

I felt awkward. I glanced at Keifer, but he didn't react. I realized I had meant for him to hear that.

"Thank you," I replied awkwardly.

He bowed his head, and I could tell he sensed I didn't want to be in front of Keifer.

"I think it's time for me to go," he said, which confused me.

"Huh?"

He glanced at Keifer for a moment before looking back at me. "Take care of yourself," he said, then without hesitation, he kissed my cheek.

Suddenly, Keifer stood up from his seat and looked at us.

"Did you get all giddy?!" he said irritably.

Here comes the jealous guy.

"Huh? Where?"

"From Yuri kissing you!"

"No," I answered innocently.

He approached me and hugged me around the waist. I was grabbed his chest. I slightly arched my body to distance myself. I had a feeling where this was going.

"You should," he said seriously. "...Now, can I have the kiss I wanted?"

Ahihihi... No!

"It's not possible."

"And why is that?" he asked irritably.

"You smell like cigarettes."

He immediately sniffed himself. "You can still smell that?"

Well, you smoked, didn't you!



I didn't want to mention it to him because he might get n

"If you don't kiss me... I'll force you," he said seriously.

I slapped his chest hard, causing him to let go of me.

Such a troublemaker!

He's overflowing with this!

"That fvcking hurt!" he said irritably.

"I know, right?" I replied, imitating a commercial.

I walked toward the sofa and lazily sat down. That's whe  
hungry. I didn't want a heavy meal anymore. I preferred  
my body wouldn't accept rice.

"I want ice cream," I whispered and then looked at the K  
glaring at me. "...Buy me ice cream. I'll kiss you."

His face suddenly brightened. He quickly ran outside.

Nice! Haha...

"Wait for me!" he shouted.

I heard his car roar, and I laughed. He's such a jerk! He'll  
kiss what more if it's for---- haizt!

And maybe what's happening with Keifer and me would be simple courtship.

Or maybe, up until now, we're still like cats and dogs. Fighting things. Irritated by each other's presence. Damn it! Why am I a bad boy? Even though I accepted suitors before, I never accepted scoundrels like him.

That's why I had a crush on Yuri back then.

But I still couldn't stop myself. I fell for him without realizing I didn't know what to do. Especially now that Kuya Angel

He'll skin you alive!

I heard the sound of a car. I knew it wasn't Tita's, so I stopped Keifer, but he was too fast. He just left, and now he's back.

I peeked out the door, but there was no one knocking or ringing the doorbell. It felt weird, but it was like something was telling me to go outside.

I scratched my neck and walked out of our gate.

"David?" I called out to him when I saw him standing by the gate. "are you doing here?"

His hair was messy, and he looked out of it. He pulled out a comb.

["Jay-jay."]

I closed my eyes when he said my name. I had wished for his voice again. The days when I desperately wanted to see him when I was so hopeful he would show up and answer all my questions.

But you just got hurt!

"P-percy."

["I'm going home. I'll answer all your----."]

"Don't show up in front of me," I interrupted.

I didn't know where that came from, but I knew it was true. He shouldn't show up in front of me anymore.

["Jay?"]

"You're just messing with me! You're messing up my life!"

["Look... I'm sorry----."]

"I don't need your apology! What I want to know is who you are. Why is it that whenever my life is calm, you show up and mess it up? I didn't want to get this angry, but I couldn't stop myself."

I felt like I was about to explode. All the pain I felt because of you was coming out. The nights when I cried. The nights when I

"I DON'T CARE!" I screamed loudly, my tears streaming down my face. "If you're just going to mess with me-----."

["DAMN IT! Listen to me!"] he shouted angrily.

I don't know, but it felt like I heard the four of them in his head. They're all friends. They all have that same anger.

["...give me three----No! Two days. Give me two days, answer your questions."]

No! Don't believe it!

"Enough..." I whispered almost to myself. "...please."

I didn't wait for him to respond. I let go of David's phone, hugging my knees. I felt weak. I wanted to be happy and the fear was there.

The fear that he might not show up again. That I might be in vain again, and that he wouldn't answer my questions.

"Jay-jay." David called me.

I didn't look at him, but I saw his hand pick up the phone. It remained standing in front of me after looking at it.

"You should go inside... It looks like it's going to rain."

He didn't say anything, and all I could hear was a deep si

I thought he wouldn't answer my question, just like Perc

"We have a contract. I work for him in exchange for help  
He answered directly.

I broke down into more sobs. I felt like a child who had l  
something but wasn't given it. My heart felt so heavy. I t  
I had for Mama came out.

Slowly, I felt David's hand and arms embrace me.

"Ssshhhh... Enough. I get hurt when you're like this."

Even though I was confused by what he said, I chose to s  
several deep breaths. I raised my head to face him, pullin  
hug.

"Davi----."

I didn't finish what I was going to say when I felt both hi  
cheeks. Without hesitation, his lips pressed against mine

D-David!

It felt like my heart exploded from the speed of its beatin  
move from the shock. I quickly pushed him away when

I heard the car door close. My heart raced with fear and a cold water had been poured over me. Slowly, I turned my

My body trembled even more. His look at me was different, questioning, full of confusion, and slowly turning angry.

He saw it... He saw it.

"K-Keifer..." I called, stepping closer to him.

But his movements were quick. In the blink of an eye, he was on David, and his fist flew to his face.

Shit!

"YOU FVCKING BASTARD!" Keifer screamed angrily.

I couldn't move. I was too shocked by what he did. David was thrown from his car from the force of Keifer's punch. I saw him spit out

Keifer punched again. David could no longer stand, and he fell out of his nose. I was scared of Keifer, I didn't know why.

But if I didn't do something, who knows what would happen.

I took several deep breaths to gather the courage.

"K-Keifer... S-stop," I said as I moved toward him.

I swallowed nervously. "K-Keifer..."

"Are you hiding something from me?" His voice was calm suspicion. "...Are you in a relationship with David?"

W-what?! Why is he thinking like this?!

I shook my head repeatedly. "N-no. N-nothing like that."

He took a step closer to me, and I took a step back. His gaze was the same, as if I had committed a huge sin.

"What is he doing here?" He asked again.

"M-m-meron k-kasi----."

"Don't fvcking lie to me!"

"It's Percy! He called David and asked to talk to me."

I quickly explained.

He stopped approaching me. His gaze became more scrutinizing. His breathing was heavy. The fear still didn't go away.

"...Believe it." I whispered, almost begging.

Please... Trust me.

Just like what he said when he saw Yuri and me. But if tl talking to me for three days or more, I can handle it, as lo get this angry.

"...But I can't. It feels like you're doing this on purpose."

I won't do that!

I immediately walked over to him and grabbed his hand. like that!"

Suddenly, he pulled his hand back from mine. It felt like my heart with what he did.

"Don't touch me! I might lose control and hurt you!"

He shouted at me.

I broke down into tears. I didn't want this! My chest felt already in pain.

Listen to me!

He shook his head and suddenly started walking toward immediately followed him when I saw him about to get i

"Wait! Keifer!" I called out and desperately knocked on car.



I tried to chase him, but what could my legs do against the ground? I bent down, holding my knee to support myself.

Dammit!

I needed to follow him. I needed to talk to him. This can't be happening. This shouldn't be happening.

I went back, but I hadn't even reached the gate when it started to rain. I looked at David's car; it was gone, and it seemed like he

"Miss Jay-jay!" One of the maids called out to me. "...She said they're on their way home."

I cried even harder when she said that, not because I was sad but because I couldn't fix everything if they were here.

Why, David?!

# Chapter 188: Boiling point

## Jay-jay's POV

I couldn't help but cry. Every move I made felt like tears flowing. I couldn't understand anything at all. I left my room at the same time, Aries also came out of his room. I glanced at him but he wasn't moving. He insisted on coming home from the hospital. That's why Tita was so frantic—the doctor didn't want to let him leave. But he's so stubborn and just wanted to come home.

"Is your mom really staying here? What does she think of this hotel?!" he asked me irritably.

I didn't want to argue. I had bigger problems to deal with than needed to see Keifer.

"They'll leave soon," I answered lifelessly.

I walked past him and went straight to the living room. I saw my mother, reading a newspaper. She smiled at me, but it felt like she noticed I was already in my uniform.

"You haven't eaten yet. Are you leaving already?" she asked, approaching me.

I pulled away from Lola and glared at Mama as she approached.

"Are you going to school, Jay?" Mama asked when she saw Tito Andy cooked."

"No... I have something to do," I answered without enthusiasm. And I don't want to see you either.

I didn't wait for their response. I immediately left the house on my bike. I pedaled fast to get away from them. I didn't really want to. I just wanted to leave the house as soon as possible. I didn't want to be with them either. Everything just becomes harder for me.

I'm so mean. I just can't be fair to them. How can I when I haven't experienced fairness in life? It's so easy to blame others for what's happening to me, but the truth is, there's no one to blame but me. I was born to be like this.

Unlucky in so many ways.

Last night, I almost crushed my phone from calling Keif. He turned it off. I also called his house, but they said he had left.

Kuya Angelo talked to me last night, but I didn't understand what he said. All I could think about was the King.

What will happen to us now?

I checked my phone, hoping he had replied to me. Like there was still no response.

I was so happy last night when I saw him outside the house. The hug he gave me. Even though things almost got chaotic, I was happy that he showed up for me.

But it was only temporary.

I was so angry at David. I thought I couldn't be mad at him. I didn't know his reasons, but I couldn't help it, especially when the incident happened last night came back to my mind. If he hadn't kissed me, this wouldn't have happened. He didn't talk to me for three days after the incident with Yuri. What more now? He wouldn't talk to me again.

I finished eating and threw all the trash in the bin. I got back on my bike and pedaled to school. While I was riding, I felt something like someone was following me.

I stopped for a moment and looked behind me, but there were no vehicles. I turned my gaze back to the front, and just then the motorcycle exhaust roared.

A big bike! The kind used for racing. It was red and had a driver who was wearing a black helmet, and even though I couldn't see him, I could feel him looking at me and grinning.

I immediately started pedaling my bike, speeding up every chance does a bike have against a motorcycle? My heart I felt a mix of nervousness and fear. I didn't know what to do. I got even more scared when I noticed it wasn't just the two were more following us. I pedaled even faster.

Race, man! Race!

Instead of heading straight to school, I changed my route straight to the police station to scare them off. But before crossing, they suddenly stopped.

I looked at them, and when I turned my gaze back to the truck, I crushed the handbrake from pressing it so hard. THERE IN FRONT OF ME!

I swerved the bike, but it kept sliding toward the truck.

I closed my eyes and braced myself for impact. I even heard

Idiot!

I heard a loud crash as my body hit the ground. I kept sliding on my bike. I wanted to scream from the pain of the impact. My head shook.

"Miss! Are you okay?!" shouted a man who looked like

More people approached me. They checked me over. So nosy.

"Why did you swerve into the truck?"

"Let's take you to the hospital!"

"I saw those motorcycles following her!"

"Call the police!"

I checked myself thoroughly. I might have been injured. But it seemed like I only had body aches. Thankfully, though, just as I hit it. The impact was just really strong. I walked away, which was wobbling on one side.

The motorcycles were gone!

I stood my bike up and checked it. I didn't see any damage. I went to the side of the road to rest for a bit. The people were still talking about what had happened.

"Are you sure you don't want to go to the hospital?" an old woman asked me.

I smiled at her. "No, thank you. I just need to rest."

I stayed there for a few more moments. I checked the time on my phone. It was 10:15. I decided to call the police.

Damn it! It really hurts!

There were no students hanging around outside anymore and it seemed like I was the only one who hadn't entered the bike and decided to just push it.

I was already at the building when I noticed something. It seemed like there was chaos. I had a bad feeling that they were here again. I quickened my pace and almost threw my bike.

I reached the front of the room and let go of the bike. There was chaos! Mayo was the first one I saw when I entered. Dre was holding him back.

"Enough!" Mayo shouted.

I forced my way to the middle and covered my mouth. Kit was relentlessly punching Kit. His face was already covered in blood and wasn't even moving anymore.

Keifer was furious, and no one could stop him. I looked on as he was being restrained by Rory and Edrix.

"Enough! Keifer! Have mercy on Kit!" Mayo shouted again.

It was terrifying! He was like this last night with David. I had seen him like this many times, I'm still scared. It's different when you're close and see him unleashing his anger.

Damn it! Is he even still alive?!

He looked pitiful. His eyes were so swollen you could barely see them. Blood kept flowing from his nose and mouth. Mayo and I approached us.

"K-Kit..." Mayo said, his voice trembling. "...c-can you hear me?"

"Bro... P-please respond," Eren said.

Tears welled up in my eyes as I watched them. Mayo's hand was shaking as he checked Kit's neck for a pulse.

Before I could hear what he was about to say, a hand gripped my arm tightly. I was forcefully pulled up and turned to face Kei. My thighs to ache even more.

"Get away from him," Keifer commanded with authority.

I tried to pull my hand back, but his grip was too tight, and it hurt.

"I-I'm hurting."

"You're really going to hurt!" he shouted.

"Keifer!" Yuri scolded him.

Even Yuri couldn't calm Keifer down. Were they all afraid?



Why is he like this again? What happened now? Is this b  
night? Why does he have to be like this?

"W-what's going on—?"

"Did he kiss you?!" he cut me off, pointing at the uncon

No! He didn't go through with it!

No words came out of my mouth. It felt like even other p  
were afraid of him.

I could only shake my head to convey what I wanted to s  
but suddenly kicked one of the tables. The loud noise it  
everyone.

It was bone-chilling. All I could hear was the sound of n

Because of how loud it was, it felt like it was amplified i  
down, heart!

"Mayo..." Keifer called.

I saw Mayo flinch in surprise and fear. Even Eren looked  
call.

"...Repeat everything you said earlier," Keifer ordered.

I didn't understand what he meant. But I could clearly see

"If I hadn't caught you guys fighting, I wouldn't have known you were  
pacing back and forth.

We were all shocked when he suddenly threw a chair near me. It  
covered my mouth.

I looked around the room. Everyone was there, but none of them said  
anything. They were all bowing their heads or hiding in the corners. I saw  
David with a bruised mouth and a bandage on his eye.

"WHO ELSE?!" Keifer shouted angrily, still pacing. "WHO THE  
FVCKING ELSE?!"

Everyone kept their heads down except Yuri. His eyes were full of  
concern as he looked at me. I wanted to go to him and hug him, but because of  
the fear I was feeling, but I didn't want him to end up like the others.

"You!" Keifer said, pointing at Ci-N. "...maybe you did something  
that I don't know about!"

Not Ci-N! He's no match for you!

Ci-N was trembling and shaking his head. I could see he was crying  
of tears from fear.

"Sure?! Maybe you did something, or you all did?!" Keifer said, grabbing  
him by the collar. "...maybe something already happened  
between you?!"

Keifer paced again and stopped in front of Yuri. He suddenly not because he was happy—it was like he had realized so

Enough, Keifer!

"Of course, you... It's impossible for you not to be involved, right? Taking what's mine?" Keifer said, and Yuri avoided him. "...Freya, then Ella. Now Jay-jay!"

"I'm not taking anything from you. They were all yours and I was with them too," Yuri replied seriously.

The tension between them was deadly. All of us were waiting to see what would happen next.

Our attention shifted to Kit when he groaned and slightly moved. He was conscious; we needed to take him to the hospital.

I was about to step forward to help, but someone blocked me.

"Don't even try."

I looked at him desperately. "K-Kit needs to be taken to the hospital."

He leaned closer to me. I swallowed hard when our eyes met. He looked like a different person—cold but filled with anger.

"Is that all?" he whispered. "...maybe there's more."

quickly caught me.

"Are you okay?" Eman asked.

He helped me up, but at the same time, Keifer's fist flew

What the hell?! Damn it!

"Keifer!" I shouted, grabbing his arm.

He looked at me angrily and pointed. "You! Is that what

I let go of him and matched his angry gaze. He needed to  
and jealousy were getting out of hand.

"...Do you really want these guys to flirt with you, huh?!

You idiot!

I slapped him for what he said. I had been putting up with  
because of his anger, but this was too much. Fear was eating  
he didn't stop, things might escalate. I didn't want to end

"Why, isn't it?!" he asked angrily. "...That's why you're not  
Maybe that's what you really want?! To flirt with the whole

You've been at it for a while now!

I slapped him with my left hand, but he blocked it, so I n

"Disrespect you? What about what you did to me... Wasn't I disrespectful?" he said calmly.

I closed my eyes gently. His words hurt me deeply. I knew what happened last night, but I didn't mean for it to happen.

"Or maybe you're up to something?" he suddenly said, changing the atmosphere in the room. "...Maybe you're planning to see Section E to ruin us?"

"I wouldn't do that. They're my friends, I'm part of Section E."

"Oh no, you're not," he cut me off. "...You don't belong there."

It felt like a knife stabbed my heart when he said that. I-I was so confused.

He suddenly grabbed my arm and pulled me out of the room. I begged because of the pain in my body, but all I could do was cry.

It hurts! Stop it!

"Keifer! Where are you taking Jay-jay?!" I heard Yuri shout.

Looking back, the others were following us, full of concern for myself from Keifer's grip, but he held on tightly.

"Keifer! Have mercy on Jay-jay!" Ci-N shouted.

"Keifer," I pleaded.

He didn't react. He put me down when we reached the se to get away, but he grabbed my hand and pulled me agai

We were approaching Section A's room, so I struggled h my body was in pain and my legs were stiff, I tried, but I numb.

What's happening to you?!

He opened the door to the room. The teacher stopped tea stood up in alarm.

He pulled me again and pushed me toward Aries. But my idiot, pushed me too, so I fell straight to the floor. What are.

"You belong to him..." Keifer said, and I looked at him. ' your stupid, fvcking, asshole-----."

"Mr. Watson... What are you doing here?!" —Teacher.

"-----cousin. Who's good at hiding from his brother's sche

"What the hell are you doing here, Keifer?!" Aries asked

I tried to stand, but my thighs were completely stiff from

I couldn't stop my tears from falling. I tried not to react to saying. I felt so embarrassed in front of Section A. I saw the door.

"So does here! She can't stay here! That's why she ended up here because her life is worthless----just like yours!" Aries said.

It felt like a heavier weight was placed on my chest. Wow, he's a different person now. The way he talks, it's like I'm not a relative.

What do you expect, Jay?!

Oh right! He doesn't want me as family.

"She doesn't belong in your Section, but she's perfect for you because you're exactly the same!" Keifer said angrily, raising his fist. "...The best thing you should do is stick her to your chest and connect your belly buttons!"

"Enough, Keifer," I said lifelessly, but he ignored me.

"What the hell?! Last time I checked, you're her knight and protector. Now you're dumping her?" Aries replied, smiling and shaking his head. "...You should just go back to your classroom. It's a waste of time having her here."

From the way they were talking, I felt like such a worthless person.

"Aries!" Ella scolded.

I felt like I was going to explode any second. I couldn't tell he was saying anymore.

I held Mica's hand to remove it. She looked at me curiously. Even though it hurt so much, I tried to walk normally. We fell. I saw Yuri about to approach me, but I signaled him and Section E were watching me as I walked.

I really don't belong with them.

I passed by Ci-N, who was looking at me. David, who couldn't approach me. Mayo, Josh, and Eren weren't there, probably to help Kit.

Good thing there were still classes, or I might have died if they saw me like this. My thighs and legs were in so much pain, especially as I went down the stairs.

I wanted to scream from the pain!

I don't know how long I've been walking, but not one of them. Not that I was expecting----but I really was! I was hoping they would follow me and explain what's happening. I was hoping they would apologize to me. I was hoping it would be K

When I left the main building, I saw Josh. He had his bag



too.

I forced a smile. "O-okay."

# Chapter 189: The Prince

## Aries's POV

"...Get out of here! Leave!" the teacher scolded Keifer and  
"...These kids! Always looking for trouble!"

The Section E students left, but Keifer gave me a nasty look.  
They interrupted our class just to humiliate Jay-jay. How

Our teacher left the room. I was sure she was heading to  
to report what happened. We were all left staring at the door.

"You didn't need to say those things, Aries!" Ella said and

I ignored her. We weren't on good terms, but if she talked  
it's like she was the one in charge.

"Poor Jay-jay."

"Looks like she's really hurt."

I overheard my classmates whispering. I noticed it too—  
held her... It looked like she was in so much pain. I ignored  
didn't want to show any sympathy.

Is that why she looked like that? Is that why she seemed in pain? What the hell, Jay?!

"You should check on your cousin," Ella ordered, standing up who was also looking at me.

"Don't order me around," I replied with authority.

I could feel the whole class staring at me. This was the first time I had heard me talk to Ella like that. No one knew we had fought, accurately, that we had broken up.

After all this time... Still him...

"Ella's right," Freya suddenly said, continuing to file her nails. "Their Section is in chaos. Harrington was rushed to the hospital."

Seriously? What's wrong with their Section? Is Keifer alive? Why isn't Yuri doing anything?

I let out a deep sigh. I left the room and headed straight for the rooftop. I didn't have any plans to check on Jay-jay. Why should I?

Yeah... Why should I?

I went to the rooftop, where I could easily see their building. Some of them were outside, while it seemed like there was something going on inside the room.

["I thought something bad happened to you."] I could hear his voice.

I couldn't blame him. I had insisted on leaving the hospital to be there! Too many memories came back whenever I was lying on a hospital bed with an IV attached.

"Nothing bad happened," I said, emphasizing the word \*to know if Jay-jay is there."

["If the 'there' you're talking about is our house... I don't know if she went home."]

Tsk!

"Okay... Thanks," I said, about to end the call, but I heard

["Wait... Is Jay-jay not there at school?"]

"She's here... I just don't know if she went home. She was lying."

I wasn't covering for Jay-jay. I just didn't want my brother to ask questions. The conversation would drag on, and we'd end up reliving the past again.

["I see... I'll text Mom to confirm. Thanks."]

~~~~~

The King that was once on the throne. Everything becom because of his name. They also gave me a title... The Pri them call me that.

At first glance, I appear as the Prince because my brothe that's not how I see it! They call me Prince because I wil on the throne. I will never be the man like my brother. A give that to me.

Because someone else has already taken it long ago.

I hate myself for being like this. I'm always second.

Second to Percy because he's better at making others hap

Second to Yuri because he's smarter.

Second to Keifer because he's better than me.

And most of all, second to Jay-jay in the family because

I bitterly smiled when I remembered her. How I used to their house to play with her. How I'd comfort her when s made sure she knew how much her Kuya loved her.

But that will never happen again. I will never do that aga It's her fault why I got sick.

~~~~~

Lola looked at me with concern. She was the only one he back. Mama and Andy already left, and so did Aunt Gen. Kuya was at his company stuff.

"It's not okay not to tell them... Look at the state you're in pointing to the bruises I had.

"It'll go away quickly."

She sighed deeply. She always does that when I come home and wounds. I usually just choose to turn away from her of fighting.

"Have you been to the hospital?"

I nodded and handed her the X-ray and check-up results. I faced her.

She stared at me for a moment before taking it and reading it.

There were no fractures in the bones. It was just muscle pain. The doctor prescribed a lot of pain relievers. She also advised me to ice the bruised and sore areas.

"Oh Jay! I allowed you to stay here because I knew you'd be at your Kuya Angelo's place... But here you are again, come up." She scolded me as she set the results down beside me.

I smiled back at her. She adjusted my blanket and kissed forehead. She then walked out and closed the door. I look was only after lunch, but I already felt so sleepy, probably exhaustion.

I yawned repeatedly. I stared at the ceiling, and the even replaying in my mind. The motorcyclists and what Keife

My body hurt, but the things he said hurt even more.

It felt like my heart was punched, and I couldn't retaliate Keifer could do something like this because of jealousy.

I hugged Snorlax tightly. I used to think love was easy. I with my first boyfriend. I was just mad because he was g no one would find out at school.

Damn him! In the end, he was better looking than me.

I didn't feel pain with Cyrus either. I didn't take him serious knew he didn't take me seriously either. I was just scared carelessly.

But now! Now, for the first time in my life, I feel this wa Keifer said. I never thought words could hurt like a knife

Yes, I've been hurt by things said about me and Mama, b different.

or if I still needed more sleep.

I heard loud laughter from Mama and the others in the li

I got up and checked the clock, it was 6:42 PM. I also gr  
see if I had messages from him.

None!

There were messages from Yuri and the others checking  
didn't feel like replying. I got up and quickly went to the  
freshen up.

I also started feeling hungry, so I hurried downstairs.

I saw Mama and Aunt Gema in the living room. Uncle J  
there too. Lola was talking to Kuya Angelo.

They all looked at me, one by one. The first thing I notic  
smiling face. It was different, though—her smile was ful  
excitement.

"Are you okay, Jay?" she asked, looking me up and dow  
Join us."

Huh?!

I raised an eyebrow. What's going on with her? I didn't p



What's the point?

Nothing would change. He's mad at me, and he doesn't v  
doesn't accept me. I understand, though—who would wa  
as a sibling?

I continued eating. Then I heard shouting coming from t  
wasn't sure, but I could clearly hear Mama's voice.

Even though I hadn't finished eating, I decided to peek a  
on.

Before I could even get close, I could already hear what

"...Don't talk to me like that!" Mama yelled.

"Get out of our house! I don't want you here!" Aries ans

What's going on?

I reached the living room, but it was Mama and Aries w  
attention. Andy was trying to stop Mama, while Aunt Ge  
them.

"Aries! Stop it!" Kuya yelled, but Aries clearly wasn't pl

"Hey! You're so ungrateful!" Mama yelled again.

"Ungrateful? Why? What have you done for me? You

Children?!

"At least they're teaching something! You're teaching the retorted before Aunt Gema could say anything.

"If I knew you were going to be like this, I should never  
FUCKING HELL, GLASS!

I felt my heart stop. My skin prickled, and my hands were

"Jay-jay?" Lola called when she saw me.

Everyone's attention shifted to me. Mama's anger was re-embarrassment. Aunt Gema and Lola immediately rushed

"Jay... W-what..." Aunt Gema started, and I knew she didn't say.

"What's this? She still doesn't know?" Mama asked, clearly glared at Aries. "...And you really weren't planning on telling

"Tsk! How was I supposed to tell her? You already did!" rudely.

"ARIES!" Kuya yelled in anger. "...Go to your room. No

Aries shot me a dirty look before leaving. I stayed still, speechless. Aunt Gema and Lola were saying something to me

What the hell! Am I being played with?!

"I-I'll go to my room." That's all I managed to say.

No one stopped me. They let me walk away as if I wasn't  
It felt so humiliating.

Jay... You've been facing your brother for a long time. ---

So that's why he said that. He knew the truth too. He knew  
my brother.

Brilliant! Really brilliant!

I look so stupid, thinking about his situation. Thinking of  
the family he has. I wonder if he has a brother there too.

A fucking nice question, but the answer was right in front of me.  
I can't believe how stupid I am.

"You now know the truth, but that doesn't change anything."  
Aries suddenly said as he appeared in front of me.

I furrowed my brows at what he said. "Oh?"

"Don't expect me----."

"I don't expect you to do anything. I know... You don't even  
your cousin, let alone a sibling." I interrupted him before

The things I thought I'd do when I finally faced my brother couldn't do them. My expectations of what our conversation never going to happen.

Damn it! They're giving me a sibling like him, someone like me!

It's so unfair, it's just so unfair. I grabbed my chest as I collapsed. Why him? Why does it have to be him?

# Chapter 190: Open ears

## Jay-jay's POV

I wanted to leave my room. I wanted to open the door and I wanted to because I was hungry.

I didn't have dinner because of what I found out. I thought I would go away because of everything that happened, but my stomach doesn't want to get involved with the drama of it.

But I was scared, scared that when I opened the door, I would find another secret.

What if I have a twin I don't know about?!

I looked at the clock on the wall: 11:39 PM. I was sure everyone in the house was asleep, but I was still scared.

My stomach growled loudly, as if screaming, "Damn it! I can't just sleep this hunger away, I hadn't eaten properly."

Though it was against my will, I turned the doorknob and opened the door toward me. I peeked outside, all the lights were off. I grabbed the handle and used its light as a guide.

It was like a portal that would take me to a different parallel universe. I opened the fridge door and clapped when I saw it. There were so many things there, even cake!

I first grabbed some food and heated it in the microwave. I then looked for more things I could eat. I also found a Chuckie drink that made me laugh a little.

Pffttt... Childish!

I knew who that Chuckie drink belonged to. It was Kuya who usually drinks it when he's stressed. I thought for a moment I should try it, but I was worried Kuya might get mad. But he wouldn't mind if I did it.

I smiled widely. I grabbed one and shook it. I was about to take a sip with a straw when I glanced at the kitchen door. Aries was standing there with arms crossed, staring at me without any reaction.

I quickly put the Chuckie back in the fridge and closed the door like nothing happened and went back to the microwave. I then heard his footsteps approaching me.

I got nervous for reasons I couldn't understand. I couldn't move like I was about to faint. I could feel his presence behind me and instinctively closed my eyes.

I waited to see if he would say something or do something.

I thought he was going to leave after making his coffee, I sink. After gathering what I needed, I began eating. I probably foolish because I kept glancing at him with every bite.

He didn't look at me, so I didn't know if he noticed me. While I eat, my mind kept replaying what happened earlier. It felt

But there was something I was wondering about. His age was the same. I was sure we weren't twins because my brother was a year older than me. I was confused.

"Stop looking at me," he suddenly said, stopping me from

"S-sorry..." I muttered. "...Ari—what should I even call you?"

I wanted to slap myself for asking that. Seriously?! He raised his head and I immediately looked down.

"Nothing will change," he said firmly.

Okay... Aries still. Aries the horoscope! How's Taurus doing?

I couldn't stop thinking about our age. I didn't want to discuss that with him yet, especially since everything was still for help but ask.

"Aries... W-why are we the same age?"

~~~~~

along.

I felt a deep sadness. Even back then, he really didn't want to. He didn't know the full story of why he was placed in foster care. He always said it was for the betterment of both of us.

But it didn't turn out to be for the better.

I didn't say anything else. He finished his coffee and left.

I was left alone, staring at the food in front of me.

This is so frustrating! I know he's angry with me. A big part of it is because we can't get along despite everything we've been through. He's also angry with him. I see him as a cousin, so I just leave it alone and respond whenever I get the chance.

But now that I know the truth, I just want us to make up. I want to know before, at least we'll know that we're okay.

Even if he doesn't recognize me as a sibling, it's okay with me.

I held back the tears that were threatening to fall. I quickly washed the dishes and washed Aries' cup.

I turned off the light and quickly went back to my room. I lay down before finally lying down on my bed. My mind was blank as I fell asleep.

I felt sad. I let out a deep sigh.

He still hasn't replied to any of my texts. His phone is off him.

Shit... Keifer...

I got up and went straight to the bathroom. I got ready for

When I stepped out of my room, Aries was just coming and looked at me lifelessly before walking away.

Before, when he would look at me like that, I would just now, it felt heavier inside me.

When I entered the dining area, I could hear Mama's voice telling stories.

"Good morning, Jay!" she greeted me with a smile.

There's nothing good about my morning!

"Good morning," I replied before sitting down.

Aries was sitting across from me, starting to eat. He seemed about anyone around him. He was looking down and eating.

I started eating too and acted like I didn't care about the people. But I could still clearly hear their conversation.

They just smiled at me. They were really good at pretending.

It was so obvious we were the topic of their conversation like Aries and I will be fine now that I know the truth.

But they're just assuming.

Aries finished eating first. We were almost done at the same time. Both stood up and walked back to our rooms together.

We were only a few steps away from his room when he stopped. He looked at him in confusion, but he didn't face me.

"Stop it," he said, making me even more confused. "Don't act like they do. We're not going to make up."

He didn't wait for my response. He quickly walked and disappeared. I stayed there, staring at nothing.

Don't expect anything?

I shook my head and walked back to my room. I quickly got ready. My scars from the accident yesterday were still a little muscle hurt, but I had gotten used to it.

The benefits of always getting into fights!

I was walking towards the living room when I heard Kuy

"Go with him. You both go to school together again, and home together."

I saw Aries messing with his hair. He had no choice, so I went out toward the garage.

"Why? What for?" I asked Kuya, making sure Aries had

"Just in case what happened to you yesterday happens again, I'll keep you safe," he answered and walked away.

Safe! Pfft... Who are they fooling?

They're just trying to make us get closer and get along.

They're wasting their effort. I walked outside, planning to give them orders.

My heart was heavy because of the problems I had with Aries. Now, it was made worse by finding out the truth. Whatever they should just stop. It's only making things harder for me.

I stopped in front of the gate when I saw Aries' car parked. The driver's side lowered, and I saw his angry face.

"Get in," he ordered.

"No need... I still have somewhere to go," I answered lightly.

I knew he didn't want me in his car, so I chose to sit in the car to feel his irritation, but I chose to look at the road instead.

He started the car, and all we could hear was our breathing.

It's so frustrating!

He's not doing anything, but I'm getting hurt. Or maybe I am because he's doing nothing. I've gotten used to him yelling at me out of frustration, but now that he's silent... Damn! I feel so worse.

The car stopped a corner before getting to the school. He did nothing, but I knew what that meant. I got out of his car and let him go ahead into the school.

All that was left was the smoke from his car after he left. The smoke's better off! Haaayyy...

I walked into the school. As soon as I reached the gate, I was staring at me.

"She really got humiliated!"

"She didn't even defend her."

"Poor thing."

Whispers from the students. I immediately knew why the

When I got to our building, I took a moment to listen. Th
it seemed like there wasn't any trouble... but that was jus

"Just tell the truth already!" David shouted.

I was standing next to the door when I heard that. I stoppe
a moment to what they were talking about.

"Don't tell Keifer what to do!" Rory replied. "...He'll tell
needs the right time."

"I feel sorry for Jay-jay." Ci-N said, which made my hea

Feel sorry?! Really?!

"They already said to stop this plan!" Eman shouted ang

"Stop pretending! You're one of the ones who started this
Denzel snapped.

Plan?!

Everything they were saying mixed up in my mind. I wa
couldn't understand what they were talking about. It was
and now they wanted me to know the truth because they

"Just say it properly, then we'll apologize." Blaster said.

"I like it's that easy?" Drew said sarcastically.

I took a step into the room. Everyone was staring at me, hide the emotions I was feeling. My eyes fell on Keifer, reaction.

"J-jay-jay..." they called me softly.

They were all there. Even Kit, with his swollen face, was

"What's the truth? What's the plan?" I asked weakly.

I wanted to know the truth, but I also didn't. There was fear hurt by what I might find out. My intuition was screaming

They all looked at Keifer. He was emotionless, arms crossed straight back in his chair.

"What's the plan? What's the truth?" I repeated the question, gaze on him.

Just say something!

"Keifer... Please, say something," Yuri pleaded.

"Keifer! Just say it!"

"Say something already!"

"What's the plan? What's the truth?" I repeated, my voice

I couldn't hold back my emotions any longer. I was in so how he just stared at me and didn't say a word. The other shocked by my reaction, but they chose to avoid eye con

"You sure you want to hear it?" Keifer asked seriously.

I tried to hold back my tears and nodded at him. He smile shook his head. His mouth slowly opened, but I didn't hear any sound from anyone else. It was like I suddenly went few seconds before his words sank in.

"I used you."

I stood there, stunned, waiting for him to say more. Another tear fell from my eyes.

"...and the whole Section E knows it."

It felt like my heart had been punched, defenseless.

All I could do was cry and stare at the ground.

U-used me?

Keifer stood up and slowly walked toward me. "I used you your cousin—oh wait! Your brother, actually."

I trembled at his words. He knew about that too? They all

"Then I'll explain it to you," he said calmly. "...The mom up in front of me, acting like he cared for you, that's what — to be exact? That was when we made fun of you in the

That's when they hit me with the ball. My nose bled, and I could faint, Aries came to stop me and asked me to go home

"...We made sure we had your information—thanks to Rory

I looked at Rory, but he quickly looked down, avoiding my gaze. "I found out that you and Aries are siblings."

Damn! They knew!

He suddenly smirked, and his aura changed. I couldn't tell if he was serious or if he had something else in mind.

"...but the plan is useless. That asshole doesn't care about revenge is pointless." He said, chuckling lightly.

This wasn't the Keifer I knew. His eyes were dark, full of

"K-keifer... P-please stop," Yuri interrupted.

My legs and feet froze from standing. I wanted to believe it was a joke, that they were messing with me. But no, he wasn't. It was real. A joke.

The next day, I was in the hospital. My nose was broken, and I had a concussion. The doctors said I was lucky to be alive.

I looked at Ci-N. he was crying too, staring at me like he needed my mercy.

"Were you in on it too?" I asked weakly.

he sobbed, trying to wipe his tears away. "I-I'm sorry, Jay."

That's why he apologized to me before—it was because from the beginning, they had been playing games with me. I could have trusted them so much.

I looked at the others, but they all avoided eye contact. Crying me for a long time. But even with him, I felt anger.

Did I do something wrong?! Why did I have to be played?

I turned my gaze back to Keifer, who had no expression even a hint of pity or remorse for what he did.

"W-why, Keifer? W-why?"

He didn't answer. I couldn't stand being in front of him and all of them. What's the point of crying in front of them? My knees were shaking, I forced myself to walk away.

"Jay! Wait!"

"Jay-jay."

"Don't even try!" I wiped my cheek. "...You really are be so good at manipulating people!"

"Jay... Believe me, we're regretting it—"

"So you admit it now?! Because your conscience is eatin
I glanced behind him and noticed Ci-N following him.

he was still crying. As much as I wanted to feel pity for l

"You too..." I shook my head. "...I treated you like a brot

"Jay... I'm sorry," he said.

I also saw the others staring at us. I glared at them until l

"Enough..." I whispered, then immediately ran off.

I pushed through the pain and aches in my legs and thigh nothing could hurt more than what I was feeling. The wc even come close to describing the pain.

I could hear Yuri and the others arguing behind me. It se were trying to follow me, but the others were stopping th nearing the school gate when I saw Aries looking at me.

They wanted to get back at him...

Chapter 191: Brother

Jay-jay's POV

It's the end for me!----That was the first thought that crossed my mind. I smelled burning rubber, and it was a bit smoky. I was so shocked by the sudden appearance of the car that I almost couldn't move.

I was sitting on the road, almost right next to the front of the car. I couldn't move from the shock; I felt like my entire system was shutting down. Just what I needed. This was the same feeling I had when a girl kissed me on my head. But the situation now was different.

"Shit!" I heard someone shout. "...Are you okay?!"

I looked up at the person who spoke. He was now in front of me with concern. My body still refused to move, but even so, I saw the person in front of me.

"P-Percy?"

He slightly crouched down to be at my level. He looked at me, and I knew what shocked me more—what I had just found out. That I was almost hit by a car, or that Percy was now standing in front of me.

"G-get me out of h-here!" I pleaded.

I couldn't stay in this place any longer. I knew they were earlier, and at any moment, they might find me.

"O-okay," Percy replied, helping me stand up.

He also helped me get into his car. I continued to cry, my much that I wanted to stop.

He got in and immediately started the car. He kept glanc back at the road.

"Are you hurt? We're going to the hospital," he said.

I shook my head while trying to wipe my cheeks. "I-I do

"Huh? But—"

"JUST TAKE ME TO A QUIET PLACE!" I shouted, sta

"O-okay... W-we're going..."

The car sped up. I didn't know where we were headed. I away, as far as possible. Far from Mama, far from Aries, damn snakes, and far from their King.

I used you...

was so insistent. Because he knew they would retaliate. I was guilty, and that beast Keifer would come after him.

He's the reason for all of this! None of this would have happened weren't for him. I wouldn't have been played by those bastards. I have...

Fallen for him and his trap!

"Jay..." Percy called out to me as he continued driving. "What happened? Why are you crying like this?"

I didn't answer. I kept staring outside. I relived everything that happened. Their reactions and everything they said.

Family?!

I was the only one who thought of them that way. I was the only one who believed we were friends. I was the only one who thought of them as family. I was the only one, just me.

I should have had doubts. Who would accept someone like me? Who would want to be my friend? Even back then, they would prefer to leave when they had nothing more to gain from me.

No one wants to be with someone like me!

My mind and body were exhausted from everything that

I couldn't get the image of his eyes out of my mind as he
to me.

"Of course, it's part of my plan."

My chest tightened even more at those words. I punched
times, hoping to lessen the pain, but it didn't work.

This is so messed up!

I looked outside and noticed we had stopped. We were p
beach. I looked at Percy, but he wasn't in the driver's sea
quickly opened the door and got out.

A strong wind greeted me. I tried to wipe the tears from
in my system was still swirling, but I was more focused o

Did he leave me again?!

"Are you done?"

I turned around. He was holding a bottle of water as he a
expression was serious, and I couldn't tell if he was angr

I swallowed hard and took a deep breath. "S-sorry... I-I c
stopped."

He handed me the bottle, which I took. "Yeah... It's obvie
... .."

I quickly took the handkerchief and wiped my nose. I was overwhelmed with embarrassment because of that. Of course crying, I'd have a runny nose too. I hadn't even thought about it since earlier.

So embarrassing! So annoying...

I glanced at Percy when I noticed him walking toward the car. I looked around. There was a store near where we parked. It was empty except for some kids playing in the distance.

It was quiet, and the sound of the waves was soothing.

I took off my shoes and socks and left them by the car. I followed Percy, who continued walking.

"You've lost weight..." he said as I caught up to him. "...not properly?"

"Y-yes..." I answered hesitantly.

This was what I had been waiting for—to finally face him. My head and mind were too drained to ask anything. Still, it mattered that he was here with me now. I just hoped he wouldn't leave again.

I drank the water he gave me. I finished it quickly, partly because I was thirsty and felt dehydrated from all the crying. My eyes were watery and the wind from the sea made it worse.

This feeling was so annoying. I had so many questions w but now I couldn't say anything. There was so much I wa since I was struggling so much, maybe I'd just ask one th

"H-how's P-papa?" I asked almost in a whisper.

He stopped walking and looked in another direction.

"They're still in New York..."

"When is he coming back?"

He took a deep breath. "I don't know yet."

Why did it feel like he was avoiding the topic? He was ri but it felt like he was drifting away. I didn't understand! face me either, as if he was hiding something.

Tears started welling up in my eyes again, threatening to moment. He started walking again, but I didn't follow. I sand and watch the sea.

Should I just drown myself? To end all of this!

Damn it! Does it really have to happen all at once? Can't over the next few months? Does it have to be so immedi making me cry so much that it has to happen all at once? idiot Percy have to add to it?

What happened?!

Instead of answering him with words, tears were the first out. Damn it! Everything that happened to me was flashi

From the night Keifer got angry because of what David c
kicked me out in front of Aries. Damn it! And then findi
siblings. And now... realizing that they were just playing

"Please... say anything," Percy pleaded.

I looked at him, biting my lip hard to stop myself from c

"K-Keifer..." I took a deep breath. "...he used me. He jus
sounded like a child's complaint.

Suddenly, he hugged me, causing my head to bury into h
pushing him away, I just let it happen. It only made me c

What's happening to me is so messed up. I didn't even ge
back, to defend myself.

I'm so weak! I'm weak!

"I feel like... everyone close to me is just fooling me," I s

"Shhh... don't think like that," he said.

How can I not think like that? One truth after another ha

I clenched my fist and punched him hard. I immediately stepped back. I watched as he took the punch, wincing at the head.

"You knew..." I said, pointing at him. "...You knew Aries and you knew Keifer's plan."

He stood up, even though he was visibly dizzy. It seemed to have landed on his jaw because that's where he was holding.

"...Tell me! Were you in on Keifer's scheme too?!" I asked.

"Damn it!" he suddenly shouted. "...you punch hard! Are you?"

I felt annoyed by what he said. I didn't know if he was denying or answering my question.

"Answer me!" I demanded.

He took a deep breath. "I knew Aries was your brother because of him. As for Keifer's plan, I found out through David."

He explained. "...Believe me, I tried to come back as soon as I could to save you from Keifer. If I hadn't run into some problems, I would have been up sooner."

Shit!

~~~~~

He finished what I was trying to say.

He was right about everything. The fear wouldn't leave me when suspicion keeps getting in the way.

"S-sorry..."

"Jay-jay..." I felt his hand rest on my head. "...Let them let you make you cry. Let them fool you..." I felt his other hand on my shoulder only then did I realize he was hugging me. "...Because at the end of the day, I'm here to you and stand by you. I'll be with you and make you feel safe alone."

His words were comforting. I wanted to believe him, but I didn't want to gamble my trust again.

"P-Percy..."

"It's okay if you're scared."

I'm so scared...

If only you knew how much I want to believe what you're saying helps ease the weight in my chest, I'm willing to give you a chance.

"...I'm willing to prove I'm trustworthy."

At that moment, my tears stopped on their own, even though I was still crying.

You idiot!

I felt like banging my head on the rocks. The conversation and I had almost exhausted myself from crying, but here I was like a fool who just pulled a prank.

Should I start crying again? Because aside from the liars close to me, it seems like I won't even have a sane person. Everyone seems to have escaped from a mental institution.

Hang in there, Jay...

"Should I be sad because there's another crazy person in here innocently."

He laughed loudly while shaking his head. "Just kidding to make you smile."

I shook my head and looked away. "Tsk! I want to know if you don't have time for your jokes."

His expression suddenly turned serious. "I know you were really hurt. But with everything that's happened to you too, I'll save that for next time."

I felt annoyed. Here he goes again, leaving me hanging. There was a plane waiting to pick me up, but there wasn't

What if that's not true? What if he's just saying that to me?  
What if he's planning to leave again? What if...

"Just tell me, please..." I bowed my head and closed my eyes.  
I was tired."

I felt his hand rest on my head. "If you insist... Okay."

His hand on my head suddenly grabbed my hand. My eyes  
pulled me. We were heading back to his car. He pressed the  
key and opened the door.

I looked at him as he didn't move. He was waiting for me.

I grabbed the shoes I left earlier and got in. He closed the door  
the other side to get in and take the driver's seat. After climbing in,  
he started the engine first to turn on the air conditioning.

It felt comfortable, but my eyes were stinging.

Argh! Damn it! I might go blind.

"I hope you're ready for this..." I heard him whisper.

He took a black bag from the back seat. He pulled out a flashlight  
from it.

My heart was racing. There was nothing to expect, but what was  
going to happen next?

"Yes, and that baby who looks like a squished face... The answered.

He handed me another photo. It was a beautiful, fair-skinned foreign man with blue eyes—his dad! That was the man in the house before. There was also a baby with them.

"That's us... Our family picture. And that freakishly handsome man he explained.

Why is that?!

Why do I look like a squished face as a baby, while he's so handsome? That doesn't seem fair. Before I could protest, he handed me another photo.

"And this is... Their family," he said with a sad tone.

It was a picture of Papa with Percy's mom. They were dressed as if attending a high-class party. They weren't smiling like in the photos. What I didn't understand was the term "their family."

I looked at Percy, waiting for what he would say next. He looked at the pictures in my hands.

"We're the same..." he began. "...We're both illegitimate children."

# Chapter 192: Stepbrother

## Jay-jay's POV

"We're both illegitimate children."

I'm an illegitimate child?

I didn't know that. Lola never told me. None of them did planned to tell me.

I tightened my grip on the pictures, causing them to crumple. I couldn't understand how I became an illegitimate child.

"Explain it to me," I demanded.

He pulled out another picture from the brown envelope and showed it to me. It was a picture of an old man sitting in a wheelchair.

"That's your grandfather," he said.

My grandfather?

He handed me another picture. I let go of the earlier picture and swallowed hard, my hands trembling as I saw who was in it. It was Papa and Percy's mom, and they were wearing wedding



I stared at him, frozen, as every word he said shook me to the truth he was telling me felt like a slap in the face.

"They were married before we were even born," he added to fall again.

Damn it!

"I-I don't understand. H-how?" I asked, unable to believe what I was hearing.

Is that why we're illegitimate children? But if they were married, how did they end up having families with other people?

This is so confusing!

I regretted saying earlier that I wanted to know everything, now I was making the most of making me cry.

"I don't know how, but they both chose to build families with each other," he said, taking a deep breath. "...We're"

Every word he said was clear. It's in Tagalog! But why did I feel confused? I couldn't process what he was saying.

I had so many questions, but it felt like I couldn't even wait for answers. This is so messed up!

~~~~~

Aren't you tired of falling?!

"Just like us," he said sadly. "...Mama left us and never s
Papa married someone else, and that's Felix's mom."

"But why?"

He took one of the pictures from my lap. He showed me
grandfather.

"Because of him... He found out the truth and threatened
killed if they didn't stop."

I stared closely at the old man's face in the picture. He lo
could still see the sophistication and authority in him. He
though I'm old, I'm rich!"

Three M's! Old, Rich, and Grumpy!

I looked back at him as he lowered the picture. His eyes
knew he was also hurt by what my grandfather did. We v
of the families our parents built, but that family wasn't al

"But... How did you end up with Papa?" I asked.

He said his mom also left him and never showed up agai
they together?

Th

They immediately thought he was dead?! Didn't it occur to me I might still be alive?

"B-but why didn't anyone know you were alive?"

If only you knew what happened when you disappeared. I was apart. Almost everyone was angry at Aries because people

He gripped the steering wheel, his hold tightening. "Maybe they think that I was already dead," he said with a bitter smile. I had the nerve to feel upset about why no one visited me. Turns out I was dead to them."

I shook my head. "You didn't show up for 4 years... Why didn't you say anything?" My voice started to rise.

I wasn't the one left behind when he disappeared. It didn't matter because I didn't even know him back then, but I couldn't find him.

"Almost 4 years..." he corrected me. "...I was paralyzed. My whole body, and your dad was the one who took care of me. They thought I knew you—he kept telling me things about you, and it really hurt to love with you."

What the heck!

My eyes widened at what he said. Fall in love with me?!

Why does my life have to be this complicated? Why does this?! Why do I have to be the one to suffer through all of

I put my foot on the chair and hugged my knee. It felt like I was facing my problems.

Percy was right. Maybe I shouldn't have found out everything. I should have just let my anger pass. I guess I'm really sorry I made you cry, and that's why problems keep coming my way.

I used to be tough, facing fights, but now, I'm crumbling. I've just learned. I'm not usually a crying person, but today I was ready to face my problems, but I couldn't even face

Because I'm weak!

I looked at Percy, who was currently staring at me. His expression was full of pity, like I was the most mistreated person. I hate being pitied. What can I do? I was really mistreated.

I was mistreated by the truth, slapped in the face like I was tortured until I cried.

Feels like a soap opera, I must be an actress!

"Percy..." I called out to him, like I was asking for help.

Suddenly, he hugged me. I returned the hug and cried un-

I thought we would get along, my brother and I, even though we had different fathers, but it wasn't like that. We could never g

I don't know how long we stayed in that position. I only knew when I felt exhausted. I was still holding on to him, looking

"Do you want to go home?" He asked me.

I shook my head and pulled away from his hug. "I don't want

"It's not allowed... You need to—"

"For what?" I interrupted him. "...So I can be deceived and manipulated? Let them fool me and make me do what they want?"

"If you're not going home, where are you going?" He asked me.

I looked down and fiddled with my fingers. "To your place."

"WHAT?!" He asked, shocked. "...Are you out of your mind? Stay with us!"

I felt irritated by his words. "Why not?! You and Dad are not allowed?"

"Because your Dad isn't here! People might think I'm taking advantage of the situation while they're gone!" He replied.

I grabbed him by the collar and shook him hard. It felt like his head popped off.

"Ouch! Stop—Ouch!" He screamed while holding my hand.

"I'm not going back there! I don't want to see them!" I screamed.

"T-Tumi—Jay!" He screamed again.

I let go of him, and it caused his head to hit the car window. He flinched from the pain.

I might have gone overboard!

"It hurts... Are you going to kill me?" He complained while holding his head.

I suddenly felt guilty, mixed with sympathy for him. I didn't do it to him that way. He was still holding the part of his head that hurt.

"It's not fair!" He said angrily. "...You need to face them and give them their explanation."

I looked down. It's true, I need to face my family, but I don't want to. I'm not ready to listen to their explanations.

"Okay, let's do this." He said, and I looked at him. "...When we arrive, I'll pick you up so you can go home with us."

He put them back in the brown envelope and tossed it to started the car after cleaning up. I just stared outside the was going through my mind.

I was blank on what could happen.

I was also blank on what I could do other than leave Aur felt like a wilted vegetable, lifeless and without the will t were sore, and even without looking, I knew my nose wa

I think I used up all of Percy's tissues in the car. He hand while I was hugging him. It was a whole box of tissue p was empty.

He's rich, so he can buy a new one.

The sky turned yellow and orange when we reached the realized how far we had gone until now.

The car suddenly turned into a drive-thru. That's when I we hadn't even had lunch yet. I suddenly felt embarrasse

He was probably hungry too.

"Ten Happy Meals..." He told the McDonald's crew. "...4 Minion burgers, and... the drinks should be Honey Banai

Honey Banana float?!

What will I do with the toys?!

The car started moving, and one by one, the crew handed Happy Meal boxes, two bags filled with burgers wrapped and three plastic bags holding the drinks.

I couldn't move because Percy piled everything—plastic Meal boxes—on my lap. We started driving again and stopped in the parking area.

"Let's eat!" He yelled and grabbed a burger.

He ate so quickly that he almost choked. I couldn't help but think of his actions, it reminded me of how some people eat so recklessly.

Like the starving ones!

I gently closed my eyes and tried to push that thought out of my mind. The greed of those snakes. How they rush in line just to get food. I remember them, it brings back memories of us being together. It wasn't even real.

Don't cry!

"Eat already... I know you're hungry," Percy said, causing me to cry again.

He was holding two burgers now, both with bites taken.

I kept eating quickly. It felt like I was in some kind of ea
glanced at Percy, who was already finishing his second c
holding a burger.

I almost choked from eating so fast. Sometimes, I didn't
properly. I grabbed a drink and just drank it straight.

Shit! Brain freeze...

My head hurt from how cold the drink was. I couldn't ev
because I was holding a burger in one hand and a drink i

"Hahahaha... You eat so much," Percy laughed, bits of fc
his mouth.

So gross!

"I'm so embarrassed of you," I said irritably.

I went back to eating and ignored him. He had already fi
while I was on my second. There was only one burger le

He looked at me and smiled mischievously. "I'll take this
already eaten enough."

His hand was already reaching for the burger, but I quick
away.

.....

I was already in so much emotional pain, and now he was...
He let go of me and immediately took a bite of the burger
was still wrapped.

Wow! So, he's not greedy with that kind of behavior?!

After biting it, I screamed at him again to take the burger
grab it from me, but I quickly reached for his head to slap

"OW!" He screamed loudly, a mix of pain and anger.

I unwrapped the burger and took a big bite. He raised an
eyebrow at me.

While I was chewing, he suddenly looked out the window
pointed. I was so confused that I looked too, but suddenly
he took the burger out of my hand.

I was tricked!

"Hey!" I yelled again.

I thought he was just going to bite it, but he suddenly lied

He smiled mischievously and tried to give the burger back

"Oh here! Shove it up your chest!" He said while laughing

I looked at him with disgust. He really looked silly with

But even so, I couldn't help but smile. For a moment, I forgot my problems because of his silliness. But I couldn't let my guard down, it was the same before. I became too comfortable with them, not noticing that they were already deceiving me.

"Do you still have drinks left?" He asked while trying to open the plastic bags.

I took a deep breath and handed him the remaining drink.

I grabbed one for myself and let him finish the rest.

This guy's really something. It's like he's never eaten a burger at McDonald's before. After finishing his meal, he started playing with the toys.

"Banana! Banana!" He said while playing with one.

I suddenly laughed at him. He looked like a kid, and it reminded me of my -shit! It felt like I was being stabbed when I thought of that.

I looked away and started cleaning up our mess. I gathered the plastic bag and went out of the car to throw it in the nearest trash can.

When I came back, all the toys were already opened, and he was playing with them.

Pffftt... Childish!

I felt nervous. A huge part of me didn't want to go home. the people there.

As the car kept moving closer to our place, my heart started wanted to open the car door and jump out.

But that might hurt... Never mind.

When we turned the corner into our street, the car slowed far away, I could already see the parked cars outside our people who seemed to be waiting.

Shit! What are they doing here?!

The nervousness I felt earlier was now mixed with anger like I didn't want to go home even more. I couldn't understand snakes had to show up here.

The car stopped a few houses away from ours. I looked at heard him sigh.

"I didn't want to face them yet. But..." He looked at me and need to go home."

"Maybe I can go home tomorrow? Maybe because----."

"No. We already talked about this, Jay." He said seriously anymore.

Percy held my hand and smiled. He nodded at me as if saying "you can get out now." I had no choice but to open the door, trying my best to hide what I was feeling. I also forced myself to have a blank expression.

This was so hard for me! Hiding the pain in front of the people I loved me.

Chapter 193: I shall return

Jay-jay's POV

I'm really not ready to face them yet. The wound is still fresh, and everything else—just this morning. But Percy is so persistent, he bang his head against the wall.

"Jay-jay."

"It's Jay-jay."

"She's here."

They spoke one after another. Their faces were full of concern. Some of them tried to approach me but stopped when the door opened. I saw Felix and David's surprise. The others looked probably because they didn't know Percy.

"K-kuya?" Felix called out to him.

Percy smiled at him. "How are you? Did you miss me, Kuya?"

Felix froze, and I could see his lips trembling.

I took the opportunity while their attention was on Percy.

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She immediately gave me a sharp look but quickly softened. "You talking about?"

"I'm an illegitimate child because Papa was already married to her," I said directly.

I didn't care if others heard what I was saying. They would eventually. Keifer, especially—he has his ways, right?!

Mama took a deep breath. "W-where did you hear that?" tinged with irritation.

I didn't answer. We stared at each other for a few seconds at the door behind me.

"Good evening," Percy said as he entered.

The reaction of those who knew him in the house was silent. Tita Gema even covered her mouth. Kuya Angelo was unimpressed. Aries' eyebrows almost met in the middle as he greeted him.

"You've finally shown up," Keifer said.

"I missed you guys," Percy replied.

Even though I couldn't see him, I knew he was smiling. I smiled back at me. I glanced at him briefly before turning my attention back to the group, which was puzzled by him.

Percy laughed and looked at me before speaking. "Alive

Aries gasped and seemed to be holding back his anger. He and rubbed his face. It's really shocking when you see so well whom you thought was dead.

Percy faced me and placed his hand on my back. "Is even

What do you think?!

I couldn't answer because it was obvious that everything could feel everyone's gaze on us, full of confusion.

"Excuse me? Can I know who you are?" Mama asked irritably.

"Sorry... Where are my manners?" Percy extended his hand. "I am Percy Rey Mariano. Son of Reycee Mariano."

Mama's reaction slowly changed. It was as if her earlier anger had been answered. This only meant that she knew Reycee—Percy.

Mama immediately grabbed my arm and pulled me close. She pulled my hand away, which made her frown.

"Why are you together?! What do you want with my child?" she asked angrily.

Percy smiled as if Mama wasn't mad at him. "Nothing, really. We're just friends."

He smiled and said goodbye to us. Keifer, Yuri, and Arie followed him. I didn't know what kind of conversation they had, but I had a strong feeling it would get messy.

When they were completely out of sight, Mama immediately grabbed both of my arms tightly.

"How did you meet that guy?! What did he tell you?!" she asked.

"Jeana..." Tita Gema tried to stop her.

I tried to pull my arms away, but her grip only tightened. Her nails digging into my skin, making it even more painful.

"Answer me!" she shouted.

"He came to see me!" I shouted back.

Honestly, I wanted to scream, "It hurts!" I was already in pain. She was holding me so tightly she was holding me. Her nails were digging deep into my skin, starting to sting.

"What did he tell you?!"

I yanked my hand away forcefully. Her nails almost tore away.

It hurt!

Her gaze was fixed on me. I matched her stare. I knew she deserved respect, but I couldn't help showing her how I felt about her.

"WHAT ELSE!" she shouted loudly, making me step back.

"Why do you even care what he said?!"

Suddenly, she grabbed my chin and squeezed it. I could see anger in her eyes.

"Hon! You're hurting the kid!" Andy tried to intervene, but she pushed him away.

Tears started falling one after another. I was struggling to breathe. I shouldn't have been. I couldn't breathe even though no one was touching me. I couldn't move even though there was plenty of space around me.

"I've had enough of you! Why won't you answer my questions?" she asked angrily, poking me with her finger.

"Jeana... Let go of Jay-jay. You're hurting her—."

"Stay out of this!" Mama cut off Lola.

"...This is between mother and child!"

"Were you ever a mother to me?" I asked insultingly.

Her voice was breaking, and her subsequent slaps lacked was hitting me all over.

"Why do you have to make things so hard for me?!"

I didn't answer. I just waited for her slaps to land. They hurt nothing could hurt more than what had already happened.

"Why did you have to be my mother?" I almost whispered.

"Jay-jay!" Lola scolded me.

I waited for Mama's hand to hit my face again, but it didn't. I just and saw tears streaming down her face as if she was shocked.

I didn't feel anything. Maybe I was numb from the pain.

"Jay-jay... Don't talk to your mother like that," Kuya said.

I ignored him. My gaze remained fixed on Mama. It felt like no one else in the house except the two of us.

"A teenage mother..." I began. "...a town's wife, and now what title are you going to take next?"

Another hard slap landed on my face. I almost stumbled. My cheek went numb from the pain, but my heart hurt even more than who had slapped me.

Keifer and Yuri's car stopped in front of me. Aries' car and my car also stopped. My friends got out, looking like they'd been through a war—of course, I was the most blessed! The unfamiliar car also got out.

It was David driving, and Felix was with him, giving me a thumbs up and smiling at them while crossing my arms.

"Percy..." David called out to me.

"Tsk! Tsk! You don't answer my calls..." I said, shaking my head.

He glanced at Keifer for a moment. "S-something happened."

"What the f***?! Am I the only one who didn't know you were here?" Aries said angrily.

"We only found out recently," Yuri answered him.

"But you could've at least told me what you knew!"

Aries rubbed his face and took a deep breath. As I expected, he wouldn't be happy to see me. He struggled a lot when I did, but he carried the blame for everything.

"What makes you show up?" Keifer asked, sounding bored.

"Stupid question," I muttered, turning to him with a smile.

"That's your reason? You couldn't call or send us a message needed to leave?" Yuri asked, sounding annoyed.

If I was calm earlier, now it felt like I couldn't be anymore. It felt like I was back to square one. My head was heating up whenever I saw him.

"I was paralyzed after 'The accident.' Mom never allowed anyone," I said, slightly irritated.

I emphasized the words "the accident" so they would remember it happened. It's embarrassing because it feels like I'm the one who moved on.

"What the f*** is your connection with Jay-jay?" Keifer asked.

Ugh! Why do I need to explain everything to them?!

"Haaayy... Explaining is exhausting," I muttered and stood up. "...She's my stepsister. It just so happens that my Mom is married to Dad. I know you're all aware of my story with my Mom."

"Is that really it? It feels like something else," Yuri said.

I gave him a sharp look. "What are you trying to say?"

"I don't know... Maybe revenge against us?" he said innocently.

I thought I was the one who loved to annoy people, but Yuri was the one who loved to annoy me.

Shit! I closed my eyes as that night flashed back to me. I think about it yet. I couldn't concentrate on what I wanted.

"You can't possibly not be angry at us. How would we know planning to use Jay—"

I suddenly laughed loudly, making Yuri stop talking. They weren't believing what they wanted.

"I will never do that... I'm not like you," I said, still laughing.

Keifer raised an eyebrow. "Like us?"

"Yeah..." I suddenly became serious. "...Did you think I did you did to Jay-jay?"

Keifer smiled and looked at David. I had a clue now why he was answering my calls and why his face looked swollen.

"Your dog is loyal to you..." Keifer said and laughed.

I saw David clench his fist. There's nothing Keifer doesn't want to sure to hide my connection with David, but he still caught me.

"...did you also order your dog to kiss Jay-jay?" Keifer asked.

I didn't react even though I was shocked. Even Yuri, Ariana, and Keifer at Keifer and David.

His face was so annoying, even his red hair. He looked like I damn it!

I took a deep breath and looked at Keifer. "To push Keifer show Jay-jay his true nature."

I hope I'm saying the right things. I had no clue what happened, sure about what I was saying.

"Congratulations..." Keifer said and clapped. "...Your doing."

That was close! Good thing it didn't happen...

"What are you planning now that you're here?" Aries asked.

I smiled at him. "Make up for the hurt I caused and introduce me to your dad."

"That's not going to happen," he replied. "...Stay away from me."

He didn't wait for me to say anything and immediately got speeding off. I turned my gaze to Keifer and Yuri.

"He should have told you that," I said, laughing.

They both just shook their heads and got into the car. The other, leaving David and Felix behind. I smiled at my brother, his eyebrows were furrowed.

Chapter 194: Last cry

Jay-jay's POV

Tita kept knocking on my door. I knew they wanted to talk but I chose not to face them. I turned up the volume of the music.

My headphones were plugged into my ears. I didn't want to hear them. Right now, I only want to listen to rock music.

Sigh... It feels like old times.

I glanced at my phone when a text message arrived.

****From:**** Ci-N

****Message:**** Please come to school... 🙄🙄

I immediately deleted his message. I hadn't gone to school in a long time. I lost interest in many things, and that included going to school.

What for? To see them? To see *him*? No way!

Sometimes I think about just ending my life, but it's not that easy. I want to see and spend time with Papa, even if it's just for a moment.

I pushed him back with all my strength while gripping his angry glare.

"Why?! Did you tell me Papa was nearby?! Did you tell illegitimate child?! DID YOU TELL ME WE'RE SIBLINGS back. "...So don't complain! We're even!"

His anger toward me intensified. He pushed me back again but I pushed back. We ended up looking like kids shoving

"STOP IT!" Kuya Angelo shouted loudly and immediately at us. Tita Gema followed, trying to calm us down. They fought. Kuya stood between us, blocking us with his arms. I still have my eyes off Aries.

"Explain yourself, Aries," Kuya ordered calmly.

He didn't answer, keeping his angry gaze on me. If Kuya had his time, we might have started throwing punches.

Even if he's my sibling!

I wouldn't hesitate to make his nose bleed. After all, he has a reason for all my suffering now. I just want to get back at him just one punch.

"What's going on?" Mama suddenly interjected, looking surprised. "...Why is the doorknob like this?"

I quickly took a shower and got ready. When I came out they were gone, and the door was closed—but the doorknob was broken.

Aries must have really lost it to barge in here and confront me.

They're really all friends—they're all crazy.

But Percy is crazier.

I was wearing my school uniform, but I brought a change of clothes in a bag. I pretended I was going to school so they wouldn't ask me why I didn't want to go to school. What would I do there?!

Act all cute?!

After changing, I went downstairs, and Lola was the first to see me.

"I'm going to school," I said and walked past her.

I heard her softly call my name, but I kept walking. Her words hurt. It hurt because she was the one I expected to give me support.

Maybe I pushed her patience too far, and I really was being selfish.

I looked up at the sky and took a deep breath. I was tired of running, but before it could start again, I stopped it.

It would be nice if tears turned into needles when they fell.

"Miss..." the cashier called out to me. "...I can't sell this to a student."

Oh, come on!

"Are you serious?!" I asked sarcastically.

I was starting to get irritated by what she said. A student? Many students in uniform here buying alcohol.

"I'm sorry," she said and was about to take the two bottles.

I gave her a sharp look. My insides were heating up—I needed this?!

"What if I punch your face and make it bleed? Will you stop?"

I saw the shock on her face. She let go of the bottle she was holding.

"Miss... I-it's really not allowed," she said pleadingly.

"How annoying—!"

"Miss!" someone called from behind me. "...I'll pay for this."

I raised an eyebrow at him. I didn't know if it was a coincidence or if he had been looking for me and found me here at the Mini Mart.

"I know I'm handsome, but no need to stare like that," he said.

I didn't answer him. I just took the things he paid for and to sit at. I ate first because my stomach was really empty

When I finished, I turned to the alcohol. I stared at it into instant, the bottle cap suddenly popped off.

Oohhh... The power of staring.

Just kidding! Percy opened it without me noticing. He sat smiling as he looked at me.

"What time are you planning to go to school?" he asked.

I took a drink while looking at him. Argh! It burned my tongue

"I-I'm not going," I answered without enthusiasm.

"Then why are you in uniform?"

"So they won't ask questions."

He chuckled slightly. "That's bad!"

I glared at him sharply—sharp enough to cut. This guy is a jerk. He didn't contact me for days, and now he's teasing me.

"I don't know about you... You're such a pain!"

He suddenly laughed loudly, even slapping the table. I glared at him.

I just facepalmed. He's really something.

Can I request another sibling? It's okay if it's a girl, as long as I can think like this. Someone normal and mature, not this abnormally immature one.

Please... One more sibling! Someone normal to talk to!

"Never mind... I might get annoyed and smash this bottle if you don't said and stood up.

I left the Mini Mart and let him be alone. I knew he'd follow me home is!

"Where are we going?" he asked from behind me.

See?!

"I don't know..." I muttered and started walking away.

Honestly, even though he's like this—acting like an idiot here. For a moment, I forget my problems, even if he's a

I stopped when I noticed something across the street. The car was being all sweet while walking. I don't know why, but I thought it was something break.

"Shit! I hit the window!" Percy shouted and suddenly grabbed the car.

What a pain!

I just shook my head while looking for a bench to sit on.
for a bit but stopped when I noticed something.

A guy in a sweatshirt and a Superman hoodie, wearing a seemingly jogging.

I-it's Keifer.

My feet automatically moved toward him, but I immediately stopped myself. Would I approach him?

I admit there's a part of me that wants to see him. I haven't seen him for two days, so I haven't seen him for two days. What he can't deny—I still have feelings for him!

"Hey... Why?" Percy asked me and also looked at what I "...Ahh."

My eyes blurred with tears. They started falling uncontrollably.

I hope you turn into pearls this time!

It hurts so much! It hurts that I believed he loved me too said. Because it felt real, I could feel it. The way he look me. When he kissed me and hugged me. It felt real to me

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I took a deep breath and looked back in Keifer's direction far from us.

I don't want to assume because I might get hurt. But if I won't know the truth. I walked toward Keifer's direction.

"Hey! Where are you going?" Percy asked as he followed.

"I just want to answer my question," I replied and walked.

"Are you sure about this? Maybe it's just the alcohol talking."

If it's the alcohol, then it's fine. At least I have the courage just for now, I want to answer my question.

Do you love me too?

Even after all their lies. Even if it was just for a moment, his mind or did he ever feel it? Maybe it's possible, like you.

While following him, I didn't notice that he was already at their gate when he stopped. He took off his hands on his hips.

"Next time you follow me, make sure I don't notice you, turning to face us."

He really knows everything!

Suddenly, Percy entered the gate of Keifer's house. Yes, he owned the place.

How bold! Nice!

"Hey!" Keifer shouted at him and immediately followed

"I need to use the bathroom!" Percy replied, quickly running into the house.

I had no choice but to go inside too. I was left outside alone.

Keifer was standing near me, holding his temples.

"When your stepbrother comes out, you should leave," he said and started to walk away.

Wait... I can't waste this opportunity.

"Keifer!" I called out to him, and he stopped. "...I just want to say something."

He turned to face me and waited for me to speak. His gaze made my knees feel weak. I tried to stay strong, but I felt like I was about to collapse.

"What is it?"

"I just want to know..." I took a deep breath. "...after you

"You followed me just to ask that?" he asked, laughing. "this."

He was even shaking his head while saying it. I wanted to because I already knew the answer, but my knees and feet weren't cooperating.

Shit! A little cooperation, please!

"Let me guess... You expected that maybe I developed feelings while I was fooling around with you?"

I couldn't answer. I didn't want to hear what he was about to say.

"What a damn!" he added, laughing loudly. "...This is no movie. Falling for you or realizing that I love you in the end and revenge will never happen."

Damn it!

I didn't want to hear this! Enough! Please! I don't want to have come here.

"So that's how good I am at acting. I fooled you!" He was smiling.

He started walking toward me slowly. His smiling face was ready to do anything harmful.

.....

He smirked. "If you had just given yourself to me during probably would have learned the truth earlier. If you had up then, the plan would have worked." He crossed his arms up and down. "...Such a shame, the other half of Section the bet."

A bet?!

His smile widened when he saw that I had no idea what I was about. He moved even closer to me, causing me to step back.

"Come to think of it... The bet isn't over." Suddenly, he wrapped his arms around my waist. "...Why don't we finish what was interrupted last Year?"

One of his hands gripped my jaw tightly. I shut my eyes and tried to push him away, but he only pulled me closer to him.

"L-let me go," I pleaded, but he just stared at me.

"I know you want it," he said, and he kissed me violently.

I cried even more at what he did. This wasn't how it was supposed to be. This wasn't the kiss he gave me. I was in pain, and it felt like he was reminding me that he could easily do this to me.

I felt disrespected by what he was doing. He was losing respect for me.

I aimed for his jaw on purpose.

He fell! Even though my vision was blurry from my tear and followed up with another punch. I was on top of him punch.

My fist landed on his face several times, and his nose and bleeding, but my tears still fell non-stop.

I stopped when I saw the way he was looking at me.

There was no life in his eyes...

I cried even louder. My tears fell onto his face, mixing with his blood. I stared into his eyes, wanting him to see how much his actions hurt me. Only his conscience could eat him up and never let him sleep.

I noticed a tear fall from the corner of his eye.

Impossible!

I immediately got off him. I glared at him as he slowly sat up, his face, which was covered with my tears and blood.

Those are my tears, not his!

He's not going to cry for me. He won't do that! I saw Per the house. I quickly walked away, but before I could leave, he called out to me.

But of course, misfortune struck again. I tripped and almost fell on my face.

I stopped and sat down because of the fear I felt. That moment was the reason for all the pain I had been holding back.

I felt like a child who lost their toy. I kept crying.

"Aaaaaahhhhhh!!!" I screamed as I punched my chest.

It hurt so much!

Why did I even hope?! I'm so stupid. Why do I even like you? I'm even a crybaby. I feel so weak and stupid.

"Jay..." Percy called me softly as he slowly knelt in front of me. "It's enough now."

Instead of calming down, I cried even louder. I tightly hugged myself. I didn't want to cry anymore, I was so tired. I was so sick of crying. Shedding tears that would never become pearls.

This is really the end!

I won't cry for you anymore, never again. I won't waste a second of my life for you. You're an animal, the king of the Demon Snakes.

Chapter 195: Old Jay-jay

Jay-jay's POV

The music was loud, so loud that I couldn't hear what Pe just stared at him while he kept talking. Was he really sa just looked like his mouth was opening and closing.

"WHAT?" I asked him.

He leaned in closer to me and spoke again, but I couldn't shot him a glare.

His mouth just kept moving, but no sound came out! Da

"Idiot! I'll kick you!" I threatened him, and he laughed lo

At least I could hear his laugh. If not, this guy would be was really enjoying making fun of me.

"WOOOOOHHHHH!!" The crowd screamed loudly as t on.

We were at Kingsground now, in the disco section, not th Percy had brought me here, saying it was a good place to un emotions

entered, Tiger was standing next to the large glass window looking down at the people below.

Unlike downstairs where the music was blasting, it was quiet here.

"Boss," said the bouncer, and Tiger turned to face us.

What the hell?!

This guy really knows how to dress. He was wearing shorts with an umbrella design, beachwalk sandals, and a faded tank top with a huge sun hat on.

His outfit was screaming summer vibes!

"Jay-jay!" He greeted me, about to hug me.

I immediately stepped back when I saw the jungle-like short curly hair. Yuck! I wish he'd trim it at least. It was disgusting to see.

"What? Don't worry, I smell good even though I haven't showered in days."

So gross!

"You haven't changed, Tiger," Percy chimed in, so Tiger turned to him.

"Percy," he corrected again, but Tiger kept laughing.

What an idiot!

I glanced at the large mirror. The people on the dance floor were happy. They were dancing to the loud music, enjoying themselves, and they had no cares in the world.

I wish I could be happy like them. I envy them. I want to be happy and have no problems.

Everything seemed alive. People were dancing on the stage, some were kissing in the corners, and others were dancing like there was no one around.

I wish I could be happy like that too.

But after everything that happened to me, I don't know if I can ever be like them. It feels like I'm drowning in sadness, pain, and despair.

The people I considered family lied to me. The people I trusted betrayed me, and most of all, the person I thought loved me used me.

I don't know if I can ever be happy again after everything that's happened.

"...We should talk for a bit." Tiger said, and I looked at him. He was the best dancer I'd ever seen. He ordered the bouncer to let me in.

That night, I danced with Tiger. He was a good dancer, and he was a good person.

"You can... But you can't drink," Percy answered.

What's that supposed to mean? What do I do down there

"What do you mean 'can't'?!" Tiger asked, annoyed. "...L alcohol's on the house for her!"

I almost clapped from excitement. Finally! It's not every alcohol.

It's my lucky day!

He signaled the bouncer, and the man quickly left. I left Percy and walked straight to the bar area.

With so many people, it took me forever to get to my desk into people here and there, and some pushed me around. from it.

When I finally got to the bar, I sat on a stool. The bartender eyebrow as he looked at what I was wearing. Oh right, I uniform.

"Costume," I said to the bartender.

He just nodded, though it was obvious he didn't believe it. bouncer whispering something to the bartender.

That's all I need to know. I'm going to be a bartender.

problems only to get hurt in the end.

I had enough!

"What do you want to drink?" The bartender asked.

I didn't know much about alcohol. I only knew San Miguel seemed like they didn't have that here. Their drinks were different, but I didn't recognize any of them.

"The drink you give to heartbroken people?" I asked, unsure.

The bartender shook his head, smiling at what I said. How could he? What do they give their customers? I didn't know anything about alcohol.

He took out a shot glass and filled it with alcohol. He handed it to me, still smiling.

Is this it? With how small it is, what effect does this have?

I looked at the other customers, all holding the same kind of drink. They drank it down quickly. I mimicked the way they held the glass and drank it just as fast.

Holy crap! Ugh!

I swallowed it straight down, and it felt like I drank fire. It burned my throat and chest. I closed my eyes because the taste was so bad.

She was still right next to me, staring at me. I was starting with her. I gave her a glare, hoping she'd feel it and leave.

I want to punch you!

"What?" She asked innocently. "...Keep drinking, don't r

I did what she suggested. I quickly drank the shot glass, burning sensation hit my throat, the alcohol searing thro

After swallowing the shot, I glanced at the woman beside

She was still staring, smiling. It seemed like she had no i me alone.

"Do you need something?" I asked, a bit annoyed.

She chuckled lightly. "You're funny to watch drinking."

Huh?

I raised an eyebrow. She must be really drunk. Maybe sh she decided to mess with me. I was about to tell her to le came up and put his arm around her.

She immediately pushed him away and shoved him hard

"She's acting shy again, bro!" said the guy who was with
but his arms around her

Shit!

I quickly removed the hand that was almost touching my look at the asshole who did that. The guy who had put his woman was now standing in front of me, grinning widely.

"Fighting back..." said the guy behind him, laughing aloud.

I looked at the woman next to me. She was on the verge desperately trying to push the guys away from her.

"Shit! You're a high school student?" The guy in front of

Oh no... Elementary!

"HVIS student," said one of the guys. "...I heard the high school are wild."

My brows furrowed at what they said. Wild?! What do they mean? They all smiled widely. Six of them, who had just been looking at the woman beside me, were now doing the same to me.

"Stop bothering us! Just leave!" the woman next to me said, pushing them away.

"Shut up, Savannah!" The guy in front of me said, then looked at me.

"Are you alone? Want us to keep you company?"

"Of course. Anywhere you want," the guy in front of me
I smiled back at him and held my shot glass with one hand.
"Even to heaven?"

They laughed and exchanged glances before answering me.
"Why not? If that's what you want."

Perverts! These guys...

I smiled again at him and got ready. "Why don't you go for it."
You're done for! Damn it!

Before he could answer, I poured the shot into his face. I
face, so I took the chance to kick him in the chest.

"Shit!" they shouted.

People around us immediately looked at us. Some didn't
doing their own thing.

Just dance!

"O.M.G." Savannah, who was still by my side, said. "...That
awesome."

She's still here?!

"...Thank you for saving me. I'm Savannah Shane, by the way," she introduced herself, extending her hand.

I didn't want to acknowledge her, but from the looks of it, she was going to keep bothering me. I shook her hand.

"Jay-jay." I answered flatly.

I was about to ask for another drink, but this woman kept talking about those guys who harassed us.

"...Those guys are so annoying... Anyways, thanks again."

"I didn't save you." I interrupted her. "...I just made those guys go away because they were a disturbance."

She shrugged and kept talking. I didn't respond, just staring at my glass. The alcohol still hadn't kicked in, and I was still out of focus, feeling the weight of everything that had happened.

My heart was still broken!

"Why are you so quiet?" Savannah asked, right in front of me.

Yes! Right in front of my face. I moved a little away because it was awkward. I was starting to feel weirded out by her.

She laughed again. "What is your problem?" I looked at "...Well, obviously, you wouldn't be drinking like that if problem."

Obviously?! She's so persistent.

"There's nothing wrong." I said almost in a whisper, but it.

"It's okay, you can tell me. We're friends now----."

What?!

I quickly cut her off. "Friends? When did that happen?"

She laughed again. "Just earlier."

I was starting to get annoyed with her. It was like she didn't want to talk and just wanted to drink.

What the hell, girl?!

"...So tell me, what's your problem? School? Family? Or

I turned away from her last words. That's a bad word, but... She laughed again and even started hitting me playfully.

Just a little more! I'll punch you!

They spoke for a while before the bartender moved. He mixed it with something before shaking it.

It seemed like they were preparing poison for me.

After mixing everything, he poured the concoction into the glass and placed it in front of me. I looked at the bartender and Sarah, still smiling at me.

"What is this?" I asked, a little irritated.

"This is 'Broken Hearted Medicine.' I discovered it myself. ...And don't worry, you won't get drunk from this."

I pointed at the shot glass. "What's the point of this if it doesn't get you drunk?"

She laughed again. "Just try it!"

I just wanted this girl to shut up. It was too late, and I was back to Percy to go somewhere else. My head was already spinning from this woman.

I quickly drank the contents. I squinted my eye because it was sour, bitter, and minty. But unlike before, it didn't burn in my throat.

"Okay, I drank it-----."

~~~~~

She didn't answer, so I opened my eyes. It felt like someone was shaking me through my body. My senses woke up, and I felt so strong.  
Shit!

It felt like I had drunk ten cups of coffee. My heartbeat was racing.  
I looked around, and everything seemed so beautiful. The music was so loud, and it made me want to dance.

"What's the feeling?" Savannah asked with a smile.

I smiled too without realizing it. "Shit! This wakes you up."

Even though nothing was funny, I felt so happy. She ordered another drink that I had earlier. She drank it and suddenly stood up.

"Let's enjoy this night!" She shouted.

She grabbed my hand and pulled me toward the middle of the dance floor. When we stopped, the music got even louder. I smiled with everyone else, watching people dancing.

I want that too!

Even though I didn't know the dance steps, I kept dancing with her. Her hands and just kept moving.

"Woahhhhhhhhh!" I shouted. "Party animal!"

Why do I feel like I'm forgetting something?! Hahahahal

"Savannah!" I called to my dancing partner. "...Did I for"

She nodded. "You forgot to find a date!"

A date?! Is that it?! That's easy!

I looked around. I'll just find someone to drag along. One  
attention. He was handsome and looked serious while sta

Target acquired!

He was standing in the middle of many people. He wasn  
just standing there, staring at me. I bit my lower lip.

I was about to walk toward him when Savannah suddenl  
around me. It seemed like she saw who I was eyeing.

"That's a player." She whispered and laughed. "...His nar

Damn it!

Everything suddenly flashed back to me. The reason wh  
wound I was trying to heal. The words he said. The pain  
go away again!

I want that feeling again! I want that drink I had earlier!

"Please..."

"Miss! I really----."

"Give it to her, Kuya!" Savannah cut in, following me.

The bartender sighed deeply. He grabbed the same drink. When he put it in front of me, I drank it right away.

Shit! Here we go again!

"Let's go!" Savannah called.

We went back to the middle and continued dancing. The music was different from earlier. My senses were sharper. My heart was beating faster.

I felt like I was the only one, even though there were so many people. It was like I was the only one dancing, even though everyone was hitting me. The heat was crazy, even though the breeze was cool.

"WOOOOOHHHH!!!" I shouted. "...Disco! Disco! Good music!"

Savannah laughed beside me while we kept dancing. I couldn't stop laughing for no reason. We probably looked crazy, but we were having fun.

Unstoppable happiness!

I looked at a guy coming toward us. He was staring at me.

His tone was a bit sarcastic, but I just smiled and nodded

Suddenly, his smile disappeared, and he got serious. "En go! I'll take you home!" He said, annoyed.

Huh! This guy's crazy! His mood changed so fast!

"Why would I go with you?! I don't even know you!" I a

Then he suddenly slapped me on the head. I grabbed my force of it. I felt dizzy!

"There! Do you remember now?!" he asked angrily.

I was almost in tears from the pain in my head. I thought pass out. I looked at him angrily, and when the light hit I remembered!

"P-Percy?!"

"My slap works!" He boasted. "...Let's go!"

"I don't want to yet!"

"You're going home, or you're going home?!"

This is so annoying! I was enjoying myself!

# Chapter 196: Keifer's plan

## Jay-jay's POV

Aaaarrrrrggggghhhhhh!!!!

My head hurts so much! I didn't even drink last night, but it is worse than a hangover. I hit my head, hoping it would knock out the pain I'm feeling.

But it didn't work. I'm writhing in bed. Damn it! If this is how I feel after drinking that stuff, I'm never drinking it again.

It really hurts!

I heard a knock on my bedroom door.

"Jay..." It was Aunt Gema's voice. "...Get up. You're going to school."

"O-okay!" I replied.

I forced myself to get up even though my head felt like it was on a pillow. I walked to the bathroom and felt the heaviness of my eyes.

I felt so exhausted and sick. I sat back down on the bed.

I forced myself to move properly. I went straight to the bathroom to take a shower, hoping it would clear my head and make the pain go away. It took a long time because I was moving so slowly.

After showering and getting ready, I went out. Aunt Gen was the first person I saw in the living room.

"Are you going to school now?" she asked.

No. I'm going home. Going home!

"I might be late," I lied.

She nodded with a smile. "Take care."

I didn't reply and just walked out of the house. I could see Aunt Gema's eyes. I don't blame her; I've been distant from her since what happened.

Grandma had already left the house. She didn't say goodnight to me. She wasn't around when my brother took her. It's sad that she's always talking about the time she slapped me.

She always had an explanation for me whenever she hurt me. I wanted to hear it, despite what happened. I don't want to hold anything against her.

I stopped by the pharmacy to buy medicine. My head was



"What is it?"

"Do you have medicine for a broken heart?" I asked serious.

She looked confused and a little embarrassed. "N-no, we

"Medicine for the broken-hearted?"

"None either."

"Medicine for someone who's about to go crazy from the  
that?"

She chuckled a little while shaking her head.

She laughed at me, what a jerk!

I took out some money and handed it to her. Useless pharmacy because it's supposed to sell medicine, but the medicine I'm looking for.

JUST CLOSE DOWN ALREADY!

After getting what I bought and my change, I went straight to the Mart. I bought water and food since I hadn't eaten breakfast.

While eating, someone sat on the bench across from me, smiling at me like an idiot.

"For what?"

"I knew you weren't listening last night! I told you we're said, sounding annoyed.

I don't remember him saying anything like that!

"W-where are we going?"

He scratched his head in frustration. "The amusement pa

I don't feel like it. There's something about that place tha  
rather go somewhere else.

"I-I have school," I lied as an excuse.

"Stop pretending, you don't even study," he said bluntly,

This jerk! It's too early to be pissing me off!

"You found out?!" I asked angrily.

"Of course. Who do you think I am?" he replied with a v

It's probably because of David. That guy's a snitch! Why  
report everything? It's so annoying! I feel like every mov  
watched.

I just glared at him and continued eating. After taking th

I know he's aware of what I've been doing at school, especially in my classes. I'm just lucky I haven't faced him yet.

"He's here," Percy said, making me look at him.

The who?! The who?!

"Who?"

Before he could answer, the bell at the Mini Mart door rang, indicating someone had entered or left. I glanced over and saw one of the guys I blame for all the problems in my life walking in.

David, with his fancy instincts!

"What are you doing here?!" I asked angrily as he approached.

He looked down and avoided eye contact. But I'll admit, it was easier. I thought it was Kuya Angelo. This Percy guy is so smart, he's always in sync with my thoughts.

"Relax... You're too hot," Percy said, standing up. He tapped his arm and nodded.

David sat down in front of me, but I kept my angry glare fixed on him. David, feel it!

If only I could have lasers installed in my eyes—I would have been able to see through his lies and see the truth.

"And then what?! You'll use this chance to fool me again."

"I have no reason to do that," he said calmly.

I paused. He had a point there; he really doesn't have a reason. Unless he wants my forgiveness.

I tried to pull my arm away, but he tightened his grip.

"Let go. I'll scream," I threatened.

I looked around, and honestly, we were the only ones there. The Mini Mart crew members. So if I screamed—it wouldn't matter.

"Look... I'm sorry. I'm sorry if I kissed you."

Holy crap!

It felt like I was slapped by his words. Why did he have to say that? That's one of the reasons, one of the reasons for the way I feel.

I sat back down in front of David. His eyes were sad as he looked at me.

"I'm sorry for everything. For lying to you and for kissing you. ...I know you won't accept it, but I'm willing to take a chance."

Questions had been forming in my mind since that night. A chance, I wanted answers. Like he said, he's willing to take a chance. I know he's willing to answer my questions.

Why, David?!

Why did I kiss her that night? Maybe because of her eye  
Maybe because of her lips that she kept biting. Maybe be  
advantage of the situation.

Maybe because I wanted her.

Her eyes were full of blame as she looked at me now. It  
holding me responsible for what happened that night. Bu  
one who should be blamed.

I couldn't answer. I didn't know how to explain it to her.

"Do you have feelings for me?" she asked next.

Yes, I do!

I wanted to shout that out, but I couldn't. I looked away f  
before facing her again.

"I don't," I answered, looking into her eyes. "...I don't ha  
you."

"But why did you kiss me?!" she asked angrily.

Because I f\*cking like you, and I'm starting to fall for yo

"I needed to push Kiefer to the edge to bring out the truth

She fell silent for a moment, as if thinking. Keifer was fine. He almost killed me because of what I did. He was just a jerk when he found out the truth. Kit almost went into a coma because of him so long to wake up.

"I'm sorry, Jay. We really didn't join that plan because we were at the time. But we kept everything a secret and hid it from you explained.

I still remember the day I came back. After the mess between Freya, I returned to the regular class.

*\*Flashback... \**

"Who?" I asked.

"Jay-jay," Drew replied. "...We have a bet. Want to join?"

That girl.

I didn't think it was a good idea, especially since Jay-jay did save her from the bucket of mud and worms, but I still

"I'm not interested," I said, leaning back to sleep, but soon "...What?"

"W-well..." Ci-N stammered, fidgeting with his fingers. "I'll tell you something."



Ci-N can't disobey Keifer. He can't even fight back. If it fight him again, but this guy, with how small he is, one k over.

I patted his head, and we went back to the room. He follo entered, everyone was in chaos.

"She'll give in eventually... It's Keifer we're talking about arrogantly.

"What if she doesn't? She seems tough!" Denzel replied.

"I'm betting 1000, she'll give in!" Rory shouted.

"2000 for me!" Edrix added.

"1500, she won't give in!" Drew chimed in.

"My bet's the same as before!" Eman said.

I just shook my head. They planned it, and now they're b already feel sorry for Jay-jay. What's going to happen to

*\*End of Flashback... \**

If only I knew this would happen. If only I knew it would much. If only I knew... I would've fought Keifer. I would truth sooner. I would've defended her against the whole !



Those words were enough. She's still the soft-hearted girl still our Jay-jay.

I took something out of my pocket and handed it to her. I got it from Ci-N. She looked at me for a moment before opening it.

"Birthday party?" She looked at me again. "...What is this party?"

I chuckled a little. Ci's invitation had a childish design. "It's a birthday party. Feb. 14, and he wants you to be there."

I told him we'd meet. He wanted to come, but I stopped him because we wouldn't be able to talk properly because of him.

I saw the sadness in Jay's eyes. I'm sure she misses Ci-N.

"I-I don't know if I can go," she said, trying to hand the invitation to me. I stopped her.

"You still have one week to think about it. I know you're nervous because he didn't want that plan either." I smiled and stood up. "I have to go to class."

She looked up when she heard the word "class." I knew she was going to school. Who could blame her? After everything that happened, she might not even go back to school either.

"Maybe in the future, when things are better, I might even come over," he added with a smile.

I smiled back. "Maybe."

He just nodded and went back into the Mini Mart. I walked to my car and got in.

I understand Percy. That's why he doesn't want me to have a relationship with Jay. Her situation is too messy right now, especially since she's hiding the truth about who she is.

I pity and admire her at the same time. She remains strong despite her problems. And that's the Jay-jay we know.

The Jay-jay I like. It's just a shame that I met her in such a difficult situation. If only she weren't Aries' sister. If only Keifer had never loved only Yuri hadn't manipulated her. If only our classmates weren't so judgmental. If only...

If only I could fight for you, but I can't.

# Chapter 197: Back Attack

## Jay-jay's POV

This Percy guy is really something! So pushy. He really that damn amusement park even though I didn't want to.

"I'll just get my car," he said before quickly running off.

The parking in front of the Mini Mart is small, so he ofte away. I was left standing there, pacing back and forth.

I couldn't get David's words out of my head. Damn it! It Keifer might actually have feelings for me because he w David did.

How could that happen?! He doesn't even have feelings :

He's probably just acting. Give him an Oscar—he's bette DiCaprio. How embarrassing!

Now I'm starting to have hope again. I'll just end up hop Then I'll cry again, but my tears won't turn into pearls—1 eye gunk!

While still waiting for Percy I noticed a group of men er

I didn't hear the rest of what they said because they had a Mini Mart. But the name Savannah stuck in my head. What was that before?

Savannah Shane!

Crap! Last night! Why am I becoming so forgetful? What guy who was talking earlier looked like the one I kicked

I'm in trouble!

I looked around, hoping to see where Percy was. Why is he? Where on earth did he go? I can't stay here for long.

I decided to go look for Percy. I don't even have his phone number! I'm a guy!

I was about to walk away when someone suddenly grabbed me. I glared at them, but my expression turned to shock when

What bad luck!

"Look at this..." the guy I kicked in the chest said arrogantly, just talking about you, and here you are, right in front of

I tried to pull my arm away. His grip wasn't tight, so he let go. I turned around and was about to run, but someone blocked

~~~~~

"I'm not in the mood to argue. Can you just move out of calmly.

"What if we don't?" the one in front of me replied.

"Then I'll have to force you," I threatened, cracking my knuckles.

But nothing happened, so they all laughed. My bones didn't seem so annoying!

They all raised their hands and cracked their knuckles or swallowed hard. I wasn't ready to fight!

They laughed and exchanged glances. I needed to get out of here without the intention of getting beaten up by them.

I looked at each of them. The one with his back to the room took a deep breath and pushed him hard. As he fell, I ran.

"Damn it! Chase her!" one of them shouted.

I just kept running. I didn't know where I was going. I just ran away from them.

Damn it!

Where's my bravery now? I must've left it at home. So as I ran, I

I held my head when I felt a sharp pain. I thought the pain

This is Percy's fault! He's taking so long. He's just getting acting like it's a limousine. At this point, I feel like his car because of how long it's taking.

I couldn't hear the guys anymore; they must've moved far about to peek out, but I didn't need to. The five of them were standing in front of me, tired from running.

"Hehe... Hi," I said.

Two of them suddenly grabbed me. They held me tightly their leader.

"You made it hard for us! Did you really think you could said angrily, wiping the sweat from his chin.

"What's it to you?! Who are you?!" I shouted at him.

I knew he was the one I kicked in the chest. But I didn't know How was I supposed to know who he was!

"After you kicked me last night! Now you're asking who Just answer the question already!

"Huh?"

"This girl is really a show-off! What are we going to do :
.. .. .

The person I trusted and loved hurt me.

They all seemed confused by what I said. They looked at each other, waiting for an answer from one another. They're so slow

While they were busy thinking about what I said, I felt the hand of one of them. I quickly pulled my arm away, and threw a punch that landed right on the jaw of the one holding me.

Ippo Makonotsi!

I quickly turned to the other guy holding me. You could see his face, and it took him a while to notice my fist coming toward

He let go of me, and fell straight down. The leader of the group was both surprised and angry. I don't know why, but suddenly I felt a sense of familiarity from high school in him. It felt like I was back in the day fighting at Holy Saints High School.

"You messed with the wrong person," I said in a deadpan voice.

I stepped closer to them, and they stepped backward with reluctance. I made. My body was heating up. It felt like I wanted more and more. My body was craving the pain and excitement of a fight.

The fear and courage mixing in my chest.

"Dammit!" the leader yelled as he charged toward me.

We are easy to break, fragile, and easy to shatter. That's 1
guy was able to manipulate me.

Damn it! I remembered him again.

My fists were clenched tightly. They tightened even mor
me mixed with my anger.

"You bastards!" I yelled and rushed toward them.

But damn, guys are really idiots. They both tackled me.

THEY PUSHED ME! Damn it! I'm a woman! You shoul

"Damn it! Why are you pushing me?! That hurts!"

"Is this girl crazy?!" one of them said.

You look crazy!

"Hey!" someone shouted.

We all turned to look at them. One word: perfect timing.

"Why did you push my sister?!" Percy asked angrily.

"Do you want to see what she did to our friends?!" one o
said, pointing at his knocked-out companions.

"Per----." I didn't get to finish what I was saying as he sp
kicked the one guy still standing right in the face.

I don't want to mention his name, but... it was Keifer's m

There was only one left, and it looked like he was about know whether to run or fall to the ground. Even I couldn't be stunned by Percy's action.

I shouldn't be thinking about this, but it was like I saw th

Sometimes, it's Aries. Sometimes, it's Yuri. And now, it's

It's like Ci-N too sometimes!

The three guys who hurt me badly seem to have become
own personality, but if I'm seeing them in him... should I

While he was busy with the last guy, I slowly walked away and noticed something strange. I wasn't comfortable.

They're not all the same, but I don't know. I don't know ε losing my mind—argh!

Suddenly, something hit me in the back of the neck. I felt feeling weak and unable to stand. I tried to see who did it started to darken until I heard a voice.

DATE: 11/11/1961

I walked around the area where I last saw her, but there was no shadow of her.

I should really get her a new cellphone so I can call her. I lost her current phone.

I know there's something off with her phone!

I went back to the Mini Mart, but she wasn't there either. I started to get worried. This is not so freaking good!

"Where are you?" I whispered to myself.

I immediately went back to the place where we fought and the people we fought were no longer there. I ran for a bit, but even there I didn't see her.

I encountered three kids on the way. I immediately approached them.

I was hoping they had seen Jay-jay.

"Hi, can I ask you something?" I greeted them.

You could clearly see they were scared because of how slowly I approached them.

Did they get scared of me with my good looks?!

"I just want to ask if you saw a girl here earlier. She was

I saw their expressions change. They even brought their phone, as if examining Jay-jay's face.

"It's her!" one of them shouted. "She's the one we saw!"

"W-where did you see her?"

"Over there!" one of them pointed to a spot near where I was sleeping!"

Sleeping?!

"That's her! They're putting her in a van with those guys!"

What the heck?!

"Thanks!" I said and immediately ran back to my car.

Once I got in, I quickly dialed David's number. I need her to find her on my own.

Who was that? Who put her in the van?

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Yuri's POV

I miss her!

Poor Keifer! You're really torturing yourself!

I returned my gaze to the front, where I saw David and C two are always together now. It's like they've distanced t rest of Section E because of what they've been doing.

I sighed deeply. If only I had realized my feelings for he had been brave enough to confront Keifer. If only I had t

Maybe things wouldn't have ended up like this.

We're all regretting it now. We're all in pain.

We all looked toward the door.

Suddenly, Percy walked in?

"Hey David!" he shouted angrily. "...Why aren't you ans

David looked at him confusedly and took his phone out o was on silent, sorry."

Percy looked like he was in a hurry, obviously restless. F not knowing what was happening.

"What the hell are you doing here?" Keifer asked calmly

He finally speaks!

"What's going on with you?" David asked again.

"Jay-jay is missing." Percy replied quickly, alarming all Keifer.

"What?!"

"Maybe she just went somewhere!"

"Oh, maybe she went home!"

Percy shook his head, looking like he couldn't believe w
He paced around.

"You were with her! Why don't you know where she is?!"

He suddenly faced me and pointed at my face. "Don't lec

"What the hell happened?!" Felix asked.

"She suddenly disappeared... I just finished the fight she
she was gone." Percy explained irritably.

He was fighting?! This is not good.

I looked at Keifer, who still hadn't changed his expressio
didn't care about what was happening. Like he didn't care

"Aren't you going to do anything?!" I asked angrily

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Message:

We have your precious girl. Same place in 30 mins or you
in our bed. Haha

I tightened my grip on the phone. Another message came
was a picture of Jay-jay unconscious.

Damn it! Why now?!

Chapter 198: No care

Percy's POV

"Speed up!" Felix shouted in my ear.

"Wait! I'm on it!" I shout back.

If we weren't in such a hurry right now, I might have scooped him up.
He's starting to lose respect for me.

I'm your older brother, dude!

"There's Keifer!" Calix shouted from the backseat.

I spotted his car. He was driving so fast, as if there were no traffic on the road.

"Faster, Percy!" Felix shouted again.

Percy?!

My eyebrows furrowed at what he said. "Hey! Where's the other brother?"

"Like how much I care about you... It's gone," he answered.

"Solid burn," Calix whispered.

I smirked slightly. Not because I wanted to show I won. I like it when my siblings lose respect for me.

I can't blame Felix, though. A lot happened when I was gone. I just showed up. He even thinks I lied to them.

I saw Yuri's car cutting me off. This guy's really testing my patience.

I turned my attention back to Keifer's car. He was still weaving. Suddenly, he turned left without signaling. The car behind him and stopped, causing a traffic jam.

"Why now?!" I shouted.

Even Yuri and David's cars had to stop. Keifer's car disappeared from sight.

Damn it!

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****Jay-jay's POV****

"Guess where we are?" one of them teased.

Damn it! This guy's been messing with me for a while now. I've won all of these races and blindfolded. He's the first one I've ever lost to.

"Knock it off, A," said another guy. His voice was deeper than one bothering me.

"It's just so dull," replied the guy called A. "...AHA!"

I flinched at his sudden shout. He was closer than I thought next to me.

He almost deafened me! Jerk!

"Let me check your stuff, okay?" he said.

I still didn't respond. He won't find anything in my bag. I can't sense my surroundings, but this blindfold is making me paranoid.

I hate the dark!

"Are you really a student? You only have one notebook! and—oh! A cellphone!"

This guy must be from the mountains. It's like he's never been to a city before. Good luck trying to unlock it. My password's strong.

"What's the password?" A asked me.

I could feel his presence right beside me. I stayed silent, not touching my cheek. I turned my face away, but his hand was still there.

"Your skin's so smooth..." he said, and I felt his breath on my neck.

"Stop messing around," replied the deep-voiced guy, K. back soon. He might get mad."

What is this? The alphabet? A, K, and Z?

I heard the sound of a door opening. The hinges sounded oil. It was so loud and heavy.

"What are you doing, A?" someone asked.

"He's being annoying!" another replied.

I felt like a lot of new people had arrived. I wasn't wrong sound of their footsteps, there seemed to be many of their chatter among them.

"I was just asking for the password to her cellphone," A:

Yeah, and with some groping! You jerk!

"Put it back," a guy ordered.

A didn't say anything else, so he probably returned my p were getting noisy as they chatted.

I felt the presence of someone near me again. I became a thought they might touch me like A did earlier.

"Z! Should I remove the blindfold?" a guy asked, who I

most likely... goodbye, v-card!

I need to get out of here!

"W-what do you need from me?" I asked, almost in a wh

I heard footsteps approaching me. I felt another person s
me.

"Your boyfriend," the person in front of me, who I think
"...I haven't gotten my revenge on him yet."

"He's not my boyfriend," I quickly replied.

I heard some of them chuckle. They probably thought I v
course, these guys are dense, so they won't believe me.

"We're not stupid----."

"You're stupid!" I cut Z off before he could finish.

"What did you say?!" he asked angrily.

"You're stupid!" I repeated.

Suddenly, someone grabbed my hair. My head was yank
so much I couldn't move.

"Don't rush me, girl! If your boyfriend is scary, I'm ever

They let go of my hair, and Z laughed loudly. It seemed amused by what I said.

"Don't tell me you two broke up?" he asked, still laughing

"No," I answered almost in a whisper. "...we were never place."

Z laughed again, even louder than before. His companion laughing too.

So happy, huh? Overjoyed!

"Girl..." someone called me. "...It's already common knowledge here that you're Keifer's girlfriend. So why would

Oh, you idiots!

If I could slap myself right now, I would. If they could or they'd have been stabbed by the sharpness of my glare.

I didn't want to bring it up again. I didn't want to repeat it mention it. But—haizt! I have to!

"We were never together..." I took a deep breath. "...because me."

They stopped laughing. I could feel all their eyes on me.

I shook my head and lowered it. I didn't want to cry; I just didn't want to cry over him anymore. I tried to hold back my tears by telling myself that.

Go back, tears! Go back!

"He made me fall for him! The jerk played with my feelings and I fell for him, he said—just kidding!" I said angrily. "...going to hell didn't break. The youth of Bataan almost fell."

"What a jerk! Playing with someone's feelings like that!"

I heard some of them sigh deeply. Others cursed. They all made comments about what the so-called "King of the Dimwits" was doing.

"Nice story."

I froze. I knew that voice. I knew it very well. He heard me and I didn't know whether to be happy or annoyed.

I'll just throw a party instead!

Suddenly, there was a commotion, as if they were moving. I saw the person who spoke. I also heard some things falling.

"Son of a..." I heard Z whisper.

"That was a heartwarming story. But there's something more to be said, and then I heard a loud crash."

"C—no, Z!"

After the noise and chaos, the place fell silent, as if an airlock had been closed. I tried to sense my surroundings, and from what I could tell, there were still people there because of their heavy breathing.

"You jerk!" Z shouted.

"You never learn," Keifer said. "...I already took you down once, and you are again."

"So what?!"

"You dragged her into this!"

That's all they called me. I felt a lump forming in my throat. I wanted to cry again, I'm about to cry. It would be great if tears could be used as a weapon.

"Shut up!" someone shouted.

What's happening?!

The only basis I had for what was going on was the sound of their movements. I still had no idea what they were doing. I've had my hands free from the ropes since earlier, but nothing's changed. My wrists are already raw from all the pulling.

"Now, A!" Z shouted.

Please, no!

"W-who are you?" I asked, terrified. "...I-is that you, Kei something."

I was on the verge of tears. The person approaching me just didn't want to give me an answer. Maybe it's not Keifer. But who is it? Damn it! So

The footsteps stopped in front of me. I could hear deep, (breathing.

Whoever you are... behave!

I could feel their gaze on me. I was practically grinding : trying to free myself. My breathing was heavy, and I mu ridiculous waiting for what they'd do next.

I shuddered completely when I felt their palm caress my
are you?! I tried to turn my face away, but like before, th

Is this A?!

"Damn it! Get away from me! Don't touch me!" I shout my face away.

What if it's really A?! Damn it! If Keifer's down, then his happen. No! Tears started forming in my eyes out of fear

HTZ 'C' HTY 11 1 1 1 0 1 1 1

my hands and feet.

But what completely stopped my heart and made my soul
was what they did next.

T-they kissed me.

The effect on me was strange. It hit my system hard. I cc
couldn't even move my head away. Why is this happenir

It feels familiar!

What I'm feeling is so familiar. Even the lips pressed against mine are so familiar. I don't know why this is happening.

It feels like Kei—NO! It's not Keifer! He wouldn't do this to kiss me.

I really wanted to believe it was him. I really wanted to v
But I know it's impossible. I know it's not him, because l
me again.

"Don't... Please," I pleaded as their lips parted. "...have n

I heard nothing from them. Silence enveloped the two of more anxious because I couldn't tell what they were plan

The silence scared me. It was scarier than when there we

My vision adjusted to the bright light. The whole Section me. Ci-N looked worried, and David was beside him. Fe were looking at the bodies on the ground. Denzel, Mayo, opening closed doors to make sure no one was left. Ema were helping untie me.

But my gaze stopped at Yuri and Josh. They were standing and... Keifer. He was down, and Eren was trying to help coming from his side.

W-what happened?!

Once the ropes were off, Percy helped me stand. I wanted to check on him. But his cold gaze stopped me.

"Just hang on... We'll take you to the hospital," Yuri said over from head to toe.

He must have been checking if I was okay. Seeing no issues out.

"Are you okay, Jay?" Ci asked.

I nodded slightly, my only response. My gaze stayed on the room. And then it became clear to me that it wasn't him.

Because of his position, far from me, and the injuries he sustained, it was impossible for him to have been the one.

This happened because of Keifer. If it weren't for his end this wouldn't have happened! How many times has this been going to keep happening?!

"Let's get out of here," I whispered to Percy.

He nodded and helped me into the car. I saw Ci-N's shoulder looked at me. I quickly looked away.

I'm grateful they came. But everything that happened still was just a toy to them. After all the problems we've been meant nothing to them.

"Should I take you home?" Percy asked as he started the rest."

"I-it's too early," I took a deep breath. "...Maybe later."

He didn't respond and just kept driving. Even without him I knew he could feel what I was feeling.

It's exhausting...

It's exhausting getting dragged into their mess. It's exhausting. Even though I didn't know who took me, I had a feeling they would come to help me.

They did come, but why does it feel like they were forced

I looked down when he said that. I just said that! I should
anymore. No matter what happens to him, to them! I won't

Next time I get caught up in their mess, I won't wish for
help me. I'll find a way out myself. After all, I was known
in my old school.

I won't rely on you anymore, I won't rely on you.

Chapter 199: Game of Pai

Jay-jay's POV

"Almost there!" I shouted.

Let's see how tough you are now!

These guys are so annoying! Early in the morning, and then they're just pissing me off. They just blocked me out of nowhere when I was at the Mini Mart.

This is Percy's fault! If he had just picked me up in front of the store, this wouldn't have happened. I wouldn't have run into these ugly faces that are so irritating!

"Damn it! No one told us this girl knows how to fight!" one of them said.

"How was I supposed to know?!"

"What now? How are we going to take her?"

Take her?! Again?!

"What do you mean, take me?!" I asked irritably.

No one answered. They just looked at each other, as if waiting to speak up.

"What?! None of you are going to talk?!" I asked angrily, looking at the face of one of their companions.

He looked like a rag anyway!

"Fine! We're going to use you to get back at Keifer! You'll see!" I immediately cut him off.

"I'm not! We were never even together!"

They looked at me in confusion. I know they don't believe me, but they're idiots. Everyone who's heard that rumor probably believes it either.

Damn it! Here we go again...

Why do his enemies always come after me? La Punyeta! I'm feeling this isn't the last of his enemies who'll try to use me. Those guys on motorcycles before were his enemies too.

Damn you, King of the Dimwit Ulupongs! I curse you!

May your asshole seal shut!

I'm Barracuda! Hhhaaaaahhhh!!

My fists were sore, and my hands were shaking, but I tried to handle these idiots. There were only four of them left, but I was determined to handle them.

I have to handle it!

Suddenly, one of them charged at me. I was caught off guard, but I managed to dodge him. I countered with a punch to his stomach.

He knelt in pain, coughing as if his guts were about to come out. There were only three left, and I felt like I could still take them.

Where the hell is Percy?!

That lunatic doesn't seem worried at all since I'm not at school yet. Meanwhile, yesterday he went looking for me. He ended up at school.

I glared at the idiots. How long has it been since I last got tired? I feel so exhausted even though they're coming at me one by one.

Damn it! I got used to them defending me. I got used to them protecting me whenever someone hurt me. Now I'm the one struggling.

I need to get used to fighting on my own again. Like back when I fought alone. Because they're not coming anymore. I need their help again.

Even though I could barely breathe, I forced myself to fight his side. It didn't seem to affect him at first, but I put more next elbow. On my last elbow strike to his side, he let out

His grip loosened, so I took the chance to break free. I immediately followed up with a punch to his face, and he fell to the ground.

I didn't waste any time. Everything happened so fast, it felt like I lost control of my body anymore. I charged at the remaining opponent and exchanged punches several times.

"Aagghhh!!" I shouted as I landed the final punch.

They've all fallen down. As I looked at them, I felt like I was about to collapse as well. I was so tired and it felt like I was running on empty.

I leaned against the wall for support.

"Nice..."

Nice your face!

I glared at the one who spoke. Who else? Of course, it was my stepbrother.

"You're annoying! Where have you been earlier?!" I said

"Kind of, kind of." He replied, approaching me.

All I heard in response was his laughter. It was as if his t
been affected. He's probably gone completely crazy now

My movements were slow because of the pain in my boc
like my body was craving this kind of thing.

"You're like... not even a woman..." Percy, who was behi

"...you're just too good at fighting."

I rolled my eyes at what he said. It was so embarrassing,
he, such a big guy, didn't even help me. He was supposed
in case I couldn't handle the fight.

But instead, he just watched.

"You're such a nice stepbrother... You know that?" I said

"Of course. That's me!" He boasted.

This guy really ruins the mood. I would love to knock hi
wall. Would that make him stop being crazy?

"Where are we going now?" He asked.

I stopped walking and looked at him. I really didn't know
thinking of going to the Mini Mart, but it would be emba
crew. They might think we're making their place our han

I thought he was going to say something back, so even though I was walking ahead, I was still paying attention to him. When I started hearing anything from him, I looked back.

Percy had stopped walking and was looking at the other person. He looked in the same direction and was surprised to see Freya walking along with Ella.

What are they doing here?!

I was about to exchange a bad glare with them, but Freya started walking off.

"Freya!" Percy called out, crossing the street. "...Wait!"

I had no choice but to follow him. He caught up with Freya and she told him that she wasn't happy to see him.

"Let's talk for a bit... Please." He pleaded.

"We already talked, didn't we? What else do you want?" Freya said with no emotion.

"You kicked me out the other day..."

"Because there's nothing left to talk about!"

"Freya..."

I looked at Ella when I noticed she was looking at me too. It was like she was reading my thoughts based on my mood.

She also turned away and walked to follow Freya and Percy.

I didn't know where they were going, but I followed them.

I didn't know they were talking again. She hadn't said anything from the way she looked now, it seemed like their last conversation went well.

Percy's eyes were sad, while Freya still had that mischievous look. Percy still had feelings for her, while Freya was just angry.

It was probably the same way Felix felt when they met.

We arrived at a park. Percy and Freya sat on a bench, while Ella sat a little further away. We couldn't hear what they were talking.

"I heard you haven't been going to school." Ella said, while looking at her.

"What's it to you?" I replied, bored.

I had no problem with her. I was just being my usual rude when I was around her. It felt like it wasn't long ago when we were all together.

~~~~~

Ella! So sensitive!

I turned my gaze back to Freya. They were facing away from me. I had no choice but to find an empty bench and sit down. What I didn't know, though, was why Ella suddenly sat beside me.

"Who said you could sit next to me?" I asked irritably.

"No one... Why, does someone need to tell me?" She answered.

I swear, I'm about to slap her!

"Just get away! I don't want you beside me." I pushed her away.

"I don't want to be beside you either. You leave."

Damn! This girl is really pushing my buttons. She must be crazy.

"I was here first, so you leave!" I said angrily, giving her a glare.

"You leave!" She said, pushing me harder.

I almost tripped and fell, but luckily I was able to stand up.

I glared at her, and she glared right back.

"Damn---!"

"Go ahead! Curse all you want!" She threatened, as she sat back down.

Why the hell is this troublemaker here? She and Freya are in uniform. They didn't even go to school. Tsk! What a good girl!

Just like me!

The waiting was really boring. I reluctantly took my phone out. 68 messages and 32 missed calls greeted me. Ever since then, truth be told, my inbox and missed calls have always been like this.

Sometimes, the missed calls are even more than the messages.

I opened my inbox, and Ci-N's message was the first one.

**From: Ci-N**

*Message: I miss you... 🙄🙄 I miss my partner!*

**From: Ci-N**

*Message: They're picking on me... I don't have anyone to protect me!*

**From: Ci-N**

*Message: Jay-jay! You're so mean! Rakki's gonna court me to school! I'm still not ready... I'm still a virgin!*

**From: Ci-N**

*Message: oFfoWw nnEfoOowWwsss!*

*Message: Jay...*

I stopped reading when I noticed there was a drop of water on the screen. That's when I realized it was from me. I started crying, realizing it.

I guess this is one of the things I need to sacrifice. Just to make the pain they caused go away. I need to endure them.

"If you're hurting like this, why not talk to them?" Ella said, looking at her book. "...Not just cry when you read their texts."

I frowned at what she said. This gossiping girl! How did she know we were texting me?

"Don't meddle with me!" I said irritably and turned my back to my phone.

This time, I opened Yuri's message. He had the most messages from all.

**From: Yuri**

*Message: Let's talk... Please.*

**From: Yuri**

*Message: Jay-jay... I need to talk to you.*

"Tell me..." She said without looking at me. "...Does Yuri with you?"

A chance?

I looked in another direction. That question didn't even count. Especially when I admitted to myself that the one I truly loved was the King of the Dimunyang Ulupong.

"I... I don't know," I whispered.

"I know what happened... I heard about what they did to

I still didn't look at her. Everything was still too fresh to look at, still affected, even if I denied it. It still hurt.

"...It's not that I'm siding with them, but I hope you listen to my explanation. Especially Yuri..." Her voice sounded almost like she didn't believe he couldn't have done that."

I want to believe too!

I really do, but how? How can I believe when they've already said that he could do it? I don't want to talk about it anymore. I was intending to ask Percy, but Ella quickly blocked me.

"Listen first." She said calmly but firmly.

"...I don't know, but I don't want to talk about it anymore."

She glanced at Percy for a moment before facing me again. "E I knew were real troublemakers. They would even fight. But when you came..." She lowered her head. "...Without defending you. Something they never did for me. They said things and would rarely fight in class."

So that's why they sometimes mentioned that things were. Ella was still with them. Something stirred in my heart, but as I remembered... It was all part of their act.

"They even smile while walking home, like they're normal—something I've never seen from them before." She tried to be jealous of you. I used to have their attention, but I couldn't. Then you, in such a short time—your impact on them was

Now I understand her. That's why she did what she did to make sure she was the one blamed, because she knew you and might try to intervene.

Incredible! She's so smart!

"But now... they're not like that anymore." Our gazes met. "Their life again. They're always fighting and arguing in the classroom. Teachers have already refused to teach them because they're disruptive in class."

"W-what do you want me to do?" I asked, a hint of irritation.

"I was wrong." She quickly answered, which made me a

"...I thought he was still the one, but..." Suddenly, a tear  
eyes. "...When I lost Aries, that's when I realized everyth

W-what? She and Aries are no longer together?

But she hasn't mentioned anything about Aunt Gema. I h  
around, so I don't have any updates. But I know that whe  
hospital, Ella was there too. When did they break up?

"It's too late for me and Aries. It hurts, but that's just how

She wiped her cheek. "...I hope you don't end up like me  
me for me to realize that I truly loved him." She smiled a  
pretense. "...Yuri deserves to be happy after everything v  
through."

Slowly, she turned away from me and started walking av  
standing there, stunned, watching her. My tongue and co  
retreat all of a sudden.

Despite my irritation, I still felt sorry for her. I thought sl  
because of her admission earlier. But now, it turns out th  
horoscope guy, was the one who truly had her heart.

That's it! You even had a midnight conversation! Hah!



I did, but it seemed like you needed it more than I do!

"Y-yeah." I answered uncertainly.

"Okay. Let's go." He said lifelessly.

I felt like I'd need the alcohol I drank before again. But n  
seemed like it was for the person with me.

# Chapter 200: Drunk Percy

## Jay-jay's POV

I don't feel like drinking today. I'm not in the mood, and I'm being really careful about what Ella told me earlier.

She made a mistake...

Because of her mistake, she lost the person who truly loved her. I lost Aries because she thought she still loved Yuri.

I didn't want to listen to what she said. Why should she care? Why should I care about her? But then, I ended up being what she said about Section E.

Ugh! It's so annoying!

"Isha, more!" Percy shouted at the bartender. "...Bring on more expensive... drinks!"

I could only shake my head at the sight of him. He said he was a little, but this is his version of "a little"—he's already drunk.

"That's enough," I said, reaching for his glass, but he quietly

That's it... he's slurring now!

I'm starting to feel embarrassed by the people staring at me. Loud he is, he's also making a mess in his seat.

"Jay..." he called me. "...Have you ever been in love?"

Doesn't he already know the answer?

I didn't respond. I just let him continue. It seems like he's going out.

"I thought... she'd still take me back," he started, tears falling. "She doesn't want me anymore."

I grabbed some tissues nearby and handed them to him. I wiped his tears and snot.

He signaled the bartender for another drink, and the bartender brought him one.

"That's your last one. Don't order anymore," I said, and he looked at me.

"My sister's so concerned about me," he teased.

No, I'm not! I just don't want to carry a drunk person.

I rolled my eyes at him and glanced at the dance floor. A crowd of people dancing to the loud music.

hairpin fell off. It landed near my feet. I was planning to see her. I saw me."

It seems like he's really into Freya.

"...Her voice was so beautiful when she talked to me..." I took a drink in his glass. "...I watched her for so long. I even stood there for weeks before I got the courage to approach her." He chuckled. "...That's when I found out that a lot of people liked her."

I heard she's practically the town's fantasy.

He finished the drink in his glass and signaled the bartender. The bartender stopped him. I shook my head at the bartender to signal 'no'.

"Let's go home..." I told him.

"Later... It's still early," he said, pleading.

I stood up from my stool and approached him. I grabbed him, but he was too drunk to resist.

I faced the bartender first. "How much?"

He shook his head at me. "Did you forget? It's on the house, boss," he said, pointing to Tiger's office.

Free?! Damn it! You should've told me earlier!

It's already hard enough to guide him through the crowd squirming. I really want to smack him.

We finally made it out the door. I was panting heavily because the guy is such a pain in the ass!

"You're such a pain, you animal!" I shouted at him.

Suddenly, he raised a finger and started singing. "...Just like animals... Awwooooohhhh!"

That's it! He's gone too far!

I quickly looked around. No taxis were passing by. It was late. I guessed it was around 10 PM. I'm so dead if Kuya Ang

Percy didn't bring his car because he was so eager to get just randomly hailed a taxi on the road.

I leaned him against the wall and checked the street again. I had no choice but to call someone to pick us up. I reached my pocket to get his phone.

"What are you groping me for?" he shouted.

Oh, for heaven's sake!

I immediately smacked him on the head because of his lack of

"What now?!" I said irritably. "...I'll kick you."

"I have a joke, listen," he said, laughing. "...What do you mom?"

"Huh?!"

"Wrong!" he said, laughing. "...Bananay!"

Facepalm!

I can do this! I can handle this! I've been through a lot, so I can survive this. Even if it's corny, I'll live!

I pretended not to hear him. I quickly searched for someone to call. David was the first person I thought of, but when I tried to call him, he ended the call after just one ring.

Maybe he's busy?

If he's not available, then who? I don't know anyone else except Percy's housemates, and I don't have their numbers to call.

What about Felix?

Tsk! Not that I'm being stubborn or anything, but I don't have his number right now. Meanwhile, this crazy guy kept poking me.

"What now?!" I said irritably.

I can do this! I can handle this! I can handle even the cor grief! I'm about to bang my head against the wall becaus

In my frustration, I didn't notice that I had already presse next to Felix's name. It was too late to cancel because he

["Hello? Jay?"] I heard Felix say.

I glared at Percy, who was still laughing. This is all his f choice but to talk to Felix. I didn't want to waste my loac

"F-Felix."

["Jay-jay... What's wrong? Is there a problem?"]

"I was hoping you could pick us up here at Kingsground

There was a brief silence before he spoke again. ["Okay. way."]

I was about to ask who "we" referred to, but he already e shrugged.

I put my phone back in my bag. I was about to stand nex leaning against the wall, but three guys approached us.

"Hi, Miss!" greeted the tallest one. "...What's someone a doing here?"

"You're drunk, bro..." one of the guys said to Percy.

"Me?! Drunk?! No way!" he replied arrogantly.

I could only shake my head while holding my face. He's in front of everyone.

"Miss... is that your boyfriend?" the guy in front of me asked.

I quickly shook my head. "He's my stepbrother."

"Miss? Who's Miss?" Percy said, stepping between me and the guy I was talking to. "...This one's Miss? No, this isn't Miss! This is Miss!"

This jerk! He just turned me into a guy.

The guys laughed, even though they clearly didn't believe me.

"This one's a transgenger, bro! A transgenger!" he added, even louder.

I give up!

I'm really about to bang my head against the wall. I can't take this craziness anymore. I thought I could endure his corny jokes for another level.

"Wow... Looks like you need to take your friend home," the guy said to me.



They smiled and walked away. Once they were gone, Pe realize the guys had left.

"Hey! Where'd they go?! I was going to tell them my kil looking around.

I pulled him back and leaned him against the wall. "They because your jokes are too corny!"

He pouted and looked down. "Oh..."

If he's always like this, I'm never letting him drink too m maybe I just won't go with him. His corniness might mal

"I'll just tell my joke to you!" he said enthusiastically.

Oh no, please don't!

"Just shut up already!"

He ignored me and started laughing by himself again.

"What do you call a horse with wings?" he asked, laughi

"Tsk!"

"Idiot! It's a Pegasus..." he said, laughing even harder.

Please, no more. I'm begging you.

"What?" I asked, bored.

"I don't know... That's why I'm asking you!"

Damn it! I give up!

Should I just leave him here and go? I can't take his corny jokes are driving me crazier than everything else to me.

"Haha... My jokes are so funny. It's because I'm handsome winking at me.

I suddenly burst out laughing. "Hahahahaha... Out of all the one that got me."

I was laughing so hard I even slapped my thigh. It took a moment and that's when I noticed he wasn't moving, just staring at me.

"That wasn't a joke."

"Yes, it was! The 'you're handsome' part! Damn, that really made me laughing at him again.

He glared at me and crossed his arms. "I'm not joking. You're the one who's making me!"

I just shook my head at him. Finally! His corniness is over.

"Jay-jay," Yuri called out to me.

All I could do was stare at him. He seemed to notice I was looking at him here. He even looked down to avoid my gaze.

"Hey! Stick!" Percy shouted, making us all look at him. "What are you doing here?!"

He was staring straight at Yuri as he said that. He tried to move but because he was so drunk, he almost fell. He ended up needing support.

"Get it together! You're so heavy!" I said, trying to hold him up.

Felix came over to help me steady him.

"Bring me closer to Stick! I'm gonna punch him!" Percy stepped a step forward.

Stick?!

"Just stop!" Felix said.

Percy looked at him. "You're on his side now too?! Even you?"

"You're drunk, bro! Just come with us!" Felix said, trying to pull him down.

"What are you doing? Are you on this dude's side?!" Percy shouted.

He tried to step closer to Yuri. No matter how much we t back, he kept going, and all we could do was support him. get close enough, he grabbed Yuri's collar.

"Stop it, Percy!" I said, trying to intervene.

Yuri didn't do anything but let him. He just watched us, and moving away, he stayed still. Percy easily grabbed his collar.

"What?! Where's your arrogance now?! Yuri, you coward!" he yelled right in his face.

Felix and I tried to pull his hand away, but his grip was too strong. He kept shaking Yuri.

"That's enough, bro!" Felix shouted, but Percy wasn't listening.

"Are you happy now?! Huh?! You took everything that was mine! Keifer's trust! My brother! And Freya!" Percy said.

I didn't understand what he meant. He was saying Yuri took everything.

"I didn't take anything from you," Yuri said calmly. "...I took everything you left behind."

"Jerk! Protect?! Is that what you call what you did to Freya?"

So he knew about that too.

Yuri stood up, wiping the blood from his lip. He looked at me, looking down. I don't know, but it felt like he wasn't the same as the one I had a crush on and who asked me to marry him.

It felt like he was a different person now.

I don't regret that things turned out this way. Because if it was their fault—his and his best friend's—that we're like this, then anyone should feel this way, it shouldn't be me. It should be them.

I helped Percy up. I wanted to go home, I wanted to get away from here.

"Let's go home," Felix said.

"No! I'm not done with Stick over there!" Percy shouted.

I pulled him with all my strength toward the car. Felix did the same. Even though Percy kept resisting, we managed to get him in the car. Percy, Felix took the passenger seat, and Yuri drove.

"Freya..." I heard Percy whisper, and then his head dropped to his shoulder. "...she doesn't want me anymore."

I looked at the rearview mirror. I saw Yuri looking at me. He glared at him and turned my attention back to Percy.

We were quiet for the rest of the ride. Except, of course, for me, challenging Yuri to a fight. At one point, his hand flew up at me.

Felix and his mom came to the backseat door where we were. They both got in and worked together to pull Percy out. He woke up when they were pulling him.

"Mom!" Percy shouted, hugging his stepmom. "...I missed you."

Felix's mom chuckled a little. "It's only been a week since we last saw each other, right?"

"For me, it feels like a year has passed," Percy said, also hugging his mom. "I want to sleep together again, me and Felix."

"I don't want to sleep next to you!" Felix protested quickly.

I smiled at the sight of the three of them. Even though Percy wasn't a blood relative, they never treated him like an outsider. Even if he doesn't say it, I can tell he's happy to see his biological family.

Their mom helped Percy inside the house. Felix faced us and said, "We waited until he was inside before finally leaving."

This is so awkward! This is it!

Silence dominated the car. There were moments when we all looked at each other but quickly looked away. We looked ridiculous doing this?

He stopped in front of our house. I didn't wait for him to

"Come inside first," I told him.

I didn't wait for his response. I went inside, and he followed. I headed straight to the kitchen, turned on the light, and looked for the ice pack.

After finding it, I grabbed some ice and put it inside. I went to the living room where Yuri was sitting down, and pressed the ice pack against his hand.

He let me at first, but I was surprised when he looked at my hand. He saw the ice pack and the hand I was using to hold the ice pack.

I tried to pull my hand away, but he tightened his grip.

"M-my hand..." I said.

He didn't respond. He just kept staring at me while holding my hand. I was starting to get annoyed.

"Yuri, my hand—"

"I miss you," he cut me off.

I pulled my hand away with all my strength, causing the ice pack to fall. He glared at him.

"You can leave now," I said.

He didn't move. He kept looking at me, almost pleading.

I don't know if I'm ready to hear what they have to say. I was ready to confront him about everything, but suddenly Ari entered the kitchen, glaring at us.

"What are you doing here?" Aries asked seriously.

I quickly pulled my hand away from Yuri. I also avoided looking at them, as I felt like they were about to start another fight here, so I ran. I picked up the ice pack from the floor and placed it by the door.

"I'll just walk Yuri out," I said flatly and pulled Yuri outside.

When we got to the gate, I stopped and watched him leave. He looked sad as he looked at me. I didn't give him a chance to speak.

I-I'm not ready yet.

I quickly closed the gate and went back inside the house. I went to my room and almost collapsed onto my bed. I didn't mean to be rude to Yuri, but I couldn't help it.

Why you gotta be so rude? Don't you know I'm human too?



# Chapter 201: Angelo's rule

## Jay-jay's POV

Oh, right, it's Saturday today. No school, so no one should be up early. What I don't understand is why someone had to sleep in my room which ended up waking me.

I glared at the traitor—whoever it was—who opened my door. The doorknob's broken, so it's easy to open.

It was Aries... Too bad I'm a Taurus!

"Get up and have breakfast," he said irritably before immediately leaving.

"Abnormal," I muttered into my pillow.

I was forced to get up even though I really wanted to drop dead. I had a lot of plans for today: sleep, sleep, sleep, and more sleep.

I went straight to the bathroom to freshen up. I changed clothes and finally leaving my room. When I got to the dining area, everyone was already there—and that includes Kuya Angelo.

I'm dead...

Do I even have any allies left in this house? Tita Gema v but she can't go against Mama. Lola would've been anotl went back to the province.

I'm all alone now...

I just looked down while eating. I can't argue with them. really have to go along with Mama and her new husband things could get any worse than this.

"You're coming too, Aries," Mama added.

Whaaaaaaaatttt?!

"No, I'm not," Aries quickly replied.

I don't want to either!

"Come with us, Aries," Kuya ordered. "...Unless you wa your car."

I could clearly see Aries taking a deep breath to calm hir wanted to laugh out loud. It's the feeling of not being the scolded in the family.

But I really don't want him coming with us.

"If he's coming, maybe I don't have to go?" I asked, and

Kuya glared at me. It felt like he caught onto my challenge.

"If you don't come..." he started, and his eyes suddenly lit up in Aries' room."

WHAAAAAATTTTTTT?! NO! NO! NO!

"Fine, I'll go," I quickly replied and turned my attention back to my room.

No one said anything after that. I went back to my room and got ready. I didn't know where we were going, but I brought my bag in case I get annoyed with them and decide to ditch them.

Aries and I almost left our rooms at the same time. He didn't stop, just kept walking. I know he doesn't want to come with me, and I don't even—I don't want to be with him either.

"Ready?" Andy, the annoying one, greeted us.

"Yes... I'm ready," Mama said cheerfully, clapping her hands.

Aries and I didn't respond. We both looked bored and clueless.

Nice! At least we have something in common.

"Take care on your trip," Tita said, kissing Aries on the cheek.

She hugged me, and I almost didn't accept it. I'm not mad at her, but I don't want to make her feel bad about what happened.

While the car was moving, Mama and Andy kept talking about their upcoming wedding. I was starting to get annoyed, so I grabbed my headphones and plugged them in. I turned the volume way up.

Music that could make your ears fall off, of course.

The trip to their so-called future house took three hours. In heavy traffic, it took three hours—wow, right?

We went straight to an exclusive subdivision and stopped in front of a simple but beautiful house. The house had two floors. At first, it looked perfect for newlyweds—not too big, not too small.

I took off my headphones and got out of the car. Aries frowned, his eyebrows still furrowed.

"Isn't it beautiful?" Mama asked with a smile. "...Tito Arce is the designer."

Really?! So the annoying one's a designer.

"Is he an architect?" Aries asked.

He's a house designer!

"Yes... Right now, I'm handling our own firm," Andy replied.

"What's an architect?" I asked absentmindedly.

"Horoscope?" he asked, confused.

"Aren't you a horoscope?"

He clearly got annoyed by what I said. He probably understood what I meant. He suddenly raised his hand to hit me, but before he could, she came and put her arms around both of us.

"Picture!" she shouted, and I heard the click of a camera.

Ugh, so annoying!

Damn it! What do I look like in that photo? I feel like I look stupid there.

I was about to approach Andy to grab his phone, but he came and took the house and went inside.

"Let's go! Let's go!" Mama urged us.

Mom followed Andy, and I was left outside with Aries. I look stupid. It's his fault I look stupid in that picture.

"Damn you." I whispered, but it seemed like he heard me.

"You're the damn one!" he snapped.

"Horoscope!"

I didn't answer. I just walked ahead into the gate of the house.

My steps were big as I approached the door. It was only how spacious the yard was, and there was also a garage, organized yet.

Andy was at the door, waiting for us. I stopped with my back to the door and looked back at Mom, who was behind me.

Damn it!

Why did I even come here? We're not doing anything here with Kuya Angelo. Sometimes, I can't tell if he's getting this is just his punishment for me. It really ruins the mood.

"Hon!" Andy called out to Mom as he handed her the house key.

Mom happily took it. She walked toward the door and saw the model. It was only then that I realized she was being phoned.

What a mess! A model for the door.

"Here we go... We're entering our house." Mom said with a smile as she slowly opened the door. "...Ta-da!"

I peeked inside. Mom went in first, followed by Andy. I followed them.

The house was a mess. The door was open. The house was a mess.

"I was ahead." I said irritably.

"So what?" he answered back.

"Saturday... Moron!"

"Blockhead!"

Before I could respond to his remark, he had already reached the stairs.

I quickly followed, but his steps were much bigger.

When we reached the second floor, I saw another sofa set and a flat-screen TV on the opposite wall. There were three doors that led to bedrooms, and one door that led to the terrace.

Mom grabbed my hand and pulled me to the first door.

"This is your room." She said as she opened the door.

It wasn't as big as my room in Aunt Gema's house, but it was mine. It had a cabinet, a study table, a bed frame, and a mat on the floor covered in plastic.

"And this one's for Aries." Andy said as he opened the door to the next room.

His room was just like mine, but Aries didn't seem too happy about it.

I didn't even think about that. Mom had said I'd be living while, at least until I get married. But it looks like that w because of everything I found out.

"Yes... just for a while. And only when it's your school v

Mom answered.

"No! That's never gonna happen." Aries said, shaking his

"Aries... I just want to—..."

"There you go again! What you want... What about what interrupted Mom again, irritated.

"Aries." Andy calmly chided him.

He stopped, gave Mom a nasty look, then glanced at me walking back down the stairs. We were left standing ther him.

I understand Aries. It feels like he made a decision again our opinions. As much as I wanted to protest like my ho I didn't.

I knew he already knew.

Mom looked at me, but before she could speak, I turned



The view's ugly...

I went back inside. Mom and Andy were no longer around. I heard their voices. They seemed to be downstairs. I went back upstairs. I was supposed to be mine and just stood there, looking around. I wasn't really interested.

After a while, I went downstairs. I found Mom and Andy talking. They both looked at me when I came in.

"Jay... What do you want to eat? Tito Andy will buy it." I said with a smile.

"I'll ask Aries." I said lifelessly.

I immediately went out to find Aries. It wasn't hard to find him. He was still in the same spot I had seen him earlier, still talking to himself.

"What do you want to eat? They're going to buy something for you."

"Anything, as long as you get some sense in that head of yours." I shouted at me.

He's really the worst!

"Don't eat! Starve to death!" I yelled back and stormed in.

Andy was standing at the door, holding the car keys. It looked like he was about to leave.

Andy, the show-off, left, and the three of us were left in 1 and I were sitting at the table, and Aries had just finished someone on the phone and sat down too.

We looked like we were waiting for food. I think I've alr monologue to every ant that passed in front of me.

"This is like the old days, right Aries?" Mom said, and I

I can't remember us ever sitting together at the table befo I was 3 years old when Aries was sent to Aunt's place. I c much.

Aries lowered his head with one hand resting on the tabl

"You still remember." Mom added, forcing a smile.

I couldn't relate.

"Of course I remember..." Aries said, looking at Mom. ". you'd hit me if I didn't follow you. I remember how you'd did something wrong."

His eyes slowly changed. I could see anger in them. I wa and ask him questions, but I was afraid he'd direct his an

"...I remembered it. I remember how you'd hit me with a hanger. I remember how you'd call me 'useless,' 'brain-de

He took a deep breath. "I did what you should've done, b  
who's in the wrong in the end!"

Mom took a deep breath, and that's when I noticed that s crying. She held Aries's hand tightly.

"I was just carried away by my anger... I didn't mean to c  
while continuing to cry. "...Forgive me. I was still young

"That's not an excuse!" Aries shouted. "...Jay-jay was the one who mattered to you! Why?! Because her dad is rich, while mine is a bum?!"

Shit! I'm confused!

I know Aries and I have different fathers, but I had no id he had experienced with Mom.

Aries tried to pull his hand away from Mom's grasp. He failed to his weakness. Mom kept crying, and honestly, I felt he shouldn't.

"Maybe that's why you had me sent away." Aries added.

Please stop...

This feels heavy. I looked into the distance and took a de

001 1 A 0 00 Y 0 1 1 1 1 1 1

"Enough." I intervened.

"I know you needed me... But please try to understand."

"You always want us to understand! What about us who you?!"

"Stop, Aries."

I felt like I would go deaf from the argument they were having. It was so painful, and it was heavy in my chest. I expected we'd all be here, throwing accusations while digging up the past.

"I'm useless to you! That's why you had me sent away!"

I slammed the table hard. "STOP IT!" I shouted, glaring at Aries. "GOD'S SAKE!"

Even Mom stopped speaking. She wiped her face, which was wet with tears. I heard her taking deep breaths several times.

"Enough of accusing Mom for her shortcomings! You must realize that you have shortcomings too!" I said, looking at Aries. "Talking like that, you'll just embarrass yourself!"

From his seat across from me, he grabbed the collar of my shirt.

I stood up as he brought my face closer to his. His glare was intense.

He slowly let go of me. We still didn't break eye contact.

"Mom..." I called out, not taking my eyes off Aries.

"...Stop crying, and if you can..." "Don't expect that we'll  
Aries interrupted, finishing my sentence.

A deep silence fell between the three of us. I don't know  
stayed like that. Until Andy arrived with the food.

"D-did something happen while I was gone?" He asked I

Mom only smiled at him in response. If only you came a  
might have caught the drama.

Maybe you would've bought some popcorn while watchi

# Chapter 202: Monday Mac

## Jay-jay's POV

The day was in my favor. There was no one at home except even Mama and Andy, the annoying one, were gone. I spent the day eating and sleeping—no shower!

It's fine! Don't judge me!

But it seems like only Sunday was in my favor because Monday, Monday! Monday morning, Kuya's scolding was the first that greeted me.

I was already ready for my daily routine with Percy. Preschool, but we were supposed to meet at the Mini Mart—deal! But Kuya was still here at home, and there it was.

A sermon all the way!

"I let you off the hook before! But you're really pushing the limit!" he shouted at me.

I could only close my eyes while listening to him. With each word, I felt like objects were about to fly toward me. That's how I felt when my mouth is

Haaahhh! Can Kuya read minds now?!

"And no, I can't read minds if that's what you're thinking

Oowwwsss?!

Kuya's glare sharpened, so I immediately looked down at my  
minds, but it's like he knows exactly what I'm thinking.

"I-I'm really going to school. You can even take me there  
said, still looking down.

"You're really going to school! And to make sure you get to  
classroom..."

I'll have someone take you!

"...I'll have someone take you!"

Whhuuaaattt?!

Who?! Aries the Horoscope? Please, I won't even make it  
before I bail. We don't even have a driver to take me. And  
one, can't do it either because he's going back to his place  
lot of work to finish!

"Who?" Tita Gema asked.

"Tita " Kuya quickly answered, pointing at the door

"He's the one who'll take you AND pick you up," Kuya said with a word AND. "...and I'll be updated every hour to make sure you're in class."

Wow! Wow! Wow! Just wow! You'll make me say wow!

Kuya smiled at me like a lunatic. It's like he's saying, "You're mine." Damn it! I've already lost. There's nothing I can do. He'll tighten his grip on me if I resist. I just want to bang my head against the wall because of this.

"Go on... Go to school now!" Kuya ordered.

Here we go! Here we go! As if!

Reluctantly, I walked out. I passed by Yuri, who was looking at me. He quickly followed and even got to his car before I did. He opened the backseat door for me.

I got in roughly and slammed the door shut. That's when I realized I was already sitting in the passenger seat. Maybe Monday was my favorite day. Just when I wasn't ready to see him.

Now of all times?! What is this?! Are they just messing with me?

In fairness, they're really good at messing with me. I'm going to give them more provocation, and my fist will fly to their faces.



I feel like stabbing him in the back!

I avoided his gaze when he slightly turned to look at me. tourist too, looking out the window. My mistake was sitting should've sat behind him so I could stab him easily.

King of Demonic Snakes!

A while later, I smelled cigarette smoke. I coughed slight mix of smoke and the car's air conditioning. When I looked Judas Traitor was blowing smoke like a dragon.

Damn it!

"What the heck?! Smoking inside the car?!" I said irritably window.

All I heard was his laugh. I had a strong feeling he was judging me. It seems like he wasn't satisfied with what he did to me he's provoking me again.

"Jerk," I muttered.

I endured the smell of cigarette smoke. My lungs were protesting because of it. When we arrived at school, I got out of the car could even park and slammed the door shut.

I couldn't take it anymore!

I was almost at the classroom door when I stepped back. I couldn't do this; my knees were shaking. I wanted to go home. But then I thought, if I did them, this cowardice of mine will never end.

A little courage, please!

I shouldn't be the one afraid. Why? Was I the one who did something wrong? Was I the one who cheated and made bets? Was I the one who led someone on?

How embarrassing! I'm the one who was wronged, yet I'm scared.

I took a deep breath, the kind where I felt like I was pulling air from my lungs. I also slapped my face with both hands to wake myself—ouch, that hurt!

I walked normally, like it was just an ordinary day. Like a normal class, in a normal school, with normal classmates.

When I entered the door, it was like an angel passed by— Gradually, everyone fell silent while looking at me. Some of them were doing and faced me.

"It's Jay-jay."

"She's here."

reserved just for me. The torn piece of my skirt's fabric v  
chair.

But I'm not sitting there anymore!

I glanced at the pair of tables and chairs beside me. The c  
door and at the front. I had no seatmate because everyone  
the back or on the sides.

I put my bag on the table, dusted off the chair, sat down,  
on my hand like nothing happened. At least I didn't have  
faces anymore. I also didn't care what they were doing b

"You're here already."

I looked at the person who spoke, standing at the door. It  
his posh instincts. I gave him a bored look.

"No. I'm just a hologram."

He chuckled slightly and shook his head before fully ent

"Why did David talk to her?"

"Maybe they have something going on."

"That's so unfair."

Agreeing, right? That kind of conversation where they

"Let's sit together!" he said cheerfully.

I looked at how close his table and chair were to mine. They were in line. The space between our tables was gone.

"I noticed," I said sarcastically.

I looked around for a place I could move to. I didn't want to move why I moved seats, and now he's sitting next to me. But I didn't move, Sir Alvin arrived.

"Good morning... Sorry I'm late," he said while arranging the table.

He glanced at me and smiled. "I'm glad you're here. Ang about you."

Thanks, Sir. Remind me again!

I gave him a half-smile, half-grimace in response. He said something. I felt like I chose the wrong seat because we were at the front. The teacher could see my every move.

"Jay-jay," Ci whispered to me.

Don't acknowledge him.

"Jay-jay."

"Why aren't you answering? Did you forget to brush your

Oh, for crying out loud!

I wanted to bang my head on the table. Hard enough that I lost consciousness.

I didn't want to yell at Ci-N. I was upset with him, but then I decided to take it out on him. David already clarified that Ci was the one who did.

I just couldn't help feeling hurt. We've been together for a long time, stayed at our house and shared a room with me. For that reason, he was not talking to me.

So annoying...

Our class with Sir Alvin ended, but my seatmate still was talking to me.

"Look at this," he said with a smile, showing me a plastic egg with a "surprise egg" label. "...look! Look!"

he opened the egg and, like a child, clapped his hands in excitement over the toy he got from inside.

"Surprise!" he said, overjoyed.

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I stood up and walked, but not toward the back where the door was straight outside. I could still hear Ci-N calling me, but I ignored her.

Where was I going? I didn't know. I tried going to the back door. I wanted to see if I could buy something from my friend who worked there.

"Ate..." I called out to her from the window at the back. "I want something?"

"Wow! You're back here," she said, looking around behind her. "What do you want to buy?"

"Your combo thing," I answered, and she suddenly laughed.

"Combo thing, huh?" she commented before walking away.

I waited for a few minutes until the door opened. I thought I'd quickly approach, but I didn't expect who I'd be facing.

Aries the Horoscope!

"J-Jay..." my friend the vendor called out hesitantly.

Aries was holding what I ordered. He was glaring at me.

"Do this one more time, and you're fired," he told the vendor, looking back at me.

"My... my... I'm sorry," the vendor replied and left.

hold it.

"You chose your section... So join them in starving," he said, suddenly stomping on the food on the ground.

He smirked at me before walking away. I was left staring. There was nothing salvageable except for the bottle of water.

I slowly sat down and took it.

I chose them... But they also chose to deceive me.

I didn't know I'd regret choosing them. I even had the gut feeling about how solid our class was.

#SectionGoals. But it turns out, only they had goals. I was wrong.

I stood up and walked away. Maybe I'll just fill up on water. I'll eat the bottle to be sure. This is what I get for being stubborn.

I'll also curse Aries's asshole.

I finished the water and was about to eat the bottle when they ran past me. They bumped into the bottle, and it fell.

It's gone... I can't eat it now.

I was about to pick up the bottle to throw it away when I saw a bag on the ground. A pack of cigarettes and a lighter were inside.

I looked at the cigarette in my hand again. I really hate that I tried smoking once, and it tasted awful. Cyrus caught me over it.

I didn't realize I had already brought the stick to my lips. It is bad for girls, but why? Does it make guys look cool?

I was about to light it when a hand snatched it from my r

"Damn it!" I cursed loudly at the traitor who did that.

"What the hell?! What are you doing?!" Yuri asked angri

In my frustration, I threw the pack at his face, followed b
dodged, but he was still glaring at me.

"What's it to you?!" I shouted at him.

"Can't you see yourself?! You're changing!"

"Of course not! There's no mirror here! Idiot!"

Yuri pulled his hair in frustration. "See?! Even the way y

"Eeoowsss ppoeeh!"

"JAY!" he shouted at me, sounding like Kuya Angelo. ".
together!"

I pointed to my head, referring to my brain. "...and my brain. Do you want me to get myself together? Screw that!"

"And this is your solution?!" He pointed to the pack of cigarettes on the ground. "...You're going back to who you used to be! The person you left in your province!"

"Oh, so what? What's it to you if I go back to who I was?"

I pretended to laugh while shaking my head. "...You can't expect me to be like that, right?" He didn't answer. "...Then don't marry me. I have a problem? It's not like you're the only one who wants this."

I walked toward the stairs behind him. I didn't want to talk to him.

"You're just like your jerk best friend!" I said before finally reaching the stairs.

I was on the last step of the stairs when I stopped. The elevator was there, some looking up at me. They were listening to our conversation. I pretended not to care and just walked past them back to the classroom.

It looks like going to school won't be easy for me.

Chapter 203: Evil Phone

Jay-jay's POV

"Pick-up and drop-off! Your bald grandma can do that. A Kuya's orders. Sure, I'm scared of him, but... damn it! I'n

We were in our last class for the day. I survived without with the Snakes. Except, of course, for the one sitting ne

"It's dismissal time!" he shouted, louder than the school l cream."

"No," I quickly replied while organizing my things.

Ci's shoulders slumped, but he forced a smile. "Come on

"No."

"Please..."

"Ci-N," I called his name, and he finally got serious. "...I Understand the word 'no.'"

I didn't wait for his response. I left the room and kept wa I could still hear them calling me. I had no intention of le

"Picking up Felix. Why?"

I thought it was for me... Ouch!

"Nothing. Just asking," I replied lifelessly.

He suddenly grinned widely. "You missed me, didn't you?"

This guy really has the nerve. Solid rock! Hardcore to the point of not caring at what he said.

"Thick-skinned," I muttered, making sure he heard it.

His phone rang, and he focused on that for a moment. He looked back at me a few times before facing me again.

"Well, it's your lucky day," he said, pocketing his phone. "The car is coming. They have a meeting. Get in!"

A meeting?

The Snakes have a meeting. Maybe they're discussing so much that I can hope it's not about me.

I got into Percy's car and sat in the passenger seat. I fastened my seat belt, and he started driving. He was singing while looking at the road.

"I'm so handsome! I'm so handsome! I'm the most handsome guy in the world!" he sang.

I looked at a group of kids walking by. They were carrying helmets. They were laughing and teasing each other and even hopped on a skateboard and started riding it.

"You want to learn that?" Percy asked me.

I didn't realize he was also looking at what I was watching.

He started driving again, but my attention was still on the car.

"I want to try it," I said.

I thought he didn't hear me because he kept driving and I was about to repeat myself when I noticed he seemed to be looking at something on the road.

"Where is it? It's near here," he muttered.

I looked at the road too, but all I saw were various establishments. There were clothing stores, shoe stores, and even a spa with a swimming pool. My search ended when he parked in front of a bike shop.

The bikes were beautiful!

"Let's go!" Percy called me.

He got out of the car, and I did the same. I took a moment to look at the bikes on display outside before entering the store. It was a small, cozy place with a few bikes on display outside before entering the store. It was a small, cozy place with a few bikes on display outside before entering the store. It was a small, cozy place with a few bikes on display outside before entering the store.

He seemed to be one of the salesmen. He had a nametag on his chest.

Percy answered his question. "A skateboard for a beginner."

"Is it for you, sir?"

"No. For my tomboy sibling," Percy replied seriously.

I immediately glared at him. He's been like this for a while. He does all sorts of things. He even claimed I'm really a guy.

Transgender bro, transgender.

The man just laughed. They talked about what I needed first, but then I noticed some rollerblades for both kids and

The two continued talking. Since I couldn't understand them, I decided to look around at the bikes on display.

I couldn't help but be amazed. The models here were much better than the ones I bought before. If I had known about this store, I would have come here instead.

Bike lover be like...

As I continued looking around, I started feeling uneasy. I noticed the man was watching and observing me. I looked around, and I

I looked back at the guys who were staring at me earlier. I noticed the black jackets they were wearing. They were motorcycle riders.

Shit! It's them... They're the ones who chased me!

I quickly went back to Percy. He was at the cashier, paying. I talked to him earlier and he handed him four large paper bags.

"I did the shopping... You disappeared suddenly," he said.

I took a deep breath and glanced at the guys, but I couldn't say anything anymore.

"O-okay... Can we go now?"

I saw the confusion on his face, but he chose to hide it and said nothing.

"Just the receipt," he said, facing the man again. "...Where's the receipt?"

He signed something, and the man returned his credit card and the receipt. He took the paper bags and handed them to me.

"I paid. You carry them," he said, walking ahead.

"Such a gentleman! Wow!" I said sarcastically.

He just laughed. When we left the store, the motorcycle riders

The trip was short because the park wasn't far from the school. What was unusual about this park was that it was cemented—no grass, no trees, but they were only around the edges.

The ground wasn't level; there were slopes, curves, and even a small hill with a flat top. What caught my attention the most was that there was a large pit.

Skateboarders would slide down and then pop up on the other side of the uphill. It was awesome!

"Wear this," Percy instructed, handing me a helmet.

I did as he said. He also handed me knee and elbow pads and a skateboard.

"Do I look cool now?" I asked.

"Are you a fridge to be cool?" he replied sarcastically.

My excitement vanished and was replaced by irritation. 'Fridge? That's so annoying!

Is only a fridge allowed to be cool?!

He was cleaning up the trash and plastic he had removed. After doing that, I decided to take out my phone and take a picture.

"That's a pretty cool picture," Percy said, looking at the screen.

I stepped on it with one foot. I watched the experts first, what they were doing.

They pushed it with one foot while the other stayed on the ground. Once they'd place both feet on it once they were sure of the spot, they'd push again.

I was nervous but excited.

I tried pushing with one foot. I did it slowly, not realizing it would wobble when you stepped on it. I tried again, this time with more force and a longer distance.

"Wrong," someone commented.

I stopped and looked at her. A girl! She approached me, holding her skateboard.

"First timer?" she asked.

"Y-yes... I'm still learning how to do it," I said, glancing at her.

"Let me see," she said, referring to my skateboard.

I handed it to her, and she inspected it like she knew exactly what she was doing.

"It's brand new... Still stiff and unscratched," she commented.

"This is her..." Rheanna said to the two girls facing her. 'are Sherri Ann and Kay-kay, my friends."

They waved at me, and I waved back.

Hi Kay-kay, I'm Jay-jay.

"We'll teach you," Sherri said with a smile.

They started explaining what to do. They even taught me on the skateboard. I had more space to move around con

I glanced at Percy's spot. He looked bored, sitting alone. to join us. At first, he didn't want to, but he was clearly b hands in his pockets as he approached.

So you're coming after all...

"This is my brother... Percy," I introduced him to them.

Sherri's cheeks suddenly turned red as she waved at Perc elbowing Kay-kay while staring at the guy I introduced.

I faced Percy, but he didn't seem to notice the three.

"Percy... This is Rheanna, Sherri, and Kay-kay."

Percy smiled at them, causing them to giggle and almost could only grimace

me stand on the skateboard with both feet.

"Have you learned a lot from them?" he asked.

"A little," I answered hesitantly.

"Let's see," he said with a mischievous grin.

Suddenly, he pushed me hard. Out of shock, I forgot everything he taught me. I couldn't even remember how to stop the skateboard, even more when I saw that I was heading straight toward the cliff.

I'm going to fall!

"Jay-jay!" one of them screamed.

I just closed my eyes and braced for impact as my body hit the ground, followed by the skateboard hitting my head.

Good thing I was wearing a helmet.

"Nice! This is going viral!" Percy shouted as he ran toward me.

"Is she still alive?"

"What just happened?"

"That looked painful!"

As I stood up, I felt the pain in my back. I had landed on my back. Good thing I was wearing protective gear, but it still didn't stop the pain.

"It hurts..." I whispered as I tried to hold my back.

Sherri and Rheanna helped me walk and sit properly on the ground. I was carrying my skateboard.

And Percy? Oh, he was there—watching the video he took of me. He was even slapping his thigh as he laughed and stared at him.

"Look at your face, Jay!" he said, showing my phone to the others. "You look like you've been drained of blood!"

I was fuming!

Out of frustration, I slapped his hand, knocking the phone out of his hand. It felt like everything moved in slow motion. My phone flew through the air, hit the helmet of a skateboarder near us, then bounced off and hit the ground before landing on the ground.

I thought that was the end of it, but then a skateboard rolled over my foot once, not twice... but three times! Three times! And the screen cracked.

Holy cow calabao!

"You animal! This is your fault!" I screamed while repeating with my phone.

"Ouch! Ouch! W-wait! Stop it!"

Rheanna and the others came over. Kay-kay was still holding the skateboard.

"It's already broken, and now you're hitting him with it? It's more broken!" Sherri said.

I stopped hitting Percy, but I still didn't take my eyes off him. I was on the verge of tears because of this guy. My blood pressure was rising.

"Let me see..." Kay-kay said, extending her hand. "...Maybe it can be fixed."

I handed her my phone. She tried to turn it on. It lit up for a second and then turned off again. She tried once more, and this time, it still didn't work.

"This can still be fixed... Let's take it to my brother. He can fix it," Kay-kay said.

"No need! I'll just buy you a new one," Percy said.

Wow! Rich kid vibes...

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"Kuya!" Kay-kay called out as she put down the skateboard carrying.

Rheanna and Sherri placed their skateboards on the long down. Sherri immediately walked inside the shop, just li

A well-built man came out, wearing a blue t-shirt with a face. Kay-kay spoke to him and handed over my phone.

"The screen is the only issue... The phone still functions,

I just nodded and let him work on my phone. It took quit Rheanna and Sherri started getting bored, so they went b Kay-kay followed them, leaving just Percy and me waiti

I took off the protective pads on my elbows and knees. I helmet. I was still glaring at this blue-eyed idiot. Should eyes out?

Night fell. Kay-kay came back, saying that her friends h was almost dozing off because of the long wait. I was ab the bench when the repair guy called me.

"Miss..." he said. "...Your phone's screen is fixed, but I n

Curious, I approached him. He showed me my phone and unfamiliar app.

"It really seems like a virus... Do you want me to format

I had no idea about these things. I didn't even know what to do to my phone. I glanced at Percy, who looked completely

I turned back to the repair guy. "M-maybe tomorrow inst

He nodded at me. I then signaled Percy to pay the guy. He walked over and pulled out some cash from his wallet.

We thanked the repairman and left.

We returned to where Percy had parked his car. I placed the backseat. I sat next to Percy and buckled my seatbelt. My phone again—it looked like new! Well, newly repaired!

"What could this be?" I wondered as I tried to open it.

"Which one?" Percy asked, glancing at what I was doing

I showed him the app. He had no reaction. He started the driving.

This app was a huge mystery to me. It was so suspicious that I didn't know anything about this stuff, so I had no clue what to do. I downloaded apps without thinking.

"Why don't you ask your classmate?" Percy said seriously.

# Chapter 204: Eruption

## Jay-jay's POV

Password Incorrect!

This app is driving me crazy. I really can't understand its me up all night, and I could barely put my phone down b checking that darn app.

"Are you even listening?"

I lifted my gaze to my older brother. He was starting to l while we were waiting for my ride.

"Obviously not," Aries chimed in.

I immediately glared at him and hid my phone because n already giving it a suspicious look.

"I'll ask you again... Why didn't you go with Yuri yester questioned.

"I had somewhere to go," I quickly replied.

"Where?"

My brother just nodded and signaled for me to leave. I stepped outside, passing by Yuri. But before I could reach his car, it stopped.

What if he was riding with him again?

I lowered my head and practically crawled toward the car. It looked ridiculous as I peeked through the windows from the side. I was looking from the rear, I couldn't see who was sitting in the front.

Ugh, this is annoying! What if he was in there again? It was so embarrassing since he has his own car, yet he's riding alone in the back of a taxi?

Hah! Hah! Karma, bro!

"What are you doing?"

My whole body stiffened when I heard that voice. I almost ran away from the car window just to avoid facing him.

I knew it!

"Again... what are you doing?" Keifer repeated.

Kissing the car!

Slowly, I turned to face him while keeping my head down.



"W-what are you doing?!" I asked in frustration, still ave

I felt relieved in this position because at least I didn't have to stay strong in front of him. I had to show that I was what he did.

"Look at me," he ordered, but I didn't comply.

"Look. At. Me."

Don't look...

"Look..." He held my chin and lifted my face. "...At..." C  
"...Me."

My whole system cursed at once. My hands and knees stopped when I saw his eyes again.

They were so close to mine.

His eyes...

I don't want this. He'll see that I'm still affected by him. I and at the same time, I did the best thing I could think of

I crossed my eyes and made myself go cross-eyed. It hurt at least his face was now a blur. The only downside was that of him.

"Serves you right," Keifer said.

I rested my eyes for a moment. When I was sure they were closed, I opened them again and shot him a glare. He still hadn't moved, he was just keeping me trapped.

"Move!" I shouted at him, but he didn't budge.

"Damn it! I said move!"

He's so good at pissing me off!

A slow smirk formed on his lips, his eyes looking at me.

"Keifer."

I turned to the one who called his name. It was Yuri. For a moment, I was thankful for his sudden appearance.

"...Let's go," he said flatly.

But the smirk on this bastard king's face didn't disappear. He just looked at him just to wipe that smug look off.

"Move!" I yelled at him again.

Instead of backing off, he leaned in even closer, which put him even more. I pressed my head against the car window to put some distance between us, but it was pointless.

Surprise!!! Your insides just blew up!

Why is this happening? I shouldn't be affected anymore.

But my body refuses to cooperate. It reacts on its own.

"Jay-jay..." Yuri softly called my name.

I slowly looked at him. He didn't have any expression, but he extended toward me.

"I-I'm not coming with you," I said.

"That's not an option. Angelo might get mad."

I glanced inside the car for a moment. That Demon Bastard was there, completely relaxed.

"I don't want to ride with him."

Yuri let out a deep sigh. "Keifer can't drive yet. His wound said it still hurts whenever he moves his entire arm."

So I have to be the one to adjust?!

"Tsk! Annoying!" I huffed and stomped toward the back

I got in with a loud thud, making sure not to look at that  
eyes stayed fixed on the window

That Demon is pulling his snake moves on me again. Always.

When we arrived at the school parking lot, I quickly got didn't wait for them and walked straight to my classroom. My classmates greeted me, but I ignored them.

"Good morning," Ci-N greeted me as I sat down.

I ignored him too and just buried my face on my desk.

I could feel the Snakes passing by in front of me. I wasn't doing it on purpose or not.

"Jay-jay..." Ci called me while tapping my shoulder. "...I

I lifted my head and looked at him in annoyance. He was handed me a chocolate bar.

"I don't want it," I said and buried my face back on the desk. I was me again.

"Come on. Take it before they grab it," he insisted.

Tsk! So persistent!

"I said I don't want it. Hide it if you don't want to share,"

I was about to rest my head again when he did the same.

"Alright, I'll just keep it. We can eat it later," he said as he put it into his bag.

I glanced at the Snakes who were watching us. The moment they quickly looked away and pretended to be busy.

My gaze locked with that Bastard Keifer.

Look at what you did!

I rolled my eyes at him and turned toward the door.

I felt so heavy inside. I do yell at Ci-N sometimes, but not today.

I took a deep breath and grabbed my headset and phone.

I planned to listen to music, but my eyes landed on the C

I still couldn't uninstall this cursed application.

I looked around for Edrix, and sure enough, he was there sitting in his chair while playing on his phone.

I stood up and walked toward him.

I could feel everyone's eyes following me, as if they had been waiting for me to move.

"Edrix " I called him

"I-I don't know what that is."

You didn't even look at it properly!

I frowned at his reaction.

It felt like he was avoiding looking at my phone.

I placed it down on his desk.

"You're good with gadgets and computers, right? Uninstall the app, or just format it completely." I ordered, slightly irritated.

Edrix bit his lower lip and wiped his palm on his pants.

My frown deepened.

His behavior was odd.

Too obvious. It was like he was hiding something from me.

I'm not an investigator, but I won't let this go!

"B-because... Jay-jay," he stammered. "...I-I can't."

One of my eyebrows raised so high it could almost touch his forehead.

"You can't do it?" I asked sarcastically. "Who are you for?"

his neck.

I KNEW IT!

I slammed my phone down on his desk, making a loud noise that completely caught everyone's attention.

"Answer me! I'm starting to get pissed off!" I yelled at him.

He shut his eyes tightly, biting his lip again. I could tell—they were hiding something from me. They did something to me again. They were ganging up on me again.

I clenched my fist and punched the desk out of frustration. I wouldn't let them do this to me anymore.

"Jay-jay," some of the others called out to me, but my focus was on Edrix.

He swallowed hard and took a deep breath before finally speaking again. He picked up my phone, and to my shock, he unlocked it even asking for the password.

He tapped on the app to open it, and when it asked for a password, he entered it himself. The application opened, and he turned to look at me.

He was the one who installed it on my phone.

"A-and besides that..." Edrix continued hesitantly. "...this is another phone."

He glanced at Keifer, making me look at him, too.

He showed no reaction. He was just listening, like everyone else, but glare at him.

"All of your text messages and phone calls go through this app," Edrix added. "So whoever has the linked phone can read your messages and listen to your calls."

It felt like I was doused with cold water. Shock and fury as I turned back to Edrix. I felt like a prisoner under surveillance. I lost my right to freedom.

I lost my privacy.

"W-why did you put that on my phone?" I asked, struggling to keep my voice steady.

Edrix lowered his head. "B-because of your previous meeting with Percy."

Fvcking shit!

I ran a hand down my face, unable to believe what I was hearing.

"Percy is the one who linked the app to your phone."



I couldn't hold back my anger anymore. I wanted to smash them. I wanted to punch all of them one by one. I had no idea that I was going this far.

"You're unbelievable!" I spat at Keifer. "You really have no conscience."

He remained expressionless, staring at me as if he didn't hear me.

"You're so determined to carry out your plan, huh?! Even if it means going off-limits to you!" I shouted. "...Are you really this serious?"

Instead of responding, he just rolled his eyes at me, which was the only reaction I got over the edge.

With large, heavy strides, I marched toward him, ready to throw a punch in the face. But before I could land a hit, someone grabbed me from behind, wrapped tightly around my waist, lifting me away from him.

"Let me go!" I shouted, struggling.

"That's enough! Stop it!" It was Yuri's voice.

I was the one who had to stop?!

He carried me out of the room. Only when we were a good distance away did he finally put me down. I glared at him and shoved him away.

"Jay..."

I ran my fingers through my hair, trying to hold back, but anyway, spilling over from pure anger.

I swore I wouldn't cry anymore, yet here I was again. And just falling—they were racing, as if there was a competition down would turn into an eye booger!

"Can you all just stop already?! I'm so damn tired..." I cried.  
"...Just leave me alone."

I used to think I was the problem. That I was at fault for those bastards at the same time. I thought I was wrong for

I nearly lost my self-respect, believing I was nothing but should be lining up in the plaza with women waiting for

A certified slut, in other words!

I was practically losing sleep over them—overthinking that I would end up hurting one of them. My guilt ate me alive. I forced myself to smile whenever I was with the one I loved.

But it turns out they were the ones playing with me. I was strung along.

If I thought I was a flirt before, now I felt like a complete idiot. I might as well build a statue of myself.

I wanted to give up.

And it seemed like my body wanted the same. My knees whole body suddenly went limp, and the last thing I saw fading into darkness as I heard Yuri's panicked voice.

"Jay-jay!"

# Chapter 205: Visit Kiko

## Jay-jay's POV

"Are you eating properly?" the nurse asked me.

I couldn't answer. The truth was, I hadn't been eating well. We skipped dinner, rarely had rice for breakfast—mostly just porridge. I couldn't even eat properly at lunch.

"N-not really," I answered weakly.

"No wonder..." she said as she stood up.

She took something from her table and returned with two bottles of juice. She placed them on the table beside my bed.

"Your classmates brought these for you. They said it's for you with a smile. "...Your body weakens easily because you're not eating properly." She placed some medicine next to the lunch box.

"After eating, take this," she instructed.

I forced a smile and nodded at her. She left me and returned. She looked at the lunch box on the side table, then picked it up. It was filled with food, and I knew Ema had cooked it.

If I didn't eat, I wouldn't be able to take my medicine. If I didn't take my medicine, I wouldn't be able to leave this place. So even though I was scared, I started eating.

I missed this!

I hurriedly finished my meal and took the medicine the nurse had given me. I was planning to rest, but I knew those bastards would come back here any minute now. I stood up and adjusted my uniform.

"Where are you going? You still need to rest," the nurse said, stopping me from standing up and fixing myself.

"I-I'm just going back to the classroom," I lied.

"But you still need to recover," she insisted.

I had no intention of arguing with her. She stared at me for a moment, but when she realized I wouldn't budge, she gave up. She let me go to the clinic.

I had no plans of going back to the classroom. I kept walking straight to the school gate. I only had the money in my pocket, which was gone, completely shattered earlier.

It should have hit his face, so I wouldn't feel this regret now.

I was nearing the school gate when I overheard some guys

"That's what happens when you have strong connections Aries Fernandez, after all."

Aries was the one who reported it to the guidance office.

I was confused by what they were saying. How did Aries know one to report it, and why was it immediate expulsion? I continued walking.

If earlier I didn't know where to go, now I had an idea. I looked for a ride.

Before long, a taxi arrived, and I quickly hailed it. It stopped and I was about to get in...

"Jay-jay!" someone called out to me.

When I turned around, I saw Yuri running towards me from the building. He hurried inside and shut the door.

"Benedict Hospital, please!" I told the driver urgently.

The taxi quickly drove off before Yuri could reach me. I saw him as the car moved. He stopped at the gate, not taking any more time.

I just wanted to get away.

I knew this was the right thing to do. I felt like I couldn't stay there any longer. I needed to get away from that place.

He was holding a closed book while tilting his head back and letting the breeze from the surrounding trees.

I slowly walked toward him and observed him. His neck and arms were gone, but his left leg and right hand were still wrapped in bandages.

"K-Kiko," I called out softly.

He opened one eye first, then the other when he recognized me. He straightened up slightly and smiled.

"Jay-jay..." he greeted. "...How are you?"

I smiled back and crouched slightly to be at his level. He looked much better now—not as skinny as before. His face also looked brighter.

"You seem like you're about to be discharged soon," I teased.

Instead of answering, he studied my face as if trying to recognize me. The smile he had earlier slowly faded.

"Can you do me a favor?" he asked. "...I want to go around the garden. Can you push my wheelchair?" he requested.

I smiled and nodded. I pushed his wheelchair as he had a clear pathway along the side. My steps were slow because, honestly, the surroundings felt so peaceful.

"Thank you," he said, his voice soft and grateful.

"Mind telling me what happened?" he asked, his voice fi

I took a deep breath. I had come here to find out if what I also wanted to check on him.

But now, it felt like that wasn't my reason anymore. I stopped moved his wheelchair near a bench. Then, I sat down so other.

"You look pale. Are you sick?" he asked.

I smiled and shook my head. "I'm just tired." I bit my lower lip exhausted from everything that's happening to me."

"Jay..." he called my name. "...The guys from Section A are in chaos."

I was the one who was supposed to check on him, but now the situation had flipped. Maybe I was the one who needed to go to the hospital.

I took a deep breath. "Have you ever been ganged up on?"

"Well..." He looked at the bandages on his leg and arm. "I

Obviously!

I chuckled at my own question. He had it much worse—



Aries, really?! Just wow!

"Pffft... Aries. He's another problem. Another reason for said, slightly annoyed.

He looked at me with curiosity. "Why is that?"

"Turns out that Horoscope guy is my brother. And he has a reason I don't even know."

He tilted his head slightly, as if deep in thought. "Weird."

"Exactly. Weird."

"But when I tried to attack you... he was the one who caught me."

I froze at what he said. Aries was the one who came? In those two best friends who helped me.

I let out a fake laugh. "You must have amnesia from getting hit by Keifer and Yuri were the ones who helped me."

He looked at me seriously, with a bit of confusion. I stopped and coughed slightly to shake off my discomfort.

"No. It was Aries. And now that we're talking about it, I remember. He shouted before punching me: 'Let go of my sister.'"

I was completely confused. How could Aries have been the one who helped me?

"We were worried about you, so we followed you," Ci-N

"Who's that, Jay?" Kiko asked, his back still turned to th

I turned his wheelchair around so he could see what I wa  
expression immediately changed—he looked afraid, and  
understand why.

After all, he was now facing the very people who had be  
their glares toward him were anything but friendly.

"You look great," Keifer said sarcastically.

How did these snakes find me?

My phone was destroyed. I hadn't told anyone where I w

"H-how did you know I was here?"

No one answered, but they all looked at Keifer. That was  
understand.

"I have my ways," said the King of the Demon Snakes.

I gave him a sharp look. I really hope that deadly glare is  
know what's up! This is so annoying! What did he use th

"Damn you!" I shouted at him.

"Jay-jay!" Calix scolded me.

"Kiko already told me! You weren't the ones who saved me! You hurt me!"

Keifer and Yuri exchanged looks. It seemed they didn't expect this.

"Jay... That's what Aries asked us to do, so—"

"LIAR!" I shouted angrily at Yuri. "...You only said that to take advantage of the situation!"

"Jay! Just listen!" Eman pleaded.

"And then what?! You'll just lie to me again? Damn it! He lied to me!"

"Jay-jay, come on! Don't think like that!" Kit begged.

I felt so heavy inside. I just said I needed some space, even if it meant leaving them, but here they are, right in front of me again. They really

"If you can, just leave. I don't want to see you right now, please."

"Jay-jay," Yuri's voice was pleading.

"Kiko needs to rest too. You're disturbing him—" I stopped when I realized he wasn't beside me anymore. I didn't feel

"Faster! Faster!" Ci-N shouted, raising both hands.

I quickly ran toward them. If Kiko didn't die from the be from a heart attack because of these lunatics.

"Stop that!" I shouted as I chased them.

But it seemed they had no intention of listening. They pu wheelchair even faster. I only noticed too late that David stop them.

He blocked the wheelchair, and the idiots braked like a c could crash into David. They stopped, and I took the cha and Drew hard.

I also pulled Ci-N off Kiko's lap. I immediately checked

"Are you okay? Does anything hurt?" I asked.

He was breathing heavily, and his face was pale, as if all drained from it. I couldn't blame him for being scared—] just didn't turn as pale as he did.

He hadn't even left the hospital, and it looked like he was more injuries.

"J-Jay... P-please. Just leave with your friends," he said, breath.

That's when I noticed we were being stared at by other patients, nurses, doctors, and visitors.

"S-sorry, Jay," Ci-N said.

He was looking down, playing with his fingers. It was so obvious he wanted to yell at him and blame him, but it was pointless.

"If Kiko gets worse, you're all dead to me," I threatened Drew.

"I can't believe this," Keifer said angrily. "...You're siding with him as I remember, he tried to rape you!"

I glared at him. "At least he's not a liar like you," I said at last.

I took big steps to leave quickly. But what's the point when you have no longer legs? Someone suddenly grabbed my arm and dragged me to the car.

King of the Demons!

"Let me go!" I shouted at him.

He didn't say anything. He just kept pulling me, which made me even angrier. Damn this jerk! He never fails to annoy me!

"Let go!"

"Fvck! Get in!"

"Damn it!"

"GOD DAMN IT!" he shouted loudly, punching the close

I froze, and my heart skipped a beat. It was terrifying! I've been through this before, but I still couldn't help being scared. My knee leaned against the car.

Shit! I didn't expect that!

I slowly looked at him and saw the rage in his eyes. That was when he's ready to kill someone.

"One more time... Jasper Jean. One more time you go near me and I make sure he never sees the light of day again," he threatened, looking at me.

He slowly removed his fist from the car door. The dent was clearly visible.

"Now, get in the car," he ordered calmly.

I obeyed! He might punch me next!

My body was still shaking as I got into the car. I felt like I was out of my mind from fear. I thought I was supposed to be mad at him, but I was just scared.

# Chapter 206: Switch

## Jay-jay's POV

Have you ever woken up feeling like you just didn't want to get up because you're lazy, but because you're just so exhausted from sleeping.

I'm tired of living...

I didn't know this day would come. It feels like my life has been a blur and there's no point in continuing like this. This feeling is so familiar.

It's like it was just yesterday...

I forced myself to get up when I heard Mom's voice outside.

"Wake up... You might be late," she said while knocking.

"Okay," I replied lifelessly.

I went straight to the bathroom and went through my morning routine. I clipped my hair, changed into a t-shirt, and walked to the kitchen where they were.

Mom was talking loudly, telling some story. Kuva Angel

"What do you mean, nothing? You're about to graduate h  
Lola told me you wanted to go to college."

I didn't respond. I ate as if I couldn't hear anything. I don  
the food tasted like nothing.

"Mom's talking to you," Kuya Angelo said.

"I don't want to talk to her," I muttered under my breath,  
enough to escape their hearing.

"Jay-jay!" Kuya scolded.

It's so annoying!

It's like my ears suddenly got tired of hearing them. I don  
name coming out of their mouths anymore.

"Aren't you tired?" I asked Kuya, still staring at my plate  
"...Because I'm tired of your lectures."

"Jay-jay!" Mom and Tita Gema called out simultaneously

Even without looking at Kuya, I knew he was glaring at  
feel Aries' eyes on me.

"What do you want me to do then? Forget everything the  
asked authoritatively.



"Jay? Is there a problem?" Tita asked worriedly.

Just leave me alone...

"Crazy," Aries muttered, but it was clearly meant to be h

You're crazier!

"Are you starting with me again?!" Kuya asked angrily.  
seeing me get mad, don't you?!"

"I'm done," I said almost in a whisper.

"What?"

"I'm done! I'm done hearing your lectures! Stop it! Stop  
my father!" I shouted, slamming the table.

I took a deep breath and glared at Kuya. It felt like I was  
with what I did. I was scared, but my anger took over.

"Jay-jay!" Aries shouted at me. "...Stop it!"

"Aries!" Tita scolded him.

My gaze stayed locked on Kuya, who was currently killi  
I knew it—I didn't even need to ask. The way he was loc  
all.

I quickly walked away. I didn't want to hear another lecture. My heart was too tired. I might not be able to take it anymore.

I might just collapse!

I took a shower and got ready to face my daily punishment where the annoying Judases who ruin my life are.

When I left my room, Aries was already waiting for me. He was furrowed, and his arms were crossed.

Maybe he'll tell me my horoscope for today.

"What's your problem now?" he asked without looking at me.

I wanted to answer his question, but I couldn't. Even I don't know the answer. It's like I woke up from a bad dream and got slapped.

I just shook my head and was about to walk away when I suddenly remembered something.

"Aries," I called him, and he looked at me annoyed. "Tell me."

He raised an eyebrow, clearly not understanding what it was. It was clear to me why I said it.

Of course, I was the one who said it!

"For giving me a headache from Kiko," I explained, and his eyes

At least he can still smile despite everything that's happened. I can't even force myself to do the same.

I went straight outside without waiting for him. I was about to open the backseat door when Yuri stopped me. He had been following me.

"Sit here... Keifer won't be joining us today."

YES!!

Finally, something good is happening in my life today. I'm not going to be one bad thing after another.

I moved to the passenger seat beside the driver. Yuri even smiled at me before walking around to the driver's side. He stayed quiet during the ride, just like always.

"Jay?" he called me. "...Are you okay? You seem different."

I just shook my head and looked out the window. As if that would make a difference. I'm still the same. I'm still mad at them and his brother, the King of Demons.

We arrived at school, and as usual, I got out first and left the car. I'm so kind. Seriously!

So kind...

~~~~~

I ignored him and just sat in my seat near the door. Yuri called me. I knew the other one wasn't here yet—why am I even talking to him?! I don't care if he's late. In fact, it's better if he does. I don't have to deal with his face.

I just slumped on my desk, burying my face in my arms. I buried my whole head in the desk. I stayed like that for a few minutes, falling asleep, when I felt someone poking me.

Ci-N again...

I didn't want to acknowledge him, but of course... it's Ci-N. We go—

"Jay-jay," he called me. "Don't sleep, I have something to tell you."

I turned my head to face him. I looked at him boredly. He was leaning again, leaning his face closer to mine.

"My birthday's coming up," he said excitedly. "...You're coming to the party, right?"

Oh, right...

He did give me an invitation. The one that looked like it was for my birthday. His birthday's on Valentine's Day. The day of the heart.

I didn't answer. I just turned my head away to avoid him.

"Do you guys want to attend the Career Orientation?" Sir asked the class.

"What's that about, Sir?" I heard Denzel ask.

"Is there free food?" Ci-N chimed in.

Sir laughed before answering. "They'll teach you the right career that suits you."

"We're not going, Sir. We'll just choose our careers ourselves," Calix replied, then smirked. "...Denzel will be a house husband, Edrix at a gambling den, and Eman at a computer shop."

"You're so annoying, Calix!" Denzel shouted, and the others laughed. "You're all so good at this!"

Even Sir laughed and shook his head at their antics. At least he thought it was the nonsense of these Demons.

"Choosing a career that suits us is easy, Sir," Mayo said. "I won't go."

"It's up to you..." Sir said, smiling. "...What courses are you going to take?"

"PILOT!" Ci-N shouted loudly, raising both hands. "I want to be a pilot!"

"Like you have a choice when it comes to what your parents teased.

Ci-N grinned at them. "Did I say I wouldn't do what they

Tsk! he's so cheeky...

The others shook their heads, scratching their necks. Even I react the same way to what this little brat said.

"How about you, Jay-jay? What course are you planning to ask, focusing on me.

Even without looking at the idiots, I knew they were starstruck so used to their antics by now.

I avoided Sir's gaze. "Nothing, Sir."

"Why nothing?"

He really had to ask...

"I'm getting married right after graduation," I replied bored.

No one said a word. I could feel the weird tension behind my back. Alvin was glancing at them.

I had a strange feeling about what was happening, so I slipped away and was shocked to see Kai-fan grinning. My lips

Honestly, I shouldn't care about them. It's fine if they kill at least it'll reduce my problems. If the King dies, it's Happ If Yuri dies, I'll still be a Dalagang Pilipina by the time I

So it's fine! Go ahead and kill each other!

Our class with Sir and the other teachers ended. It was lu forgot to bring food. Looks like I'll have to endure hunge

"Jay-jay!" Ci-N called me excitedly. "...Let's eat!"

Instead of joining him to go to Eman, I walked out of the planning to just hang out on the second floor to pass the could get close to the stairs, someone grabbed my arm.

Felix...

I pulled my arm back and glared at him. "What do you w

"B-because... j-join us for lunch," he stammered, scratch neck.

Tsk! Of all people, he had to invite me...

"No," I replied quickly.

"Jay... You don't have anything to eat. Just come with us,

"What's it to you? Why do you care if I starve?" I asked.

I was left alone. Which was fine by me. I continued my path to the second floor. As expected, the wind was strong, and it was

I remembered how David, Ci-N, and I used to hang out here. We wanted to hide from those idiots, so we ended up eating here. Eventually, even Mica and Calix started joining us.

It didn't last long, though, because Eman came back to class and started eating inside the classroom, except for Calix, who stayed on the second floor.

I never thought I'd say this, but I kind of miss those times when people to eat with, even if I was the one bringing food for

"You look like you're in a music video here, huh?" some

I glared at them, ready to curse, but I stopped when I realized

"What are you doing here?!" I asked, slightly annoyed, and

He raised his hand, holding a box of pizza and a plastic table

Ooohhhh.... Pizza!

"Felix texted me. He said you weren't eating again," he said, and I stuff down in a corner.

I walked over to him and sat beside him. The pizza box was

He just laughed at me. He grabbed a slice too and started didn't talk because, of course... you know! We were both

While we were eating, Percy suddenly handed me a white to ask what it was, but based on the size, I already knew.

"What's this for?" I asked before taking a bite.

"What do you do with a cellphone?"

Honestly, I still prefer my old cellphone. Even though I had something wrong with it, I still like it better. All my pictures and videos! I'm frustrated that I can't figure out

That phone and I had history!

"You don't want it?" he asked, snapping me back to reality.

I hesitated at first, but I took it anyway. I need a cellphone doesn't?!

After eating, I was about to grab one of the drinks he brought noticed the bottle. It wasn't just any drink.

"You're shameless! This is alcohol!" I said, holding up the

He just smiled at me before grabbing one and opening it.

"I know you need this more," he teased.

True...

No one really comes to our building, so I'm sure no one saw my crazy stepbrother brought alcohol. I looked at the big bottle from ours. I didn't see anyone there.

They wouldn't see us anyway because their building is far from like the school intentionally isolates Section E from ever

I think I need this too!

I let him open one. My throat felt dry as I tasted the alcohol that long since the last time I drank, but it feels like years

"Good, right?" Percy asked with a smile.

"It's good.... But so is the beating I'll get from Kuya Ang about this."

He just laughed before taking another sip. I set the bottle in the cellphone box. It looked just like my old phone.

"Add my number. So you can call me," he said, taking out

I turned on the phone and started pressing buttons. Once I went to the phonebook and added a contact.

"Ready," I said.

Chapter 207: Cold

Yuri's POV

Jay-jay was acting weird. Almost all of us kept glancing restless in her seat, as if she wanted to do something.

"Is Jay-jay okay?" Felix asked.

I shrugged. Even I couldn't answer that. This morning, she was acting normal, and now, after lunch, she was acting like this.

"Son of a b*tch!" Jay suddenly shouted, making us look

"...It's so hot!"

But it was actually a bit cold.

The weather had been gloomy since this morning, so it was

She removed her necktie and slightly unbuttoned her blouse.

Her undergarment was starting to show.

I immediately stood up and approached her. She was expecting

She continued fanning herself with her hand. She wasn't tipsy. I could tell from the way she was acting.

"Fix your uniform. You're already showing—SHIT!"

I cursed loudly when she fully unbuttoned her uniform, she shouldn't be seen.

I quickly removed my polo and used it to cover her front off, but I smacked her hand away. She glared at me.

"I said it's hot!" she yelled at me.

That was the alcohol talking... Good thing she wasn't co

"Who gave you alcohol?" I asked again, now more anno

"Your bald grandfather."

I could only hold my temples in frustration at the way she was being difficult, responding with sarcasm, and impos

That's the price, Yuri. That's the price.

"F*ck! It's so hot!" she screamed again and threw my po

"What the..." I heard Keifer say.

I looked at him just as he entered the room. His eyebrow

His eyebrows completely met in frustration. He quickly :
but at the same time, Jay-jay started undressing again, m

I wrapped my polo around her, and Keifer did the same.
react, Keifer suddenly picked her up like a sack of rice.

"F*ck! Put me down!" Jay-jay shouted.

"Keifer..." I called his name. "...What are you planning to

"I don't know!" he shouted back and took a deep breath.
stop her!"

He suddenly walked out of the room. I immediately foll

He didn't stop walking until he abruptly turned towards t
the second floor.

"Where are you taking her?"

He didn't answer and instead went straight to the farthest
where the pictures of former Section E members were di

"Put me down! I'll puke on you!" Jay-jay kept screaming

Keifer struggled to get the keys from his pocket and ther
I quickly caught them.

"Open this s*ddam door!" he ordered angrily

"Calm down, Jay," I said and was about to approach her, polos at me.

I looked at her and realized that almost everything was e uniform was completely unbuttoned. I swallowed hard a away.

Get a grip, Yuri!

"Aahhhhh! Why is my uniform open?!" Jay-jay screame

"You're the one who—!"

Keifer didn't even finish his sentence because Jay-jay thi

She fixed her uniform and glared at us.

"Why are you both here?! You're planning something ag you?!"

I ran my fingers through my hair in frustration. I was sur drunk, but judging by the way she was acting, I wished s

"Are you sure she's not drunk?" Keifer asked me.

"She's not asking for a virgin to sacrifice. So, she's not d

He seemed to have understood what I said. Maybe she w being completely drunk. Maybe just one more bottle, an

Keifer let out a deep sigh and ran both hands over his face and watched Jay-jay, who looked like she had already fa

This was better than earlier when she almost stripped in class.

She didn't eat lunch with us. According to Felix, he tried she rejected him.

I looked at my wristwatch to check the time. We wouldn't be in next class. I let out a deep sigh.

This is all our fault. We shouldn't have let Jay-jay end up

Now we're the ones struggling with what she's doing.

I turned to Keifer, who had his eyes closed and was resting on the couch.

"Can you..." I started, but he still didn't move. "...tell me

"The reason for what?" he asked nonchalantly.

He was avoiding that question again. It was obvious that he was doing something.

Maybe they believe what you say, but not me.

You can't lie to me

But not like this.

I looked at Jay-jay, who was sound asleep.

Not in this situation.

Not when she's so distant from us, even though she's right.

Not when she's so angry at all of us.

"I still want to know the truth."

"What for?" he asked and pulled out a cigarette.

He lit it and offered one to me, but I shook my head to refuse. I stopped smoking—I stopped a couple of months ago.

Keifer suddenly chuckled. "You're really serious about this, aren't you? You were just kidding."

"Don't change the topic. Please answer me, Keifer."

He blew out a puff of smoke and looked away.

I was starting to feel irritated by his actions.

"You already know the answer, so why are you still asking me for another drag from his cigarette."

Keifer's answer was such bullshit.

He even had the nerve to lie to me.

"That's the f*cking truth," he answered lifelessly.

I laughed at what he said—laughed, but without amusement.

Talking to him was frustrating.

I might as well talk to a brick wall.

"I was the happiest guy in town when you stayed away from me."

It felt so good to think that I finally had a chance with her.

But when I saw her hurting..." I clenched my fists. "...I wanted to hurt you.

I wanted to blame everything on you and make you pay."

"Then why didn't you?" he asked, challenging me.

"Because I know there is something else."

"And that something is?"

"You're lying," I answered, making him pause mid-drag.

He just finished his cigarette, then lit another one.

It was hard to read his mind when he was like this.

"Keifer," I called his name with a pleading tone.

"...If you can't tell Jay-jay and the entire Section E, then

"I have nothing to say to you."

I couldn't hold myself back anymore.

I grabbed his collar tightly.

"Damn it, Keifer! You're in love with Jay-jay, but you ch

"Why?! What's the f*cking reason?!" I asked angrily.

His lifeless eyes met mine.

"I'm not, Yuri. I'm not in love with her."

I threw a strong punch at him.

He didn't even fight back.

He just sat on the floor, wiping his lip.

So frustrating! Damn it!

"If you don't have feelings for Jay-jay, then why do you whenever another guy gets close to her?"

He couldn't answer.

I smirked secretly.

I knew he couldn't deny it when it came to jealousy.

He stood up from the floor and looked at Jay-jay.

"I'm just playing around," he said and walked away.

I was left staring at the door where he exited.

I thought I could get him to admit it, but I guess I was wrong.

I wasn't trying to make him confess just to humiliate him.

I was doing this because it hurt me.

It hurt to see Jay-jay like this.

Every time she looked at Keifer, I felt her pain for her.

I never realized it could hurt this much to see someone in suffering.

I thought I should be happy because there was no longer

She heard us!

"Jay-jay..." I called out and took a step toward her, but she

"L-leave me a-alone for n-now," she said in a broken voice.

Instead of following what she said, I sat beside her and held her.

She tried to push me away, but at the same time, her tears told me she gave up.

Jay-jay was like a child who had just lost her favorite cat.

I let her pour out all her pain—toward us, toward Keifer.

I'm so sorry you had to hear those words.

"Damn it!" she screamed as she cried.

"...I-I told m-myself I w-wouldn't cry a-anymore, b-but I can't stop again!"

"I'm sorry, Jay. I'm so sorry."

She kept crying.

She cried until she fell asleep.

Her head rested on my chest while her body remained behind.

"K-Keifer..." I heard Jay-jay mumble in her sleep.

Even in her dreams.

This hurts.

Even in her dreams, she still thinks of Keifer.

If only I could help her forget him, I would.

"Aishiteru..." I whispered.

I let her sleep for a while.

She woke up just as classes were ending, so we decided

I was the one who took her home, just as I had agreed w

She remained silent throughout the ride.

When we arrived in front of her house, I quickly grabbed
she could get out.

"Jay... I'm sorry—"

"Stop apologizing, Yuri," she cut me off.

"...Your sorry won't change anything."

It was Hahaoya.

"Hahaoya? I'm on my way home."

["That's good to hear."]

"Is there a problem?"

["Keifer is here. He's waiting for you."]

At our house? Keifer?

"Okay... I'm almost there," I replied before ending the call.

I quickly resumed driving.

The building wasn't far from where I had stopped, so it didn't take long to get there.

After parking the car, I went straight to the elevator.

I had a weird feeling about this.

My conversation with Keifer earlier didn't go well, so it was no surprise I came here.

When I reached our floor, the maids greeted me, but I didn't have time to finish.

He looked at me and threw away the cigarette he was ho

He gave me his usual cold stare.

"Do me a favor," he said directly.

Even though I was confused, I waited for what he was at

"...Keep Jay-jay safe."

I frowned.

Out of nowhere, he came here to ask me that favor?

Seriously?

"Why are you saying that?"

"You love Jay-jay, don't you?" he asked, making me pau

Of course, I do!

"O-of course..."

"Then here I am, letting her go.

I'm stepping aside for you."

I shook my head slightly.

I thought he was going to say something else, but he just room.

I immediately followed him.

"Keifer."

"This is the only way," he said, stopping in his tracks.

"The only way I can save Jay-jay..."

He let out a heavy sigh.

"...is by hurting her."

He quickly left my room and walked away.

I didn't want to overthink, but why did I feel like his fam to do with this?

What have you done, Keifer?

Chapter 208: Master

Yuri's POV

My morning didn't start well. I stayed up late thinking about what he said. I know he's hiding something. It's so frustrating having a secret on his mind.

I was about to head to Ootosan's office to say goodbye. I was a bit late for school, so even though I was still sleepy, I decided I needed to pick up Jay-jay.

I stopped when I noticed a lot of maids gathered in front of the door. Even Auntie, the oldest among the servants, was there.

"Good morning, Young Master," Auntie greeted me respectfully.

"Good morning," I greeted back. "...What's going on?"

Auntie was about to answer when a familiar voice called out from the office.

"Yuri-kun, is that you?" It was Tanda.

What a way to start the morning!

I stayed in that position until the Head Master told me to and knees were already hurting.

Why now?!

I don't understand why the Head Master is here. All of a nervous for—I don't even know the exact reason. Please me back for training—it's not possible yet!

Jay-jay and I are still not married. If I return to Japan with not be able to come back to the Philippines. That would l

A very huge one!

And now, of all times, when I no longer have any rivals I've finally decided to help her move on.

"Tachiagaru." (Stand up), the Head Master said.

I stood up but kept my head bowed. I was sweating bullets.

"Anata no kami ni nani ga okotta nodesu ka?" (What happened to your hair?)

Oh shit!

I forgot about my hair. Why haven't I dyed it back yet?

"Sore wa watashi no tame ni yoku meiro. Iro no subarashi
looks fine to me. Great choice of color.) He said while co

I didn't know if I should feel relieved by what he said. It
he just laughed off one of my antics. But what if he finds
other misadventures? I might end up facing his Samurai.

"Ani." (Big brother), Tanda interjected. "Naze koko ni ir
wa daijōbudesuka?" (Is it okay to ask why you are here?

The Head Master stopped laughing and smiled at Tanda.

"Yumori... Watashi wa anata no kazoku o hōmon shitai."
want to visit your family.) He looked at me. "Watashi wa
inai." (I'm not getting younger.)

We all looked at him at the same time. I could see the coi
face. It seemed like he was hinting at stepping down from

No!

I'm next in line to become the Head Master. I'm not ready
the training starts now, he might step down early. But if I
separated from Jay-jay.

"Oji. Anata wa sore o itte imasu ka----" (Uncle. Are you

The Head Master quickly cut off Otosan. "Īe. Īe. Son'na]

their training. It was passed down early to Tanda's brother as me back then.

His son was supposed to inherit the position, but he died when I was still young. They searched the entire family but no one met the current Head Master's standards. Until a called lucky child—was chosen.

I wasn't even old enough to think for myself, but my name listed as the next Head Master. This is also why Tanda consults about my decisions. I quickly learned what I was capable

"Yuri-san... Anata wa ima sugu deru koto ga dekimasu. Anata chikoku surudeshou." (Yuri... You can leave now. You'll

I nodded and bowed, slowly stepping back. I was about to leave when the Head Master said something that made me stop.

"Raishū anata no fianse o tsurete kuru koto o wasurenaide wa kanojo ni aitai." (Don't forget to bring your fiancé next time I like to meet her.)

I'm dead!

"Hai, Heddomasutā." (Yes, Head Master.)

I had no choice but to agree. That's what he wanted, and I had no choice but to bring Jay-jay here and introduce her

When the elevator opened, I hurriedly walked toward my a rush, you'd think my wife was about to give birth. I was holding my breath.

Damn it! Damn it! Damn it!

The trip was quick because I was in such a hurry. I arrived home, but their maid was the one who greeted me.

"Has she left already?" I asked.

"Yes... Angelo isn't here, so Jay-jay was like a bird that escaped. She left in a hurry," their maid replied.

"Alright. Thank you," I said and quickly went back to my car.

I just hope she doesn't do anything reckless that might result in a Head Master. I stopped by Mini Mart just in case she wasn't.

I continued driving, but I had to slam on the brakes when I saw a group of men running across the street.

The hell! Of all times, when I'm in a hurry!

I let the men cross, but then I looked to the other side of the street and saw they were chasing a girl.

THEY WERE CHASING A GIRL!

I ignored them and kept running to catch up to Jay-jay. I was disappointed because I saw her fighting with a few men.

"Jay-jay!" I shouted after she punched one of them in the face.

She just glared at me. Her eyes shifted to behind me, so I knew. It was the men I had passed earlier. I moved closer to Jay-jay and shielded her behind me.

"Damn! You really made us run!" one of them said, catching up to me.

"Why did you even chase me?!" Jay-jay taunted.

I looked at her and signaled for her to stay quiet, but she wouldn't. I turned back to the men. They weren't familiar to me, but we hadn't fought them before.

"Gentlemen... Maybe you can leave her to me so you don't hurt yourselves out," I said calmly.

It wouldn't be good to get into a fight now that the Head was here. This will definitely reach him.

"No way! That girl's crazy! We just asked for her name, and she's our friend right away."

"You guys look like monkeys anyway!" Jay-jay shouted,

Before they could get past me, I grabbed the arm of the c earlier. He looked at me and tried to shake off my hand.

I looked at him seriously. "I'm asking nicely, but you're r

"Let go of me! I don't have time to waste on you!"

"Don't worry... I won't waste your time," I said and punc

He fell to the ground, staring at me in shock. I looked at were also surprised by what I did. I stepped closer to the suddenly charged at me.

I threw punches one after the other, hitting their faces. So back, but I dodged easily. They were clearly new to this even kicked one who managed to dodge my punch.

They all fell, and their angry expressions were replaced v

"L-let's go!" one of them shouted, and they all ran away, were clearly struggling to move.

I turned to Jay-jay, who was obviously not happy with w eyebrows were furrowed, and her arms were crossed.

"Are you alright?" I asked.

"You're such a killjoy, you know that?" she said irritably.

"Right... But— Jay!" I didn't get to finish what I was say suddenly walked away.

I followed her and jogged a bit to catch up. She still had look on her face. I had no intention of letting her fight al doesn't ask for help, I'll still help her.

I need to think of what to say to the Head Master.

I glanced at my car. It was blocking the road, and there v honking cars. I walked over and opened the passenger dc

I looked at Jay-jay and waited for her to get in. She glare seemingly debating whether to get in or not.

"We might be late... Let's go!" I urged.

She let out a deep sigh and got into the car. I quickly ran because my car was really causing a traffic jam. Good th police nearby.

During the drive, she was staring out the window, as usu to her about the Head Master.

"Jay-jay... Can we talk?"

"You're already talking," she replied boredly.

~~~~~



"Well... Somehow, somewhere, and something came up and Master is at our house," I tried to explain quickly and clearly. "He wants to meet you."

Her feisty reaction faded, but she kept staring at me. I did not want to be scared of the Head Master of the clan.

"Yuri..." she called me, and I looked at her for a moment. "Favor?"

"W-what is it?"

"Can you find my \*paki\* in what you're saying? I can't see it," I said sarcastically.

I sighed. I knew it. I could feel she had something to throw at me, though I was curious about the word "favor" she used, I didn't want to hear it.

How long are you going to be like this?

I know this is our fault, but I can't help but miss the Jay-jay. I know. This is what pain does. It changes a person.

We arrived at school. Before I could even park properly, she got out of her car, just like she always does.

It's sad. If this keeps up, I might talk to Tanda and Angel about getting off the wedding.

He's just like his best friend. Always spouting cheesy lines that are so annoying! They both deserve to be cursed.

Maybe grow a third eye or lose a nipple.

I hadn't even reached our room yet, but I already smelled something familiar. I quickened my pace because it felt like I knew

When I got to the room, they were all gathered around the makeshift kitchen was—well, *\*their\** kitchen. We don't have

"Pancake! Pancake! Pancake!" Ci-N kept chanting while I sat at the table. "Pancake! Pancake!"

"Alright! You sound like a broken record!" Eman said irritably.

I knew it smelled familiar. They were making pancakes. The smell of pancakes made me hungry. But I had no intention of joining them.

I sat down in my seat and grabbed my phone. I plugged it into the charger and turned up the volume. I just listened to music like I always did.

I kind of miss my old phone.

It had a lot of games and other stuff. There were even more apps than on my current phone. This is all because of that *\*Dimunyang Hari ng mga Uluhan\** (King of the Idiots). I even had to change my phone number because of it.



the number carefully, but it wasn't familiar.

**\*\*To: +639\*\*\*\*\***

**\*\*Message:\*\* Who is this?**

**\*\*From: +639\*\*\*\*\***

**\*\*Message:\*\* You're my everything.**

Is there even a name like "You're my everything"?

People these days can't even come up with normal names; unique, but "You're my everything"? Really?

I was about to reply when I stopped because of the plate on my face. Ci-N was smiling as he handed me a plate with

It looked fresh and hot, with melted butter and syrup spread off my earphones and faced him.

"I don't want it... You eat it," I said unenthusiastically, pushing back toward him.

"It's delicious! Remember when you made this for me?"

I remember. It was during grade posting day, and it was as if I was accused of stealing. I just shrugged at him, but of course, he kept talking about it.

I was starting to get annoyed with what he was doing. I p away again, but he just kept doing the same thing. he wa me, which only made me more irritated.

"Ci, I said I don't want it. You eat it or give it to someone calmly.

"It's for you."

"I don't want it."

"Just try it. I promise you won't regret it."

"I said I don't want it."

I was getting close to losing my patience. I was trying to but if he didn't stop, I might not be able to hold back.

Calm down, Jay, calm down.

he took the fork on the plate and cut a small piece of pan toward my mouth.

"Try it... Say ahhh," he said, holding the fork with the pa mouth.

I turned my face away, but he kept following me. I was r annoyed! My hand instinctively moved to push his hand

were mixed.

"I-it's okay... I'll just get you another one," Ci-N said, his face clearly on the verge of tears. he forced a smile even as his eyes frowned. My irritation was gone, replaced by anger.

Anger at myself because I was hurting.

"Stop this! Can't you see?! We're not going back to how we were. Give up!" I shouted angrily.

"Jay-jay," David called out, trying to stop me. I glared at him.

I heard Ci-N sob. I slowly turned to him, and it felt like a punch to the gut when I saw him wiping her tears with the back of his hand.

"W-why?" he said. "...Why should I give up?" he looked at me. "You give up when I was accused of stealing? Did you give up on Mica, on Denzel and Grace? On Drew? Did you ever give up on anyone?"

Just stop!

I bit my lower lip and looked away. I admit, this is hard for me. I want to push them away, but it hurts.

"...So don't tell me to give up! Because you never gave up on anyone. You give up on you either," he added, taking a deep breath. "...I'll get you another pancake."

# Chapter 209: Section E

## Jay-jay's POV

Percy has been quiet. He's been silent since he arrived, but we're back on the second floor again.

I've already eaten and am currently staring at his back. He's leaning his elbows on the railing. I sighed and stood up to lean my elbows on the railing too and looked at the trash below.

It would be nice to hang out here on the second floor, but it ruins the view.

"Percy..." I called him.

"Mm?" he replied.

"You've been quiet. What's up?" I tried to tease him, but he didn't work.

He just looked at me and shook his head. It felt strange! He was carrying some heavy burden.

"Hey... Percy," I called him again and nudged him slightly.

"That's harsh..." he commented.

"I couldn't control my anger," I said, almost in a whisper

We both closed our eyes as a cool breeze brushed past us refreshing up here, thanks to the trees around.

"I have a question for you," he said, and I waited for him  
"...How did you last in that Section?"

Last?

"T-the truth is..." Because they made me feel like I belong valued and protected me too. Because they went along with me I don't know."

He let out a deep sigh. I let him be because it seemed like that was his thought. We stayed quiet for the next few minutes.

I still can't get the image of Ci-N wiping his tears out of his eyes. How did I become that cold? Have I changed? Am I a bad person now? I want to go back to who I used to be?

"Percy..." I whispered, but it seemed like he didn't hear me. "Can you forgive?"

He wasn't speaking. So I had a strong feeling he didn't hear me. I admit, part of me feels like my suffering is pointless.



Is it just me, or does it feel like there's a deeper meaning  
He looked serious, so it felt like there was weight behind

"Do you have a problem?" I asked him. "...It's obvious."

He slightly bowed his head and smiled. That made me feel

"It's unfair..." he said, turning around to lean his back against the wall he was leaning his elbows on earlier. "...I told you before, right? My Mom."

I nodded, and he continued speaking.

"She left us when I was little—just like what your Dad did when we met again when I was in the hospital, it hurt even though she let them think I was dead..." He sighed and looked up at the ceiling away from here and gave me a new life, but she never could do any of it."

She made decisions without telling him.

I know that feeling. Like you don't have a mind of your own, and it's to me too, and honestly, it's really hard.

"H-how did you forgive her?"

"It just happened... One day I just woke up and realized that she was slowly fading," he answered with a smile.

They bet on me, ganged up on me, and made me believe

"...And now she's starting again," he said.

I looked at him, confused. Is that why he's like this? Is he thinking about?

"W-why?"

"She knows I've already shown myself to everyone. She shouldn't have come back." He shook his head while biting his lip.  
"...So annoying!"

I just stared at him. He was clearly upset about what his dad said. There's one thing on my mind that I really want to ask him.

"W-when is Dad coming back here?" My voice had a pleading tone.

The irritation on Percy's face faded, and he slowly began to turn to me slowly, swallowing hard.

I'm scared of what you're going to tell me.

He took a deep breath. "He's not..." He coughed slightly. "...back here."

I straightened up while keeping my eyes on him. He's not coming back here? What's this? Damn it! He's told me so many times that w

"I'm just waiting for your birthday... You'll be of legal age and I won't have control over you anymore, so you can come visit."

I swallowed and slowly shook my head at what he said. I looked away from my eyes off him, even though I blinked several times.

"I-I don't think... that's going to happen," I said, and his eyebrows furrowed. "...I'm getting married when I turn legal age."

So I can't go see Dad.

"...To Yuri," I said.

At first, I wasn't sure if he knew about the engagement, but the whole Section E knew about it, so it wasn't impossible for him to know.

He clenched his fists when I didn't answer. It seemed like he was annoyed again. I know he has a problem with Yuri, but he doesn't know what it is.

Freya was the first thing that came to mind, but it felt like I was overreacting.

"That Palito guy is something else. I feel like lighting his name on fire," I said, looking in another direction. "...He's such a coward and so sneaky. He even tricked you into agreeing to that marriage."

He's really weird when it comes to Yuri. All his anger and frustration seem to spill out whenever Yuri is brought up.

I wanted to say "YES," but I couldn't. I remembered everything I did to me and what Yuri did to me. It's more accurate to say...

"N-no."

"Then don't say he's not a coward."

"But---"

I didn't get to finish what I was saying because he suddenly pulled a chair lying near us.

"I fvcking hate him," I heard him mutter.

I let him pace around and vent his anger. He took several deep breaths. They really are like siblings—both struggle to let go of their anger.

After a while, he came back to stand beside me. He still looked angry, but it seemed like his anger hadn't gone away.

"Can I ask you something?" he asked.

I was ready to snap back with "you're already asking," but I didn't because of the look on his face—it felt like he'd put me off my answer properly.

"W-what is it?"

"Did Felix say anything about a Cane war?"

"That's another thing that's pissing me off! I heard him let someone over the phone. I tried to talk to him, but he refused anything. We argued about it, and I almost punched him, clenching his fists.

So that's it! That's why he's been acting up...

"W-what was he talking about with the person on the phone?

"I couldn't understand it. But he said they're joining that

I don't remember Section E being a gang. So I don't understand getting involved in something like that. They're just a Section that likes to pick fights, but they're not a gang.

"W-when is this Gang War supposed to happen?"

He looked at me seriously. "Later."

Right away?!

"...I'll try to stop Felix. So annoying! I was gone for a while because of my brother's turning into a troublemaker," he added.

I watched him for a moment until my phone buzzed, so I knew a message had come in.

**\*\*From: GagongBaliw\*\***

We cleaned up our mess and threw it in front of the room the front looks like a dump anyway?

I was about to head back to the room but stopped when I following me.

"What are you doing? Your way is over there," I said, po opposite direction.

"I'll stay in your room for a bit. I'm too lazy to go home,' toward our room.

I followed him and just let him do what he wanted. Whe room, everyone's eyes were on him. They looked shocke except for the "king."

"Where do you sit?" he asked, scanning the room.

"Here," I answered, pointing to my desk near the door.

He looked at it and then at Ci-N, who was sitting next to left near me was the bench behind me.

"Kid..." Percy called Ci-N. "...move. I'll sit there for now

Ci-N just stared at him. he looked at me and then back at

"No," he replied.

"No."

Here we go! Two kids arguing.

Percy was clearly getting annoyed with Ci-N. He couldn't sit in the spot behind me, but no, he had to pick Ci's spot. Good luck with that move.

"What's so special about your spot that you don't want to share it?" Ci-N asked irritably.

"I like sitting next to Jay-jay."

"I want to sit next to her too."

"Do you think she wants to sit next to you?" Ci-N taunted.

Percy turned to me, and I could see his eyebrows furrowed. The frown earlier hadn't gone away, and it seemed like it was only getting worse.

"I'm going to deal with this kid," he muttered to me, but I didn't hear because his eyebrows furrowed too.

"Just sit there," I said, pointing to the spot behind me.

"No. I want to sit here," he replied.

I sighed and shook my head. His childish side was acting up again.

"I'll flick your forehead! You've been like this the whole at Ci-N.

"I'll kick you! You've been like this the whole time!" he said, mimicking his tone.

"You've got some nerve, huh?"

"You're ugly, huh?"

Percy turned to me, pointing at Ci-N.

"The kid's picking a fight with me!" he said, sounding like a parent.

I sighed and stepped closer to Ci.

"Move for now. You can have your spot back tomorrow."

he pouted slightly and blinked. "But I want to sit next to

I looked at Percy, bored. "he really doesn't want to. There do."

"This kid's so stubborn! And he's so short," Percy muttered

Ci immediately glared at him. "This ugly guy's so annoying uncircumcised."



"I don't know about you," I said boredly and sat down in

Percy had no choice but to sit in the spot behind me. Occ  
Ci would still bicker. I wanted to scold them, but I knew  
of breath.

My phone buzzed again. Another text message from the  
GagongBaliw. The message was empty, so I ignored it, b  
he texted again.

**\*\*From: GagongBaliw\*\***

**\*\*Message:\*\*** *ILoveYou my Everything...*

Tsk! Who is this idiot!

**\*\*To: GagongBaliw\*\***

**\*\*Message:\*\*** *Idiot!*

I was smiling as I sent my reply. This guy's really persist  
himself. If I ever find out who this is, I'll make sure to bl

**\*\*From: GagongBaliw\*\***

**\*\*Message:\*\*** *I'm not an idiot, but maybe an Ulupong.*

I immediately looked at the Dimunyang Ulupongs. None  
holding a phone or doing anything suspicious

Our teacher arrived, so I put my phone away. I faced the teacher, but I was not to be interested in the lesson, but the truth was—nothing was getting through to me.

Occasionally, I'd glance at the two beside me. They just looked at each other. At one point, they even started throwing paper at each other.

"Shorty."

"Uncircumcised."

They whispered insults at each other. I couldn't get any closer to them. I was stuck between the two around. Maybe I shouldn't have let Percy come here. I was stuck with Ci-N away.

They're such a mess!

While waiting for the next class, I grabbed my phone, played a game. I stopped when I saw a text message.

**\*\*From: GagongBaliw\*\***

**\*\*Message:\*\*** *I'm your saviour. I saved you from your karma. I claimed my price on the same day.*

I frowned. What is this idiot talking about? Is he crazy? I thought the things he's saying don't make any sense.

\*\*\*T H I N K I N G\*\*\*

I suddenly felt nervous because of what this crazy guy would be Kei—NO! This isn't the King of the Ulupongs. He was on time doing something like this.

**\*\*To: GagongBaliw\*\***

*\*\*Message:\*\* The fvck! Who are you really?!*

**\*\*From: GagongBaliw\*\***

*\*\*Message:\*\* I told you. I'm your saviour. I saved you when you were blindfolded.*

Blindfolded? I only remember one time when I was blindfolded during the kidnapping where the Dimunyang King got stabbed.

**\*\*To: GagongBaliw\*\***

*\*\*Message:\*\* You're the one who kissed me?*

My hands were shaking as I typed that. It wasn't Keifer who kissed me. So who is this jerk?

**\*\*To: GagongBaliw\*\***

*\*\*Message:\*\* You got it right. 😊*

Damn it!

# Chapter 210: Gang War

## Jay-jay's POV

Going Home! The happiest time of the school day. Going home!

"I'll be the one to take Jay-jay home," Percy said serious

Yuri just nodded silently and looked at me with sad eyes him.

I noticed Percy glaring at Felix. His brother was doing the same been like this for a while now, and it seemed like their eyes engaged in a sword fight.

They looked like they were about to brawl.

"Come with us," Percy ordered.

"We have somewhere to go," Felix answered seriously.

"What if I cripple you so you can't go anywhere?" Percy brother.

"What's your problem?!"

"Take Jay-jay home. We're leaving," Felix told Percy before they left.

Soon, they were all leaving the room one by one, leaving me behind. We looked at each other.

"Are you thinking what I'm thinking?" he asked.

"No. And I don't care what you're thinking," I replied.

His eyebrows immediately furrowed.

"You're impossible to talk to, you know that?" he said sadly.

Of course! That's me!

I smirked a little, but he just scoffed at me. He started walking, and I quickly followed.

"What were you thinking?" I asked.

"I'm going to follow them. You should go home," he answered, not looking back at his pace.

I sped up to keep up with him. "What?! I'm coming with you!"

"You're so stubborn! You can't!"

"I don't care! I'm coming!"

I smiled in victory and walked ahead of him. As if he could win. Stubbornness always wins, man!

Outside the school, his car was parked. Since I was ahead of him before I could get in.

"You're so slow!" I complained as he approached.

"Wow, huh?" he said, mimicking Babalu's voice.

Haha... It suits him.

He opened the car door, letting me get in first. He followed the engine, but we didn't drive off immediately.

"Aren't we leaving yet?"

"You can walk, I'm taking the car," he said sarcastically.

I punched his arm with all my strength.

"OUCH!" he yelled. "...The fvck! What's wrong with you?"

"I'm talking to you properly, and you're just messing around."

He rolled his eyes while rubbing his arm. We waited for a moment before he finally drove off.

He was driving slowly. I was about to complain, but then...

'Parts for Sale'

'Available Tires'

I had no idea where we were, but there were a lot of signs or offering to buy them.

"What is this place?" I asked Percy.

"A garage and an impound lot. This is where they bring cars to be scrapped."

I looked around again. All I could see were mountains of shells. Percy slowed down and suddenly turned off the engine.

He fell silent as he scanned the surroundings. I wasn't used to him like this. I was used to him being playful and corny.

Maybe I should get him drunk?

"So, what are we going to do? Just stay here?"

He gave a slight nod. "Do you know how to drive?"

"N-no. Why?"

"Nothing."

This guy is so weird

*Message: Home already?*

I didn't reply. Then, I opened the next message.

**From: GagongBaliw**

*Message: I miss you.*

I grimaced when I read it. This guy again. I just deleted I my phone back in my bag.

"They're starting," Percy said.

I looked at Percy when he said that. I scanned the surrou see anyone or hear any noise.

"Huh? There's no---aaagghhh!" I screamed as a large ch suddenly fell on the hood of the car. "W-where did that c

"Damn it! My car's scratched!" Percy yelled, starting the

He sped up the car, turned somewhere, then turned off th out of the car. I did the same and went to check the scrat car's hood.

"Don't go too far!" Percy shouted, so I almost ran to catc

His steps were quick and purposeful, like he was looking positioned himself behind a pile of stacked cars. He got



but it seemed like he was the only one I could focus on.

"Shit! They're not here!" Percy said irritably.

It seemed like he was looking for Felix. It was true, they suddenly stood up and walked quickly. I followed him.

I felt like a dog following him! This is frustrating!

I almost had to run because of how fast he was walking. huge, like he was about to charge into battle.

We stopped when a masked man suddenly fell in front of me. He pulled me and hid me behind him. We both looked up at the first person I saw was Ci-N, who was still kicking his opponent.

"Jay?" David called out while holding a man by the neck.

Ci-N looked at us and immediately smiled. He delivered a knockout to his opponent before walking toward us.

"What the hell are you doing here?!" David asked irritably.

"Are you joining the fight? Or are you just going to watch me with a big grin."

I just looked at him and David, who still hadn't let go of the man's neck. Was he going to kill him?

Suddenly, I remembered the words I said to him. I felt like could he blame me? I was so tired, even though I wasn't

We squeezed through somewhere, and I noticed Eren and punching and kicking their opponents. Mayo and Josh were with them, looking like they had just finished off their own opponents.

I looked back at Percy and realized that he was already far ahead. He ran to catch up. He kept looking around.

Then, I saw Denzel and Drew. Their opponents were already down. Drew was patting down their pockets.

"They don't have any wallets! Stupid!" Drew yelled irritably at them.

We ran into Eman, who had a bleeding eyebrow. He seemed surprised to see us, but I chose to ignore him.

Calix was walking ahead of us, dragging an unconscious person. He didn't notice us and just kept doing his thing.

That felt so weird...

I'd seen them fight many times already. It was normal for them because they were guys. They always did that, and it had been their daily routine for them before.

Edrix was chaining his opponent to a post and continuous. Rory was relentlessly hitting two men with a wooden stick, begging him to stop.

Shit... Why?!

I unintentionally held onto Percy's arm without realizing he didn't mind. He continued searching for Felix. We stopped. I fell from above. I looked up to see where he had fallen from, who was on top of a pile of metal and car frames.

My grip on Percy tightened, causing him to face me.

"Are you alright?" he asked.

I swallowed before nodding at him. It was obvious he didn't care.

He held my hand and squeezed it.

"Really? Do you feel anything?"

I do... I'm scared!

It felt like everyone who entered this place turned into death.

"A-I'm just... I-I'm just scared." I lied, cringing at what I said.

I felt like slapping myself for saying that. Damn! It sounded like I couldn't tell him the real reason because I knew his reason.

But I turned back to him when I heard a loud noise. It so crashing. I could see the worry on Percy's face.

Shit! Please no...

We both ran to follow the sound, and when we reached t nothing but metal that looked like it had fallen from a gr

Percy punched the air in frustration. He still couldn't find behind us when I heard a familiar voice.

The Vipers.

It seemed like they were walking in a line.

"Percy." I called out, pointing at where they had passed.

We walked side by side, heading in the same direction as stopped when we saw Keifer.

He was still in the same spot from earlier. This time, the facing earlier was kneeling while holding his right wrist.

The guy seemed to be in pain. The idiot king flicked his man to scream loudly.

What the...

I covered my mouth. Keifer had done this in front of me

"...What else do we need?"

"Do you think this will make us stronger?! Ha?! Do you enough?!" he shouted back angrily.

I didn't understand what was happening. Could someone  
The Demon King is all over the place.

(N/A: He loves you.)

Damn! This isn't real. It's all chaos here.

"What do we do? Should we join every gang war here?"

Edrix asked irritably, and the King glared at him.

"If that's the only way, then we will." Keifer answered fi

"You're just increasing your enemies! Ask Jay-jay's cous  
more connections." Josh said angrily.

"It's not possible." Yuri answered lifelessly with his arms

"...He'll distance Jay-jay from us if it happens."

"Then that's good!" Drew yelled. "...so we can make sure

Both Yuri and Keifer glared at Drew. I was confused and  
what he said. Safe where? Why do I feel like there's som

This is Percy's fault. Look what's happening now, all the running through my head.

"Oh, why do you look like that?!" Drew asked irritably. "Of losing Jay-jay, huh?!" he asked, amazed.

"...You're doing something wrong, and now you're all like

Yuri quickly grabbed his collar. "Shut up, Drew." He said

Drew stared back at him fiercely. Even the other Vipers felt the tension and looked at us. It almost felt like the tension could erupt at any moment.

Let them just fight already!

Suddenly, Ci-N, David, and Eman turned toward us. The three at first, but it seemed like the idiots also noticed the tension toward us.

Yuri released Drew's collar and looked at me sadly. The others were puzzled, while Keifer didn't show any reaction.

"J-jay? Have you been here all this time?" Felix asked, his voice between us.

I couldn't respond because Percy was in front of me, and back was to me, I could feel the anger radiating from him.

"Is this what you taught my brother when I wasn't around angrily.

"...You taught him to join the killings?!"

Yuri and Keifer looked at each other instead of answering, turned away, like they were about to walk off. It was so I help but shout.

"Don't be rude!" I yelled at them.

Yuri turned to face me after stopping, while Keifer remained to us.

It's better that way... It's better that I don't face you.

"Jay-----."

Before Yuri could speak, Percy cut him off. "Damn it, Yu

Yuri sighed and lowered his head for a moment. Before I again, the King interrupted him.

"Your brother has his own mind. Whether we teach him him if he wants to join us." He said without looking at us

Everyone's gaze shifted to him. Even I looked at him, and for an inexplicable reason, I felt something strange.

He was wearing a black mask with sharp, spiky things—pig.

He was hunched, and his head kept moving in an eerie n directly at me, causing the spiky things to move.

Okay... He's creepy.

He held a knife in his right hand. I swallowed several tin

I tried to step back, but I saw him step forward toward m movements, and so did he.

Shit! If I look back to call Percy, who's currently arguing me. My heart is pounding from fear and nervousness.

Damn...

I couldn't move from where I stood. I couldn't help but ti terrifying. And it seemed like I was his target.

I was about to scream loudly, but it seemed like he saw t beat me to it.

He lunged at me with the knife pointed toward my body.

"P-PERCY!" I screamed and closed my eyes.

I braced for the impact of the knife, but it never came. I l



I felt someone's arm around me. I looked and saw Percy' leaned slightly on him, my knees feeling weak.

I looked back at the masked man. Instead of answering he laughed at us, which made Keifer even angrier.

He let out a grunt as Keifer tightened his hold.

"What the hell do you want?!"

"We... Want... Her... Dead." The man said, his voice breaking at me.

We? There's more than one?

"Who?! Who wants her dead?!" Keifer asked angrily.

Instead of answering, the man just laughed again. What the hell is crazy? Damn it! I should never have come here.

Keifer seemed to have had enough. He twisted the man's head and hear the bones snap. The man screamed loudly in response.

But what really made me fearful was when he said, "We want you dead. Who are they? Why do they want me dead?"

A deep sigh escaped me. I think I know the answer now.

I looked at Keifer angrily. He released the man, who was

We all looked at the laughing man. He was holding his v  
maniacally.

"Sato, Jason, and Ram." He looked at Keifer, Yuri, and n  
What the hell!

I pointed the blame at him, but it turns out I have some r  
But it's still his fault!

Damn it! This isn't a normal life anymore, and now I'm c  
dying.

"Who's Sato?!" Keifer asked irritably.

"Keifer." Yuri called his name.

He was emotionless, looking down. We were all confuse  
he spoke, everything became clear.

"I fought him before." He said. "...And it looks like he's c  
now."

And now it's me again... Damn it all!

This is such a mess! Why the hell did I even come here?

"Go back..." Keifer said, looking at the masked man. "...  
Jason, and Ram. Tell them I'm coming for them, and I'll

I stared at him, confused. He too was holding back his at Felix, who seemed puzzled by what he said.

"You all need to come back with me to New York."

# Chapter 211: Birthday gift

## Jay-jay's POV

I suddenly found myself staring at the world map. The Philippines was just a tiny dot, while New York looked like a patch. It was so far on the other side of the world! Where could Papa be over there? How long would we stay in New York? What about my siblings? Lola? What about the people I'd leave behind here? What about coming back? What if... What if... What if... What if... I had so many questions.

I crumpled the map without thinking. I couldn't understand this new feeling. It was like I was excited but also scared. A mix of emotions I'd never felt before. It felt like there were butterflies in my stomach. I couldn't stop thinking about it. A part of me was telling me to go. Of course! I'd finally get to see Papa. But another part of me was saying I couldn't go. Ugh! This is so confusing.

Another thing on my mind was Kuya Angelo. I knew he would go. Neither would Tita Gema or Mama. But what Percy said...

"I'll sneak you out if they don't let you. Just come with me."

Sneak out? Oh my... Who knows where we'd end up? It's like eloping. I don't think I can handle that.

~~~~~

I can punch him in the face.

I almost crushed my phone screen as I typed a message that keeps texting me. My reply to him was sweet.

****To: GagongBaliw****

****Message:**** **Look at it!**

See? My reply was so sweet!

Let's see if his nose doesn't flare up in anger. Anyone who was cursed at in a text for no reason. Then my phone rang, smiling as I read his message.

****From: GagongBaliw****

****Message:**** **ILoveYouToo!**

My jaw dropped as I blinked in disbelief. I wanted to smash my head against the wall out of frustration—but it's brand new, so I can't.

I really, really want to meet this animal. Just once. I'll let you know the sweetness of my fist.

An idea popped into my head. I just didn't know if it would work.

****To: GagongBaliw****

Son of a b*tch, this pervert. All I can say to him is a deep
PUTANG'NA MO! This guy's a creep. If I ever find out who he is, I'll go Super Saiyan 4. I really want to punch his face. I'm so
me even angrier when I think that I might know who this

Is it Keifer?

Impossible! He wouldn't stoop to something like this. And he
even text me like this—if it's even him. Is he messing with me?
Well, he sure has a weird idea of fun.

"I'm just playing around."

Sh*t! Something in my heart twisted when I remembered
was looking straight at me when he said that. So everything
was just a game to him.

So annoying!

I slammed my phone on the study table. Some of my things fell off
stack of papers. They shifted slightly, and an invitation appeared.

I slowly picked it up, and my heart almost broke when I read
N's invitation. I sat down on the bed.

Ci-N's birthday...

I remembered him crying in front of me. The words he said...

I gripped the invitation tightly. I'm so annoyed! I'm annoyed because I let myself be fooled! I'm annoyed because I'm ruined by their lies! I'm annoyed because they hurt me! I'm annoyed because even though they hurt me, there's a part of me that still loves them. A part of me that wants to reach out and accept their apology.

But it's not possible anymore.... We're not the same as before.

"S-sorry Ci-N... Things can't go back to the way they were."

I let go of the invitation and quickly went to the bathroom. For the last time, even if it can never happen again. I wanted to smile like he had no problems, like he was the happiest person I knew. I wanted to smile like his smile could make you smile too. For the last time.

After showering, I got dressed. I brought my wallet and my keys. In the room, I immediately saw Kuya Angelo. I was about to tell him I was leaving, but he turned his back on me. It seemed he was ignoring me. I decided to just let Tita Gema know instead. It looked like she was around since I hadn't seen her since this morning.

Before leaving the gate, I checked my surroundings first to make sure someone might be following me again, trying to harm me. I had gotten over the whole "we want her dead" thing. I had no more fear. What if they were pretending to be beggars just to get close to me?

"Ate, can you spare some change?"

I squinted at him, scrutinizing his entire body. His legs were covered in cuts and wounds. He smelled terrible, like he hadn't bathed in days.

"Are you sure no one sent you here? No one paid you to do this?" I asked.

He shook his head vigorously, looking like he was about to cry. His eyes were already welling up. I lowered my hand but kept it close to my face.

"C-can I go now?" he asked, slowly stepping back.

"Wait!" I shouted, and he looked like he was about to run.

He was in such a hurry!

I reached into my wallet and pulled out some coins. I handed them to him, and he looked at me curiously.

"I thought you were begging? Here you go!"

He slowly raised his hand to take the coins. When he saw them, he raised an eyebrow.

"This is it?" he asked, sounding annoyed.

Wow... He's complaining about 10 pesos.

"What?! You don't want it? Give it back..." I said, reaching out, but he pulled his hand away. "You don't seem to want it!"

I couldn't believe this kid.

Frowning, I took out my wallet again and pulled out 100 to him.

"Here! Stick it in your lungs!" I said irritably, but he just Leave! Go home and take a bath. My perfume's embarrassing smell."

He sniffed himself. "I don't smell."

"What do you mean you don't smell? I can smell you from here! You don't want to land on you."

"That's just you, Ate... Remember, the nose is close to the mouth."

Wow... Just wow...

"What if I combine your nose and mouth? Want that? Heh."

He stepped back, laughing. I was really getting into it with my punch to the head, and I'd be satisfied.

"Go home already! Stop messing around!"

He held up the money I gave him, walking backward with a smile.

"I'll buy rice with this! Thanks, Ate!"

While browsing the department store, I saw someone far
Rakki...

I was about to take a different route, but it seemed she had
She walked over to me with a smile, holding a paper bag

"Hi, Jay!" she greeted me cheerfully.

"Hello..." I replied half-heartedly.

She seemed to sense that I wasn't in the mood to talk to her
slightly. I wasn't mad at her or anything. I just didn't feel
anyone.

"Are you also looking for a gift for Ci-N?" she asked awkwardly.

I nodded. "You too?"

"Yeah."

We fell silent after that. I glanced around, and so did she
send her away or leave because that would've been rude.
didn't want to...

"D-do you want to look together?" I offered.

She immediately smiled and nodded. There went my plan.
How was I supposed to think of a gift with someone as close
to

I placed a hand on my stomach and looked at him. "Sure
"I'll take care of it. My treat," she said, holding my hand
There it is! I stumbled upon another free meal...

Rakki took me to a restaurant. The waiter greeted us with
showed us to our table. I felt awkward as I watched Rakki

It was only now that I realized Rakki was rich. I'd always
looked like an angel, but I assumed she was just like me—
not wealthy.

"I'll order. Do you want to add anything?" she asked, sneaking
my thoughts.

I slowly shook my head. "N-no, that's enough. Thank you."

She spoke to the waiter again, and I watched her. My eyes
diamond ring on her finger.

This girl's loaded!

"Is it nice?" she asked, and I looked up at her. "It's a gift."

I have one too... From Yuri.

I just smiled and nodded. She's lucky to have a sibling like
I'm just lucky I have two siblings — one who's a bit crazy

I was right... she knows.

"Y-you don't have to apologize for him."

She took a deep breath and looked at me. She reached out her hand, which was resting on the table.

"You're important to Ci-N," she said, squeezing my hand. "He brags about you to me."

Sh*t!

I bit my lower lip. "You don't have to do this."

She let go of my hand, and we both looked at the waiter approaching with our food.

We ate in silence. I really didn't understand why she felt the need to apologize. Why she was apologizing for Ci-N.

As we continued eating, a family nearby burst into laughter and clapping, so I looked over. A little boy was dancing in front of them, smiling widely. His parents were cheering him on.

"Ci-N has never experienced that," Rakki said. "...being part of a family for what he wants."

I know... He told me before.

Ouch... What's so special about that? Just order some rice at the corner stall.

I frowned slightly. She still wouldn't say it. With all the secrets she took from her, I would've thought they were a couple.

"But do you like him?" I asked, and her cheeks immediately blushed.

"Y-yeah..."

"Perfect! That guy is head over heels for you. What are you waiting for?"

She cringed at what I said. "Jay-jay, come on! You've seen me. I'm just a fourteen-year-old body, four-year-old mind."

She had a point.

"...And besides, I don't want to have a boyfriend at fourteen. It's too complicated. Maybe if Ci turns eighteen and we still feel the same about each other... I might even make the first move."

I felt embarrassed. At fourteen, I was already accepting secrets from her. We used to walk to school together, and I was all giddy about the first time having a boyfriend.

Turns out, he was gay.

That's when I realized relationships shouldn't be taken too seriously.

I almost threw my utensils at Rakki. Good thing I caught it.
Relax! Relax!

"That's why I'm so mad at those brutes! They taught Ci-N that his older brother is furious. And he won't even focus on his studies, though it should be easy for him." She continued.

Honestly, Ci-N doesn't seem like the smart type. He's always been like that. That's why I was so confident in betting against him before I learned the saying,

Don't judge a book by its cover.

Here I am, seventeen years old, losing to a fourteen-year-old who has an IQ as high as Albert Einstein.

"But do you know what changed in him when he met you? It shook my head. "...He became more cheerful. He's even more confident, but in a fun way. He doesn't dwell on how his family never loved him anymore." She smiled at me. "...Because you're there. He has a sister, the one who made him feel what family truly means."

I suddenly felt tears falling. I couldn't stop them. It was like a part of me inside me was smiling at his words.

I never knew I had that kind of impact on him.

If only you knew, Ci-N. You changed my life too.

After paying for the meal, we headed straight to the gift store where we needed. Then, we went to the toy store.

"Let's do this at my house," Rakki suggested, and I nodded.

We were waiting for a taxi outside the mall when I noticed. Across the street, directly in front of us, a motorcycle was parked. It seemed like the driver was looking at us.

I was reminded of the motorcyclists who followed me before. They challenged me to a race. Can someone check on my bike for me? It's a nuisance!

"Do you know him?" Rakki asked, noticing my stare. ".. him."

I shook my head and smiled. "It just felt like the driver was looking at me so I was observing him."

She didn't ask any more questions when the taxi arrived. Rakki gave the driver her address. But during the ride, I glanced behind us.

It felt weird, like someone was following us.

Next time, I'll definitely borrow David's high-class instructor.

For now, I need to focus on my gift for Ci-N. I just hope

Chapter 212: Motorbike

Jay-jay's POV

I suddenly found myself staring at Rakki's family picture.

There were five siblings in total. All of them were boys—
who was the only girl and the middle child.

But what I couldn't understand was...

Why was Ci-N in their family picture?

"Rakki..." I called out to her as she was tidying up our m
N here?"

She chuckled slightly before coming closer to look at the

"He said he was going to be part of our family. Then he i
the picture," she explained while laughing.

I couldn't help but laugh too. His confidence in ending u
unshakable. I just shook my head at his persistence.

"Snack time."

She placed the tray of food on the coffee table and observed my smile. She looked kind of weird, but in an amusing way.

"Come on, eat," she invited me while giggling.

Rakki sat down again, so I did the same. She then looked beside me.

"What's that?"

A bomb!

I glanced at it briefly before picking it up to show her. "I asked Rakki to help me wrap it and decorate it."

She read the card aloud. "Happy... Birthday... Ci-N!"

She smiled after reading Ci-N's name. "You know Ci-N?"

"He's my classmate."

She suddenly squealed in excitement, which I didn't understand. She returned the jar to me and clapped like a little kid.

"He's my future son-in-law! He and Rak—"

"MA!" Rakki cut her off.

"What? It's true. Ci-N is so cute! If you two have kids..."

Hearing that made me smile.

Rakki could only slap her forehead. Her mom was so perfectly adorable. She was clearly pro-Ci-N and wouldn't approve of anyone else.

"Ma, come on! Ci-N is still young!" Rakki argued.

"Then wait for him! Just make sure it's only Ci-N, okay?"

I enjoyed watching them. It was obvious how close they were. It suddenly made me think of my own mom—if she had been here, would we have been this close too?

You'd probably just be cursing at each other out of love.

"What if he likes someone else? I'd just be wasting my time with him."

Her mom immediately frowned. "That's impossible! Ci-N loves me."

He has a crush.

Suddenly, Rakki and her mom turned to look at me, their faces in shock.

It seemed like I had said that out loud. I forced a smile, but it came out more like a grimace.

Her mom immediately beamed and playfully poked her nose.

"See? He still likes you! So wait for him, okay? No boyfriend else!"

The sadness on Rakki's face disappeared, replaced by an smile. They continued teasing and joking around. I had already said goodbye but they were still at it.

My phone suddenly rang. I checked and saw a message from Jay asking what time I'd be home.

I didn't really want to leave yet, but it seemed like they were worried. I decided to say goodbye to Rakki's mom and to Jay.

"Thank you for the snack," I said.

"You're welcome. Come back again, okay? Bring Ci-N with you with a smile."

Wow! She's really rooting for them.

Rakki pouted but quickly smiled when she saw me looking at her.

"Take care, Jay! Text me, okay?" She said while waving.

I waved back and started walking away. I left my gift with Jay. I planned to go to Ci-N's birthday party together.

It was so bright that I couldn't see anything. I raised my hand to shield my eyes with a shadow. The loud roar of a motorcycle made me freeze.

I frowned, staring at the source of the light.

The brightness disappeared, revealing the silhouette of a motorcycle.

Judging by his build, he looked like a big guy.

I swallowed hard as he got off the motorcycle and removed his helmet.

He walked toward me slowly, stepping into the glow of the light.

He was wearing a leather jacket.

I was right—he was tall and well-built, and... and... and..

He was incredibly handsome!

Ridiculously handsome!

"Jay-jay Mariano?" he asked, looking straight at me.

I couldn't bring myself to answer.

Not because I was starstruck by his good looks.

Is this it? Is my time up? Am I about to die?

Are they going to kill me? Or will they play with me first and then kill me off?

Can they just kill me right away?

"I'm not going to do anything bad to you if that's what you want to talk," he said, smiling.

Don't fall for that smile! It's got

fake

written all over it.

"I-I don't talk to strangers," I stammered.

"But I'm no longer a stranger. I just introduced myself."

Well, he's got a point!

He's Jason, Ram's brother—the same Ram who once kidnapped me.

I also managed to hurt him and crush his face without realizing it.

He's Jason—one of the three people who want me dead.

HE'S JASON!—

I feel like he didn't get the reference.

Come on, that's a horror classic! A total package! Compl

Super Piritong Galunggong!

(Fried Fish Extra Crispy!)

I'm so innocent.

"Look, I'm really not here to harm you. I assure you, it's take action without the group's approval," he explained. need to talk."

"About what?"

"About Keifer."

MOTHERFU—!

"Sorry, the number you have dialed is the

wrung

number. Please do not call again," I said, making his bro even more.

"...Because Jason, I've already faced too many brainless that damn King. Don't add yourself to the list. Go back to

It's not even

Friday the 13th

yet.

Maybe there were no victims at the lake, so he switched motorcycle instead.

"I know what happened between you and Keifer," he said freeze.

News sure spreads fast. Those Alphabet guys are really s

They must be the ones who spread the word about the K messing with me.

"...So if you're thinking that I'm going to use you against added.

I really didn't want to trust him.

But I had no chance against him if he decided to grab me

"What if I don't go with you?"

"Then I will force you," he answered immediately.

I'm doomed

"You're the one who raced me before! And earlier at the angrily, pointing at him.

He smirked mischievously. "Now you know."

This bastard...

"You psycho! What's your problem?! Why did you race bike!"

He just laughed and suddenly held out his hand in front of

"Before I forget. Give me your phone," he ordered.

"What if I don't?"

He scratched his head and let out a deep sigh. "Look, I know you're not calling for backup. Just hand it over. If I have my hands won't just be touching your phone... but also y

He winked, sending shivers down my spine.

The bastard's a pervert too.

"Here! Stop talking," I snapped, shoving my phone into his

He turned it off and stuffed it inside his jacket. Then, he resting on his seat and put it on my head.

"You idiot!" I shouted at him, and he laughed loudly.

I tightened my grip on his arm as he suddenly sped up. V more was how he leaned so close to the ground that it felt almost scraping the road. Where were we going? I had no regretting why I even agreed to come along.

The sky was already dark, and I was sure Tita Gema was I even texted her that I was on my way home. I just hope take too long.

I looked around and was slightly startled to realize we were on a highway. I started to feel nervous, getting a gut feeling that he had something planned for me. Until we stopped in front of a place that serves go-to, a Filipino rice porridge)?!

I got off and immediately took off my helmet. I was still looking at the sign on the tarpaulin.

*'Superb Gotohan!'

Son of a... I wanted to say I was disappointed, but at least I felt a bit of relief. I really thought this traitor had something bad planned for me.

He took the helmet from my hand. "Come on... I'll order for you."

I sat down like an idiot in an empty spot at the far end of the table. He pointed to this area, so I sat here while he went to order for me.

He took a deep breath, rested his arms on the table, and I moved closer to me.

"We want revenge, and I know you want it too," he said.

I smiled slightly and shook my head. "No."

His eyebrows almost met in confusion. "What do you mean?"

"No, I don't want revenge," I clarified. "...if that's what you want, you could've done it a long time ago, but I didn't."

"But why?!"

"It's simple. Revenge is for the weak. And I'm not as weak as you. I did the same thing he did."

He smiled and studied my face intently, as if trying to figure me out. I was starting to feel uncomfortable, but thankfully, our order arrived.

We ate first, and for some reason I couldn't understand, the tension around him started to fade. He was actually decent to be around. After eating, we took a break before continuing our conversation.

"How did you even meet Keifer? Was it because of Ramon?"

"If you think about it, he should be mad at me for what happened. I was the one who hurt him, yet they're still after Keifer."

"I already know that," I said. "...he's like the leader of all

He smiled and took another calamansi, arranging it next he made.

"And then... This is the rival gang. If you mess with one, of them," he said. "...The one leading them is----."

"You," I cut him off.

He laughed and shook his head. "No. Ryosuke Sato is the Japanese and half-Filipino."

Half-idiot and half-crazy?!

Sato?! Wait! That's the guy who's Yuri's enemy and also Son of a...! Okay, that part's clear to me now.

I looked at Jason. "What about you? Where do you stand

He smiled and took a yellow calamansi. He took two of them between the pyramids of calamansi.

"Like Keifer... We're often called 'in-between.' We don't just don't start our own like others, and we don't care about the gangs."

I didn't say anything and just waited for him to continue.

join the gang war if he didn't want to be part of any group is really confusing.

"What about Ryosuke—Riyokwunan—the regular at the annoying, his name is hard to say. "...Why is he after me enemy?"

He looked at me curiously. "Isn't Yuri courting you?"

We're engaged, bro!

"N-no."

He shrugged. "Ryosuke probably thinks he's courting you."

He really emphasized the name Ryosuke.

I frowned. "No! Clarify that to Riyo—I mean, Sato! Make him leave me alone!"

"I'll try."

I glared at him. "You! Why do you want me dead?!"

"Dead—what?!"

"Dead. To die."

He laughed and shook his head slightly. He looked at me

I wanted to ask about Ram's plans, but it didn't seem nec
Jason slowly returned the calamansi to where he got ther

"You know... I've been thinking why Keifer never fell fo
stopping me in my tracks.

If only you knew, I've been thinking the same thing.

"You're not super beautiful, yet somehow you have some
captures our interest."

I frowned. What was he trying to say? Don't tell me he h
or I'll punch him really hard.

"...Or maybe I'm wrong. Maybe Keifer has already faller
doesn't want to drag you into his mess..."

This guy's gone crazy. The goto must've messed with his

"...we'll never know. Unless..."

I felt a surge of fear when his expression suddenly chang
say anything, he suddenly choked me. He knocked over
things fell to the floor.

Packing shit! I knew it!

"Hey! What are you doing?!" shouted the female vendor
,

Obviously... What a stupid question!

He smiled and suddenly let go. I fell to the floor along with sitting on earlier. I tried to crawl away.

Jason forcefully pushed the table between us aside. He was while laughing.

"He's taking too long to come in. I'm getting impatient," closer to me. "...Looks like he really doesn't care about you

He really doesn't, so leave me alone!

He helped me stand, and even though it was hard, I forced upright. I was still catching my breath as I looked at him

"I thought he'd save you even if he was just nearby."

So annoying!

This guy really is an idiot. Crazy, just like his brother was not close to. I mustered all the strength I had left. I kicked to stumble away from me.

I almost fell. I was still breathing heavily as I watched him he could say anything, I forced myself to walk away.

But I guess I'm just unlucky. I was sure I wasn't mistaken

"But what I really want to see is what Keifer will do when I'm crippled," he said, kicking the chair in front of him towards me.

"Aaagghhhh!!" I screamed as I ducked.

I heard it hit the wall near me. I glared at him. He was still looking at me. He picked up another chair and threw it at me.

I quickly jumped in another direction. I might as well be running. I looked at the exit, but his fellow traitor was blocking the way.

"Why are you avoiding me? Don't you want to face me?"

I was practically crawling away from him. I looked at my phone for something.

My cellphone!

I grabbed it and tried to turn it on, but I stopped when I saw him in front of me. I quickly stood up and tried to run, but his hand blocked me.

They were like perverts laughing at me. That's when I noticed the customers and the vendor were gone. No wonder no one was here. No police or trying to stop us.

I kept moving around to make sure no one could get close to me.

Honestly, I was still weak. I didn't know if I could even f
the way Jason looked, I didn't think I could take him on.

If Keifer was outside, I just hoped he'd care about me, ev

Chapter 213: King

Jay-jay's POV

My fist is trembling. I've already taken down five of them, yet the others still won't stop. Some of them are getting back to retaliate.

"Surrender now," Jason taunted.

"Screw you!"

It's not like surrendering would save me—no one's coming. No one cares. I pressed my hand against my burning cheek from a punch earlier.

Damn it! I feel so weak.

I raised my arms again, bracing for whatever blow was coming. A fist or a foot. It didn't take long before another punch was

It hit my arm, nearly knocking me down, but I managed to stay on my feet. I retaliated with a punch to the stomach, making him double over before collapsing.

"Jason! This girl is tough!" one of them complained.

I fought back with kicks and punches, but they only used
land clean hits on me. My stomach and arms took blow after

Why am I letting them do this to me?

Is it because of what Jason said?

Am I affected by the fact that he really doesn't care about

That I'm just a toy for the King of the Venomous Serpent?

I lost my focus. Someone kicked my leg, sending me crashing
ground. They started kicking me like I was some kind of

"Guess she wasn't that tough after all," Jason sneered.

Then, suddenly, they all stopped and backed away.

My eyes were brimming with tears that refused to fall.

Crap! They're going to turn into eye gunk...

"He finally showed up," one of them muttered.

I lifted my gaze, and our eyes met. There was no emotion
stood at the entrance, and I couldn't see anyone behind him.

He came alone?

Nothing could be worse than what I went through because of this bastard.

"Oh no... Looks like we went too far," Jason said with a smirk. "It took too long, so we decided to have some fun with her."

Keifer glanced at each of Jason's men.

"What happened to you?" he asked me, sounding bored. "You couldn't beat them?"

Wow.

So he really expected me to win. That's why he didn't step in even though he was just outside. Unbelievable!

I just rolled my eyes at him, refusing to explain. But honestly, the real reason I lost.

"Your girlfriend couldn't handle us," one of them said.

"He's not my boyfriend."

"She's not my girlfriend."

We spoke at the same time, immediately exchanging glances.

You piece of crap! I swear, I'd rip out his eyeballs and turn them into balls if I could.

"Shut the fvck up, Jason," the King of the Venomous Ser

Jason just laughed loudly. He pushed himself off the wall jacket, acting like some wannabe bad boy. Just like the King of the Venomous Serpents.

"What do you want?" the King asked.

Jason's smirk vanished, and his brows slowly furrowed.

"I want you dead, Keifer."

Without warning, he hurled a chair at Keifer and lunged for a punch. But it was pointless—Keifer dodged the chair effortlessly and blocked the punch with one hand.

That's when I realized Jason was bigger than Keifer.

But somehow, Keifer made fighting this Friday the 13th

Oh no, Keifer's doomed. Maybe Jason's some kind of de

Keifer countered with a kick, sending Jason flying back

Jason's men started moving, but he held up a hand, signaling back.

He stood up again, his face burning with anger.

I turned toward Jason's men and saw them grabbing something from the shop—looked like the kitchen.

Knives!!

"Keifer! They have knives!" I shouted.

Jason backed away as one of his men lunged forward, but he was about to stab Keifer, but only managed to graze him. Jason immediately retaliated with a punch to the jaw, knocking the man unconscious.

But then Jason kicked Keifer, sending him flying like a rag doll. It happened so fast. It was clear that Keifer was struggling with what Jason had done to him.

I glanced at Jason's remaining men. They seemed to be silent, not communicating, and some of them were moving toward me.

Damn it! My body hasn't even recovered yet, guys!

One of them was about to grab me, but I struck first, landing a knee straight to his face. He collapsed instantly, blood dripping from his nose.

"You're really stubborn, aren't you?!" one of them growled at me from the side.

Before his foot could connect, I grabbed his leg and knee.

I was about to counterattack from below, but my fist landed on his crotch.
His

you-know-what

... That

place

!

Ughhh! Gross! My fist touched his crotch! Disgusting!

Out of sheer disgust, I swung my fist into the face of the man in front of me.
My punch connected with his jaw—knockout.

Now there was only one left. He glared at me, acting like he was going to charge, so I stepped back. But he just got into a stance in front of me.

This bastard!

I faked a move as if I was about to lunge, and the guy flipped backward into a table, knocking it over along with himself.

Coward! Damn it! This guy is just messing with me!

I turned to check on Keifer. All of Jason's men were already down. Only two of them were still standing.

I looked at Keifer, and for a split second, I wanted to beg. But my heart clenched—what was left of it—when he shifted to Jason.

"Can you do it?" Keifer asked.

No one knew who he was talking to. I frowned as he said

"Can you do it?" he repeated.

I glanced at the guy holding me hostage, but he looked just as confused. Even Jason was darting his eyes between us.

"Can you do it?"

Is this guy a broken record? He just keeps repeating himself.

Then, it finally clicked.

He was talking to

me

.

How? I wasn't sure, but I had a gut feeling. That, and the way my hand gripping the guy's arm.

I turned back to Keifer. He must've realized that I understood.

"THREE!" we both yelled.

I grabbed his knife-wielding hand with one of mine and the other. He let go of me, and I seized the opportunity to throw my knife into his face.

At the same time, Keifer leaped into the air, spun, and kicked into the face.

Both Jason and the guy who held me hostage crashed to the ground simultaneously.

A moment of silence... for our sheer badassery.

Both of us were panting. I scanned the area to see if anyone would get up and attack us. Keifer did the same. Our eyes met, and for an inexplicable reason...

We laughed.

We laughed as if what had just happened was funny.

We laughed like we were the best of friends.

We had lost it. Both of us had completely lost it.

But our laughter died when reality slapped us in the face.

The reality that someone wanted us dead.

I pulled away and tried to push him off, but he didn't bud.
No hugging! None of this! We're supposed to be mad at
"H-Hey... W-Why are you hugging me?" I asked, flustered.
His grip tightened.

"You're the one who wanted this... I'm just indulging you."
What?!

I wanted this? And now he's hugging me even tighter?!
nonsense is this?!

"Y-You can let go now," I stammered.

"Are you sure? You seem to want more."

Am I the one who wants this?!

"I'm sure... L-Let go now," I insisted, still trying to push

"I can feel it... You still want more."

Oh, come on, man!

You really passed this on to me! It's obvious he wants it
nothing to say about how sneaky this guy is.

The sound of his heartbeat is so comforting. It feels like mine. Maybe he's right, maybe I do want his embrace.

"I know... you really want it," he whispered to me.

Even though I couldn't see his face, I could feel it—he was saying that to me. Honestly, I was confused. Here he goes and I feel like there's something when in reality, there's nothing.

So, even though I wanted to stay in his arms longer, I did what was right.

"Let go. I'm asking you," I said seriously.

It looked like he understood that I wasn't joking anymore, so he loosened his grip, and I took the chance to push him away.

Tears were welling up in my eyes from the pain I was feeling in my body—but inside me. I really hate crying. I feel so weak no matter how many fights, punches, or hair-pulling I go through.

But this guy... just his presence alone, and my tears are a fall—like they're afraid of becoming eye crusts.

He didn't say a word, but I knew he wanted to ask something.

Me too... I really wanted to ask him something. Because I was exhausted from wondering if there's really something between us.

"It's late... I'll take you home," he said and was about to leave when he quickly pulled away.

"Leave if you want, but I'm not going with you."

"Jay... don't be so stubborn."

"Answer my question first!" I shouted at him. "...Why are you suffering like this?! Haven't you done enough for me?! Here you are making me feel like we have something when we actually don't."

He took a deep breath, and I stood there like a fool, waiting for a response. But all he did was stare at me.

"Answer me, Keifer. Do you really feel something for me?"

A tear fell from my eye.

This is so frustrating. I feel like I'm begging him...

I bit my lower lip as he looked down. Any moment now, he would speak like a kid.

"I heard you... You and Yuri," my voice trembled.

"...the conversation you had..." I took a deep breath. "...I know that what Yuri said was true, that you were lying. That you don't have the same feelings for me. But I want to hear it from you."

This pain you're causing me... I can't take it anymore.

I can't stay here with him any longer. And I definitely do with him. Even though my vision was blurry with tears, phone. I saw it lying on the floor near where I had fallen

With shaky hands, I unlocked it and tried to find Percy's couldn't see properly, so I just pressed on a random conta

It rang several times before someone answered.

["Oh?"] the person on the other end said.

Instead of speaking, I just burst into tears again. No words mouth.

["Where are you? I'll come get you,"] he said calmly.

In hell, with the King of Demons.

I took a few deep breaths, trying to calm myself down.

"A-at the highway... The one near 'S-Superb Gotohan,'" I between sobs.

["I'm on my way,"] he answered before ending the call.

I hugged my knees like a child. I didn't know how to calm but so much more than any physical pain I had ever f

I will find a way to erase these feelings for you! Even if I wrestle Hulk, swallow ten pieces of kryptonite, scream "I'm the Hulk" during a staring contest with Cyclops until the Statue of Liberty melts, as long as I can get rid of this stupid feeling for you, you better believe I will.

A loud honk snapped me out of my deep thoughts.

I turned to the approaching car and—Aries?!

Oh, shit!!

I looked back at Keifer. He had no expression on his face, just stared at the car door and stared at me.

I immediately ran towards Aries' car and got in. I let Aries burn into me. I stole one last glance at the Demon King before he drove away.

"What happened?" he asked me calmly.

I bit my lower lip. I knew I would cry again if I started to shake my head and looked out the window.

"I already told you to stay away from Keifer. You're so stupid," he scolded me.

I wish I had just listened to them.

~~~~~

"Jay! Where have you been?! I was so worried," she said before looking at my whole body. "...Why do you look li

"I-I just got into a fight, A-auntie," I said, forcing a smile

"What?! Oh my—" She turned to Aries. "...Did you repo police?"

Aries shook his head. "She was with Keifer."

Tita Gema called one of their maids and asked for somet  
Then, she turned back to me.

"Come on, let's go to your room... We need to clean you  
placing an arm around me.

I lowered my head and let her guide me. It felt like all th  
drained away. I was starting to feel like this again.

I felt like I was slowly dying.

# Chapter 214: Heypi Birthd

## Jay-jay's POV

Happy Damn Day!

Can you believe it's Valentine's Day today? I touched my check if I even had a heart—I might not know otherwise

I glanced at my phone when it rang. At first, I expected i rushed a little, but turns out it was just that CrazyBastard

**From: CrazyBastard**

*Message: Happy Heart Day! Love me! (3)*

I grimaced. This idiot has some nerve. Just a little more, changing my number. I took my time thinking about my

**To: CrazyBastard**

*Message: F\* you!\*\**

I ended up laughing since it seemed like he wouldn't rep on my shoes and tied the laces. Then, I stood up and face

Section E students around, probably to clear out the "trash"

Our school is just so kind to us.

My phone rang again. This time, it was from the person I

**From: Rakki**

*Message: Ready? Where do we meet?*

She has the gift I got for Ci-N. Honestly, I'm still debating whether to forgive him or not. I know clearly that Ci only did what he wanted.

But still, it hurts...

I typed a reply to Rakki, telling her to meet me on the ground floor of N's condo unit. We could just wait for each other there.

I shoved my phone and wallet into my pockets before stepping into my room. I paused in front of my brother Angelo's door, hesitating whether to knock or not?

Deep breath...

In the end, I knocked and waited for his response.

"Come in," he said.



That was cold... I felt chills.

I lowered my head, fidgeting with my fingers. "C-can yo

He turned his chair back, facing away from me. "I have a  
Aries to take you instead. Tell him it's my order."

That felt like a stab—ten times over. His attitude toward  
cold. It feels like this is my fault.

"O-okay. Sorry for bothering you," I said and walked ou

My shoulders slumped as I bit my lip. Were my words to  
hurtful? I didn't know it would affect him this much.

"Jay-Jay! Where are you going?" my mom asked.

"To a birthday party," I answered lifelessly.

"What time will you be home? Don't stay out too late."

"Okay," I replied and walked out of the house.

I knew she would scold me again. She did the last time v  
I got into a fight at the gotohan (porridge shop). Instead o  
just stayed silent.

Just like the other day, I checked my surroundings first to  
waiting to embrace me. I still wasn't fully healed from m

Did he hear us?

"B-because..."

"Just get in. Kuya will get mad if I don't take you."

I was confused by his behavior. Was he possessed by some creature? Or maybe an angel? He's acting so weird. May his meds.

He opened his car door and was about to get in but stopped wasn't moving.

"What? Are you just gonna stand there looking dumb?" I

I panicked a little before quickly getting into the car. He didn't even glance at me while driving.

Oh no! Aries the Horoscope might be going crazy!

"Where exactly are you going?"

I blinked, processing his words. He was asking a normal question, no annoyance. Just normal. Normal. Normal...

Oh, he's sick! He must have a fever!

I leaned closer and placed my hand on his forehead. He immediately

Oh, he's yelling at me now. He's back to normal.

"Okay... You're not sick anymore," I mumbled, but it seemed he heard me.

"What's your problem?!"

"Nothing... Just take me to Ci-N's condo," I said, pointing in the building in sight.

He let out a deep sigh. I didn't say anything else. He was silent again—no need to overthink it.

He's normal to me when his craziness shows.

We arrived at the front of the building I pointed to. I stood at the entrance, holding our gifts.

"Hey!" Aries called out irritably. "...Don't ever call me crazy."

"W-why?"

Was he...worried?

"Your voice is so high-pitched! It hurts my ears! I felt like my ears just fell out!" he grumbled.

You bastard...

I picked up my gift, which was resting on the ground. She hers.

"Maybe he's sick?" She asked.

I laughed. "He was. But he got better real fast."

We continued laughing as we reached the elevator and w

"Do you think Ci-N will like this?" She asked.

I smiled at her. "Of course. As long as it's from you, even he'll accept it."

She smiled, looking giddy. It was amusing to see. She even for Ci-N. Rakki was taller than me, and her legs were well could be a model with her body proportions.

The elevator bell rang, and the doors opened. Inside, David simple white t-shirt.

"You're here," he said. "...We thought you weren't coming to pick you up."

Rakki and I stepped in, letting David press the floor number

"Why? The party can't start without Jay-jay?" Rakki asked annoyed.

"W-where is Ci's party? Why does it feel like we've gone  
asked David.

"The rooftop," he answered quickly while fiddling with l

How snappy...

We reached the top floor. Rakki was as restless as a child  
David and me.

The only way to the rooftop was through the fire exit, so  
Rakki opened the door and stepped out first, but I sudden  
hugged my gift tightly and lowered my head.

"Is there something wrong, Jay?" David asked, immediat

I looked at him, then at the fragile glass jar in my hands.  
to him.

"I-I can't face Ci... Can you give this to him instead?" I p

"But why?"

I just shook my head. I didn't know the reason either. It f  
was pulling me back, telling me not to go. My original p  
my mind—the last time I would see his genuine smile.

David took the gift and looked at me with sadness.

I was nearing the elevator when I heard someone shouting. I ignored it, but they kept yelling until the words became clear.

"JAY-JAY!" a hoarse voice screamed.

I turned around, and my eyes widened in shock.

Ci-N was in the air.

Literally. In the air. Because he just jumped toward me.

What the—

He looked like a bird with his arms and legs spread wide and he couldn't fly.

Which meant he was going to fall... fall... on me?!

It was too late to step aside. I crashed onto the floor with Ci-N on top of me. My elbow hit the ground, sending an electric shock up my arm.

"Ugh! Damn, that hurts..."

"Jay-jay!" he cried out, hugging me tightly.

"Get off me! You're heavy!" Ci-N slowly got off me, still hugging me. I waited for him to stand up. I frowned and faced him.

he kept pulling me along until we reached the fire exit. he had no chance to speak or protest.

When the door to the rooftop opened... cue music. It felt like I was in another world, like I was in a fun house or amusement park.

There was an inflatable slide, a pool full of colorful balls, tables with various characters, tables piled with candy and chocolate everywhere, and colorful lights all around.

I saw David smiling at me, drinking juice. He must've been chased by this crazy kid.

"You're crazy, David!"

"Jay!" Rakki called out as she approached. "...Where did he disappear!"

"I went to the bathroom." I lied.

I looked around, and Ci-N was nowhere to be found. he was mingling with the kids.

I saw some adults too, but they were in the corners, away from the kids.

"Keep an eye on your kids! It's the party organizer's fault that happens," I thought.

"Why did you cut your hair?"

They all had questions for me. I chose to ignore them and an empty seat far from them.

I don't know why, but I couldn't shake the nervousness. I myself many times to move on, but now that I was facing hesitating again.

"Hi, Jay!" Mica greeted me as I sat next to her.

I thought it was someone else...

"Hello..." I replied and looked at the person sitting beside

Calix wasn't there? I scanned the area and saw him sitting other Ulupongs.

"They're fighting." Rakki whispered to me.

I must've looked like I was searching for Mica's labidab.

She just kept her head down, pretending to be busy with

We looked like fools as we watched the kids happily play mascots. My eyes widened when I saw a familiar masco

"Snorlax!" I shouted without thinking.



I kept hugging it as Mica took a picture. I didn't want to. I wanted to take it home!

"Can I take this home?!" I asked Rakki and Mica.

They just shrugged. Ci-N walked by with a plate of food before stopping.

"Oh no! You're in trouble!" he said with a warning tone. "inside that costume."

I instinctively turned to look at the Ulupongs. My eyes watched their King walking toward us, fists clenched and ready to

"Hurry! We need to move it!" I shouted in a panic to Rakki and Mica.

They quickly followed me as we pushed the mascot away from the approaching King. The kids stared at us as we did this.

"What's going on?!" I heard a kid shout when we nearly

"Sorry," Mica apologized to the child.

We ended up in an area with piles of chairs and tables, a pile of cloth and balloons. We hid there until the King was out of sight.

"That's it! We're safe!" Rakki sighed with relief.

The person inside the Snorlax costume removed the hood

He looked young, probably around our age, but already

"Sorry about that. If we didn't get you out of there, you n hurt." I said while wiping the sweat from my forehead.

"Pardon?" he said nervously.

"His ex has issues, doesn't understand their feelings." Ra

I frowned. "He's not my ex... we never even dated."

"Sorry... but I'm confused. Can I go back to work now?"

There was no way Keifer would do anything bad to him. and nodded. He put the Snorlax headpiece back on and l

We stayed there for a while, exhausted. I was starting to

"Shall we eat?" I suggested to them.

They exchanged glances before nodding and walking to It was self-service, so we each got our own.

I felt embarrassed to show how hungry I was, so I took o five scoops of rice and some dishes. Two plates in total. take more.

While eating, Calix suddenly sat next to Mica and put a j cake on the table

Calix's shoulders slumped as he walked away. Both Rakki and Mica looked at him.

"What's going on? LQ?" I asked.

She shook her head and looked away. I glanced at Rakki and he shrugged.

"Jay-jay!" Ci-N called out as he carried my gift, a fragile box. "...What's this?"

I smiled at him and opened the jar. "One surprise egg per day."

I handed him a surprise egg, knowing it was his favorite. He looked forward to what was inside.

It was like a message every day for a whole year. That's why the contents would last.

I hoped he would like it...

he suddenly started crying. Rakki and Mica panicked.

"Why? Don't you like it?" I asked.

he smiled through his tears. "I like it! I really like it!"

Rakki and Mica kept exchanging looks. His actions were confusing, but he was crying.

Now I understood how powerful the word "sorry" could couldn't change the past or bring back time, it could still been holding inside.

I walked up to him, gently placed my hand on his head. 'mad anymore. Happy birthday!"

he smiled at me again and hugged me tightly. he quickly the gift I gave him.

"I'll keep this safe!" He said happily.

We were left just watching him. Mica went to the bathro went to talk to Ci-N's sister. I stayed there, looking aroun Snorlax again.

I rushed over and greeted it with another hug. "Surprise!

Snorlax tilted its head slightly, and I could almost feel th looking at me. I smiled at them as they returned the hug.

Maybe they recognized me.

"Sorry about earlier. The King of the Ulupongs has issue hugging Snorlax. "...He doesn't know what he wants in l

Snorlax kept hugging me, and I felt a small hand on my l ignore it.

I added, smiling.

Suddenly, Snorlax pulled away from me, and I heard Cle inside.

"I won't let you!"

I pulled away and looked at Snorlax in confusion. He rer head, and I was stunned to see who was inside.

"You're not Clefford!"

"I won't let you move on. I won't let you fall out of love.

# Trivia (This is originally from a book)

Well... It didn't reach 10 chapters.

I'll just give a trivia about AMNSE and the Ulupongs.

Trivia #1

AMNSE started while I was lying on a hammock, reading

*The Four Badboys and Me*

... Yes! You read that correctly. I usually read English stories and I only checked out popular Filipino stories late.

Anyway, how did it happen? While reading, there was a scene where Candice was transferred to Jeydon's section. From there (I didn't finish it), there were no girls in their section. That's when her joining the pageant.

That's when the idea came to me... What if there was a scene where one girl? But somehow, they fully supported her in every scene. #TropaGoals. But I didn't want a damsel in distress, I didn't want her being bullied. I wanted her to be a bit of a

The original plan was just Keifer, Jay-jay, and Aries—and the Ulupongs. Yes! Indeed! It was a love triangle between them and the adopted, after all. So, Yuri and Percy weren't part of the plan.

Well, my grandmother got really inspired. She kept typing on her cellphone. I didn't even realize that Yuri was already for the job. I was supposed to do something bad to Jay-jay, but that changed.

As for Percy? I liked the guy who's always following the car. He was supposed to like Jay-jay too. But damn! The main character was so beautiful! I was too shy to compare with her.

That's how APYK! Or KYPA or KYAP came to be. Just kidding.

As for the Ulupongs...

Blaster's name came from a contestant on

*Music Hero*

on Eat Bulaga. I was impressed by him, so I used his name.

Josh's name also came from there. Those were my last choices. I was too lazy to think of new names. But his character was the main character in

*The Transfer Student from Public High*

• • • • •

As for Edrix, it just popped into my head, and then I later realized it sounds similar to Calix's name. So, I added "Knight." Right?

Rory, I heard that name on TV, I think it was from a movie. It sounded unique.

Kit? Obviously, it's from my crush, Kit Harington—the actor who plays Jon Snow in

*Game of Thrones*

. I didn't intend to make him gay... I just gave him that name. It was a maynimo moment. Hahahaha.

Mayo? I have another story about a girl with multiple personalities. I had a friend named Mayo, and it's a girl. I just took the name. The book was never published.

Jeson is pronounced as He-son.

Drew or Andrew is the name of my older brother. Yes, I know. His real name is James Andrew, but I took the nickname Arellano. They share the same name. My brother's full name is James.

As for Eren... From

*Attack on Titan*



You know about Ci-N and David. Don't go looking for tl  
Brewer. He's married with kids.

Hahahahahaha... Maybe next time. Visit our group and p



# Chapter 215: Saving you

## Jay-jay's POV

Sometimes, when life gets too chaotic, it feels so tempting to bash your head against the wall. Hard enough to just fall asleep and wake up again.

Go ahead, bash your head! I support you!

But sometimes, it feels better to bash the head of the person causing all the chaos in your life. And that's what I wanted to do with you in front of me.

"You can't do that! You can't move on and forget everything I've done!" he angrily said while poking me with Snorlax's head.

He was still wearing the mascot, only the head was removed.

I was speechless. It was like my tongue retreated and my mind froze.

I don't understand this person! This Dimunyang Gagong Kumag, the King of Ulupongs!

I was confused by what he was doing. And why is he insisting on this?

I looked behind me and saw him chasing after me, but because of his costume, he couldn't even walk properly.

Good for you! Suffer, you idiot!

I quickened my pace and squeezed through the kids playing, jumping into a pool full of colorful plastic balls.

I looked ridiculous swimming in it like there was no water. I could get away from that Dimunung.

Just keep swimming!

When I got out, I saw him being swarmed by the kids. He was cursing just to get away from them.

I continued to distance myself from him. I walked over to the slide and climbed up. It was difficult to move since the slide was crowded. When I reached the top, I realized that the troublemaker was at the bottom.

"We need to talk!" he shouted at me.

I shook my head, about to go down, but then I saw a kid looking at me with a scowl and looked like he was about to push me.

I had no choice but to slide down. I knew he was waiting for me, so I stretched my legs and forcefully kicked him with all my

I furrowed my brows as I looked at him. "What do you n

Why does his face look so dull?

"Can we talk? Please..." he said, full of pleading.

I was ready to snap at him with "You're already talking," I looked into his eyes. I could see that he was sincere in l

I guess this is the routine with these best friends of mine. me, the other follows. I really can't get their life trip.

Road trip? Bad trip? Field trip?

I nodded slowly and he took his hand off my arm. He gu fire exit. We entered and moved a bit farther to talk prop

"What do you need?" I asked, and my voice echoed thro exit.

He seemed to notice it. He opened the nearest door and l spacious ballroom greeted us. The lights were at the corr dim.

"Jay... Please. Let me explain," he begged again.

I didn't want to listen, but I was already here. I didn't wa walk if I ignored him.

Honestly, I didn't plan on talking to Jay-jay today. I knew with her and Keifer at the food court a few days ago. It was in my mind, and talking to her about this would feel like a slap

But earlier...

When I saw how restless Keifer was, looking for the Snickers, I knew how it felt. He was being consumed by jealousy again.

And so was I.

"Letting go, but here you are searching for your next victim by throwing him a comment."

He shot me his usual death glare. I just shrugged and kept walking. Ci-N's party was for kids, not teenagers like us.

What else should I expect from Ci-N Peralta?

"Found you! Son of a b!tch!" Keifer angrily yelled as he walked by.

I could only shake my head. Why does it feel like Keifer is living Ci-N's traits? It should be the other way around. But it does feel like what's happening.

I let out a heavy sigh and looked around again. I saw Jay and Mica. She still looks pretty, even though she cut her

That's why I was so confused by his actions. And things I heard what he said.

'I won't let you move on. I won't let you fall out of love.'

This can't be! He had just told me he was letting go. That Jay-jay, but now this? Why doesn't he want Jay-jay to follow him?

I don't understand Keifer; he's not lying this time. He's so sure like he doesn't want to let Jay-jay go. I have to do something.

Keifer should be the first one I talk to, but I changed my mind and found Jay-jay instead. I wasn't disappointed, and here she was with me.

"Jay... I'm really sorry for all the pain I caused. Honestly, you knew that from the start." I paused to let her speak.

She told me back then that both she and Keifer were "poor" because our first meeting wasn't ideal, but she brought me back to

To being my natural self.

She didn't say anything, so I continued talking. "Keifer came up with the plan, and I was by his side. I was also one of the ones who was angry at Aries, but I admit, I already had doubts back then. I took a deep breath.

had fallen for his plan, and I was scared I wouldn't be able to get away from him."

That was the night she admitted she liked Keifer. I was very heartbroken. I didn't know what to do. I wanted to save her.

I fucking love her.

"But I didn't give up. I still tried, but of course, I failed. I wanted to save you and have you. I didn't want to be hurt again, and I didn't want to happen to you either."

"So that's why you forced that damn engagement?" she said.

I lowered my head. "Y-yes."

She shook her head. "So that's why you wanted to save me?" she asked sarcastically.

I tried to move closer, but she stepped back. I just lowered my head and stopped my attempt. I composed myself to continue talking.

"I'm not putting all the blame on Keifer. Because I was the one who planned it. I'm also at fault. I'm sorry, Jay, I'm sorry for not listening to you. I'm sorry for making decisions that crossed your boundaries. I'm sorry I didn't think I was capable of doing this."

"We never agreed that I would forgive you," she said coldly.

"...Our agreement was just for your explanation. Nothing more. So get up, your kneeling is a waste."

Her words pierced through me. It hurt so much, and it felt like I was being squeezed. I didn't know she could be so tough after all that happened. Or maybe she was intentionally making us suffer.

Slowly, I stood up, but I kept my head lowered. I didn't understand why she was able to endure this with me, but she can endure Keifer's abuse. Everything he did to her?

"Do you really love Keifer?" I said, almost to myself.

She gave me a sharp look. It almost seemed like she was trying to really show how angry she was.

"Because it's so easy for you to forgive him, even though he made a lot of effort to apologize." I said, which made her stop.

I tried to lower my voice. I couldn't help but feel upset with her. It was unfair to me.

"I haven't forgiven Keifer yet."

Not yet? But she will soon.

~~~~~


"It's not that easy!" she said angrily as she wiped the tear
"...If you can't even move on from me, how can I move on?
you think I still want to feel this way?!"

She glared at me. "...I hate this! That asshole is messing
doesn't like me, but then he shows signs that he does! And
have feelings for him, I get my hopes up!"

I felt embarrassed by what I said. She's right. Because of
forgot that she's hurting too.

Maybe.

"I'm sorry, I didn't mean to----."

She cut me off. "Damn! Always apologizing! Are you a
You and your best friend are the same! You're both idiots!"

She wiped her cheek again. "...Now I don't know what to

I stepped closer to her, and this time, I didn't hesitate. I tried
tried to pull away, but I tightened my grip.

"I know what you can do. Forget how I feel about Keifer
said, bringing her hand close to my face.

She paused for a moment, thinking. Please say yes. I swear
to help you.

"Still Keifer?" I slowly released her hand.

"...Are you still hoping?"

She didn't answer. My chest tightened with the silence sl

"But he's already let you go," I said, and she looked at m
"...He's letting you go."

"W-what are you talking about?"

I don't know if I should tell her this.

"About a week ago, Keifer asked me to keep you safe. I
didn't answer," I said, looking her in the eyes. "...He said
go."

I saw her hand tremble. Another tear fell from her eyes. I
regretted what I said. I tried to apologize, but she sudden

I couldn't move. I just stood there, watching her slowly v

I shouldn't have said that. I'm so sorry.

+++++

Jay-jay's POV

I don't know what curse I should say to lessen the weigh

He's playing with me! It'd be fine if I looked like Barbie, no. I look more like a Bratz doll.

Keifer has already let me go, and earlier, he said he would. And why? Who does he think he is? Am I really the one for something, and he's just going to play with me whenever

I'm almost at the door when it opens, and the asshole I've been talking to walks out. He stops when he sees me but quickly walks to the door.

"We need to talk," he says authoritatively as he grabs my arm.

You better get ready, you asshole!

I let him pull me along. We exit the fire exit door, and walk down the hallway floor before the rooftop. He keeps pulling me until he stops, standing in front of a door.

He quickly presses the keypad near the door. It opens, and we go inside. He lets go of my hand before turning on the light switch.

But whose is this?!

It's clean, and all the furniture looks new. It's complete, and almost the same as Aunt Gema's house.

I glance around before the reason I came here hits me.

His head turned, and it took a while before he faced me. touch his face to tend to the pain. Shock and anger were

"Does it hurt? The other side, to make it even," I said, ir

He took a deep breath, clearly trying to calm himself do

"I deserve this," he said in a lifeless tone.

I pretended to laugh. "Well, at least you know, because I REALLY MAD AT YOU! I want to break your bones!"

He avoided my gaze before biting his lip. He walked tow but I quickly slapped his hands away.

"Don't touch me!"

"Let me explain," he said calmly.

"Explain what? Go ahead, tell me another lie," I challeng

His fists clenched, and he looked like he was about to los saw his Adam's apple move up and down several times.

"Jay..." His voice carried a hint of pleading. "...I understa but please listen to me" Just explain... I want to understa playing with me. Why you keep hurting me over and over again, messing with me," I said, giving him a fake smile.

"Who are you to stop me? Why? Aren't you the reason I
And now you won't let me?! YOU'RE SO FULL OF YO
shouted, tears falling from my eyes. "...I don't want this a
want to love you anymore."

"It's not possible," he whispered.

"I don't want to!" I yelled.

"It's not possible," he whispered again.

"Stop it! I can't love you anymore!"

"It's not possible."

"Enough! Stop hurting me!"

"It's not possible!"

"Why won't you let me go? Why? WHY?!"

"BECAUSE I CAN'T HANDLE LOSING YOU!" he scr
echoing through the entire floor.

I froze. We were both panting from all the shouting. My
looked at him.

I only then noticed that he had tears in his left eye.

Chapter 216: Broken

Jay-jay's POV

"Liar! I won't believe you anymore. You can't fool me. T

"Oh!" Percy said, handing me the ice cream he bought. I eating, even though I was in a daze and seemed to be out

Currently, we were at the park with my crazy stepbrother to pick me up because no one was home except for the n out without me. They left me!

"Tell me again. I couldn't understand you earlier; you ke ice cream," Percy said while eating his ice cream.

I sighed and started recounting the conversation I had wi words kept me awake all night. I didn't even know how I and made it home alone.

By the time I finished talking, Percy had finished his ice

"Do you believe what he said?" he asked.

I shook my head. "I-I don't know."

If I think about it, he's right. If I didn't believe, my answer would be 'no.' So I guess, part of me is still hoping. Hoping that will be true.

I was about to take another bite of my ice cream, but I suddenly realized I wasn't holding it anymore. I looked down at my hand, thinking it had fallen.

I looked at Percy, and the shameless guy was eating the ice cream, though his was already finished!

"That's mine! You're an animal!" I said in frustration.

"It's going to melt! You haven't finished it yet. Let me finish it, teasing me.

I was so annoyed! I felt like slapping him repeatedly.

"Didn't you think I already licked it?" I said sarcastically while eating.

"Oh right!" he said, shocked, covering his mouth. "...Shit."

I almost took off my shoe to hit him with it. Good thing I tied my laces. He just laughed at my reaction before eating the ice cream.

I sighed and looked around. What bad luck—I saw a sweet shop near us.

I gave him a hard smack on the back of his head. After five minutes of cream I bought, here he was, annoying me. People started

"Ow!" he complained, rubbing the back of his head.

"You really know how to ruin my day."

"You're so bitter... Don't drag other people into it. If you're stuck with it forever, just don't yell at them or make them feel it. Let them have their own..." He rubbed his neck again. "...And they're not your problem. Don't drag them into your bitterness."

I raised an eyebrow at him. "What are you fighting for?"

It was obvious that he was getting annoyed by what I said. He shook his head multiple times and looked in another direction. I understood what he meant, but the way he was explaining it felt like he was talking to me.

"You're too bitter about Keifer," he whispered, clearly trying to keep it quiet.

Am I bitter now?

I glared at him. "I'm not bitter! I'm just pissed at him! He messed up! He pushes me away, and when I start to distance myself, he pulls me back! What does he think I am? A dog with a leash?"

He took a deep breath. "What I'm saying is, he might act for you. Because if he didn't, he would've already stoppe

What Percy was saying sounded so good. It felt great to it was also scary. Scary because of the word 'might'.

"...but he hasn't let go because he can't. He's crazy about something happened, and he had to push you away."

He added. I sighed. "I don't know what happened, but it he just stayed away."

He should just stop.

"Are you really sure you don't want him anymore?" he a

I shook my head a little. I didn't want to hope anymore. I my mind. I preferred it when he said it was really over, r 'maybe' situation.

"Then tell him." I rolled my eyes. "I already told him, di

"Then show it." I furrowed my brow. "What are you talk confusing to talk to!"

"Show him that you've moved on. Date someone else. Sl happy without him."

.....

"Percy... I don't have much money with me," I whispered to Percy as I looked at the menu.

"Who's Percy?" he asked, slightly irritated. I just shook my head in response. He didn't know I saved his name as that in my phone.

"...I'll pay for this. Don't worry," he told me as he faced the waiter to place our order.

The waiter left, holding the menu. While we waited, I looked around the restaurant. The place was beautiful, with gorgeous decor and a large chandelier hanging from the ceiling.

I'm gonna sing later... I wanna swing... Chandelier, chandelier...

I accidentally looked toward the entrance of the restaurant and took a deep breath when I saw two people walking in. That's when I realized the presence of the "King of Snakes" really is.

He was with that Honey Bee Raider again! They were dressed formally, unlike the casual clothes Percy and I were wearing. It was like we just passed by and decided to eat at an expensive restaurant.

We looked like rags. I kept staring at them while they waited for the waiter. They were probably asking for a table. They should sit outside away from us. Or they can sit outside while we stay inside.

I turned to Percy, who was busy on his phone.

"Percy..." I felt his gaze shift to me. "...Jay."

Shit!

It was like I was electrocuted when he said my name. Ugh, to be like this? Slowly, I turned to face them with a plastered smile that suits them.

"Oh, you guys are here? I didn't notice," I said.

"Didn't notice, or didn't you just ignore us?" Honey replied with an eyebrow at me.

Looks like she's starting again.

"Both..." I answered with a smile.

She raised an eyebrow, but instead of retorting, she just looked at that Pest King and started rubbing it.

"Maki..." she said dramatically. "...introduce me to your eyes."

Keifer looked at her before facing Percy.

"Percy, this is Honey Bee Raider. She's my lawyer's niece, the hand of the buzzing woman who was holding onto him. Percy Coll----Mariano."

The King of Snakes wouldn't take his eyes off me. I didn't move them here.

"Okay, introductions are over... You guys can leave now, smile, even though I really wanted to shove them into our

"Rude," Honey said in an exaggerated tone. Your face is

"Jay..." Percy called me. "...don't be like that."

One of my eyebrows raised. I expected him to take my side, but I like I was really in the wrong.

"Since we're going to eat here anyway, mind if we share a table?" I asked Percy.

She only asked Percy for permission.

Percy and I exchanged glances. I gave him a sharp look to see if I wasn't okay with it.

"That's a great idea," said the King, and he called a waiter.

I signaled Percy to stop him, but it was too late because the waiter had already set up another table next to ours. I was forced to move beside him, so I was facing this so-called King.

The two of them placed their orders. Meanwhile, my brother and I

I've never really had alcohol before. My Tita and Kuya A
I've never tried it. I pushed the glass away and cleared m

I looked up and immediately furrowed my brows. The st
front of me was staring intently at me, while the girl besi
smiling at Percy.

"So, how did you two become step-siblings?" Honey ask

"None of your business," I quickly answered before Perc

She gave me a sharp look. It was like she was about to l
table and pull my hair.

"I'm not talking to you, I'm talking to him," she said snol

As if you're the only one who can act like that?!

"I'm not talking to you either, I'm talking to..." I thought
to but ended up pointing at Percy anyway. "...him."

They all raised an eyebrow. I turned to Percy and gave h
seemed like he got what I meant.

"Y-yeah... She's talking to me," Percy said, scratching hi

I wanted to laugh out loud, the kind of laugh that would
embarrassed. But it would be too awkward. People migh

"Slice it... Thanks!" I said.

Percy had no choice but to do as I asked. Even without looking at the King, I knew he was annoyed by what I did. I didn't do it to annoy him, but I didn't want his actions to mean anything to me.

Percy handed my plate back, and I started eating. But as I was eating, I was spitting it out. This animal wouldn't stop staring at me.

I was getting close to losing my temper.

"Percy..." Honey called out to him. "...do you have a girl?"

She was so straightforward. It was obvious she had feelings for Percy. She wanted to butt into their conversation, but it would be too much. It might just cause trouble.

"N-no..." Percy answered hesitantly.

Percy placed a hand on his thigh, squeezing it as if he was trying to calm himself. He answered Honey's question.

He slowly stood up. "I'm going to the restroom."

I didn't say anything. I just watched him leave until he was about to stand up and go to the restroom too, but then he spoke.

"..."

"We need to talk," he said authoritatively.

I looked at him sharply. "You're already talking."

He took a deep breath. Clearly holding back his anger. N told Honey to keep Percy busy.

"Listen to me..." he started. "...I don't know where to start

"At the starting line," I quickly cut him off.

His forehead wrinkled, and his eyebrows furrowed. He e collar.

"Okay..." he sighed. "...I'll start at the beginning."

I smiled. "Just go straight to the end to make it fun."

Finish line...

He was slowly killing me with his stare. The truth is, I re hear his explanation. I was scared. Scared that I might ge

"Jay... I'm trying to be nice here," he said with emphasis.

He took the wine glass in front of him, took a sip, and lo

"Please, Jay. I want to explain everything to you. So, ple listen to me " he added

It felt like something was stuck in my throat. I forced my
He looked hurt by what I said, his mouth slightly open.

"Enough... Please. I'm getting tired," I pleaded, and my v
blur. "...I'm tired of loving you even though I'm not doing
started falling. "...I'm trying to stay away from you, but y
back."

"Why? Why are you running away from me?" he asked s
And you still had to ask...

"Because that's what should happen. There's no reason for
right?" I forced a smile. "...I love you, but you don't love
been a fool once, I don't want to do it again."

He kept staring at me. He didn't say anything, so I contin

"If I had a choice, I'd want to leave your Section. Because
torturing me. When you're around, it feels like my heart
tried to hold back my tears. "...Going to class is torture b
everything we did. All the happy memories we had----or
were all lies."

I took a few deep breaths. "It hurts..." I pointed to my ch
bit my lip to stop myself from crying loudly.

I don't have real friends. When someone tries to befriend

He smiled, the kind of smile that made it seem like nothi

"You..." he started. "...You're making me crazy."

I wiped my tears and looked at him, confused.

"I'm Mark Keifer Watson. I'm smarter than you think. I'n know..." He smirked. "...And I'm the King of Ulupongs."

He moved quickly. From sitting across me, he was now l
up at him as he leaned down, holding the back of my neck
lips together.

I looked like an idiot, pushing him away but my lips wer

The truth?!

He pressed his forehead against mine as we both closed o
still holding the back of my neck. We were both catching
that kiss.

I won't deny it. I missed his lips too. That just added to th
feeling.

"It's only you, Jay... You're the only girl who's made me s
whispered.

He pulled away and sat back on the bench beside me. He
... ..

I looked at him when I felt something wet on the back of against his cheek. He was crying.

"Yuri is right. I lied to him, I lied to you, and I lied to my felt tied, and no words came out of my mouth. "...I have that you can never imagine."

Shit! Shit! Shit! Shit! Shit! Shit! ---my heartbeat said.

Is this real? Maybe it's just the steak messing with my head a hallucination. Like gas that I just need to fart out. Hungry to eat away. Sleepiness that I just need to sleep off.

"K-Keifer..." was all that came out of my mouth.

He placed a hand on my cheek. "I'm scared to touch you really want to. I don't want to hurt you like I hurt Freya. ...consumes me, I can't control myself."

I remembered what he did when I kissed Yuri. He pulled the room and grabbed my jaw. It hurt, and I admit I was

"...I won't let that happen again."

He smiled and closed his eyes again. "...My birthday is coming you're the gift I want."

Birthday? His birthday is on February 29.

I was getting confused again. I know English, but this guy was confusing.

"What do you..." I sighed. "...You'll stop but only for a while. What are you thinking?"

"I'm giving you space."

I need a spaceship to get away from you!

I just shook my head. I couldn't believe it. He's really crazy.

"...But when I return. You're officially mine whether you like it or not."

What the fvck?!

I was about to lash out at him, but suddenly someone slipped beside me. When I looked, my eyes widened at the sight. He was messy, his clothes were disheveled, and his pants zipped. He was panting heavily, as if he was running from someone.

"Let's go!" he said, pulling me. "...Hurry!"

I stood up and looked at him closely. He took out some money from his wallet and placed it on the table before pulling me again. We went to the parking lot where his car was.

"What's going on with you?!" I asked as I got into his car.

He suddenly started crying. There were no tears, but his scrunched up. I wanted to laugh, but he might get mad.

"Jay..." he said, pretending to sob. "...I was molested... B started wailing like a child.

Chapter 217: Engage no m

Jay-jay's POV

Percy is sick. He's running a fever, his mother told me w earlier.

I think he got sick because he didn't sleep last night. He l seemed really restless. There were times when he'd whis repeating, "my honor."

I don't even know if he really has any.

I called his phone to check on him. It rang three times be

["Jay..."] He said, his voice hoarse.

"Seriously? What happened between you and Honey?" I hear him sobbing.

Every time I ask him that, he always ends up crying and things until the call ends.

["My honor, Jay!"] I could hear his sobbing. ["She ruine

It's hard to tell if he's serious or not.

Maybe he really is possessed!

"What exactly did she do to you?"

He sighed deeply. ["Well... She did her best. I... I finished home."]

I frowned. I really didn't understand what he was saying. I probably would have slapped him already.

"You're so confusing! I don't understand a thing you're saying. Frustration."

["Eeww... She... She did it to me!"] He said, and I could hear his side.

It seemed like he was rolling around in bed. I cringed at the sound.

"Eeww... You did what?!"

["No! But she... made me happy... I mean, she assaulted me."]

I didn't want to ask any more questions. I let my imagination run wild with what he was saying. It's probably better if I don't push him.

"Okay... Rest up. You might get even sicker."

I didn't wait for his next words. I ended the call right away, driving me crazy. His mind is completely out of it.

It's better if I just let him rest. I was about to put my phone on the table when a text message came in.

I cringed when I saw who it was from.

From: GagongBaliw

Message: My life... I miss you.

I hadn't replied to him in a while, but he was still so persistent with his "GagongBaliw" ways, and something familiar.

Instead of replying, I just placed my phone down on the table and, after staring at the ceiling for a long time, I eventually fell asleep.

I woke up to the sound of my phone ringing. It seemed like it had been calling for a long time.

I got up and grabbed it from the table, but as soon as I touched it, the screen went black.

It was Yuri who called.

I shrugged and looked at the clock. It was already 6 PM. I had been asleep for a long time. I felt hungry. I put the phone back down on the table and walked toward the door of my room.

~~~~~

He sighed. "Remember? Dinner with the Head Master."

Who is the Head Master?

I slowly shook my head. I couldn't remember. What was  
Why is there such a thing?

"I'm doomed," he whispered, his head lowered.

I could tell that he was dealing with something heavy. I  
him to leave, but the word "dinner" rang in my ears.

Food... Free...

"Please... I can't go back home without you," he begged.

My eyes narrowed at him.

There! Now I'm also speaking Japanese.

"So? What are we going to do?"

"I'll introduce you to the Head Master, then dinner."

Dinner... Dinner... Dinner... Food!

"What if I don't want to go?"

His shoulders slumped as he tried to force a smile. "I unc



I went straight to my cabinet and picked out clothes. I looked for something that would match Yuri's outfit. I wanted to look like I belonged where we're going to.

Semi-formal dress...

I looked a mess as I combed my tangled hair. It had gotten messy from the clips I wore earlier. Now it looked like a witch's hair.

I think I even accidentally put some deodorant in my hair.

Once I finished with all the mess, I stepped out. Yuri was sitting on the floor, head down, leaning against the wall.

"Let's go! The sushi is waiting for me." I said as I walked towards the door.

He followed me, slapping the back of my head. Aunt Geom was in the living room. She was smiling while talking on the phone.

"Are you leaving?" she asked us.

"Yes..." Yuri answered. "...I'll drop her off around 10 PM."

"Alright, be careful."

"Thanks, Aunt." I said before walking out.

Neither of us spoke while the car started. He was focused on driving. I just stared out the window.

I frowned slightly while looking at him. I waited for him swallowed a few times before raising his head to face me

"Whatever happens, don't tell them our exact status." He with pleading eyes. "...If the Head Master finds out the t something to you. So please... don't talk about our situati

Even though I didn't fully understand what he meant, I ju

For the sushi!

He started the car again, and we headed to the basement building. I was about to open the door, but he stopped m

"Don't get out yet." He said before quickly getting out of opening the door for me.

I wanted to slap him hard because I didn't understand wh He was acting like a gentleman.

He was also holding my hand as we walked toward the e

I was getting really weirded out by what he was doing. V and the only reason I went with him was for the free food

Food is life!

Inside the elevator, he was still holding my hand. I gave

This is getting too much! I'm going to slap him!

We stopped in front of a wooden and paper door—one of those doors like in old Japanese houses. I could hear loud laughter inside. Yuri sat down and was about to bow, but suddenly

"You have to do this too." He whispered.

"I don't want to." I replied flatly.

He grabbed my hand and tried to pull me down to sit. I ran away.

"Jay... What's wrong?!" He said in frustration.

"It hurts my legs. I don't want to!" I said while pulling my hand away.

"Stop being difficult!"

So annoying! I only came here for the sushi.

He pulled me again, and out of frustration, I kicked him. At the same time, the door suddenly opened.

Shit!

I froze as I looked at the people inside. Their laughter stopped. They all looked at me and Yuri.

I didn't understand anything. Can I eat now? I've been hu

"Anata no fianse?" (Is that your fiancée?) asked the man sitting at the end of the long table.

I didn't recognize him. I knew he wasn't Yuri's grandfath scarier than Yuri's grandfather, whom Yuri calls Tanda.

"Hai, heddomasutā." (Yes, Head Master.) replied the per me.

What are they talking about?

Suddenly, the old man talking to Yuri burst out laughing holding his stomach as if whatever they were talking abc funny.

Are they laughing at me?!

"Tsuyoi on'na! Kare wa anata o utsu koto ga dekimasu." She can beat you down!)

I was getting really annoyed with this old man. I didn't u was saying. He was just being a jerk.

"Come here, eat with us." Yuri's dad called out to me.

I looked at Yuri as he slowly stood up. I did the same, an

I tried to smile, but I knew it came out as a grimace. This  
Damn this sushi.

Suddenly, the old man in the middle spoke again. I didn't he said, so I just stared at him blankly.

"He's asking for your full name." Yuri whispered to me.

"J-Jasper Jean Mariano," I answered awkwardly.

Yuri spoke, and it seemed like he was explaining what I smiled and nodded.

I started eating when Yuri handed me a bowl of rice. I ate with the annoying chopsticks.

# Where's the sushi?

The old man in the middle kept talking while we ate. Even when they would laugh, and I felt out of place. I had no idea what he was talking about.

Soon, the old man looked at me again and said somethin to whisper what he said, but he just stared at me, his face

"Hey... What did he say?" I asked him.

"A-ano... K-kung pwede daw na... Magka-b-baby na tay!"

"Kanojo wa itta, kanojo wa sore ni tsuite kangaerudarou. (think about it.)

The old man burst out laughing again. He kept talking un

There was no sushi! Yuri is a liar!

I walked angrily behind Yuri. He was talking to the old man and me and smiled.

"He wants to talk to you. Please... fix your answer for him

I furrowed my brows. "How am I supposed to do that? I don't understand what he's saying."

Yuri scratched the back of his head and faced the old man. He said something to him before the old man walked away from my hand, and we started walking.

"He just wants to ask you some questions. I won't be there. I will help you talk to him." Yuri said.

We stopped again in front of the same door as earlier. We were here are the same anyway. The door opened, and the old man was sitting behind a big table.

Who is this guy, really?

~~~~~

"The Head Master is asking if you know him." Alliah said.

I blinked. Head Master? Is that him? I was expecting the samurai, not this intimidating old man.

"M-maybe not." I answered uncertainly.

Alliah spoke in Japanese, and the old man chuckled lightly. He said something long to me, which sounded like an anime scene in Japan.

"I want you to know that I am the Head Master of the Hamada family. I am responsible for maintaining balance in the family. I care for all members in all things..." The old man continued, and then said "...Yuri, your fiancé, is my grandson from my youngest son."

I froze. Alliah said it in Tagalog, but it still felt like a difficult situation. This is such a mess!

My head started to hurt. Isn't there any sushi here?

"Okay... I-I understand now."

Alliah translated what I said, and the old man spoke again. He translated it immediately to me.

"To be honest, I don't like you. You're far from the woman I want. You're not Japanese, you have no influence, you're a basic person."

heir. He used those to get what he wanted."

I wasn't sure if I had the right to respond. All this old man was saying to me. I really wanted to curse, but I was still too shy. I'm in a position where he's the one saying I have no manners. I didn't want to put myself in a worse position.

The old man spoke again, and Alliah translated.

"I want you to improve. Fix yourself, because when we t
no one in the family will accept you."

F***! Not only is there no sushi, but there's also an insult.

"That's fine... I don't even accept myself as part of your family. I'm continuing without hesitation.

Alliah seemed taken aback and hesitated to translate what he said. She signaled for her to continue.

I didn't want to be rude, but what could I do? My pride was hurt by this old man. I just wanted to slap him back to back.

Alliah translated what I said to the old man. Suddenly, he looked at me and he shouted words I couldn't understand.

Alliah was shaking as she looked at me.

"You have no respect... You didn't even show me any. W

I didn't wait for him to respond. I quickly left and walked to the elevator. I saw Yuri, but I kept walking.

While waiting for the elevator door to open, I struggled to get my shoes on. I was so annoyed! I couldn't even put them on properly.

I'm going to throw these!

"Jay-jay!" Yuri called out to me. "...What happened? What did you say to the Head Master?"

I just gave him a glare. Just as the elevator door opened, I stepped inside. I pressed the button in frustration.

"Jay-jay, what happened?! What did you say to him?!"

I took a deep breath. I had been wanting to slap someone, but he didn't stop, it was going to be him.

"Stop this already." I said calmly.

"Jay..."

"Stop this wedding already."

He stopped and just looked at me. I don't know if he was

The elevator door opened, and I quickly stepped out, but I

"Why?! Damn! Is that a question?!" I shouted angrily. ". You're the only one who wants this! Your family doesn't want it, and Tita Gema is being forced into it!"

He lowered his head, and his fist clenched. He knew that say it.

"Is that really what you want?" He asked calmly.

I took a deep breath. I needed to calm down. I didn't war punch with another one.

"Yes."

"Okay." He quickly replied. "...I'll stop it."

I wanted to shout with joy. The frustration I felt earlier ju
Even without sushi.

"...But on one condition..."

I froze. The happiness I was feeling was suddenly interr

"...Let's start all over again."

Chapter 218: Textmate

Jay-jay's POV

It's official! The wedding is off. I feel like jumping for joy all night, except Kuya is causing a scene outside my room.

"Angelo! That's enough!" Aunt Gema pleaded. "...You're resting!"

"No! I just want to talk to them!" Kuya Angelo insisted.

I feel sorry for him, though I don't fully understand. This time I've seen him so drunk. In exchange for the agreement between me and Kuya, their company withdrew its support for Kuya.

"Tomorrow! It's late already!" Aunt Gema shouted.

"Now! We need to talk about it now!"

I slightly opened my bedroom door and peeked out. Aunt Gema was struggling to get Kuya into his room, with two maids helping her.

I glanced at Aries' door, which was also slightly ajar, and saw him looking out just like me. We looked like nosy neighbors watching each other.

Kuya's body seemed to give in, and he stopped resisting into his room to rest. They stayed inside for a while before came out.

Aunt Gema followed. Before she could close the door, I approach her, but Aries beat me to it.

This Horoscope guy is so attention-seeking!

"Ma... What happens to us now?" Aries asked.

Aunt Gema smiled at him and touched his cheek.

"Go to sleep. Don't worry about it."

Aries hugged Aunt Gema and kissed her on the cheek.

"You too, Ma."

I wonder what would have happened if Mama hadn't adopted him. Would he have been the same with our Mama? Would he have been affectionate? Or would he have been even more abnormal?

Let's go with worse.

Aunt Gema broke the hug and smiled as she turned to go. I started walking back but stopped when he saw me.

"Aries..." I called out to him. "Is Aunt Gema okay?"

Damn it! He even spat while yelling!

"Let me go! I'll punch you!" I threatened.

He let go but shoved me back, causing me to hit the door.

"I really hope you had nothing to do with this. Kuya will punish you," he said, then walked straight to his room.

He slammed the door shut. I just stood there, stunned. Thinking about the freedom I wanted. I knew this could happen, but I didn't do this bad.

I went into my room and lay down on the bed. Ugh! I don't have to face Kuya Angelo. I feel ashamed. We haven't even had a conversation since I last yelled at him, and now this happens.

My phone suddenly grabbed my attention. It rang, but when the call ended. I checked and saw a missed call from Kuya.

What's his problem? Suddenly calling.

I wasn't planning to respond, but something made me want to talk to that guy.

To: CrazyIdiot

Message: Idiot!

***Message:** Who are you really? You're so intense with this world! If you're just messing around, can you leave already have so many problems, I don't even know which. Don't add to it.*

I was staring at my phone while sending that. I didn't take my eyes off it while waiting for their reply. I've already played games on Facebook, but they still haven't replied.

Maybe they've given up...

I let out a deep sigh. It felt like the weight on my chest grew heavier when they didn't reply.

I ended up throwing my phone at Snorlax out of frustration. I wanted to turn around and sleep, but suddenly it rang. Someone

I picked it up and was surprised to see that it was Gagon. I didn't want to answer, but my hand seemed to move on its own and pressed the green button.

I put it to my ear and waited for them to speak, but I didn't hear anything.

"H-hello?" I said, but there was still no response.

"Hello? Is anyone there?" Still no one spoke. "...Is there anyone? An alien? A spirit? A demon?..." Still no answer.

I was annoyed by their behavior. They were making me sit up properly on the bed.

"Hey! Can you stop it? Quit being all mysterious! It's not annoying! You're just adding to my stress—I already have problems!" I said angrily, and suddenly the call ended.

This Gagong isn't just rude!

A text message arrived from them again. Even though I had opened it.

****From: GagongBaliw****

***Message: ** I can't talk but I can listen. Tell me your problems, it might lighten the burden you're feeling by sharing it with me.*

I paused. They had a point, honestly. I was still thinking about it when they called again. I answered and put the phone to my ear.

They still didn't speak. This time, I was the one who spoke. I told them, I don't know who they are. But right now, they're the only ones who's willing to listen to me.

"Gagong baliw..." I started. "...I don't really know you. Tell me your name."

It felt like they smirked on the other end. I didn't see it, but

"I don't know if you already know my whole story... I'm family. My mom keeps marrying different people, and I dad. It feels like I've had to carry the weight of their struggles. Snorlax and imagined they were the one on the other end of the line. At home, I'm just staying with relatives, but they treat me like I'm not of course not all the time. They tried to set me up with my first child of their business partners. They tried to force me into it—but they backed off, though it cost them the collapse of their company."

I shifted positions, still hugging Snorlax and playing with it.

"...My problems at school are probably the same as any of yours. Graduation is taking forever!..." I said, slightly annoyed, and I heard them laugh. "...With my classmates..." I paused as my friends with them came flooding back. "...they made me believe I was part of the group. I thought I belonged with them. But it turned out I didn't—they bet on me and ganged up on me as if all our problems meant nothing."

Tears were starting to well up, so I took a few deep breaths.

"And then there's the person I love. What a mess! I feel like I'm going back and forth. They're playing with me—do I look like I'm not? They're so full of themselves! They're probably gay!" I hit my hand against their throat, as if they wanted to say something. "...They know Mark Keifer Watson? They're gay! Gay!"

*So gay according to you *

It's not them... That person wouldn't waste their time just

I was about to speak, but the call suddenly ended. I waited for them to call again, but they didn't. I tried calling them, but they didn't answer.

I just typed a message for them instead.

****To: GagongBaliw****

***Message:** I wasn't done talking... I thought you'd listen.*

I stared intently at my phone screen. I waited for a few minutes but didn't receive their reply.

****From: GagongBaliw****

***Message:** Sorry, I have to go.*

I slammed my phone onto the pillow out of frustration. I was so annoyed. This person just gives me a weird feeling, like I'm talking to one of the Snakes. But how could that be? No one knows about the Snakes except them. I only gave it to Percy. And Rakki, because of his birthday. I'm not sure about David.

Ugh! Who the hell is this person really?

My cellphone buzzed again. Annoyed, I picked it up, and a text message came through from him.

I ended up rolling over Snorlax because I suddenly dropped in frustration. It's so annoying!

I grabbed my phone and typed a reply.

To: GagongBaliw

Message: I don't know with you! Good night already!

I didn't want to say goodbye yet, but he said "I have to go to bed now." I was still texting this idiot. My phone buzzed again with his reply.

From: GagongBaliw

Message: Good night... I hope you'll have sweet dreams.

Ugh! What's up with him?! The emoji again!

My hands were trembling as I typed my reply. I wanted to say "Your dreams are sweet because of you," but of course, I had to be polite.

To: GagongBaliw

Message: You too. Sweet dreams. 😊😊😊

He replied quickly. Even though I hadn't read it yet, I was already turning in bed, still trying to make sense of my feelings.

But I wasn't feeling giddy!

The feeling was gone in an instant. My irritation came back to smash my phone against the wall. I forgot I was texting.

I angrily pressed the buttons on my phone to finish my rant. This bastard!

To: GagongBaliw

Message: Queen Ina! Stop texting me! You're really good.

In my rage, I choked Snorlax. Damn it! I felt a little better. My anger inside me lessened. But then it came back... because

My phone buzzed again. I didn't want to look at it anymore, but it was pushing me to read his message.

From: GagongBaliw

Message: I more like it when you talk to me like that..

I winced. This guy is crazy. He really likes it when I curse in my texts, huh? This dude's head is totally messed up.

To: GagongBaliw

Message: You're really crazy! Your name fits you perfectly.

He replied quickly.

*Message: I don't care about you! Stop bothering me! I th
go already? Why are you still replying?!*

I angrily pressed the send button. I stared at the conversa
minutes, but no reply came. Maybe he had fallen asleep
what I said.

I put my phone on the bedside table and turned to lie dow
some strange reason, sleep wouldn't come.

I turned around to change positions and find a more com

I closed my eyes, but my mind was wide awake. I pulled
me, but it didn't help.

I lay on my stomach, then my back, then rolled over and
but nothing worked. I was still awake!

When you want to sleep, you can't! When you don't, you

I checked my phone and looked at the time. I got even m
I saw the time. It was 2:26 AM!

Damn it! How long had I been texting with that idiot?! A
we spent talking... well, I was the only one talking since

The thought of GagongBaliw crossed my mind again. W

.....

Oh wow! He's the one accusing me.

I quickly replied to him.

To: GagongBaliw

*Message: You're so thick-skinned! How dare you say I'm
YOU'RE THE ONE WITH THE NERVE!*

That jerk! I'm the one who can't sleep. Of course, he's the one not assuming, it's obvious! Why would he text me first if it's about me?

I looked at my phone as it buzzed. I immediately read the

From: GagongBaliw

Message: How else? 'Cause you're the only person I'm talking to earlier.

Ugh, he's such a snob!

I started typing my reply to him.

To: GagongBaliw

Message: Don't blame me! Don't blame me!

I pressed send, barely checking my English because I was

From: GagongBaliw

Message: Hahaha... What's with your English?

What do you care about my English?!

I was about to reply again, but his response to my last m

From: GagongBaliw

Message: Yes, I'm thinking of you. Here in my bed, naked

My nose flared up with anger. This guy is a jerk! He's su
couldn't help but angrily type my reply.

To: GagongBaliw

*Message: Freaking pervert! If you show yourself to me, I
break from the beating you'll get!*

You're disgusting! You're such a perv! People like you sh
manhood chopped off!

People like you deserve to be tokhang-ed!

I had more to say, but I figured it wouldn't fit, so I hit sen
another message for him, but suddenly his reply came th

From: GagongBaliw

From: GagongBaliw

Message: And of course... The honeymoon!

This jerk!

I was so mad at him that I threw my phone on the bed, and it hit the floor.

I also started stomping on the bed from frustration. Even up in the wrestling match.

"Pervert! Pervert! Pervert!" I angrily said, punching the 1

With all the moving and kicking, I didn't realize I was at bed, and suddenly I fell off. My head hit the floor first!

I'll make sure I meet you face to face! You're dead to me

Chapter 219: Begin Again

Jay-jay's POV

The days went by unnoticed. I didn't leave my room because I didn't want to face Kuya.

In those days, I only talked to Percy and that GagongBal. They did nothing but annoy me.

Speaking of the phone, it buzzed, and when I checked, Percy called me. I answered immediately, thinking he might need something, but he still didn't leave his room.

"Hello," I casually said.

["Jay... It's Felix."] I glanced at my phone screen for a moment, and it was really him calling.

"Why? And why are you holding Percy's phone?"

["Because... Kuya Percy said----"] Suddenly, someone started shouting, "He's going out!" ["So, he doesn't want to leave because he might lose all his charm again."]

Percy really lost his mind

"Yeah." I answered, lifelessly.

["Why is he involved here?"]

I rolled my eyes. It was such a hassle to explain. I was tired for school.

"Just tell him that."

He didn't say anything, but I heard some movement on his side. I heard the door creaking.

["Hey! Get out... I'm going to school now."] Felix must've heard Percy.

["I don't want to... I'll stay here."] Percy replied.

["Suit yourself! Honey knows my address."] Felix said, and I heard a creak again. ["Jay?"] He called me. ["I've told him."]

"What was his reaction?"

Suddenly, I heard a loud bang from his side, followed by

["I'll drop you off!"] Percy's voice. ["I'll go to Tito Jasfher's house?"]

Tito Jasfher's house?

Oh right, that's where he used to stay, but when things went bad,

I don't know what's with our school. Whenever there's a rich, they suddenly cancel our classes.

After finishing getting ready, I grabbed my phone again. my bag and left my room. I went straight to the dining room where we were having breakfast.

As soon as I entered, they suddenly went quiet, like an ant. Mama wasn't there because she was following Andy, the

"Good morning po," I greeted them.

Tita Gema and Tito Julz smiled at me. Kuya Angelo kept while eating. Aries glared at me.

Like he was going to burn me with that stare.

"Good morning, Jay. Are you leaving already? Eat first." but I immediately shook my head.

"Thanks, but I'm just saying goodbye. I have to go to school."

"Just bring food with you." She added, about to call the nurse but I stopped her.

"Let her be, Ma. If she wants to leave, let her." He said, looking at us.

"I'll be home later, Ma." I said, looking at them.

I continued walking toward the corner. I was planning to then I remembered I hadn't had breakfast yet. So I went to a mart and bought a sandwich.

While in line at the cashier, I noticed a guy walking in. I didn't notice him? He looked like he had just woken up with me.

He didn't even glance at me and went straight to pick his

Yuri, the disheveled one.

I paid for my sandwich and sat down on the bench by the cashier, eating quietly when someone suddenly approached and spoke to me.

"Hi Miss, can I share the table?" Yuri said as if he didn't

He didn't seem to be all there. He adjusted his glasses and raised my eyebrows and nodded at him. He quickly sat down at the bench. He put his food on the table between us.

"Are you an HVIS student too? What year are you? By the way, how about you?" He asked one after another.

I was ready to curse him out, but then I remembered. He started over. I mean from the very beginning, before we even

I'll play along.

I just stared at him while he smiled at me. He looked ridiculous but a part of me wanted to laugh.

I tapped his hand. "I'm not interested." I said.

Yuri lowered his hand but was still smiling at me.

"Nice meeting you, not interested," he said.

Great... He's completely lost it.

He's really into this "start all over again" thing. Good luck being serious.

"What's your deal?" I asked irritably.

"Hm?" He replied, while unwrapping the food he bought.

"This is good, want some?"

I wanted to slap myself. I was referring to what he was doing to me right now.

"Crazy." I mumbled, but I made sure to let him hear it.

He smiled at me before taking a bite of his sandwich. He drank the juice he bought. He faced me like he was waiting for my food.

I sighed and put my food down on the table. I shook my head and slightly leaned my face toward him.

"My full name is Jasper Jean Mariano. My nickname is J. I'm a senior in high school, 17 years old, and I'm almost 18 in May because food is life..." I dragged out the word "fooooood. I don't like to be kicked, and trash-talk. Every breath I take is followed by a sigh. That's the last thing... I DON'T... I don't like this thing we're doing. It's stupid!"

He just stared at me quietly, like he was shocked by what I said. True, we looked like idiots. We've known each other for years and I've kissed! And now we're here, introducing ourselves to each other.

What the heck?!

He slightly turned his head. "So, 'Not Interested' isn't your answer?"

I slapped my forehead. Seriously, this guy is annoying! I was just slamming my head on the table. Why am I torturing myself?

I almost forgot that this guy was in Section E.

Such a fool...

I raised my head and continued eating. I finished, but I was still hungry. I glanced at Yuri's food. He probably bought sandwiches.

I just nodded, but honestly, I had already snatched one sandwich I was talking.

"You said you're in 4th year, what section are you in?" He asked.

I started devouring the sandwich I took. I was just being hungry. I want to keep buying food. Life's tough right now!

"Section E," I answered between bites.

He seemed amazed by what I said. "Really? Wow, I'm all alone here. Huh?

I just went along with his act. I played it up like he did.

"Really?! That's awesome, right?" I said, while reaching for the sandwich near him.

"We're both going to school together." He suggested.

I could save on fare!

I nodded brightly at him. "Sure!" Then I grabbed another sandwich.

He was still smiling at me. He grabbed one of the sandwiches and ate it. It seemed like he didn't notice his food was running out.

While continuing to eat, he handed me some of the remaining sandwich.

When we were done eating, he immediately invited me to supposed to go to school together. He looked like a child a new friend.

So happy, smiling, and unable to contain his joy.

I guess if he had been like this the first time we met—real time—we probably would have become friends right away wouldn't be like this now.

Such a mess...

When we arrived at school, I waited for him to park properly. I just grimaced while watching him.

I looked around and saw a few students staring at us, which

I didn't know what they were talking about, but it seemed

"What's going on?" Yuri asked, looking at the students going building.

I ran toward them. I tried to squeeze into the curious student tarpaulin greeted me. It was attached to a large plywood two wooden posts.

Notice for Demolition!

Notice for Demolition!

"I can't do anything about that. I know you've known for Board Members wanted this building demolished, but you opposed it," she said, adjusting her books. "...And now that isn't here to support you, nothing can stop what the whole

Mr. Fernandez? That's Kuya Angelo. Why isn't he here and understand.

"But Ma'am... You can see it! This building is fine. It's better to demolish it?" Sir asked irritably.

The Guidance Counselor chuckled, which annoyed me. It was funny about it. Sir was right. Even though the paint was peeling, the building was dusty and full of grime, the walls were clean

"It's sturdy, but look at the surroundings. It looks like a garbage dump. The walls are full of vandalism! And the students? They don't come here to study!" Ma'am pointed at Sir.

"...If I had it my way, I'd demolish even the Section E students. The reason they're here is because they have backers or their parents are influential. But they're dirtying this school with their behavior."

Sir took a deep breath, trying to control his anger. "Section E is the reason this building is like this. You ordered the old desks and even old books to be dumped here. Other students who came here made this mess, not them."

Sir stood there, wiping his face several times. I could feel people behind me, so I turned around.

It was Section E, except for their leader.

"What now?" Ci-N asked sadly.

"As long as we graduate early, I'm fine with it," Eren said immediately gave him a smack on the back of the head.

I looked at Yuri when I noticed he was looking at Sir seriously.

He walked toward Sir.

"I thought Angelo was the one blocking the Board Member. It seem like he didn't do anything now?" Yuri asked.

Sir shook his head. "He didn't show up at the last meeting about the issues with their company."

So Kuya was the one helping Sir Alvin stop the demolition. But what does the company issue have to do with this? What if there's a problem?

Sir turned to face us sadly but tried to smile. "Go back to work. I need to make a call."

The rest of Section E walked out one by one. Yuri grabbed

Oh, that's right. Kuya Angelo and Sir Alvin knew each other probably why he was so against the demolition. Everything to him.

"This is so annoying! Just when we needed Keifer, now he's said angrily.

Keifer is leaving?! Should I celebrate?!

"Why is Keifer leaving?" Ci asked sadly.

"Yeah, he didn't tell us anything," Mayo added.

Edrix slammed his foot on the table as he sat down. "He's going to the school committee. He's going to be gone for a month.

A month?!

'I'm giving you space.'

I remembered what he said to me again. Is this the space month? What about his birthday? What about his studies

I looked at his spot behind me and caught Yuri staring at me when he realized I was looking at him.

"What's he gonna do while he's gone for a month?" David

"He's proposing." David answered, blushing. "His birthday

Even though it's true!

There was a pain in my chest as I thought that maybe he come back. If you have billions, what's the point of coming back? He could buy a school, classmates, and a woman who would have more than enough money.

"Keifer will come back," Ci-N whispered while looking at the ground.

I ruffled his hair and smiled at him. "Maybe not. Maybe not. I pretended to joke."

He pouted while trying to fix his hair. I really didn't get it. He was such a mess. That's why I didn't want to believe him. He was confusing.

I just hope that when he comes back, he fixes everything. I also hope he returns soon because of the huge mess he left. I won't be anything for him to come back to.

Chapter 220: No longer the

Jay-jay's POV

I've been staring at the big

"Notice for Demolition"

sign for a while now. I can only see the back, but that's e

I'm currently on the second floor, eating lunch while wat
fight.

"Get out of here! I'll flick you!" Percy said, annoyed.

"I'll gouge your eyes out!" Ci-N threatened.

Ci-N followed me here, thinking I'd join him to eat the f
refused and went straight to the second floor.

"Can I have this?" Ci said happily, taking a pizza slice.

"Your face is so thick! That's not for you!" Percy said, ar
grab what she took.

They've been like this ever since they met. I should have

he happily accepted it. Percy looked at me seriously, as if I was thinking about a problem.

"Is it the Demolition Notice you're worried about?" he asked.

Ci looked at me for a moment before continuing to eat. I gave no response.

The truth is, that's not the only thing on my mind. No matter how hard I try to convince myself not to believe or hope for anything from the Ulupongs, nothing changes. I keep hoping even though I know it's pointless.

The painful part is that a big part of me is holding on to the hope that he would come back after giving me space.

But it seems like he's already boarded his own spaceship and is never coming back.

"Don't think about it. He loves you," Ci said absentmindedly, continuing to eat.

Percy frowned at him. If I wasn't used to his behavior, I probably would have slapped him hard.

"Is this really how he is?" Percy asked, pointing at Ci-N. "...A hungry idiot, and talking to himself."

I nodded. "He bites too."

habit.

Percy was starting to tear up from the pain, so I stopped.

"Ci... Let go," I said boredly, and he let go.

He turned back to his food and resumed eating. Percy was holding his finger, which was turning almost black from the bite. Tears were in his eyes while he gave Ci-N a dirty look.

Ci-N acted like he didn't notice.

For a moment, my worries faded because of them. But then the thought I said earlier came back to my mind. Maybe he really won't.

It's possible. Maybe it's better if I just accept that it's true and stop holding any more hope. So it won't hurt as much when that day comes.

I heard my phone ring. I picked it up, and of course, there was a message from my daily textmate who's always acting crazy.

From: GagongBaliw

Message: eat well... Ptba ka, para mlamn.

I wanted to think that he was being concerned. But since he's an Ulupong too, I know what he meant by "malamalam."

I ignored it and just looked around. I caught sight of some

The two were about to exchange some sharp words when my name from downstairs.

"JAY-JAY!" someone shouted.

I walked toward the stairs to go down, and that's when I calling me. It was Eren.

"Jay! It's your cousin!" he greeted me.

I didn't wait for him to say anything else. I immediately building, pushing through the students who were clearly

I almost shoved everyone out of my way to get closer to

But even before I could get any closer, I could already see happening.

The Horoscope!

Sections A and D were ganging up on Aries. They were Kiko and Aries' friend. But I couldn't understand what w

I saw Ella crying while Mica was hugging her. Freya, on seemed like she was just watching a boring show. She w nails and sighing.

"What's happening?! Aries the great... Where's your cou
"What's happening?!" Aries the great... Where's your cou

I couldn't see Aries' face clearly because he was facing s
could see blood on parts of his face and uniform.

I was about to go to them to intervene, but someone grab
I looked, Yuri was looking at me with concern.

"Don't move yet... You might make things worse for Arie

What he said was true. There were two sections involve
were ganging up on him. If I acted recklessly, I didn't kn
might do.

I reluctantly decided to just watch them. My fists were c
could feel the heat rising as if I wanted to punch someon

Should I punch this person in front of me?

"Poor Aries," said a girl near us.

"Come on, Jelaii! You feel sorry for him, even though he
you!" said the girl next to her.

They were so loud! I wanted to shout at them!

A bit of a block from two students made me move positi
view of Aries. I was in a good spot now, facing him.

"Babe! Poor Aries," said another girl in front of me, whc
"I'm sorry."

crying and calling themselves forever alone. When they start fighting.

Unbelievable...

I was forced to return to my previous spot. I sat next to Yuri back at Mykel. I covered my mouth when I saw Mykel punch Aries's stomach. Aries fell to his knees while being held by two guards in Section D.

"Yuri! We have to do something!" I urged.

They delivered another punch and kick to Aries. He coughed, and it looked like he might lose consciousness.

I couldn't take it anymore. I was about to rush in and punch Yuri's face, but then... Percy?

Percy was in the middle, picking his nose.

"What's he doing there?!" Felix asked, surprised.

I was surprised too. He looked like he had no idea what was happening while watching the fight. Since he was in the middle, everyone started staring at him.

"Hey! Get out of here! You're in the way!" Mykel yelled

... ..

"That's some thick skin." I whispered.

Aries slightly raised his head and looked at the person in
brow furrowed slightly.

"P-Percy? W-What... What are you d-doing here?" he asked
whispering.

Percy scratched his neck. "I'm delivering."

Tsk! He's delivering food for me.

Mykel studied Percy closely, and it seemed like he recognized
looked at Freya for a moment, then back at Percy.

"You're Freya's boyfriend! But you're dead! How—"

"Correction!" Freya said loudly. "...Ex-boyfriend."

Suddenly, Percy grabbed his chest like he was hurt for some
reason. He dropped to his knees while staring at Freya.

This is over the top!

"Ouch! Argh! It hurts!" he said. "...Freya killed me."

He suddenly collapsed on the floor like he had fainted. I
him to get him to leave since he was stealing the spotlight
him first. He grabbed Percy's wrist and pretended to lead

"What the hell! What are you doing?! And you!" Mykel
"...Get out of here! I'll flick you!"

"What's it to you?!" Ci-N retorted, running towards us.

That sounds like something I would say.

Percy got up from the floor and dusted himself off. He used a handkerchief to wipe his face.

"Crazy... You killed me off already," Percy said to Ci-N.

"Hey! I don't care where you came from! Get out of here and stay in your coffin!" Mykel shouted angrily.

"I don't want to!" Percy protested. "...But you can if you

Mykel was clearly getting annoyed with him. Even Section D getting irritated by Percy's actions.

Percy flashed a big smile at him. "You want to come with me? I came from?"

Mykel lost it completely. He lunged at Percy with a punch, but Percy dodged it effortlessly. Percy even laughed when he saw Mykel's

He faced Aries. "You let this weakling bring you down?"

Aries couldn't even respond. Section D released him and

"I didn't want to fight someone younger than me," he said with no choice.

It seemed like nothing to him as he landed a punch on the man who came at him. He didn't even sweat on the next hit, looking like he punched the next one.

The women screamed in fear, while the men cheered for him.

I looked at Mykel when he circled around to Percy's back with the baseball bat. I immediately ran when I saw him about to swing. Just as I got closer, someone's foot... a foot?

Yes! Someone kicked Mykel in the face. Ci-N had done it. The idiot. The Kid was so happy.

"Yes! I've wanted to do that for so long! I'm just gonna go!" he said, raising his hands in victory.

He's crazy! That was a strong hit.

As far as I know, Mykel and his older brother are close. I must know all of his crazy antics.

I completely forgot that I was about to approach Percy. I was in the middle of the people rushing toward Percy. I was about to run, but it looked like it wasn't necessary anymore.

"Why aren't you leaving yet?!" I asked frantically.

"Isn't it obvious? We're struggling to help Aries!" Ella said.
I swear, this is frustrating!

I tried to lift Aries up. They helped me, but we were near the ceiling because of his weight.

"Let's take him to the clinic!" I said, but Ella suddenly stopped.
"They won't accept him there," she said.

I looked at her and Mica, and they both looked serious. Why wouldn't they accept him there?

I squeezed my eyes shut. "Tsk! Let's just take him to our room."
They both nodded, so we all worked together to carry him. It felt like we were carrying ten sacks of rice because of his weight.

No one even bothered to help us. When we got to our room, we laid him down and quickly looked for something we could use to lay him on.

The only thing I found was Eman's apron. I spread it out on the floor and let him lie down. His face was bruised and swollen from the injury. He was unconscious but struggling to move.

"Don't you have a first aid kit here?" Ella asked, her voice

Even all these things happening, I don't get them either. I who also seemed worried about Aries' condition.

"What's happening? Why did they do this to Aries? I thought they were his friends?" I asked both of them.

They both looked at me, hesitant about whether to tell me. Ella took my hand, as if saying it was okay to tell me.

"They put Aries down from his throne," she said, almost as if to say since Angelo is down, Aries is the same."

I was stunned by Ella's words. Why did Aries have to be the one who was happening with my brother? Yes, their company is close, but it doesn't mean they are too.

They're a bunch of hypocrites...

"They looked up to Aries because he was connected to Angelo. Angelo made him a king in this school, but now that Angelo is gone, everything is gone for Aries too," Ella added, crying.

I just sat down on the floor. I felt like everything was my fault. My desire to escape that wedding, I had to sacrifice my brother. And now, even the life they were used to is slipping away.

This is the price for my selfishness.

Chapter 221: The real Kin

Jay-jay's POV

"Here's the first aid kit," Eman said, handing a red pouch.

"T-thank you," Ella said as she took the pouch.

She opened it and took out some cotton and alcohol. She dabbing Aries' face.

I looked at them, feeling useless. I wanted to call Tita or was afraid of what they'd say. I knew I was the one responsible.

"Jay..." Ci-N called me while sitting beside me. "...Why?"

I looked at him. "They said they wouldn't be accepted at brought them here."

"Keifer might get mad," he whispered to me.

"That Kumag isn't here," I replied.

I hugged my knees and buried my head. I didn't know what to do.

I felt embarrassed in front of my brother because of what I did.

"I think we need to take him to the hospital," Kit said, looking at Ella.

I looked at Ella, who was also looking at me. It was like me to agree. I wanted to say yes because that's what Aries of me was scared. My brother would get mad.

"A-what... I think—" I didn't finish my sentence because started to rise.

I crawled over to him. He was whispering something that I didn't understand. Ella held his hand, and we both leaned down to hear clearly.

"S-si Jay-jay... D-don't..." He said, breathing deeply. "...come closer... M-m-mykel."

Ella and I exchanged looks. He didn't want me near Mykel, but why, but I had no intention of listening to him. What Ciri wasn't enough. I needed to get back at Mykel.

Suddenly, his breathing deepened. Ella panicked and did the same. I was also nervous seeing his chest rise and fall so irregularly.

Shit! Aries has a problem with his brain... or was it his lungs?

"Let's take him to the hospital!" Ella said, crying.

I also felt like I was about to cry because of the way my breathing was shallow, he had cuts, bruises, and blood on his face. We were angry at each other, but I couldn't deny that I was scared.

"Aries! We're almost at the hospital!" Ella cried.

"Hold on, Dude! We're almost there!" Yuri said, and I looked at him.

That's when I realized he was worried too. It was the first time I saw him genuinely care about Aries.

We arrived at the hospital. Yuri carried Aries inside the emergency room. Doctors and nurses arrived to take care of him.

"Please wait here... We'll take care of the patient," one of the nurses said, pulling the curtain in front of us.

We had no choice but to step aside and wait in the waiting area. I went outside a while to park the car in the hospital parking lot. While I was there, I saw Percy at the entrance and saw Percy.

I stood up and slightly raised my hand so he could see me. He looked disappointed because he immediately walked over to us,

"How is Aries?" he asked me.

"He's inside, they're taking care of him," I said softly.

He nodded and went back inside the hospital.

I didn't want Ella to hear. I knew she knew about my engagement. She might blame me too, and I didn't want to start any drama at the hospital.

He sighed deeply a few times and touched his temple. I noticed there were some scratches and marks that he probably got from earlier.

"You should go back to your school. I'll call Angelo," he pulled out his cellphone from his pocket.

"W-wait... I want to know how Aries is doing," I said, my voice almost on the verge of crying.

"I'll just call you. Go back to school."

I bit my lower lip. I wanted to stay here. I wanted to make sure everything would be okay.

Percy dialed a number on his phone. I stepped back from him to face my brother. I was afraid.

He would turn into Hulk.

I looked at Ella, who was still hunched over, crying. My vision blurred, and my breathing deepened.

I turned my back on them without saying anything. Each

Instead of answering, all I could do was sob. My arms in wrapped around him.

"It's all my fault," I said between sobs.

I didn't care if we were still at the hospital. I didn't care if looking at us. If they thought we were in a drama, then th ones.

Is it wrong to cry in public?!

"Sshhh... Don't think like that," he said, letting me bury i

I closed my eyes. Why was this person so kind to me?! I wanted to be a saint, playing the martyr. Of all the peopl was the one who just took it all in stride.

Damn, so much kindness! Share it!

Slowly, I stopped crying. I didn't say anything until he as with him. He was going to ask me to eat, but I quickly m needed to return to school.

He agreed, and he started the car, heading back to school commotion among the students even though the scene fr over. They were gossiping as soon as we arrived.

"Poor Aries, huh?"

I nodded and walked toward our building. We were getting into the room when I noticed some of the snakes and other students in a commotion.

This day really was cursed!

Yuri started running, so I did the same. As we got closer, I saw Mykel fighting. Mica was surrounded by David, Eren, and K.

"Go ahead! Knock him down!" someone from Mykel's group yelled.

Calix's face was covered in blood, but he still wouldn't stop kicking.

"Stop it!" Mica cried, her voice trembling. "...Leave Calix alone!"

Yuri and I immediately stepped between them. I punched Mykel, sending him to the floor. His angry glare was directed at me.

His group panicked and tried to charge at us, but Yuri stepped in, blocking them.

"STOP!" he shouted, his voice commanding.

The troublemakers stared at us. Mykel slowly stood up, looking at me from the side of his lip.

"Mykel... Why are you here?" Yuri asked, his voice calm.

"Get out of here," I said firmly.

Mykel approached me, smiling as he pointed at my forehead.

"You don't get to decide what happens here," he said coldly.

"Get out, Mykel. Leave Mica alone," Yuri said, now facing me.

They locked eyes, sizing each other up like they were testing strength and resolve.

"Just because Watson isn't around, you think you can act the strongest here. What can you do? Huh? Hanamitchi?"

He taunted.

Yuri didn't respond but kept his eyes fixed on Mykel. When he came, Mykel started laughing. His group joined in with him.

They were all crazy.

"You're nothing!" one of Mykel's friends from Section D said.

"You're just like Aries," another added.

"What do you expect from the Section E people?" Mykel asked.
"...They're only tough when Watson is around. But he's not here, so they're all useless!"

"I've had enough of you!" he said. "...You and your cousins are annoying."

"Let go of Jay-jay," Yuri ordered.

Mykel still held onto the collar of my uniform. He looked at me with a small laugh.

"Make me," he challenged.

Yuri started to step forward, but Mykel suddenly pulled me back. Chaos broke out in Section D when other snakes tried to

That jerk took the chance to pull me further away from them.

I tried to fight back, but he was tugging at my uniform, and if he pulled me away from him, I might end up exposed.

They'd see my... bill-bills!

"What the heck! Where are you taking me?!" I asked angrily.

"I'm going to teach you a lesson. You need to learn to respect the King."

New King?! Did he declare that himself? He was so full of himself. He knocked Aries down just to say he was the new king. How dare he!

We reached the front of the main building, the same place where we had started.

Mykel pointed at me while walking around me. "I'm so a girl."

Freya looked at me and raised an eyebrow. I ignored her

I chose to face Mykel, who was pacing around, thinking

Teachers passed by, some curious, but when they saw me just left and pretended they hadn't seen anything.

So annoying!

"Hold her," Mykel suddenly said.

Two guys from Section A started to approach me. Panick kicked one of them in the stomach. The other stopped, lo

"Idiots! It's just one girl! And you can't even handle her!" angrily.

I didn't notice how close Mykel was until it was too late. for a punch, and he hit me in the stomach.

"Ugh!" I groaned as I fell to my knees.

The students around us screamed. My vision blurred from knees felt weak.

It felt like my insides were turning

My arms were trembling as I tried to stand up. I looked at him and did that. I was both scared and surprised when I saw him.

The look on his face was one of someone ready to kill. It was like he'd fought with a comb. He was wearing a simple t-shirt, but his face was full of rage.

Those were the reasons I almost didn't recognize him. Was he a completely different person...

It was Kuya Angelo.

Everything stopped when they saw him. Some of the men, some were so scared they probably peed their pants.

I glanced at his side when Yuri and the other snakes arrived.

It seemed like they had just finished fighting with Section 9. When they saw Kuya, they also stopped in their tracks.

"K-Kuya..." I called to him, but it was barely a whisper.

As Mykel slowly stood up, Kuya began walking toward me. His eyes and mouth were covered in blood. It was clear he was dying properly.

"Who do you think you are?" Kuya asked calmly.

"... .."

We were all shocked by his reaction. Kuya had only pun it had such an effect on Mykel.

Plus, the look on his face was like a knife. I'd seen him a this was different.

It was so different!

For reasons I couldn't understand, it was like I saw Keife there was a similarity in the way Keifer, Yuri, Percy, and Kuya Angelo's and Keifer's anger was something else.

I snapped out of my thoughts when someone helped me along with David and Felix.

"What hurts?" Felix asked.

I shook my head and looked back at Kuya. He was still s Mykel.

"W-who do you think you are?" Mykel asked angrily, bu fear in his voice.

Kuya Angelo grabbed Mykel by the collar and brought h

"I am... Your worst nightmare," he said, pushing Mykel a

The guys from Section A quickly approached the jerk on

It felt like my tongue had frozen, and I couldn't speak. Kuya tried to approach me, but a loud shout of his name stopped him.

We all turned to see where it came from. From the main entrance, the Guidance Counselor was walking toward us, taking long strides.

"What do you think you're doing?!" Ma'am said. "...You're trespassing on school grounds! Do you know we could file a case against you?"

Kuya's eyes were lifeless as he looked at her. "Then sue me."

The counselor was furious, practically steaming with rage. Her veins on her forehead were bulging from anger.

"You have some nerve!"

"You might be forgetting something," Kuya said calmly, but his expression gradually changed.

The same cold look returned to Kuya's eyes. I could see the same cold look in the Guidance Counselor's eyes, but she tried to hide it.

"...I am the King here! I'm the reason this school is still standing. Technically, I own this school, and here you are, disrespecting me!" Kuya said angrily. "...Who has the audacity, huh?"

"You're disrespectful!" the counselor yelled, holding her finger. "I've never shown any respect!"

"You're done, Angelo. You have nothing left to brag about. I'll scare us anymore!" Ma'am said arrogantly. "...You think you can scare yourself!"

Kuya laughed softly, which confused all of us. "I don't need to intimidate people. You know that... Maybe you want me to go back to school again and bring your students along with it."

The counselor took a step back, looking pale. Some students stepped in to support her to prevent her from falling.

"I heard a rumor once that this school burned down because Kuya had no idea Angelo was involved in that," Yuri said, not

I felt even more scared. I didn't know Kuya was capable of that. Burn down the school?!

"I'm still the King," he said, smiling.

Chapter 222: Island

Jay-jay's POV

I'm alone again. That feeling I had before is back. The feeling is unacceptable. This time, it's not from my classmates but from the doctor taking care of me.

"The patient's vitals are stable. You don't have to worry about tissue damage anymore; it responded well to the medication," the doctor told Tita Gema.

Tito Julz and Kuya Angelo immediately breathed a sigh of relief, how I should have felt too, but guilt overwhelmed me.

Because no matter how you look at it, everything started

"...I suggest a longer rest for the patient. It would also be good to have some light exercise." The doctor continued.

Tita Gema asked more questions that I couldn't understand. I looked at Ella, who was tightly holding Aries' hand. She was looking off him.

"I'm sorry." I whispered as I watched them.

"What did Angelo say to you?" He asked.

I shook my head. He hadn't said anything since we left so I wanted to go straight home, but Kuya brought me to the

Percy smiled and touched my head. "You're too stressed.

I didn't say anything else and just followed him. It felt like what happened earlier made me hungry. I was scared to go back because of what Kuya said to our Guidance Counselor.

We went to a fast-food restaurant near the hospital. Percy While eating, I was still deep in thought.

I really didn't know what to do anymore.

I wanted to talk to Yuri's family. But it felt like I was being after answering back their Head Master. Plus, I ignored Yuri's request. What face could I even show them?

Could I show Author's face?

(A/N: Damn this! Yuri might fall in love with me.)

I was starting to regret my decision not to go through with it. If I did, I knew I wouldn't be happy, and Yuri might feel

"So, the wedding with Yuri is off." Percy suddenly said,

I looked down. I felt guilty again. If only I could do something to help without needing to get married.

"Where's the necklace I gave you?"

I looked at him, puzzled. He was serious, waiting for my answer. I took the necklace from the secret pocket and opened it. I took the necklace from the secret pocket.

Before I could even hand it to him, he snatched it from my hand. He was startled, but even more so when he removed the ring Yuri gave me.

He handed the necklace back to me. "Wear it."

To be honest, I hadn't worn the necklace because I was nervous. It was a time. On the day I called David to send a message to Yuri, I took the necklace off.

He waited for me to put it back on before speaking.

"I'll return this to him."

"W-why?"

"Just because. And if possible, stay away from him."

My eyebrows furrowed completely. I didn't understand his reasoning. I quickly took the ring from his hand.

"What's your problem? Why are you acting like this?" I asked.

I quickly stood up and walked out of the restaurant. He followed me immediately.

"Jay-jay." He called me.

I didn't stop walking.

"Go home, Percy. Felix might be looking for you."

"What's the problem?" he asked irritably.

I quickly turned to face him and glared at him angrily. I was walking by and stared at us.

"You are the problem! I'm mad at you because you won't listen."

"Because you don't need to know everything right away."

His words made me stop in my tracks. He's right. Who am I to tell me those things?

"Not everything is about you, Jay. And those things, we'll talk about first before we let anyone else know." He explained and smiled.

I bit my lower lip in frustration. I didn't look to see where he went. I returned to the hospital and went to Aries' room.

This is so frustrating!

I approached Aries, whose face was covered in bandages. His face was even blackened. His appearance was really dis

"Jay-jay..." Tita called me, forcing a smile. "...Come with them. They're going home."

"T-Tita..." I couldn't stop my voice from cracking. "...I'm sorry. Aries got hurt by his classmates."

Tita held my hand. "Don't blame yourself. Don't ever do that."

"Your Tita's right," Tito Julz chimed in. "...They wanted to see you. It wasn't you."

"B-but..." If we hadn't called off the wedding, they would have and people would still look up to Aries.

I couldn't finish what I was going to say because Tita's grip on my hand. She smiled at me, as if telling me, "It's okay."

I tried to return her smile. We talked a bit more before I left. Ella was waiting for me outside the room. We walked to the parking lot.

I thought Kuya Angelo would already be in the car, but he wasn't when we arrived.

I scanned around and saw him in a corner, smoking a cigarette.

"Just to relieve stress," he said flatly. "...Let's go. We still have Ella."

We got into the car together. He opened the door and sat. I sat in the passenger seat and Ella was in the back.

No one spoke. It was so quiet, the silence was deafening, racing with thoughts. I felt uncomfortable.

We stopped in front of a bungalow house. It was simple but so extravagant. Ella got out and thanked Kuya.

Now I realized that what they said about Ella not being vain was true. Their life was so simple—something she made complicated.

We arrived at the house. Kuya slumped onto the sofa and closed his eyes. No one welcomed us, so the maids were probably asleep.

"Get some rest," he said without looking at me.

But I didn't move. I stared at him as I gathered the words to say.

"K-Kuya—"

"Don't continue," he cut me off. "...I just want to rest."

I felt embarrassed. I went to the room without saying anything.

As soon as I closed the door, all the tears I had been holding back came out.

I heard my phone ring. I took it out of my bag, and a text

To: GagongBaliw

Message: Missing you now. 😊

I wiped my tears and quickly called GagongBaliw. It rang and they answered.

"Don't say anything yet," I said as soon as they picked up.

"...Just listen to me, please. Just listen to what I have to say. I need you."

I didn't hear anything from their end, so I continued speaking.

"My sibling got hurt because of me..." I took a deep breath. "...Because I chose not to go through with the wedding time. But... it came at a great cost..."

I wiped the tears that slipped from my eyes. "...Now, the pain is suffering. They look down on my cousin and my sibling."

I couldn't stop. I started crying like a child. My sniffles and tears. I didn't want them to hear my pain, so I ended the call. It took a long time before I received another text.

To: GagongBaliw

For some reason, I don't understand, my crying slowly stopped like it was stopping on its own, even without me trying to.

"I feel like I'm all alone. There's no one I can lean on. I've been so bad, even though I've always felt alone. Maybe it's because of me beside me.

I'm stupid if I'm stupid. I'm an idiot if I'm an idiot, but at least I'm looking for him and wanting to see him.

"...Keifer." I whispered, and suddenly the line went dead.

I didn't understand why. I slowly crawled over to the bed and didn't even bother changing my clothes, and because of that I fell asleep.

When I woke up, I felt terrible. I had a fever, and my throat was sore.

I tried to get up and head straight for the bathroom. I needed to go to school. This is the only thing I can do right for Tita Gemma and got ready, even though it felt like there was something heavy down on my head.

When I went to the dining room, no one was there. There was no food for me.

I tried to eat, and I also asked one of the maids for medicine.

I didn't want to argue. My head was heavy, and nothing in my mind. I had no words to snap at him. I walked to his car and opened the door to the passenger seat. I got in without saying a word.

He quickly got into the driver's seat and started the car. He drove for a while, though I couldn't clearly see him. As he kept glancing at the cars in front of him had stopped.

He slammed on the brakes so hard I almost hit the front of the car. I fell off the seat. My things spilled out because the zipper was broken.

This is so frustrating! The bag's zipper wasn't even closed.

I picked up the contents of my bag. There was so much trash. I ate the snacks I ate.

"Sorry." Yuri said, trying to help me, but I stopped him.

"Just drive," I told him, continuing to clean up the mess.

I even checked under the seat. By accident, I felt something soft and paper. I thought it came from my bag, so I picked it up. I raised my eyebrow when I saw it was a cigarette pack.

Yuri looked at me. "That's Keifer's," he quickly said, but I didn't want to take back the name he mentioned.

I stared at the pack. Some cigarettes were missing. Suddenly,

"Do you think..." I said absent-mindedly. "...When will he come back?"

Because maybe what Blaster said is true, and he won't come back.

"I don't know." He answered flatly.

Maybe he didn't tell anyone when he left. He didn't even tell his best friend or anyone else. Maybe he really isn't coming back. Maybe he really won't come back to me. It felt like something pierced my heart. I took the cigarette stick back in the pack and placed it in my mouth.

"Didn't you talk to him before he left?" I asked again when he didn't answer.

"No. We never had the chance."

"Can you contact him?"

"He's not responding."

I closed my eyes. Besides the pain I was feeling in my chest, my head was also hurting. I wanted to cry with every movement I made. The pain in my head.

This pain is so annoying! Does it have to be this bad?

I grabbed my head, and with it came a few tears from my eyes. My eyes were still closed.

This pain is just so frustrating! It hurts my body and my mind.

"Shit! You're burning up!" he said in surprise, quickly sta

I didn't know what he was going to do, but then he sudde
front of the hospital. Before I could protest, he was alrea
and opening the passenger door.

"W-what are you—" I didn't get to finish what I was goin
suddenly, he picked me up bridal style.

I could clearly see the worry on his face. He kept calling
would attend to me until I was placed on a bed in the em

"We'll take care of everything here." One of the nurses sa

Yuri slightly moved away while watching the nurses, but
eyes off him.

Why are you like this, Yuri? I'm annoyed with you.

I'm annoyed with you because you're so kind. I'm annoy
because it was me you loved. I'm annoyed with you beca
have no chance, but you're still here. I'm annoyed with y
like I'm looking into a mirror and you're my reflection.

It shows how foolish I am when it comes to love. Why is

Why does it have to be complicated? Can't we just date,
and then eventually be together? Why do we both have t

Chapter 223: Her concern

Jay-jay's POV

I've been eating alone in the Dining for a few days now. evening, it's just me. I haven't seen any sign of Tita Gem at home. Even Mama, who just arrived, I didn't see.

All I could see was her suitcase.

Even my sickness didn't reach them. Thank goodness I v day. Thanks to Yuri, who took care of everything.

I just finished taking a bath and was getting ready when ring. There were only two people I was expecting to text GagongBaliw.

I picked up my phone. The second person I was expectin

To: GagongBaliw

Message: Good morning! Take care of yourself.

Reading his texts has become part of my daily routine. I from texting me anymore. It feels like he's become a par

"Perfect! I have nothing to do, I'm available." I quickly r

He laughed again. We arrived at school, and I waited for getting out of the car. It felt like just another normal day

The talk about Aries and Mykel quickly died down. Even Kuya and his threat to our Guidance Counselor wasn't di

Maybe they were scared of Kuya.

The Demolition Notice was still there beside our building

There was no date listed for when the demolition would

I continued walking to the room. Yuri followed behind, and entered, it felt like something was wrong.

Something was definitely wrong!

Some pairs of tables and chairs were missing. There used to be why it was easy to switch seats, but now it was just enou

There were 16 of us, and with me, it made 17. The only one at the back where the "King" used to sit and the one where I used to sit beside David and Ci-N.

"Why... is this like this?" I muttered to myself.

"Good morning, Jay!" Ci-N greeted me harshly as he ran

Because of the arrangement of the seats, I had no choice my seat in the middle. Ci-N happily grabbed my arm and down.

I almost smiled when I saw the chair. My skirt was still s
This was the bench where my skirt got stuck before.

I chose to ignore it. I got my things in order.

I looked at David when I noticed he was staring at me.

He was grinning like an idiot.

"Why are you grinning like that?" I asked irritably.

"I miss having you as my seatmate." He said.

I raised an eyebrow. Miss? He was always asleep when v
Only when he smelled food did he wake up.

Should I knock him out?

When I looked to the other side, Ci-N was greeting me w

"I missed this." he said, raising his eyebrows.

Someone didn't take their medicine.

I just winced. When I looked around, everyone else was

it.

During the class, something small hit my head. I looked continued until the next subject.

When I looked again, it was a small piece of paper crum

I glanced around, but everyone seemed indifferent, prete

Why do I feel like this has happened before? Déjà vu?

As the class continued, more small papers started hitting beginning to get irritated by what they were doing.

What are these people up to now?

It was finally lunchtime. The bell rang loudly outside. Ci my hand before I could stand.

"Eat here." he said happily.

Before I could protest, he pulled me towards Eman, who lunch.

"H-Hey, I can't." I said, and they looked at me. "...Somec me."

"He's not coming." Felix said while smiling. "...I texted l you're here with us joining us "

"Let's go, Jay. Eat." Drew invited me.

I glared at him. "Don't talk to me, we're not close."

He just scratched the back of his head while walking away. "Jerk! You haven't even paid me back the money you owe me. I've reached Part Two and everything."

Not long after, someone dropped food in front of me. It was whatever animal you could boil—for our dish, so automatically.

It's like the jokes of the Author. Corn!

I looked to see who the traitor was who put this in front of me, smiling while looking at me.

"Let's eat." He said, but I immediately shook my head. "No."

"If I eat this, I lose." I quickly said, and he sighed.

I looked towards the door and saw Josh holding a plate of food. It wasn't for him. It was for his pet cat, which Ci-N name sounds like "EveryDAY."

An idea popped into my head. I quickly stood up and grabbed the food, went outside without looking back at the snakes, even though they were calling my name.

~~~~~

you should do it yourself."

He walked back to the room, but before he passed me, he

"Enjoy feeding Edy." He said, like it had a different mea

He left, leaving me alone. I didn't get his vibe, and it felt  
was taking over him.

Maybe he's been impacted?!

I faced Edy, who was currently eating. I was about to lo  
front of him when my stomach growled. The sound was  
screaming 'Food! Food! Food!'.

I looked closely at the food I was holding. If I eat this, I'll  
up in the pride competition. But if I don't eat, my stomach  
breath will stink.

The little brat might complain.

I looked around. Josh was right, no one could see me her

I glanced around again before deciding to sit on a bench  
down and took a bite of the rice and dish.

One bite, but I couldn't taste it. Another bite, but it felt bl  
and I could sort of taste it. I chewed a little and... took ar

In this way, I wouldn't lose in their eyes. I'd just say I gave up. That's probably why he said that to me before he left.

"Enjoy feeding Edy." Maybe he meant "enjoy feeding me."

As I was finishing, someone suddenly grabbed my shoulder to my surprise while still chewing corn in my mouth. I almost choked. I was holding.

To my surprise, it was Mica—who was the one who grabbed me.

"S-sorry." She said.

I bit the corn before pulling it out of my mouth. "It's fine here?"

She forced a smile. "I just came to visit you."

I wasn't sick. What was her deal? Why did she decide to come here after been a few days since we last saw each other. She should have stayed instead.

I noticed the sadness in her eyes. It seemed like something she was looking for someone to talk to.

"Sit down. You surprised me, I'm still eating." I said.

She sat on the bench, and I did the same. I finished my food.

"Did something happen?" I asked, worried.

"We're breaking up, me and Calix." She said continuously as she fell.

I panicked, so I quickly grabbed the tissue from the pouch and gave it to her, and she accepted it.

"W-Why? W-What happened?"

She didn't answer again. She just kept crying. It was as if the pain she was carrying in her chest had built up, and now she finally had to release it. I panicked even more.

Maybe that guy did something stupid!

"D-did Calix cheat again? What? Did he go back to being with her? Did he do? Did he say anything? W-What's the reason?"

I asked one question after another.

She tried to calm herself down and wipe the tears from her face and took a few deep breaths.

"I already know what they did to you..." I froze. "...I got hurt when we fought. He said I didn't understand, so I shouldn't get involved. He said not to speak..." She bit her lower lip. "...but I couldn't just stop. They were hurting."

Like I said, revenge is for the weak.

I didn't want to drag Mica into this. I didn't want her to g  
sighed.

"But didn't you think that if you break up with him, you'll  
effort I put in to get you two back together? All of it will  
you'll just end up hurting yourselves again?" I explained  
me.

I knew she understood what I meant. I also knew that she  
about me, but the things that happened and the pain I felt  
alone.

I was selfish, so the pain was just mine.

"But Jay—"

I cut her off immediately. "Calix is right. You shouldn't g  
a problem between him and me. If anyone needs to act a  
them, not you."

She looked down and placed her hands on her knees. She  
clenched.

"Don't just let go of your relationship because of a simpl  
tapping her shoulder.



"Calix!" I called, and almost everyone looked at me.

Are all of you Calix?

He stood up, obviously waiting for what I was going to say. I told him to look outside. He did so immediately. Faster than I thought he would, he ran toward Mica.

I didn't look at what was happening outside. I went to my room when I saw some snacks on top of my table. Nova, Chip]

I glanced at the snakes, but they all avoided eye contact.

Pretending like nothing happened. I looked at Ci-N, who was on his cellphone.

"Ci, is this yours?" I asked, and he quickly shook his head. "No," he pouted. "Yours."

I raised an eyebrow. he's really hard to talk to when he's like this. he's so busy with whatever game he's playing. I turned to go to sleep.

Is this guy always sleep-deprived?!

I flicked his forehead hard. He blinked and looked at me.

"Why are you flicking me?" he asked irritably.

"You're disturbing me. I'm trying to sleep." David replied back to his spot.

Before he could lay down again, I spoke up.

"Did you put this here?" I asked.

He stared at the snack for a moment before answering. "I know whose it is."

It's so easy to talk to the people around me. It's so embarrassing.

David went back to sleep. I just scratched the back of my head. I hid the snacks in my bag. Whoever among the snakes goes to the store will just waste their money.

But honestly, this whole situation feels familiar to me. It happened before, but in a different situation.

Weird.

# Chapter 224: Friends

## Jay-jay's POV

"Where are we now?" I asked Yuri insistently.

We've been driving for a while now, but it seems like we're at a Japanese restaurant Yuri was talking about.

I think we're lost. What was supposed to be a meal turned into a chase!

"We're almost there," he replied with a smile.

When will that "almost" actually happen? That's all he ever says. Annoyed, I pouted and just stared out the window. We were far from the city, somewhere deep in the Philippines.

The houses were gone. All I could see were tall trees.

I knew we were on the highway, but I still had no idea where we were headed.

Please don't let this be \*Final Destination\*! Oh my God!

I started to feel nervous even though there was no reason to.

What is this guy planning?

I looked up at the sky. It was almost dark, and we were in  
nowhere.

I glanced at Yuri, and he smiled at me. Oh my God... Is he  
something bad? What if he's planning to... What if he's p

ROB ME! As if... He's richer than me, what would he gain  
like me?

I tried to push the fear out of my mind. I know this snake  
the chance and trust I gave him.

I just looked ahead and frowned when I saw a construction  
bulldozer, a digger, a cement mixer, and other equipment  
project.

Maybe the Japanese restaurant is still being built.

Yuri parked the car beside other vehicles. He got out, and  
looked around, and a large tarpaulin caught my eye.

*\*Opening Soon, (Paradise) Resort.\**

"Paradise," Yuri said, also looking at the tarpaulin. "It's  
Resort."

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"Where are we going to eat? The restaurant you mention built."

He laughed. "Surprise."

I knew it! The meal turned into a rock.

He held my hand, and I was suspicious, but I quickly pul

"Why are you holding my hand? What's this?" I scolded at me, confused.

He scratched the back of his neck, realizing what he did.

I rolled my eyes. "Where are we?"

He awkwardly pointed in a direction. I didn't see anything him to walk ahead, and I'd follow.

He did as I said and went first. As we walked, I looked u
It was completely dark now, and the path we were on wa

I thought we were heading toward the building or house but Yuri suddenly turned and stopped in front of a tunnel I grimaced because it was so dark, and I could barely see tunnel seemed just the right height for him.

"What now? Are we staying here?" I asked irritably.

I looked up as we walked. The lights were beautiful. The vines hanging from the top of the tunnel. When we exited wrapped in small lights greeted us.

There was a sign with an arrow pointing to a small bridge at the end. We headed toward it. I was nervous, but I didn't

When we reached the bridge, there were lights on the railing to touch them, thinking I might get electrocuted. At the end, we completely stopped.

A familiar song started playing, and the pathway was brightly lit on the sides, covered in petals. I wanted to ask or complain but seemed to go along with the situation.

**Oh, thinkin' about all our younger years*

There was only you and me

*We were young, wild, and free.**

We started walking, following the petal-covered pathway, holding his arm.

**Now nothing can take you away from me*

We've been down that road before

And I'm not

And love is all that I need, and I found it there in your heart

*It isn't too hard to see, we're in heaven,"**

he sang.

I couldn't bring myself to smile or sing along. I knew where this was going and I had a feeling where this was going.

The lights on the sides of the pathway were gradually replaced by the end, it pointed to a gazebo surrounded by colorful flowers.

**Oh, once in your life, you find someone*

Who will turn your world around

*Bring you up when you're feelin' down.**

But it seemed like that wasn't our destination. Yuri just took a bouquet of flowers from the table inside. He handed it to me, and we walked away again.

**Now nothin' can change what you mean to me*

Oh, there's lots that I could take

But just hold me now

*'Cause our love will light the way.**

*It isn't too hard to see, we're in heaven,"**

he sang, smiling at me.

Honestly, my palm was itching to hit the back of his neck. I wanted to ask him. I was confused by what he was doing, but I knew he was doing it for me.

We stopped in front of a picnic setup surrounded by small trees. He made me sit down and continued smiling at me.

"For the boyish yet so beautiful girl that I love."

I bit my lower lip. I couldn't bring myself to thank him, but I knew truthfully, I found what he did beautiful.

"Y-Yuri..." I said almost in a whisper, but he ignored me.

Yuri held my cheek and caressed it with his thumb. I could see love in his eyes, but there was also sadness.

He leaned closer and kissed me...

On the forehead!

I was nervous even though he only kissed me there. My heart was beating abnormally fast. It felt like it was doing dribbles.

He faced me again. "Give me another chance, and I'll love you properly."

He sighed and forced himself to look at me with a strained

"I appreciate what you did, but..." It felt like something had been pushed on my chest. "...It's just too fast! We agreed to start over, like you're rushing things."

He held the back of his neck and bowed his head. It was clear that the introduction at the Mini Mart wasn't part of that agreement.

I looked like an idiot introducing myself to him back then.

I wanted us to start over as friends. Not like this, where I had to ask for another chance so quickly.

"S-sorry. I thought..."

I sighed and held the bouquet of flowers. I also removed the hat he placed on my head.

"Thank you for this. What you did was beautiful," I said, "...but you're still rushing things!"

He laughed, and the awkwardness between us disappeared.

"Okay, I won't rush anymore," he said. "...I'll just wait for you instead."

Whut the fvck?!

"Sorry if I rushed things... I totally forgot about our conversation with a smile. "...so, it means that as of now, we're---."

"Friends," I finished for him.

His smile grew wider. "With benefits, huh?"

Without thinking, my hand shot up to slap him. He blocked it and kept laughing. I tried again with my other hand.

"Idiot! You're so stupid!" I said, irritated, as I kept hitting him.

I stopped only when I felt my palm getting sore from all the hitting.

They really are friends... even with all that nonsense! I can't do anything...

"J-joke lang yun. I thought you'd say 'we're just classmates' with eyes sparkling with something like hope.

"...I'm happy that you accepted me as a friend."

It felt light, like there had never been any problems between us. I feel right now. Like we're really starting anew.

"Don't you want the benefits?" he asked, and I swung the door open and hit him.

"Told you he was really asking for it now!"

He stood up, still looking at me. "Let's eat."

Finally! This is what I've been waiting for.

"Of course! Let's eat... Where's the food?" I asked, glancing at the basket he was taking.

He opened it and took out the plates, small plates, glasses. I waited for him to take out the food, but there was none. I saw the things he took out.

I frowned. I was so hungry, and I had been thinking about food earlier.

"Is this our food? Air?" I asked irritably.

He laughed at me again. I was starting to get annoyed with his doing. Add the fact that I was hungry—if I didn't control myself, I might really hit him.

He pulled something out of his pocket. It looked like a small device with an antenna. He pressed something, and it opened. Then he said,

"Is the food ready?" he asked into it.

I heard some kind of signal disruption, and then I realized that

"Ready, Sir," came the response from the other side.

A little while later, a group of people came to us. They bowed and set them down beside us. One of them also had a bag and a bottle of wine.

Once everything was set, they bowed and left.

I thanked them.

"Let's... Eat," he said slowly.

I had already started eating before he could say it. It's his turn to surprise me first. He should've just fed me first.

"Let's go! Eat up!" I said, grabbing more food.

We started eating. We were both a little mad at each other now. With all the food they brought us, I felt like they were going to execute me. But I didn't care, as long as there was a lot of food.

Food is life, baby!

There were times when Yuri would ask me questions while we were talking. Sometimes about Aries, about Mom, and about Kuya Angelo.

"Did Kuya Angelo ever have a girlfriend?" I asked and the glass of wine Yuri handed me.

"Yes, he did. He had a girlfriend."

"Do you guys have any anger toward Kuya?" I asked inn

He looked at me confused. "Why would you ask that?"

I looked away. I raised my knees a little to hug them.

"B-because... I noticed that... that Keifer seemed to have him."

He quickly drank the wine from his glass until it was em water.

"Too much has happened between the five of us. I can't l being mad at Angelo. Especially after the day Percy disa refilled his glass.

I watched him as he drank the wine, deeply serious, like remembering what happened back then.

"If you don't mind me asking... What happened?" I aske

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Yuri's POV

I looked at Jay-jay as she asked. Honestly, part of me wa were really starting to get better between us.

Even if it's just the friendship!

...

My hands were shaking as I drank some water. It felt like accepting the medication the nurse gave me. But the truth wasn't accepting everything that had happened. It was all

"Yuri," Hahaoya called me. "...Keifer is awake."

Even though my legs and thighs were aching, I forced myself into the room where Keifer was confined.

We had only been in the hospital for a day. Even though I had fractures, Hahaoya still decided to confine me.

That accident was a nightmare.

Keifer lost consciousness after being thrown out of the car, and now he was about to learn the truth.

"Remove this thing from me!" Keifer ordered one of the nurses, even though he was clearly still dizzy.

He was trying to pull out the IV needle attached to the back of his head.

"Keifer! Please! Stop! You need to rest!" Hahaoya scolded him.

He calmed down a little. He was taking deep breaths. That's when he would hold his head because of the pain.

"What the hell is going on? Why are we here?" he asked

I wanted to explain it to him gently. But knowing Keifer he didn't understand what was happening.

"Keifer----."

"Where are Aries and Percy?"

I swallowed hard when I heard Percy's name. I didn't know

"Keifer... Aries is in a private room on the next floor," I told him.
"...P-per... Percy..."

"Yuri." His tone suddenly became serious.

I knew he had an idea. It was so hard for me to tell him about

"Percy is...." I suddenly felt numb in my throat. "...Percy is dead from my eye. "...is d-dead."

I didn't hear anything from Keifer. I took a deep breath to hold back tears. He just stared at me, like he wasn't processing what I said.

"This is a joke, right? Is Percy messing around again? Did he mess with you too. I'll make him pay later," he said, genuinely annoyed.
"You tell me his room number? I'll visit him later."

I couldn't answer. I didn't know if he understood what I was saying.

As I moved closer to help him, he quickly grabbed me by the collar.

"Damn it, Yuri! You know how I hate unfunny jokes," he said.

I removed his hand from my collar and matched his glare.

"This isn't a joke! Percy is dead."

He grabbed his head again and sat down on the floor. I wanted to call for a nurse or a doctor, but he grabbed the end of my hospital gown.

"W-what happened?" he asked gently.

"M-maybe we can talk about it later. You need to see a doctor," I said.

He grabbed my shoulder to help himself stand up.

"I don't care! I want to know what happened!" he shouted.

I saw a mix of pain and anger in his eyes. I didn't want to tell him the truth.

He needed to be checked. The pain he was feeling in his head was not normal.

"Yuri!" He shouted, shaking me a little.

"K-keifer... The car fell..." I swallowed hard. "...and Percy is dead."

Chapter 225: Friendship C

Yuri's POV

Continuation of Flashback...

Keifer kept screaming in pain, repeatedly pulling at his h

"We are waiting for the CT scan and MRI results. For no given him pain relievers, which should take effect in a fe doctor said to us.

"Thank you, Doc," Keiren responded.

"No problem. If you need anything or have any question ask."

The doctor left the room. I sat there, staring at Keifer, writhing in pain.

Hahaoya approached and sat next to me. "Yuri, do you v your room? You need to rest."

"Watashi wa koko ni tomaritai." (I would like to stay her

"Dakedo----." (But----)

Keifer's screams gradually stopped until he finally fell as sitting position, and suddenly, my legs and thighs ached

But the pain I felt inside was worse.

"Keifer will be okay, right?" Keiren asked.

I forced a smile. "Of course... It's Keifer after all."

He stood up from the sofa and moved to sit beside me. He with sadness. They were still looking for Keigan, and no happened to Keifer and me.

"I wish Kuya, Keigan was here," I heard Keiren whisper

I ruffled his hair. "We're here for you and your brother."

We talked for a while until we both fell asleep. I only we movement in the room.

When I opened my eyes, I saw Keifer sitting on the edge bed, staring blankly. His eyes were lifeless. Slowly, I sto approached him.

"Keifer... Is something hurting you? I'll laugh----."

"Yuri..." He cut me off. "...Do you still remember anything accident?"

"How is Aries?" He asked again.

The truth is, I haven't visited Aries. Only Angelo has been and he told me not to visit him yet. He still wasn't talking but he seemed good for us to see him right now, as he might think we

"I'm not sure, but Angelo said he's alright."

Suddenly, Keifer stood up and pulled out the IV again. He went out. I tried to follow him, but my thighs hurt.

Just as I stepped out the door, Hahaoya arrived. She looked full of concern as she looked at me.

"Yuri----."

"Please... Could you check on Keiren first? I'll follow Keifer."

I didn't wait for her response. Even though each step hurt, I managed to catch up with Keifer. I reached the elevator just as he entered.

"Where is Aries's room?" he asked seriously.

"You have to rest, Keifer! What do you need from him?!"

He didn't respond. He just pressed the button for the floor we were on. I didn't know what he was planning to do. I couldn't make any movements.

One of the nurses picked up the phone and dialed a number she was planning to call security. I quickly walked over to Keifer.

"Let's visit him later. Maybe he's still---."

"I don't f*cking care!"

"Sir! Please calm down!" a nurse tried to intervene.

"Just tell me his f*cking room!"

"Keifer! Enough!"

Just as several nurses were about to approach, someone slammed him back against the wall.

We all froze. Angelo had no reaction, but Keifer glared at

"What do you think you're doing?" Angelo asked authoritatively.

Keifer quickly shoved him away. "Where's Aries? I just want to see him."

Angelo looked away, and I think he was staring at Aries' room.

"He's resting. Come back another day," he quickly responded.

He was about to push Keifer away, but Keifer blocked him.

They quickly pointed to a room not far from where we were. They then headed there, and I followed. As the door closed...

"Damn it! What were you thinking?! You get too much angry and said to Keifer.

"I want to know what happened! Why did Percy just disappear?"

Angelo looked at me as if questioning why I hadn't said anything. He probably was wondering why I wasn't speaking. I didn't want to. I didn't want it to come from me.

"The car fell-----."

"I already know about that!" He cut Angelo off.

"...I just want to know why you did nothing!"

"We did something." I interrupted. "...We requested a rescue mission search for---."

"What rescue mission?! Are you telling me there's no debris? How can you make a conclusion if there's no body found? It was nearly dark with anger.

"The car was found... My car, to be exact. The car you told me was your foolishness!" Angelo's glare matched Keifer's. "...Body inside. With the force of the river current and how

It felt like something was punching my heart. It's so hard hard to think that he even called me for a picture while in the accident happened.

"Aries clearly saw how the car fell-----."

"And he didn't do anything?!"

"Keifer!" I shouted at him.

"I know you're f*cking devastated right now. But you need to get out of here. You weren't in that situation, so you don't know how hard it is to get Percy out of that car!" Angelo took a deep breath. "...make it out himself. So think about how he must have felt."

I agreed with what Angelo was saying, but at this point, I closed off to accepting any explanation.

"Aries and Percy were in the car together?"

It felt like a bucket of cold water had been thrown at me. I looked at Angelo, and I almost wanted to shout at him that he was wrong about.

No one spoke. One word from any of us and Keifer would have exploded. I didn't take my eyes off Angelo, and he did the same.

"Were they together in the car?!" he asked again.

"Go after Keifer!" I shouted, and he did.

I rested for a moment before heading out completely. I wanted to go but I could hear Keifer screaming. He was furious, and his screams echoed. Even the nurses were panicking.

People were peeking out of other rooms, clearly disturbed by the outburst. When I reached Aries's room, Angelo was holding him who was desperately trying to break free.

Aries was on the floor, his face covered in blood.

"Percy died because of you! You let him die!" Keifer yelled.

"Stop it, Keifer!" Angelo shouted, still trying to pull him back.

"I WILL NEVER FVCKING FORGIVE YOU!"

I saw Angelo struggling to hold him back. Soon, several nurses came and tried to intervene. One of the nurses injected Keifer with a sedative.

Only a few seconds passed, and Keifer began to weaken. He eventually lost consciousness. I just stood there, watching them.

I looked at my friends who had been with me through all my life. I looked at the friendship we had, which seemed to have ended because of the death of one of us.

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"The mess got worse because of the issue with Ella and t  
in the cafeteria," Yuri added.

That's also the reason why Section E couldn't go to the c

"His mind is really narrow," I said somewhat annoyed. "  
right! He wasn't there, he didn't see what happened! Why  
on Aries?!"

"I can't blame Keifer."

I looked at her confused. "Why?"

"Because that's what he's been doing to himself for a lon  
blaming himself for not being there and for being uncon  
friend was dying." he sighed and set down his glass. "...E  
that. When something goes wrong, he blames himself. H  
happened because he wasn't there."

he said he believes he could've prevented what happenec  
there.

"How do you know that?"

"He tells me. When we're smoking or drinking."

I pouted. Their closeness was something else. It was like  
they be gay?



kicking, causing trouble one day.

"What did you feel when Percy showed up?" I asked again.

"Different things. Shock, happiness, sadness, anger... through the word almost in a whisper.

I understood. They told me that when they found out he was the one who planned on getting revenge, and maybe I would be his next target.

But like Percy said, he wasn't that kind of person. He was just a person who felt like something pierced my heart.

Here we go again... It's like a cycle. It keeps running in and out of my head over and over.

"Are you okay, Jay?" Yuri asked, bringing me back to reality.

"O-yeah... I just feel something in my stomach."

"Maybe you have an upset stomach. You eat too much,"

I frowned. "Have you ever been hit in the face by a plate?"

I asked sarcastically while holding a plate near me. "Wait, you've never been hit in the face by a plate?"

he chuckled and gave a peace sign. he should thank his good friends for the shame if a plate hit his face. But it would be even more embarrassing if the plate were shiny.

style.

The effort was incredible.

It took a few hours before we thought about heading home. I took the used utensils and plates behind, telling his staff to clean up.

I hugged the bouquet of flowers while we walked back to the car.

"Thanks for dinner. I missed eating sushi," I said and lifted my arm.

The sushi was really the only thing I liked out of everything.

He winced and rubbed his arm. "Welcome. Let's go, I'll drive. It's still a long trip."

I nodded and got in the car. While on the road, I heard my phone ring several times. I grabbed it from my bag and checked.

I had messages from Kuya Angelo and Gagong Baliw. I checked the message first because he had also called me.

**From: Kuya Angelo**

**Message:**

*Where are you? Why aren't you answering your phone?*

**From: GagongBaliw**

**Message:**

*Are you busy?*

**From: GagongBaliw**

**Message:**

*I really wanted to talk to you.*

**From: GagongBaliw**

**Message:**

*Can I call you?*

**From: GagongBaliw**

**Message:**

*C'mon, I want to hear your voice.*

**From: GagongBaliw**

**Message:**

*Where are you?*

*Jasper Jean.*

"Who are you texting?" Yuri asked.

I paused for a moment before putting my phone back in

"Kuya... He's looking for me," I answered.

he nodded, accepting my response. I don't know why, but I shouldn't tell him that I was texting GagongBaliw. I didn't want a big part of me wanted to keep that a secret.

I wanted to be the one to find out who he was.

"Have you talked to your Kuya about... the cancellation of our engagement?" he asked uncertainly.

"Not yet," I answered in almost a whisper.

"He didn't say anything?"

"Nothing."

"He's not going to lecture you, is he?" he said with a smile.

"...He even thanked us."

I furrowed my brows at what he said. He thanked me? For what? It sounds weird.

Kuya Angelo is so handsome. I really love him!

"R-really? He said that?"

he nodded while still looking at the road. "The truth is, A giving us other business proposals for a while. Ones that marriage. But I told Tanda not to accept them."

My smile faded, and I felt like slapping the person I was thing it suddenly hit me that it was all in the past. We we anymore.

Calm down, calm down.

"You really did that? You're crazy," I said, slightly annoy

he laughed a bit, like he didn't care about what he did. he lucky stars that I'm full right now. Otherwise, I would've

I went silent as I suddenly remembered something. Kuya the other day and how miserable he looked.

"Wh-what about the partnership between Kuya's compar there still hope for that?" I asked.

I could see the sadness on his face, even though his atten the road. At that moment, I had a hunch about what his a

...

a girlfriend.

Our trip took a while because of how far it was. It was 9  
finally got to the house. I didn't let him drop me off at the  
late.

I was still holding onto the bouquet of flowers Yuri gave  
house. The lights in the living room were off, but there were  
stairs. I was about to head straight to my room when suddenly  
turned on.

Kuya Angelo was sitting on the sofa, holding a glass with  
on the table in front of him. He was staring at me seriously.

"What time is it?" he asked, lifelessly.

Hmm... time to sleep?

"9 pm," I answered in almost a whisper.

His gaze shifted to the bouquet of flowers I was holding.  
down and slowly stood up.

"Who gave you that?" he asked as he walked towards me.

I stepped back. "I-it's from..."

"From Keifer?"

"Is he the reason you don't want to marry Yuri?" He poked me again. "...Is he the one you like? You'd rather choose someone like Latak?"

So that's how he sees me. I admit, it hurt when he said that about Latak—like the waste of society, like the youth with no future. Suddenly, he grabbed the bouquet from me. My tears fell in surprise. I was scared of how Kuya was acting.

He stared at the flowers for a moment before throwing them away. The petals exploded into the air. He wasn't satisfied, throwing them around on the floor.

He turned to face me and pointed his finger at me. "Stay away from me! You're stupid! Yuri gave me that."

I didn't wait for him to say anything else. I quickly ran to my room, locked the door. I wiped my tears away.

I didn't know why Kuya was acting like that, but all the feelings I had earlier when Yuri told me Kuya didn't want me to get married to him. It was replaced by fear.

I didn't understand Kuya.

# Chapter 226: Gift

## Jay-jay's POV

Turns out Boy Bawang's breath is really stinky. Or is my bad?

Eww... Didn't he brush his teeth?

Idiot! You call yourself conscious, but you don't even know a tooth. Yep, singular. I brushed one tooth.

I went to school with an empty stomach. I didn't have breakfast and I was planning to buy something at the Mini Mart, but I was out of money on my side. My allowance was almost gone, and I needed something to eat.

I had no choice but to go to Tom Jones. But heaven was above. When I walked in, there was food on my table. I wasn't hungry, but my stomach took over.

What a great breakfast!

I had no choice but to eat it. Whoever the sneaky person was on my table, I'm thanking you for the first time.

"Hey! Can I have some?" Ci-N said as he grabbed some



I squinted my eyes at him. Why do I feel like I don't trust this guy has lied to me before, and I wouldn't be surprised if

"Are you being honest?"

He took a bite before speaking. "Honestly, no... But—" I interrupted before continuing. "...But I overheard them. They said that you just like what we did with Yuri. So this is probably just courting you."

Woo me?! Just like that?!

What do they think, that I'll just give in so easily? I gave in because, aside from courting me, they admitted their misdeeds. Pestilential Dimunyang Snakes?! They walk around with impunity when they face me.

And they think they can just woo me like that?! No way! No amount of snacks from all of the Philippines will make me fall for these idiots.

Ci-N stood up and went to the back to get water from the tap. I asked for some since my stomach pain was acting up again.

I have a sickness... Tamaritis! Only lazy people get this!

Sir Alvin arrived, so I was forced to clean up the mess on the table. Class started, and things went back to normal between Ci-N

I shifted my gaze to Yuri, who was writing at the moment focused, his eyes fixed on the board. He looked so cool and confident but then he's actually a nerd.

I turned my attention back to the front and pretended to listen though I wasn't really paying attention. The class ended, and we had to review since the fourth exam is coming next month.

After that, the Post-Final exam. That's when we'll know if we graduate or not. Why is there even such a thing? What if you pass all exams but fail that one? Then you don't graduate? That's ridiculous.

While we were waiting for the next teacher, we heard noise from the room. Denzel, who was by the window, peered outside.

"Section D," he said.

The Snakes were about to stand up to go see Section D when suddenly someone threw a firecracker inside our room.

The so-called Judas' Cracker. We were all startled, and fell back when we saw the fuse lit. We quickly covered our ears as another exploded after another.

The smoke quickly filled the room. We all rushed to the exits to get away from the firecrackers.

Ci-N kept shouting, but I couldn't hear what he was saying.

I looked at David, noticing that he was still slouched over asleep. I don't know if he's numb or something, but he didn't hear the explosions.

"HEY! DAVID!" I shouted, but the firecrackers were still

"David! He's probably dead!" Ci-N screamed into my ear

I flinched, almost getting sprayed with his saliva. That was

This guy has rabies, too!

Since David wasn't moving in his seat, I threw a notebook at him. A sample hit to the head.

He moved and started coughing. He probably had trouble breathing of the smoke. He stood up and took off the headphones for

So that's why he didn't wake up. He couldn't hear the noise

He looked around, searching for us. When he saw us huddled together, he quickly approached.

"What happened?! Where did that come from?!" he asked

Suddenly, Ci-N jumped on his back while repeatedly shouting

"THEY'RE ATTACKING US, IT'S TERRORISTS! WE'

We looked behind us when we heard something fall.

The water dispenser fell over as Blaster tried to grab the

It still had plenty of water, so he struggled at first. He lifted strength and threw it at the firecracker in front.

Only a few seconds passed, and the explosions stopped. soaked.

"They're dead! Let's get out of here!" Eman shouted, and we did.

Yuri helped me stand and supported me as we made our

We were all catching our breath. Some of us were almost

"What's with you?! Get off!" David said irritably as he tried to get off his back.

"I'm not getting off! I'm staying here on your back!"

Crazy! What's so special about David's back? A house?

We just shook our heads. Even after everything that happened, we had the energy to tease. Meanwhile, we were all struggling to breathe.

Good thing Blaster quickly came up with a plan.

I clenched my fists. Will this guy ever stop? Kuya Angel  
him cry, but he hasn't learned a thing.

Suddenly, someone threw a piccolo firecracker, and we  
while dodging it. They laughed like they were having the  
at how we looked.

"David! They're terrorists!" Ci shouted as he shook David

"Stop it! I can see!" David replied, irritated.

Where is Ci-N getting all this energy from? And why do  
off David's back? It would be fine if he wasn't so heavy.

The effect of Boy Bawang or the smoke, maybe!

"Can you just leave?!" Rory shouted angrily.

"Big talk! Don't act tough! Keifer's not here!" Mykel bo

"Even if Keifer's not here, we'll still fight you!" Kit retor

"What are you waiting for? Let's fight!" one of Mykel's

The Snakes were about to charge, but suddenly, Sir Alvin

He was with some teachers.

"Section E! Are you all okay?" he asked us " Someone

"We didn't... It was Mykel's group who did it," Edrix answered.

"Why would they do that?" another male teacher interrupted.

Josh answered, "Why wouldn't they do it?"

The teachers exchanged glances, except for Sir Alvin. The looks at each other made it clear they were taking sides. The teachers' faces and the looks—they all knew.

They knew what was going on.

"Did anyone get hurt?" Sir asked again.

The Snakes exchanged glances, waiting to see who would answer.

When they realized no one would, Rory answered.

"No one—" He was cut off by Ci-N's sudden interruption.

"There is!" he screamed, still sitting on David's back.

"...My heart hurts! I'm broken-hearted! Rakki ignored me!"

Sir just scratched his head. He was used to Ci-N's antics, but he didn't know how to explain further.

"If anyone's hurt, go to the clinic for treatment," Sir said and walked to our room.

I looked at David and noticed he was pale. Ci-N was choking while screaming.

I slapped the little rascal hard on the arm. He glared at me.

"My feelings are hurt!" he screamed in my face.

"You're choking David!"

He panicked and quickly let go of David, jumping off his back gasping for air.

"You'll get your turn with me," he whispered to Ci-N.

The little rascal just grinned and gave a peace sign. The rascal went back inside, and we followed. Eman grabbed the glass and some water left and returned it to the dispenser that Kit and I

"Looks like Section D really exploded! And now, they're back," Felix said angrily.

The firecracker went on for so long. There was still almost half left. Eren took it and went out of the room, but before he could go, I stopped him.

"Don't throw it away yet. I have an idea for it," he said, a grin spreading across his face.

"It's a good idea," he said, a grin spreading across his face.

"Like it's that easy!" Mayo replied irritably.

"It's easy. You're just scared," Eren teased, and Mayo angrily was holding.

"What did you say?!" he shouted, ready to charge, but D quickly stepped in between them.

"Enough! Stop!"

"You're going to fight now?"

"Stop, stop!"

"Get away from each other!" Calix yelled at them.

They did what he said but exchanged sharp glares as if they were enemies.

They really couldn't control their tempers.

After cleaning, we all went our separate ways. It seemed teachers were going to check on us, so Eman decided to

While they were casually talking, I took out my phone. I was from GagongBaliw, but he wasn't my focus.

I texted Percy to bring me lunch. I wasn't planning on rejoining yesterday. What do they think of me? That I'm



Ugh! I'm totally infected with the Snakes' dead guts men  
But I won't give in. I won't eat here! Even if Eman make  
"Let's eat, Jay!" Ci said.

I stared at him. "I have something to ask you to do."

"What is it?" he asked with a smile as he came closer.

I whispered to him. "Get food for me but don't give it to

He scratched his head, looking confused. "Huh?"

"Just get it... Don't let anyone know, then bring it to our ]

He nodded slowly. "Okay."

Perfect! My intelligence really kicks in when food is inv

Just as Eman finished cooking, the bell rang. It was lunch  
up to go out, but Felix immediately blocked my way.

"Eat here," he said with a smile.

I shook my head. "I texted Percy. He's on his way."

"Come on, just—"

Automatically, I looked toward the farthest room where former Section E were displayed.

No one else could open that room because Keifer had the key with Yuri, but Yuri was in the room.

I approached the room and tried to feel if anyone was inside by turning the doorknob, but it was locked. I even knocked, but it might open the door.

Weird! But I definitely heard a door close.

I shrugged it off. Maybe it was the door from our room that shut too hard. I walked towards our hangout spot near the stairs. When I got there, Ci-N arrived, but he was empty-handed.

"Where is it?" I asked irritably.

He pointed his chin toward the bottom of the stairs, and Felix was coming up carrying two plates, one with rice and one with food.

What the heck?!

This was exactly why I sent him there—so no one would find me.

I specifically told him not to make it obvious.

Ci-N looked at me innocently, then grabbed the two plates from him. Felix smiled at me again before turning to leave.

Before he could go down, I stopped him. He looked at me.

"Don't tell any of the other Snakes about this," I warned,

He just winked back in response.

Tsk! So cocky...

Ci-N started eating, and when I looked back at him, he was eating his food to even acknowledge me.

Since there were no more distractions, I started eating as well.

A little while later, Percy arrived. He smiled at me, but his expression changed to a grimace when he saw Ci-N ignoring him.

"Why is he here?" he whispered to me while handing me the food.

It was takeout from a fast food place. I took it from him and ate it in front of us.

"I asked him to bring it. Let's eat," I said, but he shook his head.

"I already ate at home."

I watched his face closely. He looked so pale but was trying to hide it.

Ci-N suddenly stopped eating. "Is there a storm? The wind is blowing so hard!" he asked innocently.

Percy immediately shot him a nasty look. "Yeah, there's a storm. Be a little careful, alright? The wind might blow you away, you're so small."

Ci returned the glare. "Don't brag too much or the wind will blow you away too!"

"When did my good looks become arrogance?!"

"Every time you say it!"

"You're just jealous! I'm way better looking than you!"

Ci looked at his face as if inspecting it. "Where exactly?"

"Short and blind, too!"

"Ugly and arrogant!"

Instead of stopping them, I just watched. I'd rather focus on the fact that these two are together, they always make a scene.

Go ahead, keep at it, you two!

After eating, I excused myself to go to the restroom. I let them talk. Since it was lunchtime, there were people inside when I went.

"Aren't they coming in?"

It seems like the girls left. I quickly finished washing my out of the restroom. I noticed some students staring at so walking away.

I looked too, and I saw Mykel's group heading out of the

I wonder what that was about?

I shrugged and went back to our building. I was on the st Percy.

"Where's Ci-N?" I asked.

"Why are you asking me?"

I looked at him confused. "What? You're together, right?"

"He followed you! He said the wind was with me, so he

Oh crap! But I didn't...—the group of Mykel.

My heart suddenly started beating faster. Fear took over couldn't understand it, but I had a bad feeling something

I ran toward the school gate, but they were gone. I tried t they weren't there either. I went up to the guard who was at his cellphone.

"How did you see the group of students leave earlier?" I

It felt like I was doused with cold water. What are they p  
Ci-N? What are they going to do? Don't they plan on sto

Wait for me, Ci! I'll find you.

# Chapter 227: Blood

## Jay-jay's POV

"Isn't there anything faster we can do?!" I asked, panicking.

"I can speed up the car, but if we don't know where we're going, it's useless!" Percy replied, frustrated.

I didn't know where we were anymore. We'd been driving around the school for a while. I knew they couldn't have gone too far. They take Ci-N?

"Call your classmates! You'll find the kid faster with their help!"

I shook my head. "I don't have my phone! I left it in my room!"

I didn't go back to the room. I ran out of the school, and Percy had followed me.

He stopped me and asked what was going on. I told him I had Ci-N, and I had a bad feeling about it. He immediately took his car to search, but up to now, we still couldn't find the kid.

"Use this phone—" He didn't finish his sentence.

We almost both lurched forward because of the sudden s  
"Aaaarrrrrrgggghhh..." He groaned as if something was h  
What the hell?! What's happening?!

I was terrified! I didn't understand what was going on wi  
him, and it seemed like he couldn't move. His fingers we  
legs were rigid.

"P-Percy!"

His eyes were closed, and sweat was dripping off him, e  
conditioning was on in the car.

I grabbed my hair in frustration. I didn't know what to do

"P-Percy..." I called out, my voice trembling. "...I-I'll ask

I unbuckled my seatbelt and was about to get out of the c  
suddenly spoke.

"D-Don't..." Even speaking was a struggle. "...G-Go... lo

He wanted me to leave him and go after Ci-N. I shook m

"I can't leave you like this!"

I was completely confused! I didn't know what to do any



"Leave... I-I can... still... handle it!"

I wiped the tears from my eyes. "I'm not leaving you!"

He stared at me like he was frustrated that I wasn't listen stayed like that for a while, and then he took a deep brea

"I-I can... handle it." He whispered. "...I-I'll... call... for h

But what if he can't ask for help?!

"I'll ask for help first... Then I'll go look for Ci-N."

I tried to grab his phone, but I couldn't find where it wen touch my arm.

"Go!" He shouted, pushing me. "...G-Go find... the kid!"

"Percy, please!"

He pushed me again. "I-I'll... ask... for help! Go!"

Tears that I had been holding back finally fell. I didn't w but I had to find Ci-N. I opened the car door and got out.

I looked back at Percy, and he tried to smile at me. It wa me that he would be okay. I nodded at him and closed th

I quickly wiped my tears away. I trusted Percy. If he said

I was about to cross when I saw two students across the street from HVIS too, because of their uniforms. I looked at them and then realized they were from Section D.

I quickly crossed the street and almost got hit by a car. They yelled loudly, and the attention of the two Section D students was on me.

It looked like they recognized me because they suddenly stopped.

You're in trouble when I catch up with you! Raaawrrrr!

"Dammit!" I shouted at them.

The idiots turned into a corner. People they passed quickly was starting to get exhausted from chasing them.

I slowed down, and the two took that opportunity to slip away.

They probably thought I didn't see them. Before I reached, I grabbed a trash bin drum that was empty. It was smelly—but it worked.

I could see them resting with their backs against the wall. In my hesitation, I threw the trash can at them. One of them even tried to avoid it.

"You bastards! You made me suffer!" I angrily said as I walked away from the floor.

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I stepped on the face of the one lying on the ground. "Yc

"A-argh! It hurts! It hurts!" he screamed.

I turned to the other one. I slammed his face into the wal

I didn't remove my foot from the other one's face.

"Argh! Argh! Stop! It hurts!" he screamed.

"WHERE IS CI-N?!"

"H-he's with Mykel!" the one on the floor answered.

Oh, I know! Of course! Would I be attacking you if you
to Mykel?!

I pressed my foot harder into his face. "Where?"

"Aaaaaarghhh!" he screamed, crying.

I then focused on the one with his face slammed into the
face even harder into it.

"Go kiss that wall!" I yelled at him. "Where is that Myke

His face and the wall were almost one. His nose was pre
the wall he could barely speak. I slightly pulled his face
chance to talk

The gate was covered with plants and rust. Behind it was house. I was about to open the gate and charge in when s my mouth and arms.

"We've got a guest!" the person holding me said, laughin

Damn it!

They opened the gate and dragged me closer to Mykel. I a few times, but it was pointless. I knew there was more holding me.

Mykel was smiling as I was brought closer. He threw aw

"Look who's here!" he said and even brought his face clc knew you'd come."

I wanted so badly to land a punch on his face, but their g tight.

"Inside," he ordered, pointing to the house behind him.

Shit!

I tried to pull my arms away, but they pulled me into the struggle, one of them let go of my mouth.

"Dammit! Where is Ci-N?!" I screamed, but all they did

When I got closer, I saw his condition. His nose was bleeding and his eyes and forehead were starting to turn black. He uniform was dirty.

"Ci-N!" I screamed and tried to approach, but they held me back from me!"

I heard the door slam shut. It echoed throughout the house with its size and weight.

"Help him up," Mykel's voice came from behind me.

They helped Ci-N stand, but he quickly knelt down again.

I felt defeated seeing him like this. It was clear that they wanted to make sure he couldn't fight back.

"Ci..." I called out to him.

I lowered my head as he forced a smile. It hurt me to see him. Suddenly, someone grabbed my chin and forcefully lifted my head.

"Look at him." Mykel ordered while walking closer to Ci-N.

"...Look at him closely because this will happen to your brother."

Without warning, he punched Ci-N in the stomach. Ci-N fell to the ground, collapsed, but because they were holding him, he remained on his feet.

I felt three fingers graze my thigh. The idiots surrounding

"Stop it! You idiot!" I shouted as I tried to struggle.

"Tell me..." Mykel whispered to me. "...Has Keifer tasted

"Get away from me!"

My heart felt like it was about to explode with anxiety. I could barely breathe. Tears were already welling up.

"Let go of me!"

"Bastard!" Mykel called out to Ci-N and they forced him

"...watch what we're going to do to your friend!"

Aaaagh! Damn it!

What had only brushed against my thigh earlier was now squirmed like a fish out of water. The hand was moving inching up my skirt.

"She's wearing a cycling short!" one of them said in disa

Next time, I'll wear briefs so it won't be embarrassing for

"It's okay..." Mykel didn't finish what he was about to sa

I punched one of them, but he avoided it. I seized the chance, quickly kneeling him in the stomach. A few others tried to attack me, but I dealt with them with punches and kicks.

Before the others could get close, I charged at Mykel, who was lying on the ground, standing up, wiping his lips. I punched him and followed him to the ground, hitting his chest. He fell, clearly weakened. He even coughed a few times.

I got my revenge on you!

I glanced at Ci-N and saw him leaning against a post. He was looking up and smiled. I then noticed the man behind him, who was looking at me, when suddenly something hard hit my head.

I was thrown back from the force. Everything seemed to be spinning. I felt disoriented by what I was seeing. The ground felt uncomfortable.

I closed my eyes and felt something wet on my head. So, I opened my eyes, and my own blood, was dripping.

"JAY-JAY!" I heard Ci-N shout.

My head throbbed with pain.

For a few minutes, I didn't move from where I lay. It felt like something heavy on my body, preventing me from standing up.

"Should I finish her off?" I heard one man say.

I knew what it was, but I didn't want to look at it. I wasn't more than that, Ci needed me. If I let the fear of blood take over, it would be like before, when we were attacked by Rory.

"Hey! The chick's still alive!" one of them shouted.

They looked at me, then at Ci-N. Some of them were angry, some were furious.

We need to get out of here! Why do I feel like I'm getting weaker?

I'm not weak. Not now, not when it's all about to end. Can I give in to weakness? I won't let someone like you weaken me.

One of them approached and was about to grab me, but I punched him in the chest with all my strength. The others got alarmed and backed off.

"F*ck! Still got strength? Didn't you hit her hard enough?" Mykel said to the guy holding the pipe.

Charge already! You talk too much.

I raised my arm, ready to face their charge, but that was when I realized my whole arm was covered in blood from my head injury. Everything was turning red.

I started to breathe heavily. My knees buckled, and my head was pounding. My heart was pounding relentlessly.

"You're useless!"

"Just a freeloader!"

"What are you waiting for?! Charge already!" Mykel shouted.

I opened my eyes. For the first time, I was grateful for what I had done to these people. I looked at my palm, which was covered in blood.

If this is the only way we can survive...

Blood tastes so good!

I had my fingers in my mouth. I felt like a vampire, thirsting for blood. It counted just a few seconds, and soon my body started moving on its own. I was someone else.

And everything went dark.

Chapter 228: L.Q.

Jay-jay's POV

Jay-jay's POV

It's so noisy. It sounds like there's some kind of argument. I can also hear someone singing. They're so loud, and even when I try to sleep, I can't because of the noise. What an inconvenience! So annoying!

I opened my eyes, and the annoying Snakes were the first to notice.

"Why are you so loud!" I said, irritated.

"Hey, you're awake!"

"Wide awake!"

"How are you, Jay?"

I frowned. This was the first time I saw people greeting me. Their mouths were full of food. It was even worse that they were holding their hands and still chewing.

"Can you move away? You look so ugly! It's making me

around my head.

Why is this happening? What's going on—Ci-N!

That's when everything came back to me. Why I was in there, why my hands were wrapped. Ci, Mykel, and the chandeliers.

I looked at the Snakes. I searched for the face of that braided man. I found him.

"Where's Ci-N?" I asked, worried.

David answered. "He's in the other room. He's fine, that's all."

I breathed a sigh of relief. I was so worried about what happened to him.

I closed my eyes and leaned back on the bed. Thank goodness nothing happened to him.

I tried to recall the events before I ended up in the hospital. But something was missing... like I couldn't remember everything.

I opened my eyes, and Yuri was the first person I saw. He was holding an apple.

"Who brought us to the hospital?" I asked, and he looked at me before going back to what he was doing.

"XXV 2:24"

I frowned. "I just woke up. How could I have asked that?"

He stopped eating the apple and stared at me, confused.

"Jay... You were awake earlier while they were all still asleep, even staring blankly before speaking."

Yuri and I stared at each other for a long time, both confused. What was happening. I couldn't remember being awake at all. I couldn't remember what happened after—blood!

"Yuri... C-could you take me to Ci-N?" I urgently asked.

"Why? Is something wrong?"

"B-because... because..."

How do I tell him that that thing has come back? That thing that was happening to me. The thing I've been trying to avoid for so long. It's so scary!

We heard a knock on the door. We all looked at the door. Tita Gema appeared, smiling.

"How are you all?" she greeted the Snakes and me.

"We're fine, Tita." Eren answered with a smile.

"Thank you for the food, Tita." Denzel said.

"Thank you. Good thing you're here to help take care of as she placed the paper bag she was carrying on the table food.

"Hey, what's this, Tita? It looks good." Drew said as he s the paper bag.

"That's adobo. Help yourselves." Tita replied, walking to are you feeling?"

"I'm fine, Tita." I looked at the Snakes who were eating l are there so many foods?"

She looked at the Snakes behind her and smiled before f

"Since they brought you here yesterday, they haven't gor I brought them food." She explained.

Yesterday? That means I've been unconscious for a whol

I looked at Yuri. "You've been here since yesterday?" I a nodded. "...Then you haven't showered?"

They all froze. Tita was confused by their reaction. Even rice cake in his mouth, stopped.

"It's okay. We're used to not showering." Mayo replied q smack on the head from Josh.

"I'm asking because you didn't answer."

"I'm sorry, Tita."

"Maybe you're hungry," Yuri interjected.

Tita Gema laughed. "Maybe. But you can't eat yet."

What do you mean I can't eat?!

My eyes widened as I looked at Tita Gema and Yuri.

"A-are you serious?"

Tita Gema adjusted the pillow behind me, still laughing.

"We still need to wait for the doctor's instructions. We can't

Whaaaattt????!!!

Why is that? There's so much food in front of me, and I can't eat? Why? This is so unfair!

"But why?"

"That's what the doctor said."

I turned to Tita, almost teary-eyed. "But sometimes what isn't true."

The Snakes thanked her before she completely left. Yuri took my hand.

"What were you saying earlier?"

Oh, right!

I looked at the Snakes. I didn't want to talk about those t
them.

"Maybe next time."

His grip on my hand tightened, so I looked at it. I knew I
I was thinking about something. I forced a smile and trie
but the bandages got in the way.

We stayed like that when I suddenly remembered Percy.
widened.

"P-Percy? Where is Percy?"

Felix, who was currently drinking Coke, looked at me.

"At home. Why?" he answered.

"Is he okay?" I asked, worried.

Felix looked at me, puzzled. "Of course. Why wouldn't h

I looked at David, but he just shrugged and continued eating the same. I decided to put off what was bothering me in my room.

There were times when Yuri would give me spoonfuls of soup to quench my thirst. But all I wanted was food.

Food! Food! Food!

In the afternoon, the Snakes decided to go home. They were bored with anything here but eating. Only David and Yuri stayed behind.

As soon as the others left, Yuri's phone rang, and he told me to answer it before stepping outside.

I looked at David, who was busy with his phone.

"Hey David!" I called out, annoyed. "...What happened to David?"

"He's at home, resting," he answered, bored.

"Is he okay?" I asked, concerned.

David stared at me with confusion. "Yeah, of course. What's the problem?"

"Because when we—"

"He was here earlier." David cut me off again.

His gaze was different, like he was warning me not to talk back.

Yuri occasionally gave me water to ease my thirst, but all I wanted was food.

Food! Food! Food!

In the afternoon, the Snakes finally decided to go home. I was doing nothing but eating the whole time. Only David and Yuri were behind.

After they left, Yuri's phone rang, and he excused himself and stepped outside.

David casually put his phone down, and it seemed like he was in a hurry now. "Percy's in a bad situation."

I stared at him, waiting for him to explain. "After the accident, his spine was badly damaged. He can't walk and is almost paralyzed. His mom's been doing everything to help him."

I gripped the blanket tightly. "She spent so much money on treatments who could cure Percy."

"But didn't he get better? I see him here with us now."

"Not completely. There's a side effect. His spine suddenly causes paralysis in parts of his body."

I remembered what Percy looked like in the car—how he

"Is there a chance... is there a chance that...?" I couldn't f but it seemed like David understood what I was asking.

"Yes... There is a chance. A high risk."

I covered my mouth with my hand. It felt like what David real. I hoped it was just a joke, and I would help him laugh given a new sibling, but it felt like he was going to be taken too.

"...That's also one of the reasons why his mother doesn't back here." He added.

I couldn't hold back my tears anymore. They just fell on David to panic and rush to me.

"Hey! Don't cry. Don't think about anything. Percy's stro wiping my tears away.

"It's just so unfair... So, so unfair," I said, breaking into s

David hugged me while patting my shoulder. Why does always come with a price? I was given a father, but I couldn't was given a sibling, but I wasn't accepted. I was given a seemed like he was going to be taken away from me too. teased me with food I couldn't eat.

"I'm not dead yet, and you're already crying for me?"

"You're so annoying!" I said as he came closer. "...If my bandaged, I'd punch you."

He smiled widely. "Good thing there's a bandage. My go ruined."

David suddenly stood up and walked over to the air cond it feel like the wind got stronger, but it's still on number :

He must have felt the storm too.

"Is there a problem, David?" Percy asked sarcastically. " don't like the wind."

David laughed before leaving the room. After the door sl me. I wanted to hit him, but I was afraid I might hurt my

"Why didn't you tell me?" I asked, my voice breaking. ". it's because you didn't want me to worry. That's bullshit!

He didn't respond, just stared at me, so I continued venti

"It's so unfair... I thought I had someone on my side. I th someone to lean on. But why does it feel like it's only ter it feel like they're going to take it all away from me?" M; can I keep going when, every passing moment, you coul me? What am I supposed to do? Huh?! Answer me!"

"I've already escaped death once, Jay. I'm ready to do it again. I'm doing it. Do you know why?" He asked, but I shook my head. "I'm handsome."

Annoying! This guy is crazy!

"Annoying!" I said angrily, slapping his chest, but he remained calm.

"I can't leave you. Especially you. I haven't even brought you back yet. Just trust me, I'll live longer than you think." He smiled. "You'll even leave before me."

I laughed at what he said, and for a moment, I felt lighter. I hugged him.

He hugged me back. "Just trust me. I won't disappear again."

I nodded, and I knew he could feel it. I trusted him. I believed he would leave us.

We broke our hug, and only then did we notice the presence of others. I looked at the door, and there stood Yuri and David, both looking concerned.

"We have to go." David said.

Percy nodded at him before turning to me. "I'll be back to deal with something."

"Get out of here!"

"It's fine."

We talked for a while about what happened yesterday. I told him that it happened again, but suddenly, I hesitated.

Around 7 PM, Mama arrived to watch over me. Yuri said he'd be back tomorrow.

Since I still couldn't eat, I was still stuck with a spoonful of food. I tried to eat the spoon itself, I would, just so my stomach would be full.

"Jay! Stop fighting! No university will accept you!" Mama wiped my face with a wet cloth.

As if I wanted to fight.

"Are you even listening?!" She asked, irritated.

"Yes," I answered lifelessly.

After cleaning me up, she arranged my bed so I could lie down with my back to the wall so I could fall asleep quickly. The room was dark, but there were a lot of things around me. My eyes kept moving, and I couldn't sleep.

Mama probably noticed that I couldn't sleep, so she turned on a small lamp and opened the curtains a little to let some light in from outside.

Before long, I fell asleep on my own, probably because I was too tired.

"Mom! Don't you hear—" I couldn't finish what I was saying. Mama wasn't in her seat.

Wait, I was alone?

I heard the knock again.

"Who's there?!" I shouted, but no one answered.

I heard the door handle turning. Slowly, the door cracked open and from outside poured in.

I noticed something peeking through the gap. I started to try to open the door wide and come in, but they didn't.

"Is anyone there?" I asked, my voice trembling.

The figure disappeared from the crack. I waited for a few minutes, wondering if someone would enter, but no one did. I was about to close the door when the door creaked open slowly.

But why was no one there?!

Suddenly, I remembered what Josh and Mayo were talking about. They were joking around, saying there was a little girl with a room in my bed.

I swallowed hard. I was sweating despite the air conditioning.

I was praying all the prayers I knew when I heard the door shaking, though it wasn't from the cold. I felt every bit of it as I heard the screeching of metal.

It sounded like a wheel lacking oil, or a rusty door.

The sound came closer and closer to me. My heart was pounding, but I could barely hear anything else until...

"Here she is."

Chapter 229: Video call

Jay-jay's POV

I ALMOST FELL! I almost fell off the bed. If it weren't

I almost pulled my lungs out from shouting loudly. A few my room. I even got scolded by a doctor because of the c

And it's all Ci-N's fault!

"You idiot!" I said in annoyance as the nurse left. "...I almost had a heart attack because of you! Why didn't you just come in right

He just laughed while scratching his head. I wanted to kick him but he was sitting on so he would fly away. So that was the s

"The connection keeps cutting off," he said while pointing at the screen. "...the connection was lost again. I'm still waiting for the internet."

I really thought it was a ghost peeking at me and opening my mouth. I cursed in every language I didn't even know because of l

"What the hell is this? Can't it wait until tomorrow?" I sa

While waiting for the internet connection to come back, talking.

"Do you know what happened to Mykel and where he is

He looked at me seriously. "He escaped. Didn't anyone t
Brother Angelo is looking for him now?"

I shook my head. "N-no, no one told me."

The idiot escaped.

"Your brother was really angry yesterday when he saw y
emergency room unconscious. He thought we were the c

I understand my brother. Especially since Mykel was the
to me, while that idiot has backed down.

"Mykel is really a pest."

He nodded while typing on his laptop keyboard. I got cu
seemed so busy.

"Is the internet back?"

He looked at me and smiled. "No."

"Then what are you doing?"

"Jay... Help me here," said Ci.

I got up and looked at him. He took the small rolling table bed so patients can eat. He put the laptop on it and arranged

Ci-N slowly stood up from the wheelchair and sat beside me over because he was squeezing in. He placed the table next to me and continued typing on his laptop.

"Help me with what I'm playing," he added.

All I saw on his laptop screen were letters, and it seemed like I had to find words to get extra points.

Since we were still waiting for the internet connection, I

"Here..." I pointed to the screen. "...Stars."

"Where else?"

"Here... House."

"Another word. Something with double O."

I almost buried my face in the monitor just to find the word I was looking for about.

"Here! Here! Door!"

I pinched him on the side. "I didn't even notice."

We went back to what we were doing. Searching for more double O. We got so caught up in it and didn't notice the

"That's a lot."

"Not enough." He insisted, continuing to search. "Here! Blood."

I suddenly stopped. The events from the fight with Myke came back to my mind. But there was something missing. What happened After...

Did I taste the blood?

"Ci..." I called him. "...What happened after... After... I got hit with the pipe?" I even touched the bandage on my head.

He slowly turned to look at me. His eyes were serious, and almost incredulous about what I asked.

"You don't remember?"

I shook my head. "I remember getting up and fighting with him but... When the blood touched my taste buds..."

I took a deep breath. "...It was like everything just vanished."

"What--?" I couldn't finish what I was going to say because of the sound from Ci's laptop.

He closed the game and clicked something on his laptop. The screen opened, and the face of the person I didn't expect to see appeared.

It would be more accurate to say that I had been expecting to see him for days.

But of course, he left to give me space and handle his in-laws. I had no hope of seeing him.

King of the Snakes.

["What took you so long?!"] He asked Ci in an irritated tone.

Why does his voice sound different? It sounds so manly. It must be because of the laptop's speaker. I observed his face, his hair, and it seemed like a little stubble was growing on his face.

He looked even more handsome?

"The connection kept getting lost." Ci-N answered him.

I won't deny it, I missed this idiot. I missed his shameless behavior—just, I missed him! Even though he messes with me, I

["Where the hell is she?"]

I wiped away the tears I hadn't realized had fallen. My tears were silent killers; they move in secret.

"N-not... I just got something in my eye," I explained.

Ci narrowed his eyes. "I'm not stupid. You're crying, right? ...You're crying because you think I can't see you on the screen. Let me fix it."

Oh yes! That's really the reason. Such a waste, I'm too busy being annoying!

You know, I want to slap my own face, but I can't because I'm too busy on it. I don't know if he's really that dumb or just playing dumb.

I lost my attention on Ci when I saw King Dimunyo look at me seriously. I swallowed and quickly looked away. Even though we were facing each other on the laptop, it felt like he was right in front of me.

["Hey..."] He called me. "...How are you?"

"I'm fine, thank you," I quickly answered, sounding like I was trying to hide something.

I suddenly felt tense for an unknown reason. Keifer grabbed the laptop beside him and started pressing keys.

["I need your complete statement about your experience with this blood."] He said directly.

His eyes were serious as they looked at me. ["I need you need to understand what's happening to you. This is for y

He pressed more keys on what I assumed was the keyboard. A tear fell from my eye, which I quickly wiped away before it.

He stopped and looked at me. ["Jay-jay."] He called me, should speak.

This is so frustrating! My heart is in turmoil again.

I swallowed and cleared my throat to clarify my voice and in my throat.

"I don't remember what happened. All I know is that I liked blood and I wanted to taste it," I casually explained.

["But you're scared of blood."]

I slightly shook my head. "I can't explain it. Maybe if they feel like someone might die. Also, that's what happens to might happen again, so I avoid seeing blood."

"So you're afraid of your period?" Ci innocently asked.

I grimaced, and Keifer slapped his own forehead, something I do to myself for a while now.

before he spoke again.

["Ci-N... I need your statement."]

"Okay..." He started cheerfully. "...Here's the thing! I fell in the bathroom. I didn't want to be with Percy. Then I bumped the----."

["What I mean is....Argh!"] Keifer slapped his own face.

It was obvious he was getting annoyed, but he was trying to be patient.

"Let's get to the part where I got up after being hit with the hammer," he nodded.

Talking to this annoying kid is really hard!

"I didn't see everything clearly, but I remember..." He started thinking. "...Jay-jay got up like nothing was hurting her. Her eyes, which were lifeless, were staring at Mykel. She started cursing at her opponent, as if she was really angry."

Keifer kept typing while I couldn't take my attention away from what he was saying.

"Then I saw Jay-jay's fist, all covered in blood. I didn't know if it was blood or her enemy's. They fought, but he escaped when his companions got up."

Keifer looked at me and rested his elbow on the table, the fingers, his mouth almost covering his nose and chin.

["Ci... Please leave us."] He ordered.

Ci-N followed, slowly standing up and sitting in his wheelchair and tried to push himself out of the room.

"Why did you send Ci-N out?" I asked him, a little irritated.

["I need to discuss something privately with you."] He told me.
["Remember what you did to Ram?"]

I nodded. I can't forget the first man who kidnapped me and Keifer. I knocked him down without even knowing how.

["It's the same scenario. While I was trying to stop you, they hurt me and repeatedly said something."]

"No one will hurt me. I won't allow them to hurt me."

I got goosebumps as those words naturally entered my mind. My promise I would never break. My heart began to beat faster.

["Jay? Are you alright?"]

"A-am I sick? Am I crazy? The kind of crazy that needs help. The kind that's dangerous to others?" I asked in a panic.

"What if I do have something wrong?"

["JASPER JEAN!"] He shouted at me like a tiger.

If I was really face-to-face with him, I'd probably have b

I closed my eyes, feeling frozen in place.

I took a deep breath and kept staring at him. He was right that I'm sick. I'm not crazy enough to be sent to a mental

I'll just stay in the kitchen for now.

"Sorry. I got scared."

["It's okay. We'll wait for what the doctor says."]

I nodded. He looked at his wristwatch and then turned to
few times, I swallowed as our gazes met—even though i
laptop screen.

["I have to go. Please take care of yourself and..."] He pæ
for what he was going to say next. ["...I miss you."]

The video call suddenly ended. I just stared, blinking rap
what I heard from him. A smile slowly formed on my lip

I miss you too, idiot!

He just laughed. I handed him the laptop so he wouldn't touch his wheelchair. We talked for a while about the mess that Mykel and the others.

Where is that idiot now?

He also said that the Snakes planned to get back at him. Before Kuya Angelo finds him, he'll be in trouble. Even if it hasn't happened yet, I already feel sorry for his fate. Yes, he's not strong, but his spirit is too strong, and the Snakes have so many people.

"Look... Our classmates really went through a lot just to get that idiot." He said with a smile.

I frowned. "What are you trying to say?"

"Nothing... I just hope—maybe—maybe you'll notice them."

"What if I don't want to?"

"You better. If they get mad..."

"What?! If they get mad, what?!"

He grinned so widely that it almost showed his teeth. "That's all I can do for you."

I grabbed my pillow and threw it at him. It seemed like he was startled by my playful attack. Where does this energy come from?

Ci scratched his head. "Y-yes. We were just talking about now."

He said his goodbyes, and I lay down, trying to force my couldn't stop thinking about what Keifer had said.

What if I really am sick? What should I do?

Chapter 230: Home

Jay-jay's POV

My hands were aching. I tried to crack my knuckles, but worse. The doctor said there was no problem, no fracture still hurts.

I was frustrated! Every time something like this happens get like this. I was currently on the sofa in the living room had just gotten back from the hospital.

We—all of us! Including Aries the Horoscope. You can't change fate.

I looked at him as he sat across from me on the other sofa closed while his head rested back. Some parts of his face had a band-aid and gauze. As for me, the only thing I came home with was a bandage on my head.

"...Is that so? Okay, thank you." I heard Tito Julz say, talking on the phone.

Tita Gema entered the house, carrying some of our bags. She was greeted by Tito's sad face.

Tita's expression suddenly showed worry. It seemed like Kuya was doing this.

"Okay... I'll call his friends." Tita replied.

She left our bags and went somewhere, followed by Tito both returned, looking restless and unsure of what to do had their phones in hand and were talking to someone.

When they were out of my sight, Mama came in. She was in the kitchen, holding a glass of juice.

I kind of wanted some too!

Mama looked at me while drinking her juice. Her gaze softened and she smiled.

"When you two act like that, you really look alike." She said.

I grimaced as Aries suddenly stood up. His eyebrows furrowed at me.

"Eew! I look like a monkey." He said before quickly leaving.

"Which monkey? I'm a good-looking monkey if you're talking about me, even though I'm not."

He didn't reply. We lost sight of the crazy Aries. That guy was really something.

I guess I'm glad they didn't catch us. It's good that the Sn guard, even though Ci-N had already been beaten. I don't explanation I'll give them about what happens to me when blood.

But what is it really? Is it a sickness or something?

"Ma..." I called to Mama, who was currently texting on her

"...Do you remember anything strange I did when I was a

She looked at me with a puzzled expression. "What do you strange?"

I sighed. "Nothing. Forget it."

I stood up, about to walk away, when she spoke again.

"Is there a problem? You can tell me." She said with a smile

I shook my head. I knew what she was doing. She was trying to me. Isn't she happy with the casual conversations we have where I call her 'Mama'? I thought she already understood including Aries, talk to each other.

"Nothing. You wouldn't understand anyway."

I grabbed my bag and Aries' from the floor. I passed by her

"Your bag! You're ugly!" I said quickly as I walked toward

He managed to curse me with some harsh words before I could respond. If I wasn't so tired, I would've bombarded him with curses. How can he talk to me like that? I probably have a world record for the curses I let out.

It just toned down because of the

"Profanity"

curse. I flopped down on the bed. I remembered our last conversation with the King of the Snakes.

Along with that came the pain I felt in my heart. He hasn't called. I even asked Ci for help, but he said my messages weren't working either.

He said he misses me, but he only called once. What an idiot.

Speaking of calls, I heard my phone ringing. I got up and checked my bag on top of the study table. I had left it in the room where Ci-N was. It seemed like the Snakes brought it here.

I quickly looked for my phone, but the call had ended before I could answer. It was a missed call from GagongBaliw.

There were also many text messages from him.

messages again.

From: GagongBaliw

Message: Your stepbrother and the kid are so noisy. I ca

What?! How did he know that the one with me was my s
confused by his words. How could he have heard any no
no one else there except us? There was no one else there
were open, so we would easily see if anyone else was the
room.

The room at the end, where the pictures were.

That's when the memory came rushing back. There was
heard the loud bang of a door slamming. I knew it didn't
E's classroom.

Could it have been him?!

I checked his other messages.

From: GagongBaliw

Message: Don't leave them! They're fighting.

From: GagongBaliw

Message: Hey! Why are you taking so long?

Message: Did something happen? Why are you in a hurry?

From: GagongBaliw

Message: I have to go. Hope you're okay.

From: GagongBaliw

Message: Did you go to the hospital? What happened?

From: GagongBaliw

Message: Who hurt you?

From: GagongBaliw

Message: Can you please answer my call?

From: GagongBaliw

Message: Mykel Mitchell... I will make him pay.

I froze. How did he know about that? How did he know I was on the bed, my head hurting from the confusion.

I was starting to feel uneasy about this guy. Over the couple of conversations these past weeks, I've noticed a lot of things that most of them seem to match someone I know.

From: GagongBaliw

Message: I wanted to visit you. But you had a lot of gua

From: GagongBaliw

Message: I hope you reply to at least one of my message

From: GagongBaliw

Message: Can't help it! I'm coming to see you!

From: GagongBaliw

Message: That's why you didn't reply. You're sleeping. Y

He visited me?!

I checked the date and time of the text. It was the third of hospital stay.

From: GagongBaliw

Message: Your mom looks like you. The older version of

I stood up, my hand covering my mouth. He saw Mama? of my room and searched for Mama while repeatedly calling her in the kitchen, talking to Tita Gema.

Mama paused for a moment. I knew she was awake when I came home at night. She also didn't come in the mornings because she was at home then.

"I don't think so..." She said.

My shoulders slumped as I turned away from them. I was alone when Mama spoke again.

"...But once, I passed by a guy heading toward your room. When he came back, I saw him coming out of your room..."

I turned back to her and waited for her to continue. I hoped she knew him!

"...He looked familiar to me, but I couldn't see his face because he was wearing a baseball cap."

Oh, damn it!

I scratched the back of my head and excused myself from the living room to my room and collapsed onto the bed, burying my face in the pillow.

Damn it! Who is this GagongBaliw?! I grabbed my phone and finished reading all his texts. Instead, I decided to send a message to him.

To: GagongBaliw

Hi, I'm the girl you were talking about.

Message: You went to the hospital, why didn't you show

From: GagongBaliw

Message: I showed up! You were just asleep. Haha

I couldn't help but laugh. This idiot!

To: GagongBaliw

Message: You're crazy! You went too. You should've intro

From: GagongBaliw

Message: You already know me.

I furrowed my brow at what he said. I don't know him, trying to get him to introduce himself. What an idiot!

To: GagongBaliw

Message: I don't know you! So annoying!

I dropped my phone when my hand suddenly hurt again. the pain.

The last time my hand hurt like this, Yuri massaged it. A pain went away. I grabbed my phone again and texted Yi

Message: Why do you care?! How do you know that too

From: GagongBaliw

Message: Why?! Why are you with that nerd?

Why does he know Yuri? And why is he calling him a nerd?
I haven't heard about that.

To: GagongBaliw

Message: Because I want to!

From: GagongBaliw

Message: You didn't say that nerd was your type!

Even though he wasn't in front of me, I could feel his irritation.
he was so jealous of Yuri.

To: GagongBaliw

Message: I don't care!

From: GagongBaliw

*Message: Damn it! I'll wait for my chance, and I assure
looking at anyone else.*

I even clapped my hands before taking it out and began to

So good! So good!

While I was busy eating, I could hear Tita Gema sounding angry. I walked toward the kitchen door, about to leave, Kuya Angelo's voice, so I stopped.

"Mom! Please! I'm tired!" Kuya said, irritated.

"Are you thinking at all?! You just left and didn't go to work! I scolded.

"I just had something to take care of!"

"And what was that? Were you looking for the person who took Jay-Jay?! Let's just sue them, leave it to the police."

"Not all problems can be solved by the police."

"Angelo!"

"I'll go to work tomorrow. I saw Mykel, so I don't have a problem anymore."

I wanted to go out and ask Kuya about Mykel. What did he say next.

"He's in a coma. He's in a private hospital. Looks like I

["Jay?"] he answered as soon as I picked up.

"Are you busy?" I asked.

["Not really, why?"]

"Because... Mykel. He's in a private hospital."

["What?! Is he still alive?"]

I grimaced. "Y-yes, of course."

["Good. Because I'm the one who'll kill him."]

Damn! What a snake!

"What's wrong with you?! Let's go! I want to see him!"

["Do you know which hospital?"]

"Uh... No."

["Tss... Nice."] he said sarcastically. ["Wait a second. I'll

He didn't wait for me to respond. He hung up the call. Looking going to use his "ways" too. It's really different when you have so many connections. It feels like you can know an

Minutes later. I received a text from Yuri.

"Yeah." He answered quickly.

He started the car. I couldn't stop myself from feeling terrible. I wasn't involved in what happened to him, I still felt connected to him.

We arrived at a private hospital. The building had six floors. The rooms had no air conditioning. Yuri stopped in the parking lot.

"He's in the ICU," he said and motioned for me to go ahead.

I thought he was heading for the elevator, but when he saw a group of people to go with, he chose to take the stairs. I followed him. I had no complaint. We stopped on the third floor.

We approached a nurse station.

"Where's your ICU?" Yuri asked one of the nurses.

The nurse pointed to a nearby window with a curtain half-drawn. She said that unauthorized personnel weren't allowed to enter.

Yuri knocked on the adjacent door and spoke to the nurse inside. He told him. After a moment, the nurse pulled back the curtain, and a body came into view.

Fvcking shit!

I turned away and avoided looking. Yuri noticed this and me.

"Do you want to leave?" He asked.

I nodded, and he knocked on the ICU door again, thanking me. We walked out together.

"Whoever did this, they wanted to make Mykel suffer. They just wanted to endure the pain." Yuri said, and I looked at him. "It was a simple fight, Mykel could've fought back. It wouldn't have been a problem."

He's right! They wanted to torture him.

"Do you think... more than one person did this to him?"

"Maybe... Mykel's a big guy. It would be hard if just one person was against him."

That's true. Even I'd have a hard time fighting him. But you guys... —THEM!

I narrowed my eyes at him. "Maybe you guys did this to him?"

He quickly shook his head. "No! We didn't!"

I pointed at his face. "You guys did that to Kiko! How dare you do the same to Mykel?!"

advantage, while still keeping the person we're getting back
explained. "...to make them suffer alive."

"Why am I only hearing about this now?"

"Because he didn't want you to know."

Keifer...

Why would they tell me? Who am I? They've never treated
with them.

Chapter 231: Ugly Truth

Jay-jay's POV

["It's gone! Keifer had it deleted."] Ci-N replied from the line.

Yuri sighed and brought the phone closer to his lips.

"Didn't you save even one?"

["Nothing at all."]

"Alright, thanks."

The call ended, and Yuri pocketed his phone. He was looking back at their past antics from Ci-N. Apparently, Edrix used to keep the videos had been passed on to Batang Kumag.

That's why I saw the video of them beating up Kiko before the "One Hit Rule." Yuri admitted they didn't just do it once.

It totaled over 30 times. There was a video for each incident. We tried to borrow the videos to see who they had hurt, but they were gone.

"Wow... You get tired of your enemies but not of fighting amazed.

He smiled. "That's just how it is with us. We're Section E

"Tsk! Tsk! Tsk!" I shook my head in response.

He shoved his hands into his pants pockets. I crossed my arms into the distance. I couldn't stop thinking about who might hurt Mykel.

Whoever they were, why were they so furious? If it really was because I had this strange feeling.

"Who do you think really did that to Mykel?" I asked him.

He didn't answer. He kept staring into the distance, deep in thought. I grabbed his shoulder and pointed my finger to get his attention. He turned, I poked his cheek.

He chuckled slightly. "W-what?"

"I'm asking you. You're spacing out."

"Sorry. I was just thinking about what happened to Mykel. I took a breath. "...I have this weird feeling that it wasn't a group that hurt him."

... ..

"Keifer is who I'm thinking of."

I nodded. He was one of my suspects too, but there was a
GagongBaliw! He threatened Mykel in a text, saying he'

"I have another suspect," I said, pulling out my phone from
"...maybe you know this number."

I handed him the phone, showing the name and number of
textmate.

He raised an eyebrow. "Gagong...baliw?"

I named him that! Unique, right? Unique!

"Don't mind the name!"

He shrugged and took out his own phone. He started typing
the number, but quickly shook his head when he couldn't

I took the phone back from him.

"Who is this?" he asked again.

"This idiot has been texting me. He won't reveal himself
and you guys. And when I was hospitalized, he threatened
pay."

I opened our conversation and showed him the messages

"When I was kidnapped, and Keifer got stabbed."

He stared at me, looking concerned. "There was no one else when we arrived. Only Keifer was conscious."

I already knew that. That's what I thought at first too.

I stood up and walked closer to him. "Yeah, but it's impossible. First, Keifer was far from me when you guys arrived."

"No."

"Huh?"

"He was standing close to you when we arrived."

I frowned. I was starting to get confused again.

"B-but when the blindfold was removed..."

"He was standing, trying to walk, but he collapsed immediately because of his wound."

Holy f***ing shit!

What does that mean? That it was him who kissed me? That he was texting me, trying to get my attention? But why? How? What the hell is going on? I'm not a b****!

"Let's go... I'll take you home. It's getting dark."

I looked up at the sky. It wasn't getting dark because it was getting dark because the sky was darkening because it looked like it was about to rain when I heard a faint rumble of thunder.

Yuri quickly walked to his car. I followed and got in as soon as he opened the door.

"We almost got caught in the rain."

Yeah. He can't get wet. He'll multiply.

He started the car, and it was quiet. Minutes later, the headlights came on. That's when I asked myself.

Did I shower?

It doesn't matter. I'm here, already on my way home. Should I shower about not showering? It probably doesn't show. Yuri didn't say.

I casually smelled my armpit. It smells good! When was the last time I shaved?

"Jay? Are you okay?" Yuri asked.

Oh, he saw me!

"Yeah... I was just looking at something." I said while looking at my reflection in the rearview mirror.

"Do you still remember who they were?"

He scratched the back of his neck. "Hmm... Well, some of them who hurt you and tried to kidnap you."

I looked at him with furrowed brows. The monkeys who hurt me? The ones I fought with on the road? Seriously?

Just kidding, Yuri's a joker.

"...Do you think that's why none of them have come back?"

I paused to think. Oh right! They could've easily come back because they know where to find me.

"Is that the reason?"

He nodded. "I think there's only one person we couldn't get back."

My eyes widened. "Cyrus?! But didn't he already get a tattoo?"

He tilted his head slightly. "He said he didn't get enough."

What the heck!

That's embarrassing. Cyrus couldn't even get up after the attack and he rushed to the hospital. And he said he didn't get enough? That's so embarrassing.

"The rain's too heavy. We might get into an accident." He said, looking at the car.

"...Let's eat. It's on me."

I quickly took off my seatbelt. "Let's go! You're so slow!"

I was already out of the car before him. He just shook his head and opened the door for me.

This is free, man!

He locked the car and walked towards me. There were a lot of people at the entrance and exit of the mall, probably because of the rain. I had to leave.

I had to squeeze through the crowd. Once inside, people were crowding, so I had to squeeze through again.

In the middle of pushing through the crowd, someone suddenly put their arm around me.

I got startled and was about to slap the person, but I stopped when I saw who it was.

"Don't walk away from me," Yuri said, looking ahead. "

My brows furrowed. Why did that sound different? I checked

"So manly, it makes panties drop."

"Kuya is so handsome."

I looked at the ones who said that. What the heck, bro! I they're saying. When they saw me looking, they quickly

"Jealous much?" Yuri teased.

"Excuse me, I'm not jealous. It's just that what they said

"Why are you reacting? I never said it was about you." E

I raised my fist to his face. "Do you want this?"

He shook his head. "I told you, let's go. Let's eat at Toky

"That's more like it!"

We walked towards the restaurant he pointed out, which theme. He asked me to find a seat while he would take c

While waiting, I heard the sound of my phone buzzing. A came in. I took it out of my pocket and checked who the

GagongBaliw came to mind first, and it seemed I was rig

From: GagongBaliw

I quickly replied.

To: GagongBaliw

Message: How did you know? Are you here? Where? Sh

From: GagongBaliw

Message: I don't want to! If you want to see me, come fi

To: GagongBaliw

Message: I don't want to! Later, after eating.

From: GagongBaliw

Message: Greedy! Greedy!

I was about to curse out someone really badly when Yuri hid my phone.

"Do you have someone texting you?" he innocently aske

"W-what? N-no... I'm just reading."

"On Wattpad? Oh no! Stop it... It's so addictive."

I looked at him in surprise. "You know Wattpad?"

"Keep it up. It's attractive."

"Am I attracting you?" He asked with a smile.

I've been attracted to you for a while, but my feelings for Snakes have been stronger.

I felt awkward all of a sudden, so I decided to roll my eyes at what I was feeling. He just laughed in response. It wasn't until the waiter brought his order.

I focused on my food, even though deep down, my mind was still with the situation between the three of us.

I was almost done eating when my phone rang. I looked at it and saw a call from GagongBaliw.

"Who's that?" Yuri asked.

I didn't answer. I decided to pick up the call from GagongBaliw.

"Hello..." I said as I answered. "...What do you need?"

I expected a response, but I didn't hear anything on the other end. In the accident, I looked at the glass wall of the restaurant. I felt like I was trapped.

Keifer was standing not far away.

"Is everything okay?" Yuri asked.

I didn't realize Yuri had followed me.

"Jay! Why? Did you see something?!" he asked worriedly

"I-I saw him here... He was standing here."

"Who?"

"Keifer."

I kept walking around, hoping to see him again.

"Maybe it was just your imagination."

I shook my head. "He was really here. He was looking at

It was definitely him. I couldn't be wrong.

Yuri furrowed his brows, one hand in his pocket and the phone. That's when I remembered my phone.

He was holding it, and I quickly snatched it from him.

There was a text message from GagongBaliw.

From: GagongBaliw

Message: Don't.

Yuri quickly hugged me, and I buried my face in his chest. The others were staring at us, but I didn't care about them.

"Don't cry because of him."

Damn! It was so hard for me, and he had to speak in Japanese.

I wanted to smack him! Doesn't he know I don't understand Japanese? I stayed in that position for a few moments before I decided to cry.

"Sorry... I couldn't hold it in. I was just so frustrated," I cried, wiping my tears.

"It's okay... I'm always here for you."

He gently placed his hand on my head and ruffled my hair. I smiled. His hand slowly moved from my head to my hand.

He slowly walked, and I just followed. My eyes were on him. He wasn't holding my hand too tightly, but I felt like I was being held. My pulse felt so hot.

We reached the parking lot, and he opened the car door for me. I fastened my seatbelt. He smiled at me before closing the door.

He walked to the driver's seat as if he had no life in him.

When he got in, he sighed loudly. He fastened his seatbelt.

"I want to blame you," he started. "...I want to get angry complain. But that's wrong because from the beginning, clear to me that it's really Keifer."

Please... Yuri...

I lowered my head. "That's why you should stop. I don't anymore."

"It's not possible," he replied, which made me look at him stop loving?"

"But Yuri, you're just hurting."

"And you're hurting because of him, but did you stop?"

I shook my head at his words. I understood why he was confused. I was still confused.

He took off his seatbelt and moved closer to me. He took kissed it.

"Hurt me. Hurt me many times. Hurt me anytime. I don't I feel numb." He held my hand tightly.

"...I'll accept it no matter how painful it is because I can't handle losing you."

FILE:///root/.openclaw/workspace/Scribd.html

"And you're the vice president."

Chapter 232: Doughnut or

Jay-jay's POV

Weird! So weird! Super duper weird! Super duper ultra v ultra omega to the highest level weird!

Your face, Jay-jay, is weird.

I was standing in front of my table, staring at the food. Y There was a box of donuts on the table. There was also c Starbucks.

"Jay-jay!" Ci-N greeted me as he approached.

he glanced at the box of donuts, and his eyes instantly lit the food was meant for him.

"Can I have some?" he said, reaching for the box, but I s away.

"Don't take it! We don't even know where that came from

"Of course, one of our classmates brought it! You don't h outside to bring you something like that!" he said, irritate hand

Okay, it's not him either!

I turned to the left where the group of troublemakers and seated together. I first looked at Edrix, who was busy on idiot didn't even notice. He was probably playing some g

Okay, not him!

Next to him was Rory, who was writing something in his glanced at me and quickly turned the notebook away, as something I wouldn't understand.

It's not him either.

It's just not him! That guy's greedy too—if it came from getting the box!

I then looked at Mayo. He would sometimes glance at K whoever he was talking to, which was Josh.

Seems like it's not him either. Kit's his focus.

I then turned to the person next to him, but I froze when box was already open, and he had a donut in his hand, al away.

"Wait! I only looked away for a second!"

"G... 1"1... 1111... 11111"

But I can only afford donuts worth 11 pesos.

I looked at the Snakes around me. They were all staring at me, avoiding eye contact as if they were waiting to see if I would or not.

Tsk! If I take one—of course, I'll get to eat it. I don't care! It's delicious!

But if I do what they expect—whatever! I'll eat it! No more should I overthink? It's food! Food is life! My life to be eaten!

I'll eat and eat!

I don't care if they think I lost because I accepted it. I grabbed it and quickly ate it. I heard some people laughing, but I ignored them.

I ate, and Ci-N joined me. I noticed David, who had just one eyebrow at us, as if asking where we got the food.

"Do you want some? Go ahead and take one." I offered.

"I'll just take the coffee," he said as he grabbed the coffee.

He looked like he was dead tired. He probably hasn't slept. He's going to sleep until later.

David, the one with high-class instincts but always looking

—Felix.'

I raised my eyebrows. Felix gave this? Oh, this is intense

Son of a... I got tricked!

I quickly stood up and threw the box at Felix, who was c
mischievously. He ducked to avoid it.

"I never said I agreed!" I yelled at him angrily.

"...And I didn't even eat it, Ci-N did!"

"But you still ate it," he said with a smile.

"Whatever! I'm not going on a date with you!"

I went back to my seat, crossing my arms and leaning ba
hear their teasing and laughing. These Snakes thought th
like that.

No way! I'm too smart for that!

Sir Alvin arrived, and our class started. He began by rem
upcoming exam until...

"You'll have a half-day today." He announced.

I straightened up. My ears almost grew bigger so I could

Hehehe...

Time passed without me noticing. Our class ended, and there was no more school, so I quickly packed up my things.

I was about to leave the room when I heard Felix calling
"Wait for me! We have a date!"

I cringed. He really thought I would agree to this so-called date.
"You have a date?" Ci asked, suddenly appearing in front of me.

I almost cursed at him because he startled me. he popped a mushroom. I glared at him.

"No way! Let's go, we're going home!" I said, pulling on my bag.
I took big steps away from the room to avoid Felix.

Let him figure out his own life. He can have a date with anyone.

When we got to the gate, we walked with a group of students.

I could still hear my name being called out. As soon as we reached the gate, I let go of Ci and started running. I knew that idiot would follow me.

I only stopped when I started feeling tired. We were pretty far from school.

I turned to face him angrily, ready to yell at him, but my
when I saw who was standing beside him.

Felix was leaning against a car, and Percy was peeking f
Both of them were laughing and smiling at me. I gave Ci

"Run if you can! They're in a car!" he said irritably. "I've
"Sorry."

"You think you can escape me." Felix teased. "...I'm sma
That line is mine!

"You think I'll agree to a date with you?" I mimicked his
bro, smart."

"Let's go sightseeing." Ci said.

I shook my head. No matter where they take me—wheth
Kingdom or Disneyland.

"Let's go shopping." he added.

I shook my head again. Even if they bought the whole Pl
"Food."

I shook my head once more. Even if it's all the food—I n

NO! I won't be fooled by that "free" offer. No matter wh
NO!

"Fine. I want pizza." I said, quickly getting into the car.

Ci-N and Felix clapped in joy. I took the backseat, and tl
me.

"Who said you could come with us?" Percy asked Ci, irr

"Jay-jay," he quickly answered while holding my arm.

I didn't say anything.

"It's okay, so Jay-jay won't feel awkward around me," Fe
buckled his seatbelt.

He turned to me and winked. I just sighed in annoyance.
catching his arrogance, like the king of this cat.

Or maybe it's just because he's a Snake, that's why he's li

He's a cat. He's Felix the Cat.

If I weren't so hungry, I wouldn't be going with them. I'll
Percy and Ci-N invited me. I know what Felix's plan is.

I know this is part of their courtship routine. He thought
me over. He still went with him, despite everything such

Whenever Percy and I were together, there were times he'd ask me if I had forgiven his brother for trying to get me to talk to him.

What a piece of work! Maybe I shouldn't have eaten that

The car slowed down gradually. I looked out the window

I saw a vintage-style pizza house. Just in time, the car turned into the parking area.

Felix and Ci-N were the first to get out. Percy and I followed.

"We'll find an empty table," Felix said, quickly walking toward the entrance.

"Pizza! Pizza! Pizza! Pizza!" Ci-N sang while following us.

"Hey! You're paying for what you eat!" Percy shouted at the brat.

The brat didn't even acknowledge Percy's shout until the car stopped. He quickly turned to Percy and shot him a sharp look.

"What is this?! You planned this, didn't you?!"

He scratched the back of his head and smiled at me. "I'm sorry, brother. I want us to be a happy family."

I pointed at his face. "Your face is a happy family! You're a happy family!"

I pretended to throw a punch at him, but he quickly dodged. I know, Felix was made a Collins because of Percy's dad. I told him to America, if it ever happened.

I walked toward the entrance of the restaurant, but before I reached the door handle, Percy blocked my way. His eyes were serious and he looked at me.

"If you're going to force me to adopt Felix—"

"It's not that," he cut me off. "...Give Felix a chance to explain."

I furrowed my brows at him. "Even if—"

"Jay. Everyone makes mistakes. Felix made one, but doesn't have the right to explain."

"Right?"

"The right to be forgiven and given a chance," he smiled at me.

"...too bad my brother's good-looking. He got that from his dad. I got my chance."

He even slipped that in.

I was about to slap him, but he quickly entered the restaurant. I put my hand on the door. Thankfully, I pulled back before it was too late.

"What are you two doing?" I asked, irritated.

The two quickly moved apart and almost simultaneously other.

"I said I want to sit next to him," the brat explained.

"I'm his brother, so I should be there."

I shook my head at them. The two of them couldn't be in together. Instead of fueling their argument, I decided to sit at a spot near them.

Before the two idiots could start fighting over who would sit next to me, Felix sat at the spot opposite me.

It should've been for a single person.

"Why? What's the matter?" he innocently asked while looking at me.

"Trying to steal seats," Percy said sternly.

Ci-N started to snuffle like he was about to cry. Reluctantly, I moved to the seats near us that were for two people. The two immediately looked at each other.

"What do you want to eat?" Felix asked.

Felix placed my order, and of course, since those two are ordered so much food. They even almost argued over what to order.

They acted like they were the center of attention.

Good thing there weren't that many people here. I started to think the food might not even be that great. I hope it is, or I'll probably be I'm already not enjoying my companions, and the food too.

"Jay-jay," Felix called me.

I pretended I didn't hear him. I kept looking around at the place, even noticing the light bulbs on the ceiling.

"I know you can hear me," he said. "...I just hope you understand my explanation."

I sighed in the air. I shouldn't have come with them. Dan was right.

You look like you're free!

Those damn Snakes! They're taking advantage of my weakness. I'll come up with a strategy to avoid their nonsense.

"I'm sorry, Jay," he started. "...I'm sorry for lying to you. I was angry at you back then. Every time I saw you, I thought of Aries. All those feelings came rushing back."

"I'm sorry, Jay," he started. "...I'm sorry for lying to you. I was angry at you back then. Every time I saw you, I thought of Aries. All those feelings came rushing back."

"What happened with the whole Section E isn't a lie. Those were happy, the days you helped us face our problems, the days we were happy because we had a troublesome Jay-jay with us." Felix was still smiling. "...All of that is real."

It sounded so sweet, but it was hard to believe.

I looked at Ci-N. he was obviously listening to us, but he was taking care. I turned back to Felix, but this time, my gaze was different.

Just like how I felt with Yuri and Ci-N when I was putting on a brave face. I felt the same way now. There was a pain in my chest.

"How can you say that? It was a lie, right? A form of deception." Felix laughed. "...and that's the whole point. Making you believe what's not true."

Felix stared at me seriously. It looked like my words hurt him.

I couldn't blame him, but that's how I've felt all along.

I blamed myself for being fooled. I thought I was dumb. But something's wrong, because even the smartest person can be deceived in different ways.

It just means they know how to trick you. They know how to make you believe quickly. They show you the truth, but behind that is deception.

stopped a long time ago. We felt it, we knew he stopped. He smiled. "...was starting to feel real emotions for you."

Shut up!

I opened my mouth, ready to speak, but my words got stuck. I quickly looked away.

Just in time, I caught Ci-N's eyes. he was smiling at me. I thought of what Felix had said. Like he was telling me that everything was true.

"Honestly, you've changed the way I see women because you became friends, and you tolerated me even when I pushed you away."

He grabbed my hand again, and this time, he didn't let go. I did with Keifer. I regret pushing that plan. I understand your hope you can give me, or us, a chance to show you that you're one of us."

My words got stuck again. It was so messy. Everything was so messy. I didn't know what to believe anymore.

Chapter 233: Tren

Jay-jay's POV

Stunned! No response!

"It looks like he's stunned."

Looks like stunned—who are you calling stunned?! I immediately gave a bad look to the one who said that. It was Ci-N, holding a

"Are you talking about me?"

he shook his head. "No, I'm talking about the two siblings"

he was referring to Felix and Percy. We were about to leave when someone greeted them, someone they said was a friend. When they started chatting away.

We were already at the parking lot waiting for them. We watched from here through the glass window.

"You're unbelievable. They're the ones treating you." I spread my arms.

he continued eating his ice cream. some of it dripped on

"Jay, can I have another tissue?" Ci asked.

I opened my bag again and got the tissue he requested, but noticed something inside. There was a pink envelope.

I handed the tissue to the brat before picking up the envelope design. It looked familiar, like I had seen it and held it before.

Déjà vu again.

I opened the envelope. It was obvious it was for me. It was in my bag if it weren't. Inside was something that looked like a letter.

All I can say is: the penmanship is beautiful! Very feminine.

'Dear Jay-jay,

This is not a love letter. It's more like a friendship letter.'

I stopped reading and put it back in the envelope. The cursive was so corny. It almost made me sleepy, and I couldn't understand the handwriting was impressive.

I looked at the restaurant door when the siblings came out.

Percy had a scowl on his face, but Felix was smiling.

"Annoying! Why am I so good-looking?!" he said in frustration.

"...apparently, the guy is interested in zombies."

Felix and Ci-N burst out laughing. Percy shot them both started laughing at the idea of Percy being a zombie. His really something.

"Want to walk home?" Percy threatened them, and they l stopped.

I just shook my head. He opened the car door, and we qu two of them were laughing occasionally.

"Let's go, Zombie Lord." I teased.

He slammed the door shut. "I'm not a zombie! Don't you handsome to be a zombie!"

I had to hold back my laugh in the back seat. He's really word "handsome." He sounds so ridiculous! He's totally

"...When I turn into a zombie, a lot of girls will want to k my looks!" he continued as he buckled his seatbelt.

"The air conditioning's so strong!" Ci-N sarcastically rer were directly under the car's air conditioner while laughi

"Do you want to get out?" Percy asked him sarcastically. around! I haven't even started the engine yet! You're just

"What's that?! Why are you guys laughing?" Percy asked.

"Nothing. Just drive." Felix responded with a laugh.

The car stopped for a moment because of a traffic light. I looked out the window. It seemed like we were going down a different street than we were going home.

Wait! Where are we going?

"I thought we were going home? Why does this feel like a wrong direction?" I asked while continuing to look outside.

"Who said we're going home?" Felix replied, smiling at me. "Not over yet."

I frowned. This guy is intense! If my phone didn't ring, I would have hit him already.

I took my phone out of my bag. I had received a text message.

From: Pres. Yuri

Message: How's it going? Enjoying your date with Felix?

I edited his name by adding 'Pres.' which means President. President of our club. I quickly typed a reply to him.

To: Pres. Yuri

I almost laughed because of his emoji, it seemed like he surprised. I smiled and replied to him.

To: Pres. Yuri

Message: It's not that! I'm just feeling awkward.

From: Pres. Yuri

Message: ahh... I thought it was because of the two of you feel jealous. 🙄🙄

I shook my head while smiling. That guy's acting like me, probably why he texted me, he's restless.

Yuri, the jealous one...

To: Pres. Yuri

Message: Tsk! To calm you down, Ci-N is the one beside

From: Pres. Yuri

Message: 🙄🙄

To: Pres. Yuri

Message: 🙄🙄

This kid's unbelievable! So persistent in eavesdropping.

In my frustration, I shoved my phone in his face.

"There! Take it! Shove it in your eyes! Stop snooping around angrily.

he just laughed at me when I took the phone away from him.

he even made a funny face while flashing a peace sign.

I just want to slap him sometimes.

"Who are you texting?" he asked.

I looked at the rearview mirror, and Percy was looking at me. I turned away and coughed lightly to clear my throat.

"Nothing."

I gripped my phone tightly. Percy doesn't like it when Yu mentioned. As time passes, it seems like his anger towards me is getting stronger.

I've been trying to understand the real reason behind it, but he's so elusive. He either avoids it or changes the topic, getting me to stand hearing the truth.

But if he doesn't tell me, I won't understand.

Message: busy?

You look busy!

This is another mystery in my life. My gut is telling me a strong feeling that this person is connected to the King of

I didn't reply. There are some things I'm waiting for this. Things will lead to him being caught.

"We're here!" Felix announced.

I looked at what they were looking at outside the car. It was the biggest arcades here in our area.

Game House!

Percy parked the car in front of the building. It was obvious. He even got out of the car first, looking thrilled while pointing at the Game House building.

"Let's go! Let's go in! I'm so excited!" he said.

I scratched the back of my head while getting out of the car. The side was coming out again. He already had a birthday, so +1 in maturity, but it's like he got a -1 instead.

"Why did we even bring him?" Percy whispered.

The little one was so eager, he almost bumped into the d the guy avoided it. I just apologized so there would be no discussion.

The place was huge, divided into three sections: a playground, an arcade for adults, and a shop selling food, toys, and clothes.

Awesome! This place was heaven for the great hangout place.

"Wow! It's really big." Felix commented from behind me.

"Jay-jay!" Ci-N called me while waving. "...let's ride this thing."

I walked towards him to see what he was pointing at. It was a small cart usually in malls for people to ride around. But we couldn't ride it, we were too big for it.

Some young people were looking at us, probably wondering why we wanted to ride it even though we were already grown-up.

We'd look ridiculous if we did.

"Ci... Um... H-haha, we can't ride that." I said awkwardly.

His face immediately changed. His shoulders slumped, looking like disappointment.

"Oh no... It looks like the kid's going to cry." I heard Per

His thinking really regressed.

"Ci-N. You're too old for this..." I didn't finish my sentence started to sniffle.

Sigh! I can't believe I'm going to do this. But I can't be that ridiculous.

"Fine. Fine. I'll ride it." I said boredly.

he started clapping with joy and even jumping up and down to shake my head.

"On one condition." I added, stopping him. "...they have to be able to ride it." he looked toward the two idiots. Percy was even picking up the reins. Both looked our way. I gestured for them to come closer.

"Why?" He asked, flicking his finger after using it to dig his nostrils.

What a mess!

"We're all riding it together," I emphasized the word "all."

"There's no 'all' here." Felix replied.

"You want a punch to the stomach?" I threatened.

Felix furrowed his brows and gave Percy a bad look. "U mean it's not just one person?"

The two continued arguing. I whispered to Ci to buy tick us. Once he found a spot, I quickly moved behind the tw them with all my strength.

"W-wait! We're not riding this!" Percy complained.

I kept pushing them toward the train car's entrance. They because the entrance was so narrow. Once they got insid followed and positioned myself near them to prevent the

I thought Ci-N was with us, but when I looked for him, h beside the driver in front of us. Looks like that guy didn' him. He could only scratch his head while staring at the l

"Why did we even have to come with you guys?" Felix s

"Who started this date?"

"It's embarrassing to ride this. It's for kids."

"Why did you even bring us here?"

"Percy said... you'd like the arcade."

I quickly turned to Percy, who was frowning. "Who said
1 3"

Felix, Percy, and I all quickly bent down. People were still laughing. I couldn't blame them. We did look ridiculous.

"This is your fault, Jay." Percy said to me while covering his hands.

"It's your fault! You knew there was a kid with us, and you were here!" I replied angrily.

What's even worse is that the train was moving so slowly it crawled faster.

Crawl already! Hurry up!

I just wanted this humiliation to end. At least Ci-N was sitting beside the driver. He was even waving his hand, acting like a celebrity with a motorcade.

Our embarrassment got worse when we passed by the architecture high school students. They quickly stared at us and laughed.

Annoying! So frustrating!

We stayed hunched down for a few more minutes until the train stopped. We all jumped out of the car. We stepped a little back and crossed our arms almost at the same time.

We waited for Ci-N, who was still so happy and didn't seem

Ci scratched the back of his head and pouted. We walked because that was really where we were supposed to go, the train.

Percy bought the cards for us. He also loaded them up with games.

He handed the cards to us with a frown. He even got one

Ci-N quickly ran to the games that gave out tickets as people going to save them to get the stuffed toy he saw on display.

There were a lot of games to choose from, but I immediately chose a basketball game. It was all guys playing, but I didn't care because that was the reason I was there.

Who cares about them!

I swiped my card and started playing. I kept shooting the ball in the second round when I noticed something from the corner of my eye.

The group of guys who had been playing earlier were all looking at me. I barely glanced at them, and I was so annoyed that they were imitating my chest.

They were pretending to have boobs using their hands and saying they would bounce. They laughed while pointing at me. I just felt frustration.

They threw the ball back to me. I smiled at them and that's when I hadn't even returned to my spot yet when they spoke again. "I think you like us!" One of them said, and they all laughed. Like?! I felt like my stomach was turning.

I raised an eyebrow. "Excuse me?"

"Don't play hard to get. Just tell us if you want one of us."

I just laughed at what they said. They were like a worse version of me.

"Wow, you guessed it." I said with a smile.

They're probably relatives of Madam Auring.

The idiots quickly exchanged smiles and high-fived each other.

I gripped the ball tightly.

"Which one of us is your type? Point us out." One of them said.

"I like all of you..." I lost my smile. "...I like breaking all of them."

With all my strength, I threw the ball at one of them. It hit his face! Chaos quickly broke out as people stared at us.

He was about to approach me, but a big body quickly blocked him. He was too tall for them.

"You're angry at what she did to your friend? What about disrespecting her?" Felix retorted.

Has he been here the whole time? He even knows about

The guys couldn't do anything, especially when Percy stood up to Felix. The two of them were almost the same size. They had a swagger and presence.

"Is there a problem here?" Percy asked, pretending to be

The guys slowly shook their heads. They hurriedly lifted their heads and walked away from us. I even heard the people around us

The two turned to me. "Are you okay?"

I nodded and looked at Felix. He was smiling at me as if I was fine now. I don't know why, but I found myself smiling.

"Thank you." I said while lowering my head.

I felt his hand gently rest on my head. "You sure know how to

I couldn't help but laugh at what he said. He was the same old simple laugh, it felt like everything between us lightened

Chapter 234: Penmanship

Jay-jay's POV

It was already late in the afternoon when we decided to go be out too late because Tita knew we were only supposed to be out the day.

Ci-N was enjoying his hug with the stuffed toy he got. he dog.

"You're so cute! I'll name you..." he looked up and held i jay!"

You idiot!

I slapped him on the back of the head hard. Seriously, w you name an animal after me?!

"Ouch! Jay-jay... Jay-jay slapped me," he complained to

I heard Felix and Percy laughing softly in front of us.

I kicked their chairs, so they looked at us for a moment.

They really had the audacity to laugh at me.

But now you know, right?

He slipped earlier and mentioned that he had a video call. I tried to clarify, he avoided me and pretended to be busy.

"How long are you going to hide it from me that you guys are talking?" I asked irritably and faced Felix. "...Maybe even talking to him?"

Felix quickly avoided eye contact. Tsk! I knew it. There he was talking to those Snake people. I'm not mad or sulking. We need to talk about giving each other space, right?

But I don't know, a part of me is looking for him, and that's because of my annoyance.

He misses the King.

"He won't be able to resist." Percy said, and we looked at each other.

"...It's too much for him. He doesn't know how to wait."

That reminded me of when Yuri and I were eating. I'm sure he was thinking about it too.

"Is it possible that..." I whispered.

I don't understand something. Actually, I don't understand anything. Why does everything have to be so messy?

"You said Keifer stopped the plan on his own, so you guys in the end, it seems like he still continued it."

Ci-N and Felix exchanged looks. It was as if they were a the same thing.

"Jay..." Ci called me. "...We really don't know the reason mess happened, we noticed he was acting restless."

"They always argue with Keigan." Felix added.

I looked at them in confusion. "Keigan?"

Felix nodded. "One time I went to their place, and they v each other. They were about to fight."

What?!

I had a feeling that something happened that we didn't ki
Honestly, I'm struggling with this situation. There's no cl
anything.

Keifer! I think you have a lot to explain to me. When you
you better be ready.

"We're here. Get off, kid!" Percy said.

Ci-N stuck out his tongue at him. "Okay, okay!" he turne

Suddenly, the two of them started arguing about who she date. I didn't pay attention to them because there were ot mind.

Food?!

I always think about that. But there's something else. Wh have to be so complicated?

The two of them were still arguing when we got to the fr

"Thanks for the ride." I said and got out of the car.

I was about to enter the gate when Felix called me.

"Thank you." He said with a smile. "...I won't waste the c me."

I smiled at him and nodded. I entered the gate. At least n towards Felix. I guess that's how it feels when you've for

But what about the others?

Should I forgive them too? But how can I do that when s proud of what they did?

Those Snakes. Those Stupid Snakes. That's why they bec because they're Snakes.

"You just came out from the hospital, Jay."

I lowered my head. I knew what he meant. He was worried because of the trouble that happened.

"S-sorry. I should've texted first."

He let out a loud sigh, as if he was really troubled and I just felt worse. I knew he was already having problems with them, but there was something different about the way he acted now.

"Nevermind. Go change and eat. Mom made snacks." He then walked out of the house.

I just stood there watching him. I followed him with my eyes.

Maybe Kuya is really tired from everything he's dealing with. I'll comb his hair.

Good thing he's handsome.

I went straight to my room to change, just like Kuya told me to.

While changing my shirt, I heard my phone go off.

I took it from my bag, and it was a message from Yuri.

From: Pres. Yuri

Message:

Hahahahaha...

Is he crazy?!

He laughed at me. He seemed so happy. His happiness was enviable, I wish he would share some of it with me.

I put my phone down and continued getting dressed. When I was about to grab my phone again, I noticed something in my pocket open, and some things were peeking out.

The letter...

I took it out and looked at it again. I didn't finish reading it, but I felt like it was a woman who wrote it. It looked like it was written by a woman!

I opened the envelope again and continued reading the letter.

'Dear Jay-jay,

This is not a love letter. It's more of a friendship letter. But I know we're not lovers—and this thing is so cheesy.

Please bear with me, I'm not good at writing letters. All I want to do is explain my side and ask for your forgiveness. So please,

didn't have any female classmates who would write some continued reading.

*'But believe me, when things got better because of you, I
out. I wanted to not get involved, but I was forced to stay
my fear of Keifer. None of us could face him. Even Yuri, I
admitted he couldn't handle him. That's why I stayed quiet
acting.*

*I was also angry when I saw him succeeding. I felt sorry
you were falling into his trap. I had no one to talk to bec
was the only one opposing what he was doing. I didn't ev
because I knew she'd get involved.*

*I stayed quiet over time, not because I was still scared, b
that even Keifer had fallen into the trap he set for you. I
happened, but when he said those hurtful words to you, I
surprised and confused.*

*I won't drag this on. I know you're lazy to read. It's you!
and leave the decision to you.*

I'm happy to be your friend. I hope you'll give me a chan

With love as a friend,

—Handsome Calix'

can explain why he still hurt me.

What are you hiding, King of Snakes?!

I put the letter down on my study table. I was starting to because of all this. I left my room and walked to the kitchen for snacks.

I was near Kuya Angelo's room when a paper flew to my window and I looked at it. It looked like a print of some kind of request. I read!

I looked at Kuya's room since it seemed to be where it came from. I approached it and saw that the door was open. There were papers on the floor, likely blown by the wind.

I scratched my head and entered, picking up the papers. I found the source of the wind that had blown the papers. I looked at the window next to Kuya's study table. It wasn't fully closed, and it seemed to be the cause.

Tsk! Kuya again! Doesn't know how to close a window!

I properly shut the window and started fixing the papers. While looking at the papers, I noticed a picture next to a brown envelope.

"That's me," I whispered.

R.Sato? Is this the Ryosuke Sato they were talking about wants to kill me? The one who fought with Yuri? I thought trying to hurt me, but what is this?

I put the picture down and looked inside the brown envelope more pictures of me. I quickly checked the backs of them

'Just wait... for me to kill you. Bitch!'

'Blame Yuri and Keifer... Blame them when you see them

'Keep laughing... Because that will be your last laugh.'

'I can't wait to kill you and see Yuri cry in pain.'

All of these were from Sato. My hands were shaking as I read the letter and picture. Death has been watching me without me knowing.

Maybe one day, I'll just collapse on the street.

"Hey! What are you doing there?!" Aries shouted at me from behind.

I just looked at him, my tears almost falling because of fear.

"I'm asking you!" He said as he quickly walked toward me.

He grabbed the pictures I was holding and looked at them. Then he looked at the writings on the back. His eyes widened, and he

I don't need a lecture right now! Please!

He grabbed his phone and dialed a number. I didn't know he was calling. He stared at me while waiting for the call to connect.

"When did this happen?" He asked me.

I shook my head. "I-I don't know."

"What do you mean you don't know?!"

"I only saw it now... in Kuya's room."

He looked at the pictures on the table for a moment. He held his phone away from his ear and started pressing buttons again, then brought it back to his ear.

It was obvious he was getting annoyed at whoever he was talking to.

"Do you know where Kuya went?" He asked irritably.

I shook my head again. "I-I saw him leave the house, but I don't know where he went."

He dropped the phone and almost threw it out of frustration. He was calling Kuya Angelo.

"Do Keifer and the others know about this?!"

I nodded. "I-I talked to him the first time, but it ended up

"What the fvck, Jay?! Are you really looking for trouble involved with Keifer's mess?!" He angrily said.

He paced back and forth in front of me, running his fingers as if pulling at it in frustration.

I didn't know if he was worried about me or what. Whatever I couldn't feel anything. Fear and anxiety took over me.

"Call Yuri. I need to talk to him." He ordered.

I looked at him, confused. My mouth hung open as I started

This must be the first time he's going to talk to Yuri since the incident.

"Do what I said!" He yelled at me, and I panicked on what

I ran back to my room to grab my phone and call Yuri. My hands were shaking as I dialed his number.

Calm down, Jay!

How can I calm down?! I'm about to die without knowing

The phone started ringing. I felt like with each second that he answered, death was getting closer.

My hands were still trembling even after talking to him. I was scared, but I didn't understand why. It seems like all my energy has been drained by Kuya Angelo, and now I couldn't face them.

Suddenly, Aries appeared at the door and spoke. "Did you curse at me?"

"F*CK!" I screamed out of shock.

"Did you just curse at me?!" He said angrily.

"Why do you keep barging in like that?!"

"Now it's my fault?!"

"Stop surprising me!"

"Why are you spacing out?!"

"I'm thinking, obviously!"

"Did you call him?"

"Yes!"

"Why are you shouting?!"

"Because you're shouting!"

Tita Gema suddenly appeared and looked at us with surprise.

Jay-jay... Yes! Especially when she's hungry.

"I'm just saying." Tita replied before turning around and
Aries immediately glared at me. "Don't leave your room.

"Why?! Yuri's coming."

"We need to talk. Not you two!" He said and closed the door
before leaving.

What on earth are they going to talk about?!

Chapter 235: Forgiveness

Jay-jay's POV

"What did you two talk about?" I asked Aries while we v breakfast.

"Nothing, forget about it," he replied in a bored tone.

I gave him a sharp look. "Tell me!"

"Tsk! Stop annoying me!"

"What's going on here?!" Mama said irritably, walking to

She drank the coffee from her cup before placing it down

She gave us both a sharp look as if telling us that we were annoying siblings on the planet.

But Aries looked like dirt.

"Early in the morning and you two are already fighting! quiet?" she said, grabbing a piece of bread.

I just lowered my head as I took a bite of my rice, while

Aries and I exchanged looks. It was like he was about to tell me something. "We stared at each other for a long time before he told me about Angelo."

Oh no! He's going to report me!

"It was Aries! Aries went into your room!" I said, pointing at him.

His eyebrows furrowed immediately, and he gave me a skeptical look.

I bit my lower lip as I slowly pulled back my finger.

Kuya looked at Aries. "Did you go into my room?"

Aries stared at me for a moment. "Yeah, I did."

Wooooooshhh! Saved!

"...I saw what was inside the brown envelope on your table. It was a letter from Kuya stopping Kuya in his tracks."

Kuya's gaze shifted from him to me. I quickly avoided eye contact and returned to eating my breakfast. Mama looked confused and the conversation went on.

"What are you two talking about?" she asked.

Secret! No clue!

Kuya quickly grabbed his things and walked out. Aries f up without saying a word.

I tried to chew my food quickly so I could leave too, kno only keep bothering me.

Hurry up and eat, Jay!

Just as she was about to ask something, I stood up and sw everything in my mouth. I drank some water to help it go

"I'm going to take a shower," I said as I quickly left with response.

Each step was big, but I wasn't headed to my room. I wa room instead. I didn't knock and just walked straight in, r regretted.

Mistake on my part—walking straight in and getting clo wasn't expecting to find him topless, with just boxer sho

Shit! My eyes! Oh no! My eyes!

"What the fvck!!" he screamed when he saw me.

Honestly, it wasn't new to me since I'd gotten used to see half-dressed. I've seen them in boxer shorts and without dressed in front of me, especially during P.E. class.

I almost forgot why I came in. It was his scar that caught

"Just... I just wanted to say thank you for what you did e

He raised an eyebrow. "Because I had no choice. You ma
hadn't—just be thankful I wanted to know something, so
responsibility!"

"What do you want to know?"

He placed his hands on his hips. "Do I really need to say

I averted my gaze and bit my lip. "Yes, please."

He sighed deeply. "I want to know why the pictures are
he's already done something about it. Is that okay? Satisf

I nodded slowly. "I actually have one more question."

"What?! Spill the beans."

I felt so shy asking him this, but... "Are we okay now?"

He froze for a moment, clearly confused, but it seemed l
thinking about it.

"Tell me my horoscope for today."

"Get out " That was his only response

I couldn't understand his actions, and I couldn't understand why he was mad at him. I felt bad because of what he was doing to me, a part of me wanted to make up with him. I missed the life I had.

I went straight to the bathroom and took a shower. While brushing my teeth, I suddenly remembered Aries' scar beneath his chin.

Where did he get that? Why does he have that?

It felt strange, thinking about that scar. I found myself touching my chest. If I wasn't mistaken, the scar was near the bottom of my chest.

Wait... Was that right? Near the ribs—near the lungs? Is that possible?

'Jay-jay! It's me! WAAAG!'

"Argh! That hurts!" I shouted as I held my head.

I dropped my toothbrush and grabbed the sink with one hand. My head suddenly hurt, and then a thought popped into my mind.

That was Aries' voice. I couldn't be wrong. But it was vague, I couldn't understand it. It felt like a part of the past, a sudden flash of memory I didn't remember.

I couldn't recall when that happened. It felt like I had no idea.

~~~~~

**From: +639\*\*\*\*\***

*Message: You're dead*

A strange sense of fear enveloped me after reading that r  
dropped my phone. I hoped it was just a prank. I hoped I  
what I was thinking.

Please, no...

What if someone was waiting for me when I leave the ho  
to go back inside. What if something happens to me at sc  
to look good if I die.

How would I get out of this? I knew Aries wouldn't take

Yuri!

Right! I'll ask him to pick me up. I'll also ask him about  
about with Aries. I'll tell him about the message I receive

My hands were still shaking as I searched for his number  
message came through, and I accidentally tapped on his  
started the call.

StupidCrazy!

He answered the call quickly, so I didn't get a chance to

*Message: Why are you not responding to my messages?*

I stared at his message. It seemed like he wasn't acting like now.

I ignored it and just replied to him.

**To: StupidCrazy**

*Message: bc it's me A lot happened yesterday. (Because happened yesterday.)*

**From: StupidCrazy**

*Message: Still! You should have text me atleast!*

**To: StupidCrazy**

*Message: demanding! Do you love me?*

**From: StupidCrazy**

*Message: no! But I'm your future.*

I just grimaced at what he said. This guy is something. But good effect. He temporarily made me forget my fears.

I didn't reply to him anymore. I just focused on what I needed Yuri to ask him for a ride

I heard him laugh lightly. ["Actually, I've been waiting for you outside the house since earlier."]

I was shocked by what he said and panicked. I didn't even answer or hang up. I quickly grabbed my things and ran.

"Jay! Be careful, you might trip!" Aunt shouted as I ran in.

"I'm going to school now," I answered.

I went straight out of the house, and sure enough, Yuri was in the car. He smiled and waved at me. I immediately walked to the car.

"Get in! We might be late," he greeted me with a smile.

"Okay. I'm coming."

He opened the car door for me and even buckled my seat belt. I felt spoiled. He always does that. I think I'm starting to like it, but that's not a good thing.

He quickly went to the driver's seat and started the car. When he started driving, I couldn't help but keep looking at him.

He's so attentive. He's just the same as before when he took care of me.

In fact, I think he's even more attentive now compared to before because he has nothing holding him back.



"So I can make you suffer. Am I the only one who suffer relationship? You should suffer too."

I punched him hard on the arm, making him scream in pain. I immediately rubbed his arm.

"Itai! Itai! Itai!" (It hurts, It hurts, It hurts) he said, almost

Why is he calling his dad "Itay" though?

"Sore wa totemo warui ga itai!" (It's very bad but it hurts irritated.

I furrowed my brows and gave him a disapproving look, face.

"Look at it too!" I yelled.

He looked at me with teary eyes. "I am not cursing you!"

"How would I know?"

He angrily gripped the steering wheel and started the car and leaned back on my seat, looking out the window.

Throughout the drive, he stayed quiet, probably annoyed. I punched him. There were times I looked at him and saw pain.

I glared at Felix, but he was busy talking to his fellow "Ci-N" (his nickname for his group). I was about to sit when David handed me a note.

I looked at him, confused, but took the note to read it.

*'Jay, I enjoyed our date. I hope you liked the French toast and coffee, Felix'*

French toast and coffee? But there was none... I immediately knew. He didn't greet me like he always does, probably because he was doing something.

He slowly turned towards me when he felt I was staring at him. He smiled, even though his mouth was full of food.

Looks like he got the toast, but who has the coffee? It was supposed to be mine. I glared at him to let him feel my anger. He was too busy drinking and reading something from his phone. I heard a loud sip of something from David.

Nice! Looks like they shared it.

There was an "aahhh" sound after he finished drinking the coffee, which was supposed to be mine. I glared at him to let him feel my anger. He was too busy drinking and reading something from his phone.

"That's embarrassing for the person who got my food," I said. I took a breath to both him and Ci-N before sitting down.

I sighed. I know it's my fault, but is it really okay to ignore how he feels like my mistake is so huge. But when I hurt him, he said, "What's his deal now?"

I subtly glanced at him from behind. He was talking to Riku, who was serious, just like when I first saw him.

Back then, when I had a crush on him. I shook my head and walked to the front just as Sir Alvin entered to start the class.

"The schedule for your exam has changed. It was supposed to be in the first week of March, but it's now moved to the first week of April,"

"Why was it moved, Sir?" Eren asked.

"Because it didn't progress," Ci-N suddenly answered, a bit loudly.

"Wow, Pandak spoke up!" Josh teased.

The "Ulupong" group laughed again. I looked at Ci-N, and he raised his brows.

He stood up and pointed at Josh. "I will kill your Pussy!"

There was a moment of silence in the room, like you could hear a pin drop. Then they suddenly burst out laughing again. Some were laughing and crying. I ended up laughing too.

"Alright, alright! Sit down, Mr. Peralta," Sir interrupted.

Ci-N sat down with a pout. I faced Sir again to listen to v

"...Your exam will be in the first week of April. If I'm no  
also have a two-week vacation before the Post Final Exa  
graduation will be in June," he added.

Why does it have to be like this?! Their schedule is all m

This school starts in August, so my lessons are a mess. I  
learned anything from previous lessons. Actually, it feels  
behind.

After Sir explained the schedule, he went back to teachir  
teachers were also focused on their lessons because we n

Our last teacher for the morning left early, so Eman was

But I still didn't want to eat there.

I left the classroom and headed to the second floor, wher  
my crazy stepbrother.

As I approached the stairs, I saw Calix. He had one hand  
was scratching his cheek with the other. He was looking  
shy to face me.

"N... I... Calix..." I said, my voice trembling.

I raised an eyebrow at him. "None. You didn't even write  
"Hey, I wrote it!" he defended.

He wrote it? But the letter looked so feminine. It almost  
flowers, and unicorns to make it look like a "rainbow lov

"Is that really your thing?" I asked without thinking.

His brows furrowed. "What?!"

"The handwriting looks so girly! My writing is more stra

His letter looked like it had been written by a storm.

"Mica said my handwriting was pretty. She said it's one o  
love letter—because it's true that her handwriting is beau

"Yeah, it was too beautiful—now it's questionable wheth  
it." I whispered, but it seemed like he heard me.

"Maybe I shouldn't have made it too beautiful," he said,

Just make it look nice, that's all!

Honestly, I was laughing at him. I had a strong feeling th  
for help just to write that "friendship letter" for me.

There was a brief silence between us. I glanced behind h

"S-sorry. I just got happy."

"Thank you, you can thank Mica," I said.

"It's fine, even if it was my mom's idea." He smiled.

I winced. "Wow, that's intense!"

"As long as you gave me a chance. That's how important a friend, of course."

I just shook my head because of his antics. He walked back to the classroom. I just stood there, staring at him.

I don't know, but it felt different.

# Chapter 236: Forgiveness

## Aries's POV

I was currently staring at my reflection inside the elevator.

Ella said I've changed a lot since our last conversation.

Maybe because I keep coming back from the hospital. I'm already going back again. I reached for the side of my torso that was.

She saw my scar.

But it seemed like she had no clue. There wasn't a hint of interest in her eyes. It didn't seem like she was interested in asking me anything. She didn't.

Maybe she really doesn't remember, or maybe she just doesn't want to. I was one of my nightmares that haunted me almost every night. I tried to remove the image of it from my mind.

Her lifeless eyes. Her bleeding fist, and one of them was on the wall. Even the sound of the shattered glass pieces falling. I picked up a large shard of glass and used it to stab me.

I headed straight to my older brother Angelo's office door. She greeted me with a smile before standing up.

"Is Sir Angelo here?" she asked.

I nodded, and she pressed a button on the intercom. She was here.

"Let him in," I heard my brother reply.

The secretary gestured to the door of his office.

I thanked her before entering.

The first thing I noticed was the piles of paperwork. Aside from the executive table, there were also papers on the coffee table and sofa sets.

"Why are you here?" he asked authoritatively without looking up.

I crossed my arms and moved a bit closer. I skipped my usual greeting to talk to him. Thankfully, he didn't have any meetings.

"I just want to ask you something." He stayed silent, clearing his throat to continue. "...About the pictures."

His hands stopped moving, but he didn't look at me.

"Why do you have them?"



He was right. I would've blocked those pictures too if I had. My brother must have seen their content before they reached me.

"Have you taken any action?" I asked again.

He stopped again and looked at me seriously. He let out a sigh, then stood up and walked to a table where his things were.

He took something from a briefcase and handed it to me. I stepped closer, so I had to reach out to take it.

A Manila envelope?

I opened it and looked at the contents—pictures and some papers.

"Ryosuke Sato. Only son of a very well-known Yakuza family, a close rival of Yuri," he said, leaning against the table with his hands in his pockets.

I looked at the pictures. I've never seen him before.

"If Yuri is his enemy, why is he sending death threats to him?"

"Probably because he knows how important Jay-jay is to Yuri."

In the end, it was his fault this was happening. But there was no one to blame but him. I looked at the papers. Information about Sato was enough to really identify him.

I returned the papers and pictures to the brown envelope on the table. I ran my hand across my face. This was tougher than anything to do.

"I talked to Yuri," I said, and he looked at me. "...I told him

"What did he say?"

"He said he's known about it for a long time. He's been telling Jay-jay as much as he can."

"But he can't be with Jay-jay all the time."

He was right. There were times when they weren't together. Sometimes, Sato could make a move.

He also told me that the whole Section E knew what was going on, that they were helping. But that wasn't enough. Their effort wasn't enough.

This was so frustrating!

I shouldn't be troubled by this, but I couldn't avoid it. I let

"You look worried," my brother Angelo said.

I glanced at him. His gaze was different, as if he was obsessed with me.

"You know, Aries..." He started. "...I always take care of if you're my own flesh and blood. I try my best to discipline and provide for your needs..." He loosened his necktie.

"...I try to do many things like a real father would do. Be you to experience what I felt—growing up without a father."

I shook my head. "You didn't fail."

"I did." He quickly replied with a smile. "...because if I could, I would still love each other the same way you did before."

"It's a different story."

"I tried to make peace between you two, but you both betrayed me, Aries... what's the real reason for your hatred toward me?"

My fist clenched. I knew he would ask about it. I'm not sure it's the right time, but he would never stop asking.

I had to explain everything.

Slowly, I unbuttoned my polo shirt from the bottom. Then, I pulled it down to show him the scar below my chest.

"What's with the scar?"

I took a deep breath. "She's the..." I closed my eyes. "...she was the one who..."

From my own father.

"H-how?"

"she wasn't herself. I called her several times and begged but she couldn't hear or listen to me."

He looked confused by what I said. He seemed puzzled, not understanding my explanation.

"I don't get it."

"she wasn't herself. I know you know what happened. She didn't care anything of what she was doing."

He cursed and held the bridge of his nose. I knew this had been the case for him for a long time. He just didn't want to give in to my suggestion.

He was scared... scared to find out that he's gone mad.

"...because of her, there are many things I can't do now. I need medication before I can do any activity." I sighed deeply. "I got sick."

"You can't blame Jay-jay like that."

"I have a lot of reasons to hate her."

I looked away and lowered my head. Was I wrong?! Is it anger from everything I've been through?!

"You let her suffer! Tell me, Aries... isn't that enough of a pain she caused you?! Your sister needs you."

I tried to open my mouth to speak, but no words came out.

"Try to fix things between you two... before it's too late,"

Can I do it? Can I fix what's between us? I wish it were true that that's not the only reason why I'm angry with her.

Can I forget all my anger toward her?

+++++

### **Jay-jay's POV**

Yeah! Do that! You'll pay for it with me!

Go ahead... just ignore me.

"Hey! What?! Is this how you're going to be?!" I said angrily.

He glanced at me for a moment and then turned away again. I smacked him so badly. Lunch ended and everything, yet he paid attention to me.

I rolled my eyes to push the memory away. I didn't want thing that comes to my mind every time I sit on this bench.

I whistled as I followed him, then plopped down on the bench. He furrowed his brows and looked at me.

"Do you need something?" He said with disinterest.

"N-no. I'm just sitting. Why? Do I need a reason to sit on the bench?"

He raised an eyebrow. "Really?"

"Why? Do you think I'm trying to get your attention? I'm not."

Yeah, sure. Keep lying to yourself, Jay.

"Then not." He whispered, but I heard him.

"Really not." I replied sarcastically.

He didn't say anything else and stayed seated there. I heard him standing up, seemingly trying to leave again.

I quickly grabbed the end of his shirt. "What now?!"

"I'm moving to another spot. You're embarrassing me." I pulled the shirt away.

"Isn't it?! I keep getting closer to you—yet you keep pushing me away!"

"Because I'm annoyed with you!"

"That's it?! That's why you're annoyed? I've punched you before, and now you're just annoyed?!"

He suddenly grabbed his hair and sighed before answering.

"I'm trying to see what you'll do! I'm waiting for you to admit you're too proud."

"Then sorry!"

"Your sorry sounds angry! Is that really how you are?! Sorry is not a need to learn to be humble!"

Aww...

I furrowed my brows, but it wasn't because I was angry. I didn't agree with him. Maybe my pride really is too high, and I need to give a sincere apology to him.

I looked down. He immediately noticed I was affected by this and walked over to me and placed a hand on my shoulder.

"S-sorry. I didn't mean—."

"No, it's okay." I put him off. "Honestly, you're right. I

"...I was just trying to be sweet with you. I didn't mean a

I lowered my head, avoiding eye contact. He held my ch  
but I kept avoiding him.

"Jay-jay."

Both of his hands held my face to force me to face him.

He succeeded, but I shut my eyes.

"Open your eyes." He commanded.

I kept my eyes closed.

"Don't make me count."

I didn't say anything.

"Jay-jay. One."

I tried to remove his hands from my face.

"You really don't want to. Two."

I squeezed my eyes shut tighter.

"You'll regret this. Three."



"Y-yuri..." The only thing that came out of my mouth.

I wanted to yell at him and scold him. This was wrong! No agreement, but why did he do this?

"Jay... I'm—."

"Nice. As soon as Keifer's gone, you make your move."

We both turned to look at the person who spoke. Edrix sat in his pocket, glaring at us.

"E-edrix..." I called out to him.

"Ma'am's here. Go inside," he said disinterestedly before us.

Shit! Why am I so nervous?

I briefly glanced at Yuri before walking back. I almost caught Edrix, who was ahead of us, but just before he could enter, he looked back at me.

He stared at me seriously. "If it's okay with you... I'd like time to explain my side to you."

I nodded without thinking. He was about to turn away against his arm.

I was about to turn my back on him when he spoke again

"...Are you scared?"

There was no emotion in his voice. He wasn't accusing or sounded serious, but without any anger.

"W-what?"

"Are you scared that he might tell Keifer?" he continued

S-scared?

I don't know, but there's definitely a feeling of fear. Fear afraid that it'll reach him?

I turned my back on him, confused. "I-I don't know."

I hurriedly walked into the room. I immediately sat down staring at me.

"Are you okay?" he asked.

"H-huh?"

he stared at me with furrowed brows. I swallowed nervous sudden tension I felt. I tried to avoid his gaze until suddenly

*'PPPPRRRRQQQIIIIITTTTTTTT'*

*"Cancel the class!"*

"Jay-jay farted!" Ci shouted while pointing at me.

Son of a...!

"I-I didn't!" I denied.

"Really? It stinks! When did you bring that with you?" I

I glared at him quickly. He actually believed what that boy

"What the hell, Jay! You don't act like a girl!" Eman said

"Are you trying to kill us all?" Felix added.

"Enough! Just sniff it to get rid of the smell," our teacher fanning herself.

What a pain!

They really think I'm the one who released the bomb. I had to fan the air to make the smell go away. I noticed Ci was laughing.

I smacked him on the head. "You farted!"

he rubbed his neck with one hand while giving me a peace sign with the other. So annoying!

The question he asked me earlier came to mind. Am I scared?  
Am I really scared that Keifer might find out?

# Chapter 237: Siblings

## Jay-jay's POV

Tulala. I'm almost drooling, which would confirm that I'm. Well, I'm always out of my mind, but this time feels different.

I'm staring blankly at the calendar. It's been almost two weeks since my birthday ended. That means Keifer's birthday is next.

Tomorrow is February 28, and then the 29th is the King's birthday. I haven't received a single call or text from him. And that's weird because he's been texting me less and less too. My hope that they'll be as the King is shrinking.

"You're such a pest, Keifer! You're such a pain in the gut."

I was about to eat the last Pepero stick I was holding, but it was already gone. I must've eaten it without realizing. I checked my bag but there's no more food left. Just when I feel like having a snack, I run out of snacks in my bag. I glanced at the wall clock. It's 10 PM. Kuya is probably asleep by now.

I slowly opened my bedroom door and peeked at Kuya's door. It was closed, and there was no light coming from under it.

Thanks, horoscope. Was there no warning in there?

It seems Aries is also looking for food. He kept peeking inside the fridge but wasn't satisfied. He stood up straight and sighed. He slowly turned toward my direction before closing the door.

It seems he didn't sense my presence because he continued to look for food.

"Aries."

"What the!..." he said, startled. "...What's wrong with you? You're scaring me like that?"

I wanted to laugh at his reaction. He's becoming more easily scared every day.

"I wasn't trying to scare you. You're just spacing out."

He glared at me. "I'm not spacing out! Look at where you are!"

I looked at where I was. I was at the kitchen door. It was dark. There was no light coming from anywhere. The lights in the other rooms of the kitchen were off too.

"Who wouldn't get scared by that? A voice from the dark. How can you see who it is?"

"Sorry," I said, scratching my head.

Ugh... I don't want that. I just want something to munch sweet.

"Oh..." I said, scratching my head. "...I'll just buy something" I started to walk away.

Before I could get far, a hand grabbed the back of my collar like a puppy being carried in the air.

"What do you mean, 'outside'? Let me remind you that you're dead. And you're planning to go out?!" he said irritably.

"Then I'll disguise myself."

He raised an eyebrow, almost sarcastically saying, 'You're kidding'.

I tried to break free from his grip on my collar, but he only tightened it.

"Come on... I just really want to buy something," I pleaded.

"It's late."

"Owwwsss... Really?!" I said, pretending to be amazed.

He let go of my collar but gave me a strong flick on the forehead. I teared up as I rubbed my head.

"That hurt!" I complained.

I found a bonnet. Even though it smelled like it had been ages—whatever! I need this. I also grabbed the shades that left here when he stayed over once.

There! Now I look stupid!

I grimaced when I saw myself in the mirror. I looked like an American—just missing some bling-bling. It's dark outside, wearing shades? Nice! I look like an addict. The bonnet? Bagoio vibes.

I took them off and threw them on the bed. Disguise, my ass. I adjusted my hood to cover my face.

This is better than looking like a drugged-up American.

I pocketed my wallet and phone. When I opened the door, stepping forward, I stepped back.

Standing in front of me was the face of the Horoscope guy wearing a hood, and guess what? Same color as mine... I

"You look like Kokey," he said, arms crossed.

"Who's that? Is he an actor?"

He smiled at me and nodded. "It's an actor."

XXXXXXXXXXXXXXXXXXXXXXXXXXXXXXXXXXXXXXXXXXXXXXXXXXXXXXXXXXXXXXXXXXXXXXXXXXXX



I looked at what he was wearing. "Why are you dressed in disguise too?"

"Idiot! It's drizzling outside. I'm too lazy to carry an umbrella, turning his back to me.

He's really fun to talk to.

Sometimes, I feel like I just want to slam his head against the wall, maybe I'll drag him to his fellow Horoscopes. Are Taurus friends too?

I followed him grumpily, but then I stopped when I remembered my older brother was still asleep, and he might wake up. I tiptoed until I reached the stairs.

My stupid brother wasn't in the living room, so I went straight to the stairs.

He was holding my bike while staring off into the distance.

"Let's go," he said, without looking at me.

"What do you need my bike for?"

"I'll walk it." He answered flatly, with no emotion.

Good luck with that plan of yours.

I frowned at him and he rolled his eyes at me.

I glanced behind me, and just as I did, the Horoscope was had a serious expression as he looked at me.

"I'll go out first," he said, so I stepped aside to let him pass.

When he went outside, he checked the surroundings, just to be sure.

Once he made sure there was nothing suspicious, he pulled out and motioned for me to follow.

He got on the bike and looked at me. I expected him to ask me to get on, but instead, he started pedaling away.

"Go ahead. Start walking now," he said in a lifeless tone.

Oh, this guy...

"It's embarrassing for me. That's my bike," I said irritably.

He stopped and glanced at me. "Fine, get on."

I flashed a wide smile and quickly walked up to him. I wanted to get on the bike, but just as I positioned myself, I bumped into his leg.

"Ouch..." I whispered and looked at him.

He was glaring at me while holding his mouth and chin.

I winced.

It felt weird. I was both happy and sad.

I was happy because we used to do this. I would ride on and he would take me on a ride. I didn't expect we'd be doing this again.

But with that, there was also the sadness I felt. I knew that time was over, we might never do this again.

To be honest, I had been thinking about how he was acting. I wanted to ask him, but I was scared it would bring up what happened in the room when he suddenly got angry at me.

I wanted to know if we were okay. I wanted to know if he was still my friend. I wanted to know if he accepted me as a sibling. I wanted to know if we could just stay like this.

I looked at my hand as I felt a few drops of water.

What he said was true. It was drizzling.

"I hope it doesn't happen," I whispered.

He slightly glanced at me. "What?"

"The rain... I hope it doesn't happen."

He stopped, almost causing me to fall into him. He looked up at the sky. I did the same, and that's when I noticed that the

He also looked up. "It's not that... The moon is bright, and the stars are too."

*EndOfFlashback...*

I couldn't take my eyes off Aries, even though I could or couldn't.

He started pedaling again, and my gaze was still on him.

For some reason I couldn't understand, tears started to fall from my eye. That memory was telling me how happy I was back then, but my past with him wasn't entirely complete in my mind.

Now, I'm grateful that I haven't lost the happy memories. It wasn't perfect, it's okay. As long as I know we were happy.

And if only I could make a wish...

I wish we could be like we were before. I wish we could go back to the way we used to be. No problems, just us, and the whole world when we're together.

That single tear from earlier, now it's followed by more. I don't want to cry, but I can't stop it. I'm frustrated because I didn't wish to cry, but I can't stop it.

The difference is, I'm not crying because I'm sad. I'm crying because I can't stop it.

It's because I'm wishing for something I know is impossible.

"Always hungry," he muttered.

When I entered, the clerk signaled for me to lower my hood. I was not allowed, apparently.

Do I look like a robber?

I had no choice but to lower my hood and storm over to the counter. I wiped my eyes again, hoping my redness wouldn't be noticed.

How annoying! Why did I cry over that Horoscope? I grabbed a 1.5-liter soft drink before heading to the drinks aisle. I grabbed a 1.5-liter soft drink.

"Put it back!" Aries said irritably as he walked toward me.

I slightly looked down and avoided his gaze. "I want this soft drink!" I said.

He snatched the soft drink from me and put it back in the shelf.

"That's why your brain is empty—you're eating unhealthy food!"

He gave me a lecture and then turned his attention to the next customer.

Does my brain have food in it?

"These are what I want!" I said irritably, trying to grab the soft drink.

Oh wow! Seems like he has a hidden hunger.

"Will I get full from that?" I asked, irritated.

"Most likely! All food fills you up!"

How annoying! I don't want that. I reluctantly started looking at even pre-heated food, and even yogurt I didn't like—I started eating too.

I walked up to him, my arms full of food.

"I'm making you pay for this," I said.

He glared at me. "Fine." He quickly grabbed the things I was holding, then turned back to face me. "...This is embarrassing, you know, and this might not even be enough."

We both walked up to the cashier. As the cashier scanned the items, I secretly stepped back and went back to the shelves to get more snacks.

I hid them behind me, and when the cashier was almost done, I put everything in front of her. Aries was shocked, his eyes wide.

"This is part of it!"

The cashier shot me a sharp look. "You're so stubborn."

"You're so happy, huh?" he said sarcastically.

I couldn't wipe the smile off my face as I sipped my protein through a straw.

"Food is life."

He walked over to the bike and lifted its stand. He slowly put it down with one hand while holding a plastic bag with the other.

"I'm walking, right?" I asked.

He lifted the plastic bag. "Do you think I can drive with this while carrying?"

"I told you... We're walking," I said, quickening my pace to leave him.

At first, it was quiet as we walked, and I chose not to speak because I was scared of his silence.

Instead, I focused on the contents of the plastic bags. I opened one and started eating it.

"Are you pregnant?" he suddenly broke the silence, starting a conversation.

I almost choked on the bite I had taken. "Idiot! Where did you come from?!" I shot him an irritated look.

When I say I want certain foods, he buys them right away spoiled by him.

Suddenly, his expression changed, and it seemed like he said.

He looked ahead again and continued walking.

It seemed like they still hadn't talked.

"Y-you know..." I started, but he still wouldn't look at me.

"...Percy is really angry with Yuri."

He sighed deeply. "And I'm really angry with them too."

I stopped walking and kept my gaze fixed on him.

"And you're really angry with me too."

He stopped and it felt like my words had hit him like arrows. He refused to look at me, and I saw him slowly lower his head.

"Why, Aries? Why? What did I do to make you angry at the fact that I'm your sibling?"

Seconds turned into minutes, and it felt like ten minutes. I didn't answer until he slowly took a step away from me.



I was confused.

He looked at me, and I couldn't understand what he meant  
time.

"...Give me time to think about what happened..." He smiled  
brother will make it up to you."

My lips moved on their own, and I smiled back. I was about to  
when we suddenly heard the sound of a speeding car.

It was coming from behind me, and when I turned around  
when I saw it approaching fast. My legs stiffened as my

JAY-JAY! MOVE!

It was too late for me to dodge. I shut my eyes and brace  
the car, but that's not what I felt.

Two arms wrapped around me, and we were thrown to the ground.  
The embrace was tight, and I couldn't move.

When I opened my eyes, all I saw was the back of the sports car  
following it was Kuya Angelo, running after it.

I couldn't hear anything, my ears were ringing from the impact  
my heart.

.....

Suddenly, he pulled me into his chest. I could hear his de  
loud thumping of his heart.

"Damn it! You almost got hit."

# Chapter 238: Birthday Wish

## Jay-jay's POV

"Your Kuya Angelo is right, Jay," Tita said. "...Maybe you're not ready for school yet."

"Because Tita..." I was planning to send a video message to Kuya Angelo. "...maybe because of what happened."

"You almost died last night. Thank goodness Aries was there to save you."

I lowered my head. Both Aries and I weren't allowed to go out last night. Kuya Angelo. He knew we went out last night, and the sight of my car—apparently, that really happened. Kuya tried to chase us, saying we were going too fast. Plus, it had no license plates.

"Stop being stubborn. Rest now," Tita added.

She kissed my head before standing up and leaving the room. She grabbed my phone to text Ci-N.

**To: BatangKumag**

*Message: I'm not going to school. Something happened.*

I heard a knock on the door, and it slowly creaked open. appeared.

"Are you okay?" he asked.

I nodded. "You? Are you okay?"

He stepped inside and approached me, trying to smile.

"I'm okay too."

"Can you give me my horoscope for today?" I asked innocently. He flicked my forehead hard, making me fall back on the bed.

"Aagghhh! That hurts!" I screamed, holding my forehead around on the bed. "What the heck! Ouch!"

"You're full of nonsense! You almost died last night and that!" he said, irritated.

I almost cried as I looked at my forehead in the mirror. It was swollen. I felt like his finger was as hard as a rock because of the force.

"Pain..." I whispered. "...it hurts."

"You're so dramatic," he said irritatedly, approaching me.

I faced him angrily. "Here! Look!" I almost shoved my finger in his face.

Is this it? Is this how it feels when things are okay between siblings?

I grabbed my phone again, and this time, I texted Percy.

**To: Percing**

*Message: Hey! Hey! Call me! I have something to tell you!*

I smiled while waiting for his reply. It took a few minutes before he texted again.

**From: Percing**

*Message: Eeww... Poor! No phone credit.*

My eyebrows immediately furrowed. If it weren't for that,

I was calling him to tell him what happened, and this is what

"You annoying blue-eyed jerk! I'll make that black!"

**To: Percing**

*Message: Damn! Just do it!*

It didn't take long, and he did what I told him to. I quickly called.

This guy is crazy.

"You're nuts! I have something to tell you."

["And... What is it, you pregnant horse?"]

I winced and looked at my phone before putting it back t

"Aries and I are okay now!" I said with joy.

["Oh? Really?"]

"Yeah... I think?"

["Why the 'I think'? You're not sure? What is that!"]

"Maybe he'll suddenly go crazy."

["Here's what you do..."] He said, sounding like he was g  
to a child. ["...go see him. Hold his forehead, if it's hot—  
pain—then he'll talk to you."]

I rolled my eyes while slapping my forehead. I'm going t  
with this guy. Is it even okay to say that? Seriously! Tha  
more courage.

"What if it's not hot?"

["Good news! He might really be making up with you "I

"They're trying to take my life." I said, without thinking.

["What?!"] Percy suddenly said, snapping me back to reality.

That's when I remembered I hadn't told him about what I had happened.

"Percy... Do you remember what the guy who fought with me said? He said someone wants to kill me?"

["Yeah. Oh, shit! Don't tell me—"]

"Someone's been sending me death threats and... Last night, he tried to run me over."

["What the... Do your classmates know about this? Yuri?" I asked worriedly.

"I—I don't know."

He sighed deeply. ["I'll talk to your Kuya Angelo. I have to go now."] He hung up the phone.

He didn't wait for my reply and quickly hung up the phone.

I hugged my knees.

So many thoughts were running through my mind. What if he really was going to kill me? Why did he talk to me because he thought...

I couldn't take it anymore. I quickly stood up and walked

I went straight to his room, but he wasn't there, so I walked to his room.

He wasn't there either. I was about to go to the kitchen when I saw something outside. Aries was standing there, looking at his hands.

I approached him, and I was shocked to see that he was holding a picture. I quickly grabbed it from him.

It was a picture of both of us. We were sitting on the road, I was holding my cheek and seemingly saying something. I couldn't believe this was the scene from last night.

"They're closer than I thought," I heard him say.

I hadn't said anything yet when he suddenly walked to the picture and took it.

He quickly walked inside the house. I followed him immediately.

"Manang! Make sure you check properly who's outside the door! Don't just let anyone in!" He shouted at their maids.

I froze, standing by the door, holding the picture. My hair was

.....



I quickly walked back to my room, took a shower, got re-uniform. I'm going to school; I won't let someone like th

I was organizing my bag when my phone suddenly rang.

I picked it up and saw an unknown number.

I held the phone tightly. My fingers were still shaking as answer button.

"H-hello?" I greeted the caller.

["Jay-jay? It's Eren!"] He answered loudly.

My brows furrowed when I heard noise on his side, like and people fighting.

"W-what's... Why is it so noisy?"

["Jay! We need your Kuya's help!"]

"Ha?! What's going on—Hello?! Hello!" The noise sudd

When I checked, the call had ended. I grabbed my bag and Luckily, Aries wasn't in the living room. I took my bike to school faster.

I was sweating from the speed I was going. I had to get to I reached the gate. I saw his vehicles used for construction

"The board already issued an order! We need to clean up  
The Guidance Counselor said.

"Maybe you can do it another day?! We'll clean up the re

I looked around. The piles of old tables and chairs were  
trash was gone too. When I looked at the Ulupongs, they  
stairs going to the second floor.

"It's not allowed! The demolition starts next week! We're  
time!"

"Wait for Keifer to come back! He's the one you should  
Rory added angrily.

"Why wait for him?! We have a schedule to follow!"

"If you demolish this building, where are we going to ha  
asked irritably.

"In the open auditorium!"

"What?! Are you crazy?" Edrix responded harshly.

The Councilor glared at him. "How dare you talk to me l  
no respect!"

"Why should we respect you?!" Blaster fired back.

"I'm begging you, Ma'am. P-please, until tomorrow! We' tomorrow," I pleaded, almost kneeling.

The councilor and the Serpents stared at me with sharp g

"Until tomorrow, Miss Mariano!" she said, pointing at m

She turned around and walked away, followed by the wc  
Even the students who had been watching left.

I faced the Serpents, whose brows were still furrowed.

"Let's go to the room. We need to talk," Yuri started, but  
the Serpents suddenly turned away.

Yuri gave me a forced smile, then put his arm around my  
walked to the room. When we got inside, everyone was f  
The only ceiling fan wasn't working, and it was dark bec  
was out.

"We've lost power. They cut the line," Ci-N said sadly.

The others slumped, looking defeated as if the world had

"What's the plan? Are we just going to let them destroy t  
Drew asked, irritated.

"N-no!" I quickly responded.

"I think... he can't. He's struggling with his own problem to add to them."

"So, we're just going to let it happen? Is that it?" Felix asked.

"Like we have a choice," David replied.

Felix quickly stood up and rummaged through some stuff, grabbed a box and walked out of the room. Yuri, Rory, and I followed him.

Ci-N and I exchanged looks before we followed them. They went to the second floor. I ran to catch up, and my worry grew as I broke the doorknob of the last room.

The picture room.

"Felix..." I called, my voice tinged with pleading.

He ignored me as he broke the doorknob and forcefully opened the door. We all stepped inside.

One by one, he took down the pictures from the walls and put them in the box. I felt weak as I watched him. My feet moved on their own, and I went to help him take down the pictures.

I couldn't help but look at the faces in the photos. They looked like people I knew, though some had bandages or bruises. Some had serious

I placed the picture in the box. It took us a few more minutes to take the box back to the room. The atmosphere felt heavy as we organized the stuff behind us.

"Is this really it? Are we leaving this building?" Denzel asked.

I nodded slowly. We looked at Ci-N as we heard him sob.

"This place was like my second home," he said. "I was here when I had problems at home."

And so was I.

We decided to finish everything that needed to be done before we were moving. We even cleaned up the trash in front of our movers to collect tomorrow.

It was already dark by the time we finished. David and Ci-N went home since Yuri stayed behind to help Eman.

"Thanks for the ride," I said lifelessly.

"Everything will be okay, right?" Ci-N asked.

That's the question I was asking myself.

I wanted to say yes, but I didn't want to take away the hope of the rascal.

Before, people were wary of Section E because they knew trouble, but now it felt like we were too weak. The other students were not us anymore.

I collapsed onto my bed. I wanted to sleep, but my mind wouldn't. Thoughts kept rushing through my head, as if my brain was a playground.

I tried to get up from my bed and changed clothes, hoping it would help me sleep. But it only kept me awake longer.

I sat on the bed when suddenly the door opened and Aric appeared.

"Where have you been?" he asked.

"School," I replied.

"You're really stubborn, huh?"

"There was something that happened, that's why I had to leave."

He rubbed his temple, looking ready to lecture me. He stayed for a moment. I wasn't in the mood to argue, so I just let him talk.

I didn't listen to his words. They just passed through my ears, not sticking in my mind.

"Aric," I said, "I'm not listening to you."

I heard my phone ring. I grabbed it from my bag and saw

**From: GagongBaliw**

*Message: hey. How are you?*

I wanted to scream, "F\*\*k! I'm not okay!"

But I didn't want to make a scene and disturb the neighbors.

**To: GagongBaliw**

*Message: Keifer.*

I deliberately sent it to him. I wanted to know who this is

**From: GagongBaliw**

*Message: Watson.*

I was a bit surprised, though I was expecting this. Of course it was him!

**To: GagongBaliw**

*Message: It's you.*

**From: GagongBaliw**

A photo followed his message. In the middle of a large h  
wearing a black tuxedo, talking on the phone.

**To: GagongBaliw**

*Message: Who are you really?*

**From: GagongBaliw**

*Message: I know you more than you know me.*

I dropped my phone. Damn it! Was I being played again

Who is this GagongBaliw?



# Chapter 239: Happy Birth

## Jay-jay's POV

11:48 PM. My eyes were wide open. I couldn't sleep because that jerk sent me. What's worse, he wasn't responding to

"Damn it!" I snapped at my phone in frustration.

If he's not Keifer, then who the hell is he? One thing's for sure, he's close to that King of Snakes.

And what was that outfit he was wearing? Why did he let us have a party? Was it his birthday party? Wow! How embarrassing. I had the nerve to celebrate while we're here on the verge of losing

"You bastard! You're all happy while we're here crying."

I stood up angrily and grabbed my phone again. I searched for his number—he was the only one I knew who had access to

But just before I could press call, I remembered I didn't have his number. I could only text.

Poor girl Jay-Jay.

I released a deep sigh. My shoulders slumped as I notice only 10 minutes left before it hit midnight. That meant it February 29th. The King of Snakes' birthday.

It's so irritating! So frustrating! So much!

I had one last chance to contact this GagongBaliw person. I slowly opened my bedroom door.

I was really hesitating about doing this. I walked carefully into the room. I just hoped he wouldn't snap.

Ugh!

I knocked gently at first, but there was no answer. I tried again. Nothing. I grabbed the doorknob and slowly turned it.

I almost clapped my hands in joy when I realized that A door.

Tiptoe, tiptoe, tiptoe.

There! I had become a ballerina from tiptoeing so much. I reached the bedside table, and there it was—the thing I was looking for.

The mysterious horoscope phone. This was how I would change my destiny—no, I would use it to contact GagongBaliw.

~~~~~

I just needed his fingerprint. That was all, and then I could have held it there?!

There were so many other things he could have held!

"I can do this." I whispered to myself.

I slowly pulled his arm away from... well, there. I managed to get his thumb first. I brought his phone near the fingerprint sensor.

But it didn't unlock!

I tried his index finger, but no luck. I tried his middle finger, but nothing happened either. I almost screamed in frustration. His ring finger was my last hope.

Just as I was about to grab it, his hand suddenly moved.

It went back to... well, there!

I tried again to pull his arm, but it returned to... that spot. Frustrated, I started punching the air silently. And then, because of my stupidity, I dropped his phone.

It flew in the air, and the real foolishness? It hit... I'm so sorry to my future children.

I'm sorry! I'm so sorry!

"How on earth....?! Argh!"

I was the one who almost cried because of what I did. I f
have kids again. I could hear him groaning and cursing f

When it got a bit quieter, I tried to peek at him from the l
surprise, he wasn't there. I quickly stood up and pulled th
bed.

Oh no! He was gone! And so was his phone.

"Where did it go?" I asked.

"Is this..." My eyes widened. "...what you're looking for?"

I slowly turned to look behind me where the voice came

I clenched my mouth shut while bowing my head.

"What the fvck are you doing here?! In the middle of the

He really emphasized the last word.

I played with my fingers, unsure how to respond. I just v
his phone to call that GagongBaliw.

"...and seriously?! Why did you hit my... my... my... my "

"How did you know it was me? You're quick to accuse!"

"What do you need this for?" he asked while holding out

"I just need to make a call. I don't have credit."

He sighed deeply and typed something on his phone for handing it to me.

I looked at him curiously before taking the phone. I pressed button on the phone, and it unlocked. No password!

"I already removed the password. Just return it after you while getting closer to the bed. "...and PLEASE! Wake n way."

He lay down on the bed and covered himself with the blanket. I looked at the phone in my hand.

Nice! I can finally call GagongBaliw!

"Thank you!" I said happily as I quickly exited his room

His room was only a step away from mine.

I quickly searched for my phone that was scattered on the floor. The jerk was what I was after.

I almost gawked at Aries' phone while I typed the number. My hands were shaking as I brought the phone to my ear.

"Who the hell are you?! Your trip is so intense, I don't get it. It's so frustrating, you know!" I said with wide eyes. "...Just tell me already? You're so stressful—so much!"

You're ruining my beauty!

I heard him clearing his throat, though it was soft, I knew he was.

"Can you please say something? My mouth is getting dry, but you're still speechless."

I was almost losing my mind because of him. I just wanted to be on the other side. If only... ugh!

I glanced at the wall clock. It was 12:09 AM—the idiot's birthday.

I sighed deeply. I still didn't know who this GagongBaliv was, but one thing was certain—he was connected to that King of Snakes.

"Hey! Whoever you are, I know you're close to Keifer. Maybe you can tell him... well... can you tell him..." I scratched the back of my neck. "...Nyappi Brrrittday."

Wait—what did I just say?!

I quickly covered my mouth. I stuttered, damn it! I couldn't say "Happy Birthday" properly.

~~~~~

"...Section E needs him..."

I needed him. "...many people are counting on him..." I wanted him. "...his friends want him back..." I wanted him back.

For reasons I couldn't understand, a tear fell from my left eye. My throat tightened. I just wanted to send a simple message, but my heart said so much.

"Please also tell him... Whatever he's dealing with, tell him. I felt like I wouldn't be able to handle it if he stayed away. I also wish him a happy birthday. I hope he's true to his feelings. I hope he'd be true to me. "...I also wish he forgives me..." Because I was ready to give up. "...for what I've done to him."

I wiped my tears discreetly. I also swallowed hard to clear my throat.

"I really hope he comes back soon... but if he can't, it's okay. I'll live with it." Even though it hurt... Even though it hurt so much.

"...Please tell him all of that, okay? I'm counting on you. I'll wait my time, even though I knew this conversation wouldn't last. I'll be there. "...Alright. I'll hang up now. My brother might get mad—credit."

As expected, no one spoke from the other side. I was about to hang up the phone from my ear when I heard something. It wasn't clear what it was, but I knew if there was a signal issue.

"Did something happen?" He asked and sat down next to

I quickly wiped the stray tear off my cheek. I swallowed little.

"N-nothing... I just felt like being dramatic." I explained.

I felt his arm around my shoulders. He gently leaned my shoulder.

"Is this about him?" he whispered.

It was like a switch had been flipped in my emotions. Tears came quickly, and it felt like I couldn't stop crying. My arms immediately wrapped around him.

Why is this happening? Why am I like this?

"It hurts, even though he's not doing anything." I don't know why he's not doing anything. "...It hurts, even though he's not here. "...Why do I have to feel like this?

"Ssshhhh... It's normal. I mean, it's Keifer you love."

His answer irritated me.

I slapped his chest, which made him laugh. But slowly, I became serious. His hug around me tightened.



Of course, I knew. It's me, after all!

"But they didn't love Keifer," I said. Not like me.

"They were scared of him," he replied, which confused me. He's different when it comes to liking girls."

I started thinking. Someone had told me that before. He's like, if he likes someone, he'll fence them in and won't let them go.

"How... How do you know so much?"

He looked at me and ruffled my hair. "Even when we were young, he was like that with girls. Good thing he loses interest quickly."

I frowned. That guy is unbelievable. It's like he doesn't see people. He acts like he owns them, thinking he can always get what he wants.

I looked at Aries, who was staring into space. I wasn't sure it was the right time to ask him this question.

"A-Aries... Can I ask why you're so angry at Keifer?"

I saw him clench his jaw. He swallowed and quickly looked away.

"S-sorry. It's okay if—"

"He never listens to me," he said without looking at me. He just thought about what happened to Daisy without even trying to understand it.

"Spoiled."

"Big asshole."

"A womanizer."

He suddenly burst out laughing. I laughed too. For a moment, I was over mocking the King of Snakes.

For some strange reason, in the middle of our laughter, I was crying again. I was crying again. Crying because of him.

Aries stopped laughing and quickly hugged me. I buried my face in his chest.

"Jay," he called me.

"B-birthday's today, but he didn't even try to reach out. He never even message me." I said like I was complaining. "...It's unfair."

Damn you, Keifer.

I felt my brother's hand gently rubbing my back.

"Stop it, Jay. Stop crying over him. You have to accept the truth."

"W-what truth?"

I tried to lift my gaze to him, but he stopped me. He kissed me on the forehead.

major shareholder of the company. With all the responsibility do you think he'll be able to come back?"

I started crying again, loudly. He was right! He might need us—to me. He has a life there that I'm not part of. That was

I shouldn't have been expecting it... but why do I still believe

"He will come back. I know he will. He said he would come back," I insisted.

He has to come back. He should come back here. He should protect me. Because if he doesn't, what will happen to me? What will be gone for good?

I don't understand why Aries had to tell me this. I thought it was fine between us, but why did he say that? Does he want to leave? Maybe he's just angry at me. Maybe he's getting back at me.

But that's not it.

"Take back what you said! He'll come back!" I shouted and punched him.

"Jay! Enough!"

"Take it back! He'll come back!" ...He'll come back. "...I'll handle it."

What? You don't know your age?

"So the reason I told you before—about why I didn't tell you wouldn't suspect we're siblings—it wasn't true." He I wasn't sure if I was looking at him. "...Because before I knew was your age. You were three years old then. Yeah you, but I didn't know how far apart we were."

I looked back into space. It was kind of funny how foolish that.

So silly! Let's laugh... Ha.ha.ha.ha.

"To make it worse, I didn't have a birth certificate. So when I got me, he thought I was just three."

"How did you find out your real age?" I asked softly.

"Because of our mom—our mom. But I found out when school. Percy even laughed at me back then, saying I was know my own age."

At that moment, I smiled. We really had the same way of then. But I don't think it was his fault. I thought he was just would've learned that if someone older had taught him. I Mom never taught him anything other than age.

"Are you happy?" I asked absent-mindedly. "...Are you l

"Aries..." I called him. "...Your nostrils are huge. I can see  
OW!" He slapped me on the forehead.

# Chapter 240: Kuya's Pain

## Aries's POV

Her forehead was red. It looks like I hit her too hard. But she sound asleep. Her eyes were swollen from crying. I guess that hasn't changed about her—aside from her stubborn tendency to cry easily.

I couldn't help but smile. Even at such a young age, I still took care of her.

*Flashback...*

"Ari!"

"Aris." I corrected her.

"Where's Mama?" she asked while looking at me with her head tilted.

"She's still at work."

She lowered her head and picked up some stones from the ground. "I'm long."

I took her hand and shook off the stones she picked up. "Mama's not home."

"Mama!" I greeted her.

But she didn't answer me, and she passed by me as if she quickly approached Jay and hugged her.

"Mama!" Jay shouted happily. "Why are you so late?"

"I missed you, Mama! I was working."

Jay nodded at her. Mama looked at me.

"Close the gate and come inside." She said, walking in.

I did what she said and quickly ran inside. I saw that she plastic bag. It was full of food.

"There's so much food! Look, Ari!"

"Kuya Aries." Mama corrected her. "...he's older than yo

Every time Mama came home from work, she always brought said her boss gave them to her. Sometimes, she also brought and me.

But I preferred it if Mama were at home. I preferred being

Suddenly, Mama came home from work. She had a red mark near her mouth. She was furious, like she had an enemy.

"Really?"

"Yeah. Let me check for you." I said as I walked inside t

I didn't think they were actually fighting. Mama was sitting in front of the table, and so was Ate Jamela. They were just making loud voices.

"That jerk! No wonder he's so nice! He has plans for me. I'm angry. "Giving me groceries! What does he think I'll just stay because our kids have different fathers?!"

"I already went! You're right, but why did you bang your head on the wall?" Ate Jamela said irritably.

Mama pointed at the side of her mouth. "He slapped me! I was scared of his violence!"

Ate scratched her head roughly. "How about you now?!" "What about the kids?"

"I don't care! I'll just find another job where I can bring more money home. Aries in school."

"And what about money? How will you pay for school? What about uniforms?"

"I still have money for that."



"It was when I got pregnant with Aries. My siblings fought left, it was getting tiring!"

"Call Jay's father. He's rich, right? He's the one who gave this house, right?"

Mama didn't respond. She suddenly turned to me and gave me a look.

"I told you to watch over Jay! Why are you inside? OUT!"

I quickly ran outside. I saw Jay digging in the dirt. I approached her hands again.

"Are they fighting?" she asked again.

I shook my head. "No. They're just talking."

I didn't really understand what they were talking about. What did she mean by "outside child"? Is that us? Because we were outside.

I just ignored it and played with Jay. I also told her that I would take me to school. I saw Ate Jamela's child, who was always supposedly going to school. Maybe I would go there too with my sibling with me.

"Aries! Aries! Wake up!" Mama shouted.

~~~~~

I ran outside the house. I was almost at the gate when I saw her. She closed the door and almost ran to the gate. It was there that there was no one on the street.

"Jay! Just wait! We're going to the hospital!" Mama said looking for a ride.

I didn't know how long we had been there when a tricycle driver didn't want to take us, but Mama pleaded with him.

When we got to the hospital, the woman in white talked to me.

I really couldn't understand what was going on. But I noticed she wasn't speaking. She was unconscious and seemed to be unmoving.

"You're not going to school today," Mama said to me.

"Why?"

"Because we don't have money. I used it to pay for the hospital to bring Jay home."

"I want to go to school!" I insisted.

My friends were going to school already. I wanted to go to school. I wanted to start school too.

"You can't! We don't have money!" She shouted at me.

"Stop being so annoying! I told you it's not possible!" She slapped me again.

Her hand was hitting me all over, but she still didn't stop

"Stop! No more! No more, Mama!"

"Grow up, you brat! You can't understand!" She shouted

"...I'm already struggling! Don't make it harder!"

She was about to hit me again when suddenly, an old woman came in through the door. Mama froze and quickly faced the woman.

"Why are you hurting the child?" The woman asked Mama.

She tried to approach me, but Mama quickly blocked her.

"I'm just disciplining my child," Mama answered her.

They stared at each other for a while. I didn't know her, at first time I'd seen her. She was carrying a bag and a plastic bag with things inside.

She was actually our grandmother, Jay and my Lola. She came to the house several times to leave toys and food for us. She also came sometimes when Mama had a new job.

Before, Mama was only away for half the day. But now

"Ari!" Jay shouted from inside the house.

I ran inside and looked for her. She was sitting on the floor which had its head missing again. She always takes the h

"My tummy hurts!" She said while holding her stomach and started crying.

I approached her and tried to lift her. I made her sit on the floor and looked for the bottle that Mama used on us when we had a fever. It was green and had a strange smell.

I found it in the medicine cabinet. I opened it and tried to do what Mama usually does, but some of it spilled and spread on the floor. I went to check on Jay-jay, who was still crying.

I lifted her shirt and placed it on his tummy, but she kept crying.

I tried to calm him down, but she wouldn't stop.

"I want Mama!" She cried.

"Mama is at work."

Her crying only got louder. I didn't know how to stop her. I went to the gate open. I ran to greet her, but she looked at me angrily.

"What did you do? Why is Jay-jay crying?" She passed t

"You idiot! This damn life! Don't you have any brains? \nspill?"

She was muttering something under her breath, saying the mentioned bad words and that children shouldn't imitate

"I'm going to work. The thing I told you! Don't leave Jay before leaving the door.

Mama loves her so much, while it feels like she wants m

But it's okay; she's younger than me, so I understand. Ba love from their parents, Lola told me.

I looked out the window. It seemed like Lola wasn't com

I stood up and peeked into the house. Jay was still asleep up later. I'll just come back before she wakes up.

I closed the door and ran out through the gate.

"Let's go to the court!" They said, and I followed them.

When we got there, some people were playing basketball watch for a while because they looked like they were having fun. There were many people playing, passing the ball around. When I saw them play too.

I don't know how long we were there, but I noticed that I was getting tired to leave. That's when I remembered Jay-jay. I hadn't fed him.

I said goodbye to my friends and ran back home. The gate was open when I arrived. I suddenly got scared because I thought my friends had gone outside.

"Jay-jay!" I called.

When I went inside, something suddenly hit me.

I fell to my knees and cried from the pain. When I looked up, it was Mama. She was holding a hanger and was ready to hit me.

She hit me again, and I screamed from the pain.

"Mama, please stop!" I cried.

"Do you want to go outside?! Fine, go outside!" She dragged me and almost threw me. "...Stay there!"

"I won't do it again, Mama!" I begged.

"Will you do it again?! You don't know how to listen!"

"I won't leave Jay-jay!" I said, still crying.

She didn't say anything else and threw the hanger inside. She took her bag and left again. I stood up and went back inside.

I saw Jay-jay sitting on the floor eating bread. Lucky her. She didn't hurt her. Maybe she really loves her more.

Mama left early today. Jay-jay and I were left alone again.

I didn't want her to leave yet because Jay was sick again.

She was hot and seemed weak. I tried to wake her up to eat but she cried and cried. She went back to sleep after that.

I was worried about her. I was scared that they might take her to hospital. They injected her with so many medicines there.

"Aries!" Someone called from outside.

I saw her open the gate and come in. She was holding a bag. I saw that it was Ate Isabela.

She immediately went over to Jay and touched her forehead. "Where's your mama?"

"She's at work."

"You were left like this? Well, well." She stood up and opened a drawer where we keep our clothes.

She grabbed a towel, wet it with water from the sink, wrung it out, and folded it. She then approached Jay and placed it on her forehead.

"I'll check if there's any medicine here. You eat first." She went outside.

I did what she told me. I ate the food she brought, but I couldn't keep an eye on Jay. I wanted to feed her too.

Ate. Jamela came back with the medicine she mentioned. Jay ate and tried to make her take the medicine. Her pain slowly subsided.

It's been dark for a while, but Mama still hasn't come home. I tried checking at work but they said Mama wasn't there. Jay has gotten better.

I went over to her to adjust the towel on her forehead. She looked at me.

"Where's Mama?" She asked.

We didn't have any food left. I had already eaten the rice. Mama is usually home at this time to feed us. Since she had no food.

"I want to eat." She said.

I looked around for any leftover food, maybe some bread, but there was none. I only had one idea, and that was to buy food outside.

I grabbed the coins on the table. Ate Jama left them for me.

"I'll buy food. Stay here." I told her, and she nodded.

I ran outside. There's a food store near our house. They sell rice and sometimes snacks.

"Please give me some food." I said to the vendor.

"What do you want?"

"The one for the sick." I replied, and she laughed.

"Rice porridge?" She asked.

I didn't know what that was, but I just nodded. She quickly gave me a plastic container and filled it. I handed her the payment, and she gave me the food.

I ran back home, but when I reached the gate, I saw Mama

"Do you want to stay outside?! Fine! Sleep outside!" She slammed the door.

"Mama!" I yelled and repeatedly knocked on the door.

"Stay out there! Don't come in!" She shouted from inside.

I needed to give Jay-jay his food. I could hear her crying name.

"Mama! I have food for Jay-jay."

"Shut up!"

I stopped knocking and sat on the floor in front of the door with the food I bought for Jay.

I didn't want to sleep outside, but I was scared that Mama would hit me. The last time she hit me, she even struck my face. It stung.

I rested my head against the side of the door. Mama had the lights inside and outside the house, so it was pitch dark. I didn't know how much time had passed until the lights of the neighborhood went out.

Maybe Mama really doesn't love me.

Jay-jay was brought to the hospital again. Mama left me

I didn't respond. After gathering some clothes, she pulled house. She almost couldn't close the door because she was

She flagged down a tricycle and had us dropped off at the house. I wasn't familiar with the route we were taking. I wanted to go home but was afraid she'd get mad.

While the jeep was moving, I kept looking out the window, trying to find home again. I didn't know where we were anymore.

"Stop!" Mama shouted, and the jeep stopped.

She got off, and I followed. We walked to a place and stood in front of a big gate. It was tall, not like our house, which is low.

I immediately saw Lola watering the plants.

"Lola!" I shouted, and she looked at us.

She smiled and greeted us. She took the bag Mama was holding and was talking about something I couldn't understand.

"Aries." Mama called me and sat down to be at my level. "I need your Lola. I need to take care of Jay-jay."

I nodded. "You'll come back for me when Jay-jay is better, right?"

She nodded too. "Of course! I'll come back for you."

Lola said she was my aunt, but she always fights with me.

"I don't know. I'm not close with your mother, so I would
replied.

She always answers like that. It's frustrating. Suddenly, t
strongly, and since we were sitting by the window, all he
face.

Her hair smelled bad.

"Your hair!" I shouted.

"Enjoy it."

I was really annoyed now, so I grabbed her hair and pull
face freeze in surprise, and her face slowly darkened.

She quickly slapped me with two fingers, pinching my s
strength. I screamed from the pain.

"Lola!" I screamed while crying.

"Lara! You made him cry again!" Lola angrily called to m

"Your grandchild is so rude!" She replied, moving away

I was about to report what happened when we suddenly l
looking

"Aunt! Who is that?" I asked my aunt, the one who always angry with me.

"Why don't you ask her yourself?"

I couldn't get any answers from her. She always talks like I could get along, but she's always rude to me.

Soon, the woman entered the house, followed by a child.

"Here's another pest," I heard my aunt whisper.

"Lara! How are you? You're a lady now! How's school?" my aunt, smiling.

"Ask our principal." My aunt replied as she turned around her room.

I was about to follow her when I was stopped by the sight of the woman. It was clear she didn't know me, but she

"Hello..." She said, approaching me. "...how are you? Welcome."

"A-Aries."

"This is Jeana's child." One of my aunts said from behind me.

The woman's expression changed immediately, but she remained calm.

Chapter 241

Aries's's POV

*

Continuation Of Flashback...

*

I didn't realize that the child with him was my cousin. He and because he's older than me, I'm supposed to show respect to his lead.

"Get me a glass of water," Kuya Angelo said, but I didn't

I looked at him, confused. "Huh?"

He raised an eyebrow at me. "Get me some water."

I was about to stand up to obey him when suddenly, a bright light appeared on his face.

"Ugh!" He shouted while holding his face.

I looked around to see where it came from and saw Tita.

"Because I like hitting you! You don't English me! I'm the speaker!" Tita shouted while pointing her finger at his face.

I didn't understand what they were talking about. All I knew was that I had fallen victim to Tita's strong hands. He was one of the few who was scared of her.

"What's happening?" Tita Gema asked as she approached.

"Mom! She hit me with this!" Kuya said, running to his mother and showing her the book that had hit him.

"Lara..." said Lola, who was with Tita Gema. "...You treat me like this."

"That's an exaggeration. At least I haven't hurt anyone."

Tita replied while putting her hands in her pockets. "...I saw her at the hospital, right? I haven't seen her yet."

She was referring to Jay-jay. She was still in the hospital and hadn't picked me up yet.

"Who's in the hospital?" Tita Gema asked.

"Well, this monkey's sibling," she said, pointing at me.

Tita Gema turned to Lola and they started talking about the

"Hey!" Tita Lara called me.

"What?"

"You're ugly," she said, laughing.

I just turned my back and rested my elbows on my knees chin with my hands. Tita sat beside me and observed me

"Hey!" She called again.

"What now?" I answered without looking at her.

"If Angelo asks you to go with them, will you go?"

Would I go with them? Kuya said they had more toys than a bicycle that I could borrow. He said he would give me a

"Yes, but we'll come back right away because Mama might miss me."

Tita sighed. "What if there's no return? Will you still go?"

I shook my head. "I can't. Mama will come back for me and find me if I leave."

"Your mom won't come back for you," she said, and I got

"Tay-tay was released from the hospital the other day."

I started hitting her arm, but it didn't seem to have any ef

She just stared at me.

"Making the child cry. You're old enough for this," Kuya standing in front of us.

Tita gave him a nasty look. "Oh really? You want me to :

Suddenly, Tita ran, and Kuya started running too. He wa yelling "help" and "SOS."

I didn't believe him. He always made me cry, so I knew I me. I decided to go to Lola and ask if Jay-jay had really I the hospital.

I really wanted to see her.

They were in the back of the house, where the laundry w she were gathering the clothes from the line.

"Lola..." I called, and she glanced at me for a moment.

Tita Gema smiled at me and approached. She bent down were at eye level.

"How are you? I thought you were playing with your Ku

"Tita, Jay-jay is his playmate now."

"You want to study, right?"

I nodded eagerly.

"...I will send you to school." She said, full of joy.

My eyes widened at what she said. I couldn't stop myself. I really wanted that. I would be able to study.

"Really?"

"Yes. And you'll study at the same school your Kuya went to."

My smile faded. "Where is that?"

"Close to our place."

Does this mean I will really go with them? Is what Tita I live with them because Mama doesn't want me anymore?

"Tita Lara told me that you'll take me and won't bring me back true?"

Gradually, the smile disappeared from her face. She picked me down on the floor under the table where the clothes she earlier were placed.

"Because, Aries... Jay-jay needs to be looked after carefully and needs constant attention." She sighed deeply. "So...

I looked down. Jay-jay knows how much I want to go to tell her that I'll teach her what I learn there.

"No."

"So, you'll study first. You can see each other every vaca

I didn't know how to answer. I really didn't want to be av
What if Mama needs to work? Who will be with her? W

I really don't want this.

I was in Kuya Angelo's room when I overheard Lola and
They were talking about me, so I couldn't help but listen

"The child doesn't have a birth certificate," said Tita.

"How does he not? His full name is Aries Fernandez, Jea
Lola.

"Only Jay-jay is registered."

"Why is that? How will Aries enroll in school?"

"Maybe they can do a late registration."

I didn't understand what a birth certificate or registration
whatever it is, why don't I have one? Why does it seem l
has one?

"Mama! Are you picking me up? Are we going home?" I looked at me.

"Where's your Tita Gema?"

I let go of the hug and pointed to the house. She walked but didn't see me. I followed her.

I saw Tita Lara standing by the door, hands in her pockets, cold stare.

"Where's Gema," Mama said to her.

"Inside," Tita answered lazily.

Mama went inside and looked for what she was after. I followed her, but Tita grabbed my head to stop me.

"Stay here. It's an adult conversation."

I removed her hand from my head. "I told you, Mama is here. We're going home."

She didn't say anything, but there was something in her stare that told me what it was, but it felt like she didn't believe what I said.

Before long, we heard shouting inside the house. Even though the house looked over, I could hear Mama's voice, follow

The shouting paused for a moment until suddenly, Mama was furious and headed straight for me.

She sat down so we were face to face. I saw a tear fall from her eye. She quickly wiped it away.

"Aries... Listen," she said, holding my face. "...For now, Tita Gema. She'll send you to school. She'll feed you. She'll give you clothes..." She sighed deeply. "...For now, you'll be safe."

I shook my head. "I don't want to. I want to be with Jay-jay."

"It's not possible yet. I promise I'll come back for you one day. I'll take you back."

I couldn't stop myself from crying. "I don't want to! You left me before. You didn't come back to get me!"

"Because I needed to take care of Jay-jay."

"She's the only one you love! You probably want to give her to Tita Gema. You don't want me! You don't love me!"

"Aries! It's not like that. You're still young, you can't understand."

"No! You're lying! You're going to give me away!"

She tried to hug me, but I quickly ran and hid behind Tita Gema.

"You look so sad! You should be happy!"

I looked up at her. "Why would I be happy?"

"Because you'll be out of my sight!" She said and laughed.

That might be a good thing, since she's mean to kids. She is. Even my other cousins who visit here, she fights with them.

"Aries." Tita Gema called me as she walked closer. "...Aries, about to leave."

I shook my head in response. "I didn't get to say goodbye. You might look for me."

"You'll still see her during vacation."

"Okay." That's all I could say.

Kuya Angelo came out of the house with his bag. He gave a last moment before turning to Tita Gema.

"Let's go?"

Tita nodded at him, and they said their goodbyes to Lola. I told her I would be happy there, even though that's not how I

We got in the car, and when it started moving, I felt like I was sitting next to Kuya Angelo, and he kept glancing at

Every vacation, I would go back to Lola's house and then their new house. It wasn't far from our old house.

I'd take my bike, which was a gift from Kuya Angelo, to quickly see her on the road, and as usual, she didn't have

"Aries!" She called me while waving.

She could say my name clearly now. It was cute, but it a

"...He's my cousin." She said to her playmates. "...I'm going home while."

Cousin.

I didn't understand why she saw me that way. I know she was happy when I left, but I didn't expect her to forget so quickly w

I tried to push that thought out of my mind. I smiled for a moment, but I looked at her seriously.

"You don't have slippers again! Where are they?" I asked.

She looked at me confused. "What? Are you speaking in

"Your slippers! Where are they?!"

She scratched her neck. "They threw them on the roof."

As we rode, the wind hit us, and her hair kept flying in the air. After the accident, I glanced at the back of her neck and saw a straight line. She had it on the back of her ear too, and some parts of her hair were

I stopped the bike, and she was confused.

"What? Why did we stop?" She asked.

"What happened here?" I asked, holding her arm.

"Aahhh... It hurts!" She screamed and pulled her arm away. "Don't mind it."

"Where did you get that?"

she shook her head and tried to avoid my gaze. I had a bad feeling. The last time we met, I noticed bruises and cuts on her.

I knew she didn't get those from just fighting with someone.

"Is your stepfather hurting you?" I asked without hesitation.

Suddenly, she jumped off the bike. She turned her back to me.

"I'm going home. Let's play tomorrow." She said and ran away.

I was about to follow her, but I didn't want to anger her stepfather. He had remarried.

I stopped, and so did it. I looked at the car, annoyed.

After a while, the window rolled down. A man wearing sunglasses looked at me.

"Are you Aries?" He asked.

I didn't answer. I stared at him closely, and for some reason my heart started beating faster. I turned away from him and pedaled hard to make a turn down an alley to make sure he couldn't follow me.

I stopped before reaching the end of the alley and the man's car was still there.

I looked behind me. I was out of breath from what I had just done.

The feeling I had because of that man was strange.

I couldn't stop thinking about him. What was worse was that he was always outside our school. Just like today, while I was waiting for him to pick me up.

His car was parked nearby. The window was down, and I could see him coming out from the cigarette he was smoking.

"Aries!" Kuya called me while running. "...Sorry I'm late."

I immediately followed him. There were times I glanced back but he didn't move from his spot.

Chapter 242: Happy Family

Aries's POV

Continuation Of Flashback...

"Are you ready yet?" Percy asked, making a face at me.

I heard Yuri and Keifer laughing loudly.

"What the hell?!" That was all I could answer.

"Seriously, Percy? What were you thinking?" Yuri asked

"I'm older than you guys, so I should be taller." He replied about our heights.

He was the shortest among us, while Keifer was the tallest. It was unfair because technically, he was the youngest of us all.

There was a two-year age gap between them, one year between me and Keifer, and a month between me and Yuri. It really showed that I was the youngest.

"Maybe you didn't get enough sleep." Yuri teased.

down his shorts and briefs.

He scratched his neck and looked away. For the second time, he was the best of him. We all burst into laughter.

I wanted to introduce Jay-jay to them, but they didn't know that I had a sibling from my real mother. I could say she was my sister, but they'd probably wonder why I was so close to her.

Especially Keifer, who was good at suspecting things. He knew that everyone around him was lying to him. I didn't want to introduce Percy either because I didn't know what he might say or do. I had a problem with Yuri though.

"I think I need to go home. It's late, and Hahaoya might be waiting."

"What's Hahaoya?" Percy asked.

"That's 'Mother' in Nihongo."

He nodded and then suddenly came closer to me.

"I bet Yuri is a Mama's boy." He whispered to me.

"I heard you." Yuri said, glaring at him.

I just shook my head, laughing. We each went home after saying goodbyes. Keifer lived the farthest away. His house was

ones than those.

When I arrived home, all the lights were on. That meant awake, and I was in trouble with Kuya again. I quietly entered the door and saw Mama talking on the phone.

"Okay. We'll be home soon." She said, worriedly.

I froze as I watched her. For some reason, Jay-jay was then popped into my mind.

"Where have you been?" Kuya asked authoritatively. "...and get your things. We're going to Lola's house now."

"Did something happen?"

Mama answered my question. "Your sister is missing."

I didn't understand. There were a lot of people in front of the house. They were also talking to the police.

"Oh, that kid's been hurt for a long time. All the men were here." An elderly person told the police.

"They were making noise after the kid screamed loudly." said another police officer.

"Then the kid suddenly ran, all covered in blood. Her clothes were all bloody."

I didn't look at her. I wasn't in the mood to talk to her. I walked away when she grabbed me by the collar of my shirt.

"Come with me." She said, not looking at me.

We passed by the crowd of people and police outside. He was so close that I almost tripped.

"What the hell?! Let go of me!"

"Wait! Let's rent a ride!" She said and flagged down an auto-rickshaw.
"...Get in!" She pushed me inside.

"Where are we going?"

She didn't answer. She faced the tricycle driver.

"Hey... Go to my sister's house."

I was sure she was referring to Jay-jay's house. I didn't say anything the whole ride until we stopped in front of a house with a yellow door.

Auntie got out, and so did I.

"What are we doing here?" I asked.

"We're going to find Jay-jay." She said, arms crossed.

I furrowed my brows. If the police couldn't find her, how could I?

I scratched my head. She really thought she was so clever.

She grabbed me by the collar of my shirt again and practically threw me into the tricycle.

I felt like I was going to get sick from being with her.

It seemed like we'd already visited every neighboring village.

We almost got into a fight because of the noise coming from my companion.

The sky had darkened by the time we decided to have a rest. I didn't have any money with me. I'd be embarrassed if I had to ask for help from someone who was bold enough to rent a tricycle but had no money.

We were at the plaza now, sitting on a plant box, though it looked like trash was planted there instead of actual plants. I wasn't eating, but my companion was so persistent. It seemed like she was planning to shove a stick down my throat.

"Eat that! Eat it!" She said, forcing me to eat the fishball.

I winced at her cruelty. She had no mercy. Sometimes, I felt like I was dealing with some kind of dark creature.

"Where could that kid be?" She muttered to herself.

"She's not a kid. She's a girl. She's a girl."

She had already mentioned every possible bad outcome : now she was talking about her becoming homeless. I could feel frustrated and buried my face in my hands.

I heard the sound of her cellphone ringing. She looked at it and was pressing buttons.

"Let's go... Your brother's looking for you."

Brother?

She stood up, and I followed suit. We were walking down the street when I noticed a kid sitting by a trash bin, staring blankly.

I stared at him, and my shock and joy were overwhelming. I immediately recognized him.

"JAY-JAY!" I screamed, pointing down the road.

I crossed the street without waiting for my aunt. Cars honked at me because of what I did.

As I approached, I immediately hugged her.

"Jay! What happened to you? We've been looking everywhere for you," she said, but she didn't even move.

She just stared ahead, lost in thought.

"It's clearly a sign of traumatic disorder. Dissociative amnesia can sometimes be experienced by the victim," the doctor said.

We were all stunned when she told us that she couldn't remember what happened.

Lola gave the doctor a name, but Jay-jay didn't recognize it.

But the doctor said it seemed normal.

"How long will he be like this?"

"It depends on the patient, but I suggest taking her to child psychology trauma treatment."

They spoke for a while about possible actions. I chose to leave the room. She was sitting and reaching for her back.

"What are you doing?" I asked her.

"What did they treat on my back?"

She had a large wound on her back. She said it was caused by her stepmother.

She burned her with a hot iron.

"Y-you have a wound."

She lay down on her side, still frowning.

"Where's Mama?" She asked, stopping me in my tracks.

The truth is, I don't even know where she is. Ever since we haven't seen her. The last I heard about her was that she

"I don't know. Maybe she's on her way here. I'll tell Man

"Okay. Thanks," she replied and closed her eyes.

Wherever she is, I hope she comes here to check on Jay-

Because of the incident, Jay-jay ended up staying with L take care of her to ensure her well-being.

I just hope she's okay there, I still worry about her. Especially with that aunt of ours, who seems to be angry at the world

"You're quiet. Are you about to poop?" Percy asked, making

Here we go again.

"No." I answered flatly.

"You're still shy. Just say it. It's just between us."

"I said no. Stop it!"

"We just got back."

"How's your cousin? What was her name again? Jason?"

"Jay-jay."

"Boy or girl?" Keifer asked, sounding genuinely interested.

I raised an eyebrow. He's quick to get interested when it

I had no plans to introduce him to her.

"Just—" I didn't finish my sentence when Percy suddenly cut in of us.

"I found your spot. You can just cover it up later," he said.

"Huh?" We all answered in unison.

"Aren't you about to poop?" he asked me.

I just shook my head and turned around. The three of them

We talked about a lot of things, but most of it was about family.

His mom finally gained the courage to leave his dad. The situation was a lot, but Jay-jay's situation was even worse.

"What?! You can't miss it," Percy insisted.

"Fine, I'll come."

My plan didn't go as expected. I didn't visit Jay-jay, and passed without me going home to Lola's.

Whenever I'm with these three, I forget about the things Even my assignments and school projects. Yuri's the luck really mind forgetting those things. He's quick to catch up exams.

"Have you seen Percy?" Keifer asked me when I stepped

"No. Why?"

"That idiot won't introduce me to Freya."

I raised an eyebrow. Freya Hidalgo? I think I know where

"Let's go to the court," I suggested, and he followed me.

The court wasn't far from our room. As we got closer, I saw a ruckus with the guys. He seemed to be sneaking a peek at like everyone else.

"Percy!" I called, and he looked at us.

He seemed flustered and unsure of what to do

"Where are you going to high school?" Yuri asked me.

"At the school my brother went to."

"Which one? He's been to a lot," he said, laughing.

I laughed too. My brother transferred schools often because of fights, and Mama tried her best to straighten out his behavior but her efforts didn't really work.

We had to go home to Lola's. We found out that my brother had moved without us knowing. Lola had asked him to go to the school where mess Jay-jay got involved in.

I was shocked when he admitted to us what Jay-jay had told her. I had heard that she got into fights, but I didn't know it had escalated to this.

She was sitting on the couch with her knees pulled up to her chest, head down, not talking to anyone in front of her.

"Are you listening?!" My brother asked angrily.

She didn't answer. She glanced at me for a moment and then looked away again.

"You, a girl, getting into fistfights! Are you even thinking about your future?" he added.

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He tried to follow Jay, but Mama immediately blocked h

"Let her be for now!"

"I'll follow her," I said, and they allowed me to go.

At first, I thought she went to the street, but I saw her he  
back, where there was a big tree.

"Jay!" I called out, but she didn't pay attention to me. "...

She glanced at me with furrowed brows but immediately

"Wow, you came back here?" She asked sarcastically.

A lot had changed in her, but one thing remained the san  
like a guy, even though her appearance was very feminir

"Are you mad at me?"

"No. Is there any reason for me to be mad at you?"

I asked the wrong question. It was obvious she was mad  
because of our last conversation and because I hadn't vis

I looked at the basketball sitting in the corner. I grabbed  
dribbling.

"Come on. Let's play." I suggested

"Oh, is that what it was? What—"

"Just treat me, okay?" She cut me off.

I looked up at her. She was looking in another direction, put the ball down and dug into my pocket for some money.

"Let's go..."

To make it up to Jay-jay, I chose to celebrate my birthday with her. She helped me but smile. She thought it was only my 13th birthday but I know I had already turned 14.

Maybe I'll tell her later.

"I have a question for you," she said while eating. "...I have a brother. Is that true?"

I froze and slowly looked at her. It's still unclear to her why I couldn't stop feeling sad.

I'm your brother.

"Is that true?" She asked again.

"Y-yeah... He's older than you."

"I thought we were twins. You were the one on my mind when I was sad."

"Come on! You're too weak! And you know how to drive!"

I sighed. I think I know what they're planning. We once stole a car without permission, but only Yuri was with me at that time. Now they've already heard about what we did.

"I don't have a license."

"That's fine. When you get home, just call me right away."

He hung up before I could answer. When I hung up the phone, Jay-jay was at the window. Jay-jay was at the gate, talking to a man.

I went out and approached him. My brows furrowed quickly. I didn't know who he was. I couldn't be wrong—it was the guy who had kidnapped me before.

"Jay-jay!" I called, but before she could turn to face me, he grabbed her by the mouth and dragged her away. "Let go of her!"

I tried to fight and help Jay, but another man grabbed me from behind and tried to force us into a van.

"Who are you?!" Jay-jay screamed as we were put into the van.

"What do you want?!" I asked.

The van started moving without us getting any answers.

# Chapter 243: Basement

## Aries's POV

*\*Continuation Of Flashback...\**

"Aries..." Jay-jay whispered to me.

I opened my eyes, but it was too dark, and I couldn't see

My back was cold, and only then did I realize I was lying

I slowly sat up.

"Jay... Where are you?"

Someone grabbed my arm. "Aries."

I knew it was her. I took her hand and pulled her closer t

I hugged her tightly.

"Where are we?" Her voice was shaking. "Where did the

I couldn't remember much about what happened. Because earlier, they put me to sleep with a handkerchief that had



"There's a window," Jay-jay said.

I looked at where she pointed. There was indeed a small window, but it was too high. It was almost touching the ceiling.

It was because of that window that a little light came into the room in the morning, and only then did it become clear where we were.

It looked like the basement of our house. There were piles of boxes, a sofa set that looked even older than me, boxes of clothes and miscellaneous items. There was a full-body mirror and a door that looked like it didn't work.

"Can you reach it?" She asked.

I tried to climb up the boxes to reach, but we heard a loud noise followed by footsteps and the sound of keys.

I quickly jumped down and moved to Jay's side. I hid behind him and waited for whoever was coming inside.

The door opened, and the man who had been following us came in.

He was holding a tray full of food and a gallon of water.

"Your food," he said before closing the door behind him.

He placed the tray on the old coffee table and sat on the sofa.

Jay-jay and I exchanged glances, but before I could move something that stopped me.

"You look alike."

My heart started racing faster, and a lot of thoughts spun pointing to this man. Could it be... No!

"Aries," he called my name and stood up. "...We have the

I stepped back, and so did Jay. He moved closer to me, s

"Your mom was really serious about what she said. She told me to you."

I swallowed hard as he grew more serious and turned his back who was behind me.

I tried to hide her behind me, but he laughed slightly.

"I'll be back here, so make sure to eat well," he said and

He exited the door, and I heard the sound of keys again.

Then came the sound of metal hitting the wall.

I couldn't help but feel weak. I had never looked for a father I thought he was dead.

"Jay! You're just making a mess."

I looked at her, but she wasn't answering anymore. All I saw were boxes, but she was nowhere to be found.

"Jay?"

I stood up from the floor and approached where she was.

"Jay? What the—?" I stopped when I saw her inside a large box.

It was obvious she had fallen asleep, that's why she hadn't been answering. She was wrapped in some clothes used as a blanket. She had been here for a while earlier, so I guess she got tired.

I always said we'd go home eventually, but it felt like that day had never happen. I didn't want to lose hope.

While watching Jay, I suddenly got an idea.

I quickly fixed the boxes and put back everything she had.

I also rearranged everything back to its proper place.

I just hope this works!

As expected, he brought food again. I covered Jay's mouth so she wouldn't make any noise.

"Dammit! They might have escaped!" he shouted and ran.

I didn't hear him close the door, so I immediately ran out. Jay. As expected, he thought we had escaped.

"Do you think... he left?" Jay asked me.

I nodded as a response, though deep down, I wasn't sure. I opened the door and peeked outside. I was greeted by a concrete

"I'll go first," I said, taking a step up the stairs.

I moved slowly, and when I reached the top, I saw a metal door. It was the metal sound we've been hearing every time he broke

It was open. I peered out, and when I was sure there was no one outside, I signaled Jay to come closer, but it seemed unnecessary. When she turned around, she was already behind me.

"Sorry, I couldn't wait," she said with a smile.

We quietly walked outside. We found ourselves in a large open area. There was complete silence, so I felt more confident to just walk. I peeked out of the nearest window.

"Where are we?" Jay whispered.

I shook my head. "I don't know."

Think, Aries!

"Aries... th-there's someone... coming," Jay said, trembling.

I panicked even more. I looked around for somewhere to hide, but there were no walls. Damn it! I had no choice but to run in some direction. Jay and I didn't let go.

We turned a corner, went up the stairs, and entered some room. I had no idea where we were. Gasping for air, I was forced to stop running from exhaustion and hunger.

"Aries! A door!" Jay said happily, pointing to a door not far away.

Without hesitation, I ran towards it, but before I could get to the door, Jay slipped from my grip. I looked back at her and froze.

He grabbed Jay and pressed a knife to her neck. He was looking at me.

"I've been looking for you everywhere!"

A hard slap sent me to the ground. My face went numb, and I couldn't move.

"You smart little brat! But you won't outsmart me!" he yelled. "I have to pay a lot for someone to adopt you, so why would I let you go?"

I heard him laugh. "I'll let you go now. Once I get the men together anymore, so enjoy the time you have!"

He pushed Jay towards me. I caught her, but we both felt weakness. He grinned at me like a demon before leaving man.

We were silent as they left, but not long after, I heard Jay crying, and I couldn't stop myself from crying either because of the situation.

I felt so weak. I couldn't even defend Jay-jay. I was her c  
should be the one she can lean on, but I was the first to g  
us.

I was useless.

"I-I want to go home," Jay said.

I wanted that too, but I didn't know how.

"Sorry," was all I could say.

"Your sorry won't change anything."

Her words froze me. I slowly got up and looked at her, filled with confusion.

**007-1**

I didn't know how many hours I had been awake, but I could feel it. I felt different. I had been scared before, but I was more so now. I didn't know why. My breathing was tightening, even though I wasn't choking me.

It was dark, and the only light we had was what came through the window. There was a light bulb on the ceiling, but the switch seemed to be broken.

Jay was peacefully asleep beside me. I envied her because she could sleep despite our situation. She hadn't spoken to me since we had been here.

I wanted to leave here. What if it's true that he will separate us? What if it happens to us then? To Jay-jay?

I heard the sound of the metal door opening from outside. A person was coming, so I quickly woke Jay.

"What now?!" She snapped at me and turned her back.

"Jay! Get up—" I couldn't finish what I was saying because the door suddenly opened.

He was holding handcuffs and a handkerchief. He walked in quickly, and I stood up and backed up against the wall. Jay didn't seem to hear anything.

"It's time... Angelo paid me well for this," he said with a smile.

"No, I won't!"

I couldn't stop him from putting the handcuffs on one of  
panicked and screamed.

"Shit! Jay-jay!"

"Shut up!" he said, trying to cover my mouth.

"No!"

We both froze when we heard the sound of a car horn. H  
door, looking scared. I immediately realized that he had  
horn. It could be that it didn't come from his companions  
people!

"Help! Somebody help us!"

"Shut up, I said!"

"Kuya Angelo! Mom!"

"You're a pain!" he said angrily, slapping me.

"Jay! Wake up, please!"

I ignored the pain. What mattered to me was escaping fr  
reached for one of my hands to cuff me, but suddenly so  
away from me. It wasn't a strong push, but it was enough



sending her flying somewhere.

"Jay-jay!" I screamed, running towards her.

I hadn't even seen her clearly when the monster pulled me again to cuff my hand.

"Let go of Aries!"

Jay-jay!

He tackled us and tried pulling my hand away from the cuff, hitting my hand with the other one. I seized the opportunity and kicked him in various places, and he grimaced in pain.

"What the heck?! Stop, you kid!"

"Let go, I said! Let go of me! I won't leave without Jay!"

Something came to mind, and I kicked him where it hurt from the pain but still held onto us. Jay wasted no time and screams grew louder from the double pain.

I was free, but Jay-jay wasn't, and in the blink of an eye, my eyes. He slapped Jay with all his strength, and Jay went down. I saw her head hit, but I wasn't sure if she was hurt.

"JAY!" I shouted, about to approach, but she stood up on

"Don't be afraid... We'll treat this." I said, looking around.

The monster was still in pain. It would have been a good time to escape, but I was panicking over what was happening. I saw a small wound bleeding on her head.

The cuffs were a hindrance to my hand, so I focused on getting them off first. They weren't very tight, so I slipped my hand out easily and stood beside Jay.

I stood up and walked toward the boxes, hoping I could find something to treat the wound. I almost threw everything around but still didn't find anything. I grabbed my own hair in frustration.

What should I do? What if something happens to Jay?

"Hey, kid." The monster called as he slowly stood up.

I braced myself to fight him. I wasn't going to let fear control me. I had to protect my sister. I looked behind him and saw Jay standing there, her cuffs in her right hand.

It seemed the monster noticed where I was looking, so he turned. Just as he turned, the cuff hit his jaw. Jay punched him with her fist like brass knuckles.

He fell, blood flowing from his jaw and neck. His skin was covered in cuts. I stepped back. Something was wrong!

seemed like she didn't care. I was about to take another step when I heard the monster speak.

"Y-you damn kid."

He tried to stand up. Blood kept pouring from his jaw.

He was turning pale and looked like he was going to collapse in a moment.

We heard the sound of sirens. I knew it came from the police station, which seemed to be nearby. I turned my gaze back to the monster, who was crawling away.

I looked back at Jay, but I was shocked when she suddenly fell to the ground with the cuffs. I stepped back and managed to avoid it, but I lost my balance and fell to the ground.

"Jay! What's wrong with you?!"

She was crying, and it seemed like she was afraid of something. She slowly walked towards me. She quickly raised her fist, but I managed to dodge it, and it hit the mirror behind me.

The glass shattered, and pieces fell everywhere.

She dropped the cuffs, and I saw blood on her fist. It seemed like she was hurt herself.

"Jay."

I tried to approach him, but her hand quickly grabbed a glass. Without hesitation, she lunged at me with it. I blocked my arm, and it landed there.

"Argh!" I screamed from the pain.

"You're going to hurt me too. All of you." She said while

"H-hy, I won't do that," I pleaded with her.

She took another step toward me. I couldn't move back and she lunged at me again with the glass, and I couldn't block it.

It hit just below my left chest.

I screamed loudly. I grabbed Jay's arm to stop her, but the glass sank deeper into my flesh.

"JAY! NO!"

It felt like my skin and flesh were being torn apart.

I couldn't hold on any longer, so despite myself, I kicked the glass being pulled from my body. It was painful! So painful.

But that wasn't all I felt. My breathing was getting tighter and my blood was filling my mouth.

My vision was blurring. I couldn't breathe or move.

Maybe this was it.

Why did you do this to me, Jay?

# Chapter 244: Cousins for r

## Aries's POV

\*

## Continuation Of Flashback...

\*

I hear something. A repetitive beep sound, followed by a  
Slowly, I opened my eyes, but everything was blurry. It

"He's awake," I heard a woman say.

I tried to move my gaze in another direction. It was blurry  
something moving, and there was some light. I tried to o  
speak, but my throat was dry. I couldn't move properly, &

"Check the vitals," I heard a man's voice say.

After a while, my vision adjusted on its own. I could unc  
still alive, and I was in the hospital. It didn't take long fo  
come back to me. Why I was in the hospital, and why I v

Jav had tried to kill me!

"A week or two from now. It depends on when you can see the doctor answered.

I wanted to leave. I felt strange in this place. I didn't like the hospital. We all looked at the door when we heard a knock. Mom, Dad, and Percy, Yuri, and Keifer entered.

They brought a cake, ice cream, and balloons. The doctor came and left. Kuya followed him out.

"Hello, Tita!" Percy greeted Mom with joy.

"Hello, too. Thank you for coming," Mom replied.

"Sorry, Tita, this is all we brought. We didn't know what to bring. Yuri said while placing the cake on the table near us.

"It's okay, it seems like you're the only ones who will eat here yet," Mom explained, and they all looked at me.

"Poor you, Pre... I'll eat the one for you." Percy smiled. "I'm not a doctor, but I can help with your circumcision?"

He quickly got a tap on the head from Keifer. I guess he was joking. My expression hadn't changed. I couldn't smile. I couldn't do anything.

"Are you okay?" Yuri asked me.

"I'm fine, Yuri. I'm just a little nervous." I replied.

"Happy Birthday to you... Happy Birthday to you... Happy Birthday... Happy Birthday, Aries!" they sang as they broke closer to me.

They blew party horns and threw confetti. I tried to smile but I  
didn't feel anything. My heart felt numb.

"T-thank you," I said and blew out the candle.

As soon as I lifted my gaze, I saw Jay-jay at the door. She was holding a gift while wearing a patient gown. But as I blinked, the woman was now holding a piece of glass, covered in blood.

I backed away, and my wound ached, causing Percy to p

"Pre! Are you okay?" he asked.

"I'll call the doctor," Mom said as she walked out.

When I looked again, Jay was gone. I slowly started to b again.

"I-I'm okay," I said and lay back down.

The doctor and Mom came back. They examined me for convinced them that I had just moved the wrong way, wI wound to hurt.

**T**     **A**     **F**     **1**     **C**     **1**     **1**     **1**     **1**     **1**     **1**     **1**



I shook my head. "W-who?"

"Why are you affected?" he asked again.

"I-I just got surprised."

He didn't ask again but didn't take his eyes off me, almost studying me. He could really tell when someone was lying.

I can't sleep. Every time I close my eyes, I see her face. I stained hand won't leave my mind. My sister tried to kill

"Aries..." Kuya called me. "...what's wrong?"

"N-nightmares."

"You have trauma, expect nightmares almost every night. Come over to the table to get some water. "...we can visit a psychologist if you want."

He handed me a glass of water. I drank before answering.

"I don't think that's necessary."

I returned the glass to him. He put it back on the table at the previous spot. I laid down properly and tried to close my eyes. Her image came back to my mind, it felt like my breathing

"It's so quiet. He probably passed." Dany said.

"Honestly, I'm not full from what we're eating," Keifer said, pointing to the pizza box on the table.

The pizza's finished, and he's still not full?

"Yeah, pizza's not really filling," Percy added.

"When can you leave the hospital?" Yuri asked me.

"They said next week, I can go home."

"That's a long time!" Percy complained and laid down on the bed.

"Why did you ask?"

Yuri shook his head. "It's so boring here."

"And it's making me hungry," Keifer added as he searched for something to eat on the table.

"You can eat outside. I can take care of myself. I'll call a doctor if anything happens."

Percy quickly stood up. "Let's go. Aries is fine."

The rascal started walking towards the door, but before he could get out, Yuri stopped him.

"Are you crazy? Aries is a patient, we should never leave him alone."

"Yeah."

Yuri nodded and stood up. "We'll be back soon."

I nodded as well and watched them leave the room. But I couldn't close, someone stopped it. My brows furrowed in

Slowly, the person peeked in. My breathing started to tighten, pain in my wound flared up. I turned my head away and

"A-Aries..." she called me.

I couldn't breathe.

I gripped the blanket tightly. I couldn't move, and it felt like I was in a confined space.

"How are you? Sorry I'm just getting here. I've been feeling bad for some time."

Even though I didn't look at her, I knew she was getting close. I took a deep breath to calm myself. I opened my eyes and saw Jia while standing by my side.

"Are you feeling bad? Do you want me to call a doctor?" she asked. I quickly shook my head.

I glanced at her bandaged hands. There were bruises on her

"Don't!" I shouted at her. "Don't touch me."

"Aries. I'll call a doctor."

"No!"

I looked at her, and for some unknown reason, all I felt was  
her.

"P-please... Jay. Don't come near me. D-don't talk to me

I knew what I did was wrong. I shouldn't have pushed Jay.  
could I do? I couldn't handle it when she was close to me

"It's so quiet!" Percy shouted, breaking our attention.

Even Keifer and Yuri weren't speaking since we all met up

"I'm bored," Keifer answered.

"I'm tired," Yuri said.

"I'm thinking," I said.

"I'm handsome," Percy said.

We all looked at him at the same time, raising an eyebrow  
one able to joke and smile in this situation.

"I can buy as many cars as I want. But I don't have a license all."

"You're so unlucky..." he replied with a mischievous smile. "Wait for one more year, and I can get a student license."

"Wait for our licenses. Our cars will be better than yours."

It was clear the rascal wasn't backing down, so I spoke up to continue the conversation.

"Just use Kuya's car," I said, bored.

They all looked at me and nodded. I knew Kuya wasn't happy I would use his car.

We went back to our house to execute our plan. I peeked out the window to make sure no one would see me, then I had Percy open the gate.

Kuya's car keys were in his room. I quietly walked there and opened his door because Mama doesn't like it.

I immediately spotted the keys on his study table. I quickly grabbed them and hurried out to the car. I was going to drive because I knew who knew how to.

Kuya was the one who taught me. I started the car and drove away from the house, then had them close the gate. Once I was sure everyone was asleep, I

between us at first.

"Are you okay?" he broke the silence.

"H-huh?"

"Ever since you got out of the hospital, you've changed a

Here he goes again.

"N-nothing... I just haven't been sleeping well."

He didn't say anything, but he gave me that meaningful l

His instinctive ability to read people is so annoying! Wh  
smart? He's good at reading people. Weird!

I looked across the street. Yuri and Percy were crossing,  
plastic bags each. What I found odd was that one of the 1  
was holding seemed heavy.

Once they got back in the car, I immediately checked wh

My brows furrowed when I saw the cans of beer they ha

"Percy... we're all minors," I reminded him.

He grinned widely. "We're the law now."

Yuri answered for me. "He's going to drive, and he just got to the hospital."

I turned my back to them and looked at the city again. Things looked like toys because of how small they appeared.

"Aries..." Keifer called me.

I looked at him, and there it was again — that strange weight on my chest. He took a sip from the beer he was holding.

"...you still haven't told us what happened to you."

I shook my head. "Maybe next time."

"Now, bro!" Percy said eagerly. "...What did your kidnappers do?"

"Typical scenes."

"Like the ones in the movies?" Yuri asked.

I walked over to sit beside them. "Yeah."

We fell silent. It was as if they were waiting for me to say something, but I wasn't ready to tell them yet. I quietly touched my wound.

It was slowly healing, but not the wound inside me.

It was

We all grimaced. If anyone should be worried, it should be of the huge inheritance waiting for him, from his grandpa inherited from his mom.

"Seriously, guys... If something happens to me, you'll take care of my siblings, even Freya," Percy said seriously.

We all looked at him seriously too. What he said was scary.

"I'm not doing that," Keifer quickly replied.

Percy shot him a glare. "See? This is what happens."

"If I agree, you'll slack off and let something bad happen to me," Yuri explained.

"Of course, that's not what would happen!" Percy defended.

"Nothing bad will happen to you, because you're the one who caused all the bad things that happened to us," Yuri joked, and it looked like he was about to charge at him, but Yuri stopped him.

"Is it drizzling?" he said, looking up with his hand outstretched.

I also looked up to feel it, but the drizzle I was expecting turned into a heavy downpour. We all panicked. Everyone scrambled and hurriedly got back into the car.

"What is this?" Keifer asked, looking up at the sky.



"Let's wait until the rain calms down," Yuri suggested.

I checked the time on the small digital clock in front of the car. Kuya must have already come home. I'm really going to

"We can't stay here too long," I said, trying to start the car. I was doing anything at all.

"Don't force it. We might get into an accident," Yuri warned. I stopped.

"We'll stay here for now," Percy said as he adjusted his seat.

I followed what they said. We waited for the rain to lessen. I was sitting in the car for almost an hour. Keifer had fallen asleep. How long we'd been waiting. He's the impatient type.

Another hour passed, and I decided to try starting the car. I must be looking for us. The worst part is, the sky was getting dark. It only made it harder for me to drive.

"This is dangerous, bro..." Percy stopped me.

"No choice. It'll be harder for us if it gets darker."

He didn't say anything and just let me continue. We moved forward, especially since the road was going downhill. But the headlights were even worse by a sudden flash of lightning followed by a

"The radio isn't working here," Percy said without looking at me.

I angrily turned the switch off. I had to prepare myself for the fact that I also needed a good excuse for why I took his car without permission.

I closed my eyes and rubbed the space between my eyes, trying to think of what I could do, suddenly, there was another car in front of me and when I opened my eyes, I saw Jay-jay's face.

My breathing tightened again. Sweat poured down my forehead as the car's air conditioning was on. My hands were trembling on the steering wheel and tried to start the car.

"Bro... wait," Percy said, sitting up straight.

I ignored him and kept driving. My wound throbbed along with the beating of my heart.

"Are you okay, Aries?" Yuri asked.

"W-we need to go home."

Both he and Percy shrugged. They started talking about the situation, but I didn't understand. I didn't bother to listen anymore because all I wanted in my mind was getting home.

The sky grew darker quickly due to the bad weather. We were on the dangerous road of Danger's Hills, so I tried to calm myself down.

# Chapter 245: Say goodbye

## Aries's POV

### **\*Continuation Of Flashback...\***

Jay-jay....w-why?

"Aries!"

Slowly, I opened my eyes. Everything was blurry, and I didn't feel anything, and it seemed like I couldn't move.

"Wake up! Aries!" Someone shouted angrily.

Only two people I know speak English when they're angry: Keifer and Percy. I tried to move my hands, but they wouldn't cooperate. I was at the front of the car.

W-why does it seem like—?!

Where am I?! No! Where are Keifer, Yuri, and Percy?! I was looking from the back, but I only saw Percy. Bloodied and trembling.

What happened?

"W-what was that?"

Percy took a deep breath. "W-we're on the edge of a cliff  
Cliff?"

I peeked out the window beside me. The front of the car wheel was hanging over the cliff. The car could fall anyt

I didn't know what to do. My mind went blank. Is this w  
die? I survived what Jay did, but now I'm going to end u

"W-what do we do, Percy?" I asked him.

He looked at me as if saying there was no hope left.

"Open the door beside you." He commanded.

I did as he said and was shocked when it came off from  
attached to the car. That caused the car to shake even me  
onto the steering wheel and the seat.

The car stopped moving. I took a deep breath to calm my  
what I needed to do if I panicked.

"P-Percy." I called out to him, wanting to ask what to do  
when I saw him smiling at me.

"X-yes, have to jump out." He said with a broken voice

I can't. I can't just leave him here.

"You have to. T-this is the only way." He replied, tears falling.  
"...my siblings, please. And Freya..." he smiled bitterly. 'I told her that her boyfriend tried to be a superhero."

"No, Percy! Ask anything else."

He shook his head while wiping his tears. "You have to listen to me seriously."

"Percy! No! I can't!"

"Get out! Leave me here!"

"No! I'm not leaving you here!"

"Do it! Leave me here!"

He grabbed me by the collar of my shirt. His tears continued to fall from his hand.

"O-only one of us can survive today....don't waste this chance."

"I-I can't."

He smiled at me again. That smile that says everything's going to be okay.  
That smile he always gives us.

A river was at the bottom of the cliff. The current was still  
was muddy. I clearly saw how quickly the water swallow

"P-Percy..."

*\*EndOfFlashback...\**

Slowly, I opened my eyes. The light peeking through the  
me. I turned my head to the other direction, and Jay-jay,  
greeted me.

She was even drooling while sleeping.

I can't hold my smile because of her face. Yup! She's def

I flicked her forehead to wake her up, but it didn't work.

I tried to get up but stopped when I saw what was on my  
was almost touching my face.

I moved her leg and gently pushed her, but she still didn'  
still sound asleep even though she fell asleep before me ]

"Sigh... I can't believe this." I whispered to myself.

I got up from her bed and grabbed my phone from the be  
frowned when I saw a text message from an unknown nu

**From: 1620\*\*\*\*\***

Could it be?

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## **Jay-jay POV**

I held the fork and was ready to strike. I quickly stabbed plate, but I had an opponent. There was another fork staring at the hotdog I was eyeing.

There's one more fork.

I could totally play that scene from a movie—when the two forks face off. Accompanied by an intense glare in the middle of the plate.

Hehehe, this feels so cinematic.

"This is mine," I said threateningly.

"No, this is mine," came the reply from my opponent, not Perena—er, I mean, the horoscope guy.

"This is mine! I got here first!"

"Jay! You've eaten seven hotdogs already."

"Seriously, it's only five," I explained as I slowly pulled the fork away from the hotdog.

Still holding my neck, I looked at him in confusion. "What 'learn'?"

"Those things you're saying—about the hotdog," he said at me.

"Well, he really does have his own hotdog! There, in his his plate with two untouched hotdogs.

Aries acted oblivious while continuing to eat. I glanced at him and he seemed embarrassed. It looked like he was reading the newspaper upside down.

Maybe Kuya's brain is full of moss.

Since we finished our breakfast—hotdogs, eggs, and bacalao, we went back to settle for pandesal. I was still hungry. I wanted to eat more.

"So where are you going to 'room'?" Aries suddenly asked.

I looked at Kuya for a moment before answering. "M-maybe the gymnasium or the open auditorium at school."

I heard the sound of the newspaper folding beside me. I looked at him and he didn't ask. He didn't know we'd been officially kicked out of the school. We were going to end up in the swamp.

"What do you mean? Why are you going to 'room' in the



"...answer me."

"Because..." I scratched my head.

"...They kicked us out of the room," I quickly said, but it seemed like he understood.

"WHAT?!"

I acted like I was checking the time, even though I didn't know where the wall clock was.

"Wow, look at that! I'm going to be late. I need to get ready."

I quickly stood up and didn't wait for Kuya to say anything. I ran to my room and locked the door. I really hoped he wouldn't rush to the school. That would cause a whole new scene.

I grabbed my cellphone and checked for messages from him, but there were none. I threw it onto the bed and grabbed my towel before heading straight to the bathroom.

At least the ghost knows how to make itself known.

It's embarrassing for the King of Snakes. It seems like he has no intention of coming back here. I was already under the shower when something crossed my mind.

What if that idiot already has a girl? He's in another country. There are plenty of beautiful women there, tall and well-endowed. It's not impossible—damn you, King!!!

I really hope that idiot is not flirting with anyone. I'll board a plane, even if it's just on the wing or the wheels, just to get to where he is. I'll make him feel the pain of revenge.

Your eyes will be unscathed.

Even your... there, I'll mark it with a whip. You'll crawl in and I'll beat you with curses.

"Just don't go around flirting with women," I said, continuing my shower.

After finishing my bathroom routine, I got dressed. I was about to leave the room when I heard a knock on the door. Without thinking, I opened the door. Horoscope for today.

"Hurry up. We're going to be late," he said irritably before I could respond.

I blinked in confusion. What?! Did he just say "we"? We're going to be late? That mean...? It does!

I'm being dramatic, but I'm kind of happy.

Wow! Is this it? Is this the sign that everything's okay because there's no more fighting? We're okay now, like that!

Smiling, I grabbed my bag and ran out of my room. That was the reason I was there from something so simple. A shallow reason, but for me, it was enough.

It's official! Everything is alright now between me and him. I can finally predict the future.

When I stepped outside, I saw him standing by his car. He was waiting for me to get in the passenger seat next to the driver. I, being excited, got in.

"You're weird," he whispered, though I heard it.

"I'm just happy," I replied.

"And why?"

"Because we're okay now. You've accepted how beautiful

Suddenly, he laughed and shook his head. I let it go since I was probably happy about us making up.

We reached the school, and he didn't let me get out. I stayed parked the car. I was grinning from ear to ear as I unbuckled

"Thank you," I said to him.

"For what?"

I shook my head. "Nothing. I just wanted to say it."

He smiled and signaled for me to come closer, which I did. I didn't know what he was going to do, but suddenly he pinched my cheek

"Aaahhh... It hurts! It's painful!"

"Get a grip! Stop picking fights!" he said while pulling me

I was almost in tears when he finally let go. I was expecting a forehead like in the shows I watch on TV

"Jay," he called. "...let's go to the gymnasium."

I looked at him seriously and nodded. I turned toward the door and he followed me.

"Jay-jay," he called again, but I didn't look at him.

"...I have something to give you."

I stopped and quickly faced him. I looked at his hand.

It was a flash drive, the type with a small connector. I knew it was for cellphones.

I thought it was food.

I took it from him and examined it. "What's this for?"

"I wanted to apologize to you... for what we did. As a way to try and retrieve all the files from your old phone."

My eyes widened at what he said. The old phone I had thought was that idiot King, but he avoided it! It was broken and shattered.

If he got the files, that means all the pictures and videos.

"I'm really sorry, Jay. I'm loyal to Keifer, so I followed him. I was looking down."

"You're such a jerk. I only held your hand and now you're leaving me," I said sarcastically. "...You're something else."

"Sorry. I was just happy," he replied, scratching the back of his head. "I'll go to the gym."

He started walking ahead, and I quickly followed. I felt like many good things were going on right now. I was holding onto memories from before.

I couldn't stop smiling. It felt like nothing could ruin my happiness.

But that was just what I thought, because when we entered the hallway,

The world's punishment awaited us.

# Chapter 246: New room, new enemy

## Jay-jay's POV

GARBAGE! Garbage everywhere. Garbage here, garbage there, the gymnasium is piled with garbage.

"What is this?!" I said in annoyance.

I looked at the Ulupongs who were kicking the garbage around.

Edrix and I approached them.

"Jay-jay!" Ci-N greeted me with full joy while waving.

"Why is it like this here?" I asked him.

he shook his head. "I don't know. When we got here, it was like this."

Why do I feel like this was done on purpose?

It's disgusting to stay here, and to add to it, there's a slight

"Yeah, Sir!" Kit agreed.

Everyone started complaining until I felt someone grab r  
and saw Yuri. he gently pulled me away from the Ulupo

"W-what?" I asked him.

"I went to your place, but they said you already left. Why  
for me?" Sadness was evident in his eyes.

I scratched the back of my neck. "I went with Aries." I st  
remembered what I needed to tell him. "...we're okay now

he smiled too. "Really?! Congrats!"

But the sadness in his eyes didn't go away. It seemed like  
problem he didn't want to show me.

"Are you okay? You seem sad."

he shook her head. "I was just worried earlier."

I frowned at his answer. Worried? But about what?

"Why would you be worried? I was just going to school.

he quickly avoided my gaze. "I-it's about Sato."

But it didn't feel like that was the real reason. I just chose

"Let's just clean the gymnasium. That's the only way we be taught by the other teachers," Sir explained.

"Sir, come on! It's already a hassle that they moved us on now this?!" Eren said angrily.

Others agreed with him, but some also agreed with what course, there were those who just wanted to stir things up

"Let's just blow up the other rooms so they can join us he most troublemaker of all.

Ci-N, as always!!

"That's great, keep up the stupidity," Josh said sarcastica

The Brat immediately glared at him. "If you're so smart, here?!"

"If you're smart, why do you need to ask me that? Why c yourself?" he shot back.

"Keep going. Fight some more. That'll be a big help," Bl on.

"Fight! Fight!"

Everyone's attention shifted to the two brats arguing abo



"What do we need? Teamwork! What do we need? Teamwork!" and we all looked at him. "...wonder pets! Wonder pets!"

At this moment, it wasn't just me who facepalmed. Even Ulupongs had the same reaction. He's really acting like a

"I'll pretend that I didn't hear that," David said and approached the cleaning supplies?"

"In the storage room where the other equipment is," Sir said and walked to the door at the far end.

David walked there, followed by Eman, Denzel, Ci-N, and F. The others didn't want to follow until they were pushed.

I followed too. We each grabbed brooms, dustpans, mop heads, and bags. We each had our own areas to clean. There was so much to do by the pests—I mean, students of this school.

Even the bleachers in the corner of the gymnasium had to be cleaned. Embarrassing for them? They kicked us out of our room, but they showed us.

They're so kind, I hope Lowd takes them soon.

"Jay-jay!" Ci-N shouted, but I didn't look at him.

I had a feeling about what he was doing.

"See, I'm so pretty!" he said in a dramatic tone while wa

He wore the garbage bag like a dress and tied it around h  
headband. He looked ridiculous. He was spinning around  
wearing some fancy outfit.

"Hey, a crazy person got in here!" Felix shouted, followe

"Tsk! You're just jealous of my beauty!" Ci-N replied flir

"Oh no! He's lost it!" Calix teased.

"It's the effect of the garbage smell!" Kit added.

Maybe!! The smell was so bad, it must have cooked his l

They all burst out laughing. Even I couldn't help but laugh  
Brat was still at it! He was even better than a model on a  
approached David.

"Hi Dabid," he greeted while batting his eyelashes.

David grimaced at his appearance. "What are you? A gai

"No." He spun around and raised his hand, then stopped.  
princess!" he said flirtatiously.

Oh my, really?!

"You're too hot, David. Chill a bit. Want me to give you a little more?" Koya pucker-  
ing his lips at him.

There it is! Koya finally gave in.

David tried to push him away, but the Brat clung to him and burst out laughing, but not everyone found it funny.

"Stop that, Ci-N! You're disgusting!" Drew said angrily, looking at him.

"She's just joking... let it go," Denzel replied to him.

"Even so!"

"Do you have a problem with gay people?" I asked, slightly crossing my arms.

His eyebrows furrowed as he faced me, clearly unhappy to be the center of attention among his classmates.

"N-no... whatever! They're just gross," he said, turning his head away.

He went back to cleaning, pretending we weren't watching. Kit and Mayo, who were also exchanging meaningful looks.

I just shook my head and went back to what I was doing. The teachers were enough of us, so it only took about an hour to clean.

"Thank you, Sir."

"Let's take a break."

Sir was about to grab the garbage bags, but David stopped and volunteered for us to take care of disposing of them. Sir showed concern for us.

I couldn't blame him; we looked like beggars here. I don't know why we still come to school. It's obvious we're not welcome here.

"I need some help here," David said, but no one paid attention. "...come on. A little cooperation."

The idiots were still ignoring him, each doing their own thing—some chatting, others were playing on their phones, and some were just sitting down on the bleachers and sleep.

Wow, these Ulupongs are really something else.

I saw David look at Ci-N—still wearing his "princess" outfit.

"Hey, beautiful princess. Maybe you can help me," he said.

The Brat dramatically flipped his imaginary long hair and crossed one leg over the other.

Gorgeous! he really nailed it.

class time, so there were no students loitering around.

If there were, we'd be the talk of the school again. We're in a new building. It was one of the oldest buildings in the school and now it was that only one room was occupied by students. The rest was empty or closed.

"This was our room before," David said, looking at the building. "The second year when I moved to their section."

I looked at it too. It seemed even older than the building was. This school really has it out for us! There's an even newer building here, so why are they so eager to demolish ours first?

The people here are really out of their minds!

I turned my attention back to David. "Why did you end up here anyway?"

He looked at me, smiled, and then continued walking. I followed him.

"There was trouble in our section. Some of my classmates were expelled, and others were going to be suspended. To keep from escalating, I took the blame for everything," he explained. "I was the backer, so it wasn't a problem for me."

I nodded, accepting his answer.

We reached the back of the old building. Would you believe segregation was actually impressive. Bottles were separated by biodegradable from non-biodegradable.

So why can't they segregate their students like this?

I looked around and noticed two men organizing the garbage.

"Where should we dump these?" I asked David.

"Over there, I guess," he said, pointing to a pile of garbage in the corner.

We started walking toward it when one of the men suddenly stopped us. David and I both turned to look at him, and he approached us.

"Where did those come from?"

We exchanged glances before answering.

"From the gymnasium."

The man suddenly frowned and scratched his head.

"Sorry, but we can't accept those."

They won't accept garbage? What is this? Are there requirements?

"Huh?" My eyes widened at what he said. "Why won't you accept them?"

deserved to be dumped with garbage?

Sons of b\*\*\*\*!!!\*\*

"Kuya!" I yelled at the guy in front of us. "...as far as I know, no problems, but maybe now we do!"

He took a slight step back. I wasn't trying to intimidate him, I really wanted to punch something! This school was really beyond its limit. Just a little more patience, and we wouldn't have to leave since we were about to graduate, but they still chose to do that.

"Kuya, this is just trash. There's no way we're going to take it," David said. "Just let us leave it here."

He let go of everything he was holding and pulled out his wallet, taking out some cash, which I estimated to be around five thousand pesos.

"This should be enough to keep you quiet," he added while handing the money to the guy.

For some reason, I suddenly felt like becoming a garbage collector.

The guy quickly grabbed the money and gave us a wide, toothy grin showing dark gums and yellowing teeth. At least they were still in there, it looked like bacteria were eating away at his mouth.

"You can count on me, sir," the guy replied.

So annoying! So frustrating!

We reached the gymnasium quickly, probably because it was bigger than usual. As soon as we stepped inside, loud shouting echoed throughout the entire building.

I looked to see what was causing all the commotion. The girl was fighting with the students from Section D.

"You're doing this on purpose!" Eren yelled at the girl in the corner.

"We're going to use this gymnasium, so you all need to leave the guys."

"This place is huge! Even if there were more than 200 of you, you'd fit!" Mayo responded angrily.

What is it this time?! I muttered in irritation.

David and I quickly ran towards them and stepped in between them.

"What is this?! What is this?! What's happening now?!" I stood standing in the middle of them all.

One of the Section D students turned to me. "You all need to be using the gymnasium."

I looked around the entire building. The space was enormous. It was like a giant's living room.



I clapped my hands together. "Well, what do you know? being around you! So why don't

**you**

leave instead?"

The girl rolled her eyes at me. Should I poke her in the e

"Miss!" A guy, who I assumed was their president, called the gymnasium is meant for P.E. classes. Obviously, you're not in class. You're just using this place as a hangout because you don't have your own classroom."

Excuse me?! Now this guy was pissing me off. I was about to say something, but Yuri stepped in front of me.

"FYI, we're not here to hang out. The school manager said, crossing his arms, clearly trying to intimidate them. You should leave, it's you."

The Section D president laughed mockingly. "Don't act so stupid, Hanamitchi. The only reason you're talking like that is because you're here."

What did the King have to do with this?

I furrowed my brows while looking at the arrogant fool i

Section D immediately reacted, ready to step in, but Dav

"We can settle this peacefully," he said while standing be  
use the area you need in this gym, and let us stay here in

"That's not how this works," one of the Section D girls re  
comfortable with you being here."

"We're not comfortable with you being here either, but w  
Denzel said irritably.

"There is something you can do! Leave! Problem solved

The argument quickly escalated into more shouting and l  
looked like they were about to start throwing punches at

In the middle of all the chaos, I noticed Josh, Eren, Drew  
walking out of the gymnasium with their bags.

I immediately ran after them because I had a feeling I kn  
about to do.

"Where are you guys going?" I asked angrily.

Eren and Josh stopped walking, but Drew and Blaster co

"There's no point in arguing anymore. It's obvious they v  
school," Eren explained.

# Chapter 247: Fly

## Jay-jay's POV

Unbelibubbles—unbelievable, really!

Damn it! This school is really pushing my buttons. The I us out of the gymnasium. They really rubbed it in our face matter to this school.

The ending? Everyone just went home. These idiots also followed Drew, who had already left earlier.

"Jay," Yuri called me. "Did you call Percy?"

I nodded at him. "He said he's on his way."

He smiled at me apologetically. "Sorry, I really have son take care of. I wanted to take you home myself."

Earlier, he was supposed to give me a ride, but he sudden message. He was told to go home because his grandfather him. He asked me to call Percy instead to take me home.

He doesn't want me commuting.

Even though, honestly, I feel like someone could come a anytime. It feels like I can't go anywhere alone anymore.

I saw Ci-N and Felix approaching us. Good thing the Lit off his ridiculous outfit. It would've been embarrassing in school looking like that. People might think he's crazy.

"Are you going home?" he asked sadly.

"Yeah, you know my life's in danger."

I recently found out from Yuri that the entire Section E is threats against me. Even the King knows, but why does it doesn't care?

He lowered his head and swayed like a wilted vegetable. to do something but can't.

"I want to go out with you," he said, almost in tears.

I want that too.

"You can't, Ci-N. We need to make sure Jay-jay is safe right said.

"Yuri's right. Just come with us to take Jay home if you want

Ci sighed deeply. "Fine. What else can I do?"

His brows quickly furrowed when he saw Ci-N getting in with me.

"Long story, bro," Felix replied, but his eyes were still on

"Why is that shorty with you?!" Percy asked irritably.

"I'm coming along to take Jay home," Ci answered proudly.

Percy grimaced. "And then I'll have to take you home too too much?!" he said sarcastically.

And just like that, they started exchanging heated words both decided to just stare out the window instead.

Honestly, I don't want to go home yet. It's still too early, to do there. It wouldn't hurt to go out for a while, right? I told them.

"I don't feel like going home yet," I said, making Ci grin like a puppy.

"Let's go out!" he suggested.

Percy turned to look at me with confusion. "Are you sure

"Bro's right, it's dangerous for you to just wander around

"Then with you guys, right? You wouldn't leave me alone

"Where, though?" I asked.

"Hold on, let me think."

I heard Ci clear his throat beside me, so I turned to him.

"We're never leaving," he whispered. "...he said he's thin problem is, he doesn't have a brain—"

I quickly covered his mouth. If Percy heard him, they'd c fighting again. We'd probably be stuck here until nightfa them argue.

"I got it," Percy finally said, starting the car.

I looked at Felix, hoping he had some clue where we we seemed like he was just as clueless.

I let go of Ci's mouth and signaled him to keep quiet. Otl probably spout more nonsense.

We just waited to see where our crazy stepbrother was ta

I looked out the window, and when I noticed that the sur becoming unfamiliar, I nudged Percy.

"Where are we? Where are we going?"

"To a place where we can hang out without too many pe

A bunch of little kids were running around—probably for school. They were all in uniform, which made me think they were at school.

The car gradually slowed down and stopped. We all got out at the same time, and our reactions were practically identical.

"Seriously? Here?" I asked Percy irritably.

He was still smiling at me while nodding. Felix frowned. I felt like he wanted to smack Percy. I turned to look at the other kids, but he was the only one who looked happy about what he saw.

Of all places, he brought us to a playground.

"I like it here!" Ci said excitedly, even giving a thumbs-up.

"See? A place to hang out! Not too crowded!" Percy pointed around with both hands.

"You're an idiot!" I yelled at him. "...Are you serious right now?"

"You literally made us kids again!" Felix added in frustration.

No wonder we saw a bunch of kids earlier. I looked around and saw a large building not far away. The name was written in bold letters.

Hopes and Joy School of Learning

I just rolled my eyes and walked over to Ci to sit on the seesaw. The fool was having the time of his life, swinging as high as he could.

I hope he doesn't actually fly away.

I decided to swing too, though not as high as him.

"Jay! Look at me! I'm flying!" he shouted excitedly, pushing himself up.

I turned to look at the brothers when they sat on the seesaw. I had no choice but to play along too.

Wow. I'm really enjoying this!

And no, I'm not being sarcastic. Well, maybe a little.

"Oh, crap!" Felix suddenly shouted.

He was stuck in the air because Percy refused to lower himself. He jumped down, but every time he tried, Percy would suddenly jump back up to scare him.

"Bro! You jerk! Let me down!" Felix yelled again.

I just laughed at them. They were really acting like kids.

Meanwhile, the guy next to me was literally a kid, so there was no worry about there.



My heart almost stopped—I thought he was going to crash and landed smoothly, raising both hands like he was in a gymnastics competition.

Wow... what a show-off.

"That was sick!" Percy praised him.

Ci grinned widely and turned to me, raising his eyebrow so proud of himself.

"You're insane!" I yelled.

"That was cool, huh?" he bragged.

I rolled my eyes. "You think that was impressive? That was nothing."

I had done that before—even higher jumps. I pushed myself to go higher than he did.

"Hey, Jay! That's dangerous!" Percy warned.

I ignored him and kept going. When I felt like I was at the peak, I jumped.

Big mistake.

My foot got caught on the swing seat.

I slowly lifted myself from my own stupidity. My face ate the brunt of the fall, and they were both aching. When I looked at them they were right in front of me, barely holding back their laughter.

Damn it. This is so embarrassing! I was too cocky!

"Ow... that hurt..." I muttered, holding my forehead, nose, and cheek.

I could even taste a little dirt between my teeth. Good thing I didn't start bleeding.

"D-do you... w-want to go to the hospital?" Percy asked, trying to hold back from laughter.

I glared at him. He was so close to bursting out laughing.

"A-are you dizzy?" Felix asked, also trying so hard not to laugh.

I shot him a death glare too. My eyes were practically cutting through the air, letting them know just how pissed I was. Their faces were pale—flaring—they were desperate to hold it in.

No one spoke until Ci-N suddenly started singing.

"I believe I can fly... I believe I can touch the sky..."

You little—

That was it.

I just brushed off the dirt from my clothes and wiped my handkerchief. Even though, deep inside, I wanted to cry.

I wanted to cry because my face hurt like hell.

I wanted to cry because my dignity flew away along with

I wanted to cry because I was stuck with these three mor

Damn it. I just want to go home.

As I was sulking, I suddenly noticed someone approaching. Idiots were still laughing, so they hadn't seen him yet.

"Are you okay, Jay?" the guy asked.

Ci-N immediately looked up. "David!" he greeted.

David was still looking at me. "I saw what happened to you, alright?"

Great. Let's add more people to my humiliation.

I looked at him, confused. The same went for Felix, Perc

Because of one word—"saw."

How?! There was no one around earlier. That's why we f  
playing like this

What is he? An eagle? There's no way he could recognize me there.

"I saw you guys on the CCTV," he explained, pointing at the screen in front of us.

"...I ran over here as soon as I saw you fall."

What?! CCTV?!

Damn it! So now there's actual footage of my stupidity?!

"There's a CCTV at the playground?" Felix asked. "...Where?"

"For the safety of our students."

"Ours?" Ci asked.

"The school and playground belong to us," he explained, leaning in closer to me.

He took a handkerchief from his pocket and wiped my forehead.

"Your forehead and nose are red," he said.

I could really feel the stinging pain from my forehead. I didn't want to get a scratch on my face. It would be a shame to ruin my face.

I rolled my eyes at him. Now he's worried? When he was earlier? I suddenly felt so pitiful, like I was about to cry.

So dramatic—straight to the hospital?

"No need. I'm fine."

"Let's get it checked. Poor head of yours—there wasn't a begin with, and now it took a hit too," he teased.

I immediately walked up to him and pulled his hair.

"You idiot!"

"Ouch! My hair!" he whined before I let him go.

"You deserved that."

"There, she got to hit someone. She's fine now!" Ci teased, playing. I'll go to the slide."

The brat ran toward the slide, playing alone but still smiling.

David just shook his head at him. Percy and Felix returned, and this time, Felix got his revenge.

I turned to David, who was just watching me, as if observing.

"Thanks for worrying about me. I'm really okay. I promise."

Oh, go ahead and tease me more. I can feel it. I can really

"I was just copying Ci," I excused, looking down.

He shook his head, laughing. If he dares to watch a replica swear I'll curse him.

I looked at their school building. "I didn't know you guys had a school. You must be rich!"

"The school originally belonged to my uncle, but he sold it," he explained.

I nodded. "Then what were you doing earlier, watching the

"The security guard pointed you guys out to me. He said I was wearing the same uniform."

Wow, their security is on point.

"JAY-JAY!"

Ci-N's voice blasted like a stereo. He screamed so loud, it sounded like someone had gotten into an accident. Felix and Percy even stopped their seesaw, thinking something bad had happened.

"What the hell was that? You scream like a lunatic!" I snarled toward him.

Ci pointed somewhere far away, looking shocked.

"I-I saw! T-there's... something!"

"What is it?!" I snapped impatiently.

This brat loves suspense!

"I saw an ice cream vendor!" His eyes were wide as he a

I raised my fist, almost ready to punch his face. Seriously, I saw something shocking, but it was just an ice cream ven

"Talk to him, Jay. I might end up hitting him," Felix said

"Go ahead. We won't stop you," David added.

I noticed Percy stepping closer to Ci. His face was dead

I thought he was finally fed up and was about to hit the k spoke, and we all got confused.

"Tell me the truth," he said seriously.

Even Ci looked confused by him.

Looks like he's losing his mind again.

"Tell me." Percy repeated, as if he were angry. "...Tell me

"As painful as it is to say this..." he took a deep breath. "gone! He's far away now!"

Percy suddenly let out a dramatic wail, as if he had just lost someone. Except there were no tears.

"No! Nooooo... Why did this have to happen?!" he cried, clutching his knees.

Ci-N joined in on the act, pretending to cry.

"There's nothing we can do. He's already far away!" Ci-N wailed.

Percy wailed even louder. "Why didn't you tell me sooner?"

"I tried, but he was too fast."

The rest of us smacked our foreheads. Like I said before, it was never going to be together.

"You guys are so over the top!" Felix said in frustration.

"Stop the drama. The ice cream vendor is right there," David said, just as we heard the ice cream truck's music.

It was like a switch flipped in their heads. Their immediate faces serious. The moment they saw the vendor, they stopped. Percy almost tripped.



Felix immediately frowned. "With Jay-Jay, you're so quiet you to—"

He didn't get to finish his sentence when he saw me look smiled and walked over to Percy.

What did he mean by that? Does he also have contact with Just wow.

I turned to David and glared at him. "Hey! You! Do you that annoying snake too?!"

He suddenly looked away. "Well... he called me once, but again."

Oh, fantastic. Just fantastic.

# Chapter 248: Dora vs Dieg

## Jay-jay's POV

"Here's the payment," David said as he handed the money vendor.

The man thanked him before leaving. When he turned to suddenly froze.

Melt under my gaze, you idiot!

"W-what?" he asked.

"I'm annoyed..." I said calmly as I grabbed the ice cream "...thanks for this."

I turned my back on him and walked towards the place where my face had smacked the ground. So frustrating!

The one time I tried to show off, and that happened. They have my moment just this once.

I sat back down on the swing and started eating my ice cream. I did I realize that David had followed me.

"So what?! I only talked to him once too, and he didn't even talk to me!" I complained.

That damn King!

He said it would only be a month, but why does it feel like a year has passed when it's only been a few weeks? When that idiot says I swear, I'll kick him in the face.

"He asked about you through me," David replied, making me feel like a fool.

And just my luck—I had my tongue out licking my ice cream cone at that moment.

"He asked about me through you? Seriously?"

He nodded. "He also threatened me."

Threatened?!

"About what?"

"He told me not to make a move on you... or else he'd punish my body."

Oh wow. That bastard really never changes. Instead of coming at me directly, he threatened David? The same David who's been my friend since we were kids—the thing that HE should be doing?

"Do you think he's coming back?" I asked David without

"It depends," he answered.

I frowned and turned to him. "What do you mean, 'it dep

He looked at me seriously. "It depends if there's still some  
return to."

I met his gaze. I knew exactly what he meant. He was talking  
whether I would still be here waiting for that bastard.

I hesitated. Was there really something left for him to come  
Problems were piling up, and now someone was after me  
it was too late when he finally returned?

"I don't know," I replied, looking away.

I went back to eating my ice cream, which was slowly melting.  
patience was melting too—melting from all the frustration  
was causing me.

Damn him!

That bastard! When he comes back, if I'm still alive and  
him out until he drowns in insults. Damn idiot!

After finishing my ice cream, I tried searching for a tissue

"What time do you think they'll be done?" he asked while Ci.

I also turned to look and immediately frowned when I noticed them arguing. Just a moment ago, they were quiet—they must have been

I quickly stood up and approached them.

"Dora is better! She can go anywhere!" Ci said angrily.

"Diego is better! He saves animals like you!" Percy retorted.

I winced and looked for Felix. I spotted him nearby, looking at the argument. He was permanently stuck in an expression of frustration.

It was clear he wasn't amused and was about to slap someone.

I turned my attention back to the two idiots arguing.

"Stop interfering! Diego can't even leave the forest!"

"At least Diego doesn't sneak out without telling his parents!"

"All Diego ever deals with are animals!"

"Dora looks like an animal! And she still uses a map—how is that possible now!"

"Hello?!" Ci mimicked Percy. "That's called survival training!"

"And you're still arguing? Neither of those shows are good better!" I snapped in annoyance.

Yep... good job, Jay. You joined the argument.

The shows they were talking about were terrible. They were terrible. God, I think I was still in grade school when those aired.

"Wow, Jay, what a fantastic cartoon you just mentioned," I said sarcastically.

"That show's ugly too!" Percy yelled. "Daddeh!" George added, mimicking Peppa's accent.

I winced. That accent really didn't suit him. It sounded awkward.

"Seriously?!" David asked, exasperated. "You're really a fan of those shows?" He shook his head. "...so childish."

Ci glared at him. "And what do you watch?"

"Care Bear." He answered without hesitation.

We all burst out laughing at the same time. I almost collapsed from weakness. Even Percy and Ci-N were clutching their sides. Felix just shook his head.

He called us childish, yet he's just the same.

**5 from GagongBaliw.**

**1 from an unknown number.**

Suddenly, a wave of anxiety hit me because of that unknown fingers moved on their own to open the message.

**From: +639**

\*\*\*\*\*

Message:

*keep playing, I'm watching you.*

My hands trembled, and my heart started racing. I didn't around, fearing that I might actually see him here.

I thought I was safe when I was with my friends, but it so the case. I told myself not to be scared anymore, but danger threats still get to me.

"Jay..." Percy called out to me. "...is something wrong?"

I quickly shook my head. "It's Aries... He's asking me to

David checked his watch. "I should head back too. Take home." He said before walking back to his school building

"Let's go home. We might get home late," he said before  
Hahahahaha.

We all followed him. At that moment, I didn't look anywhere, I walked straight ahead, focusing only on Percy's back.

He stopped in front of his car. Ci and the others were still outside as he opened the door, I quickly got inside, making them in confusion.

"Are you in a rush to go home?" Felix asked.

I forced a smile. "A little. Aries is getting mad."

Once everyone was inside, Percy started the engine. Ci kept requesting to go back, but I couldn't focus on anything but driving anymore.

he was the first to be dropped off at his condo. Finally, that uneasy feeling inside me wouldn't go away.

Relax, Jay.

We arrived at my house, and I quickly said my goodbyes, rushing inside. I almost tripped in my haste.

"JAY-JAY!"



"What happened to your face? Why is your forehead and scratch?" He asked in quick succession while stepping cl

He grabbed my chin and tilted my face up to get a better me carefully.

How am I supposed to tell him that I faceplanted on the

He let go of my chin and took my hand. "Come on." He

He dragged me to the kitchen. My face was full of confu used to how he was acting.

When we got there, he made me sit on one of the stools l through the drawers. Then, he went to the fridge and gra

He walked back to me with an ice bag in his hand, his br

"Where the hell were you?" He asked irritably before pre against my forehead.

I held onto the ice bag so he would let go. He still looked

Sorry! Sometimes stupidity is just inevitable.

"I was showing off... but I ended up face-planting," I exp

One of his eyebrows raised. "Don't tell me... you landed

I quickly glared at him and put the ice bag down. This guy  
Couldn't he just say it was an accident instead?!

Yes! It was an accident!

I wanted to watch him laugh and then smack his face right  
that, I'd probably get hit back even worse.

He kept laughing for a few minutes before getting himself  
He shook his head as he walked back toward me.

"So, did you learn something from your own stupidity?"  
crossed.

I nodded. "Never give in to a kid's arrogance."

He looked at me in confusion. "A kid?"

"Ci-N. he acted like an acrobat on the swing, so I copied

Little by little, his smile faded. He looked down for a moment  
lowering his arms and standing up straight.

"So, you were with him. Let me guess—you were with F

I looked away. I knew he was upset with Percy, but I hoped  
show that he wasn't okay with me being with him.

"Are you really going to force me to avoid him?" I could

"You two will never reconcile?" I asked seriously.

He took the ice bag from my hand and pressed it against himself. He gave me a weak smile.

"Probably not. It's hard to rebuild something that's already broken."

But I could feel the regret in his voice. I could sense that he wanted to go back to how things used to be. I could feel it in his sad eyes as he stared at his hand holding the ice bag.

If only I could do something for him.

"Where did you guys go earlier? You weren't in the auditorium?" He changed the topic.

I grimaced. It seemed like he didn't know that we were kicked out of the gym earlier. I didn't want to make things worse.

"We were sent home early. Some lectures will just be given online." I smiled.

He looked unsure whether to believe me or not. In the end, he let it off.

When the ice in the bag melted, he threw it away and put it in the drawer. He also washed his hands.

"Can I see you again?" I asked.

It was GagongBaliw. I wanted to tell him, but he might j  
thing Yuri did.

He might also tell me to stop talking to that idiot. That's  
want Yuri to know.

I smiled at him. "A friend. I just needed to pass on a mes

He nodded, accepting my answer. "How about Keifer? I  
contact with him?"

I looked down before shaking my head. "I don't have his

And that was the painful truth.

I didn't hear him say anything, so I looked at him. He wa  
he was trying to figure something out.

"Why?" I asked, and he quickly shook his head.

"I was just asking," he replied and motioned for me to go

I just shrugged and ran to my room. I quickly changed cl  
out right away. Instead, I grabbed my phone and checked  
most of which were from Aries.

But that wasn't the first one I checked. I went straight to  
text.

? This guy really had something wrong with his head.

I replied to him.

**To: GagongBaliw**

**Message:**

*Did you pass my message to Keifer?*

I waited for his reply. It didn't take long before he respor

**From: GagongBaliw**

**Message:**

*Yes.*

So short! Seriously?! Couldn't he at least tell me Keifer's

**To: GagongBaliw**

**Message:**

*What did he say?*

My eyes were glued to my phone screen. I was practicall  
with it. Luckily, his reply didn't take long.

was the one saying it and not Keifer?

Or maybe... he really was the King of Snakes? I really needed a way to confirm if my suspicion was correct.

Maybe I should ask for help. From Yuri, Percy, or Aries. I was sure they could help me.

I didn't reply to that idiot. Instead, I threw my phone onto my room. I couldn't keep my snack waiting.

"...stop bothering her."

That was Aries' voice. I saw him walking out of the house.

I planned on ignoring him, but then I heard him mention

Curiosity got the best of me, and I followed him, stopping

"It would be best if you started a new life there."

I frowned. Who was he telling to start a life somewhere else?

"Enough... Just stop. I'm asking you, please stop bothering

Wait a minute... Why did I feel like—

"Please, Keifer."

I kept hitting his hand, forcing him to let go of the phone succeeded and took the chance to run away. I ran straight locked the door.

I checked Aries' phone to see if Keifer was still on the line pressed it against my ear.

"Keifer! Please say something!" I pleaded.

But I heard nothing from his side. My body started to we the floor as tears started falling.

"I-I don't understand. Why won't you talk to me? W-why but not me? Why, Keifer?!" I took a deep breath. "Keifer

Still, there was no response from him. Maybe he really d me. Maybe... he didn't care anymore.

I forced myself not to sob out loud. I didn't want him to l was struggling. How much I was hurting.

I debated whether I should end the call. There was no po going to say anything. There was nothing I could do if h me.

My hands trembled. I was about to pull the phone away : finally heard something. Words I had never heard from h since I met him.

# Chapter 249: What now

## Jay-jay's POV

I didn't sleep well. My eyes are once again accompanied feel like I'm not myself. I've been staring blankly at the r while brushing my teeth. My teeth might be worn out alr

I heard a knock on my bedroom door, followed by a sho "We're going to be late!" It was Aries. I let out a deep sigh washed my toothbrush, and then left the bathroom. I wen door and opened it.

His eyebrows quickly furrowed when he saw that I hadn "What's that?! What time is it?!" he said irritably.

I looked at him boredly. "I don't know. Don't you have a you—OUCH!"

I almost fell to the floor from the force of his flick on my hands were holding my head as tears welled up in my ey like he doesn't know his own strength!

"Ouch! That really hurt!" I said to him irritably.

"Can you stop that already?!" he replied angrily. "You'



"Ugh! Just go ahead! I'll just ask the Ulupong to pick me

"What Ulupong?" he asked, confused.

"My classmates."

He seemed hesitant to agree with what I said. But if he d he'd really be late. They can't afford to be late because th section.

"Fine. It's up to you. But text me, okay? And don't leave someone picks you up," he sternly reminded me while p

"Okay, okay! Just go!"

He turned his back on me, so I closed the door. I went ba and continued my ritual—I mean, my shower.

To be honest, I had no intention of asking any of the Ulu up. I didn't want to involve them in my being late.

As for Sato's threat, I'll just deal with it. I really need to f Nothing will happen to me if I let him intimidate me. I d him; maybe he's all talk.

I was soaking wet, and if my fingers hadn't pruned, I wo to get out from under the shower.

As for Sato's threat, I'll just deal with it. I really need to f

I quickly typed a reply.

To: Pres. Yuri

Message: Still at home. I'm going to be late.

From: Pres. Yuri

Message: You're already late. I'll pick you up.

He might already be at school since he's asking. It would be weird if he came back here just to pick me up.

To: Pres. Yuri

Message: Don't bother. I'm leaving the house now. See you later.

I didn't wait for his reply. I arranged the things I needed and then I checked if I had forgotten anything. Once I was sure everything was ready, I left.

I said goodbye to one of the maids. When I went out the taxi was already approaching. It was a bit strange because not many taxis were in this area.

The people here are wealthy. They have cars!

But even so, I still hailed it. Maybe it just dropped off a passenger. The taxi stopped in front of me.

I immediately tried to open the door, but it was too late. ' quickly.

"W-who are you?! What do you want from me?!" I shout on the car window.

Neither of them responded or looked at me. Both were w black shirts or jackets. I took the opportunity to grab my a number.

One of them seemed to notice me. The one sitting next to at me and tried to reach for my cellphone. I used my foot getting closer.

"Give that to me!" he shouted.

"No! Stay away from me!"

I kept kicking him to keep him from reaching me.

I looked at my cellphone and noticed that Yuri was callin answered.

"YURI!" I shouted while keeping the phone away.

"...HELP....ME....HELP ME! SOMEONE....KIDNAPPE

"I SAID GIVE IT TO ME!!" the man shouted as he grab

It hurt my arm, but I tightened my grip as much as I could.

"B-bro! She's gonna k-kill me!" he struggled to say.

The driver tried to stop me, but he couldn't concentrate because of my driving.

"Let go of my partner!" he said, trying to pry my arm loose.

He dug his nails into my skin, making me scream, but I tightened my grip even more.

"You damn woman!" the driver shouted, keeping his eyes on me.

"You damn man!" I shot back.

As if you're the only one who knows how to curse!

His nails dug deeper. The pain was so intense that my grip slipped. I started kicking his side repeatedly. I didn't care if he was hurt.

The car swerved slightly because of what I did. I kept doing it until the car started to sway. The horns of the cars behind us blared continuously.

"You're crazy!" he shouted at me again.

"Argh! You're so annoying!" I shouted back.

I kept kicking when suddenly, our car was hit from behind.

I looked at the two of them. The driver was busy avoidin while the other guy was coughing and catching his breat

"Where are you taking me?!" I angrily asked.

Neither of them answered until we were hit from behind forward from the impact. I looked back and saw a famili

"YURI!" I shouted.

I knew he couldn't hear me, but I still hoped. He looked i and his expression quickly turned to concern. He signale as if telling me to move to the other side.

I did as he said, even though I was full of confusion. He again. I almost screamed from the force.

I was scared of getting into an accident, but if this was th ready to end up in the hospital again.

But I was even more alarmed when the taxi I was in sudc hit Yuri's car. I panicked and looked at him, but he didn't

This can't go on. I need to help!!

I turned to the driver and started kicking him again.

"Hey! Stop that!" his companion shouted, trying to stop

The driver and his companion were gone. I was stunned, comprehend what had just happened. That was close!

The door beside me opened, so I turned. I saw Yuri, full

"Jay! Are you okay?" he asked worriedly.

I instinctively hugged him. My whole body was trembling in sweat.

"I-I almost didn't make it!"

"Ssshhhh... It's okay now. I'm here," he whispered to me

"Y-Yuri..." I was on the verge of tears.

He hugged me back tightly, as if he was afraid to let me my mind to process everything that had just happened.

Yuri let go of the hug and held my face with both hands, at him.

"Are you hurt? Did they do anything to you? How are you asked rapidly.

I shook my head. "N-nothing hurts."

I looked around the taxi. There was a wallet on the drive and handed it to Yuri.

I followed, but after just one step, my knees gave out. I hadn't caught me immediately.

He helped me until we reached his car. He helped me in phone and signaling that he needed to make a call.

I just nodded at him. I stared at the taxi in front of us. It was that even public vehicles like that could be used to kidnap.

I had no proof, but I had a gut feeling that Sato was behind it. Would he want to harm me?

This is so frustrating!!

I can't just be scared. I need to fight back against that idiot Japanese guy! I'll send you back to Japan with just one kick.

My thoughts were interrupted when I heard the car door already gotten in without me noticing.

"I called the police to report what happened. They'll need more information," he explained. "...are you going to tell them that someone helped you?"

I shook my head. "It'll only make things worse. Let's just treat it as a simple robbery case."

He nodded. Soon after, the police arrived. We told them what happened.

Bad luck! Of all times, I didn't ride with Aries today!

Yuri started the car. "I'll take you to the hospital to—"

"To school," I cut him off. "...I wasn't hurt earlier. I'm fine."

He didn't speak for a long time, as if he was thinking about it.

"I understand, but please tell me if you feel something."

I nodded without looking at him. I was still annoyed by the kidnapping incident. I don't think I can take a taxi again.

I remained silent the entire ride until we arrived at school. When the car stopped, I stepped out.

Where was my room again?

I was about to ask Yuri, but I decided to just follow him. He went to the other side of the main building, heading toward... the gymnasium.

Yesterday, it was the gymnasium, now it's the auditorium. I was kicked out of here too. That would be embarrassing!

Upon entering, I saw the Snakes sitting in a corner on the stage. The teacher in front of them. Their attention immediately shifted to me as I approached.

"Sorry you're late," Yuri said to the teacher.



I just gave a simple nod in response. I wasn't in the mood. I was still upset about what had happened earlier. If I had my aunt would have questioned me. Then it would get to my king of overthinking.

He'd figure out I was lying. He might even find out about through his connections.

What connection is he using anyway? Smart or Globe?

The class ended with me just staring blankly ahead, my eyes closed. As soon as the teacher left, the idiots immediately turned to me.

"Why were you late?" Mayo asked teasingly, being the class clown.

His smug grin irritated me instantly. I shot him an annoyed look.

"None of your business!" I snapped.

Mayo's face turned sour. "What's your problem? I was just asking."

"The way you asked, why? Are we okay now?"

He suddenly stood up and pointed a finger at me. "There it is in my face! That's what you're good at!"

I shot up as well, meeting his angry glare. "So what if I did? It's not my fault."

"Your problem is you act like you're so important!" he said to my face.

Something snapped in my head. My fist moved on its own and landed on his face. By the time I realized what I had done, it was too late.

Mayo dropped to the ground, and his fellow Snakes immediately surrounded him.

"Jay!" Yuri called out. "...why did you do that?!"

No reason. Just felt like it.

I didn't like the way he asked me that. Like everything was my fault.

"He threw it in my face!" I defended myself.

"So what?! You already know how he is. Why did you have to react like that?"

Oh, great! So now it's

*my*

fault?!

I didn't say another word. Frustrated, I kicked my bag against the auditorium. I hadn't gotten far when I felt someone grab my arm.

I yanked my arm away and turned around with a glare. I

*angry*

.

Angry about what happened in the taxi earlier, and now  
it. Yeah, this helped

*a lot*

, shit!

"You know what, Kit? I have a grudge against you guys  
me. You all ganged up on me, but what hurt me the most  
said. It was like he didn't even realize how much he hurt

He lowered his head for a moment. "I'm really sorry, Jay  
closer, but I stepped back. "...Believe me, we really do re

I shook my head. "But that's not what I see from the othe

"What do I have to do for you to give us a chance?"

I looked away, biting my lower lip. I was still angry, and  
heavy.

"I don't know... Maybe if you admit you're gay to them, I

*might*

didn't really mean it like that.

I grabbed some tissue from the box near the mirror, wiped quickly headed back to the auditorium.

When I got there, I froze at the sight of Kit standing in front of me, if making an announcement.

"Jay-jay! Hurry! Kit's about to make an announcement!" with a grin.

Oh, shit!

I rushed toward Kit to stop him. This isn't how I meant for this to go to everyone.

I did my best, but it seemed like I was too late. In an instant, I saw mixed reactions.

"This is for real... I'm gay."

# Chapter 250: Saving friend

## Jay-jay's POV

"This is for real.... I'm gay."

No one moved. Ci's smile faded, and some of them straightened their postures. Some furrowed their brows, while others seemed to react or not.

He's really serious about what I said.

"Ahahaha..." I forced a laugh, even though it was obviously such a joker, Kit."

I approached him and grabbed his arm, intending to pull the rest of the Ulupong.

"Let's talk." I whispered to him while pulling, but he didn't.

He looked at me as if saying everything was fine. I felt like I was crazy because of what he was doing.

"Kit!" Mayo called angrily, standing behind the others. "What are you saying?!"

"Cut it out, Kit. Your joke isn't funny." Rory said.

Shit! I had a bad feeling about this.

I tapped Kit's arm and looked at our confused classmates

"We're just messing around. Don't believe—."

"No!" He removed my hand. "I said it's for real." He cut

He looked at me and smiled. I shook my head, signaling continue. This wasn't the right time for him to come out

"It's okay, Jay. I'm tired of hiding."

He faced Mayo's group. Eren stood up from his seat, looking pleading with him.

"I've been hiding this for a very long time. I knew I'm different from you." He took a deep breath. "...I'm different because I'm the same sex."

"Shit." Calix said, standing up. "...you can't be serious."

I was about to speak up to stop them from thinking the way I did. They stood up one after another, each making their own comment.

"Bro! We used to go to the restroom together." Edrix said.

Eman said calmly.

"What's the deal?! Are you really gay?!" Rory asked, un-

"Can everyone just quiet down—." David didn't get to finish saying because Drew suddenly shouted.

"YOU'RE DISGUSTING!"

His voice echoed throughout the auditorium, causing everyone to look at him. His brows were furrowed, and he looked angry by Kit.

Before any of us could speak up to respond, a powerful jolt hit my face. He fell to the floor and was quickly helped up by David and Drew who were near him.

It looked like things were about to get out of hand!!

"What's your problem?! Why did you hit him?!" Denzel immediately addressing Mayo, who had silenced Drew.

Eren and Josh immediately approached him to hold him back so that Mayo was about to start another fight.

"His mouth is filthy!" Mayo replied, pointing at Drew.

I took the opportunity to talk to Kit. I grabbed his shoulder and

"Jay, I'm tired. I don't care if others judge me." He said a

Even though he said there were other reasons, I still felt  
If only I had thought before speaking. If only I hadn't let  
over!

I hugged him tightly. "No matter what happens, I'm here

I heard him laugh softly. "Does that mean you've forgive

"You're an idiot." I replied, smiling even though I felt lik

I let go of the hug and looked at him. His sad eyes from  
free of burdens. Maybe he really couldn't keep hiding the  
he was.

"SON OF A B\*TCH!" Someone shouted.

When we looked to see where it came from, Mayo and I  
each other's throats. If the other Ulupong hadn't stepped  
started throwing punches.

"I won't back down from you! You're an a\*\*hole!" Mayo

"Enough!"

"Stop it!"

"Will let 1000 on Mayo!"



Suddenly, Drew burst into loud laughter, confusing all of us by mocking.

"I almost forgot. You're into guys too, huh?" Drew said with a smug expression.

Mayo visibly froze, and for a moment, he tried to reach for his friend. Josh held him back tightly.

"Your ex-girlfriend told me you left her for a guy." Drew continued, laughing even louder. "...it was Kit!"

Shit! Stop it already!

"Enough, Drew!" Felix shouted at him.

But Drew seemed unwilling to back down. It was like he was deliberately provoking Mayo, testing his patience.

"What?! Can't respond?! Because it's true—."

Everything happened so fast. It seemed like Eren intended to protect Mayo. In just two steps, Mayo reached Drew and landed a punch on his head.

Chaos erupted. I covered my mouth in shock. Ci-N, who was sitting next to me earlier, stood up and tried to intervene. Kit also approached us.

"Stop it! Stop it!"

Damn it!

The slap was so hard that I immediately fell to the floor.

"You're an a\*\*hole, Mayo!" I heard Kit shout.

I held my cheek, which was probably numb by now. I fe arm to help me up. I looked and saw Yuri and Kit.

"Are you okay?" Yuri asked with concern.

"You're such a jerk! Why did you hit Jay-jay?" Ci-N ask

I looked at Mayo, who was standing while being held ba Ulupong. I couldn't understand why he had to hurt me.

"You b\*stard! I wasn't even doing anything to you!" I sa up.

My cheek felt uneven!

"I want to smash your face with my fists, but you're still me. "...are you really this angry at us that you want to ru sake of that damn forgiveness?!"

"Don't blame Jay for your stupidity!" Felix said angrily.

Mayo was still looking at me, clearly wanting to hurt me

"You want to know how angry I am at you?" I said calmly to them before turning back to Mayo.

"Have you ever been alone? At school? At home?" He didn't answer.  
"...because I have. My whole life, I've been alone. Mayo, you know that." I took a deep breath, feeling a lump in my throat. "Then you came along, only to hurt me. And how much did it HURT SO MUCH! So much that I almost wished I could leave this world."

I couldn't hold back my tears anymore. I didn't want to cry, but I couldn't help it. My voice was already breaking. I kept my eyes on the ground as he wanted to look away.

"It hurt so much that I was furious at you! I was so angry that I wanted to hit back at you so you could feel what I felt!" I bit my lower lip. "Because I didn't want to become like you."

I looked down to wipe my tears. I took another deep breath, trying to control myself. I was so tired of them again.

"You're angry because Kit is gay? You should be angry at him, not at me. You're no different from him!" I turned back to Mayo, looking down. "...because it's not what real men do to gay people."

"Jay..." I heard Yuri call from behind me.

"Now, tell me, Mayo. Don't I have the right to throw back at you what you've thrown at me?"

"Jay..." Kit called me. "...maybe it's better if you rest for explaining things to the other teachers."

"No." David interjected. "...It's better if all of us take a rest Alvin."

"I agree with David." Yuri said.

The two nodded, and David walked away. I looked at them as they were now talking among themselves.

I noticed Ci-N, who seemed deep in thought. He was away and looked worried. I didn't like seeing him like that, as if I felt like he was caught off guard and didn't understand what happened.

"Yuri... Can you check on Ci-N first? Something seems off," I asked.

He smiled at me before approaching Ci-N. I turned to Kit.

"Let's talk." I said to him.

We walked away from the Ulupong. At one point, I held my head, as the pain still hadn't gone away. Damn it!! I wanted to hit Ma.

Kit seemed to notice what I was doing. He touched my forehead, which startled me. I almost jumped because of it.

Damn this guy! He could totally pass as a K-pop idol with his looks but he likes men?! I've been outshined!

"I'm the one apologizing for what Mayo did. I didn't know I was of hurting a woman."

"Anyone is capable of that," I replied, taking a deep breath.

I wiped my nose because I could feel the snot coming. I stood in front of them again. I hate doing that. Of course, my face was embarrassing right now.

"What's your plan now? Looks like those jerks don't like me," I asked, concerned.

He smiled at me. "Sometimes, the people closest to you are the ones to judge you the most."

I smiled back. "But not me."

He put an arm around my shoulder, and I hugged him back a little when he pulled away slightly. I just hope he doesn't tell the women like some others.

I felt his hand gently patting my back. "O-okay, that's enough. Go now. If Keifer finds out about this, I'll be dead meat."

Oh, great! He just had to mention that guy!

"Didn't I tell you to text me?!" he said, clearly annoyed.

My mouth just formed an "O." I had forgotten about that happened earlier.

Oh, and I couldn't tell him about it either.

"I forgot. Sowrey," I said, glancing at what he was holding.

It was a styrofoam food container, the kind used for packing.

It looked like he bought it from the school cafeteria.

"Is that for me?" I asked, pointing at the container.

"No," he replied quickly. "...Someone just asked me to hold it."

Oh... I really thought it was for me!

I noticed him staring at me for a long time, as if he was trying to figure something out.

I started to feel uncomfortable, so I tried to look away.

"Did you cry?"

Oh no! I looked at Kit, but his face remained expressionless.

I couldn't even ask for help!

My eyes widened at what he said. Oh no! Aries might get mad at him.

Just as I expected, Aries immediately shot him a sharp glare ready to throw a punch.

"Harrington, right?" Aries asked.

Kit nodded.

"Next time, be more careful so you don't hit people," Aries stepped closer.

"...And one more time I catch you hugging my sister, I will break your bones."

I quickly moved between them and pushed Aries away from them.

"What is wrong with you?! What are you even saying?!"

He turned his glare to me. "I'm just warning your classmate."

I pushed him again. "Just go away! You're threatening people."

He rolled his eyes, which annoyed me even more. "It's not a warning."

I rolled my eyes back. "That was a threat!"

"Thank you!! Mwah! Mwah! Tsup! Tsup!"

His face immediately twisted in disgust. "Yuck! Get away from me!"

I pouted. This guy! I was just being affectionate, and now he's grossed out.

He really deserves a smack sometimes. I turned back to him, still smiling at me.

"You and your brother are okay now?"

I nodded. "Yeah. Good thing he finally talked to me."

For a moment, silence surrounded us. A terrifying silence. The silence that what happened earlier started creeping back into my mind.

What now? What's going to happen to him now?

"Everything will be okay, right?" he asked.

I wanted to say yes, but that's not how I felt.

I lowered my head and softly answered, "I hope so..."



# Chapter 251: Human

## Jay-jay's POV

Starting your morning with a sermon—what a way to start. My brother must be in the mood— In the mood to lecture.

"You never complete your school day! You always leave of that, you're always late!" He scolded me while we were at the table.

I kept my head down while eating my rice, occasionally looking up at the man who was sitting across from me. But he wouldn't even look at me, he would rather stare at his hotdog!

"What's even going on in your school?! They took away the school and now they can't even give you proper classes!"

Why was he scolding me about this? He could just go to the school if he wanted to know what was happening.

"Enough with the sermon. Eat your food," Aunt Gema said.

She was in a good mood today. My brother should be too. But when he saw me, he suddenly got irritated.

No wonder he looks extra handsome today. Just as long as I start steaming from anger.

"Ma, you're really not coming?" My brother asked before.

"No. You can handle it," she replied.

"Alright, I'll call right away to give you an update."

Aunt Gema didn't say anything else. She just patted my head and was heading back to the kitchen.

I turned back to Aries just as he suddenly stood up.

"I'm taking a shower. Hurry up," he said before leaving.

He left me at the table with my brother. He left me? He left me! I was doomed!

I hurried to finish my food because I already knew what

"Hey, Jay-jay, I'm telling you! You're about to graduate! You're getting yourself into trouble!" My brother warned me.

I was eating so fast it was like I was in a race. At this rate, I was just swallow everything whole.

"Are you even listen—?"

I went straight to the bathroom to shower. This time, I won't get left behind again—yesterday was bad enough.

Yuri called me last night. He found out who those damn bastards tried to take me. They were R. Sato's men. But what I did was that they didn't seem serious about kidnapping me.

Usually, people who try to take me put me to sleep first—it happened multiple times, and it's always the same. But this time they didn't even bother. It was like they were just out for a joyride. It was a whole different level of crazy.

After showering, I got dressed quickly. I glanced at the window and saw that it was still early, so I sat at the edge of my bed and checked my phone.

I had a message from CrazyIdiot and another one from Yuri.

I read the one from the President of the Shunga Lovers Club first, because it was important.

**From: Pres.Yuri**

*Message: Do you want me to pick you up?*

I pouted. I was riding with Horoscope. I quickly typed a reply.

**To: Pres.Yuri**

Yes, I want you to pick me up.

**From: CrazyIdiot**

*Message: Almost*

What the hell? What does "almost" mean? Was this guy this message? People these days have the weirdest hobb

What are they even on?

I didn't bother replying to the fool. I might catch his craz  
stuffed my phone into my bag.

While putting on my shoes, I heard a knock on my door,  
voice.

"Hurry up, Jay! I'll be waiting outside!" Aries called.

He holds my fate in his hands.

"Got it!" I replied.

I sped up my movements—if I took too long, my brother  
with anger.

Horoscope has a nasty temper. I don't want my day ruine  
starts.

After fixing myself up, I grabbed my bag and stepped ou  
into my brother, who was glaring at me.

"You're so slow," he said before getting into his car.

I pouted. Slow? I already moved as fast as I could! I even he want me to do? Turn into The Flash just to prove I'm

I got into the car too.

He stayed quiet while driving. I glanced outside occasionally cars behind us.

I needed to stay alert. Those damn Sato guys might strike

I wonder if "Swiper, no swiping" would work on them?

I noticed the car slowing down until we turned into a suburban area that was unfamiliar to me, and I had no idea who lived here. The question was answered when I saw a woman in the distance. She was wearing an HVIS uniform. Her long hair was blowing in the wind, and her skin was glowing. And of course, her angelic face. But her eyes were definitely devilish.

I looked at Aries. He was serious, and it seemed like he had a problem with this woman. I wasn't sure if we had made a mistake as I knew, we weren't on good terms anymore.

The car stopped in front of her. In front of Ella. It looked like they were picking this woman up. She smiled and walked up to my car door.

"What?"

I stared at him, hoping he would get what I meant—I sh here, and Ella should be in the back. But he really didn't at us and looked out the window.

"Please, Jay," Ella said, though it was clear she wasn't re

I felt like a bull who had air blown into its nose. This wo else!

I stormed out of the car and moved to the backseat. I aln by slamming it shut.

My eyes almost popped out from rolling them so hard. T were already starting to boil my blood.

Ugh! I want to slap her. Just once.

Okay, fine. She's pretty. But I was so mad I didn't even n accidentally played on my phone.

"The hardest thing is being a fool."

Oh crap!

Was this song aimed at me? It felt like the anthem of our

I ignored the type of them in front. I let them talk. I didn't

"Jay." Someone called me, tapping my elbow.

I turned around to see Yuri smiling at me.

"Oh yeah, I forgot you were waiting for me," I said, scratching my head.

"See... when someone isn't important to you, you quickly forget them."

I blinked a few times, confused, while looking at him.

"What are you fighting for?"

"My love for you," he replied, flashing a wide grin.

I chuckled at him but with a teasing tone.

"Ha, ha. Did you skip breakfast?" I asked, smiling mischievously.

He smiled back like a little kid. "I didn't."

He must be crazy from hunger.

We both laughed and shook our heads. We walked together towards the auditorium. As we got closer, I couldn't help but feel nervous. Why! I just hoped nothing would go wrong like yesterday.

When we entered, it was different from what I expected. It was quiet, almost like a church mass because of how serious everyone was.

Kit elbowed him to stop him.

"I'm not talking to you," I replied.

Kit turned to face me and smiled. "I stepped away from them and it wouldn't be any trouble."

I pointed at Mayo. "What about him?"

"he's just following me," Kit answered.

I lowered my head. he really had to adjust for these narrow streets.

"Honestly, you shouldn't be the one adjusting for them. They're the ones adjusting for you."

I heard Mayo's insulting laugh. "As if they're gonna do that."

My eyebrows finally met in frustration. "Why are you bothering me by talking to you?"

he glared at me. "Just get out of here."

"I don't want to!" I sat beside Kit. "I'll sit here."

Suddenly, Kit looked at the "Ulupongs," and I glanced at them. They were all staring at us, and some, like Drew, were glaring.

What I didn't understand was why Eren and Josh—who were



Good thing the annoying King wasn't here yet.

We finished our class with Sir Alvin. I understood a bit, I was going to say what because it's better kept to myself—it n

While I was fixing my bag, which only had a few notebooks, people calling me.

"Jay..." Rory called. "...sit here. Not there."

I rolled my eyes. "I want to sit here."

"Don't sit there," Denzel said irritably.

"Don't mind me."

"Stop being so stubborn! Sit here!" Edrix snapped.

"I said I want to sit here."

"Jay-jay..." Kit called me. "...maybe you should sit with

"I don't want to! I told you, I'll sit beside you no matter v

"Yeah... But not literally."

"Sit here, Jay-jay," Drew said. "...you might catch 'gayne

Oh, come on.

I just grabbed my hair in frustration. It's so hard when you're ready to fight each other like that.

What else can I expect from "Ulupongs"?

I let out a deep sigh. We waited for a few minutes before finally separated.

Drew had new bruises and scratches, adding to his old ones that Mayo wanted to knock him out because of his anger.

"Okay now? Done? Did your mouths kiss each other's friends now?" I said sarcastically.

"He's the one at fault!" Mayo pointed at Drew.

"You're just mad because it's true!" Drew fired back.

Mayo tried to reach for him again, but five people held him back. Yuri and David stepped in between them.

"Is there a problem?" Ci-N asked, and everyone turned to look at them. "Is there a problem with them?"

Ci-N...

"Isn't a gay person someone who dresses as a woman even if they're a man?" he asked, and immediately, all attention shifted to him.

"...he tried to kill himself," he said, and we all froze. "...he judged him just for being gay."

"Is that why you're so quiet?" I asked.

He nodded, tears falling. "I don't understand. I don't understand. I don't have to judge someone just because they're gay." He looked at them. "Are they still people? They're still the ones we're with? They're still the ones who help us? They're still the ones who make us smile? They're still the ones who care about them, they just admitted who they are. So, what's wrong?"

Silence. That's all that surrounded us. I wanted to answer him, but I couldn't. I didn't know how to explain it to him.

I didn't know what was wrong.

"Should I wait for Kit to kill himself before I get an answer to my question?" he asked while wiping his tears. "...I've already lost a friend. I'm going to lose a friend too?"

Since I met Ci-N, he's always amazed me with what he is. He's smart, talented, and persistent.

Now, I'm amazed by him again because of what he said.

It was obvious that those words slapped the "Ulupongs." They broke eye contact, and some even looked down.

own understanding. They're the ones who are wrong, not cousin."

He hugged me back. He was still so young. He had such perspective on things. So innocent about things that, tech already understand.

"Jay-jay's right," Edrix said. "...we shouldn't have judged

"But you can't blame us either. We've been with him in e day—just like that."

"Give us some time to adjust," Calix added.

"Maybe... we're still friends with Kit, so we'll accept him

At that moment, I suddenly remembered the "Ulupongs" Those idiots who, despite being idiots, I could count on.

It felt like something pinched my heart. I shouldn't be feeling couldn't stop it.

"Sala—"

"Hey, you!" someone shouted, cutting me off.

I frowned. What is this woman doing here?

"Is that Helen?" Felix asked while looking at the woman

I frowned and looked at Felix, who was just as confused happening.

"P-percy?"

She raised an eyebrow at me. "Do you have another step him?"

I shook my head. What's her problem?

"Then, answer my question," she ordered.

It felt like something clicked in my brain, and I started g her face.

"What's your problem? What do you need from him?"

She glared at me. "Your. step. brother. owe. me. a. lot."

Shit!

What kind of mess is this, Percy?

# Chapter 252: Hide and see

## Jay-jay's POV

"Ouch!" I complained as I tried to pull my hand away.

"...your nails are hurting me!"

"You walk like a tortoise. So slow!" Honey snapped irrit

She kept dragging me along. And she was wearing high  
the mood, I'd punch her by now. We had just finished all  
the "Ulupongs," so I still felt heavy from everything.

We finally reached the outside of the school, where her c

I'm so screwed with Kuya Angelo. He's going to think I  
am I going to explain that a bee dragged me off?

"Get in!" she ordered when we stopped in front of her ca

Wow. A Ferrari.

I immediately grabbed my wrist where she had held it. It  
she dug her nails in deep. She must really hate me!

I put one hand on my hip, and the other mirrored her drag as if I was ready to scratch her with my long nails.

"Obviously, you're dumb." I snapped, flicking my finger is with him at home, so he should've been the one you dr

"Eew. Don't copy me," she said, raising one eyebrow. "I

I dropped my hand from my waist and slapped my forehead such a hard head. She and Freya must be besties.

"Why not?"

"Because we have a past."

I raised an eyebrow. "You two were a thing?"

"No!" She quickly replied. "He asked me out, but I didn't. Things like that."

I nodded, pretending to buy it, but I wasn't really convinced. She couldn't even look me in the eye, and she was tense. earlier disappeared.

I smell something... smells like fart.

"Eeww... did you fart?" I asked, covering my nose.

She shot me a nasty look. "Tell me!"

farted."

She immediately pulled her ear away from me and slapped making me flinch in pain.

"What the fvck?! Get in already! I'm getting mad at you.

I rolled my eyes at her and got into her fancy car.

Sheeeet! The seat itself feels expensive. Now I kind of w

She got in too and quickly started the engine. Luckily, tr in front of us, or she would've sped up with the way she steering wheel.

"What's with the traffic? In London, it's not like this." sh

I immediately looked at her. Did she just say London? L

Wait, isn't...

Could they be together?

"You're from London?" I asked.

She looked at me briefly before focusing on the road aga

"Yes. I am," she replied, bored.



I knew it! He's so shameless. No wonder that jerk tolerat  
You're Judas! You're Herod's sibling!

"Damn you! You better not tell him I admitted it to you.  
added, making me stop.

I looked at her confused, though part of me wanted to pu  
slam her face into the steering wheel.

"A-what..."

"Yes, I'm with him in London, but it's because of my job

She explained, glancing at me now and then. "...He's my

I blinked a few times, processing what she said. Keifer's  
an employee? And all this time, I thought there was som  
between them.

"Wait! Pull over! Explain this properly!" I ordered.

"Ugh! I can't believe I have to do this!" she complained,  
the car to park by the side of the road.

"Explain it properly! From the top!" I demanded again.

She glared at me before speaking. "Look, Keifer is my b  
already know that my uncle is his lawyer. He needed sor

Were they playing royalty or something?

She rolled her eyes again as if I were the most stupid person spoken to.

"Duh! Haven't you heard about the transfer of all of Watson to him?"

I scratched my neck. "I've heard about it."

"And you're still asking a damn question," she said sarcastically, talking about billions or trillions of money here. What do you do in London? Of course, working with it! Helping him manage the papers." She explained irritably. "...seriously."

Sorry! How would I know about that?

I felt small in my seat because of the way she spoke to me. I was so stupid and didn't understand what they were doing.

"So if you have a job, why are you here?"

She looked at me like I had the smallest brain in the world.

"Don't you know what's going on with Keifer?"

I shook my head, confused. She stared at me for a few moments before deciding to start the car again.

"Let's try at Felix's house."

I pointed the way to her. Before long, she turned into the house that was their house. I immediately saw Felix's house, a place I had seen several times.

I was about to point it out to her, but it seemed like it was already there.

She was already glaring at the house from a distance. She was standing right in front of it without even asking me which specific house she was going to.

Something's off.

We both got out of the car. I didn't move at first to see if I could see and deal with whoever was inside.

When she didn't move, I decided to do it and pressed the button.

Only a few seconds later, the gate opened, and Felix's mother came out to meet us seriously. She was holding a potholder and wearing a concerned expression.

"J-jay-jay? H-how are you? Is there something you need?" she asked, stuttering.

I noticed that she seemed uneasy and looked back inside the car. I wasn't sure why she was acting like that, but I had a strange feeling. I smiled at her.

Wow!

She stopped and looked around before facing us. "Nice to meet you. Shall I call you Mom, Mama, or Mommy?"

Huh? This girl really has some guts! Solid!

I cringed at how she acted. Felix's mom seemed puzzled.

"H-huh?" was all she could say.

Honey smiled again and flicked her long hair back. "I'm your future daughter-in-law."

You just have to admire her boldness. I could only blink, and that's something else. She's really something else, I might even love her.

The real question is: who will she end up with? Percy or Felix? There seems to be something going on between them?

Tita tried to smile at her. "I-is that so?"

"Yes. Where is Percy, by the way?"

I noticed how tightly she was gripping the potholder. She was looking at Honey in the eye. It was clear she was hiding something.

"Tita's not here."

It was Dalia.

"Hello, do you remember me?" I asked as I slightly crouched to her level.

She moved the long hair that was covering her face and she started nodding.

"Ate Jay-jay," she said, giving me a hug.

I hugged her back and kissed her cheek. It hadn't been the last time we saw each other, but she had grown so much. Kids really grow up so fast.

I heard Honey cough lightly behind me. I let go of Dalia.

I almost forgot about her. I missed Felix's little girl. Even though she was a bit creepy, I love her.

"This is Dalia, Felix and Percy's little sister." I introduced her.

Honey slightly bowed and smiled at Dalia. "Hello, Dalia. I have beautiful eyes."

Dalia's eyes widened, and she pointed at Honey's face with her finger. "Impakta!"

I was startled by what she yelled, so I quickly covered her mouth.

I removed my hand from Dalia's mouth. She looked at Honey for anything. I couldn't help but feel nervous.

Maybe I hurt her without realizing it.

I turned Dalia to face me and smiled at her. "Is something wrong?"

She leaned closer to my ear and whispered, "Kuya said something about purity. He told me not to talk to her."

What?! That Blue Eyes idiot really said that? He even talked about purity? How messed up can this idiot be?

Before I could say anything, Dalia ran inside the house and disappeared. I stood up, scratching my head, and faced Honey.

"I-it seems like Percy's not here," I said.

It was obvious she wasn't convinced by my answer. Suddenly, she ran into the house while calling out my stupid brother's name.

Troublemaker! So annoying!

"Where the hell are you, Percy?!" Honey shouted.

Dalia and her mom came out of the kitchen. The little girl was holding the end of her mom's shirt, staring at the woman who kept scolding her.

Honey went upstairs to the second floor. Tito was curious about what was going on.

I opened the bathroom door and looked up at the ceiling. properly fastened on that hole.

"Percy," I called softly, but loud enough for him to hear.

It didn't take long before the door opened, and my crazy peeked out.

"Hi, Jay. Is she still here?" he asked quietly.

I nodded at him. "What did you do? Why are they looking

"I didn't show up for our date last night."

I paused and looked inside the house before turning to face him.

"What date? Are you two together?"

He quickly shook his head. "She's a 'Impakta.' She's so a

I could only shake my head, laughing. That phrase came from people. It really came from him.

"Don't you want what happened between you two to happen again?" teased.

Suddenly, he acted like he was disgusted. "She ruined me. I don't think I'm going to let it happen again? No way!"

I could only roll my eyes. He really is an idiot. I could just wish his blue eyes turn red.

"Alright. I'll pull you out of here so you can leave," I said.  
"...you owe me."

"Thanks, sista," he said in a dramatic tone and winked.

I closed the bathroom door and held Dalia's hand to take her to hear Tita and Honey talking, probably arguing.

"Ate Jay-jay," Dalia called me. "What's purity?"

Oh my God... Here we go.

I scratched my head. "It's something your brother Percy said. It's obvious."

She nodded, accepting my answer. I couldn't stop myself from knowing she didn't really understand it. She was too young for that to her.

When we entered the house, Honey was clearly stressed. She ran her hair several times while calling someone on her phone.

Tita glanced at us, like she wanted to ask something. It seemed like she knew where her mischievous son was hiding. I just smiled and gave her a thumbs-up.



"When Percy gets back, tell him to answer my calls. I'll go before walking out of the house.

"Wait!" I called out to her.

She was about to leave, but she was the one who brought have lost it.

I said goodbye to Dalia and her mom, telling them I'd come had the time. I also apologized for the trouble this "Impa

I ran out to catch up with Honey. Luckily, she was still a car, so I caught up with her.

"Hey! Hey! Wait up!" I shouted, pointing at her.

"Whatever! Get in!" she yelled at me.

This girl is crazy! She didn't even find Percy and went no fault—if she hadn't kept pestering him, he wouldn't have

I got into her car and slammed the door shut. She didn't see what I did, so I just left her alone.

She's rich, she can afford cars.

It was clear that she was still annoyed by what happened was dying to ask her about what she said regarding Keife

# Chapter 253: King

## Jay-jay's POV

"Where are we going?" I asked almost in a whisper.

It looked like Honey was reaching her limit. She was gripping the steering wheel so tightly, it looked like it might break. The car was speeding up.

This is a Ferrari, man! We're going to fly here!

I couldn't get an answer from her if she kept acting like that. I needed her to give me an explanation about what was going on with the King.

"Damn it! Ugh!" she screamed, almost making me jump.

If she wasn't already crazy, she was about to be. I might as well brace myself for the car. My goodness!

But it seemed like I wouldn't need to do that. Slowly, the car came to a stop, and she parked it on the side of the road.

"Is there a problem—?" I started to ask, but I couldn't finish. She suddenly hit the steering wheel hard.

I shouldn't have said anything, but I had to distract her so her anger out on me.

Suddenly, she screamed in a shrill voice. It was so loud i eardrums were going to burst.

I didn't want to hear it anymore.

"That Felix! He's damn! And that Percy!" She took a dee

"...we were supposed to have a date last night. It was so l into my schedule, and he just wasted it! He promised me

I furrowed my brow. Something didn't add up. Percy pro but why did he hide? These two are such a mess.

"He promised?"

"Yes! He said if I helped him talk to Keifer, as a reward, a date! That guy! So stupid!" she said angrily.

Talk to... what the hell?!

That fool was doing something I didn't know about. Why idiot? Was something going on that I didn't know? What this?

"W-what did they talk about?"

She raised an eyebrow. "What?"

Now I was the one who felt annoyed. "What we were talking about? Why did you both come back to the Philippines because Keifer!"

She gave me a sharp glare. That only made me even more annoyed.

Should I poke her eye out?

Should I blind her?

"It's probably better if I take you to him," she said, quickly.

I didn't have time to argue. I grabbed onto whatever I could and got down the road. She was driving like she was in a race. A car almost got honked at by other cars because of her overtaking.

In my panic and fear, I didn't even bother to look around.

I only felt relieved when she turned into a wide parking lot.

When the car stopped, she said, "Get out!"

I rolled my eyes. Like, seriously? As soon as I stepped out, I almost wanted to jump back in. The huge Fer Corp sign was right there.

What the... If Kuya sees me, I'm dead!

My feet moved toward the building entrance on their own of people scattered around, most of them in business attire anymore if Kuya Angelo saw me.

Annoying! Why am I so eager to see him?!

Suddenly, someone grabbed my arm before I could get in. When I turned, Honey's annoyed face met mine.

"Are you stupid? If you haven't noticed, something is happening."

I looked around and saw the same people from before. No one was staring at us.

"Miss Jasper Jean," someone called.

Wow. That "Miss" sounded really classy.

I turned and saw a familiar woman approaching. She smiled in front of us, and Honey let go of my arm.

"Are you here to see Sir Angelo?" she asked politely.

I gave a hesitant smile and grimaced. "W-what..."

I couldn't remember who she was. She might be Kuya Angelo or one of the employees I had met before.

"Welcome looking for Mr. Watson?" Honey said in

"Just wait inside. Come on, I'll get you a visitor's ID," the woman said.

She walked ahead, and Honey followed her. My feet wouldn't move! Why are they freezing now?

Maybe it's too much of a wrap.

"What! Are you just staying there?" Honey said irritably, looking back at us again.

I tried to move my legs. They felt like they were made of lead after them. People kept staring at us.

Come on, people! Get a grip! I almost felt like I was going to faint in half. At the reception, I saw Honey and the woman. She looked just like the one they gave me the first time I came here.

When I got closer, Honey handed me the ID that was for her.

"Follow me," the woman said.

She led us to the back part of the reception area. There was a coffee table in the middle. A marble wall separated this area from the rest of the reception. Some parts were glass, where you could see the building.

I never made it to class. I knew Ci-N and Yuri, along with Snakes, were probably worried about me. I'd like to call phone in my bag back at school.

"You know, you look dumb," Honey said to me.

I rolled my eyes just as I turned to look at her. She was sitting in a pose, facing her phone.

I should have taken my phone!!

"W-when did you both come back to the Philippines?" I

"Me? Just yesterday. Keifer? I don't know."

"What do you mean you don't know? I thought you were in the UK?"

She rolled her eyes before answering. "Duh! Obviously I know. Besides, he's run away from us so many times. We only suddenly starts fighting with Keigan." She paused to type then spoke again. "...but from what I understand, he's come back to the Philippines several times."

He's come back several times?

If he's been back here several times, why hasn't he shown up to me? What does that mean? Is he giving me the space I

"He's fine, I think. Just the same as before. He doesn't talk. Always alone, drinking. The only change is that he quit smoking," he explained.

I wanted to know if he's eating well. I wanted to know if he was with other girls. I wanted to know if... if... if he misses me too.

I'm mad at myself. Why am I so hopeful about him? It shouldn't be. Why am I letting him affect me so much?

Damn it! This is all your fault, you idiot.

I glanced at Honey. I'm jealous of her. I'm jealous because she's with Keifer. I can't help but wish that I was the one in her place.

I remembered when I first met him. I was so irritated by his flirtatiousness. Speaking of which, I suddenly remembered something.

"Didn't you say there was nothing going on between you and him?" I asked Honey.

She nodded in response.

"Then why, when we first met, did you cling to him like a lost child?" I asked her, a little annoyed.

She paused for a moment to think before adjusting her ponytail. "One!" She smiled sweetly at me. "...It's just for show. We're not really together."



She stared at me, and her gaze was full of meaning. It was saying, 'You know what I mean, don't play dumb with me.'

I quickly looked away, and she laughed.

Damn it!

Her phone rang, so she stopped laughing. She answered it for a moment. When she hung up, she stood up and walked away.

"Let's go..." she said before walking past me. "...they're coming."

As soon as she said that, I looked at the elevator. From the floor above, I could clearly see the floor number of where the elevator was, and the arrow pointing downwards.

My heartbeat slowly started to quicken. It felt like what I was about to happen. But my thoughts were racing. I was wondering whether I should face him or not.

Either way, my body made the decision. I couldn't move. I was standing. I couldn't take my eyes off that damn elevator.

My breathing tightened until the bell of death—I mean, the elevator—rang.

My heart started pounding even faster. It felt like it was going to escape my chest. It felt like it was trying to escape my chest.

He was in business attire. His movements were neat, as if he was a respected individual. He looked a little more mature, but his face was calm.

He briefly talked to another man, also in business attire.

I got a chance to watch him.

"I need to leave," Honey said, but I didn't pay attention to her.

I didn't even realize she had already left my side. My eyes were glued to that damn King.

I wanted to step forward and rush to him. I wanted to scream at him. I wanted to... I wanted to make him feel the pain we all felt when he disappeared.

You son of a bitch, Keifer!!

Why do you have this effect on me? Damn! My body wobbled, my legs and knees wouldn't obey me. Damn it!

It was only then that I noticed my cheeks were wet with tears. I shouldn't be crying. I shouldn't be crying! Goddammit! Why am I crying?

This is your fault, you animal! All you've done is make me feel like a fool. You piece of shit! You're one big, huge disaster! Waaaah

I need to hide! What... should I crawl... no. Crawl... slide

Shit! It felt like I was hiding from someone I owed some

In my attempt to hide from the King, I jumped from where I was to the other side of the sofa. I probably looked more like I should have.

"Who is that?"

"Please, someone call security."

"Kids these days."

"What a filthy mouth."

I could hear people nearby talking about me. They can catch me once they're gone.

I heard footsteps getting closer to my hiding spot. Oh no security guards.

"Where is she?" A familiar voice said.

My body froze. I even stopped breathing, hoping they wouldn't find where I was. I wasn't ready to face him.

I really shouted!

those profanities."

I shut my eyes tightly. He knows I'm here. He knows! The last word he said. Shit!

"Brother!" Keigan's voice. "...we have to leave. We're going on our flight."

Fine! Just go!

"Okay." He replied, and I heard a few footsteps as they went.

Even when I couldn't hear them anymore, I still didn't leave. I still felt like there were people nearby. My gut feeling was right.

I was right when I heard him speak.

"Maybe next time." He said, sounding like he was walking away. "I'll be back, jay."

I finally came out of my hiding spot. But he was gone, heading out of the building. I just wanted to see him.

The kind of cry that's like a scream, the kind that a child would cry.

And it looks like that's exactly what I'll do later. Because standing there was Kuya Angelo. His eyebrows were furrowed, and he looked like smoke was coming out of his nose from anger.

# Chapter 254: Who knows

## Jay-jay's POV

"AaaaaAaaaAaalllLllaaaAaaayyyyyyy!!!" I screamed as pulled my ear.

What's worse is that from the Fer Corp building to the parking lot, he was holding my little ear. I felt like it was about to tear off.

Let go, please!!

"You're so stubborn! Right when your final exams are approaching, you're acting up!" He scolded me.

"It hurts, Kuya!" I complained, almost in tears.

When we stopped in front of his car, only then did he let go.

I quickly grabbed my ear, which was numb from the pain.

He opened the car door. "Get in!" He ordered.

"Wait a minute!" I protested.

My ear hurt so much. I couldn't even listen to his lecture.

"Then what are you doing here?"

"Honey brought me here. Then I found out that he was tl UK." I looked at him like I was pouting. "...And you? W me Keifer was the investor?"

"He's not the investor. He's just a representative. He's no he hasn't graduated to be able to run a company."

"Even so! You still didn't tell me he was coming!"

Suddenly, he swiped at the back of my head. I quickly ra block it and dodged his hand.

"It's a business matter! You don't work at the company, s you?"

I pouted. Talking to Kuya is so hard. He doesn't know ar happened in my life, so he doesn't get what I'm trying to

"Get in the car." He ordered, pointing to the open door.

"...I'll take you to your school."

I slammed myself into the car. My eyebrows were furrow they were about to meet in the middle.

Kuya's funny. I don't have school anymore, and yet, he's

Damn that space of his. He should go live in outer space the aliens there. So annoying! Let him be with E.T.

One month of his felt like a decade. I want to cry because I am. So frustrating! So frustrating! FRUSTRATING!

You're frustrating, Keifer! You really are!

He didn't even bother to check if I was okay. He didn't even eat properly. He didn't ask about what was happening. He didn't even check if I got involved in another mess.

That bastard didn't care about anything—!

"He asked how you were." Kuya said, making me look at him.

"...Keifer asked how you were."

"Fuck!" I responded, completely without thinking.

Kuya shot me a sharp look. "Are you cursing at me?"

I quickly shook my head. "N-not you. Keifer."

He returned his focus to the road and kept driving. I straightened my throat to calm my voice.

If I heard correctly, the bastard actually asked about me.

Kuya glanced at me briefly before looking back at the road.

"That's it. Why? Was there supposed to be more?"

I wanted to bang my head against the car window. That was making me mad. Damn! Damn!

Before long, we reached the school gates. The car stopped. I could get out, Kuya said something that made me freeze.

"Do you really love Keifer?"

I bit my lower lip. I wanted to say yes, but I knew he would hear that answer.

It seemed like he noticed that I didn't want to respond.

"I'm not stopping you from loving anyone. But maybe, just maybe,

I looked at him, confused. I understood when he told me before because I was engaged to Yuri then. But now, why?

"It's hard to love a Watson. There's a heavy price to pay."

How much? I'll save up.

"Are you trying to scare me?"

"No. I'm just telling you the truth."



"Jay-jay?" Someone called.

When I looked, I saw Yuri approaching me. I wiped my tears from my face. But before I could even say anything, his arms wrapped around me.

His hug was tight. I couldn't help but hug him back, and tears started flowing again. It was like a waterfall, the tears.

"Keep crying. I'll be your handkerchief to wipe your tears," he said. "Only made my crying worse."

"I-I saw him," I said, feeling him hold me even tighter. "I feel like I'm the only one suffering between the two of us?"

"You don't seem to know him at all," he said, laughing but with a sad tone. "He's tough, but inside, he's soft like a marshmallow."

I managed to laugh a little, but it wasn't enough to stop me from burying myself further into his chest.

"Jay..." He called my name. "...I'll only wipe your tears, not your snot."

Oh crap!!

I quickly pulled away from him and let go of the hug. My white shirt was already soaked with my tears.

~~~~~

Damn that guy.

"Why?"

"Because I might not be able to control myself. I might p
looks so good, too."

I heard him laugh softly. He pulled me back into another

But this hug was different. It was full of fear and worry.
reason for it. I'm not numb. I could feel it in every act of
me, I could feel that he was giving his all.

I chose not to say anything. I didn't want to risk losing w
left, Yuri and me. I was happy with what we had. He was
anything in return for all his efforts.

There was no pressure, unlike before. There was no forc
I felt more comfortable like this.

Yuri is my comfort zone.

"Do you know that PDA is not allowed here?" Aries' voi

Both Yuri and I pulled away and looked at him. Our brow
and our arms were crossed.

"Where did you come from?" Yuri asked.

I just nodded briefly in response.

"What did he say to you?"

I decided not to answer him.

"Aries... Let's talk later. We're going back to class now."

I didn't wait for him to respond. I started walking toward
Not long after, I felt Yuri following me.

As we neared the "Ulupong" group, he grabbed my arm

"Jay... What's the problem?"

I turned to face him and looked into his eyes. "Do you ki

He looked puzzled at first, but it seemed like he figured i
let go of my arm.

"Do you know too?" I repeated. "...Do you know that he'

He quickly looked away, and from that, I already knew t
question.

He knew. He knew everything!

I didn't want to get mad at him, but I couldn't help but fe
they had done. I started walking again towards the Ulupong

he looked at me confused. "Know what?"

"That he's coming?"

His brows furrowed in confusion. he couldn't understand

"Who's coming?"

It seemed like he had no idea. I sighed.

"Keifer arrived." I said almost in a whisper.

He was shocked by his appearance. In a panic, he grabbed his pocket and opened the message.

"Why is this? He hasn't sent me any messages since yesterday showed me the messages in his inbox.

It seemed like he intentionally didn't tell Ci-N.

"Let it go. We haven't talked anyway," I said without even walked closer to Kit.

They were still separated but were now with Eren and Jo my shoulders slumping.

I let out a deep sigh that caught the attention of the four.

"Hey. What happened? Where did Honey take you?" Eren

I looked at him, equally puzzled. Did he not know what happened between the two?

"You're asking the wrong question. It should be, what's going on between you and Honey?"

"Between us?" he asked, pointing at himself. "...N-nothing! I teased her before, calling her Manang. Then when she came to see US, she started acting cold toward me. Her appearance changed."

I raised an eyebrow. "That's not what she told me."

The Ulupongs all looked at him at the same time. They all gasped in unison, "Ayyiiieehhhh!!"

"Haha... There's something going on!"

"What kind of sorcery happened between you two?"

"Come on, spill it!"

Felix immediately became flustered and tried to distance himself from teasing him. It seemed like he was close to losing his temper.

"Nothing! What's wrong with you all?" he said irritably.

They were about to tease him further, but he walked away and turned his back so we couldn't see his reaction.

"Keifer. He's back," Ci-N said.

Their reactions varied.

"Why hasn't he shown himself to us?"

"Where is he now?"

"Does he know what's happening here?"

"That's it! Keifer left us hanging!" Blaster said angrily, c
him.

"What are you talking about?" Eman asked.

"Don't you realize? He left on purpose when things were
apart!" Blaster said, and the other Ulupongs exchanged g
think about it, he's the reason for all of this! He's the reas
at us, and then what did he do? He left!"

"Blaster's right!" Drew chimed in. "...We've been workin
to Jay-jay! Meanwhile, he's the one who started all of thi

"Stop it already!" Rory scolded.

"What they're saying is true!" Mayo joined in.

Kit immediately stopped him. "Don't get involved with t

"Let's not pretend here! You're mad at him, right? He's your friend!" he retorted, causing Yuri to grab him by the collar.

We thought they were about to fight, so we were alarmed and looked straight in the eyes.

"Yes! We are rivals, but don't forget that he's also my friend. I know what he's going through right now, so don't talk about him like a guy!" he said angrily before letting go of Drew.

He glanced at me for a moment and tried to calm down. He then turned on us and walked away. We were left just staring at him.

Out of all of us, only Yuri knew what Keifer was truly going through now. Despite their differences, he still considered him a friend.

I wish I could do what you're doing.

I want to think that despite everything that's happened, they are still my friends. But I'm afraid that maybe they don't see me the same way.

I looked at all of them. We've been through so much together in the front of them, and they've done the same in front of me. We've had our problems and joys together.

It only fell apart when they lied to me. Blaster and Drew want to think they're right because we all made mistakes.

Chapter 255: Forgive & Fo

Jay-jay's POV

I spent the whole night thinking about the Ulupongs and so late that I only fell asleep at 4 a.m. The result? I was c

Young dumb and brokkkee...

I was even singing off-key.

"Jay... Eat already. You might be late." Tita Gema said.

I was just sitting there with my mouth half-open, my eye open. I was so out of it that I thought the laughter in from my imagination. When I tried to look, my eyes widened shoved into my mouth.

"Who put this here?" I asked while chewing.

What a waste! It was already in my mouth.

Kuya Angelo and Aries were laughing. I gave them both

"Stop staying up late. That way, you won't get pranked a

When Aries stood up, I did too. But before I could leave called me. I faced him.

"What?" I asked.

He looked at me strangely. It was like he was observing like he wanted to say something I couldn't understand.

"Nothing, just be careful," he said and went back to what

Whut?!

Even though it was weird, I chose to ignore it and went to shower. Maybe Kuya was also sleep-deprived.

Before I could fully enter the bathroom, I heard my phone. I grabbed it from the top of my bed.

It was just an ordinary message. One was from Yuri, and *GagongBaliw* (Crazy Idiot). The president of the Shura just greeted me 'Good Morning.' But this one...

****From: GagongBaliw****

****Message:**** *I am loving you more each day!*

I grimaced. Was he high again? Maybe he hadn't slept either chose not to reply.

I wasn't wrong because while I was getting dressed, I heard him shout from outside the door.

"Hurry up! Jay! You're so slow!"

"WAIT!" I shouted.

Of course, he's a guy. His preparation before going out is like Aries just pours water on himself, then walks out of the house. Maybe he just sprays a bit of perfume so it's not obvious.

In my rush, I only noticed too late that my socks were mismatched. I can't change them because it would take too long to find a matching pair. It probably won't be noticeable anyway.

I left my room and almost ran straight to the living room, seemingly looking for something in his pocket.

"Let's go!" I urged.

"Wait a minute!" he said irritably. "...you're always in a rush."

Oh wow!

How embarrassing. I guess I shouldn't rush him. But who's supposed to rush. How embarrassing!

"Found it," he said, holding his phone. "...let's go! You're ready."

I kind of regretted thinking about that idiot earlier. Why through this? Why do you have to make things hard for me?

Ulung! You're an ULUPONG!

But at least I got something out of staying up late. Aside from having their own eyebags, I decided to become a KPop idol. I'm so sleep-deprived, give me SLEEP!

I've decided to forgive the Ulungs. Yes! I'll forgive them. With the drama, it's not trendy anymore. It's time to forgive.

I know it's only been a few months since the truth came out. A few days I made them feel the pain of what they did. I regret it, even if it's not obvious with some of them.

What should I expect? They're Ulungs.

It's really hard when you're sleep-deprived! I end up speaking when it's not necessary.

It didn't take long before we arrived at school. When the bell about to get out when I noticed my brother looking for someone.

"What? What is it?" I asked.

"Did you see where I put my phone?"

"What? What is it?" I asked.

No way! My plans are too good today!

While walking, I saw Yuri in the distance. I quickly ran t
arm around him. he was surprised at first but smiled whe

"Good morning," I greeted him with a smile.

"Good morning. Looks like someone is in a good mood t
smiling. "...care to tell me why?"

I moved away from him and walked alongside him. Hold
backpack, I grinned.

"Because... I'm ready to forgive the Snakes," I said.

he stopped and stared at me before smiling widely. "You
shit! This is good news. They'll be happy when they hear

he was about to run towards the auditorium, but I stoppe
arm tightly, which confused him.

"W-what?" he asked.

"Wait! Don't be in such a hurry!" I said before letting go
to time it right before telling them."

he nodded. "Okay. You've got a plan, right?"

I raised a finger ready to respond with a confident "Yes

"Trust me! It's hard to explain! I have one, but I'm just a sleep, so my mind's all over the place."

he nodded in acknowledgment. We both continued walk auditorium where our classroom was. Ugh!

When will we get out of here?

"Hello, Jay!" Ci greeted me.

I noticed that he was doing better, probably no longer th about his cousin. Maybe he's chosen to keep his feelings

I might talk to him about it later. It's tough having no one the pain. Based on my own experience, of course!

"How's it going?" I asked as I got closer.

I looked over at Kit and Mayo. They were still with Eren time, they were also hanging out with other Snakes like]

They were chatting like it was nothing. It was a good sig getting over the situation with Kit and Mayo. But of cou was fine. Like Drew, who was talking to Denzel.

"Jay... Why are your socks different?" Felix suddenly asl at my feet.

~~~~~

I saw Yuri smiling at me. It was a different kind of smile  
"I know something." I just rolled my eyes at him.

I had no idea how to time it to say what I wanted to say.  
wasn't now, especially since I could already see Sir Alvin  
us.

We all took our seats. I couldn't help but glance around and  
like my stomach was tickling from excitement.

So excited!

I think everyone's here. Except that damn King of theirs.  
punch him the next time we meet. I'm not scared anymore  
when I pull the hair from your nose!

"Mariano?" Sir Alvin suddenly called.

What?!

"Nose hair, Sir," I answered without thinking.

The Snakes burst into laughter. Of course, the usual trouble  
leading the charge. Even Sir Alvin couldn't stop laughing  
head.

"It's just attendance," Yuri said.

"Nose hair!"

These guys really! They replaced the "present" with "nose hair!"  
They're really asking for it!

"Peralta!"

"Lots of nose hair!"

The teasing just kept coming. The Snakes couldn't stop laughing and  
someone answered like that.

I just hung my head in embarrassment, pouting. So annoying.

"Ramos!"

"Nose hair!"

I noticed Yuri laughing a lot beside me. I was getting so annoyed that  
he didn't stop.

"Venites!"

"Nose hair!"

I didn't know whether to cry or what. I couldn't handle the teasing.

Damn it!

Class with Sir Alvin ended, and I decided it was time to

I really didn't have a solid plan for how to begin telling them I was forgiven them.

I stood up from my seat and started walking around like I was even playing with my hands, swinging them with ease.

I didn't realize Josh was about to stand up from his seat. My hand, it hit his face.

"Ow!" He shouted and sat down again.

"Sorry, sorry! I didn't see you!" I said frantically, holding my hand that I hit.

"Oh no! Jay punched Josh!" Eren said, pretending to scare me.

"I didn't mean to! I didn't know he was standing!" I explained.

"You did it on purpose. I saw it," Felix teased, and I shot him a glare.

"Jay's got a grudge against Josh," Blaster added.

Great. You guys are really helping me out.

I just slapped my forehead. It's so hard to talk to these Shiganshina. If they're helping me, they're making it worse.



"HEY! YOU SNAKES!" I shouted, holding my waist.

The fools turned and looked at me, puzzled.

"What?" The bratty guy innocently asked.

Suddenly, I got nervous under their gaze. My tongue froze. I couldn't remember what I was about to say.

What was I supposed to say?

"The w-wether's nice today, huh?" I said while scratchin

They still looked at me, blinking in confusion. Then Ci-N stepped up, grinning widely.

"The weather's great, but this coming news is even better!" he said, running off.

he bumped into me. I looked at who he was running to and saw a girl coming, holding a bunch of papers in her hand.

Ci-N stopped just a few steps away from me, raised both hands, and gave me a big about to hug.

I could see Rakki cringe and try to avoid him, almost like a cat. She walked straight to us and smiled at me.

"Is someone giving away money?"

The Snakes were being nosy as they approached. I almost they rushed up to me.

"Can you guys back off for a second?" Rakki said irritab

"Just tell us the good news!" David ordered.

Rakki, irritated, pulled back the papers and glared at the

"You guys are so chaotic!" She said. "...This is a permit f members and Principal."

"A permit? For what?" I asked.

"It's a permit to let you use one of the vacant rooms in th she explained. "...so grab your things, we're moving."

"YESSS!" The idiots screamed.

I felt like my eardrums shattered from their loud shout. E hold her ears.

Everyone started grabbing their things. Since Ci-N wasn spot, I grabbed his things. Josh arrived just in time for m was happening.

"Ci, is this how you're gonna be?" Rakki asked him

We followed Rakki to the main building. People we pass at us, confused, but we just ignored them. "We finally have a classroom to use," Denzel said.

True...

It's really hard to sit on the floor, using your legs as a desk and notebook. It's exhausting and numb.

We were led to the fourth floor of the main building. We walked down the hallway and stopped in front of a door.

The Snakes seemed giddy, constantly smiling and fidgeting.

Who wouldn't be?

Yes, even I was excited. It's a new classroom with proper desks. We had to endure the old desks in our original room.

It's a bit nostalgic, though. Even though the old desks were there through all our experiences, whether it was fighting or sitting together.

"Are you ready?" Rakki asked.

We were about to answer when Ci-N suddenly yelled out.

"I'M READY TO LOVE YOU FULLY!" he shouted, smiling.

As soon as the door opened, the light from the large window caught my attention. The classroom was almost too close.

I was squinting! Ughhh...

"How's everything?" someone asked.

When I looked, I saw Mica holding a broom and rag. Ella holding a garbage bag. "Baby!" Calix called as he approached. "...Why are you here? Why are you holding that? You're holding hands."

We entered to check the room. Everything was brand new. The classroom was air-conditioned. It also looked like Section 8. They had a flat-screen TV.

"It's fine," Mica answered Calix. "...We cleaned the room."

"You shouldn't have done that, it's embarrassing," I said.

"A simple thank you would have sufficed," Ella replied with her arms crossed.

Whew...

"Thank you," I said while avoiding eye contact.

I looked at the Snakes. Everyone was finding their spots.

Then who do I thank?

# Chapter 256: R.Sato

## Jay-Jay's POV

"...Aries?"

No way! The Aries Horoscope? That sounds unbelievably believe.

"He was the one who talked to the Principal. He also convinced the Members," Rakki explained. Really?

I was touched. My sibling is such a good person, even though it seems like his brain is somewhere else. I love him!

"Did he really do that?" I asked in disbelief.

"If you don't believe it, maybe you should ask him yourself."

It might be better to ask him directly to understand his reaction. I took my cell phone from my bag and typed a message. While I was waiting, and the others said their goodbyes because they still had to go.

I thanked them again and didn't take my eyes off them until they were gone.

"Take care. Baby!" Calix said as he walked Mica to the car.

"I won't get full from a love life."

He slightly smiled. "Just go home, so you don't end up li

Ah, you jerk!

I immediately threatened him with a punch. He quickly s  
avoid it. I just pointed at him while watching him walk a

I checked my phone again, hoping that maybe my sibling  
—had replied. But there was no response from him.

I looked for a seat. I wanted to sit by the window, but me  
already taken those spots.

I couldn't even pick a seat!

"Jay-jay!" Kit called out, waving. "...Sit here."

He pointed to a seat next to him, close to the window.

I was about to go over when Mayo suddenly sat there. K  
frowned because of what he did.

"Get out of there! Jay-jay's sitting there!" Kit pushed hin

"I don't want to!" he replied angrily, then smiled sweetly  
you more often." Then he suddenly hugged Kit.

We all laughed for a moment. I had to find another spot, wouldn't be far from the two people I always copy during

But most of the time, I'm the one doing the copying.

"Jay-jay!" Ci greeted me, smiling.

"Same old, same old," David said as he adjusted the chair

And once again, I was in between them. The three of us had our own little world, especially when I had food with me.

But I won't deny it, I missed this!

The Snakes looked happy. I glanced toward the back to see who were. I saw Yuri in his usual spot, and for some strange reason I saw the King beside his empty chair.

My smile disappeared, and I turned my attention back to the table. I lowered my head as my eyes clouded with frustration. The

I casually wiped my eyes. I didn't want to ruin the happy memories I was having. It's been a while since something good happened to us, we've been through.

"Quiet! Quiet!" someone shouted while banging on the table.

We all looked toward the back where the sound came from. The



"Right! Right!" others agreed.

"We haven't forgotten, and because of your sibling, we did the old building," Drew said.

"He was the one who ordered our building to be filled with weapons," Eren added.

"He's also the one who deepened the issue, banning Sect 4 cafeteria," Eren chimed in.

I raised an eyebrow at their accusations. I knew about the first two but I didn't realize the other two things they were accusing him of just learned about them now.

"Wait! Why are you all blaming my sibling for everything?" I asked, annoyed.

"It's not blame. These things really happened," Eren said.

I felt my tongue freeze. I wanted to defend my sibling, but I didn't know if they were lying, but it seemed like they had fallen out with that Horoscope guy.

Damn! This is tough.

"S-sure... But I know he won't do that again," I said, even though I wasn't really sure.

I scratched my neck. Mayo's comment really hit the mark.

"I think Jay-jay has something to say to you all," Yuri said.

Oh, right! How should I tell them that?

They all looked at me, waiting for what I was going to say nervously.

Suddenly, I felt anxious even though I shouldn't have.

"A-anyway... I think—" I stopped when my phone suddenly

I quickly grabbed my phone, but it stopped ringing. I saw from... Aries? I also had a text message from him.

**From: Horoscope...**

*Message: Meet me outside the school. Now!*

"What are you going to say?" Ci-N asked me.

"I'll tell you later. Aries is meeting me," I said, then walked

I heard them call my name, but I ignored it.

I hurried downstairs because I knew Aries would get impatient rushing me.

"AW! What the heck?! So stupid!" came the dramatic shout as she bumped into me.

I stood up, brushing off my clothes. I looked at the person and for some reason, I felt like bumping her again. Of all the people I could've bumped into, why Freya?

"What's your deal?! Can't you be any more stupid?!" she shouted, brushing off the skirt that had gotten caught in the fabric of my pants.

"Sorry," I said, about to walk past her, but she immediately blocked my path.

Oh great, here she goes again.

"Where are you going? Are you planning to ditch your class?"

I shook my head. "I'm going to see—"

"Jay-jay? Freya?" A familiar voice called out.

We both turned toward the voice. It was Rakki, walking toward us.

"Jay? Why are you here? Your class is about to start," she asked.

I pointed to the gate to indicate I was meeting Aries, but she didn't seem to care.

"She's planning to cut class," she added dramatically.

"Hey! You!" A familiar voice yelled.

Oh no... Here we go!

I turned to face the pouting Honey, who was approaching; guess this was about Percy. My goodness! What is that girl?

"Oh?" I answered her boredly.

"Where on earth is your freaking stepbrother?" she asked to me.

I knew this was coming!

"I don't know," I answered, clearly annoying her.

I glanced at Freya, who was almost beside Honey. She was probably surprised to see that someone was more of a dr was.

And then, an idea popped into my head.

"Maybe Freya knows where Percy is," I said, pointing at

Immediately, I was given a nasty look by the witch. Honey toward her. Here we go! Looks like a fight is about to break on the one with the red lipstick... Freya. Honey has pink

"What a b!tch! I don't have time for you," Honey said, turning around.  
"Come with me." Then she started pulling me.

But before she could drag me out the gate, Freya and Rakki immediately pulled me away from Honey, while I was full of courage and attitude.

"How dare you? You have no right to drag a student around here!"  
Freya said boldly.

Honey walked up to her, and their faces were almost touching.  
"I don't give a shit about anything you're saying."

Freya crossed her arms. "Guess what? You have to give up because you're in my territory, and I'm the queen here."

Honey eyed her from head to toe. "A queen? More like a bitch."

I thought they were about to start pulling hair, but they just glared until I saw Mica and Ella approaching us.

"What's going on here?" Ella asked, glancing at Honey.

"...Honey? What are you doing here?"

Do they know each other? Oh right. Honey is Percy's ex.

Honey raised an eyebrow at Ella. They clearly didn't get along.

But I didn't feel anything in my pocket. It seemed like I had instead.

Unbelievable!

Mica and Ella suddenly looked at each other. It was as if they were in what I had just said. "How is that possible? His phone was missing for a while now," Ella said.

That confused me. If his phone wasn't with him, then where was it?

Maybe it was a different number that I didn't notice. But I was wrong. I knew that the number that replied to me was his.

But who—shit!

I immediately looked around. My instincts kicked in, that gut social intuition that I think I'm starting to pick up. Just kidding.

"Why, Jay? Is there a problem?" Mica asked, worried.

"C-can we talk inside?" I replied while still scanning my surroundings.

"No! You need to come with me," Honey said, trying to pull me away.

Rakki quickly stopped her hand. They exchanged sharp glances.

What the heck?! Let's just fight inside!

Even I joined in trying to separate them. It was a shame; watch the two drama queens go at it.

*"Shut your filthy mouth!"*

*"Leave! You're a slut!"*

*"Compared to you, b!tch!"*

*"Enough! Stop it, Freya!"*

*"They're staring at us! Get yourselves together!"*

Amid the chaos, I only realized that we had already left to even notice the approach of a black van to where we were.

Just as I turned to check it out, something black covered grabbed both my hands.

"What the heck?! Let go of me!" I screamed as they dragged me.

I heard Ella shouting loudly, followed by Freya and Hon.

They were pushing me into something that I thought was tied something thin around my hands.

I tried to kick them, but I didn't know if I was even hitting them.

**I knew it!**

"What the heck?! Don't touch me!" I heard Freya's voice closer to my position.

"Freya?" I called out to her.

"The hell! Where are you? What is this thing on my head?" Freya said dramatically.

Then, I heard Mica's voice. "Please, don't! Have mercy on me!"

"This is so wrong! If my uncle finds out, it's over for you!"

It sounded like Honey was somewhere behind me.

"Take this off!" Ella yelled from not too far from where I was.

"What's happening? Who are you people?" Rakki asked.

I didn't understand. I was sure they were targeting me, but why drag Mica and the others into this? I could only think of one person who would do this to me. The one who had been threatening me for a long time now.

R.Sato

The one who always sends me pictures of myself with le...  
The one who texts me besides Yuri and GagongBaliw. The one who is my enemy, but for some reason, dragged me into this.



"Don't answer her," one of them from behind said.

"Why do you have to drag my friends into this—?"

"OMG! We're not friends!" Freya cut in.

Of course, she had to insist on that now.

"B!tch! You're not the one she's referring to!" Honey sho

"Shut up!"

And they started fighting again, throwing insults and cur  
I could, I would slap myself right now for letting myself  
them earlier.

"Will you all shut up, or should I make you?" A man, wh  
front of me, said.

How annoying!

I couldn't see anything with this thing covering my face.  
strange, like burnt sweat.

I was forced to stay quiet. The longer we were in the car,  
breathing tightened. My heart was pounding faster, and I  
myself down, no matter how hard I tried.

Then the car stopped, and I heard the door open again.

While walking, I knew the others were following me. I could hear Ella and Honey bickering again, Ella and Rakki complaining.

We stopped for a moment, and I heard a door open.

Then, someone pushed me down into a chair.

"Ouch! What the heck?" Rakki complained, who seemed to be sitting beside me.

"Take it off," I heard a man's voice, and they removed the bandage from my head.

What the...

I squinted because of the sudden brightness. It felt like my eyes had dried out.

Once my eyes adjusted to the light, I finally opened them.

A man in a white sleeveless shirt appeared before me. He was a Filipino. His arms and neck were covered in tattoos. He looked like he could pass for a handsome guy like Yuri, but he looked like he lived on the street.

And let's not forget the piercings on his nose and lips. He had been "Tokhang'd."

"What the hell is going on?" I asked, my voice hoarse from disuse.

# Chapter 257: Enemy who?

## Jay-jay's POV

Sweat was dripping down my face. My wrists also stung from the bindings they had placed on me.

That bastard didn't speak to me again. He just kept talking in Japanese. Thankfully, the others seemed to have sensed this and stayed quiet.

Ryosuke Sato.

That was his name. His men called him "Ryo."

But I preferred to call him Idiot.

I was getting frustrated. I couldn't think of a way out because Mica and the others would get hurt. I couldn't even speak because they might not like what I had to say.

"You!" the idiot suddenly said, pointing at Ella. "...why are you like that?"

It was obvious that he struggled with English. I turned to look at whom he had pointed at. I wanted to slap my forehead with my hand.

"Why are they even here? I'm the only one you need, right?"

His eyes shifted to me. "Yes, but things didn't go as planned. Not with Jason."

Jason? Friday the 13th?

The guy we fought at the Gotham? The one with the cool powers? Even still alive?

"...what I want is Keifer, Yuri, and their gang," he added.

A gang? Who? The Snakes? They're not even a real gang, are they?

Besides! Their "king" wasn't even here. What, were we supposed to wait for him to return? Geez! We'd still be here by the time we got to wait for that guy to show up.

"Maybe you could just let them go? If you only have me, you can. I said, trying to reason with him."

"So you just want to be the main character?!" Freya butted in.

"Oh, what an idiot." Ella muttered under her breath, but it was loud enough for Freya to hear.

Even though Ella and I weren't exactly best friends... I agreed.

I wanted to bang my head against a wall because of these  
literally trying to get them out of here, and that's what the  
about?!

Wow... Just wow.

"Urusai!" (Shut up!) Sato suddenly yelled at us.

"WHAT?!" Freya and Honey yelled back in unison.

Sato rubbed his temples in frustration. "I said 'shut up'."

We all just nodded. The two idiots finally shut their mouths.

Sato turned away from us for a moment and spoke to one  
guy pulled something out of his pocket.

A phone.

I stared at it because it looked familiar. It had the same color.

Shit! Aries' phone!

"How did you get that?!" I demanded, my eyes locked on it.

I knew it! That text earlier wasn't from Aries! He was just  
again!

"That belongs to Aries!" Ella said, attempting to stand up.

"He was with us looking for his phone. We split up for a while, but when I came back for him, we found you guys instead," Mica explained.

No... Please, no...

I turned to Sato. "Is he here?!"

A sickening grin spread across his face before he made a hand gesture to his men. My heart started pounding even harder.

A man in a uniform walked in, dragging someone with a limp behind their head.

My heart stopped.

As they brought in a chair and forced the person to sit, Sato stepped forward and pulled off the bag.

"ARIES!" Ella and I screamed at the same time.

He looked dazed, like he had been drugged or spent an afternoon playing video games.

His gaze landed on us, and it was like he woke up from a deep sleep.

"J-Jay? Ella? What—The hell?!" He yelled when he realized he was tied.

He struggled against the bindings, but it was useless.

Ella and the others screamed in shock.

"FVCK YOU! DON'T YOU FVCKING TOUCH MY SI  
roared in pure rage.

If it weren't for the hands holding me down, I would've c  
the floor. I squeezed my eyes shut from the pain.

You bastard! I'll get you back for this later!

I forced my eyes open. I realized that each of us now hac  
behind us, gripping our arms to keep us from moving.

"Noisy, noisy." Sato sighed as he stepped closer to me.

The guy behind me yanked my hair, forcing me to look u

"I don't like noisy people," he said, and before I could re

He punched me in the stomach.

You bastard!

The guy holding me let go, and I collapsed to the floor, g  
Aries was cursing at them, thrashing in his chair.

"FACE ME, COWARD!" Aries roared, but Sato just laug

Tears welled up in my eyes from the pain, but I refused t

"Don't listen to him." Aries growled.

Sato snapped his fingers and pointed at Aries. One of his  
punched my brother.

I nearly ran to him if it weren't for this damn idiot standi

"You will do what I say, or..." Sato gestured toward Ella.  
next."

"Just do what he says!" Freya screamed at me.

"Shut up!" Rakki snapped at her. "...Or he might do som

""Rakki is right. Calix and the others might not be able to  
are too many enemies." Mica added.

"What?! Of course, they will ask the police for help. The  
down this lunatic." Honey said irritably.

"Be quiet! Let Jay-Jay decide." Ella said, her concern for

I looked at all of them. I knew they wouldn't be able to h  
Sato had planned for them. They weren't as tough as I wa

But if I called Yuri here, they might be ganged up on. W  
more men than we expected?

Tell! Whatever happens, happens!



"Y-Yuri..."

["Jay? What happened? Where are you?"]

I looked at Sato. It was clear from his expression that he response.

"Yuri..." I took a deep breath. "...there are many of them, room, and I'm not sure how many more are outside. Brin

I wasn't able to finish my sentence because Sato suddenly away and slapped me across the face.

I almost fell again, but someone grabbed me from behind

I took advantage of how close he was and spat directly on his cheek. His cheek was already numb from the two consecutive slaps

Maybe he should hit the other side next time, just to even

Sato glared at me angrily. He wiped his face with his palm. With his other hand toward one of his men for the phone.

"Send him our location and get ready," he ordered without looking at me.

"Fuzakeruna!" ("Don't mess with me!") he yelled at me.

"Fuzakeruna!" I mimicked his tone mockingly.

"Jigoku he ike!" ("Go to hell!") he yelled right in my face

You bastard! I don't care if you just cursed at me or not!

Just as my world was about to completely black out, he collapsed forward, gasping for air and coughing violently. Tears involuntarily formed at the corners of my eyes.

"I am so eager to kill you!" he said before walking away

"S-Sato." I called out to him, even though my voice barely

He turned to face me, and I glared at him.

"...just wait until I get out of here. I will make you pay for this!" he just laughed at me.

He exited the room, followed by most of his men. The others finally let go and left as well, until only two of them

"Jay..." Aries called my name.

I looked at him and forced a smile. "I-I'm okay."

"They're coming, right?" Honey asked.

"What if they can't handle the enemy?" Mica asked worriedly. "What happens to us then?"

They will come, I know it. But... will he come?

"Who was that guy earlier?" Rakki asked. "...what does I

Aries and I exchanged glances. We weren't sure if we should answer Rakki's question. If they found out that I was the real target, I would take it well.

"I remember him," Ella suddenly said. "...I've seen him there before."

"He said he wanted Yuri, Keifer, and their gang," Freya asked. "Is he a gang?"

"He was referring to Section E," I answered.

"Is that why we're here? Because he knows we're close to the target?" asked.

That could be it...

I had never thought about it before. He wouldn't have killed the others just because of me. Unless he had been watching our movements closely... or maybe even the movements of the others from Section E.

"Then why am I here? And Aries?" Mica asked, looking at Aries. "...and why is Rakki here? She's not even close to Section E."

"Whatever the reason is, I'm sure that guy is crazy," Rak staring at the door that the Idiot had just walked through. he did to Jay-Jay."

"So, what now? Are we really just going to wait for those people?" Honey asked irritably.

"Pray," Aries responded. "...Pray that they arrive with Keifer."

I looked at Honey. "You were with him. D-do you think he's still alive?"

"I don't know," she replied, avoiding my gaze.

"What do you mean you don't know?"

"I don't know! There's no way to contact him! Except through the internet, which is impossible because he's blocking all of Keifer's access to the internet in the Philippines."

Her explanation made the others turn to look at her.

"I-I don't understand," I said, shaking my head.

Honey took a deep breath. "Keifer needs to fix himself. He's been too busy for distractions because his relatives refuse to give him help. But Keigan made sure that he would have all the time in the world to fix his connections—"

If he really had no connection to us, then there's no way person as my textmate, the one who always seemed high talked to him.

We all fell silent. Listening, thinking about what could h

It was only now that I realized how maddening silence c

I subtly tried to loosen the rope binding my hands, but ev it just made the pain worse.

So frustrating! Nothing useful was coming to mind.

I looked at Aries, who was also looking at me. Concern his face. I wanted to ask if he had a plan, but the two gua us and Rakki's group were keeping a close eye.

"It's so hot in here! Don't you guys have air conditioning

We all sighed. She was really more concerned about the than her own life.

The two guards ignored her, only glancing at her briefly to their conversation.

"Oh, so now they're pretending to be deaf! And they're n Freya muttered loudly.

"C... .."

It must've been half an hour of us just sitting here, waiting for something to happen, when suddenly, the Idiot Bastard, Sato, walked in.

He was even smiling, his teeth shining so much it made a few of us blink.

Please don't sing! Please don't sing!

"He's here," he said, looking behind us.

We all turned to follow his gaze.

The old, rotting wooden door creaked open, revealing the darkness we had been desperate to see.

He was followed by two of Sato's men. He walked toward us, his eyes locked on mine.

"Y-Yuri..." I barely whispered.

He gave me a small smile before stopping and turning to look at the others.

"Let them go now," Yuri ordered seriously.

Sato laughed loudly. "No!" he suddenly shouted. "I said, let them go, your gang."

He was still searching for the Snakes and their King.

We all turned to look.

A thin, termite-infested plywood panel had collapsed. A stood up, dusting himself off.

I glanced at Yuri just in time to see him slap his forehead.

Looks like this one messed up.

"Why was that wood so weak?" the small person—more complained.

"Ci-N?" Ella said.

He turned to us, looking like an innocent child.

He glanced at me and Yuri before flashing a wide grin.

"Torplise!" he said, raising both hands.

"Get him!" Sato yelled, but before they could move, a se erupted from outside.

"Someone got in!" someone shouted.

I looked at Yuri.

He had backup. He wasn't alone!

I looked at the people in front of me.

They were all rushing.

"Get the car!" Sato ordered one of his men.

A car? They're taking me away!

I struggled against the man holding me, but since they were so fast  
I ended up stumbling onto the floor.

Sato started cursing in Japanese.

I recognized some of the words—definitely insults.

Then, out of nowhere, he grabbed my hair and yanked me back.

I screamed in pain.

Even with thick hair, it wasn't enough to support my weight.

"Kisama! Ama!" (You! Bitch!) he shouted.

All I could do was kick my feet in frustration.

I couldn't stop the tears from falling.

I hated this feeling of being powerless.



Fueled by anger, he grabbed something hard and started

I quickly rolled onto my stomach, trying to protect my face from the next targets.

"Stop it! STOP IT!" I screamed, my voice laced with desperation.

He finally stopped after a few more strikes, most of which hit my shoulders and arms.

Some hit my thighs and legs, too.

I wanted to cry out loud from the pain.

I couldn't move anymore.

It felt like this was how he planned to kill me.

But I was wrong.

I heard the sound of a gun being cocked.

He was going to shoot me.

"Go to hell now!"

Someone... anyone... please... help.

# Chapter 258: Black and w

## Jay-jay's POV

I held back my tears and my breath. I felt like with just one blow my skull would be shattered. Even without looking, I could feel the pressure pressed against the back of my head.

I've been held at gunpoint many times before, but as time goes on, the weight of it feels heavier and heavier. It's like death is getting closer.

"Aaarrggghhh!!" Sato let out a loud scream, followed by a loud gunshot.

I screamed loudly, thinking I had been hit, but I didn't feel pain. I died instantly, and that's why. I opened my eyes, and through my tears, I could still see my surroundings.

This is no joke! I might really die here.

Can it wait? There are still people who owe me money. I have things to do with the Ulupong yet. I haven't punched their King yet. My Dad yet. Maybe after all that, then it's fine.

Once again, one of them grabbed me and forced me to sit

witch, but that wasn't what I was worried about. I needed him!

Suddenly, Sato lost his temper and started kicking his men. Holding me wasn't spared. He was like a child throwing a tantrum when he didn't get what he wanted. When he ran out of targets, he turned his anger at me again.

"I want you dead! You're going to die! Your friends will be killed!" he shouted, pressing the gun against my head.

"That's not true!" I replied, but he kept shouting and pointing the gun at me.

"No one will help you! You will die here! I will kill you!"

"NO!" I shouted back at him with all my strength. "They will save me!"

They're already here!

"They will not make it! My men will defeat them!"

He really wanted to have a shouting match with me. If only he could. To make it worse, his spit kept landing on my face.

I know what he's doing. He's trying to take away my hope for it. What does he think of me? A child?!

"Nice! She trusts us!" said Mayo, raising his eyebrows.

"Trust trust, baby!" said Drew, even dancing a little.

"Wow... Trust." Josh chimed in, his tone obviously sarcastic.

I smiled, but it quickly disappeared when I felt the cold metal against my head again. At the same time, he grabbed my arm from moving away. Here we go again!

They all tensed up. Some tried to approach, but the idiot pushed me harder against my head.

"Easy..." said Felix.

"Where are Yuri and Keifer?" he asked the Ulupong.

The crazy guys looked at each other. No one could answer. I'm about to die, and he still won't show up. What else can I do? Maybe I'll be buried and rotting in a coffin, and he'll still be here.

Damn you, Keifer! You're really the worst!

I'll feed you my mismatched socks. Traitor! So annoying on your gums! I'll flick your teeth! I'll rip out your esophagus!

"Dammit! Let me go! That bastard isn't coming!" I shouted.

If I'm annoyed with Sato, I'm annoyed with you at that point.

"H-he's here," I said, scanning the area. When I couldn't see him, I said, "Ulupong. Is he here? Is he here?"

"W-who? Who's here?" Sato asked, panicking.

Your mom's here!

It looked like he was starting to feel fear. He slowly dragged my idiot classmates. But it was pointless because they are all here. Even if we ran, we'd still be seen wherever we went.

"Let her go now!" someone shouted.

If I wasn't mistaken, that was Yuri's voice.

"Let her go... Let her go..." another voice sang, just like I

I couldn't be wrong—that was Percy's voice.

"Let go of my sister!" That voice belonged to Horoscope.

From the side of the building we had just come from, the voices slowly walked forward. It started with my brother, then my other brother and Yuri.

I thought that was it, but time seemed to slow down when I saw them. When I saw them stepping onto the dusty ground, moving upward to the building.

Oh wow!

Wow, really?! Out of everything, that's what he focused on? That's the only feeling when you just want to curse out of frustration? Yes.

"You idiot! That's what you're worried about?! You bastard!"

I wanted to reach for his face so I could punch him, but I couldn't. This damn Sato was still holding me. I couldn't even hug him. I couldn't even hit him.

He grinned again, that annoying, infuriating grin. His perfect, white, behind-lips that didn't need any coloring. He ruffled his hair before finally pulling off his tie and throwing it aside along with the rest of his clothes.

Why does he look even more handsome—ugh! Stop! That's not right now!

"I came back straight from London, and you call me an idiot? A bastard?" he asked, raising an eyebrow. "...No. I miss you."

You son of a—!

"You idiot! We literally saw each other yesterday!" I yelled.

He nodded. "Yeah, and you cursed me out, didn't you?"

Damn it! Why did he have to bring that up?! There were

"The sky is so pretty," I muttered, but Sato suddenly tightened his grip on me.

"Ahhh... Ouch!" I screamed.

I almost forgot this idiot was still here. The damn King just kept drawing my attention.

"Let go of Jay-jay now," Yuri said, glaring at Sato.

Sato pressed the gun harder against my head. I was scared, but I also felt something else. I couldn't explain it, but my heart felt like it was in a situation like this would send me into a panic, but now I was calm.

All of them... All four of them.

I felt like everything was going to be okay. I felt safe even though I was in their arms yet.

"Let go of my Baby Sister. Isn't our handsomeness enough for you?" Percy boasted.

I saw Felix slap his forehead. Even I wanted to do the same thing if they were still tied.

"Don't call her Baby Sister. She's my sister, not yours," A

Aries, with his ever-grumpy face. He held my fate in his hands. No matter how angry he always seemed, I loved him. No matter how important he was to me. And that scowling face of his reminded me of the lecture I was going to survive later—because I was going to survive.

I turned to the far end.

Yuri's serious expression. His red hair made him look like a man with anger. But despite that, he was strong because, after what happened between us, he was still here. That red hair reminded me of the time just a while ago, he would be hugging me, showing how much he cared.

And lastly...

Damn it!

The annoying, frustrating, bastard face of the damn King.

He reminded me that I was going to punch him later. That he would pay for everything he did to me. That he would explain everything he did.

"YOU BASTARD! LET ME GO!" I screamed at Sato, shaking my arm.

For some reason, he seemed to snap and, with all his strength, he pushed me away. I crashed onto the dusty ground, but at the same time, he pointed his gun at me.



"Let me go back! Something might happen to them!" I p  
ignored me.

It took a few more moments before they stopped and put  
body felt so heavy, and I felt like I couldn't breathe.

"Untie her!" Kit's voice ordered, and someone removed t  
hands.

I was weak, and my throat was completely dry. I fixed m  
that was all over my face. I also wiped my face with my

I was gasping for air as I looked around. We were still in  
already close to the exit. Some stood in front of me while  
helping Mica.

"Jay-jay." Ella called me. "...Where's Aries?" Her voice v  
worry.

"H-he's outside... They're facing Sato and the rest of his 1

"Where does it hurt?" Eren asked me.

My whole body, and even my soul.

But I couldn't answer. I wanted to cry. They shouldn't ha  
from there—how would I know if they were okay?

~~~~~

I shifted my gaze to the lovers—Mica and Calix. They were kissing. Calix kept kissing his girlfriend's forehead.

Okay... They're still annoyingly sweet.

"He hurt you, didn't he?" David asked, making me look at him.

"...Your cheek is starting to bruise."

I didn't care about those bruises. I wanted to go back out there to see if I could know if they were okay. I had to be sure that this Sato was not a threat.

I didn't know how much longer we had to wait, but my attention was drawn to us as we suddenly heard a series of gunshots. I immediately ran towards the source of the noise, but David blocked my way.

Ella ran too, but Edrix stopped her.

"Get out of my way!" I shouted at David.

"Stay here!" Denzel responded.

"Something might have happened to Aries!" Ella cried, running towards the sound.

"Sorry... But this is their fight." Rory said sadly.

"Why? Am I not part of this? We're here because we got involved in the fight!" I couldn't help but break down.

Half an hour had passed. We hadn't heard any more sound. My mind was racing with all sorts of thoughts, but none of them were good.

I felt someone sit beside me. I didn't bother checking who it was.

"Jay-jay." It was Ci-N. "...I have something to tell you," he said. I didn't respond. "...I rarely get to talk to Keifer. But when I do, he always asks the first thing he asks about. Sometimes, you're even our top priority."

I didn't react, even though this was the first time I was hearing him.

"He was always worried about you. He even wondered if you were still alive." he added.

If only you knew, Ci...

There were so many times I wanted to give up. I even tried to, but I failed.

"He also said that you have big—"

I immediately shot him a sharp glare. he grinned mischievously. I couldn't tell if he was serious or just messing with me.

"Seriously?" I asked.

he shook his head. "Just kidding... I just wanted to see if you were conscious or if you had already fainted without us knowing."

he laughed first. "He was always looking at you, so he noticed your body and your movements."

He was looking at me? I don't know why, but something his statement made me feel weird.

Well, he used to sit behind me, so I had no idea what he was doing.

"He better be ready for me when he comes back." I threatened. He just laughed at me.

"This is taking too long!" Honey complained.

"You can go home if you're getting impatient," Felix said at him.

"I'm waiting for Percy." She replied.

"I have no one to wait for. Can I go home now?" Freya asked, annoyed.

"W-we should all go home together... J-just to make sure we're all together to you guys." Edrix said.

For a few moments, they continued arguing about whether to leave. Felix kept trying to send Honey home, while Edrix argued the opposite with Freya.

~~~~~

"What happened? Whose blood is that?" I asked as we saw

I knew it wasn't his because the blood wasn't concentrated

"Are you okay, bro?" Felix asked as he appeared beside me.

Percy looked at his clothes and smiled at us. He was about to say something when someone suddenly pushed Felix and me aside.

Damn it...

"Percy!" Honey called out dramatically, arms open for a hug.

But Percy's reflexes were quick. He pushed Honey away before she could reach him. "Get off me, statue."

"Hm! Witch!" He muttered, followed by Felix's loud laughter.

"Aw... Did you really have to push me that hard?" Honey whined.

But Percy's attention had already shifted. He was now staring at Freya, who looked absolutely annoyed.

"Frey-aaaa!" He yelled as he ran toward her with his arms outstretched.

But Percy must have forgotten that Freya was just as fast as he was. Before he could reach her, she pushed him away, making him fall like a toppled doll.

"Don't touch me!" Freya said with disgust.

"Whatever." She added before turning around to face Ed from her. "...You!" She called out. "...Since you're so per me outside. I'm bored in here!"

Edrix nodded and followed Freya out of the building. Pe slumped as he turned to us, but he quickly forced a smile

"I fall even harder for her every time she gets mad at me cheerfully.

But that wasn't what I wanted to know.

"Where's the rest? Why are you the only one here?" I ask

"W-where's Aries? Where is he?" Ella asked worriedly.

Percy's smile slowly faded. It felt like something kicked ache.

He always joked around with us, but at this moment, I w

.

# Chapter 259: White & Rec

## Jay-jay's POV

I heard Ella sobbing behind me. Even I wanted to cry but I said anything yet, but the serious look on his face was et heavily on our hearts.

"Where is he?!" Ella's voice was pleading.

"P-Percy... Where's Aries?" I asked.

He bowed his head for a moment before sighing. "Aries. held my breath, afraid I might break down completely. " He glanced behind us. "...There! He's coming!"

I immediately turned to look where he was pointing. His and there were a few bloodstains, about the same amount walking straight toward us, as if nothing bad had happen

Ella immediately ran toward him and was met with a tig

Okay... Let the girlfriend have her moment first, then the theirs later.

Once I made sure he was okay, I immediately turned to f

I turned back to Aries, who was still hugging Ella. I didn't because I didn't want to disturb them. I was just happy to be safe and that nothing bad had happened to him.

A few seconds later, Aries looked at me. He let go of Ella and walked over to me. I didn't hesitate to meet him with a hug.

"That damn Percy! I thought something terrible had happened," I said, burying my face in his chest.

I'll deal with that lunatic later.

"It's okay... It's over now. No one's going to mess with you," he whispered to me before letting go of the hug. "...what happened to your face?"

"It's Sato... The guy who pulled me away from you earlier... he started showing now."

He hugged me again and kissed my forehead. "Sato's dead."

I was shocked and let go of him. D-dead? How? Who? What? I wanted to get to take revenge on him.

It was hard to believe. Yes, I was angry at him, but I never thought where I wished for him to die. I'm not that cruel. I'm just

"W-who—?"



"We're not getting back together, if that's what you're thinking," the Horoscope guy answered, and my smile faded.

"Why were you together?"

"Because you needed us. But that's as far as it goes."

What a shame...

He patted my head before leaving to go back to Ella. I was glad that they were okay now. But do they always have to be?

My worry for Aries was gone, but now I was annoyed with them. Why do they really have to scare us like that?

Now it was just Yuri and their annoying King who were causing the trouble. Why were they taking so long? I couldn't help but think that.

I must have paced back and forth several times already. I was following the same path the two of them had taken, hoping to see them come back.

"Eww... Stay away! You're disgusting!" I heard Percy shout at Honey.

Serves you right! That's karma!

"Wow, you're the one disgusted by me? You've got some nerve!"

"Because you're the center of my solar system," the Bata giggling.

It was obvious that he was the only one thrilled by his ov Rakki just sighed in response.

At least they could enjoy themselves now. Meanwhile, I because of my worries. On top of that, I was getting hun terrible when I was hungry.

I might just start biting people.

"Should we call the police now?" I heard Drew ask.

"Let's wait for Keifer and the others first," Eren replied.

"That's exactly why we should call the police. What if th Drew said, making me shoot him a sharp glare.

"J-just kidding," he quickly added upon noticing me.

"Your joke isn't funny!" I snapped. "How about I make s  
*you*

don't make it?"

"If you're going to crack jokes, do it with a drunk person

"But don't do it with Jee-jee, who's already worried sick

gotten my revenge. Not even a single flick to his forehead.

Then, I turned back to where Percy and Aries had come. The weight on my shoulders lessened slightly when I saw Yuri.

I smiled, ready to run toward him, but then I noticed his so much blood—so much that anyone would assume it was his.

I swallowed hard. Turns out I wasn't ready. I thought I could have already gone numb from worrying too much. But I've paid much attention to the bloodstains on Aries and Percy's clothes. They were just splatters. But Yuri's clothes...

There was just

*too much*

.

Yuri greeted me with a smile, but when he noticed me staring, he immediately stopped in his tracks.

"Is that your blood?" I asked anxiously, my fear evident.

"No, it's not mine," he assured me before removing his undershirt, which had blood on it.

He stared at his bloodstained clothes for a moment before he hit him. He let go of his polo and took off his undershirt.

My eyes widened. That idiot was now

*topless*

. The worst part? My eyes were stuck on his body.

I had seen him shirtless a few times before, but I didn't know I always felt

*new*

to me.

Can someone hand me some peanut butter for this bread?

I didn't hear another word from him. He took long, hurried breaths like he was racing against time.

In the blink of an eye, I was pressed against his bare chest, his arms wrapped around me.

"Please ignore the fact that I'm topless," he muttered.

How could I ignore it?! His body was so

*warm*

"Sorry. I had to call our embassy... and my

*Otosan*

."

"You scared me," I admitted, hugging him even tighter.

He didn't say anything, but I felt him place a kiss on my

I don't know, but something about his embrace felt different. I was feeling a certain kind of fear.

I was about to ask when those damn idiots started yelling

"That's so indecent!"

"There are innocent people here!"

"Have some shame!"

"These two are being way too lewd!"

"Don't look at them, Mica!"

We weren't planning on paying them any attention, but suddenly a man stood up near us, eyes wide as he pointed toward the sanatorium. Aries, and Yuri had come from.

wrong!

Yeah, that's right!

I immediately turned to face the little brat, but the slipper already run away, laughing loudly along with the others.

"You little punk! I should tie you and Percy together!"

Speaking of Keifer... why wasn't he here yet?

"Yuri..." I called out to him as he picked up his clothes. 'happen to Keifer? Why isn't he back yet?"

Yuri didn't even look at me. He walked closer, holding h patted my shoulder with a sorrowful expression.

"M-maybe he just had to talk to someone. Let's wait a lit forcing a smile.

I wanted to ask more, but he had already walked past me didn't want to talk anymore.

I wasn't sure if I should apologize to him. I knew I had h did, it would feel like I was admitting I did it on purpose

I chose to stay silent. I didn't want to add to his pain. I di him even more.

At first, I thought they were just messing with me again, footsteps. Slow but heavy.

I froze. My heartbeat matched each step he took. I forgot to do.

Not far from me, he appeared—wearing his coat, without blood. His necktie was wrapped around his right hand, he used it for punching.

His face, though, looked the same. There was no sign of

And here I was again, feeling something strange. Why did this whenever I saw him? I never used to be like this before cry, but at the same time, I wanted to smile just because I wanted to hug him, but I also wanted to punch him.

This man was going to drive me insane!

"Keifer..." Ci-N called out to him, walking toward him.

Keifer stopped right where I had been waiting for him earlier talking, but we couldn't hear what they were saying.

He glanced at me for a second but didn't react at all.

It felt like a stab to my heart.

~~~~~

Like I was a ghost.

"Whoa... Jay-jay just got ignored," Drew commented, raising his voice.

I suddenly felt the urge to punch him.

I

knew

! I

knew

I was being ignored! Did he really have to rub it in my face? The billboard missing was a giant billboard saying

Keifer ignored Jay-jay

, plastered right in front of me.

I rolled my eyes at Drew.

All I could do now was watch Keifer. That was all I could do. I couldn't even bring myself to chase after him.

But that changed the moment I saw what he did when he saw Ella.

He looked at her!

HE LOOKED AT HIS EX-GIRLFRIEND!

Oh, hell no! This bastard was really pushing my buttons!

He ignored me, but he

looked

at his ex?!

What the hell?! Was something going on that I didn't know?

I wasn't the jealous type. I wasn't quick to get jealous. No.

Not at all.

NOT AT ALL!

Why would I even be jealous? Was there even something there?
Was there?!

WAS THERE?!

He just

looked

, but the person he swore his love to, the person he prom
—he just walked past.

"Are you okay, Jay? Do you need to use the bathroom?"
watching my face.

I ignored him completely.

I was annoyed.

I was so annoyed because I

shouldn't

be annoyed—but I was.

That was such a

dick move

.

You

shouldn't

be jealous of an ex. That's the whole point of being an

ex

ex

, then why look?! Why turn his damn head?!

Does he want to never turn his head again for the rest of

Should I just snap his neck right now?!

"You bastard..." I muttered under my breath.

Out of sheer frustration, I took off my shoe and threw it :

It hit him right on the back, making him stop in his track

"Jay!" Yuri scolded me.

I ignored him and grabbed my other shoe to throw again

It hit him squarely on the head, making him bow slightly

I only then realized that everyone was staring at me. Even
eyebrows were furrowed deeply. Percy just stood there, c
what I had done.

"Oh, Jay... Your socks don't match!" Ci pointed out while

Oh, wow! Thank you for mentioning that!

Now everyone was staring at my mismatched socks—on

He slowly straightened up, letting out a deep sigh. He turned his serious eyes. I couldn't read any anger in them.

He had no right to be angry at me!

He even picked up my shoes and socks and handed them to the closest to him.

"Done?" he asked, emotionless.

I couldn't answer. I felt embarrassed by that one word alone. It grew. I wanted to charge at him, but my feet wouldn't move.

"...If you're done, then I'm leaving," he added, about to turn his back.

Oh, hell no!

"That's what you're good at! Turning your back and leaving!"

"...Go ahead! Leave! That's all you ever do! The only thing you're good at is a fistfight!"

"J-Jay... That's enough," I heard Rory trying to stop me.

"Let Keifer be. Maybe he just has something important to say." Denzel added.

"Oh, really?!" I replied sarcastically. "Something important to say about running away?"

"This isn't the right time to talk about that," Percy said so surprised me.

He rarely got serious, and when he did, it usually wasn't

But I chose to ignore him and kept my focus on this dam

"If you're leaving, then leave," I said quietly. "...But I can't
will be anything left for you to come back to."

Because I didn't know if I could keep waiting.

"Done?" he asked again, which irritated me even more. I
cursing at him, I could only nod.

I thought he would leave. I thought he would turn his back
walk away.

But I was wrong.

Something in him seemed to snap. He took large, fast steps
looking extremely serious.

I wanted to step back, but before I could, his hands grabbed

"You talk too much," he said before quickly pressing his

I heard the Ulupong and everyone else react to what was
my mind was blank

"KEIFER!" I screamed loudly.

Something was wrong! What was happening?

The Ulupong quickly ran toward us. They tried to lift Keifer but he could move. As soon as I could, I looked at him.

He was unconscious, his lips pale. I didn't understand! He was here a moment ago!

"Keifer! W-what's happening? Open your eyes!" I said, trying to shake him.

Damn it! You owe me!

"Move aside!" Yuri's voice called out as he pushed past the others, blocking his way.

He knelt in front of Keifer and turned him over. Even though I was confused, I let him do it, hoping he knew what to do.

Yuri lifted Keifer's coat, and I froze at what I saw.

Blood was flowing from his back.

I thought he didn't have any wounds from earlier. But it was hidden from us.

They tore open Keifer's shirt, and two puncture wounds were visible. Blood was flowing out like a leaking faucet.

"I'm already doing it!" Percy responded.

While they were busy helping their wounded King, I just
unable to move.

I stared at my hands, only now realizing they were stained
Fresh, warm blood. I could even smell its metallic scent.

Move! Keifer needs you!

I couldn't. I felt dizzy. My stomach churned.

There was so much blood. It felt like someone was about

I hated this feeling.

I couldn't stop trembling. It reached deep into my core.

"JAY! WHAT ARE YOU DOING?!" Yuri shouted at me

"...Help us!"

I shook my head frantically. "I-I c-can't... G-get him a-a-

I felt their eyes on me—filled with confusion and judgment

"...P-please, I'm b-begging you."

Chapter 260: Pay him a visit

Jay-jay's POV

I haven't changed. I didn't lose consciousness. I didn't hurt. I was just knowing. But why?

"Jay-jay," Kuya Angelo called me.

Oh, it's just him!

I didn't notice his arrival. I thought he was just one of the guys going in and out of our room.

"Huh?" was all I could reply.

"Where is Aries?" he asked as he set down the briefcase on the sofa near Aries' bed.

"H-he's in the canteen. With Ella."

Kuya walked over to me and sat on Aries' bed, which was mine. He looked exhausted from work again.

But of course, he still looked handsome.

"Why did you come here? You could have gone home find him rubbing his temple.

"The Sato guy..." he began. "...apparently knows Tiger."

What the...? PPAP?!

My eyes widened at what he said. That crazy guy who once said he'd turn his yellow hair black.

"H-how?"

"That lunatic knows a lot of people. I wouldn't be surprised if they know each other," he sighed.

Knows? That guy can't even remember names properly. He's probably been eaten by his own cringiness.

I watched Kuya's troubled expression. It seemed like he was overthinking it. Like he was holding back a fart or a burp.

"Is there a problem?"

He shook his head and forced a smile at me. "Nothing serious."

I wasn't convinced by his answer. I felt like there was a catch. He was getting nervous. Who knows what's about to happen next.

Shit! Maybe I won the lottery without even knowing it!

I blinked rapidly. "Get me out of here. Please."

"Why?" he asked, confused.

"I'll be the one to crack that damn Tiger's skull open! Th
angrily.

Kuya shook his head. "He's not a traitor."

"What do you mean he's not? He's the one who gave out
us!"

That's probably why Rakki and the others got involved e
didn't need to be. Who knows what he told Sato. Of cour
believed him.

Heaven forbid!

"Tiger is talkative. He's like a walking newspaper. I thinl
blabbed about you," Kuya explained.

Even if it was accidental, he still shouldn't have given ou
that. What if Death itself asks him next time? That migh
ends our lives.

"I'm still going to slap him!"

"I'll do it for you," he replied.

"You panicked again when you saw blood."

I looked away. I didn't want to talk about it. Even Aries looked away about it, but I chose not to answer him.

Kuya seemed to notice what I was doing. He let out a deep breath.

He stood up and walked toward the door. "I'll go see Aries."

"O-okay."

All I heard was the door closing. I slumped back onto the floor, looking at the ceiling.

I was relieved that I hadn't changed after seeing blood. But a question was swirling in my mind after we were all rushed to the hospital.

At that moment, I wanted to get away from all of them. I wanted to help Keifer. I really wanted to help him. I wanted to do what he did. The fear of blood and the fear that my vision might take over me. The fear of blood and the fear that my vision might take over me. The fear of blood and the fear that my vision might take over me.

I turned to my side. I was ashamed of myself. After he saw me, I acted like I was fine.

How shameless of me.

I wasn't ashamed of him anymore. He got shot saving us.

"Psst! Jay-jay," the voice called my name in a whisper.

I grabbed the blanket wrapped around me up to my waist exactly why I hate staying in hospitals—because of situa

Then, I felt someone's presence behind me. That whistling approaching again. I squeezed my eyes shut tightly.

Damn it! Just don't show yourself to me!

Suddenly, something hit my arm. I screamed loudly and of the bed.

"STAY AWAY FROM ME! GHOST!" I shouted, struggli

"Ghost, my foot!" said a familiar voice, making me stop

Or rather, look at THEM.

The Brat was grinning widely beside me. Felix stood not course, his brother was there too, always carrying his pet conditioner.

"Didn't you hear us knocking and opening the door?" Fe

"Of course not. They're out of it," Percy answered for me

He walked over to Aries' bed and lay down. He better hope doesn't catch him, or he'll get hit. Or get beside me, as I

I averted my gaze. I was happy to hear that he was awake and facing him. Not anymore.

"J-just tell him I'm resting," I told them.

"That won't work!" Felix quickly replied.

I raised an eyebrow at him.

"He's asking for you," Percy said in a bored tone, eyes still fixed on the ground. "Don't go there, he'll come here himself."

That stubborn idiot.

"That's why you should just come with us! We even brought food for you," Ci said with a smile, pointing beside Felix.

I frowned. "What am I? A cripple?!"

"It's so we can bring you to him carefully," Felix said.

"I told you we should've just wrapped them in bubble wrap," Ci mumbled as he scratched his foot, then sniffed his finger.

Gross!

"Then we could put them in a balikbayan box too. Genius," Ci said sarcastically.

Percy now looked like a kid about to lose an argument. He got up from where he was sprawled on the bed and pointed at Ci.

"Y-you!" he stammered, but he couldn't think of anything else.
"...Shorty!"

And now it got personal!

Ci's nostrils flared. He looked pissed at what Percy had called him. He got up straight just to clap back.

"UNCIRCUMCISED!" he fired back.

Percy immediately grabbed his belt and acted like he was in a hurry.

"You wanna check?!" he challenged.

I instantly grabbed my pillow and covered my eyes, while Ci looked at him.

"Hey! Hey! Hey! Are you crazy?! There's a girl here!" he yelled.

"It's his fault!" Percy pointed at Ci and fixed his belt. "...uncircumcised one! If anything, he is the one who hasn't fixed his."

"I'm only 15, you idiot!"

"Hey! I wasn't like that when I was 15!"

They're insane!

"Could you guys argue outside instead? You're making noise and they all turned to look at me at the same time.

"Should I call a doctor?" Percy asked in a panic.

I rolled my eyes at him. "Just go outside. I'd feel better."

"What about Keifer?" the Brat asked.

"Just tell him I'll go later... when I feel better."

When I can face him.

"O-okay. Get some rest first," Ci said before walking out and Percy.

Finally! Peace and quiet again!

I fixed my pillow and lay back down. I wanted to sleep, but the house was already rumbling. I was getting hungry—not a good

Aries and the others were taking too long. They were supposed to bring food, but they still hadn't come back. My brother went outside and he hadn't returned yet.

Then, my phone rang from the bedside table.

conversations.

With every message he sends, it really slaps me in the face. But how is that possible? On his birthday, there was a picture of that GagongBaliw group.

There's one way I can find out who he really is. But the price will be huge—a large amount of prepaid load.

Where can I buy load?

I checked my balance inquiry, hoping I had at least a peso. I called my older brother and ask him to load me up.

While waiting, the door suddenly burst open with a bang. I was about to start a fight. I jumped in surprise and almost dropped my phone.

"Son of a—" I muttered under my breath, waiting for the person who slammed the door to reveal themselves.

And I didn't have to wait long because out came... a Bunyavee.

"Where is Percy?!" she demanded angrily as she stormed into the room.

She didn't even wait for my answer. She immediately locked the door and even opened the bathroom door. What's this all about now?

"What's going on?" I asked, looking at her.

What's her problem? Should I just pull her hair?

"That annoying Percy! I even wore my favorite costume just went into hiding again!" she complained, almost on

I felt a little bad for her. She really puts in a lot of effort. I keeps avoiding her.

That guy's an idiot too. Why doesn't he just talk to her properly stop playing this game of hide and seek?

"Why are you even wearing a costume? Are you crazy?"

She rolled her eyes at me again. "Obviously, for Percy."

I cleared my throat and got serious. If Percy can't do it, I Honey looks so pitiful.

"You know... if I were you, I'd stop chasing after Percy. You're just making a fool out of you?"

She immediately glared at me but didn't say anything.

I continued, "We're not even friends, and I shouldn't be in your business. But you're making a fool of yourself in front of everyone who are laughing at you. Your beauty is wasted if you keep this up."

But of course, I'm still prettier!

I looked at the bedroom door, relieved that it was closed.

She took off the trench coat, revealing what she was real

The idiot was in a bunny costume.

Why does this outfit seem familiar to me? I paused for a thought.

Bunny? Bunny? Bunny?! BUNNY?!

Damn it! The Halloween party last year! That's where I had the dinner for Keigan's girlfriend's birthday.

But wait, something suddenly came to mind.

"Honey..." I called her while she struggled to reach the zippers.
"...Do you remember when we saw each other at the Halloween party last year?"

She glanced at me. "Did we?"

"Yes... And then the next time we met was at the dinner for my girlfriend's birthday."

"Oh, the time you punched me! I almost ran to a plastic surgeon because of that."

She was still trying to reach the zipper of her outfit

No wonder he didn't care when Honey flirted with him r
That guy really is insane—his mind changes all the time

I see now. That guy is full of nonsense.

"Help me take this off!" Honey ordered.

Finally, she asked for help. I was already feeling uncomfort
watching her struggle.

I was about to reach for the zipper when the door sudden
walked my older brother, Angelo.

"Jay-jay, have you eaten—?" He stopped mid-sentence v

"...Sorry."

"Angelo... Nice to see you again," Bumblebee greeted hi

"H-hi," my brother awkwardly replied.

He was trying to look at me, but his eyes automatically k
Honey's body.

I frowned. Men really are all the same. Not even my own
exception.

Men are all the same!

"Why do I have this weird feeling?" she said, raising an eyebrow.
"...When I look at Angelo, it's like I'm seeing Keifer. Especially at his birthday party. They look like brothers."

Well, that's natural. They were always together before.

"Even Yuri and Aries have similarities with your brother."

She looked at me as if deep in thought. "You don't get it. It's that intimidating aura that I also feel whenever I see Angelo. It's just... connected."

I thought about it. There were times when my brother seemed to have that same aura. But I also saw that in Aries and Yuri. Sometimes even in Yuri. Often.

"Maybe you're just imagining things," I said.

"You know, he could pass as their brother—Keifer, Keiger. Plus, they kind of look alike. Could he be their long-lost brother?"

I swear I'm going to punch this girl! She's thinking of the wrong person.

"Do they look like they're missing a sibling?" I said sarcastically.

"Whatever. Just unzip it already," she commanded before turning away from me.

~~~~~

"Cover yourself up! You look embarrassing!" he scolded

"What the hell?! I'm changing!" Honey protested.

"Change somewhere else! I like your outfit—err, I mean in front of Jay-jay! Her brother might walk in!" he insisted the coat on her.

What the heck?

Honey had no choice as Felix grabbed her clothes and by the hand and started dragging her out.

"What's your problem? Let me go!" she protested, struggling stronger.

Before they reached the door, I suddenly remembered so I yelled it out so I wouldn't have to disturb them.

"Felix! Load me up!" I shouted.

"Sure! Even 1000 pesos!" he replied.

They finally left, and everything became quiet again. No one was there, and what was really important.

Eat! Let's eat!

# Part Two End: GagongBal

## Jay-jay's POV

Felix really meant what he said—he actually loaded ₱100. The question is, what am I supposed to do with this? I do much.

I could get unlimited calls for just ₱100. Felix the Cat released. Anyway, at least I have load now. I can finally do what I want to catch GagongBaliw (CrazyFool).

If you're not Keifer, I don't know who you are anymore.

I texted the idiot first.

**To: GagongBaliw**

**Message:**

*Hey!*

It only took a few seconds before he replied.

**From: GagongBaliw**

He didn't reply anymore, so I figured he was already waiting.

I pressed the call button and held the phone to my ear. It rang before he answered. As usual, he didn't speak.

"Hey! GagongBaliw! I know you're listening!" I said, but he didn't respond.

"...I have a secret to tell you. Just between us! Don't spread it."

I heard a soft chuckle, but it was brief. I got serious and asked,

"There's someone I love. I won't say who. He told me he loved me, but I found out he was only fooling me. He used me, but he didn't care."

I started feeling my breathing tighten.

I know I've told this story so many times, but I can't help remembering it makes me want to cry again. Damn it! I tried to hold it back. I can't afford to cry—I need to execute my plan.

"...I tried to find out if he ever really loved me despite everything I said he didn't. It hurt so much, but what could I do? That was the end, I thought. That's all I could do. I thought that was the end of it, but he didn't stop. He kept making me feel that he had feelings for me, even though I knew he didn't."

I couldn't stop my tears anymore. I kept looking up, hoping he would fall, but it was useless. Damn it! My eyes are turning into

I broke down into sobs. That wasn't supposed to be part of the plan. I blurted it out before I could stop myself.

"...Maybe I should just give up. Maybe I should finally let

The call suddenly ended.

I couldn't hold back my tears anymore. I had so many reasons to stay, but I really didn't want to. I was willing to find even just one person waiting for him.

But after what happened the other day, I feel like I have no choice. I didn't even get to help him after he saved me.

I'm not the girl for him. I'm worthless. I must be so shameful that he expects him to fight for me after what I did.

I need to stop him.

If you really are Keifer, you'll come here right now—become the King I know would do.

I gripped my phone tightly while staring at the door. If he was still in that door now, I'm ready to make up for my mistakes and

But if he doesn't... I'll give up.

Hours passed, but no one entered the room. I stopped cry



But Aries returned, and my brother and Ella already went to bed. They never came.

He really isn't the one texting me.

"Go to sleep," Aries said when he noticed I was still wide awake.

I turned my back on him while lying down, hugging my knees.

Any moment now, I might start crying again.

It's already 2 AM—Keifer isn't coming.

I forced myself to sleep even though my mind was still racing.

He's not coming.

I kept waking up because I was sleeping so lightly. I thought I was drifting off, but then I'd wake up again. It kept happening.

A little later, I heard Aries moving around. He was talking on his phone and then walked out.

I shut my eyes again, forcing myself to sleep. I needed to sleep. When I woke up, this heavy feeling in my chest would be gone.

I wasn't in deep sleep yet when I felt someone sit beside me.

He stroked my hair and whispered something.

I felt him kiss my forehead.

*"I can't live without you..."*

Something wet dripped onto my cheek.

*"...When I come back, I won't just promise—I will fight f*

He kissed me again—but this time, on the lips. It was a l  
with hesitation.

*"...But please, don't give up. I love you, Jay..."*

I felt him move away from me. He stood up from where  
earlier.

*"I love you until scientists find the end of the universe."*

I forced myself to wake up.

I tried to move my body.

When I finally opened my eyes, the first thing I did was

But he wasn't there.

There was no one.

Only the darkness of the room greeted me.

He was here! He came!

And damn it!

That bastard stole a kiss from me!

## **End of Part Two**

+++++



## **Author's Note**



So there! Ending already, no continuation!

Just kidding... Of course not!

I had so many plans back in Part One, but they changed 1  
finish

*AMNSE*

, and then I changed my mind again.

I'm so messy, right?

So what should you look forward to in this damn

*Part Three*

?

**Jay-jay**

—

(1) Still a big eater.

(2) Is it really Keifer now? What about Yuri?

(3) Meeting her

*Pudra*

! (Father)

(4) What was your illness again?

(5) They say you're flirty!—they said so.

**Keifer**

—

(1) How's London?

(5) Is it big?—your love for Jay-jay.

## **Yuri**

—

(1) Why are you still so handsome?

(2) Can I just have you instead?

(3) So what now? Still fighting for Jay-jay?

(4) Is your hair still red? Still got abs?

(5) Is it bigger?—your love for Jay-jay.

## **Percy**

—

(1) Why do you hate Baby Yuri so much?

(2) The weakening aircon.

(3) The Percy vs. Ci-N showdown. Battle of the shorties  
Percy isn't short.)

(4) What about the illness?

(4) Just Ella? That's it? Okay.

(5) Goodness! He doesn't like Jay-jay, they're siblings! Y

**Ci-N**

—

(1) Happy Birthday!—oh wait, that's over.

(2) Rakki—nothing, just Rakki.

(3) The Percy vs. Ci-N showdown. The most awaited ba

**David**

—

(1) Any plans on confessing?

(2) Where's your girlfriend?

(3) How to develop a high-class instinct?

**Felix**

—

(1) Honey—the one you call "darling."

*Just for you, just for you, who are you...*

**Edrix**

—

(1) Is there hope for Freya?

(2) You're in trouble with Percy.

**Rory**

—

(1) This one's a stalker, folks...

**Eman**

—

(1) Where's the food I asked you to cook?

**Eren**

—

(1) Let's not be playboys anymore.

**Kit**

—

(1) Because of your confession, you're now

*Kitty*

. 😊😊😊

**Mayo**

—

(1) Tone down the sweetness with Kit, you might get diabetes.

**Denzel**

—

(1)

*Dadey*

.

(2) It's coming soon, get ready.

**Josh**

—

(1) Edy?

(2) Ci-N has a new enemy. It's not you anymore.

**Drew**

—

(1) My gosh! Your debt! How embarrassing!

**Blaster**

—

(1) How's the band?

(2) The fight with Keigan is finally happening.

**For those rarely mentioned...**



**Ella**

—

(1) What now? You've been overshadowed.

**Rakki**

—

(1) Ci-N. Nothing, just Ci-N.

**Mica**

—

(1) Don't encourage your boyfriend's flirtiness, okay? Too much is bad for health.

**Honey**

—

(1) You're just an extra, I don't even know why you made it in here.

**Freya**

—

(1) Honey beat you.

**Grace**

—

(1) She's about to give birth.

**Kuya Angelo**

—

(1) Stop looking at other women. You're going to get a story.

(

*Title: His Tears*

)

**Kaizer**

—

(1) Here it is! Keifer's dad finally gets a scene.

**Jasper**

—

(1) Did I spell that right? When are you going to show yourself to your daughter?

Hahahaha... There's so many of them. I just realized how ridiculously large this story's cast is.

I feel like trimming it down...

Mwuhehehehe... 

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